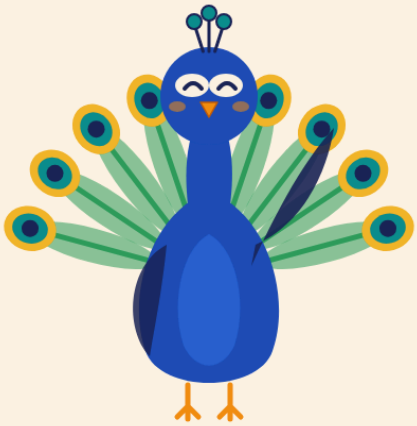
Roots & Rivers

An interactive guide to South Asian cultures for high school students. Learn where the traditions in your family (or your best friend's family) come from, and what they mean.



Start Chapter 1

See all chapters

22	22	8	368
chapters	interactive sims	countries	concepts in the learning graph

What this book is

South Asia is eight countries: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka. Together they're home to about 1.99 billion people (2025), roughly one in four people on Earth. Millions of families in the United States, including here in Minnesota, carry its traditions.

Many readers grew up with those traditions and never learned the "why". Why does Diwali move every year? Why does your grandmother have a different word for your mother's brother and your father's brother? Why do so many scripts look different but work the same way? This book answers those questions, one chapter at a time.

Every chapter has:

- **A story** with Zara and Ben, two Minnesota sophomores figuring this out together
- **An interactive MicroSim** you can play with: spin a festival calendar, clap a rhythm cycle, draw a kolam, build a thali
- **A "Whose Story?" box** that shows how different communities tell the same history
- **Ask Your Elders**, a short interview guide for talking with your own family or community
- **A quiz**, practice questions and sources you can check

Part 1: Foundations

1. What Is South Asia?
2. Ancient Roots
3. Empires and Encounters
4. Colonialism, Independence, and Partition
5. Faiths of South Asia
6. Languages and Scripts

Part 2: Living Culture

{start="7"} 7. Festivals Through the Year 8. Food and the Table 9. Music 10. Dance and Theater 11. Art, Architecture, and Craft 12. Clothing and Textiles 13. Family, Names, and Life Events 14. Stories and Literature 15. Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture 16. Science, Math, and Ideas

Part 3: The Eight Countries

{start="17"} 17. India 18. Pakistan and Afghanistan 19. Bangladesh and Sri Lanka 20. Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives

Part 4: Here and Now

{start="21"} 21. The South Asian Diaspora 22. Bring It Home

Who it's for

- **Students** who want to understand their own heritage, or a friend's. No background needed.
- **Teachers** looking for free, sourced material for world history, geography or the new ethnic studies courses. See For Teachers.
- **Clubs**: South Asian student associations can run a full year of meetings from the Club Kit.
- **Families**: the Ask Your Elders guides are a good excuse for a long conversation at dinner.

Free and open

Roots & Rivers is free, has no ads and needs no login. It's licensed CC BY-NC-SA 4.0, so teachers and clubs can copy and adapt it. Every fact is sourced. If you find a mistake, please report it; corrections are logged in public.

Created by Aaryav Sharma, a member of the board of the South Asian Student Association at Eastview High School in Apple Valley, Minnesota.

About This Book

Why it exists

Many South Asian American teens grow up inside traditions they were never taught to explain. They know the food, some of the words and the festival days. They don't always know why Eid moves every year, why their grandparents tell the story of 1947 or 1971 the way they do, or how the script on a wedding card works. Their friends are curious and have nowhere good to start.

Good free material is scattered. Some covers only ancient history or art. Some is written for teachers, not students. Some covers a single country, or only the diaspora. No single resource is interactive, covers all eight countries of South Asia, and sends readers back to their own families with good questions. Roots & Rivers tries to be that book.

Starting in the 2026-27 school year, Minnesota high schools must offer an ethnic studies course (Sahan Journal; Minn. Stat. 120B.021), and teachers need free, sourced material they can trust.

What makes it different

- **All eight countries.** Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka, in every theme and in four country chapters.
- **Interactive.** Every chapter has a MicroSim you can use on a phone: a festival calendar, a rhythm cycle, a script family tree, a kolam you draw yourself.

- **Ask Your Elders.** Every chapter ends its teaching with an interview guide, and the final chapter turns those interviews into an oral history project with a community Story Archive.
- **Whose Story?** Every chapter shows how different communities, countries and historians tell the same thing differently. Disputed questions are presented as disputed.
- **Checked and sourced.** Every number and date links to a source. See Accuracy and Corrections.

How it was checked

The chapters were drafted and checked by AI agents working under the creator's direction, with written rules for accuracy and fairness, and each chapter went through several separate passes by different agents. A script checked the structure. Every claim was fact-checked against its source. Another review looked at nuance, balance and whether facts were current. A final edit put the language in plain words, and a script checked that no fact changed. The details, and every correction made, are on the Accuracy and Corrections page. The full process is described on How This Book Was Made. If you spot something wrong, please tell us.

Who made it

Roots & Rivers was created by **Aaryav Sharma**, a student at Eastview High School in Apple Valley, Minnesota, and a member of the board of the school's South Asian Student Association (SASA). It was made for SASA's meetings and for any school, club or family that wants to use it.

It is built with Dan McCreary's open intelligent textbook framework, which also powers books on dozens of other subjects.

Not affiliated

Roots & Rivers is an independent student project. It is not an official publication of Eastview High School, Independent School District 196, or any government, religious body or organization named in it.

How to Use This Book

If you're a student

1. **Start anywhere.** Chapter 1 is the best first stop, but each chapter lists its prerequisites at the top, so you can jump to the festival or food chapter if that's what you're curious about.
2. **Play with the MicroSim.** Each chapter has one interactive simulation. Most take two minutes. Try the controls before you read the paragraph that explains them.
3. **Do the Ask Your Elders interview.** It's the most important part of the book. Ten minutes with a parent, grandparent or community elder will teach you things no book can.
4. **Check yourself.** Each chapter has five quick questions, twelve exercises and a separate 10-question quiz with explained answers.
5. **Use the glossary.** Every concept in the book has a short definition in the Glossary.

How words from other languages are shown

The first time a key word appears, you'll see it in its original script, a simple respelling and its meaning, like this: Diwali (दीवाली, *dee-VAH-lee*), "row of lamps". The CAPITAL letters show which part to stress. The respellings are approximate; the best way to learn a pronunciation is to ask someone who speaks the language. See Appendix A.

Meet your guides

Mora is a young peacock who pops up in each chapter with a tip, a warning about a common mix-up, or a question to think about. The peacock motif runs through art across South Asia, from temple carvings to textiles.

Zara Hossain and Ben Lindqvist are two fictional sophomores at a Minnesota high school. Zara's family is from Bangladesh; Ben's is Swedish and Norwegian. They start a South Asian Student Association together, and each chapter begins with a question one of them can't answer yet. Their friends Arjun, Simran, Ayesha, Nima and Dilan show up along the way. All of them are made up.

The boxes you'll see

Box	What it's for
Mora's boxes	A welcome, a tip, a common mix-up, a question to think about
Whose Story?	How different communities or historians tell the same thing
Your interview for this chapter	The Ask Your Elders guide
Collapsible questions	Click to reveal the answer after you've tried

The learning graph

Every idea in this book is a node in a learning graph, a map of 368 concepts and which ones you need first. You can explore it in the Learning Graph Viewer.

On a phone, offline, or on paper

The site works on phones. If your internet is slow, or you want to read on paper, every chapter is on the Downloads page as a PDF.

If you're a teacher or club leader

See For Teachers for pacing plans and standards connections, and the Club Kit for a ready-to-run meeting plan.

Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?

Summary

South Asia is a region of eight countries: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka. Together they were home to about 1.99 billion people in 2025, roughly one in four people on Earth. This chapter explains the difference between a region, a subcontinent and a country, then tours the land itself: the mountain walls in the north, the three great rivers, the plains, plateau, desert and coasts, and the monsoon that brings most of the year's rain. By the end you'll be able to find all eight countries on a map and explain why so many people live where they do.

Concepts Covered

1. South Asia
2. Indian Subcontinent
3. SAARC
4. Himalaya
5. Hindu Kush
6. Indus River
7. Ganges (Ganga) River
8. Brahmaputra River
9. Indo-Gangetic Plain

10. Deccan Plateau
11. Western and Eastern Ghats
12. Thar Desert
13. Monsoon
14. Bay of Bengal
15. Indian Ocean
16. Population of South Asia
17. Regional Diversity

Prerequisites

None, just curiosity. It helps to know north, south, east and west on a map, and that's all.

Welcome to Roots & Rivers!

Hi, I'm Mora! If your family is from South Asia, people have probably asked you "So where are you *really* from?" and expected a one-word answer. This chapter gives you the map you need to answer that question your own way, and it helps your friends ask better questions too. Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

1.1 "Wait, Isn't Bangladesh Part of India?"

It's a Tuesday after school, and Zara Hossain and Ben Lindqvist are sitting in Ms. Okafor's classroom at Prairie Ridge High School. Zara is co-founding the

school's South Asian Student Association, and the first meeting is in two weeks. Ben, her best friend since fourth grade, has already signed up as the club's first member who isn't South Asian. Ms. Okafor, their faculty advisor, has asked them for one thing: a single slide that answers "What counts as South Asia?"

Ben is typing notes. "Okay, so your parents are from Bangladesh. That's part of India, right? Like a state?"

Zara opens her mouth to say no, then stops. She knows Bangladesh is its own country. Her parents grew up in Chattogram, a port city in Bangladesh, and her Nanu (her mother's mother) still tells stories about it at dinner. But Zara has also heard her uncle say "the subcontinent," and her cousin in London say "South Asian," and a relative call everyone from that part of the world "desi." She realizes she can't explain the difference between a country, a subcontinent and a region. If the words themselves are confusing, how is one slide supposed to clear them up? This chapter is that slide, in long form.

1.2 Region, Subcontinent, Country: Three Different Words

Ben already knows this idea from his own family. His family's roots are in Sweden and Norway, two separate **countries**, each with its own government, flag and laws. People also talk about "Scandinavia," a **region** that groups those countries (and usually Denmark) because they share some history and culture. Nobody thinks Norway is "part of Sweden" just because both are in Scandinavia.

South Asia works the same way.

- A **country** is a political unit with its own government and borders. India is a country. So is Bangladesh.

- A **region** is a group of places that people choose to talk about together, because of geography, history, culture or politics. Regions don't have governments.
- A **continent** is one of the very large landmasses, like Asia or Africa. A **subcontinent** is a large, distinct part of a continent.

South Asia is the region in the south of the Asian continent made up of eight countries: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka, the members of SAARC (Section 1.3). It's a geographic and political label, and it doesn't put any one country at the center.

The **Indian Subcontinent** is an older, more physical term for the big wedge of land south of the Himalaya that pushes out into the Indian Ocean, between the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal. It sits on its own tectonic plate (Section 1.5). Today that wedge is divided mainly among India, Pakistan and Bangladesh, with Nepal and Bhutan along its northern edge and Sri Lanka just off its tip. Afghanistan is usually not counted as part of the subcontinent. In short, "subcontinent" describes the land, and "South Asia" describes a group of countries.

Term	What kind of thing	What it includes	Who often uses it
South Asia	A region of countries	Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, Sri Lanka	Governments, the World Bank, the United Nations, most universities in North America
Indian Subcontinent	A physical landmass	The land south of the Himalaya: mainly India, Pakistan and	Geologists, historians, many people in the UK

Term	What kind of thing	What it includes	Who often uses it
		Bangladesh, plus Nepal and Bhutan; Sri Lanka is often included	and in South Asian families
India	A country	One country, with 28 states and several union territories	Everyone, for that one country

Why "Indian"? For centuries, outsiders used "India" to mean the whole land around and beyond the Indus River, and historians still sometimes write "India" for the whole subcontinent before 1947. Since 1947, though, India has been the name of one modern country. That's why many people prefer "South Asia" for the region: it doesn't make one country's name stand for everyone.

Try this

Notice how Zara's family uses its own word for home. In Bangla, দেশ (*DAYSH*), "desh," means "country" or "homeland," and the word is even inside the name Bangladesh. When your family says "back home," which do they mean: a village, a city, a country or a region?

1.3 Eight Countries and SAARC

So which countries count? The answer most governments and researchers use comes from a regional organization.

SAARC, the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, is a group the countries of the region set up to work together on trade, health, education and culture. It was founded in Dhaka, the capital of Bangladesh, on 8 December 1985 by seven countries: Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka. Afghanistan joined as the eighth member in 2007. SAARC's secretariat (its main office) is in Kathmandu, Nepal. SAARC's leaders last met for a full summit in Nepal in 2014. The next summit, planned for Pakistan in 2016, was postponed and, as of October 2026, has not been held. Even so, "the SAARC countries" is still the most common way to define South Asia.

Here are the eight countries, listed alphabetically. Population numbers are for 2025 from the World Bank.

Country	Capital	Population (2025, World Bank)	Main language(s)
Afghanistan	Kabul	43,844,111 (about 44 million)	Pashto and Dari
Bangladesh	Dhaka	175,686,899 (about 176 million)	Bangla (Bengali)
Bhutan	Thimphu	796,682 (about 800,000)	Dzongkha

Country	Capital	Population (2025, World Bank)	Main language(s)
India	New Delhi	1,463,865,525 (about 1.46 billion)	Hindi and English are official; 22 languages are listed in the Constitution's Eighth Schedule
Maldives	Malé	529,676 (about 530,000)	Dhivehi
Nepal	Kathmandu	29,618,118 (about 30 million)	Nepali
Pakistan	Islamabad	255,219,554 (about 255 million)	Urdu (national language) and English (official); Punjabi, Pashto, Sindhi, Saraiki, Balochi and others are widely spoken
Sri Lanka	Sri Jayawardenepura Kotte (legislative)	21,756,000 (about 22 million)	Sinhala and Tamil

Country	Capital	Population (2025, World Bank)	Main language(s)
	and Colombo (executive)		

The sizes are very uneven: India alone has more people than the other seven countries put together. The "main language" column also hides a lot. India's Constitution lists 22 languages in its Eighth Schedule, from Assamese to Urdu, and many more are spoken across the region. You'll meet them in Chapter 6. And two of the eight, Sri Lanka and the Maldives, are island countries.

Some lists differ a little. Afghanistan is sometimes grouped with Central Asia instead, and Myanmar or Tibet are occasionally included. This book follows the SAARC list of eight, which is the most widely used.

Whose Story?

Even the name of the region depends on who is talking. "The Indian subcontinent" became common under the British Empire and is still widely used in Britain and in India, where many writers like it because it points to the culture the region shares. Many people in Pakistan and Bangladesh, which became separate countries in 1947 and 1971, find the phrase uncomfortable because it puts India's name on everyone, and they usually say "South Asia," as historians increasingly do. Afghans may describe their country as part of Central Asia, South Asia or both. Even international bodies differ: since mid-2025 the World Bank groups Afghanistan and Pakistan with the Middle East and North Africa in its regional statistics, though both remain SAARC members.

1.4 How Many People Live in South Asia?

The **Population of South Asia** is the total number of people living in its eight countries. Add up the 2025 World Bank numbers from the table and you get about **1.99 billion people** (2025, World Bank). The whole world had about 8.2 billion people that year, so South Asia was home to roughly **one in four people on Earth**.

In 2025 India was the most populous country in the world, ahead of China, and Pakistan and Bangladesh were both among the ten most populous countries on Earth (World Bank).

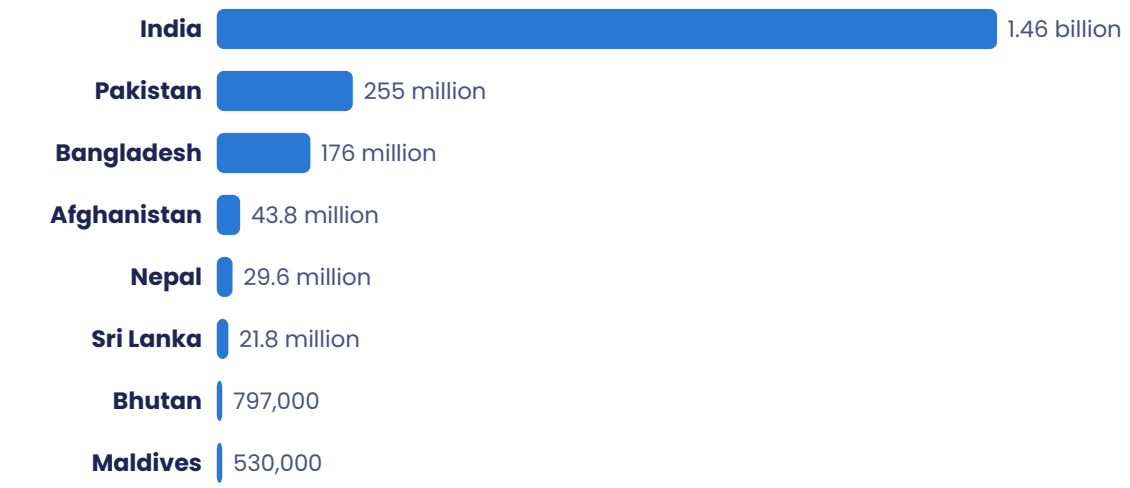
Here's how the total breaks down.

Country	Share of South Asia's 2025 population (approximate)
India	about 73.5%
Pakistan	about 12.8%
Bangladesh	about 8.8%
Afghanistan	about 2.2%
Nepal	about 1.5%
Sri Lanka	about 1.1%
Bhutan	about 0.04%
Maldives	about 0.03%

The chart shows the same 2025 numbers as bars. Hover over a bar, or tap it, to see the exact figure. Then press **Hide India** to compare the other seven countries on their own scale.

India is so large that it can hide the others. Use the button to compare the other seven on their own scale.

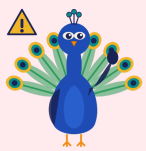
Hide India



Source: World Bank, World Development Indicators (SP.POP.TOTL), 2025 estimates, dataset updated October 2026.

Show the numbers as a table

Watch out for this number trap



If you look up "South Asia population" on the World Bank website, you'll get a smaller number than 1.99 billion. That's because the World Bank's own "South Asia" group now leaves out Afghanistan and Pakistan, so always check which countries a total includes.

Why do so many people live here? Part of the answer is history: farming villages and cities have existed in the region for thousands of years (that's Chapter 2). But a big part of the answer is the land and water you're about to meet. Rich river soil, warm weather and a dependable rainy season make it possible to grow a lot of food, and food supports large populations.

1.5 The Mountain Walls: Himalaya and Hindu Kush

Look at any physical map of Asia and you'll see South Asia's northern edge drawn in dark brown. That's a wall of the highest mountains on Earth.

The Himalaya

The **Himalaya** (हिमालय, *hi-MAA-lay*, "abode of snow") is the mountain range that separates the plains of the subcontinent from the high Tibetan Plateau to the north. The name comes from Sanskrit: *hima* means frost or snow, and *ālaya* means dwelling or home. You'll also see it written "the Himalayas," with an s. Both are correct.

Some key facts:

- The range curves in an arc about 2,400 km (1,500 miles) long, running from west-northwest to east-southeast.
- It holds more than 100 peaks taller than 7,200 m (23,600 ft), including the highest mountain on Earth.
- That mountain is Mount Everest, 8,848.86 m (29,031.7 ft) tall, according to a joint measurement by China and Nepal in 2020. Its summit sits on the border between Nepal and China. In Nepali it is called Sagarmatha.
- The Himalaya spans five countries: Nepal, India, China, Bhutan and Pakistan. So it is not "in" any single country.

How did mountains this tall form? Through a very slow crash. About 80 million years ago, the land that is now the subcontinent was a separate piece of Earth's crust (a tectonic plate) sitting roughly 6,400 km south of Asia. It drifted north. Somewhere between 40 and 50 million years ago, it ran into the Eurasian plate. The crust crumpled and piled upward, and according to the US Geological Survey, the Himalaya is still rising by more than 1 cm a year. That's why it makes sense to think of the subcontinent as a distinct piece of Asia. It really did arrive as its own piece of land.

The mountains matter for people in two big ways. They block the cold air of Central Asia from blowing south, and their snow and glaciers feed the region's largest rivers. Many Himalayan peaks are also sacred in Hindu and Buddhist traditions.

A disputed area

The western end of the Himalaya runs through Kashmir, a region whose control is disputed among India, Pakistan and China, and each country has its own position on where its borders lie. That's one reason the maps in this book are schematic and never draw official borders.

The Hindu Kush

West of the Himalaya, another range takes over. The **Hindu Kush** is a mountain range about 800 km (500 miles) long that stretches from central and eastern Afghanistan into northwestern Pakistan, with a small piece in far southeastern Tajikistan. Its highest peak is Tirich Mir, about 7,700 m, in the Chitral District of Pakistan. It is the highest mountain anywhere outside the Himalaya and Karakoram ranges.

The Hindu Kush has been both a wall and a doorway, with routes that carried traders, travelers and armies between Central Asia and South Asia. Buddhism was once widespread in its valleys, and the giant Buddha statues carved into the cliffs at Bamiyan, in Afghanistan, stood until they were destroyed in 2001. Today most people in the region are Muslim.

1.6 Three Great Rivers

Mountains collect snow, the snow melts into rivers, and the rivers carry soil down to the plains. That chain is a big reason so many people live in South Asia. Three rivers matter most.

The Indus

The **Indus River** is about 3,180 km (1,980 miles) long. It begins on the Tibetan Plateau in China, flows northwest through the disputed Kashmir region (first through Indian-administered Ladakh, then Pakistani-administered Gilgit-Baltistan), then turns south and runs the full length of Pakistan before emptying into the Arabian Sea near Karachi. Along the way it collects five big tributaries in the Punjab: the Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas and Sutlej. The name *Punjab* means "land of five rivers."

Most of Pakistan's farming depends on the Indus. It's also the river that gave the whole subcontinent its outside name. Its old Sanskrit name is Sindhu, and through Old Persian and Greek that name became the English words "Indus" and "India," as well as "Hindustan," "land of the Indus." And it was along the Indus and its neighbors that one of the world's earliest city civilizations grew, a story for Chapter 2.

The Ganges (Ganga)

The **Ganges (Ganga) River** is about 2,525 km (1,569 miles) long. In India it is called the Ganga (गंगा, *GUNG-gaa*), and in Bangladesh it is called the Padma. It rises in the western Himalaya in the Indian state of Uttarakhand, flows east across the northern plains of India, picks up major tributaries such as the Yamuna and several rivers coming down from Nepal, then crosses into Bangladesh.

Hundreds of millions of people depend on the Ganga, and many big cities stand on it or its connected rivers, including Varanasi, Patna, Kolkata and Dhaka. Many Hindus revere the Ganga as a goddess and bathe in it as an act of devotion. You'll learn more in Chapter 5.

The Brahmaputra

The **Brahmaputra River** is about 3,000 km (1,900 miles) long. It begins in Tibet near Mount Kailash, where it's called the Yarlung Tsangpo, and flows east along the north side of the Himalaya. Then it turns and cuts south through the mountains in deep gorges, enters India in the state of Arunachal Pradesh, flows west through the Assam Valley, and turns south into Bangladesh, where it is called the Jamuna. It is a braided river, which means it splits into many shifting channels, and it floods often, especially when Himalayan snow melts.

Where the rivers meet

In Bangladesh, the Padma (Ganga) and the Jamuna (Brahmaputra) join, then merge with the Meghna River and pour into the Bay of Bengal. Together they built the Ganges Delta, also called the Bengal Delta, which is the largest river delta in the world. It covers most of Bangladesh and the Indian state of West Bengal. At its edge on the sea is the Sundarbans, the largest mangrove forest in the world, shared by Bangladesh and India. The Ganges-Brahmaputra-Meghna system carries so much water that only two river

systems on Earth, the Amazon and the Congo, pour more fresh water into the sea.

That's the land Zara's family comes from: wet, green, flat, crossed by rivers, and shaped by them.

River	Approx. length	Starts in	Flows through	Ends in	Ot no
Indus	3,180 km	Tibet (China)	Kashmir region, Pakistan	Arabian Sea	Se Za Tib
Ganges (Ganga)	2,525 km	Uttarakhand, India	India, Bangladesh	Bay of Bengal	Pa Ba
Brahmaputra	3,000 km	Tibet (China)	China, India, Bangladesh	Bay of Bengal (through the delta)	Ya Ts Ja

River lengths are approximate. Sources differ by a few hundred kilometers, depending on where they place a river's source and how they trace its channels.

1.7 Plains, Plateau, Ghats and Desert

Between the mountains and the sea, the land changes a lot. Four landforms explain most of the map.

The Indo-Gangetic Plain

The **Indo-Gangetic Plain** is the huge, flat, fertile lowland that stretches across the north of the subcontinent, from Pakistan in the west, through northern India and southern Nepal, to almost all of Bangladesh in the east. It covers about 700,000 square km (270,000 square miles). It's named for the two river systems that drain it, the Indus and the Ganga.

The rivers built the plain themselves. Flood after flood, they spread fine mud called **alluvium**, so the plain is one of the largest unbroken stretches of river soil anywhere. It's among the most densely populated and most intensely farmed places on Earth, home to many of the region's biggest cities: Lahore, Delhi, Lucknow, Patna, Kolkata and Dhaka all sit on or near it.

The Deccan Plateau

South of the plain, the land rises. The **Deccan Plateau** is a large raised tableland that covers much of central and southern India. Its average height is about 600 m (2,000 ft). The name Deccan comes from the Sanskrit word दक्षिण (*DUK-shin*), "south."

The plateau tilts gently from west to east, so most of its big rivers, such as the Godavari, the Krishna and the Kaveri, flow east and empty into the Bay of Bengal. The northwest part of the plateau is made of thick layers of dark volcanic rock called the Deccan Traps, laid down by enormous lava flows about 66 million years ago. Much of the land there has dark black soil. Because mountains on its western edge block rain, much of the Deccan is drier than the coasts, with a semi-arid climate.

The Western and Eastern Ghats

The **Western and Eastern Ghats** are the two mountain ranges that frame the Deccan Plateau, one along each coast of peninsular India. *Ghat* comes from

the Hindi word घाट (*GHAAT*), which means a flight of steps leading down to a river, or a mountain pass. These ranges are like giant steps from the plateau down to the sea.

- The **Western Ghats** run about 1,600 km along India's west coast, from the state of Gujarat south through Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka and Kerala to Tamil Nadu. They form an almost continuous wall, with peaks over 2,000 m. The highest is Anamudi, 2,695 m. They catch the rain-bearing monsoon winds coming off the Arabian Sea, so their western slopes and the coast below them get very heavy rain, while the land behind them stays drier. The Western Ghats are also famous for their forests and wildlife.
- The **Eastern Ghats** run about 1,750 km along the east coast, from Odisha through Andhra Pradesh and Telangana to Tamil Nadu. Unlike the Western Ghats, they are broken into separate hills, with many gaps where rivers cut through to the Bay of Bengal. They are lower, about 600 m on average, so they affect the weather less.

The two ranges meet in the Nilgiri Hills in the far south.

The Thar Desert

In the northwest, where India meets Pakistan, the land turns to sand. The **Thar Desert**, also called the Great Indian Desert, is a dry region of sandy plains and low hills. About 85 percent of it lies in India, mostly in the state of Rajasthan, and the rest lies in Pakistan's Sindh and Punjab provinces. It gets most of its little rain from the summer monsoon, usually less than 500 mm (20 inches) a year. Summers are extremely hot and winters are cooler.

The Thar is a good reminder that South Asia isn't one climate. People have lived in the Thar for a very long time, getting by with herding and careful water storage, and the desert has its own traditions of music and craft that you'll meet in later chapters.

A quick way to remember the layout: walk south from Tibet and you step down from the Himalaya to the Indo-Gangetic Plain, up onto the Deccan Plateau, then down the Ghats to the coast, with desert to the northwest and delta to the northeast.

1.8 The Monsoon

Ask South Asian grandparents about the weather back home, and there's a good chance the first word they say is "monsoon." It's the most important weather pattern in the region.

What the word means

The English word monsoon comes from the Arabic word موسم (*MAW-sim*), *mawsim*, which means "season." Sailors crossing the Arabian Sea between Africa, Arabia and India learned long ago that the winds blew from the northeast for half the year and from the southwest for the rest, and they used that pattern for their voyages. Ocean trade depended on it, as you'll see in Chapter 3.

So a **monsoon** is, first of all, a wind that reverses direction with the seasons. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) describes it as winds along the Indian Ocean coasts that blow from the southwest for about half the year and from the northeast for the other half. In everyday speech, though, "the monsoon" usually means the rainy season that the southwest winds bring in summer. In Bangla, Zara's Nanu calls that season বর্ষা (*BOR-sha*), *borsha*, which means both "rain" and "the rainy season."

How the summer monsoon works

You can feel the basic idea at a beach. On a hot day the sand gets hot fast, but the water stays cooler, because land heats up faster than water.

1. In spring and early summer, the huge landmass of South Asia and the rest of Asia heats up much faster than the Indian Ocean.
2. Hot air over the land rises, which lowers the air pressure there.
3. Cooler, moist air from over the ocean flows in toward the land to fill the gap. In South Asia that wind blows from the southwest.
4. As the moist air is pushed up over hills and mountains, such as the Western Ghats and later the Himalaya, it cools, and its water falls as rain.
5. In winter the pattern flips. The land cools faster than the sea, and cool, dry winds blow outward from the land, from the northeast.

The Himalaya matters here too. It acts like a wall that stops the monsoon clouds from simply drifting away north, so they drop their rain on the plains and foothills.

When it arrives

The southwest monsoon arrives on a fairly regular schedule. According to the IMD, it normally reaches the state of Kerala, at India's southwest tip, around **1 June**, then moves north in surges and covers the whole of India around **8 July**. Rain moves up the west coast from the Arabian Sea, while low-pressure systems that form over the Bay of Bengal carry heavy rain westward across the land. The monsoon begins to pull back from northwest India in September and has usually withdrawn from the whole country by mid-October. Those are average dates, though. In any real year the monsoon can come early or late, and people watch the forecasts closely.

The amount of rain changes a lot from place to place. Mawsynram and Cherrapunji, two towns in the hills of the Indian state of Meghalaya, just north of Bangladesh, trade places as the wettest spots on Earth. Meanwhile, the

Thar Desert gets only a little. And Afghanistan sits mostly outside the monsoon zone altogether; most of its rain and snow falls in winter and spring.

Not all monsoon rain comes in summer, either. In the southeast of India, Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh get rain from the northeast monsoon during the winter months, after the summer monsoon has left, when winds crossing the Bay of Bengal pick up moisture on the way.

It doesn't rain all day

"Monsoon season" doesn't mean nonstop rain. The monsoon comes in active spells of heavy rain and "break" spells of days with little rain, and many monsoon days mix sun, sticky heat and a big afternoon downpour.

Why it matters so much

The southwest monsoon brings most of the year's rain to most of India, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Pakistan and Sri Lanka. Many farms in the region don't have large irrigation systems, so they depend on the monsoon to water their crops, especially rice, and to refill wells and underground water for the rest of the year. A late or weak monsoon can hurt harvests and the whole economy. A very strong one can cause floods and landslides. The monsoon also feeds the rivers that power hydroelectric dams.

The monsoon shows up in songs, poems, foods and festivals too, and in a lot of family memories of the first rain of the season.

1.9 Water All Around: The Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean

South Asia's southern half is a peninsula, which means water on three sides. Two big bodies of water shape the coasts.

The **Bay of Bengal** is the northeastern part of the Indian Ocean, lying east of India and south of Bangladesh, with Myanmar on its eastern side and Sri Lanka at its southwestern edge. It covers about 2.2 million square km (about 840,000 square miles). Many of the subcontinent's biggest rivers flow into it, including the Ganga, the Brahmaputra, the Godavari, the Krishna and the Kaveri.

The bay's coasts include the Sundarbans mangrove forest, Cox's Bazar in Bangladesh, one of the longest natural sea beaches in the world, and Marina Beach in Chennai, India, one of the longest city beaches. Severe cyclones also form over the bay, which is one reason coastal Bangladesh and eastern India plan so carefully for storms. Chattogram, where Zara's parents grew up, is Bangladesh's busiest port, right on the bay.

The **Indian Ocean** is the third-largest of the world's five oceans, covering about 70.6 million square km, or about 20% of the water on Earth's surface. It has Asia to the north, Africa to the west and Australia to the east. It's also the warmest ocean, and monsoons shape the climate all around it. The Arabian Sea, to the west of India and south of Pakistan, and the Bay of Bengal are both arms of it.

Two of South Asia's countries sit out in this ocean:

- **Sri Lanka** is a large island just south of India's tip, mostly flat to rolling coastal plains with mountains rising in the south-central part.
- **The Maldives** is a chain of 1,192 small coral islands grouped into 26 atolls (rings of coral reef around a lagoon), stretched across the equator southwest of India and Sri Lanka. More than 80% of its islands sit less than 1 m above sea level, which makes the Maldives the lowest-lying country in the world and very vulnerable to rising seas.

For thousands of years the Indian Ocean worked more like a highway than a barrier, carrying ships, goods, faiths and languages between South Asia, Arabia, East Africa and Southeast Asia. Arab and Persian traders helped bring Islam to the Maldives in the 12th century.

1.10 Putting It Together: Regional Diversity

Regional Diversity is the idea that South Asia is not one place with one climate, one language, one faith or one way of life, but many different places shaped by different land, water and history. The geography you've just read about is one of the biggest reasons for that diversity.

Here's how different everyday life can be, depending on where you stand:

Place	Country	Landscape	What shapes daily life
Kabul	Afghanistan	High valley ringed by mountains	Most rain and snow from December to April; dry summers; little monsoon rain
Lahore	Pakistan	Indo-Gangetic Plain, Punjab	Hot summers, monsoon rain from June to September, farming on river-fed land
Kathmandu	Nepal	Valley in the Himalayan foothills	Summer monsoon rains, mountains all around

Place	Country	Landscape	What shapes daily life
Chattogram	Bangladesh	Coast of the Bay of Bengal, near the delta	Heavy monsoon rain, rivers and floods, port life, cyclone risk
Jaisalmer	India	Thar Desert	Little rain, extremely hot summers, careful water use
Kandy	Sri Lanka	Central highlands	Cooler than the coast, green and rainy
Malé	Maldives	Low coral island	Ocean on every side; fishing and tourism; sea-level rise

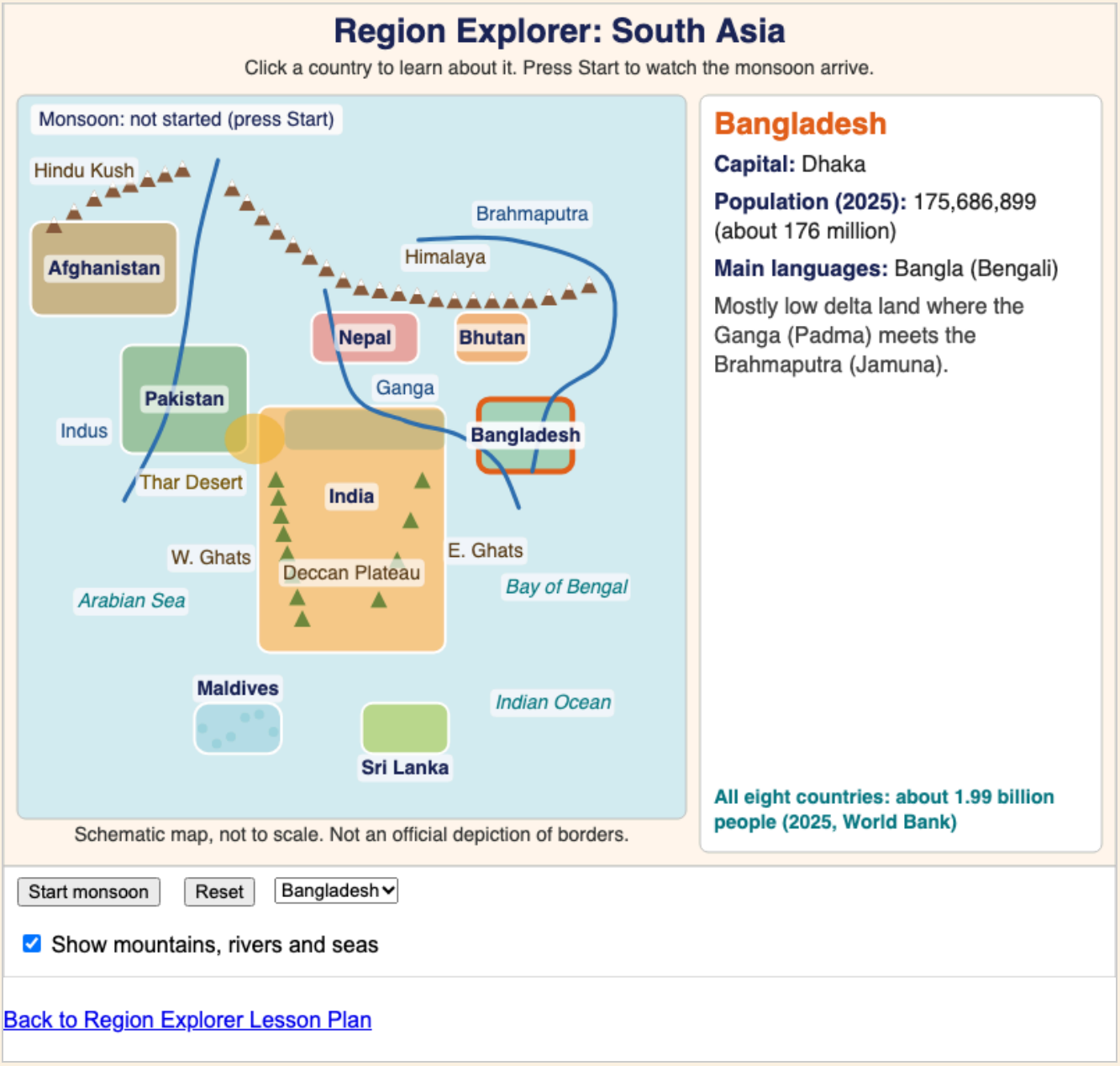
Each of those places has its own foods, clothes, building styles and festivals, and the land is one big reason why. In the chapters ahead, every time you meet a tradition, try asking: what about the land and weather made this make sense?

Geography isn't the only reason. History, trade, migration, faith and language add their own layers, as the rest of this book shows.

Back in Ms. Okafor's classroom, Zara and Ben finally finish the slide. At the top, in big letters: **"South Asia = a region of 8 countries, about 2 billion people."** Below that, a simple tile map with the Himalaya across the top, three rivers running down, and the monsoon arrow coming up from the southwest. At the bottom, Zara adds one line: "Bangladesh is not part of India. Both are part of

South Asia." Ben reads it and grins. "Okay," he says. "Now I get why your Nanu talks about the rain so much."

Diagram: Region Explorer



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch01-region-explorer/main.html

Open the Region Explorer fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Region Explorer

sim-id: ch01-region-explorer
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: explain
Learning Objective: The learner will locate the eight countries of South Asia on a schematic map and explain how the mountains and the southwest monsoon shape where rain falls and where people live.

Canvas: responsive width; 620 px drawing area plus 80 px control area.

Controls: Start monsoon / Pause button, Reset button, country menu, "Show mountains, rivers and seas" checkbox; click or tap any country tile.

Behavior: Eight country tiles sit roughly in their geographic positions (no borders). Selecting a tile shows its capital, 2025 population (World Bank) and main languages. The monsoon starts paused; Start animates a shaded rain zone spreading from the southwest sea (late May) to all of India (about 8 July, IMD normal date), with a Bay of Bengal branch. Most of Afghanistan and the far north stay dry. The caption "Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders." is drawn inside the drawing area.

Start by clicking each of the eight tiles and reading the panel. Which country has the most people? Which have the fewest? Then untick the checkbox to hide the labels and see if you can still name the Himalaya, the Hindu Kush, the two Ghats and the three rivers.

Next, press **Start monsoon** and watch carefully. Pause when the date banner says the monsoon reaches Kerala, and again when the rain covers Bangladesh. Notice where the rain shows up first (the sea near Sri Lanka and India's southwest coast), how the rain reaches Bangladesh from the Bay of Bengal side, and which country stays almost completely dry. Then compare

the rainy areas with the places you know are crowded, like the Indo-Gangetic Plain and the delta. The map is simplified, so the exact edges aren't precise, but the pattern is real.

Ask Your Elders

> **Your interview for this chapter**
>
> Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about where your family comes from: the village, town or city, the river or region nearby, what the land and weather were like, and what the monsoon meant to them. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Bring a printed or phone map of South Asia and ask them to point to the place they grew up. Ask if it's okay to take notes.

Questions to ask

1. Where did you grow up? What was the nearest river, mountain, desert or sea?
2. What did the place look like out your window or on your walk to school?
3. What was the weather like through the year? Which season did you like most, and why?
4. When the first monsoon rain came (or the first big rain of the year), what did people do? Was there a smell, a food, a song or a game you remember?
5. How has that place changed since you were young, or since you moved away? Do you know what the weather is like there now?

6. If I visit one day, what is the one thing about the land or the weather there that you'd want me to see or feel?

Listen for: names of rivers or mountains (is it near the Indus River, the Ganges (Ganga) River or the Brahmaputra River, or the Himalaya?), stories about the Monsoon, and details that show Regional Diversity, such as how different their home was from another relative's.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's description of the weather back home with what this chapter says about the monsoon in that part of South Asia. Did the monsoon arrive when the IMD's normal dates say it should? If a friend interviewed someone from a different country or region, list two ways the landscapes and seasons they describe were different.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: South Asia is just another name for India.
Reality: South Asia is a region of eight countries: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka. India is the largest by far, but Bangladesh, Pakistan and the others are separate, independent countries with their own governments, languages and histories.

Myth: The Himalaya is in Nepal (or in India).
Reality: The Himalaya stretches about 2,400 km across five countries:

Pakistan, India, Nepal, Bhutan and China. Mount Everest itself sits on the Nepal-China border.

Myth: Monsoon means it rains all day, every day for months.
Reality: A monsoon is a seasonal shift in wind direction. The summer monsoon brings a rainy season, but rain comes in active spells and break spells, and many monsoon days include sun and heat between heavy showers.

Myth: All of South Asia is hot all the time.
Reality: The region includes snowy Himalayan peaks, cold, dry high valleys on the northern side of the western Himalaya, and Sri Lanka's central highlands, where frost can occur on some winter nights, as well as hot plains, deserts and tropical coasts. Climate depends a lot on height and distance from the sea.

Myth: The "Indian subcontinent" and "India" mean the same thing.
Reality: "Indian subcontinent" is a geographic term for the landmass south of the Himalaya, which today includes several countries. "India" is the name of one modern country since 1947. That's why many people prefer the term "South Asia" for the region.

Check Yourself

1. Name the eight countries of South Asia.

Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka. They are the eight members of SAARC.

2. What is the difference between a region and a country?

A country has its own government, borders and laws. A region is a group of places people talk about together because of geography, history or culture; it has no government of its own.

3. About how many people lived in South Asia in 2025, and what share of the world is that?

About 1.99 billion people (2025, World Bank), roughly one in four people on Earth.

4. Which two rivers join in Bangladesh to form the world's largest delta, and what are they called there?

The Ganga (called the Padma in Bangladesh) and the Brahmaputra (called the Jamuna). They join and flow with the Meghna into the Bay of Bengal.

5. Why does the summer monsoon blow from the southwest?

In early summer the land heats up faster than the Indian Ocean. Hot air rises over the land, and cooler, moist air from the ocean to the southwest flows in to replace it, bringing rain.

Exercises

Remember

1. List the capitals of Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal and Pakistan.

Answer

Bangladesh: Dhaka. Bhutan: Thimphu. Nepal: Kathmandu. Pakistan: Islamabad.

2. In what city and year was SAARC founded, and which country joined later?

Answer

SAARC was founded in Dhaka on 8 December 1985 by seven countries. Afghanistan joined as the eighth member in 2007.

Understand

1. Explain in your own words why the land south of the Himalaya can be called a "subcontinent."

Answer

The land that is now the subcontinent sits on its own tectonic plate. It drifted north for millions of years and collided with Asia between about 40 and 50 million years ago, pushing up the Himalaya. It is a distinct piece of the Asian continent.

2. Explain why the Deccan Plateau is drier than the coast of Kerala, even though both are in southern India.

Answer

The Western Ghats stand between the Arabian Sea and the plateau. Monsoon winds rise over the Ghats and drop much of their rain on the western slopes and the coast, so the plateau behind them gets less.

Apply

1. Use the Region Explorer. Pause the monsoon on 15 June. Which countries are getting rain on that date, and which are not? Write two sentences explaining the pattern. *Hint: think about where the monsoon starts and which way it moves.*
2. A family member says they grew up "near the Jamuna, in the north of the country." Using this chapter, figure out which country and which big river they mean, and where that river starts. *Hint: rivers can have different names in different countries.*

Analyze

1. Compare the Indo-Gangetic Plain and the Thar Desert. Using at least three facts from the chapter, explain why one supports so many more people than the other. *Hint: think about water, soil and rain.*
2. The World Bank's "South Asia" total is smaller than the eight-country total in this chapter. Analyze why the two numbers differ and why it matters to check the definition behind any statistic. *Hint: which countries are in each group?*

Evaluate

1. Some people prefer "South Asia" and others prefer "the Indian subcontinent." Which term would you use on your club's slide, and why? Consider who will be in the room. *Hint: the Whose Story? box gives several points of view.*
2. Your friend says, "The monsoon is just bad weather." Evaluate this claim using evidence about farming, water supply, floods and culture from the chapter. *Hint: a fair answer looks at both benefits and dangers.*

Create

1. Design your own one-slide answer to "What counts as South Asia?" for a club meeting. Include a schematic map (no official borders), the eight countries, one population fact with its year and source, and one fact about land or weather. *Hint: keep it to what fits on a single slide.*
2. Write a short postcard (100 to 150 words) from someone living in one of the places in the Regional Diversity table in 1.10, describing their weather and landscape during the monsoon season. *Hint: use at least two concept words from this chapter.*

Key Takeaways

- South Asia is a region of eight countries: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka, the members of SAARC.
- "Indian Subcontinent" describes the landmass south of the Himalaya; "South Asia" describes the group of countries. Many people prefer "South Asia" because it doesn't center one country.

- About 1.99 billion people lived in South Asia in 2025 (World Bank), roughly one in four people on Earth.
- The Himalaya and Hindu Kush form the region's northern mountain walls. The Himalaya spans five countries and was pushed up when the subcontinent's plate collided with Asia.
- The Indus, the Ganges (Ganga) and the Brahmaputra carry snowmelt and soil to the plains; the Ganga and Brahmaputra build the world's largest delta in Bangladesh and India.
- The southwest monsoon normally reaches Kerala around 1 June and covers India by about 8 July, bringing most of the year's rain to much of the region, but not to most of Afghanistan.
- Mountains, plains, plateau, desert, delta and islands help explain South Asia's regional diversity in food, dress, buildings and ways of life.

You've got the map!

You can now find all eight countries and explain why rivers and rain matter so much here. Next, in Chapter 2, we travel back thousands of years to the cities that grew up along the Indus.

Quiz: What Is South Asia?

Test your understanding of Chapter 1. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

Which list contains only countries that are part of South Asia as defined by SAARC?

A. India, Myanmar, Nepal, Sri Lanka

B. Afghanistan, Bhutan, Maldives, Pakistan

C. Bangladesh, Tibet, Bhutan, India

D. Pakistan, Iran, Nepal, Sri Lanka

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Afghanistan, Bhutan, the Maldives and Pakistan are all among SAARC's eight members. Myanmar and Tibet are sometimes mentioned as border zones, but they are not SAARC members, and Iran is not part of South Asia.

Concept Tested: SAARC **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

About how many people lived in the eight countries of South Asia in 2025, according to the World Bank?

A. About 500 million

B. About 1.46 billion

C. About 8.2 billion

D. About 1.99 billion

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The eight countries together had about 1.99 billion people in 2025, roughly one in four people on Earth. About 1.46 billion is India's population alone (a common mix-up), and 8.2 billion is the whole world.

Concept Tested: Population of South Asia **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 3

Which body of water receives the combined flow of the Ganga and the Brahmaputra?

A. The Bay of Bengal

B. The Arabian Sea

C. The Red Sea

D. The Caspian Sea

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The Ganga (Padma) and the Brahmaputra (Jamuna) join in Bangladesh, flow with the Meghna, and empty into the Bay of Bengal through the world's largest delta. The Arabian Sea is where the Indus ends, on the other side of the subcontinent.

Concept Tested: Bay of Bengal **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

What is the best explanation of the difference between "South Asia" and the "Indian subcontinent"?

A. They are two names for the country of India.

B. South Asia is only the island countries, while the subcontinent is the mainland.

C. South Asia is a group of eight countries; the subcontinent is a physical landmass south of the Himalaya.

D. The subcontinent includes Afghanistan, but South Asia does not.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. "South Asia" names a region made up of eight countries, while "Indian subcontinent" is a geographic term for the landmass on its own tectonic plate. Option D has it backward: Afghanistan is usually counted in South Asia but not in the subcontinent.

Concept Tested: Indian Subcontinent **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 5

Why does the summer monsoon blow from the southwest toward South Asia?

A. The Himalaya pushes air south in summer.

B. The land heats up faster than the Indian Ocean, so moist ocean air flows in toward the warm land.

C. The ocean is hotter than the land in summer, so air flows out to sea.

D. Winds from Central Asia carry rain over the mountains.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. In early summer the land warms faster than the ocean, air rises over the land, and cooler, moist air from the Indian Ocean flows in from the southwest, bringing rain. Option C reverses the pattern, which is closer to what happens in winter.

Concept Tested: Monsoon **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 6

Why is the Indo-Gangetic Plain one of the most densely populated places on Earth?

A. Its rivers spread fertile alluvium, and water from Himalayan rivers supports large-scale farming.

B. It is the highest and coolest part of the region.

C. It is a desert with large oil reserves.

D. It is an island chain with many ports.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The Indus, Ganga and Brahmaputra built the plain from river soil, and their water makes intense farming possible, which supports huge populations. Option B describes the Himalaya, not the plain.

Concept Tested: Indo-Gangetic Plain **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 7

Ayesha's family is from Lahore, Pakistan, and Nima's family is from Solukhumbu, Nepal. Ben says, "So they both live near the Himalaya, which is in Nepal." Which response best corrects Ben?

A. "The Himalaya is only in India."

B. "Lahore is on the Deccan Plateau, far from any mountains."

C. "Nepal has no mountains; they're all in Pakistan."

D. "The Himalaya stretches across five countries, including Pakistan, India, Nepal, Bhutan and China, so it isn't in just one country."

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The Himalaya spans Pakistan, India, Nepal, Bhutan and China, about 2,400 km in all. Option B is wrong because Lahore is on the Indo-Gangetic Plain in Punjab, and the Deccan Plateau is in central and southern India.

Concept Tested: Himalaya **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

Zara's cousin in Dhaka is planning a June trip to visit family in India and asks Zara when the rains start there. Using the chapter, where does the southwest monsoon normally arrive on mainland India first, and around what date?

A. Delhi, around 1 May

B. Kerala, around 1 June

C. Kabul, around 1 July

D. The Thar Desert, around 15 June

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The India Meteorological Department's normal onset date over Kerala, at India's southwest tip, is around 1 June. The monsoon then covers all of India around 8 July. Kabul is wrong because Afghanistan lies mostly outside the monsoon zone.

Concept Tested: Monsoon **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

The Deccan Plateau is drier than the Kerala coast, even though both are in southern India. What is the best explanation?

A. The Deccan is closer to the Thar Desert.

B. The Eastern Ghats block all rain from the Bay of Bengal.

C. The Western Ghats catch the monsoon winds from the Arabian Sea, so much of the rain falls on the coast side before the air reaches the plateau.

D. The Deccan is at sea level, and rain only falls on mountains.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Monsoon winds rise over the Western Ghats and drop much of their rain on the western slopes and coast, leaving the plateau behind them drier. Option B can look right, but the Eastern Ghats are low and broken, so they affect the weather much less.

Concept Tested: Western and Eastern Ghats **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

---

Question 10

A club member finds a website that lists South Asia's population as about 1.69 billion for 2025, not 1.99 billion. What is the most likely reason for the difference?

A. The website is counting a different set of countries; the World Bank's own "South Asia" group now leaves out Afghanistan and Pakistan.

B. The population of South Asia fell by 300 million people in one year.

C. The website forgot to count India.

D. The smaller number counts only people who speak Hindi.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Since mid-2025 the World Bank groups Afghanistan and Pakistan with the Middle East and North Africa, so its "South Asia" total covers only six countries. Leaving out India (option C) would make the number far smaller, about 0.5 billion.

Concept Tested: Population of South Asia **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 2: Ancient Roots

Summary

This chapter follows South Asia's long story from the farming village of Mehrgarh, about 7000 BCE, through the planned cities of the Indus Valley, the Vedic period and the birth of Buddhism and Jainism, to the empires of the Mauryas, Kushans and Guptas, ending around 550 CE. You will see what historians know for sure, what they still argue about, and why those arguments matter today. By the end you'll be able to put the major ancient periods in order and connect each one to real places across Pakistan, India, Afghanistan, Nepal, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Concepts Covered

1. Mehrgarh
2. Indus Valley Civilization
3. Harappa and Mohenjo-daro
4. Indus Script
5. Indo-Aryan Migration
6. Vedic Period
7. The Vedas
8. Sanskrit
9. Mahajanapadas

10. Rise of Buddhism and Jainism
11. Maurya Empire
12. Ashoka
13. Edicts of Ashoka
14. Kushan Empire
15. Sangam Age
16. Gupta Empire
17. Nalanda

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?, especially the Indus and Ganges (Ganga) rivers, the Indo-Gangetic Plain and the Hindu Kush.

Welcome to the deep past!

The symbol on India's money, the wheel on its flag, the Sanskrit words in a wedding ceremony and the Buddha statue in your neighbor's garden all come from this chapter's time period. When people argue online about "who was here first," they are arguing about this history too. Knowing the real evidence helps you join those conversations calmly and fairly.

2.1 "Nobody Can Read It?"

It's the club's second planning meeting, and Ben Lindqvist is supposed to be making a sign-up sheet. Instead he's holding his phone out to Zara Hossain.

"Look at this," he says. On the screen is a museum photo of a small square stone, about the size of a postage stamp. Carved into it is an animal that looks like a bull with one horn, and above it a short row of neat little symbols.

"It's a seal from Mohenjo-daro," Ben reads. "In Pakistan. About four thousand years old. People pressed it into clay, like a stamp." He scrolls. "It says the writing on it has never been deciphered." He looks up. "Wait. Nobody can read it? Like, nobody on Earth?"

Zara shakes her head slowly. Her Nanu talks about the old ruins in Bangladesh as if they were neighbors, so Zara knew South Asia was old. But she pictured "old" as a few kings and temples, not planned cities with writing that has stumped experts for a hundred years. "So how do we know anything about them?" she asks. "And what came after?" That is what this chapter is about: how we know what we know about ancient South Asia, from the first farmers to the end of the Gupta Empire.

2.2 How Do We Know? Clues from the Ground and from Memory

Think about how a detective works. There is no confession, so the detective reads small clues: a footprint, a receipt, a coffee cup. Historians of ancient South Asia work the same way. For the oldest periods, there are no books that anyone can read. The clues come from the ground.

Archaeology is the study of the human past through the things people left behind: buildings, tools, pots, beads, bones and seeds. Archaeologists dig carefully, layer by layer. The deeper layers are usually older. Scientists can measure the age of things like charcoal, seeds and bone using **radiocarbon dating**, which reads the slow, steady decay of a form of carbon. That gives a date range, not an exact year, which is why almost every date in this chapter has the word "about" in front of it.

For later periods there are words too: texts that were memorized and passed on by voice for centuries, then inscriptions carved in stone, coins with kings' names, and reports by travelers from Greece and China. Each kind of clue has limits. Pots can't tell you what people believed, and a king's inscription tells you what he wanted people to think. Good history uses all of them together.

A quick note on dates. **BCE** means "before the Common Era," and **CE** means "Common Era." They count the same years as BC and AD. When you count BCE dates, bigger numbers are further back in time, so 7000 BCE is older than 2600 BCE.

2.3 The First Farmers: Mehrgarh

Mehrgarh is an archaeological site on the Kachhi Plain in Balochistan, Pakistan, near the Bolan Pass, a gap in the hills that leads toward Afghanistan and Iran. It is one of the earliest known places in South Asia where people farmed and herded animals. French archaeologists Jean-François and Catherine Jarrige discovered it in 1974.

The first village at Mehrgarh is usually dated to **about 7000 BCE**. Its people grew wheat and barley and raised sheep, goats and cattle. They lived in houses made of mud brick and buried their dead with ornaments. Over thousands of years the village grew, and its people learned to make pottery and work copper.

Archaeology keeps changing, and Mehrgarh shows how. In 2025, a team led by the archaeologist Benjamin Mutin radiocarbon-dated tooth enamel from 23 of the oldest graves and got a much younger start, about 5200 to 4900 BCE (*Scientific Reports*, 2025). So the start of Mehrgarh is a live debate, but nobody disputes that it was a very early farming village.

There's one more surprising find. In 2006, scientists reported in the journal *Nature* that some teeth from Mehrgarh had tiny holes drilled in them while the people were still alive. It is some of the oldest known evidence of something like dentistry anywhere in the world (how old exactly depends on which Mehrgarh dates turn out to be right).

Mehrgarh matters because cities need food. Farming villages like it are the roots the region's first cities grew from.

2.4 The Indus Valley Civilization

A civilization bigger than Egypt and Mesopotamia

The **Indus Valley Civilization** was a Bronze Age civilization that grew up along the Indus River and nearby rivers, mostly in what is now Pakistan and northwestern India, with outposts as far as northeastern Afghanistan. It is also called the **Harappan Civilization**, after Harappa, the first of its cities to be excavated. Its full city-building phase, which archaeologists call the Mature Harappan period, lasted from **about 2600 to 1900 BCE**. Early Harappan towns go back to about 3300 BCE.

It was one of the world's three earliest civilizations, alongside Mesopotamia (in today's Iraq) and Egypt. Of the three, it covered by far the most land. According to *Encyclopaedia Britannica*, its sites stretch from Sutkagen Dor near the Arabian Sea coast of Balochistan to Ropar at the foot of the Shimla Hills in India's Punjab, and as far east as the Yamuna River basin north of Delhi. A Harappan trading post, Shortugai, even sat on the Amu Darya (Oxus) River in northern Afghanistan. Of more than a thousand known sites, most were villages and small towns.

Harappa and Mohenjo-daro

Harappa and Mohenjo-daro are the two best-known cities of the Indus Valley Civilization, both in present-day Pakistan. Excavations began at Harappa, in Punjab, in 1921, and at Mohenjo-daro, in Sindh, beside the Indus River, in 1922. Other large cities include Dholavira and Rakhigarhi, both in India, and Ganeriwala in Pakistan's Cholistan Desert.

These cities stand out because they were planned so carefully. At Mohenjo-daro:

- The streets meet at right angles, like a grid.
- Most buildings were made of baked brick.
- Many houses had a room for bathing, and waste water flowed into **covered drains** that ran along the main streets.
- A large, watertight brick pool, now called the **Great Bath**, may have been used for ritual washing.
- The city had a raised western area that archaeologists call the citadel, and a larger lower town.

UNESCO, which made the ruins of Mohenjo-daro a World Heritage Site in 1980, describes it as the best-preserved city in South Asia from the 3rd millennium BCE. The site covers about 240 hectares, and only about a third of it has been dug up since 1922. Britannica cites estimates of about 35,000 to 41,000 people at Mohenjo-daro and about 23,500 to 35,000 at Harappa, which would make them very large cities for their time.

Feature	What archaeologists found	What it suggests
Grid streets	Main streets crossing at right angles	Planning by some kind of authority

Feature	What archaeologists found	What it suggests
Standard weights	Stone weights that follow the same system across a huge area	Shared rules and well-organized trade
Covered drains	Brick drains along streets, fed by house bathrooms	Care for cleanliness and public works
Great Bath	A watertight pool with steps at Mohenjo-daro	Possibly ritual bathing; its exact use is unknown
Seals	Small stone stamps with animals and short inscriptions	Trade, ownership marks, maybe religious symbols
Few palaces or big temples	No clear royal palace or royal tomb found	Power may have been shared in ways we don't yet understand

Indus people grew wheat, barley, peas, sesame and some of the earliest known cotton, and Indus objects such as red carnelian beads have turned up as far away as Mesopotamia. A tiny bronze figure nicknamed the "Dancing Girl" and a stone bust nicknamed the "Priest-King" are two famous finds. Modern archaeologists invented both nicknames, and nobody knows who the figures really showed.

Spot the guess

Notice how many words in this section are labels that modern people made up: "Great Bath," "citadel," "Priest-King." When you read about the Indus cities, ask: is this something the evidence shows, or a guess dressed up as a name?

Why did the cities fade?

The big Indus cities did not end in one dramatic day. Britannica describes a decline in stages between about 2000 and 1750 BCE. Mohenjo-daro had been hit by serious floods more than once, and its houses got more crowded and more poorly built over time. Many scholars think shifting rivers and a drier climate made it harder to farm near the old cities. People did not vanish. They moved to smaller villages, many of them farther east and south, and kept farming and making crafts.

2.5 The Indus Script: A Puzzle Still Unsolved

The **Indus Script** is the set of signs that Indus people carved on seals, pottery, tools and small tablets. It has **not been deciphered**, which means nobody can read it with confidence.

Four problems make it so hard:

- **The inscriptions are tiny.** The average one is about five signs long. Imagine learning a language from license plates.
- **There are many signs.** Scholars count around 400 (the Indian scholar Iravatham Mahadevan listed 419 in the 1970s), too many for an alphabet.

- **There is no "Rosetta Stone."** No inscription has been found with the same text in a language we can already read.
- **Nobody knows the language.** Some scholars link it to the Dravidian family, which includes Tamil and Telugu, and others disagree. A few argue the signs were not full writing at all, more like merchants' marks.

The puzzle still makes news. In January 2025, M. K. Stalin, the chief minister of the Indian state of Tamil Nadu, announced a prize of 1 million US dollars for anyone who deciphers the script to the satisfaction of archaeological experts. As of 2026, no decipherment has been accepted by scholars.

Be careful with 'solved!' headlines

Every few years, someone claims to have cracked the Indus Script. Until other experts can test a decipherment and read new inscriptions with it, treat those claims as ideas, not facts.

2.6 New Languages and the Vedic Period

The Indo-Aryan Migration

After the Indus cities faded, a new language family spread across northern South Asia. The languages most people in Pakistan, northern India, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka speak today, including Hindi, Urdu, Punjabi, Bangla, Nepali and Sinhala, belong to the **Indo-Aryan** branch of the Indo-European language family. That family also includes Persian, Greek, Latin, English and Ben's family languages, Swedish and Norwegian.

How did related languages end up in places as far apart as Norway and Bangladesh? The explanation most scholars accept is the **Indo-Aryan Migration**: the idea that people speaking early Indo-Aryan languages

moved into the northwest of the subcontinent from Central Asia in gradual waves, starting **after about 2000 BCE**, and that over centuries their languages spread and mixed with the languages and peoples already living there.

Three kinds of evidence support it:

1. **Language.** Words in Sanskrit, Persian, Greek and Latin match in regular, predictable ways, which points to a common ancestor spoken far to the northwest.
2. **Genetics.** A 2019 study of ancient DNA from 523 people, published in *Science* (Narasimhan and colleagues), found that ancestry linked to herders of the Central Asian steppe spread into South Asia starting around 4,000 years ago. A second 2019 study, in *Cell*, read the DNA of a person buried at the Indus city of Rakhigarhi in India and found little if any steppe ancestry. Together they suggest this ancestry arrived after the Indus cities were built.
3. **Texts.** The oldest Vedic hymns were composed in the northwest of the subcontinent, the region where the languages first arrived, and only later texts describe lands farther east.

Just as important is what the evidence does **not** show. An older colonial-era theory imagined an "Aryan invasion" in which conquerors destroyed the Indus cities. Scholars reject it. The cities were already declining for other reasons, there's no sign of one great war, and the movement of people looks slow. The colonial version was also tied to racist ideas about skin color.

The word "Aryan" itself needs care. In the old texts, *arya* meant "noble," a name for people who shared a language and customs, not a "race." European racists, and later the Nazis, twisted it into a racist label.

Whose Story?

Most linguists, archaeologists and geneticists worldwide accept that Indo-Aryan languages arrived through gradual migration over centuries, mixing with the people already living in the region. Some writers and scholars in India dispute this. They argue that Vedic culture grew up locally, sometimes linking it directly to the Indus cities, and they point to cultural continuity across the region. In Pakistan, the Indus cities are taught as the deep roots of the nation's own land, from Mohenjo-daro in Sindh to Harappa in Punjab. Tamil scholars and politicians often stress a possible Dravidian link to the Indus Script. The same ancient DNA results have been quoted by people on different sides of these debates, so it is worth reading the actual studies, not just headlines about them.

The Vedic Period

The **Vedic Period** is the era, from **about 1500 to 500 BCE**, when the Vedas were composed in northern South Asia. It sits between the end of the Indus cities and the rise of new cities and kingdoms around 600 BCE.

Early Vedic people lived mostly in the Punjab region, organized into tribes rather than kingdoms, and lived largely by herding. Priests performed rituals around a sacred fire while chanting hymns. Between about 1200 and 1000 BCE, Vedic culture spread east into the western Ganga plain, and the Kuru kingdom became its new center.

This is also when **varna**, a division of society into priests, warriors and rulers, farmers and traders, and laborers, appears in Vedic texts. Varna is an idea from the texts. In everyday life, people later belonged to thousands of local groups, called *jati*, that were usually inherited and married within the group. Over many centuries, the textual varna idea and these local jati groups together shaped what is now called caste, and how they fit together varied

from region to region. You'll learn about that long and painful history, and about the movements against caste discrimination, in Chapter 13.

The Vedas

The Vedas (वेद, *VAY-duh*, "knowledge") are four collections of sacred hymns, chants, ritual instructions and teachings composed in an early form of Sanskrit. They are the oldest scriptures of Hinduism. The four are:

- the **Rigveda**, a collection of hymns of praise to gods such as Agni (fire) and Indra (storm and war);
- the **Samaveda**, hymns arranged for singing;
- the **Yajurveda**, prayers and formulas for priests to use during rituals;
- the **Atharvaveda**, which includes prayers for health, protection and everyday life.

Most scholars date the bulk of the Rigveda, the oldest, to about 1500 to 1000 BCE. Later layers include the **Upanishads**, philosophical dialogues about the self and ultimate reality that shaped central ideas in Hinduism.

The way the Vedas survived is unusual. For centuries nobody wrote them down at all. Teachers passed them to students by voice, using memory techniques so precise that the sound of each word stayed fixed for thousands of years. UNESCO recognized the **Tradition of Vedic Chanting** as part of the world's intangible cultural heritage (it was proclaimed in 2003 and inscribed on the list in 2008). In Hindu tradition, the Vedas are *shruti*, "what is heard," revealed to ancient sages rather than written by human authors.

Sanskrit

Sanskrit (संस्कृत, *SUNS-krit*, "refined" or "perfected") is the classical language of ancient South Asia, part of the Indo-Aryan branch of the Indo-European

family. The oldest form, used in the Vedas, is called Vedic Sanskrit. Later, a grammarian named **Panini**, who most scholars place around the 4th century BCE (some argue earlier), described the language in a famous grammar called the *Ashtadhyayi*, "Eight Chapters." His rules shaped Classical Sanskrit for the next two thousand years.

Sanskrit became the language of Hindu scripture, philosophy, drama, poetry and science, and many Buddhist and Jain texts used it too. For centuries it was a shared language of learning, a bit like Latin in medieval Europe. Its words live on in many modern languages and even in English: "yoga," "karma," "avatar" and "jungle" all trace back to Sanskrit.

2.7 Cities Return: The Mahajanapadas

Around 600 BCE, something happened in the Ganga plain that had not happened in South Asia since the Indus cities: big towns and cities appeared again. Historians call this the "second urbanization."

The **Mahajanapadas** (महाजनपद, *muh-HAA-jun-uh-puh-duh*, "great realms") were the sixteen large kingdoms and republics that ruled northern South Asia from about the 6th to the 4th century BCE. The word comes from *maha*, "great," and *janapada*, a territory where a people (*jana*) had settled. Old Buddhist texts list sixteen of them, stretching from Gandhara in the northwest (today's northern Pakistan and eastern Afghanistan) to Anga in the east (today's Bihar, India).

Most were ruled by kings, but a couple were governed by councils of leading families, which historians sometimes call republics. Over time, the kingdom of **Magadha**, in today's Bihar, swallowed its neighbors. Its rulers built a fort at a village on the Ganga that grew into the city of **Pataliputra**, near modern Patna. Pataliputra would become the capital of two of the biggest empires in this chapter.

In the far northwest, the city of **Taxila**, near today's Islamabad in Pakistan, became an important stop on trade routes to Central Asia. UNESCO's description of the site notes that Alexander the Great entered Taxila in 326 BCE, during his campaign into the Punjab.

2.8 New Paths: The Rise of Buddhism and Jainism

The new cities brought new wealth and new kinds of work, and with them came new questions. Some people began to doubt that elaborate fire rituals were the only path to a good life. Wandering teachers, called *shramanas*, gave up home and possessions to search for answers through meditation and simple living. Two of these teachers started traditions that are still alive today.

The **Rise of Buddhism and Jainism** describes how these two traditions began in the Ganga plain in the 6th or 5th century BCE, during the age of the Mahajanapadas, and grew into religions followed by millions.

The Buddha

Siddhartha Gautama, who became known as **the Buddha**, "the awakened one," lived in the 6th or 5th century BCE. Historians are not sure of his exact dates. According to Buddhist tradition:

- He was born into a ruling family of the Shakya clan at **Lumbini**, in what is now southern Nepal.
- He left his comfortable life to search for an end to suffering.
- He reached awakening (enlightenment) while meditating under a fig tree at **Bodh Gaya**, in today's Bihar, India.
- He gave his first teaching at the Deer Park at **Sarnath**, near Varanasi.

- He died at **Kushinagar**, in today's Uttar Pradesh, India.

The Buddha taught a "Middle Way" between luxury and extreme self-denial. His core teachings are the Four Noble Truths (life involves suffering; suffering has a cause in craving; suffering can end; and there is a path to end it) and the Noble Eightfold Path, a practice of ethics, mindfulness and meditation. He founded a community of monks and, later, nuns, called the *sangha*.

Mahavira and Jainism

Mahavira, "the great hero," was born Vardhamana in today's Bihar and lived around the same time as the Buddha. Jains consider him the 24th and last *Tirthankara*, or "ford-maker," of the present age: a teacher who made a crossing over the sea of rebirth for others. Jainism's most basic rule is **ahimsa**, non-violence toward every living being. Some Jain monks carry a soft brush to gently move insects out of their path.

	Buddhism	Jainism
Key teacher	Siddhartha Gautama, the Buddha	Mahavira (the 24th Tirthankara)
When	6th or 5th century BCE	6th or 5th century BCE
Where	Ganga plain (Lumbini, Bodh Gaya, Sarnath)	Ganga plain (today's Bihar)
Central idea	The Middle Way; the Four Noble Truths	Ahimsa, non-violence to all living things

Both traditions questioned the idea that rituals performed by priests were the only path to a good life. Hindu thought was changing at the same time, too,

and the Upanishads were asking similar deep questions about the self, rebirth and freedom. You'll explore all three faiths, and more, in Chapter 5.

2.9 The Maurya Empire and Ashoka

The first great empire

The **Maurya Empire** was the first empire to rule most of the Indian subcontinent. It lasted from **about 321 to 185 BCE**, with its capital at **Pataliputra**.

It was founded by **Chandragupta Maurya**, who took the Punjab after Alexander the Great's death in 323 BCE. Around 305 BCE he fought Seleucus, one of Alexander's generals, and the two made a treaty that gave Chandragupta lands in the northwest. A Greek ambassador, Megasthenes, lived at his court. His book is lost, but pieces survive in later Greek and Roman writers. Chandragupta's son Bindusara pushed the empire south into the Deccan. The Mauryas ran a large government with a standing army and officials, and kept up a great royal road running from the northwest to Pataliputra.

Ashoka: a ruler who changed course

Ashoka (also spelled Asoka) was the third Maurya emperor and Chandragupta's grandson. He ruled from **about 268 to 232 BCE** (Britannica gives two possible ranges, about 265 to 238 BCE or about 273 to 232 BCE). His empire stretched from present-day Afghanistan in the west to present-day Bangladesh in the east.

In the eighth year of his reign, about 260 BCE, Ashoka conquered **Kalinga**, a region on the Bay of Bengal coast in today's Odisha, India. The war was brutal. In one of his own inscriptions, Ashoka said that 150,000 people were

carried away as captives, 100,000 were killed, and many times that number died. He wrote that he felt deep sorrow and regret.

After Kalinga, Ashoka gave up conquering new lands by war. He became a follower of Buddhism and promoted what he called **dhamma** (𑀥𑀫्𑀫, *DUM-muh*, "righteousness" or "right conduct," the Prakrit form of the Sanskrit word *dharma*). For Ashoka, dhamma meant things like non-violence, tolerance of all religious groups and opinions, obedience to parents, respect for priests and religious teachers, and humane treatment of servants.

He ended the royal hunts, and Buddhist tradition says he built many stupas (dome-shaped shrines holding relics) and sent missions to other lands. The Sri Lankan chronicle *Mahavamsa* says he sent his son Mahinda and his daughter Sanghamitta to Sri Lanka as missionaries.

Ashoka is on your money

Look at an Indian rupee note. The lion emblem on it is India's state emblem, adapted from the four-lion pillar top Ashoka put up at Sarnath, and the 24-spoked wheel in the middle of India's flag is the Ashoka Chakra.

The Edicts of Ashoka

The **Edicts of Ashoka** are messages that Ashoka had carved on rocks and on tall polished stone pillars across his empire. They are some of the oldest readable written documents in South Asia. Most were written in Prakrit, an everyday form of the languages related to Sanskrit, using the **Brahmi** script. Brahmi is the ancestor of dozens of modern scripts, including Devanagari, Bangla, Tamil and Sinhala.

The edicts were written for local readers. In today's Pakistan, some used the **Kharoshthi** script, written right to left. Near Kandahar, in **Afghanistan**, one was carved in **Greek and Aramaic**. At **Lumbini** in Nepal, Ashoka put up a pillar marking the Buddha's birthplace, and UNESCO dates it to 249 BCE.

Over the following centuries Brahmi changed so much that nobody could read the edicts, and Ashoka was nearly forgotten. Between 1836 and 1838, James Prinsep, a British official and scholar in Calcutta (now Kolkata), worked out the Brahmi script, and Ashoka returned to history.

Not every Ashokan inscription fits the gentle image, though. Ashoka did not give back the lands he had conquered, and Kalinga stayed part of his empire. In the Kalinga region itself, his inscriptions leave out the edict that expresses regret for the war. One possible reason is that confessing to the people he had conquered did not seem politically wise. Ashoka really did rethink power after a terrible war, but he was still an emperor.

After Ashoka's death, the empire weakened. The last Maurya ruler was overthrown about 185 BCE.

2.10 Crossroads in the North: The Kushan Empire

After the Mauryas, many smaller kingdoms ruled the north, and new groups came through the northwest passes, including Greek kings from Bactria (today's northern Afghanistan and Central Asia). The most powerful newcomers built the **Kushan Empire**, which ruled from **about the 1st to the 3rd century CE** (some scholars extend it into the 4th). The Kushans came from Central Asia.

At its height, their empire covered much of today's Afghanistan, Pakistan and northern India, along with parts of Central Asia. Its most famous ruler, **Kanishka**, came to the throne around 127 CE. His main capital was

Purushapura (today's **Peshawar**, Pakistan), with a second major capital at **Mathura** in northern India.

The Kushan Empire sat on the **Silk Road**, the trade routes linking China, Central Asia, Persia, India and the Roman world. Some Kushan kings honored the Hindu god Shiva, and Kanishka strongly supported Buddhism. Two things grew out of this crossroads:

- **Gandhara art.** In the region of Gandhara, around Peshawar and Taxila, artists mixed Buddhist subjects with styles learned from Greek and Roman art. Some of the earliest surviving statues showing the Buddha in human form were made in Gandhara and in Mathura during Kushan rule.
- **Buddhism's journey east.** Monks, merchants and pilgrims carried Buddhism from Gandhara across the Karakoram mountains into Central Asia and China.

2.11 The Tamil South: The Sangam Age

The south had its own kingdoms, language and literature. It wasn't simply a copy of the north.

The **Sangam Age** is the period in the Tamil-speaking south of the subcontinent when the earliest Tamil poetry was composed. Most scholars place it between **about 300 BCE and 300 CE**, though some argue for a narrower range (the Tamil literature scholar Kamil Zvelebil suggested about 100 BCE to 250 CE). The dates are debated because the poems rarely mention events that can be dated.

The word *Sangam* (சங்கம், *SUNG-um*) means "assembly" or "academy." Tamil tradition says poets gathered in academies under the Pandya kings at Madurai. Scholars treat the oldest parts of that story as legend, but the poems are real. They fall into two groups:

- **Akam** ("inner") poems about love, each tied to a particular landscape, such as mountains, forests, farmland or seashore.
- **Puram** ("outer") poems about war, kings, generosity, death and public life.

Three ruling families, called the "three crowned kings," dominated the Tamil country: the **Cheras** on the west coast (in today's Kerala), the **Cholas** in the Kaveri River delta, and the **Pandyas** around **Madurai**. They often fought each other.

The Tamil south grew rich from sea trade. Ports like **Muziris**, on the Malabar Coast in today's Kerala, traded pepper with the Roman world and the Middle East. Roman writers such as Pliny the Elder described it, and a Tamil poem describes foreign ships arriving with gold and leaving with pepper. You'll follow this ocean trade in Chapter 3.

Meanwhile, in Sri Lanka and Bangladesh

Ancient history happened across the region, not only in today's India.

- In **Sri Lanka**, **Anuradhapura** became the capital of a Sinhala kingdom in the 4th century BCE (377 BCE, according to the chronicles) and stayed a capital for well over a thousand years. Tradition says Sanghamitta brought a cutting of the Bodhi tree there in the 3rd century BCE, and a tree grown from it still stands. The city became a center of Theravada Buddhism. UNESCO listed the Sacred City of Anuradhapura as a World Heritage Site in 1982.
- In **Bangladesh**, **Mahasthangarh**, in today's Bogura (Bogra) District, is the earliest city site found so far. A limestone slab carved with six lines of Prakrit in the Brahmi script, found there in 1931, shows the city existed by at least the 3rd century BCE, when it was an important town under the Mauryas. Zara's Nanu calls it "very, very old," and she's right.

2.12 The Gupta Empire and Nalanda

The Guptas

The **Gupta Empire** ruled much of northern and central South Asia from **about 320 to 550 CE**. Its kings came from Magadha, the same region as the Mauryas, and Pataliputra was again a major capital.

Chandragupta I (not the Maurya one) began the dynasty's rise around 319 or 320 CE. His son **Samudragupta** expanded it through war, and **Chandragupta II** extended it west to Ujjain, though his reign is remembered more for culture than conquest. Sanskrit literature and science did well under the Guptas. The poet and playwright **Kalidasa** wrote famous Sanskrit works such as the play *Shakuntala*. The mathematician and astronomer **Aryabhata** wrote his book, the *Aryabhatiya*, in 499 CE, when he was 23 years old, according to the book itself. You'll meet Aryabhata again in Chapter 16, along with the story of zero and the decimal place-value system.

Historians used to call the Gupta period India's "Golden Age." Many now question that label: some achievements once credited to the Guptas began earlier, and "golden" mostly describes life for the wealthy. The empire weakened under attacks by the **Hunas** from Central Asia and the breakaway of its own local rulers, and by the mid-500s it had shrunk to a small kingdom.

Nalanda

Nalanda was a great Buddhist monastery and center of learning in today's Bihar, India. Most historians date its founding to the reign of the Gupta emperor **Kumaragupta I**, around 427 CE. It grew into one of the most famous places of study in Asia and operated for roughly 800 years.

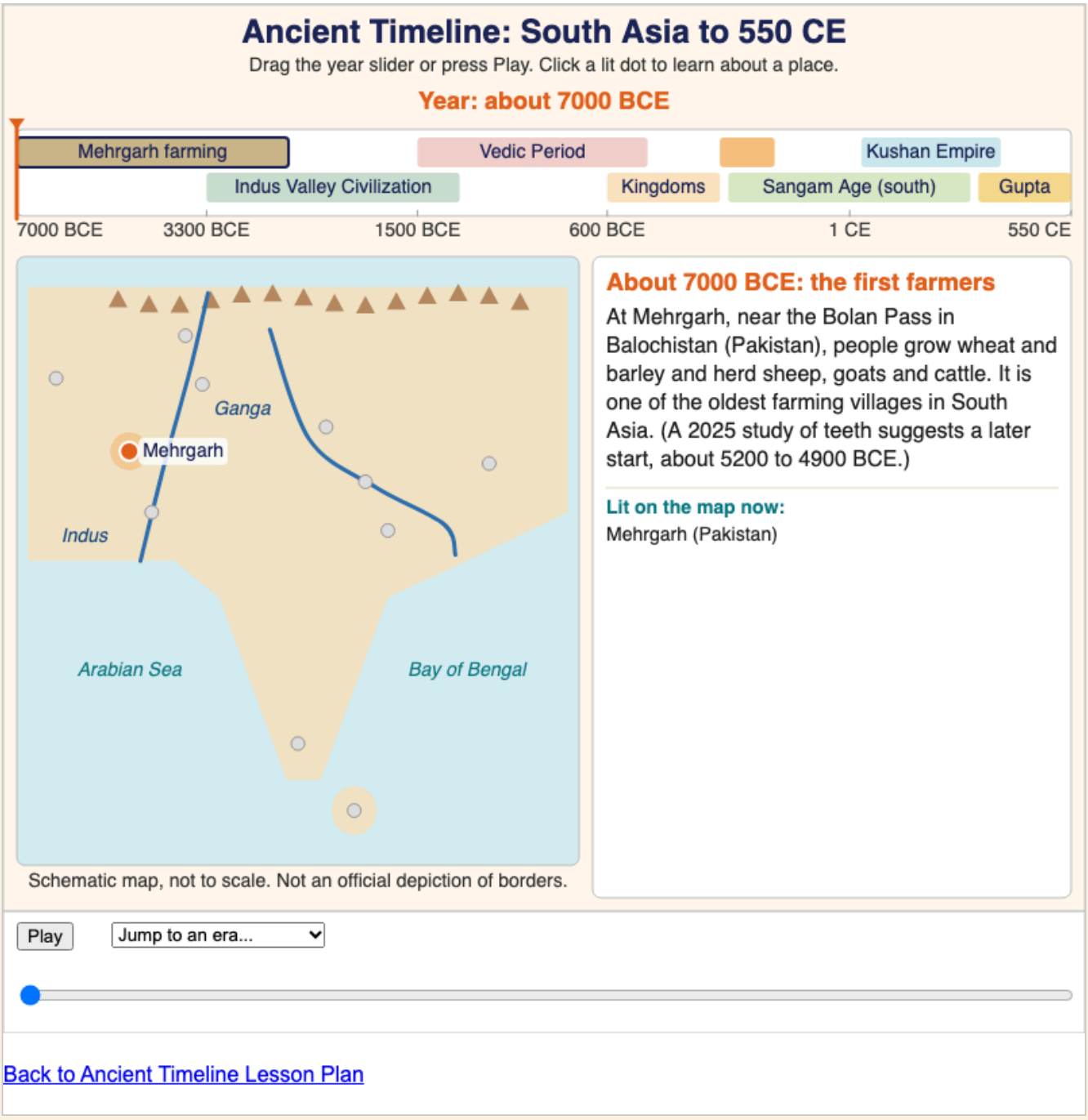
Monks and students there studied Buddhist philosophy along with grammar, logic, medicine, mathematics and astronomy. They lived in brick buildings

called *viharas*, and the monastery had a famous library. Students and scholars came from as far away as China and Korea. The Chinese pilgrim and scholar **Xuanzang** studied there in the 7th century and carried many texts back to China. Nalanda was badly damaged in attacks around 1200 CE and was later abandoned.

UNESCO made the Archaeological Site of Nalanda Mahavihara a World Heritage Site in 2016, calling it the most ancient university of the Indian subcontinent. Some historians note that "university" is a modern word that fits imperfectly, since Nalanda was first of all a monastery.

Our story ends around 550 CE, as the Gupta Empire fades. New kingdoms, new faiths and new traders are about to arrive, and that is the story of Chapter 3.

Diagram: Ancient Timeline



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch02-ancient-timeline/main.html

Open the Ancient Timeline fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Ancient Timeline

sim-id: ch02-ancient-timeline
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: sequence
Learning Objective: The learner will put the major ancient periods of South Asia in order, from Mehrgarh (about 7000 BCE) to the end of the Gupta Empire (about 550 CE), and connect each period to the places where it happened.

Canvas: responsive width; 670 px drawing area plus 90 px control area.

Controls: year slider (about 7000 BCE to 550 CE, with more room given to later centuries), Play / Pause button, "Jump to an era" menu; click or tap a dot on the map.

Behavior: Eight period bands sit on a timeline strip; bands containing the current year are highlighted. Eleven dots on a schematic map (Mehrgarh, Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Taxila, Kandahar, Lumbini, Pataliputra, Nalanda, Mahasthangarh, Madurai, Anuradhapura) light up while each place mattered. An event card describes the current year; clicking a dot names its present-day country. Starts paused at 7000 BCE. The schematic-map caption is drawn inside the drawing area.

Drag the slider slowly from left to right and watch which dots light up. The timeline gives later centuries more room, so the early farming period is even longer than it looks. Stop at 2200 BCE, 250 BCE and 500 CE and read the event card each time.

Then look for overlaps: at 100 CE, two bands are highlighted at once, the Kushans in the north and the Sangam kings in the south. Finally, click every lit dot to find its present-day country. You should end up able to name an

ancient place in Pakistan, India, Afghanistan, Nepal, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about the ancient past: stories they heard as children, old places they visited, and how history was taught in their school. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Pull up a photo of one ancient place from this chapter, such as Mohenjo-daro, Lumbini, Sarnath, Anuradhapura or Mahasthangarh, and show it to them first. Ask if it's okay to take notes.

Questions to ask

1. When you were growing up, what stories did you hear about the very distant past? Who told them?
2. Have you ever visited an ancient site, like Mohenjo-daro, Taxila, Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, Lumbini, Anuradhapura or Mahasthangarh? What do you remember about it?
3. What did your school teach about the Indus cities, the Vedas, the Buddha or Ashoka? Was there a part of that history your teachers were especially proud of?
4. Are there old words, prayers, chants or sayings in our family that you were told come from a very old language, like Sanskrit, Pali or old Tamil?

5. Has the way people talk about ancient history changed since you were young, or since you moved here? Do people argue about it more now?
6. What is one thing about the ancient past of our region that you hope I'll always remember?

Listen for: names of places tied to Harappa and Mohenjo-daro or the Rise of Buddhism and Jainism, any mention of Ashoka or the Vedas, and signs that your elder learned a different version of the story, like the debate over the Indo-Aryan Migration.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare what your elder learned in school with what this chapter says. Did they learn about periods or places this chapter mentions, such as Mehrgarh, the Indus Script or the Sangam Age? If a friend interviewed someone who went to school in a different country, such as Pakistan, India, Bangladesh, Nepal or Sri Lanka, list two ways their versions of ancient history were different and one way they were the same.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: South Asian history begins with the Vedas.
Reality: Farming villages like Mehrgarh go back to about 7000 BCE (some say later), and the planned cities of the Indus Valley Civilization flourished from about 2600 to 1900 BCE, centuries before the Rigveda was composed.

Myth: Scholars have figured out how to read the Indus Script.
Reality: The Indus Script is still undeciphered. Its inscriptions are very short, there is no bilingual text to help, and the language is unknown. In 2025 the government of Tamil Nadu offered a 1 million US dollar prize for a decipherment that experts accept.

Myth: "Aryans" invaded and destroyed the Indus cities.
Reality: The Indus cities declined gradually between about 2000 and 1750 BCE, likely because of floods, shifting rivers and a drier climate. Most scholars think Indo-Aryan speakers arrived slowly over centuries and mixed with people already there. The violent "Aryan invasion" story is an outdated colonial-era theory that scholars reject.

Myth: Ashoka was always a peaceful Buddhist king.
Reality: Ashoka fought a bloody war to conquer Kalinga, around 260 BCE, before turning to Buddhism and dhamma. Even afterward he kept his army and his empire, and the edict in which he expresses regret was left out of the inscriptions in Kalinga itself.

Myth: Ancient South Asian history happened only in what is now India.
Reality: Mehrgarh, Harappa, Mohenjo-daro and Taxila are in Pakistan; Lumbini is in Nepal; Ashoka's Greek and Aramaic edict is near Kandahar in Afghanistan; Mahasthangarh is in Bangladesh; and Anuradhapura is in Sri Lanka.

Check Yourself

1. Why is Mehrgarh important?

It is one of the earliest known farming villages in South Asia, usually dated to about 7000 BCE. Its people grew wheat and barley and herded animals, and villages like it were the base the later Indus cities grew from.

2. Name three features that show Mohenjo-daro was a planned city.

Any three of these: grid streets meeting at right angles, baked-brick buildings, covered drains along the streets, bathrooms in houses, and a raised citadel area with the Great Bath.

3. Give two reasons the Indus Script is so hard to decipher.

The inscriptions are very short (about five signs on average), there is no bilingual text like the Rosetta Stone, and nobody knows what language it recorded. Any two are correct.

4. What changed after Ashoka's war in Kalinga?

Ashoka gave up conquering new lands by war, turned to Buddhism and promoted dhamma, or right conduct, through edicts carved on rocks and pillars across his empire.

5. Which empire founded Nalanda, and about when?

The Gupta Empire. Most historians date Nalanda's founding to the reign of Kumaragupta I, around 427 CE.

Exercises

Remember

1. Put these in order from oldest to newest: Maurya Empire, Mehrgarh, Gupta Empire, Indus cities at their height, Vedic Period.

Answer

Mehrgarh (about 7000 BCE), Indus cities at their height (about 2600 to 1900 BCE), Vedic Period (about 1500 to 500 BCE), Maurya Empire (about 321 to 185 BCE), Gupta Empire (about 320 to 550 CE).

2. Name the four Vedas.

Answer

The Rigveda, the Samaveda, the Yajurveda and the Atharvaveda.

Understand

1. Explain why almost every date in this chapter starts with "about."

Answer

Ancient dates come from methods like radiocarbon dating, which give a range, and from texts that often don't name exact years. Scholars also disagree about some dates, such as Mehrgarh's start and the Sangam Age.

2. Explain the difference between the Indo-Aryan Migration that most scholars accept and the old "Aryan invasion" theory.

Answer

The migration idea says Indo-Aryan speakers arrived gradually over centuries after about 2000 BCE and mixed with people already living there. The invasion theory claimed a violent conquest that destroyed the Indus cities. The evidence does not support a single invasion, and the cities were already declining for other reasons.

Apply

1. Use the Ancient Timeline. Set the year to about 100 CE. List every place that is lit and the present-day country it is in. Which two period bands overlap? *Hint: one band is in the north and one in the far south.*
2. A cousin says, "Buddhism is from Sri Lanka." Using this chapter, write two sentences that politely correct and add to that statement. *Hint: think about Lumbini, Bodh Gaya and Ashoka's missions.*

Analyze

1. Compare the kinds of evidence historians use for the Indus Valley Civilization and for Ashoka's reign. Why do we know so much more about what Ashoka believed? *Hint: one of them left writing people can read.*
2. Ashoka's regret for the Kalinga war appears in edicts across his empire but not in the edicts placed in Kalinga itself. Analyze what this might tell us about Ashoka as a ruler. *Hint: who was the audience for each inscription?*

Evaluate

1. Some historians call the Gupta period India's "Golden Age," and others reject the label. Which side do you find more convincing? Use at least two facts from the chapter. *Hint: ask "golden for whom?"*
2. Your club wants to put "Ancient India" as the title of a slide about Harappa, Taxila and Lumbini. Evaluate whether that title is accurate and fair, and suggest a better one. *Hint: check which present-day countries those sites are in.*

Create

1. Create a five-panel comic strip that follows one object through time, such as a Harappan seal, a Brahmi inscription or a Nalanda manuscript, from when it was made to when it was found or read again. *Hint: James Prinsep or the 1922 Mohenjo-daro dig could be a panel.*
2. Write a short museum label (80 to 120 words) for an Indus seal that tells visitors what we know, what we don't know, and why the script matters today. *Hint: use "about" for dates and avoid claims the evidence can't support.*

Key Takeaways

- Farming began early in South Asia: Mehrgarh, in Pakistan's Balochistan, is usually dated to about 7000 BCE.
- The Indus Valley Civilization (about 2600 to 1900 BCE at its height) built planned cities like Harappa and Mohenjo-daro, and its script is still undeciphered.
- Most scholars think Indo-Aryan languages arrived through gradual migration after about 2000 BCE; the violent "Aryan invasion" story is

rejected, and some people in India dispute migration altogether.

- The Vedic Period produced the Vedas in Sanskrit, kept alive for centuries by careful memorization.
- The Buddha and Mahavira lived in the world of the Mahajanapadas, the new cities and kingdoms of northern South Asia, and their teachings became Buddhism and Jainism.
- The Mauryas, especially Ashoka, built the first empire across most of the subcontinent; the Kushans linked the north to the Silk Road; Tamil kingdoms of the Sangam Age traded across the sea; and the Guptas supported Sanskrit learning and founded Nalanda.
- Ancient South Asian history belongs to the whole region: Pakistan, India, Afghanistan, Nepal, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka all hold key sites.

Seven thousand years, done!

You just crossed about 7,000 years of history, and you can now explain why Ben's tiny seal is such a big deal. Next, in Chapter 3, new empires rise, Islam arrives and spreads, Sikhism begins in Punjab, and European ships appear on the horizon.

Quiz: Ancient Roots

Test your understanding of Chapter 2. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

Mehrgarh, one of the earliest farming villages in South Asia, is in which present-day country?

A. India

B. Afghanistan

C. Pakistan

D. Nepal

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Mehrgarh is on the Kachhi Plain in Balochistan, Pakistan, near the Bolan Pass. Afghanistan is a tempting guess because the pass leads toward it, but the site itself is in Pakistan.

Concept Tested: Mehrgarh **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

About when did the Mature Harappan cities of the Indus Valley Civilization flourish?

A. About 2600 to 1900 BCE

B. About 7000 to 5000 BCE

C. About 1500 to 500 BCE

D. About 321 to 185 BCE

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The planned Indus cities were at their height from about 2600 to 1900 BCE. About 1500 to 500 BCE is the Vedic Period, which came after the cities faded, and 321 to 185 BCE is the Maurya Empire.

Concept Tested: Indus Valley Civilization **Bloom's Level:** Remember

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Question 3

Which statement about the Indus Script is accurate as of 2026?

A. It was deciphered in the 1830s by James Prinsep.

B. It has not been deciphered, partly because the inscriptions are very short and no bilingual text has been found.

C. It is an early form of the Brahmi alphabet and can be read easily.

D. It was deciphered after Tamil Nadu offered a prize in 2025.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The Indus Script is still undeciphered: inscriptions average about five signs, there is no Rosetta Stone, and the language is unknown. Prinsep deciphered Brahmi, Ashoka's script, not the Indus Script, and the 2025 prize has not been claimed with a decipherment experts accept.

Concept Tested: Indus Script **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Which feature of Mohenjo-daro best supports the idea that the city was carefully planned?

A. A huge royal palace at the center of the city

B. Gold coins stamped with the names of kings

C. Temples covered in readable inscriptions

D. Streets crossing at right angles, with covered drains along them

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Grid streets and covered drains fed by house bathrooms show planning. Archaeologists have not found a clear royal palace, and Indus writing cannot be read, so the other options describe things that were not found.

Concept Tested: Harappa and Mohenjo-daro **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 5

Which description of the Indo-Aryan Migration matches what most scholars accept today?

A. A sudden invasion around 1900 BCE that destroyed the Indus cities in battle

B. A movement of Indo-Aryan speakers from the south of India to Central Asia

C. A gradual movement of Indo-Aryan speakers into the northwest over centuries after about 2000 BCE, mixing with people already living there

D. A myth with no supporting evidence from language or genetics

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Linguistic and ancient DNA evidence supports gradual migration after about 2000 BCE. The violent "invasion" story (A) is an outdated colonial-era theory that scholars reject, because the cities were already declining for other reasons.

Concept Tested: Indo-Aryan Migration **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 6

How did the Vedas survive for many centuries before they were written down?

A. They were carved on stone pillars across the empire.

B. Teachers passed them to students by voice, using precise memory techniques.

C. They were painted on the walls of the Indus cities.

D. They were copied onto paper by monks at Nalanda.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The Vedas were passed on by voice, using very precise recitation methods, a tradition UNESCO recognizes as intangible cultural heritage. Carved pillars (A) were Ashoka's way of sharing his edicts, much later.

Concept Tested: The Vedas **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

Dilan's grandmother in Kandy tells him that the Bodhi tree in Anuradhapura grew from a cutting brought from the place where the Buddha reached awakening. Using the chapter, where did that cutting come from, and which emperor's family is linked to it?

A. Bodh Gaya, and Ashoka's daughter Sanghamitta

B. Lumbini, and Chandragupta Maurya's son

C. Nalanda, and the Gupta emperor Kumaragupta I

D. Taxila, and the Kushan emperor Kanishka

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The Buddha reached awakening at Bodh Gaya, and Sri Lankan tradition says Ashoka's daughter Sanghamitta brought the cutting in the 3rd century BCE. Lumbini (B) is the Buddha's birthplace, not the place of his awakening.

Concept Tested: Rise of Buddhism and Jainism **Bloom's Level:** Apply

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Question 8

Your club is making a map of ancient sites by present-day country. Which site belongs under Bangladesh?

A. Taxila

B. Anuradhapura

C. Pataliputra

D. Mahasthangarh

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Mahasthangarh, in Bogura (Bogra) District, is the earliest city site found in Bangladesh, dated by a Brahmi inscription to at least the 3rd century BCE. Pataliputra (C) was in Magadha, in today's Bihar, India, which is west of Bangladesh, not inside it.

Concept Tested: Maurya Empire **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Ashoka's edict expressing regret for the Kalinga war appears across his empire but was left out of the inscriptions placed in Kalinga itself. What is the best conclusion?

A. Ashoka never actually fought in Kalinga.

B. Ashoka's inscriptions were shaped for their audience, so they show both his new ideals and his political judgment as an emperor.

C. The Kalinga inscriptions were carved before the war began.

D. Ashoka stopped believing in dhamma after the war.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The omission suggests Ashoka chose his message for each audience, since confessing to the conquered people may not have seemed wise. His own inscriptions describe the war, so A is wrong, and he promoted dhamma for the rest of his reign, so D is wrong.

Concept Tested: Edicts of Ashoka **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

The Kushan Empire (about the 1st to 3rd century CE) and the Tamil kingdoms of the Sangam Age existed at the same time. What does that overlap show?

A. That one empire ruled all of South Asia in the 2nd century CE

B. That the Sangam poets were writing in Sanskrit for the Kushan court

C. That different regions had their own rulers, languages and cultures at the same moment

D. That the Kushans conquered Madurai

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. While the Kushans ruled the north from Peshawar and Mathura, Chera, Chola and Pandya kings ruled the Tamil south, where poets wrote in Tamil. Nothing in the chapter suggests a single empire (A) or a Kushan conquest of Madurai (D).

Concept Tested: Sangam Age **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters

Summary

Between about 600 and 1800 CE, South Asia was shared by many powers at once: ocean traders and temple-building kings in the south, island kingdoms in Sri Lanka, sultans in Delhi and Bengal, the Vijayanagara emperors, the Mughals, the Marathas, the Durranis of Afghanistan, and, from 1498, European trading companies. This chapter follows those powers and the people who moved between them: merchants, poets, saints and teachers. It also follows ideas, such as the devotional poetry of the bhakti movement, the Sufi path in Islam, and the teachings of Guru Nanak. By the end you'll be able to explain why the history of this period looks less like a relay race and more like a crowded highway with many lanes.

Concepts Covered

1. Indian Ocean Trade
2. Chola Dynasty
3. Sri Lankan Kingdoms
4. Early Islam in South Asia
5. Delhi Sultanate
6. Vijayanagara Empire
7. Bhakti Movement
8. Sufism

9. Guru Nanak
10. Mughal Empire
11. Akbar
12. Indo-Persian Culture
13. Taj Mahal
14. Maratha Empire
15. Durrani Empire
16. European Traders
17. East India Company

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?, especially the monsoon and the Indian Ocean.
- Chapter 2: Ancient Roots, especially the Maurya and Gupta empires.

Kings, saints and spice ships

Hi, it's Mora! Many of the buildings in your family's photos, the foods on your table and even some of the words you use at home were shaped in the centuries this chapter covers. When someone online argues about "who ruled whom," this chapter helps you see the bigger, more crowded picture. Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

3.1 "How Many Empires Were There?"

It's the second meeting of Prairie Ridge High School's South Asian Student Association. Zara Hossain has asked everyone to bring a photo of one old building from their family's home city. Ayesha Qureshi goes first. Her photo shows a huge red sandstone mosque with white marble domes. "This is the Badshahi Mosque in Lahore," she says. "My Dada calls Lahore 'the city of the Mughals.'"

Arjun Reddy holds up his phone. It shows a square stone monument with four big arches and four tall minarets. "This is the Charminar in Hyderabad. My grandmother says Hyderabad was built by the Qutb Shahi sultans, not the Mughals." Zara shows a picture her Nanu sent from Bangladesh: a low brick mosque crowned with rows of small domes. "And this one is in Bagerhat. Nanu says it's from the Bengal Sultanate."

Ben Lindqvist has been writing names on the whiteboard: Mughals, Qutb Shahis, Bengal Sultanate. He stops, marker in the air. "Wait. If the Mughals ruled Lahore, who ruled Hyderabad and Bengal? Were these all the same empire with different names? How many empires *were* there?" That question is the whole chapter.

3.2 A Highway, Not a Relay Race

Ben's family history can help. In the year 1100, the place we now call Scandinavia did not have one ruler. There were kings in Norway, in Denmark and in Sweden, plus earls, chieftains and trading towns, all at the same time. Sometimes they fought, sometimes they married into each other's families, and sometimes they traded. If you drew their history as a timeline, you couldn't draw a single bar. You'd need several lanes, side by side.

South Asia between 600 and 1800 works the same way, but on a much bigger scale. Many people imagine history as a relay race, where one empire hands

the baton to the next: first the Guptas, then the sultans, then the Mughals, then the British. That picture is wrong in two ways.

- **Powers overlapped.** When the Mughals ruled Lahore and Agra, the Qutb Shahis ruled Hyderabad, the Kingdom of Kandy ruled the hills of Sri Lanka, and Portuguese ships controlled Goa.
- **No single power ever ruled everything.** Even the largest empires left areas to local kings, chiefs and communities.

Historians often draw this period as a set of "swim lanes": one horizontal lane per power, with bars showing when each one existed. You'll build exactly that kind of picture with the MicroSim later in this chapter. As you read, keep a rough lane in your head for each power you meet.

3.3 The Ocean Highway: Indian Ocean Trade

Before we meet the kings, meet the sea. **Indian Ocean Trade** is the network of sea routes and ports that linked South Asia with East Africa, Arabia, Persia, Southeast Asia and China for many centuries. It worked because of the monsoon you met in Chapter 1. The winds blow from the southwest for part of the year and from the northeast for the rest, so sailors could ride the wind one way and come back on the reverse wind months later. Merchants were using this seasonal pattern at least as far back as Roman times.

South Asia sat right in the middle of this network. Its ports sold cotton cloth, pepper, cinnamon, gems and much more. Some of the busiest included:

Port or coast	Today in	Known for
Kozhikode (Calicut), Malabar coast	Kerala, India	Pepper and spices, plus Arab, Persian, Chinese and later European visitors
Gujarat ports such as Cambay	Gujarat, India	Cotton textiles, links to Arabia and East Africa
Chattogram and the Bengal ports	Bangladesh and West Bengal	Rice, fine cotton and silk cloth
Galle and other harbors	Sri Lanka	Cinnamon, gems, a stopping point between east and west
Malé and the atolls	Maldives	A rest stop on the east-west route, and seafaring islanders

Kozhikode, ruled by kings called the Zamorins (Samoothiris), was one of the most important ports in the world in medieval times. It welcomed Persian, Arab and Chinese traders, and famous travelers such as Ibn Battuta. Zara's family city, Chattogram, was also a busy port in this era, at the head of the Bay of Bengal.

The ocean carried more than goods. It carried people, languages, food and faiths. Traders settled in port towns, married local families, and built places of worship. That's how one of South Asia's major faiths first arrived.

Early Islam in South Asia

Early Islam in South Asia means the first centuries of Muslim presence in the region, which came along several different routes, peacefully and through

conquest, over hundreds of years. Islam began in Arabia in the early 600s. Arab merchants were already sailing to South Asia before then, so Muslim traders appeared on its coasts very early.

- **The Malabar coast (Kerala).** Muslim merchants settled in port towns. The Cheraman Juma Mosque in Kodungallur, Kerala, is traditionally dated to 629 CE, which would make it one of the oldest mosques in the world. Historians debate that date, and some suggest a much later building. Either way, Kerala's Muslim communities have deep roots in this trade.
- **Sri Lanka.** Arab traders arrived by the 7th century. Many Sri Lankan Muslims, often called Sri Lankan Moors, trace their ancestry to these merchant families.
- **The Maldives.** In 1153 (some records say 1193), the last Buddhist king of the Maldives became a Muslim, and the islands gradually became Muslim too.
- **Sindh (Pakistan).** In about 711 to 712, an Arab army led by Muhammad ibn al-Qasim conquered Sindh in the lower Indus valley, and it became a province of the Umayyad Caliphate.
- **The northwest.** From about 1000, Mahmud, the sultan of Ghazni (in present-day Afghanistan), led raids deep into northern India. Later rulers from the northwest founded kingdoms in North India itself.

So Islam reached South Asia through trade, through teachers and holy men, and through conquest, over many centuries. That variety is one reason Muslim communities in Kerala, Sindh, Bengal and the Maldives have such different languages, foods and customs today.

Map the routes

I like to imagine two arrows: one sailing across the sea to the coasts of Kerala, Sri Lanka and the Maldives, and one crossing the mountains into Sindh and Punjab. Can you guess which arrow reached your family's region first?

3.4 Temple Builders and Island Kingdoms

The Cholas

The **Chola Dynasty** was a Tamil royal family from the Kaveri River delta in south India. A *dynasty* is a ruling family whose power passes from one generation to the next. Cholas are mentioned in very early Tamil poems, but the empire most people mean by "the Cholas" was founded around 848 CE by a king named Vijayalaya. For the next four centuries the Cholas were one of the strongest powers in South Asia, until they were absorbed by their Pandya rivals by 1279.

Two Chola kings stand out:

- **Rajaraja I** built the enormous Brihadisvara Temple at Thanjavur between 1003 and 1010. Its main tower rises like a stone mountain over the town, and the temple is still in use today.
- **Rajendra I**, his son, led an army north as far as the Ganga, then built a new capital, Gangaikonda Cholapuram, whose name celebrates that campaign. His great temple there was completed in 1035. He also sent a naval expedition against the Srivijaya kingdom in Southeast Asia.

That last point surprises many people. The Cholas were a sea power. Tamil merchant guilds traded across the Bay of Bengal, and Chola fleets reached

Sri Lanka, the Maldives and the Malay Peninsula. Three Chola temples (at Thanjavur, Gangaikondacholapuram and Darasuram) are listed together by UNESCO as the "Great Living Chola Temples," a name that reminds us that people still worship in them.

The Sri Lankan Kingdoms

Sri Lankan Kingdoms is the name for the series of kingdoms that ruled the island of Sri Lanka, some Sinhala and some Tamil, often at the same time. A quick tour:

Kingdom	Approximate dates	Capital	One thing to know
Anuradhapura	from the 4th century BCE to about 1017 CE	Anuradhapura	A Sinhala Buddhist capital for over a thousand years. Chola armies captured its last king around 1017
Chola rule in the north	993 to 1070	Polonnaruwa	Part of the island was ruled by the Cholas for decades
Polonnaruwa	1070 to 1232	Polonnaruwa	Parakramabahu I (ruled 1153 to 1186) built huge irrigation reservoirs

Kingdom	Approximate dates	Capital	One thing to know
Jaffna kingdom	1215 to 1619	Nallur, near Jaffna	A Tamil kingdom in the north, taken over by the Portuguese
Kingdom of Kandy	1469 to 1815	Kandy	The last independent kingdom. It kept the Buddha's Tooth Relic from 1595 and fell to the British in 1815

Notice how the Sri Lankan lane splits in two. From the 1200s to the 1600s a Tamil kingdom ruled the north while Sinhala kingdoms ruled further south. Dilan Perera's family is from Kandy, and the Temple of the Tooth Relic there is still one of the most important Buddhist sites in the world.

3.5 Sultans of Delhi and Bengal

The Delhi Sultanate

The **Delhi Sultanate** was a series of Muslim-ruled kingdoms based in Delhi that controlled much of northern South Asia from 1206 to 1526. A *sultan* is a king, and a sultanate (سلطنت, *sul-TUH-nut*, in Urdu and Persian, "rule" or "kingdom") is the land he rules. Historians divide the Sultanate into five dynasties (ruling families):

1. Mamluk, 1206 to 1290
2. Khalji, 1290 to 1320
3. Tughlaq, 1320 to 1414
4. Sayyid, 1414 to 1451
5. Lodi, 1451 to 1526

At various times the Sultanate covered parts of today's India, Pakistan and Bangladesh. Its sultans fought off Mongol armies from Central Asia, built forts and mosques, and drew scholars, poets and soldiers from Persia and Central Asia. One of its rulers was a woman: **Razia Sultan**, who ruled from 1236 to 1240 and was the only woman ever to rule the Delhi Sultanate. The 72.5 m (238 ft) Qutb Minar, a red sandstone tower in south Delhi begun in the early 1200s, is the Sultanate's best-known monument.

The Moroccan traveler Ibn Battuta reached the Indus in 1333 and worked as a judge in Delhi under Sultan Muhammad bin Tughluq. Later he sailed to the Maldives. His travel book is one of our best eyewitness sources for the 1300s, and it shows how connected the Muslim world, from North Africa to the Maldives, had become.

The Bengal Sultanate

Far to the east, Bengal had its own lane. The Bengal Sultanate ruled the delta from 1352 to 1576, independent of Delhi for most of that time, until the Mughal emperor Akbar's armies conquered it. Persian was the language of government, but some sultans and their officials also supported poets writing in Bangla, and the sultans employed both Muslims and Hindus in their government.

In the 15th century, a general named Ulugh Khan Jahan founded a city at Bagerhat in what is now Bangladesh. Its Sixty Dome Mosque (which actually

has 81 domes held up by 60 columns) is the photo Zara's Nanu sent, and the city is a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

3.6 Vijayanagara and the Deccan

The Vijayanagara Empire

In 1336, two brothers named Harihara and Bukka founded a kingdom in the south. It grew into the **Vijayanagara Empire**, a large Hindu-ruled empire of southern India from 1336 to 1646, named after its capital city, Vijayanagara ("city of victory"). The ruins of that city are at Hampi, in Karnataka.

Vijayanagara was strongest under Krishnadevaraya, who ruled from 1509 to 1529. Its capital was one of the biggest cities in the world in its day, with markets described by foreign visitors such as the Persian envoy Abdur Razzaq and the Portuguese traveler Domingo Paes, and its kings supported poetry in Telugu, Kannada, Tamil and Sanskrit.

In 1565 an alliance of Deccan sultanates defeated Vijayanagara at the Battle of Talikota. UNESCO notes that the capital was then plundered for six months and abandoned. The empire continued in a smaller form until 1646. Today Hampi's temples, bazaars and royal buildings are a World Heritage Site.

The Deccan sultanates

Vijayanagara's northern neighbors were also important. The Bahmani Sultanate, founded in 1347, was the first independent sultanate of the Deccan Plateau. By 1518 it had split into five smaller sultanates. One of them, Golconda, was ruled by the Qutb Shahi family from 1518 until 1687.

This is where Arjun's grandmother comes in. In 1591, Sultan Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah moved his capital to a new city, Hyderabad, and built the

Charminar at its center. The Qutb Shahis began with Persian as their court language, but in the 1600s Telugu came to be used alongside it, and many royal orders were written in both languages. Arjun's family speaks Telugu, so the language of his home was once a language of a sultan's court. The Mughal emperor Aurangzeb conquered Golconda in 1687.

Don't read today's politics backward

It's tempting to sort these wars into "Hindu side" and "Muslim side," but alliances crossed faith lines all the time. Sultans had Hindu generals and ministers, Hindu kings hired Muslim soldiers, and kingdoms of the same faith fought each other constantly.

3.7 Paths of Devotion: Bhakti, Sufism and Guru Nanak

Not all of this period's big changes came from kings. Some of the most lasting came from poets and teachers who spoke to ordinary people in their own languages.

The Bhakti Movement

The **Bhakti Movement** was a wave of devotional poetry and practice within Hinduism that taught that loving devotion to God is open to everyone, whatever their caste, gender or education. *Bhakti* (भक्ति, *BHUK-tee*) means "devotion." It began in the Tamil country around the 6th century CE with two groups of poet-saints, the Alvars, devoted to Vishnu, and the Nayanars, devoted to Shiva. Over the next thousand years it spread north, and from the 1400s it was strong across north and east India.

Bhakti poets usually wrote in everyday languages, not in Sanskrit, so people could sing their songs at home and in the street. A few you may hear about in your own family:

- **Basavanna** (12th century, though sources give different dates), a Kannada poet in Karnataka linked with the Lingayat tradition, who criticized caste divisions.
- **Kabir** (15th century, though his exact dates are uncertain), a weaver from the Varanasi area whose sharp, short verses questioned empty ritual in both Hinduism and Islam. Hindus, Muslims and Sikhs all honor him, and some of his verses are in the Sikh scripture.
- **Mirabai** (16th century), a Rajput princess remembered for her songs of devotion to Krishna.

Sufism

At the same time, a parallel path was growing within Islam. **Sufism** is the inward, devotional tradition of Islam, focused on the love of God and on drawing closer to God through prayer, remembrance and the guidance of a teacher. A Sufi (صوفی, *SOO-fee*, in Persian) usually belongs to an order, a chain of teachers and students.

In South Asia, the Chishti order became especially well known. Moinuddin Chishti (who died in 1236) settled in Ajmer, in Rajasthan, and his shrine there is still visited by huge numbers of people of many faiths. In Delhi, Nizamuddin Auliya (1238 to 1325) taught crowds of followers. The Chishtis are famous for *sama*, gatherings where devotional music and poetry, usually qawwali, help listeners focus on the love of God.

A Sufi saint's tomb is called a dargah (درگاہ, *dur-GAAH*, in Urdu, also meaning "threshold"). Dargahs across Pakistan, India and Bangladesh became places where Muslims and non-Muslims alike came to pray, ask for blessings and

listen to music. Many historians see Sufi teachers as one important way that Islam spread among ordinary people, especially in Punjab, Sindh and Bengal, alongside trade, migration and the influence of rulers.

Guru Nanak

Guru Nanak (1469 to 1539) was a spiritual teacher and poet from Punjab whom Sikhs honor as the founder of Sikhism and the first of the ten Sikh Gurus. A *guru* (ਗੁਰੂ, *GOO-roo*, in Punjabi) is a teacher or guide. Nanak was born in 1469 in the village of Talwandi, now called Nankana Sahib, in Punjab, Pakistan. Many historians give his birth date as 15 April, while Sikhs usually celebrate his birthday, Guru Nanak Gurpurab, on the full moon of the month of Kartik, in October or November. In Sikh tradition, he traveled widely, sharing his message in poetry and song, then settled in the town of Kartarpur (also in present-day Pakistan), where he lived as a farmer and householder until he died in 1539.

In Sikh tradition, Guru Nanak taught devotion to one God, honest work, sharing with others, and the equality of all people. His followers ate together regardless of caste, a practice that grew into the langar, the free community kitchen you'll meet in Chapter 5. Simran Kaur Gill's family keeps a picture of Guru Nanak in their home, and her grandparents have visited Kartarpur.

Bhakti, Sufism and Sikhism are three separate traditions with their own teachings. Each came out of its own faith world. But they shared some features: poetry in local languages, music, and a focus on personal devotion rather than status. That's one reason a single qawwali singer or bhajan singer today might draw a mixed audience.

3.8 The Mughal Empire

From Babur to Akbar

The **Mughal Empire** was a Muslim-ruled empire, founded by a dynasty from Central Asia, that ruled much of South Asia from 1526 until it formally ended in 1857. Its founder, Babur, was a prince descended from the Central Asian conqueror Timur. He took Kabul in 1504, and on 21 April 1526 he defeated the last Lodi sultan of Delhi, Ibrahim Lodi, at the First Battle of Panipat, north of Delhi. Babur died in 1530. His son Humayun lost the throne to a rival, Sher Shah Suri, and only won back Delhi and Agra in 1555.

The emperor most people remember is Babur's grandson. **Akbar** was the third Mughal emperor, who ruled from 1556 to 1605 and built the Mughal state into a lasting empire. He became emperor as a teenager. Over almost fifty years he took control of most of northern and central South Asia, from Kabul to Bengal, including the rich trading region of Gujarat.

Akbar is famous for how he ruled such a mixed population:

- He brought Hindu Rajput kings into his government and army as high-ranking officers, and married into Rajput families.
- In 1575 he built a hall for religious debate, the Ibadat Khana ("house of worship"), at his new capital, Fatehpur Sikri, and later invited scholars of many faiths, including Hindus, the Jain teacher Hiravijaya and Jesuit priests from Goa, to discuss their beliefs.
- He followed a policy called *sulh-i kul*, "universal peace," meaning the emperor should stand above any single faith.
- He set up a translation house that turned Sanskrit works into Persian. The best known is the *Razmnama*, a Persian version of the Mahabharata, illustrated by his court painters, who included Persians, Indian Muslims and Hindus.

Historians admire Akbar's policies of tolerance and also point out that he was a conqueror whose wars caused great suffering. Both things are true.

Indo-Persian Culture

The Mughals inherited and expanded a way of life that had been growing since the Delhi Sultanate. **Indo-Persian Culture** is the blend of Persian and South Asian languages, literature, art, architecture, music, food and manners that developed in Muslim-ruled courts and cities of South Asia. Persian was the official language of the Delhi Sultanate, the Bengal Sultanate and the Mughal Empire, so officials, poets and scholars of every faith learned it.

You can still see and hear Indo-Persian culture all around you:

- **Language.** Mixing Persian and Arabic words with the everyday speech of the Delhi region produced Hindustani, the ancestor of today's Hindi and Urdu. The poet Amir Khusrau (who died in 1325), a follower of Nizamuddin Auliya, is honored as an early master of it.
- **Architecture.** Domes, arches, minarets, inlaid marble and gardens divided into four parts appear in Mughal buildings from Kabul to Dhaka.
- **Painting.** Mughal miniature painting mixed Persian styles with Indian subjects and artists.
- **Food.** Many families' biryanis, kormas and kebabs come from this court cooking tradition.
- **Music.** Instruments, styles like qawwali, and parts of North Indian classical music grew in this setting. You'll meet them in Chapter 9.

The Taj Mahal

The most famous Mughal building is a tomb. The **Taj Mahal** is a white marble mausoleum (a large tomb) in Agra, built between about 1631 and 1648 by order of the emperor Shah Jahan in memory of his wife Mumtaz Mahal. The surrounding gardens, mosque and gateways were finished around 1653. Shah Jahan himself was later buried there beside her. UNESCO listed it as a World Heritage Site in 1983, calling it a jewel of Muslim art in India.

Shah Jahan also built the Red Fort and the Jama Masjid in Delhi and added marble palaces to the fort in Lahore. Lahore's fort, rebuilt under Akbar starting in 1566, and the Shalamar Gardens are a UNESCO World Heritage Site in Pakistan. Shah Jahan's son, Aurangzeb, built the Badshahi Mosque opposite the fort between 1671 and 1673. That's the mosque in Ayesha's photo, and it's why her Dada calls Lahore "the city of the Mughals."

Height and decline

Aurangzeb ruled from 1658 to 1707. Under him the empire reached its largest size, stretching over almost all of the subcontinent, including Golconda in 1687. But his long wars in the Deccan were expensive, and after his death the empire broke apart quickly. Governors in Bengal, Hyderabad and Awadh became rulers in their own right, and new powers rose. By about 1760 the Mughal emperor controlled little more than the area around Delhi. The empire formally ended after the uprising of 1857, which belongs to Chapter 4.

Whose Story?

The same rulers are often remembered very differently depending on who tells the story. Aurangzeb is a clear example: historians note that some South Asian Muslims remember him as a model of a devout ruler, while many others, including many Hindus in India, remember him mainly for destroying temples. Arguments about him still flare up in Indian politics today. Shivaji (Section 3.9) is honored as a hero by many people in India, especially in Maharashtra, a view that grew stronger during the independence movement. Many Afghans call Ahmad Shah Durrani "Ahmad Shah Baba," the father of Afghanistan, while in Punjab, which he invaded again and again, and among the Marathas, who lost to him at Panipat, many people remember him mainly as an invader. Historians try to weigh all of these memories against the evidence: court chronicles, travelers' accounts, coins, inscriptions and buildings.

3.9 New Powers: Marathas and Durranis

The Maratha Empire

The **Maratha Empire** (also called the Maratha Confederacy) was a state founded by Marathi-speaking warriors in western India that grew, in the 1700s, into one of the largest powers in South Asia. Its founder, Shivaji, inherited land from his father, who had served the Bijapur sultanate. Shivaji built up his own kingdom in the hills of Maharashtra, fought both Bijapur and the Mughals, and was crowned Chhatrapati (sovereign) at the fort of Raigad in 1674.

After Shivaji, the Marathas kept fighting the Mughals and kept expanding. In the 1700s their real leaders were chief ministers called Peshwas, based in Pune, along with several powerful Maratha families who ruled their own regions. At their height, Maratha armies collected taxes across much of India. Their power ended in a series of wars with the East India Company, the last of which finished in 1818.

The Durrani Empire

Meanwhile, a new power rose in the northwest. The **Durrani Empire** was an Afghan empire founded in 1747 by Ahmad Shah Durrani, a Pashtun military leader. From his capital at Kandahar (later moved to Kabul by his son), his empire stretched over Afghanistan, much of present-day Pakistan, and into Punjab and Kashmir. Many historians, and many Afghans, see it as the beginning of the modern country of Afghanistan.

The Durrani and Maratha lanes collided on 14 January 1761, at the Third Battle of Panipat, north of Delhi. The Durranis won, and the Marathas suffered enormous losses. Neither side gained lasting control of North India from the battle. Within a few decades, a different kind of power, a company, was in the strongest position of all.

3.10 Strangers from the Sea: European Traders

Who came, and why

European Traders were the merchants and companies from Portugal, the Netherlands, England, France and Denmark who came to South Asia by sea from 1498 onward to buy spices, cotton cloth, indigo and other goods. For most of this period they were guests and customers of South Asian rulers, not rulers themselves.

- **The Portuguese** came first. Vasco da Gama crossed the Arabian Sea from Malindi, in present-day Kenya, and landed near Kozhikode on 20 May 1498. In 1510 the Portuguese captured Goa from the Bijapur sultanate and made it their capital in Asia. They held Goa until December 1961.
- **The Dutch** founded the Dutch East India Company (VOC) on 20 March 1602. In Sri Lanka they pushed out the Portuguese and took over the island's coasts, while the Kingdom of Kandy kept the interior.
- **The English** formed their own East India Company in 1600. The French and Danes followed with smaller companies.

Ask what the ships carried

For any trading company, ask three questions: what did it buy, who gave it permission to trade, and who protected its ships and warehouses? When the answer to the last one becomes "its own army," a trader is starting to turn into a ruler.

The East India Company

The **East India Company** (EIC) was an English, later British, private company that received a royal charter (official permission) on 31 December 1600 to

trade in Asia, and that later conquered and governed large parts of South Asia. Many readers are surprised to learn that it was not the British government. It was a business owned by investors, who hoped to profit from trade.

For its first century and a half, the Company depended on permission from Mughal emperors and regional rulers. It set up trading posts at Madras (now Chennai), Bombay (now Mumbai) and Calcutta (now Kolkata). When it picked a fight with the Mughal Empire in the war known as Child's War (1686 to 1690), it lost badly and had to beg Emperor Aurangzeb for pardon to keep trading.

Over time, though, the Company built its own armies. Most of its soldiers were South Asians called sepoys. The Company also got involved in the wars between regional powers. In the 1700s, as the Mughal Empire broke apart, the Company began to take over territory itself. Britain's Parliament began to limit and supervise it, renewing its charter only for twenty years at a time. How a trading company ended up ruling much of the subcontinent, starting with the Battle of Plassey in Bengal in 1757, is the story of Chapter 4. The Company was finally dissolved in 1874.

3.11 Back to the Whiteboard

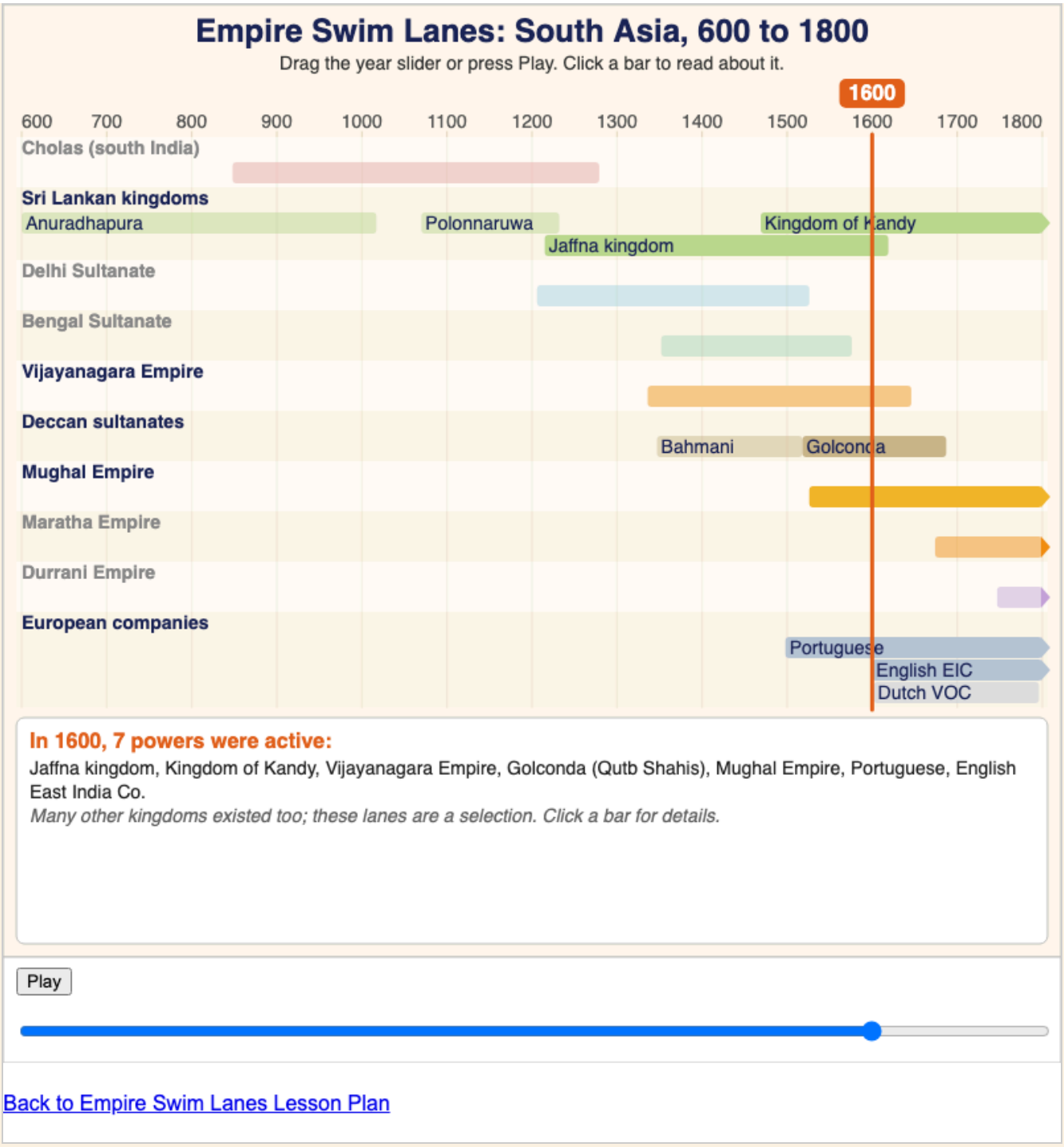
Ben steps back from the whiteboard. It's covered in names now, with arrows everywhere. "Okay," he says, "so the answer to 'how many empires' is... a lot, and they were mostly at the same time?"

"Not just at the same time," Arjun says. "They were trading with each other, marrying into each other's families, fighting each other, and borrowing each other's languages."

Ayesha points at the Badshahi Mosque, the Charminar and the Sixty Dome Mosque. "Three photos, three different dynasties, all built by Muslim rulers, and none of them were the same empire."

Zara adds one line at the bottom: "South Asia had many lanes." Then she turns to the club. "Next meeting, everybody asks an elder about the oldest building near their family's home."

Diagram: Empire Swim Lanes



Back to Empire Swim Lanes Lesson Plan

Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch03-empire-timeline/main.html

Open the Empire Swim Lanes fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Empire Swim Lanes

sim-id: ch03-empire-timeline
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Analyze
Bloom Verb: compare
Learning Objective: The learner will compare the dates of major South Asian powers between 600 and 1800 CE and explain that many powers coexisted and overlapped rather than replacing each other one at a time.

Canvas: responsive width; 720 px drawing area plus 80 px control area.

Controls: Play / Pause button; year slider (600 to 1800); click or tap any bar.

Behavior: Ten lanes (Cholas, Sri Lankan kingdoms, Delhi Sultanate, Bengal Sultanate, Vijayanagara Empire, Deccan sultanates, Mughal Empire, Maratha Empire, Durrani Empire, European companies) show colored bars for each power's approximate dates. An orange year line follows the slider; bars active in that year are bright, and the panel lists every power active that year. Clicking a bar shows its dates, capital and one key fact. Powers that continued after 1800 end in an arrow. The sim starts paused at 1600.

Start by reading the panel at 1600. Seven powers in this small selection were active at the same time, from the Kingdom of Kandy in Sri Lanka to the Mughals and two European companies. Now drag the slider back to 1000 and count again, then forward to 1750. Which year has the most lanes lit up? Which has the fewest?

Then press **Play** and watch the year line sweep across. Notice that new powers usually appear while old ones are still alive, and that the Mughal bar starts in 1526, more than 300 years after the Delhi Sultanate began. Finally, click the Delhi Sultanate and the Vijayanagara bars and compare their capitals. The lanes are a selection: many other kingdoms, such as the

Rajputs, the Ahoms in Assam, the Kingdom of Nepal and the Sikh kingdom of Punjab, existed too.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about the oldest building, ruin or monument they remember near their home, and the stories they heard about kings, sultans, nawabs, rajas or traders. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Look up a photo of a famous building from your elder's home region (a fort, temple, mosque, tomb or market) and show it to them to get the conversation going. Ask if it's okay to take notes.

Questions to ask

1. What was the oldest building or ruin near the place you grew up? Did you ever visit it as a child?
2. Who did people say built it, and when? Were there any legends about it?
3. Did your family or town have stories about a king, sultan, nawab, raja or famous saint from long ago?
4. Were there shrines, temples, gurdwaras or dargahs near home that people of different faiths visited?
5. How has that building or place changed since you were young? Is it looked after, crowded with tourists, or forgotten?

6. Which part of your region's history do you most want me to remember, and why?

Listen for: names that connect to the Mughal Empire, the Delhi Sultanate, the Vijayanagara Empire or the Sri Lankan Kingdoms; stories about saints that connect to Sufism, the Bhakti Movement or Guru Nanak; and memories of trading towns that link to Indian Ocean Trade.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Find the building your elder named in this chapter or in the Empire Swim Lanes sim. Does their story about who built it match the historical dates? If a friend interviewed someone from a different region, place both buildings on the swim lanes. Were they built under the same power, or under two powers that existed at the same time?

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Islam arrived in South Asia only by conquest.
Reality: Muslim traders were living on the coasts of Kerala and Sri Lanka by the 7th and 8th centuries, the Maldives became Muslim after its king converted in the 12th century, and Sufi teachers drew many followers in Punjab, Sindh and Bengal. Conquest was one route among several.

Myth: The Mughals ruled all of South Asia.
Reality: Even at its largest, under Aurangzeb, the Mughal Empire never included Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bhutan or the Maldives, and many regional kings

inside it kept real power. For most of the Mughal period other powers, such as the Deccan sultanates, the Kingdom of Kandy, the Portuguese and later the Marathas, existed alongside it.

Myth: The Taj Mahal is a palace.
Reality: The Taj Mahal is a mausoleum, a tomb built by Shah Jahan for his wife Mumtaz Mahal, who is buried there. Shah Jahan was later buried beside her.

Myth: The East India Company was the British government.
Reality: It was a private company owned by investors, with a royal charter to trade. It later built armies and ruled territory, and Parliament increasingly regulated it, but it only handed India over to direct rule by the British Crown in 1858.

Myth: Each empire neatly replaced the one before it.
Reality: Powers overlapped for decades or centuries. The Delhi Sultanate, the Bengal Sultanate, Vijayanagara, the Bahmani Sultanate and the Kingdom of Kandy all existed in the 1400s at the same time.

Check Yourself

1. What natural pattern made long-distance Indian Ocean Trade possible?

The monsoon winds, which blow from the southwest for part of the year and from the northeast for the rest, so sailors could travel one way and return months later.

2. Name two Chola achievements.

Rajaraja I built the Brihadisvara Temple at Thanjavur (1003 to 1010), and Rajendra I built a new capital at Gangaikonda Cholapuram and sent a navy to Southeast Asia.

3. What do the Bhakti Movement and Sufism have in common, and how are they different?

Both stress personal, loving devotion to God, often through poetry and music in local languages. Bhakti grew within Hinduism, while Sufism is a tradition within Islam.

4. Why is Akbar remembered for his religious policies?

He included Hindu Rajput nobles in his government, held debates among scholars of many faiths at the Ibadat Khana, followed a policy of "universal peace" (sulh-i kul), and had Sanskrit works translated into Persian.

5. In what year was the English East India Company chartered, and what kind of organization was it?

It received its royal charter on 31 December 1600. It was a private trading company owned by investors, not the British government.

Exercises

Remember

1. List the five dynasties of the Delhi Sultanate in order.

Answer

Mamluk, Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyid and Lodi (1206 to 1526).

2. Who founded the Durrani Empire, and in what year?

Answer

Ahmad Shah Durrani founded it in 1747, with its capital at Kandahar.

Understand

1. Explain in your own words what Indo-Persian Culture means, with two examples you could find in a South Asian family today.

Answer

It is the blend of Persian and South Asian languages, art, food and manners that grew in Muslim-ruled courts. Examples include Hindustani words in Hindi and Urdu, biryani and kebabs, qawwali music, and buildings with domes and arches.

2. Explain why Arjun's grandmother says Hyderabad was built by the Qutb Shahis, not the Mughals.

Answer

Hyderabad was founded by Sultan Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah of Golconda, who built the Charminar in 1591. The Mughals only conquered Golconda in 1687, almost a century later.

Apply

1. Use the Empire Swim Lanes sim to find a year when at least one power was active in every one of these regions: Sri Lanka, the Deccan, North India and the coast (European companies). Write the year and list the powers. *Hint: try years between 1500 and 1650.*
2. A cousin visiting Lahore sends you photos of the Badshahi Mosque and the Lahore Fort. Write a three-sentence caption for each photo, using dates from this chapter. *Hint: the fort and the mosque were built under different emperors.*

Analyze

1. Compare the Delhi Sultanate and the Mughal Empire. Give two similarities and two differences. *Hint: think about dates, founders, capitals, language and how they ended.*
2. The chapter says Islam reached South Asia "through trade, through teachers and holy men, and through conquest." Analyze which of these routes mattered most in Kerala, in Sindh and in the Maldives, using evidence from the chapter. *Hint: different regions had different first contacts.*

Evaluate

1. Some people call Akbar "the Great" because of his tolerance, while others point out that he was a conqueror. Write a short paragraph evaluating whether "Akbar the Great" is a fair title, using evidence from both sides. *Hint: a strong answer can agree with part of each view.*
2. A website says, "The British conquered India in 1600." Evaluate this claim. What is right and wrong about it, and how would you rewrite it

accurately? *Hint: who received the charter in 1600, and what was it allowed to do?*

Create

1. Draw your own swim-lane timeline for your family's home region (or another region you choose) from 1000 to 1800. Include at least four powers, with start and end dates, and one building for each. *Hint: the Empire Swim Lanes sim and the Sri Lanka table are good models.*
2. Write a short dialogue (150 to 200 words) between a Persian-speaking official at the Mughal court and a Portuguese merchant in Goa in 1600, each explaining what they want from the other. *Hint: use at least three concept labels from this chapter.*

Key Takeaways

- Between about 600 and 1800, South Asia was shared by many powers at once. History in this period looks like parallel lanes, not a relay race.
- Indian Ocean Trade, powered by the monsoon winds, linked South Asia's ports with Africa, Arabia and Southeast Asia, and carried goods, people and faiths, including early Islam.
- In the south, the Chola Dynasty and the Vijayanagara Empire built great temples and cities. In Sri Lanka, Sinhala and Tamil kingdoms ruled side by side for centuries, and the Kingdom of Kandy stayed independent until 1815.
- The Delhi Sultanate (1206 to 1526) and the Mughal Empire (1526 to 1857) spread Indo-Persian Culture, from the Hindustani language to buildings like the Taj Mahal, a tomb built for Mumtaz Mahal.

- The Bhakti Movement, Sufism and the teachings of Guru Nanak brought devotion to ordinary people in their own languages.
- As the Mughal Empire weakened after 1707, the Maratha Empire and the Durrani Empire rose, and clashed at Panipat in 1761.
- European Traders arrived by sea from 1498. The East India Company, a private company chartered in 1600, would later turn from trader to ruler.

You can read the lanes!

You can now explain how many powers shared South Asia, and why your family's favorite old building might belong to a dynasty you'd never heard of. Next, in Chapter 4, the trading company becomes a ruler, and South Asia's road to independence and Partition begins.

Quiz: Empires and Encounters

Test your understanding of Chapter 3. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

In what year was the Delhi Sultanate established?

A. 1206

B. 1336

C. 1526

D. 1747

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The Delhi Sultanate began in 1206 and lasted until 1526. The year 1526 is when Babur founded the Mughal Empire, which is why it's a tempting distractor. The year 1336 is the founding of Vijayanagara, and 1747 is the founding of the Durrani Empire.

Concept Tested: Delhi Sultanate **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

What is the Taj Mahal?

A. A royal palace where Shah Jahan lived with his family

B. A Sufi shrine built for Moinuddin Chishti

C. A white marble tomb built by order of Shah Jahan for his wife Mumtaz Mahal

D. A fort built by Akbar to guard Agra

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The Taj Mahal is a mausoleum, built in Agra between about 1631 and 1648. Many people think it is a palace because of its size and beauty, but it was built as a tomb, and both Mumtaz Mahal and Shah Jahan are buried there.

Concept Tested: Taj Mahal **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

Which teacher, born in 1469 in Talwandi (now Nankana Sahib, Pakistan), do Sikhs honor as the founder of their faith?

A. Kabir

B. Guru Nanak

C. Nizamuddin Auliya

D. Basavanna

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Guru Nanak (1469 to 1539) is the first of the ten Sikh Gurus. Kabir is a common distractor because some of his verses are in the Sikh scripture, but he was a separate poet-saint of the bhakti tradition.

Concept Tested: Guru Nanak **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Why were the monsoon winds so important to Indian Ocean Trade?

A. They blew from the same direction all year, so ships could sail quickly in one direction only.

B. They kept pirates away from the coasts of South Asia.

C. They brought rain that filled the harbors so large ships could enter.

D. They reversed direction with the seasons, so sailors could travel out on one wind and return on the other.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The monsoon winds blow from the southwest for part of the year and from the northeast for the rest, which let ships make round trips across the ocean. Option A gets the key idea backwards: it's the reversal that made return voyages possible.

Concept Tested: Indian Ocean Trade **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

Which statement best describes how Islam first reached South Asia?

A. Through several routes over centuries, including traders on the coasts, Sufi teachers and conquest in the northwest

B. Only through the Mughal conquest in 1526

C. Only through Arab armies that conquered the whole subcontinent in 711

D. Through European traders who arrived after 1498

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Muslim traders settled on the Kerala and Sri Lankan coasts very early, the Maldives' king converted in the 12th century, Arab forces conquered Sindh around 711 to 712, and Sufi teachers drew many followers. Option C is wrong because the 711 conquest covered Sindh, not the whole subcontinent.

Concept Tested: Early Islam in South Asia **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 6

What does the term Indo-Persian Culture refer to?

A. The culture of Persian immigrants who lived only in Iran

B. A blend of Persian and South Asian language, art, architecture, food and music that grew in Muslim-ruled courts and cities of South Asia

C. A religion that combined Hinduism and Islam into one faith

D. The European style of buildings brought by the East India Company

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Indo-Persian Culture includes things like the Hindustani language (ancestor of Hindi and Urdu), Mughal architecture and painting, and court cooking. It was a culture shared by people of many faiths, not a new religion, so C is wrong.

Concept Tested: Indo-Persian Culture **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 7

Ayesha shows a photo of the Badshahi Mosque in Lahore, and Arjun shows the Charminar in Hyderabad. Using the chapter, which statement about the two buildings is correct?

A. Both were built by the Mughal emperor Akbar.

B. Both were built by the Delhi Sultanate.

C. The Charminar was built by the Qutb Shahi sultan of Golconda in 1591, and the Badshahi Mosque by the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb in 1671 to 1673.

D. The Charminar was built by the Vijayanagara Empire, and the Badshahi Mosque by the Durrani Empire.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The two buildings come from two different powers that existed at the same time: the Qutb Shahis ruled Golconda until the Mughals conquered it in 1687. Assuming every Muslim-built monument is Mughal (option A) is exactly the mistake the chapter warns about.

Concept Tested: Mughal Empire **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

A classmate says, "In 1600, the British government took over India." Which correction is most accurate?

A. In 1600 the Portuguese took over India, not the British.

B. In 1600 the Mughal Empire invited the British government to rule Bengal.

C. In 1600 the Dutch East India Company conquered Sri Lanka.

D. In 1600 the East India Company, a private English trading company, received a royal charter to trade in Asia; it did not rule territory yet.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The East India Company was a private business chartered on 31 December 1600. For more than a century it traded with the permission of Mughal emperors and regional rulers. The Portuguese (option A) held Goa from 1510, but they never took over South Asia as a whole.

Concept Tested: East India Company **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Using the Empire Swim Lanes idea, which pair of powers existed at the same time?

A. The Chola Dynasty and the Mughal Empire

B. The Vijayanagara Empire and the Bengal Sultanate

C. The Delhi Sultanate and the Maratha Empire

D. The Anuradhapura Kingdom and the Durrani Empire

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Vijayanagara (1336 to 1646) and the Bengal Sultanate (1352 to 1576) overlapped for more than two centuries. The Cholas ended by 1279, long before the Mughals began in 1526, and the Delhi Sultanate ended in 1526, long before Shivaji's coronation in 1674.

Concept Tested: Vijayanagara Empire **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

---

Question 10

What do the Bhakti Movement and Sufism have in common?

A. Both are branches of Sikhism founded by Guru Nanak.

B. Both rejected music and poetry as distractions from prayer.

C. Both emphasized personal, loving devotion to God, often through poetry and music in local languages, within their own faith traditions.

D. Both were started by the Mughal emperor Akbar to unite his empire.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Bhakti grew within Hinduism and Sufism within Islam, but both focused on devotion and used songs and poetry, such as bhajans and qawwali. They are separate traditions, so they are not branches of Sikhism (A), and both began centuries before Akbar (D).

Concept Tested: Sufism **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition

Summary

Between 1757 and 1947, Britain went from running a trading company in Bengal to ruling most of South Asia. This chapter follows that story: the battle that gave the East India Company its first big territory, the revolt of 1857, the British Raj and the princely states, and the freedom movements that pushed Britain out. It then explains the Partition of 1947, which created India and Pakistan and forced millions of people from their homes, and the events that led to Sri Lanka's independence in 1948 and Bangladesh's in 1971. By the end you'll be able to explain how one colonial territory became several nations in separate steps, and why families on different sides of those borders remember the same years so differently.

Concepts Covered

1. Battle of Plassey
2. Revolt of 1857
3. British Raj
4. Princely States
5. Anglo-Afghan Wars
6. Bengal Famine of 1943
7. Indian National Congress

8. All-India Muslim League
9. Mahatma Gandhi
10. Satyagraha
11. B. R. Ambedkar
12. Muhammad Ali Jinnah
13. Partition of 1947
14. Radcliffe Line
15. Partition Migration
16. Kashmir Dispute
17. Sri Lankan Independence
18. Language Movement of 1952
19. Bangladesh Liberation War

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia? for the eight countries, the rivers and the Bay of Bengal.
- Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters, especially the Mughal Empire, the European traders and the East India Company.

A hard chapter, and an important one

Hi, I'm Mora! The years in this chapter, 1947 and 1971 most of all, still shape where many South Asian families live, which flag they salute and which stories they tell at dinner. Some of what you'll read is painful, so go slowly, and remember that real people lived every line of it. Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

4.1 Three Countries, One House

It's a snowy Sunday, and Zara Hossain is helping her Nanu (her mother's mother) sort a box of old photographs for the South Asian Student Association's first "Family History Night." Ben Lindqvist, her best friend, is sitting on the floor of the Hossains' living room, carefully flattening a photo of a tin-roofed house surrounded by banana trees.

"That's my mother's house," Nanu says in Bangla, tapping the picture. "Near Chattogram. She was born there, she grew up there, and she died there." Then she switches to English, for Ben. "She was born in India. She grew up in Pakistan. And she died in Bangladesh."

Ben looks up. "So she moved a lot?"

"Never," says Nanu. "Not once. The countries moved around her."

Zara laughs, then stops. She knows Bangladesh became independent in 1971. She has heard her parents talk about "1947." But she can't explain how one woman could live in three countries without ever leaving her house. Who drew the lines, when, and why did they keep changing?

4.2 When the Map Changes Around You

Ben has a version of this in his own family history. For most of the 1800s, Norway was joined to Sweden under the Swedish king. In 1905 the union ended peacefully and Norway became fully independent. A Norwegian farmer who never left his farm went from one country to another without packing a bag.

South Asia's borders changed in a similar way, but on a much larger scale and, in 1947 and 1971, with terrible violence. This is what happened to the land around Nanu's mother's house:

Year	What the area near Chattogram was part of
Before 1947	British India (the province of Bengal)
1947 to 1971	Pakistan (first called East Bengal, later East Pakistan)
1971 onward	Bangladesh

To see how that happened, we have to start almost two hundred years earlier, with a trading company that became a government.

4.3 From Traders to Rulers

In Chapter 3, you met the East India Company, a private English (later British) business that came to South Asia in the 1600s to buy cotton cloth, spices, indigo and tea. For more than a century it was one of many foreign trading companies, working with the permission of Mughal emperors and regional rulers. That changed in Bengal.

The Battle of Plassey, 1757

The **Battle of Plassey** was the battle on 23 June 1757, near the village of Plassey (Palashi) in Bengal, in which the East India Company's forces, led by Robert Clive, defeated Siraj-ud-Daulah, the Nawab (ruler) of Bengal. The Company won mostly because the Nawab's own commander, Mir Jafar, made a secret deal with the British and kept his troops out of the fight. Afterward, the Company made Mir Jafar the new Nawab.

Plassey matters because of what came next. Bengal was one of the richest provinces in South Asia, and after Plassey the Company dominated its

government and used its tax revenue for its own purposes. From this base the Company fought, signed treaties with, and took over one region after another for the next hundred years. Many historians treat 1757 as the start of British rule in South Asia, even though most of the region was not yet under British control.

The Revolt of 1857

By the 1850s, the Company ruled large parts of the subcontinent and had a huge army made up mostly of Indian soldiers, called sepoys. Anger had been building for years: about land taxes, about the Company taking over kingdoms whose rulers died without a son, and about new rules in the army. The spark was a new rifle cartridge that soldiers believed was greased with cow and pig fat, which would offend both Hindu and Muslim soldiers.

The **Revolt of 1857** was a large uprising against Company rule that began on 10 May 1857, when sepoys at Meerut, a town about 64 km (40 miles) northeast of Delhi, mutinied and marched to Delhi. There they declared the elderly Mughal emperor, Bahadur Shah Zafar, their leader. The revolt spread across much of northern and central India. Soldiers, peasants, landlords and some rulers joined, including Rani Lakshmibai of Jhansi, a queen who fought on horseback and is still remembered as a hero in India. Both sides committed massacres. By 1858, British forces had crushed the revolt, often with brutal reprisals against whole villages.

Even its name is debated. British writers long called it the "Sepoy Mutiny," a soldiers' revolt. Many Indians call it the "First War of Independence," the start of a national struggle, though some historians question that label because the rebels did not share one plan. This book uses the neutral name "Revolt of 1857."

The British Raj

The revolt convinced the British Parliament that a private company should not govern millions of people. The Government of India Act, passed on 2 August 1858, ended Company rule and transferred its territory and army to the British Crown.

The **British Raj** (*Raj* means "rule" in Hindi-Urdu) is the name for direct rule of South Asia by the British Crown, from 1858 to 1947. A Viceroy, appointed in London, governed from Calcutta (now Kolkata) and later from New Delhi. In 1876, Queen Victoria was given the title "Empress of India." A small number of British officials ran it, relying on huge numbers of Indian clerks, police and soldiers.

Same company, two chapters

Notice the hand-off: from 1757 to 1858 a company ruled, and from 1858 to 1947 a government did. When your family says "the British," which of those two do you think they mean, and does it change the story?

4.4 A Patchwork, Not a Single Colony

On a map of "British India" from 1900, it can look like one solid block of British pink, but the Raj was a patchwork.

The princely states

Princely States were the hundreds of kingdoms inside British-controlled South Asia that kept their own Indian rulers (called maharajas, nawabs, nizams and other titles) but accepted British control over their defense and foreign relations through treaties. At the time Britain left, there were officially about 565 of them. Some were tiny, a few villages. Others were huge:

Hyderabad, ruled by a Nizam, and Jammu and Kashmir, ruled by a Maharaja, were each larger than many European countries. In 1947, princely states covered about 40 percent of the land of pre-independence India and held about 23 percent of its people.

That matters in 1947, when every one of those princes had to decide what to do.

The neighbors Britain never fully ruled

Several of today's South Asian countries were never formally colonized, though Britain still shaped their history.

- **Afghanistan.** Britain feared that the Russian Empire, expanding in Central Asia, would use Afghanistan as a route to India. This rivalry led to the **Anglo-Afghan Wars**, three wars Britain fought in Afghanistan: 1839 to 1842, 1878 to 1880, and 1919. In the first, a British army was destroyed during its retreat from Kabul. After the second, Britain controlled Afghanistan's foreign affairs, though not its internal government. After the third war in 1919, the Treaty of Rawalpindi recognized Afghanistan's full independence in foreign affairs. Afghans remember 1919 as the year they won back control of their own foreign relations.
- **Nepal.** After a war with the Company, Nepal signed the Treaty of Sugauli in 1816 and gave up some territory, but it remained an independent kingdom.
- **Bhutan.** Under the Treaty of Punakha in 1910, Bhutan agreed to be guided by Britain in its foreign relations, while keeping its own king and internal rule.
- **Ceylon** (today's Sri Lanka) was a British colony, but it was run separately from British India, with its own governor.

- **The Maldives** became a British protectorate in 1887. It kept its own sultan, and Britain handled its defense and foreign affairs.

4.5 Life Under the Raj and the Bengal Famine of 1943

What did British rule mean for ordinary people? Historians still argue about the balance. The Raj built railways, universities and courts, but decisions were made in London, most people had no vote, and many historians argue that colonial policies drained wealth from the region and weakened older industries such as handloom weaving.

One of the worst disasters of colonial rule came during the Second World War, in Bengal.

The **Bengal Famine of 1943** was a famine in the province of Bengal (today's Bangladesh and the Indian state of West Bengal) and parts of neighboring Orissa (now Odisha) during the Second World War, when a very large number of people died of starvation and of diseases such as malaria that spread among people weakened by hunger. Estimates of the death toll vary widely, from about 800,000 to as many as 3.8 million. The economic historian Cormac Ó Gráda describes the scholarly consensus as about 2.1 million deaths.

Several causes came together:

- Japan had occupied Burma (now Myanmar) in 1942, cutting off rice imports that Bengal depended on.
- War spending caused prices to rise sharply, and farm workers' wages did not keep up, so poor families could not afford rice even where it existed.
- Fearing a Japanese invasion, the government removed or destroyed boats and rice stocks in coastal areas, a "denial policy" that hurt local fishermen and traders.

- Officials were slow to declare a famine, and wartime priorities, including the use of ships for war supplies rather than food, slowed relief.

Historians weigh these causes differently, but most agree that government decisions, in London and in Bengal, made the disaster far worse. For many people in Bengal, it showed why they wanted to govern themselves.

4.6 Organizing for Freedom

The movement to end British rule lasted about sixty years and took many forms, including petitions, marches, strikes and armed revolt. Two parties and a few leaders shaped it most.

Two political parties

The **Indian National Congress** is a political party founded on 28 December 1885, at a meeting in Bombay (now Mumbai), that became the largest organization in the movement for independence from Britain. It grew from a small group of professionals into a mass movement. It wanted a single, independent India for people of all religions, and many of its leaders, such as Jawaharlal Nehru, became leaders of independent India. The Congress still exists today as a political party in India.

The **All-India Muslim League** was a political party founded in 1906 in Dhaka to represent the political interests of Muslims in British India. Muslims were about a quarter of British India's population, and many Muslim leaders worried that in a democracy with a large Hindu majority, their community's rights, jobs and culture would not be protected. For decades the League asked for safeguards inside a united India. In 1940, at a meeting in Lahore, it adopted the Lahore Resolution (later called the Pakistan Resolution), which called for independent states in the Muslim-majority areas of the northwest

and the east. Pakistan marks 23 March each year as Pakistan Day in memory of that resolution.

Mahatma Gandhi and satyagraha

Mahatma Gandhi (Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, 1869 to 1948) was a lawyer from Porbandar, in present-day Gujarat, who became the most famous leader of the Indian independence movement by leading mass campaigns of nonviolent resistance. *Mahatma* is an honorific from Sanskrit meaning "great soul." Gandhi first developed his methods in South Africa, where he lived from 1893 and fought discrimination against Indians there. He returned to India in 1915 and soon became the leading figure in the Congress.

Gandhi called his method **Satyagraha** (સત્યાગ્રહ, *SUT-yaa-gruh*), "holding firmly to truth" or "truth force": nonviolent resistance in which people openly refuse to obey unjust laws, accept the punishment, and try to win over their opponents rather than defeat them. Gandhi chose the word in South Africa as a Gujarati name for his campaign (Gujarati was his first language), building it from *satya* (truth) and *agraha* (firmness, insistence).

The most famous example is the Salt March. The British government held a monopoly on salt and taxed it, which hit the poorest people hardest. On 12 March 1930, Gandhi and 78 followers set out from his ashram near Ahmedabad and walked about 387 km (240 miles) to the seaside village of Dandi. Crowds joined along the way. On 6 April 1930, Gandhi picked up natural salt from the shore, breaking the law. Across India, people began making and selling salt, and tens of thousands were arrested.

In August 1942, during the Second World War, Gandhi and the Congress launched the Quit India Movement, demanding that Britain leave immediately. Its main leaders were arrested almost at once.

Gandhi's ideas later inspired civil rights movements around the world, and Martin Luther King Jr. in the United States drew on them. Gandhi also opposed Partition. On 30 January 1948, a few months after independence, he was shot and killed at a prayer meeting in Delhi by Nathuram Godse, a Hindu nationalist.

Not only nonviolence

Gandhi's campaigns were huge, but freedom did not come only from nonviolence. Revolutionaries such as Bhagat Singh, the Indian National Army led by Subhas Chandra Bose, strikes, elections, and Britain's exhaustion after the Second World War all played a part, and historians still debate how much each mattered.

B. R. Ambedkar: whose freedom?

B. R. Ambedkar (Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar, 1891 to 1956) was a lawyer, economist and political leader, born into a Dalit family (a community that faced "untouchability," the most severe form of caste discrimination), who fought for the rights of Dalits and chaired the committee that drafted India's Constitution. As a boy he was segregated from other students at school. He went on to earn doctorates from Columbia University and the London School of Economics.

Ambedkar asked a question many other leaders preferred to skip: if India became free of Britain, would Dalits become free inside India? He clashed with Gandhi in 1932 over whether Dalits should elect their own representatives separately. Gandhi went on a fast against the idea, and the two men reached a compromise, the Poona Pact, which reserved seats for Dalits instead.

After independence, Ambedkar became India's first law minister and chaired the Constitution's Drafting Committee. The Constitution, which came into effect on 26 January 1950, includes Article 17, which abolished "untouchability" and made its practice a crime. In 1956, shortly before his death, Ambedkar and a very large number of his followers converted to Buddhism, which he saw as a path free of caste. Today he is honored across India, and especially by Dalit communities, often as "Babasaheb." You'll read more about caste in Chapter 13.

Muhammad Ali Jinnah

Muhammad Ali Jinnah (1876 to 1948) was a lawyer from Karachi who led the All-India Muslim League and became the founder and first Governor-General of Pakistan. Early in his career Jinnah was a member of the Congress and worked for Hindu-Muslim cooperation. Over time he concluded that Muslims needed their own homeland to protect their political future. His argument, often called the "two-nation theory," was that Muslims and Hindus in South Asia were two nations with their own religions, cultures and histories. In Pakistan he is honored as *Quaid-e-Azam*, "the Great Leader." He died on 11 September 1948, about a year after Pakistan's creation.

Leader	Organization	What he wanted for South Asia
Mahatma Gandhi	Indian National Congress	A free, united India, won through nonviolent mass action
Muhammad Ali Jinnah	All-India Muslim League	By 1940, a separate homeland for Muslims in the Muslim-majority regions

Leader	Organization	What he wanted for South Asia
B. R. Ambedkar	Dalit political organizations; later chaired the Constitution's Drafting Committee	Freedom from Britain together with equal rights and protections for Dalits

4.7 The Partition of 1947

By the end of the Second World War, Britain was exhausted and in debt, and its government had decided to leave South Asia. The question was no longer *whether* Britain would go, but what it would leave behind: one country or more than one.

The road to Partition

In 1946, a British Cabinet Mission tried to design a loose federation that would keep India united while protecting Muslim-majority provinces. The plan fell apart because the Congress and the Muslim League didn't trust each other. Jinnah called for 16 August 1946 to be "Direct Action Day," to press the demand for Pakistan. That day, riots broke out in Calcutta, and over the following days large numbers of people, Hindus and Muslims both, were killed. The violence spread: to Noakhali in eastern Bengal, where Muslims attacked Hindus; to Bihar, where Hindus attacked Muslims; and in March 1947 to Rawalpindi in the Punjab, where Hindus and Sikhs were attacked.

In March 1947, Lord Louis Mountbatten arrived as the last Viceroy. On 3 June 1947, he announced the plan: British India would be divided into two

independent countries, and power would be handed over in August, much earlier than expected.

What Partition was

The **Partition of 1947** was the division of British India into two independent countries, India and Pakistan, in August 1947, largely along religious lines: Muslim-majority areas became Pakistan and the rest became India. The British Parliament passed the Indian Independence Act on 18 July 1947. Pakistan celebrates its independence on 14 August, and India celebrates on 15 August.

Pakistan was created in two parts, with India in between:

- **West Pakistan**, made up of Sindh, Baluchistan, the North-West Frontier Province and the western half of Punjab.
- **East Pakistan** (first called East Bengal), made up of the eastern half of Bengal and the Sylhet district of Assam. It had more people than the western wing: in Pakistan's first census, in 1951, about 42 million of its roughly 76 million people lived there, and most of them spoke Bangla.

India was not created as a "Hindu country." Its leaders built a secular state, meaning it would not have an official religion, and many millions of Muslims stayed in India.

Two provinces, Punjab in the northwest and Bengal in the east, had populations that were roughly half Muslim and half non-Muslim. They could not simply be handed to one side. They had to be cut in two.

Whose Story?

The same August is remembered very differently. In Pakistan, 14 August is above all a day of celebration: the birth of a homeland, achieved under Jinnah's leadership. In India, 15 August is Independence Day, the end of colonial rule won by a long freedom struggle, and Partition is often remembered as the price of that freedom. For millions of Punjabi and Bengali families on both sides, especially Sikh and Hindu families who left West Punjab and Muslim families who left East Punjab, 1947 is remembered first as the year they lost their homes. Many British accounts once focused on the "transfer of power" and Mountbatten's speed, while more recent historians, on all sides, have centered the voices of ordinary survivors, including women, whose stories were missing from the official record.

The Radcliffe Line

Someone had to decide where the new borders would run through Punjab and Bengal. The British appointed Sir Cyril Radcliffe, a London lawyer who, according to many accounts, had never visited India before. He arrived on 8 July 1947 and had about five weeks to divide two provinces home to tens of millions of people. He chaired two boundary commissions, each with members chosen by the Congress and the Muslim League, who usually disagreed, leaving the final decisions to him.

The **Radcliffe Line** is the boundary Radcliffe drew to divide the provinces of Punjab and Bengal between India and Pakistan in 1947. It was based mainly on which districts had Muslim or non-Muslim majorities, though Radcliffe could also weigh "other factors" such as canals, railways and roads. No line could separate the communities neatly. The Punjab was home to many Sikhs, whose holiest sites and farmland lay on both sides.

The Line was published on 17 August 1947, two days *after* independence. That meant many people celebrated freedom without knowing which country

their village was in. Today the Punjab part of the Radcliffe Line is part of the India-Pakistan border, and the Bengal part is the India-Bangladesh border.

Partition migration

As the new borders became known and violence spread, huge numbers of people began to move.

Partition Migration is the movement of millions of people across the new India-Pakistan borders in 1947 and the years after: Hindus and Sikhs moving into India, and Muslims moving into Pakistan. In Punjab, the migration was concentrated into a few terrible months. People traveled on foot in columns many kilometers long, on bullock carts and on overcrowded trains. In Bengal, the movement was slower and continued for years and even decades.

Historians don't know the exact numbers, and the estimates differ:

- **People displaced:** Stanford Libraries' Partition guide gives about 14 million refugees. A study based on census records (Bharadwaj, Khwaja and Mian, 2008) estimated about 14.5 million people arriving in the new countries and about 17.9 million leaving, which leaves about 3.4 million people unaccounted for. So a fair range is **about 14 million to 18 million people displaced**.
- **Deaths:** Estimates range from **about 200,000 to 2 million** people killed. No one counted at the time, and many deaths were never recorded.

People were killed in every community. Hindus and Sikhs were attacked in areas that became Pakistan, and Muslims were attacked in areas that became India. Trains arrived carrying people who had been killed on the way. Tens of thousands of women were kidnapped and assaulted. After Partition, India and Pakistan each claimed that tens of thousands of women from their communities had been abducted and agreed to try to return

them. There were also many acts of courage: neighbors who hid families of another faith, and villages that protected their minorities.

Survivors rebuilt their lives in new cities. Refugees from West Punjab helped reshape Delhi, and refugees from East Punjab helped reshape Lahore and Karachi, while Bengali Hindu refugees settled in and around Kolkata. Many never saw their childhood homes again. Today the 1947 Partition Archive and other projects record survivors' memories before they are lost.

If this feels heavy

It's okay if these numbers feel hard to hold. Historians use ranges here because every number stands for people who were never counted, and it's fine to take a break before reading on.

The princely states choose

When Britain left, its treaties with the princes ended. In theory each prince could join India, join Pakistan, or stay independent. In practice, leaders on both sides, especially India's Vallabhbhai Patel, pressed them to join, and most did so by August 1947, largely based on geography.

A few did not. Hyderabad, the largest princely state, had a Muslim ruler, the Nizam, and a mostly Hindu population, and it was surrounded by Indian territory. The Nizam wanted to remain independent. In September 1948, Indian troops entered Hyderabad in a military operation and the state became part of India.

4.8 The Kashmir Dispute

The hardest case of all was Jammu and Kashmir, a large princely state in the far north, touching both India and Pakistan. Its population was mostly Muslim, but its ruler, Maharaja Hari Singh, was Hindu. He delayed choosing a side.

In October 1947, armed tribesmen from Pakistan's northwest, supported by Pakistan, entered Kashmir. The Maharaja asked India for military help and, in late October 1947, signed an Instrument of Accession joining India. Indian troops arrived, and the first war between India and Pakistan followed. A ceasefire arranged by the United Nations took effect on 1 January 1949. The ceasefire line became, after another war and the 1972 Simla Agreement, the **Line of Control** that still divides the region.

The **Kashmir Dispute** is the continuing disagreement, mainly between India and Pakistan, over who should control the former princely state of Jammu and Kashmir. Each side states its position this way:

- **India's position:** the Maharaja's Instrument of Accession was legal and final, so the whole former state is part of India.
- **Pakistan's position:** the accession was not valid, the region's Muslim majority should have joined Pakistan, and the people of Kashmir should decide their future through a vote, as early United Nations resolutions called for.
- **Many Kashmiris** have their own views, which differ from region to region and person to person: some favor India, some Pakistan, and some want independence or more self-rule.

China also controls part of the wider Kashmir region, including Aksai Chin, which India claims. Today India controls roughly 55 percent of the region's land, Pakistan about 30 percent, and China about 15 percent. The dispute has led to several wars and much loss of life. In August 2019, India ended the special self-governing status of the part it administers and split it into two union territories, a move Pakistan rejected. In May 2025, after gunmen killed 26 people, most of them tourists, near Pahalgam in Indian-administered

Kashmir, India and Pakistan exchanged missile and drone strikes for four days before agreeing to a ceasefire on 10 May. As of October 2026 the dispute remains unresolved. This book describes Kashmir as disputed and does not take a side, which is also why its maps never draw official borders.

4.9 Sri Lankan Independence

Sri Lankan Independence is the peaceful transfer of power from Britain to the island then called Ceylon, which became an independent country on 4 February 1948. Britain granted it under the Ceylon Independence Act of 1947, after years of negotiation, with no partition and none of the mass violence seen in Punjab and Bengal. Don Stephen Senanayake became the first prime minister. For its first years, the country stayed closely tied to Britain, which kept military bases there, and the British monarch remained head of state. In 1972, Ceylon became a republic and changed its name to Sri Lanka.

Sri Lanka's later history had its own deep conflicts, including a long civil war covered in Chapter 19, but independence itself was quiet. Sri Lankans celebrate 4 February as Independence Day.

The Maldives followed a different path again. It had been a British protectorate, not a colony, and became fully independent on 26 July 1965.

4.10 From the Language Movement to Bangladesh

Now we come back to Nanu's mother's house near Chattogram. In 1947 it became part of East Pakistan. Why did East Pakistan become a separate country only 24 years later?

The Language Movement of 1952

Pakistan's two wings shared a religion, Islam, but differed in language, food, dress and history. In 1948, Pakistan's government announced that Urdu, a language most people in East Bengal did not speak at home, would be the only national language. Bengalis protested, because most of Pakistan's people spoke Bangla.

The **Language Movement of 1952** was a protest movement in East Bengal demanding that Bangla be recognized as a national language of Pakistan, which reached its peak on 21 February 1952, when police in Dhaka opened fire on student protesters and killed several of them. Those killed are honored in Bangladesh as Language Martyrs, and the Shaheed Minar (Martyrs' Monument) in Dhaka stands in their memory. In 1956, Pakistan's first constitution recognized Bangla as an official language alongside Urdu.

In Bangladesh, 21 February, often called *Ekushey* ("the twenty-first"), is a national day of mourning and pride. In 1999, UNESCO declared 21 February International Mother Language Day, an idea that came from Bangladesh, and it has been observed around the world since 2000.

The Bangladesh Liberation War of 1971

That didn't solve the deeper problem. Many East Pakistanis felt that the western wing controlled the government, the army and much of the money, though the east had more people. The Awami League, led by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, demanded much more self-government for the east.

In the December 1970 national elections, the Awami League won 167 of East Pakistan's 169 seats, which gave it a majority in Pakistan's whole National Assembly. Pakistan's military government did not hand over power, and talks failed. On the night of 25 March 1971, the Pakistani army launched a military crackdown, called Operation Searchlight, in Dhaka and across the east.

The **Bangladesh Liberation War** was the 1971 war in which East Pakistan fought for and won independence from Pakistan, becoming Bangladesh. In Bangla it is called মুক্তিযুদ্ধ (*MOOK-tee-jud-dho*), *Muktijuddho*, "liberation war." Bangladesh's independence was declared on 26 March 1971, which Bangladesh celebrates as Independence Day. Bengali fighters, called the Mukti Bahini ("liberation force"), fought a guerrilla war. About 10 million refugees fled to India. On 3 December 1971, war broke out openly between India and Pakistan, and India's army joined the fight in the east. The Pakistani army in the east surrendered in Dhaka on 16 December 1971, which Bangladesh celebrates as Victory Day.

The human cost was enormous, and the numbers are disputed:

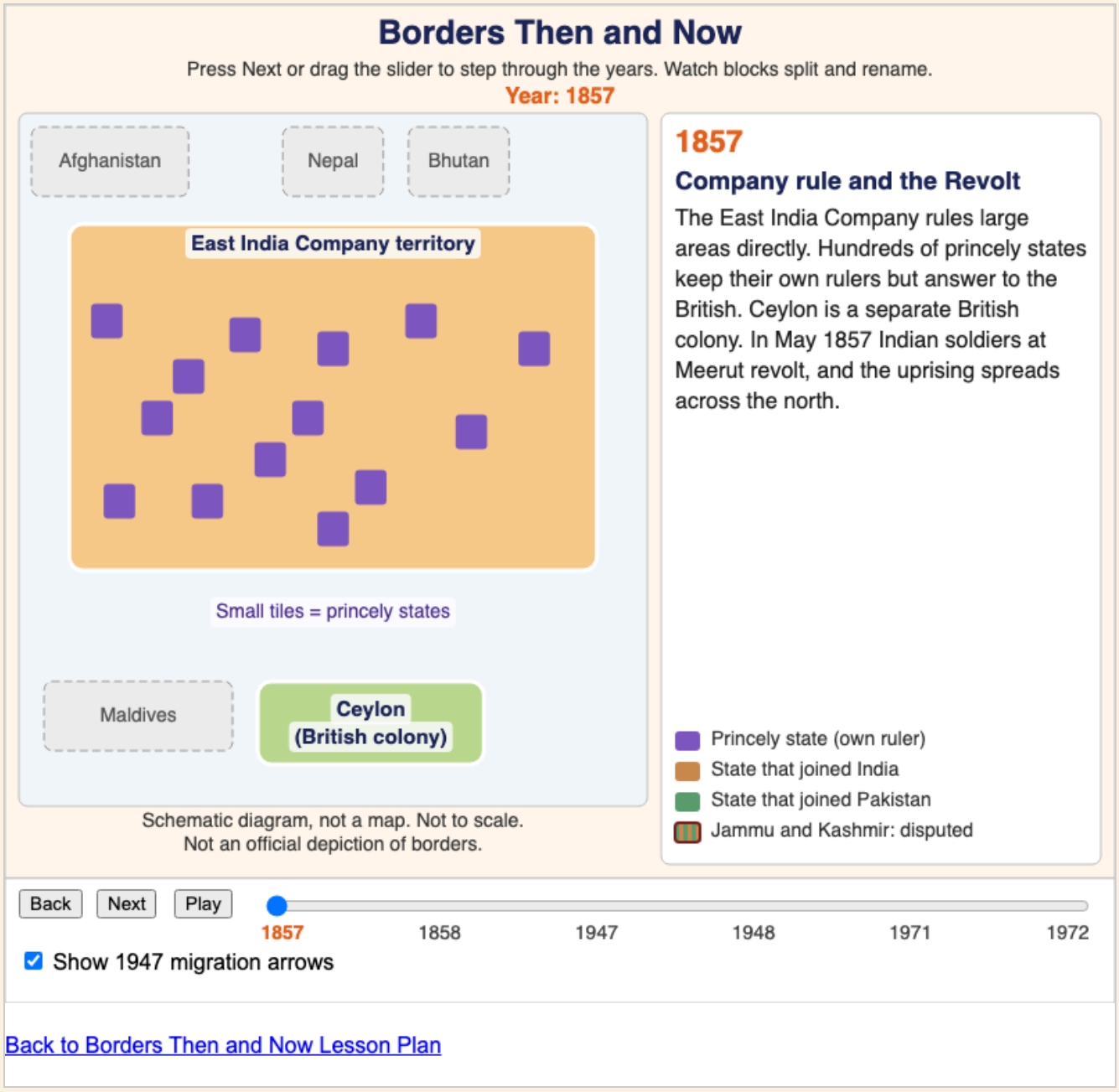
- **Deaths:** most estimates range from about **300,000 to 3 million**. Bangladesh's official figure is 3 million. Some researchers give lower figures, and there is no complete count.
- **Refugees:** about 10 million people fled to India, where crowded camps had high death rates of their own.
- Pakistani soldiers and allied militias killed large numbers of civilians, including students, teachers and the Hindu minority, and committed widespread sexual violence against women. Many Bangladeshis and many scholars describe these killings as a genocide.
- There was also violence against Urdu-speaking Biharis (Muslims who had moved from India to East Pakistan around 1947), many of whom were seen as supporting Pakistan and were killed or driven from their homes by Bengali fighters and crowds.

So the answer to Zara's puzzle is that Bangladesh was **not** created by Partition. It was created in a second, separate event in 1971. Partition made the area part of Pakistan, and the Liberation War made it Bangladesh.

Two events, not one

Try saying the whole sequence out loud: British India in 1946, East Pakistan in 1947, Bangladesh in 1971. Which step was decided by a line drawn in an office, and which was decided by the people living there?

Diagram: Borders Then and Now



[Back to Borders Then and Now Lesson Plan]

Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch04-borders-then-and-now/main.html

Open the Borders Then and Now fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Borders Then and Now

sim-id: ch04-borders-then-and-now
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: explain
Learning Objective: The learner will explain how one colonial territory, British India, became several nations in separate steps (1947 and 1971), and how Ceylon and the princely states fit into that story.

Canvas: responsive width; 630 px drawing area plus 90 px control area.

Controls: Back and Next buttons, Play/Pause (starts paused), a stage slider (1857, 1858, 1947, 1948, 1971, 1972), a "Show 1947 migration arrows" checkbox; tapping the diagram also advances one step.

Behavior: A schematic block diagram, not a map. In 1857 and 1858 one large block (East India Company territory, then British India) holds small purple tiles for princely states, with Ceylon below and Afghanistan, Nepal, Bhutan and the Maldives as gray outside blocks. In 1947 the block splits into West Pakistan, India and East Pakistan; tiles change color as they join India or Pakistan, Hyderabad stays purple until 1948, and Jammu and Kashmir becomes a striped "disputed" tile. In 1948 Ceylon is labeled independent; in 1971 East Pakistan becomes Bangladesh; in 1972 Ceylon becomes Sri Lanka. A panel gives the dates and sourced ranges for each event. The caption says the diagram is schematic, not to scale and not an official depiction of borders.

Start at 1857 and press **Next** one step at a time. At each step, read the panel, then ask: what split, what joined, and what only changed its name? Watch the jump from 1858 to 1947, when the big block breaks into three and the princely-state tiles change color as they join a side.

Then go from 1947 to 1971 and watch East Pakistan. Its block doesn't move at all. Only its name changes. That's Nanu's point: the land and people stayed put while the country changed around them. Finally, compare Ceylon's single peaceful step with Bangladesh's two steps.

Ask Your Elders

> **Your interview for this chapter**
>
> Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about what your family remembers or was told about independence, 1947, 1971 or 1948, and how those years are talked about at home. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Some memories of 1947 and 1971 are painful. Ask first whether they want to talk about those years at all, let them choose what to share, and never push for details. Ask if it's okay to take notes.

Questions to ask

1. When you were young, how did your family celebrate Independence Day (14 August, 15 August, 4 February or 26 March), or Victory Day? What do you remember about it?
2. Where was our family living in 1947, or in 1971? Did anyone have to move?

3. Were there stories in the family about neighbors, friends or places left behind? You only need to share what you're comfortable with.
4. What did people call these events at home? For example, "Partition," "independence," "the liberation war," or something else?
5. How do you think people talk about these years now, compared with when you were young, or compared with how people talk about them here in the United States?
6. What is one thing about our family's history in those years that you hope I remember and pass on?

Listen for: whether the story centers the Partition of 1947, Partition Migration or the Bangladesh Liberation War; places on either side of the Radcliffe Line; and how the memory compares with the "Whose Story?" box above.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's account with a friend's interview from a family with roots in a different country, such as India, Pakistan, Bangladesh or Sri Lanka. Did they use the same name for the events? Did one family remember celebration and the other loss? Write two sentences on why both memories can be true at once.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Partition in 1947 created Bangladesh.
Reality: Partition created India and Pakistan. The area that is now

Bangladesh became East Pakistan in 1947. Bangladesh was created in a separate event, the Liberation War of 1971.

Myth: India won independence through nonviolence alone.
Reality: Gandhi's nonviolent campaigns were central, but independence also came from elections and political bargaining, armed revolutionaries, the Indian National Army, strikes and protests, and Britain's weakness after the Second World War. Historians still debate how much each mattered.

Myth: The violence of Partition happened on one side.
Reality: People of every community were killed, attacked and forced from their homes: Hindus and Sikhs in areas that became Pakistan, and Muslims in areas that became India. Survivors on both sides carry the memory.

Myth: Britain ruled every part of South Asia directly.
Reality: About 565 princely states kept their own rulers under British control. Afghanistan, Nepal and Bhutan were never British colonies, though Britain influenced their foreign affairs, and the Maldives was a protectorate. Ceylon was a colony governed separately from British India.

Myth: Pakistan was always one block of land.
Reality: From 1947 to 1971 Pakistan had two wings, West and East, with India in between. Most of its people lived in the eastern wing and spoke Bangla.

Check Yourself

1. What happened at the Battle of Plassey, and why does it matter?

On 23 June 1757, the East India Company under Robert Clive defeated the Nawab of Bengal, helped by the betrayal of the Nawab's commander, Mir Jafar. It gave the Company control of Bengal's wealth, the base from which it expanded across South Asia.

2. What changed in 1858?

After the Revolt of 1857, the Government of India Act of 1858 ended East India Company rule and placed its territories under the British Crown. That began the British Raj, which lasted until 1947.

3. What was the Radcliffe Line, and why did its timing cause problems?

It was the boundary drawn through Punjab and Bengal to divide them between India and Pakistan. It was published on 17 August 1947, two days after independence, so many people did not know which country they were in when independence came.

4. About how many people were displaced by Partition, and why do historians give a range?

About 14 million to 18 million people. No one kept a full count in the chaos, and different methods, such as refugee records and census comparisons, give different totals.

5. Why is 21 February important in Bangladesh and around the world?

On 21 February 1952, police killed student protesters in Dhaka who were demanding recognition for Bangla. Bangladesh honors them on that day, and since 1999 UNESCO has marked it as International Mother Language Day.

Exercises

Remember

1. Give the independence dates of Pakistan, India, Sri Lanka (Ceylon) and Bangladesh.

> **Answer**
>
> Pakistan: 14 August 1947. India: 15 August 1947. Ceylon (Sri Lanka): 4 February 1948. Bangladesh declared independence on 26 March 1971, and the war ended on 16 December 1971.

2. Name the leaders most closely linked to the Indian National Congress, the All-India Muslim League, and the drafting of India's Constitution.

> **Answer**
>
> Mahatma Gandhi (with Jawaharlal Nehru) led the Congress. Muhammad Ali Jinnah led the Muslim League. B. R. Ambedkar chaired the Constitution's Drafting Committee.

Understand

1. Explain in your own words what satyagraha means and give one example of it.

> **Answer**
>
> Satyagraha means "holding firmly to truth": openly and nonviolently refusing to obey an unjust law and accepting the punishment. The Salt March of 1930, when Gandhi walked to Dandi and made salt in defiance of the British salt law, is the best-known example.

2. Explain why the Kashmir Dispute began in 1947.

Answer

Jammu and Kashmir was a princely state with a Muslim-majority population and a Hindu ruler. After armed tribesmen from Pakistan entered in October 1947, the Maharaja joined India in return for military help. Pakistan disputed the accession, war followed, and both countries have claimed the region ever since.

Apply

1. Use the Borders Then and Now MicroSim. Step from 1858 to 1972 and, for each step, write one sentence saying which blocks split, joined or only changed their names. *Hint: notice which step changes only a label.*
2. A classmate says her grandfather was "born in Pakistan" in 1950 in Sylhet. Using this chapter, explain which country Sylhet is in today and why her statement is still correct. *Hint: Sylhet was part of East Pakistan.*

Analyze

1. Compare the Partition of 1947 with Sri Lankan Independence in 1948. Identify two reasons one was so much more violent than the other. *Hint: think about how the land and its people were divided, and how fast it happened.*
2. Analyze the causes of the Bengal Famine of 1943. Which causes came from the war, and which came from government decisions? *Hint: sort the four causes in section 4.5 into two groups.*

Evaluate

1. The 1857 uprising has been called the "Sepoy Mutiny" and the "First War of Independence." Evaluate both names. Which would you use in a club presentation, and why? *Hint: what does each name assume about who rebelled and why?*
2. Some people say Radcliffe should not be blamed for Partition violence because he was given an impossible task. Evaluate this claim using evidence from the chapter. *Hint: consider the five-week timeline, the mixed populations and who decided the timing.*

Create

1. Create a timeline poster with six dates from this chapter, from 1757 to 1972. For each date, write one sentence and a symbol, and include at least one event from Sri Lanka and one from Bangladesh. *Hint: the MicroSim stages can be your starting points.*
2. Write a short letter (150 to 200 words) from a fictional teenager in Lahore, Delhi or Dhaka in 1947 or 1971 to a friend on the other side of a new border. Show the friendship and the fear, without graphic detail. *Hint: use at least two concept words from this chapter.*

Key Takeaways

- British rule began with the East India Company's victory at the Battle of Plassey in 1757. After the Revolt of 1857, the British Crown ruled directly as the British Raj from 1858 to 1947.
- British India was a patchwork: about 565 princely states kept their own rulers, and Afghanistan, Nepal and Bhutan were never British colonies.

- Freedom came through many paths: the Indian National Congress, the All-India Muslim League, Gandhi's satyagraha, Ambedkar's fight for Dalit rights, Jinnah's call for Pakistan, revolutionaries and Britain's postwar weakness.
- The Partition of 1947 split British India into India and a two-winged Pakistan along the Radcliffe Line; about 14 to 18 million people were displaced and between about 200,000 and 2 million were killed, in every community.
- The Kashmir Dispute began in 1947 and remains unresolved, with India, Pakistan and many Kashmiris holding different positions.
- Ceylon became independent peacefully on 4 February 1948 and was renamed Sri Lanka in 1972.
- Bangladesh was not created by Partition: the Language Movement of 1952 and the Bangladesh Liberation War of 1971 turned East Pakistan into an independent country.

You untangled the map!

You can now explain how a woman could live in three countries without leaving home. Next, in Chapter 5, we visit the mosques, mandirs, gurdwaras, temples and churches where so many South Asian families find meaning.

Quiz: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition

Test your understanding of Chapter 4. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

What happened at the Battle of Plassey in 1757?

A. The East India Company defeated the Nawab of Bengal, helped by the betrayal of the Nawab's commander

B. Indian soldiers at Meerut rose up against the East India Company

C. The British Crown took over the government of India from the East India Company

D. Britain fought its first war in Afghanistan

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. At Plassey, Robert Clive's Company forces defeated Siraj-ud-Daulah after Mir Jafar kept his troops out of the fight, giving the Company control of Bengal. The Meerut uprising (B) was the start of the Revolt of 1857, a century later.

Concept Tested: Battle of Plassey **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 2

Which statement best describes the princely states?

A. Provinces governed directly by British governors

B. Independent countries outside the British Empire, like Nepal

C. Kingdoms with their own Indian rulers who accepted British control of defense and foreign affairs

D. Territories created by the Radcliffe Line in 1947

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. About 565 princely states kept their own rulers but were tied to Britain by treaties. They were not directly ruled provinces (A), and unlike Nepal they were inside the British system (B).

Concept Tested: Princely States **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

Why is the Revolt of 1857 called by different names, such as the "Sepoy Mutiny" and the "First War of Independence"?

A. Because historians disagree about the year it took place

B. Because each name reflects a different view of who rebelled and why

C. Because it happened in two separate countries

D. Because the British Crown renamed it in 1858

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. "Sepoy Mutiny" treats it as a soldiers' revolt, while "First War of Independence" treats it as the start of a national struggle. The date (A) is not in dispute: it began on 10 May 1857.

Concept Tested: Revolt of 1857 **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 4

Which pair of dates gives Pakistan's and India's independence days?

A. 26 January 1950 and 15 August 1947

B. 4 February 1948 and 14 August 1947

C. 23 March 1940 and 26 March 1971

D. 14 August 1947 and 15 August 1947

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Pakistan celebrates 14 August and India 15 August 1947. 26 January 1950 (A) is when India's Constitution took effect, and 4 February 1948 (B) is Sri Lanka's independence day.

Concept Tested: Partition of 1947 **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 5

What made satyagraha different from other ways of resisting British rule?

A. It relied on secret armed attacks against officials

B. People openly and nonviolently broke unjust laws and accepted the punishment

C. It asked Britain to divide India into two countries

D. It was a petition sent only by lawyers to Parliament

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Satyagraha, "holding firmly to truth," meant open, nonviolent refusal to obey unjust laws, as in the Salt March. Armed attacks (A) were the path of some revolutionaries, not Gandhi.

Concept Tested: Satyagraha **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 6

Why did the timing of the Radcliffe Line's publication add to the confusion of 1947?

A. It was published two days after independence, so many people did not yet know which country they were in

B. It was published a year before independence, giving people too long to argue

C. It was never published, so the border was decided by the armies

D. It was published only in English newspapers in London

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The Line was announced on 17 August 1947, after both countries had become independent, so many people celebrated without knowing where the border would fall. It was published (C), and it came after independence, not before (B).

Concept Tested: Radcliffe Line **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

Zara's Nanu says, "I was born in Pakistan in 1960, near Chattogram." Which explanation is correct?

A. She is mistaken, because Chattogram has always been in India

B. She is mistaken, because Bangladesh was created by Partition in 1947

C. She is right only if she later moved to Lahore

D. She is right, because from 1947 to 1971 Chattogram was in East Pakistan

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Chattogram was in East Pakistan from 1947 until Bangladesh's independence in 1971. Option B repeats a common myth: Partition created India and Pakistan, and Bangladesh came later, in 1971.

Concept Tested: Bangladesh Liberation War **Bloom's Level:** Apply

---

Question 8

A student uses the MicroSim and notices that between 1948 and 1971 one block only changes its name. Which block is it, and what does that show?

A. India; it shows India changed its borders in 1971

B. Ceylon; it shows Sri Lanka was partitioned

C. East Pakistan becoming Bangladesh; it shows a new country can form while the land and people stay in place

D. West Pakistan becoming Afghanistan; it shows the Anglo-Afghan Wars changed borders

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The East Pakistan block keeps its size and place and becomes Bangladesh, showing that the country changed around people who never moved. Ceylon (B) was never partitioned. It changed its name to Sri Lanka in 1972.

Concept Tested: Bangladesh Liberation War **Bloom's Level:** Apply

---

Question 9

Compare the Partition of 1947 with Sri Lankan Independence in 1948. Which is the best explanation of why Partition was far more violent?

A. Partition divided mixed provinces like Punjab and Bengal in a few weeks, while Ceylon became independent as one unit after years of negotiation

B. Ceylon had no British officials, so there was nothing to fight over

C. Partition happened during the Second World War, while Sri Lanka's independence came after it

D. Sri Lanka was a princely state, so its ruler kept order

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Splitting mixed provinces at high speed, with borders announced after independence, set off mass migration and violence, while Ceylon was handed over whole. Option C is wrong because Partition took place in 1947, after the war had ended.

Concept Tested: Sri Lankan Independence **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

---

Question 10

Why do historians give Partition migration as a range, about 14 million to 18 million people, instead of one exact number?

A. Because the British government kept exact records but has not released them

B. Because only people who crossed by train were counted

C. Because Pakistan and India agreed to use different numbers

D. Because no one kept a full count, and different methods, such as refugee records and census comparisons, give different totals

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Refugee counts and census-based estimates produce different totals, and a census study found about 3.4 million people unaccounted for. There is no hidden exact record (A). The gaps come from the chaos of 1947.

Concept Tested: Partition Migration **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

---

Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia

Summary

South Asia is home to many of the world's faiths. Four of them, Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism, began in the region, and others, including Islam, Christianity, Zoroastrianism and Judaism, arrived long ago and put down deep roots. This chapter introduces each faith through the same five lenses: where it came from, its sacred texts, its place of worship, a major festival, and a core idea. It also looks at pilgrimage, at the places and practices that different faiths share, and at religious pluralism, the fact of many faiths living side by side, with all its friendships and tensions. The goal is understanding, not ranking: you'll learn how followers describe their own beliefs, in their own words where possible.

Concepts Covered

1. Hinduism
2. Dharma
3. Karma and Rebirth
4. Puja
5. Buddhism
6. Theravada and Vajrayana
7. Jainism
8. Ahimsa

9. Islam in South Asia
10. Sunni and Shia Islam
11. Sikhism
12. Guru Granth Sahib
13. Langar
14. Christianity in South Asia
15. Zoroastrians (Parsis)
16. Jewish Communities
17. Pilgrimage
18. Religious Pluralism

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?, for the eight countries and the rivers.
- Chapter 2: Ancient Roots, for the Vedic period and the early history of Buddhism and Jainism.
- Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters, especially early Islam in South Asia, the Bhakti movement, Sufism and Guru Nanak.

Many ways of believing

Hi, it's Mora! You probably have classmates who fast in Ramadan, light diyas at Diwali, wear a turban or kara, go to Mass, or don't follow any religion at all. Knowing a little about each other's faiths helps you ask kind questions, avoid hurtful mix-ups, and maybe get invited to a great festival meal. Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

5.1 Shoes Off, Three Times

On a Saturday in October, the Prairie Ridge South Asian Student Association goes on a field trip. Ms. Okafor has arranged three visits in the Twin Cities: a mosque in the morning, a gurdwara at lunchtime, and a mandir (a Hindu temple) in the afternoon. Zara Hossain's family prays at the mosque. Simran Kaur Gill's family goes to the gurdwara every Sunday. Arjun Reddy's grandmother volunteers at the mandir.

At the mosque, Zara shows Ben Lindqvist the shelves by the door, and everyone leaves their shoes there before entering the prayer hall. At the gurdwara, Simran hands Ben an orange scarf to cover his head, and again, shoes come off. Then they all sit in rows on the floor and eat dal, roti and kheer for free, side by side with strangers. At the mandir, Arjun points to a long rack of sneakers and sandals. Ben laughs. "Okay, three buildings, three religions, and I've taken my shoes off three times. So are these faiths basically the same, or totally different?"

Simran shakes her head. "Not the same. But you can't understand any of them from the outside in five minutes." On the bus home, Ben keeps asking questions. How do you learn about many faiths without mixing them up, and without deciding one is better than another?

5.2 Five Lenses, No Ranking

Ben already knows one faith from the inside. His family is Lutheran, a kind of Christian. If a friend asked him about it, he could answer a few basic questions: Where did it start? What book do you read? Where do you go to worship? What's your biggest holiday? What's one idea that matters most? Those answers wouldn't be the whole of his faith, but they'd be a fair start.

This chapter uses those same five questions, or **lenses**, for every faith:

1. **Origins:** where and when it began, and who followers say founded or taught it.
2. **Sacred texts:** the writings it treasures.
3. **Place of worship:** the building where people gather.
4. **A major festival:** one celebration among many.
5. **A core idea:** one teaching that followers often describe as central.

Using the same lenses for every faith keeps the comparison fair. It also comes with three ground rules that this whole book follows:

- **Describe, don't judge.** We say "many Hindus believe" or "in Sikh tradition," because these are the beliefs of followers, not claims the book is making.
- **No ranking.** Older doesn't mean better, and bigger doesn't mean more important.
- **Practice varies.** Inside every faith there are many communities, schools and family customs. When you read "Muslims do X," remember that real families are more varied than any summary.

Ask before assuming

A person's name, clothes or country don't tell you their faith, or how they practice it. If you're curious, ask politely, and accept "I'd rather not say" as a full answer.

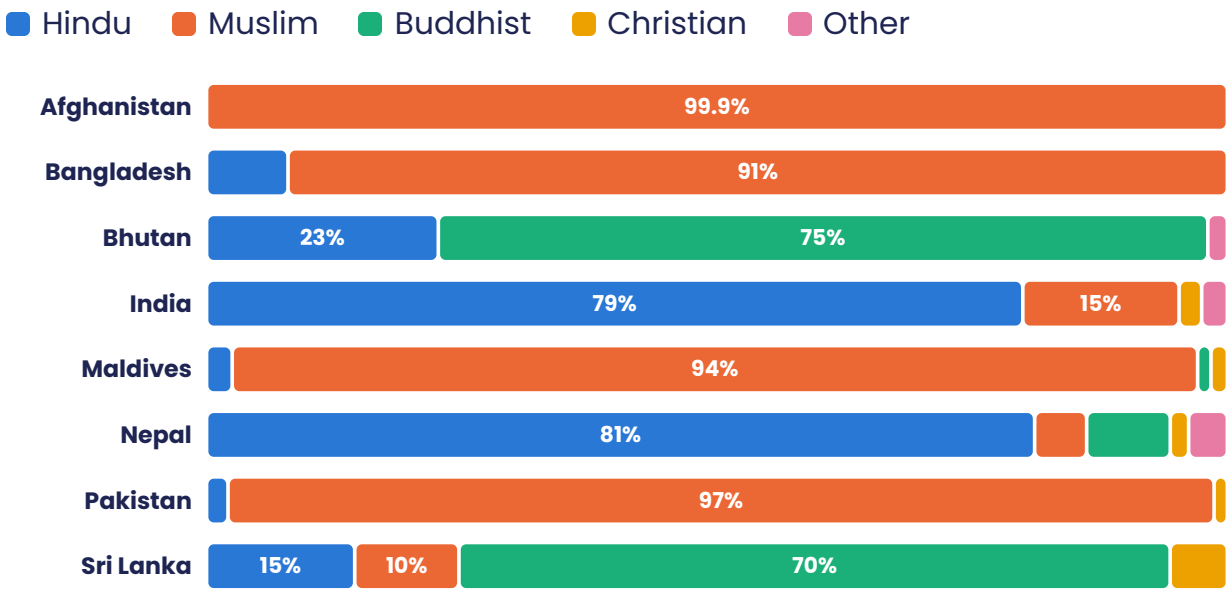
5.3 A Faith Map of South Asia

Before meeting each faith, it helps to see where people of different faiths live. The table shows the largest groups in each of the eight countries, using each country's most recent census (or the best available estimate).

Country	Largest faith	Other important communities	Source and year
Afghanistan	Islam (almost everyone; mostly Sunni)	A Shia minority; very small Sikh and Hindu communities	Estimates; no recent census
Bangladesh	Islam, 91.08%	Hindus 7.96%; Buddhists 0.61%; Christians 0.30%	2022 census (final report, 2023)
Bhutan	Buddhism, about three-quarters	Hindus, most of the rest	Pew Research estimate
India	Hinduism, 79.8%	Muslims 14.2%; Christians 2.3%; Sikhs just under 2%; Buddhists and Jains each under 1%	2011 census
Maldives	Islam	The constitution requires citizens to be Muslim	2008 constitution
Nepal	Hinduism, 81.19%	Buddhists 8.21%; Muslims 5.09%; Kirat (the faith of Kirati peoples such as the Rai and Limbu) 3.17%; Christians 1.76%	2021 census

Country	Largest faith	Other important communities	Source and year
Pakistan	Islam, 96.35%	Hindus about 3.9 million, plus about 1.3 million in a separate Scheduled Castes category, many of them Hindu Dalit communities; Christians about 3.3 million	2023 census
Sri Lanka	Buddhism, 69.8%	Hindus 12.6%; Muslims 10.7%; Christians about 6.9%	2024 census

The chart below shows the same idea a second way. It uses Pew Research Center's 2020 estimates, which apply one method to all eight countries, so its numbers differ a little from the census figures in the table. Hover over or tap a bar to see each share.



Source: Pew Research Center, "Religious Composition by Country, 2010-2020" (June 2025), 2020 estimates. Only the groups Pew lists for each country are shown. Shares are rounded, and groups under 1% that Pew does not list separately are left out, so some rows do not reach exactly 100%. Each bar is drawn on its own row total.

Show the numbers as a table

A few things jump out. India's figures come from the 2011 census, so treat them as a snapshot from fifteen years ago. India's next census counts its population in February 2027. Even small percentages can mean huge numbers of people: India's 14.2% Muslim share in 2011 was about 172 million people, one of the largest Muslim populations in the world. And no country lines up with only one faith. Every country on the list is home to several.

5.4 Hinduism

Origins and variety

Hinduism is a family of related traditions, beliefs and practices that grew in South Asia over thousands of years, with no single founder, no single holy book and no single central authority. Most Hindus live in India and Nepal, the two Hindu-majority countries of South Asia. There are also large Hindu communities in Bangladesh, in Sri Lanka (mostly among Tamils in the north and east), in Pakistan (mostly in Sindh), in Bhutan, and around the world.

The word "Hindu" was first used by outsiders, from the name of the Indus River (Sindhu). Many Hindus also call their tradition *Sanatana Dharma*, "the eternal way." Inside that family are many traditions. Some Hindus focus their devotion on Vishnu (often as Krishna or Rama), some on Shiva, and some on the Goddess (Devi) in forms such as Durga or Kali. Many worship several deities, and many describe them as forms of one divine reality. In Pew Research Center's 2021 survey of India, 84% of Hindus who believe in God

either picked more than one god as feeling close to them or said they have many personal gods, and 61% said there is one God with many manifestations.

Sacred texts

Hinduism has many sacred texts, not one. The oldest are the **Vedas**, hymns in Sanskrit passed down by memory for many centuries. The **Upanishads** explore questions about the self and ultimate reality. The great epics, the **Ramayana** and the **Mahabharata** (which includes the **Bhagavad Gita**), are known to almost everyone through stories, TV shows and festivals. The **Puranas** and devotional poems in Tamil, Bengali, Hindi and many other languages matter too. Different communities value different texts most.

Three key ideas

Dharma (धर्म, *DHUR-muh*) is the idea of right order, duty and right conduct: the way things should be, and the way a person should act. In Hindi, *dharm* can also simply mean "religion." Many Hindus think of their own dharma as depending on their stage of life and responsibilities, such as being a student, a parent or a teacher.

Karma and Rebirth is the belief that a person's actions and intentions (karma, कर्म, *KUR-muh*, "action") have effects, in this life and in future lives, and that the soul is reborn again and again in a cycle called *samsara*. In many Hindu traditions, the highest goal is *moksha*, release from that cycle. Buddhists, Jains and Sikhs also speak of karma and rebirth, each in their own way. In the 2021 Pew survey of India, 77% of Hindus and 77% of Muslims said they believe in karma, a sign of how widely the idea has spread across faith lines.

Puja (पूजा, *POO-jah*, "worship" or "honor") is the Hindu ritual of offering worship to a deity, often with light, flowers, water, incense or food. Puja can be a big

temple ceremony with priests, or a few quiet minutes at a home shrine in the morning. Arjun's grandmother does a short puja every day at the small shrine in their kitchen.

Places and festivals

Hindus worship at a mandir (मंदिर, *MUN-dir*, "temple"), and many families also keep a home shrine. Big festivals include Diwali, the festival of lights; Holi, the spring festival of colors; Navaratri and Durga Puja in autumn; and harvest festivals such as Pongal. In Bangladesh, Durga Puja is the largest Hindu festival, and Dhaka's Dhakeshwari National Temple is dedicated to the goddess many say gave the city its name. In Pakistan, the Hinglaj Mata temple in Balochistan draws the country's largest Hindu pilgrimage. You'll meet the festivals in Chapter 7.

5.5 Buddhism

Buddhism is the faith based on the teachings of Siddhartha Gautama, called the Buddha ("awakened one"), who Buddhists believe found the path to freedom from suffering. He was born at Lumbini, in present-day Nepal, about 2,500 years ago (the exact dates are debated). Buddhists believe he reached enlightenment while meditating under a tree at Bodh Gaya, in present-day India. Both Lumbini and the Mahabodhi Temple at Bodh Gaya are UNESCO World Heritage Sites.

In Buddhist teaching, the Buddha described **Four Noble Truths**: life involves suffering and dissatisfaction; suffering has a cause, especially craving; suffering can end; and the **Eightfold Path** of right understanding, ethical living and meditation leads to that end. Buddhists take refuge in the "Three Jewels": the Buddha, his teaching (the Dharma), and the community of monks, nuns and followers (the Sangha).

Buddhism spread from South Asia across Asia and developed different schools. In India itself, many Buddhists today are Dalits whose families followed the reformer B. R. Ambedkar into Buddhism after his conversion at Nagpur in 1956 (you met him in Chapter 4). Two schools matter most in South Asia today.

Theravada and Vajrayana

Theravada and Vajrayana are two of the main schools of Buddhism. Theravada ("teaching of the elders") is the school of Sri Lanka, and its scriptures are the **Pali Canon**, preserved in the Pali language. Buddhism reached Sri Lanka in the 3rd century BCE, and the island has been a center of Theravada learning ever since. Vajrayana (the "diamond" or "thunderbolt" vehicle) developed later and became the Buddhism of Tibet, Bhutan and Himalayan Nepal. It uses Mahayana scriptures and Tibetan teachings, and is known for its rituals, chanted mantras and the close bond between students and their teachers.

	Theravada	Vajrayana
Where in South Asia	Sri Lanka; also most Buddhists in Bangladesh	Bhutan, Himalayan Nepal, Ladakh and other Himalayan areas
Scriptures	Pali Canon	Mahayana sutras and Tibetan Buddhist texts
Typical place	A vihara (monastery temple) with a stupa	A monastery; in Bhutan, many sit inside dzongs (fortress-like centers)

	Theravada	Vajrayana
Example	Dilan Perera's family in Kandy visits the Temple of the Tooth Relic	Nima Sherpa's family follows the Nyingma school of Tibetan Buddhism

The big Buddhist festival in Sri Lanka is Vesak (Sinhala වෙසක්, *VEH-suk*), held on the full moon of the month of Vesak, usually in May. In Theravada tradition it marks the Buddha's birth, enlightenment and passing. Streets and homes glow with lanterns called Vesak kudu, and volunteers set up stalls called dansalas that hand out free food and drinks to passersby. In Bangladesh, Buddhists are a small minority (0.61% in 2022), and most of them live in Chattogram Division, where Zara's parents grew up, especially in the Chittagong Hill Tracts to the east of the city.

5.6 Jainism and Ahimsa

Jainism is a faith from South Asia that teaches that every living being has a soul, and that souls can be freed from the cycle of rebirth through non-violence, self-discipline and right knowledge. Jains believe their path has been taught by 24 *tirthankaras* ("ford-makers," teachers who help people cross the river of rebirth). The 24th, **Mahavira**, lived in what is now Bihar, India, around the 6th or 5th century BCE, close to the time of the Buddha.

Jains belong to two main groups, Digambara and Svetambara, which differ in some practices and in which collections of scripture they accept. In India, Jains live in many states, with especially large communities in Maharashtra and Gujarat. Jain temples, often carved in white marble, are famous for their detail. Jain merchant families have long been prominent in trade, and Jain families have supported temples, libraries and charities for centuries.

Ahimsa

Ahimsa (अहिंसा, *uh-HIM-sah*) means non-violence: not harming any living being, in action, word or thought. Hindus and Buddhists also value ahimsa, but Jains put it at the very center of their life. Many Jains follow a strict vegetarian diet that also leaves out root vegetables such as potatoes, onions and garlic, to avoid destroying the many tiny living things in and around them. In the 20th century, Mohandas K. Gandhi made ahimsa famous worldwide as a method of peaceful protest.

The most important Jain festival is **Paryushan**, a period of fasting, reflection and study, eight days long for Svetambara Jains. It ends with a day of asking forgiveness from everyone you may have hurt in the past year. Jains also celebrate Diwali, which in Jain tradition marks the anniversary of Mahavira's final liberation.

Same word, different weight

I notice that karma, dharma and ahimsa show up in Hindu, Buddhist, Jain and Sikh traditions, but each faith gives them its own meaning and its own weight. When you hear one of these words, try asking, "What does it mean in *your* tradition?"

5.7 Islam in South Asia

Origins and basic practice

Islam began in Arabia in the early 600s CE. Muslims believe that God (Allah, the Arabic word for God) revealed the **Quran** to the Prophet Muhammad, and they also follow the **Hadith**, reports of what the Prophet said and did. Muslims around the world share the **Five Pillars** of practice: declaring faith in

one God and in Muhammad as God's messenger (*shahada*), praying five times a day (*salah*, called *namaz* in South Asia), giving to those in need (*zakat*), fasting from dawn to dusk in the month of Ramadan (*sawm*), and, for those who are able, making the pilgrimage to Mecca (*hajj*).

Islam in South Asia is the faith and culture of the region's Muslims, who today form one of the largest Muslim populations on Earth. As you read in Chapter 3, Islam arrived over many centuries, through Arab traders on the coasts, Sufi teachers and conquest in the northwest. Most South Asian Muslims are descended from people who lived in the region long before. Pakistan, Bangladesh, Afghanistan and the Maldives are Muslim-majority countries. India had about 172 million Muslims in 2011, one of the largest Muslim populations in the world, and Sri Lanka and Nepal have significant Muslim communities too.

A Muslim place of worship is a masjid (Urdu مسجد, *MUS-jid*), or mosque. Many South Asian Muslims also visit Sufi shrines (dargahs), though some Muslims, especially in reformist movements, disapprove of some shrine practices. One of the largest in South Asia is Data Darbar in Lahore, the shrine of the 11th-century saint Ali al-Hujwiri. In the 2021 Pew survey, 37% of Muslims in North India said they identify with Sufism.

Zara's family celebrates two big festivals: **Eid al-Fitr**, which ends the month of Ramadan fasting, and **Eid al-Adha**, which comes at the time of the hajj. On Eid morning her family goes to prayer in new clothes, and her Nanu hands out money to the children.

Sunni and Shia Islam

Sunni and Shia Islam are the two main branches of Islam, which separated over a disagreement about who should lead the Muslim community after the Prophet Muhammad died in 632. Sunni Muslims hold that the community rightly chose the Prophet's companion Abu Bakr as the first leader (caliph).

Shia Muslims hold that the Prophet named his cousin and son-in-law, Ali, as his successor, and they honor a line of leaders called imams descended from Ali.

Both branches share the Quran, the Five Pillars and most beliefs, and in many South Asian towns they have lived side by side for centuries. Most South Asian Muslims are Sunni. Shia Muslims are an important minority: Pew Research Center has estimated them at about 10% to 15% of Muslims in both India and Pakistan (2009 estimate), and some scholars estimate more. During the month of Muharram, many Shia Muslims mourn the death of Imam Husain, the Prophet's grandson, at the Battle of Karbala in 680, with processions, poetry and gatherings.

5.8 Sikhism

Sikhism is a faith founded in Punjab by Guru Nanak (1469 to 1539), which teaches devotion to one God, honest work, sharing with others, and the equality of all people. You met Guru Nanak in Chapter 3. In Sikh tradition, nine more human Gurus followed him. The tenth, **Guru Gobind Singh**, created the **Khalsa**, the community of initiated Sikhs, on Vaisakhi in 1699. Initiated Sikhs keep five articles of faith, including uncut hair (often covered by a turban) and a steel bracelet called a kara.

Sikhs believe in one God, expressed in the phrase **Ik Onkar**, "one creator," the opening words of their scripture. Most Sikhs live in Punjab in India, where they are the majority. Some of Sikhism's holiest places, including Nankana Sahib, Guru Nanak's birthplace, and Kartarpur, where he died, are in Pakistan. In 2019 a visa-free corridor opened so pilgrims from India could cross to the gurdwara at Kartarpur. India suspended it in May 2025 amid tensions between the two countries. It was still closed to Indian pilgrims at its sixth anniversary in November 2025, although Pakistan says its side is open.

The Guru Granth Sahib

The **Guru Granth Sahib** is the Sikh scripture, a collection of hymns that Sikhs honor as their living Guru. The fifth Guru, Guru Arjan, compiled its first version in 1604 and placed it in the Golden Temple at Amritsar. In October 1708, shortly before he died, Guru Gobind Singh declared that after him the scripture itself would be the Guru. It has 1,430 pages, and its hymns are meant to be sung. Most are by the Sikh Gurus, but it also includes hymns by fifteen other saints (bhagats), including bhakti poets such as Kabir and Namdev and the Muslim Sufi saint Sheikh Farid.

In a gurdwara (ਗੁਰਦੁਆਰਾ, *GUR-dwah-rah*, "door to the Guru"), the Guru Granth Sahib sits on a raised platform under a canopy. Visitors remove their shoes and cover their heads, and they usually sit on the floor. The holiest gurdwara is the Golden Temple (Harmandir Sahib) in Amritsar, which receives about 100,000 visitors on a typical day.

Langar

Langar (ਲੰਗਰ, *LUN-gur*) is the free community kitchen of a gurdwara, where volunteers cook and serve a vegetarian meal to anyone who comes, regardless of religion, caste, gender or wealth. Everyone sits together on the floor, in rows, as equals. Sikh tradition traces langar to Guru Nanak, and it shows his teaching that all people are equal. A Sikh tradition even says that the Mughal emperor Akbar sat and ate langar with ordinary people before meeting the third Guru, Guru Amar Das.

The cooking, serving and cleaning are done as *seva* (ਸੇਵਾ, *SAY-vah*), selfless service. Simran has helped make roti for langar since she was eight, and she's the reason Ben now knows how to hold out both hands to receive it.

Visiting a place of worship

Before visiting a mosque, gurdwara, mandir, church or temple, check its website or ask a member what to wear and do. Most welcome respectful visitors, and asking first shows you care.

5.9 Christianity in South Asia

Christianity in South Asia refers to the region's many Christian communities, some among the oldest in the world, others formed later through Portuguese, Dutch, British and other missions. Christians believe that Jesus is the Son of God, and they read the **Bible**. Their place of worship is a church, and their biggest festivals are Christmas and Easter.

- **Kerala's St. Thomas Christians** trace their church to the apostle Thomas, who, according to their tradition, came to the Malabar coast in the 1st century CE. They speak Malayalam and have their own ancient forms of worship.
- **Goa**, ruled by Portugal from 1510 until 1961, has many Catholic churches. Its old churches, including the Basilica of Bom Jesus, which holds the tomb of St. Francis Xavier, are a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
- **Northeast India:** Christians are the majority in the states of Nagaland, Mizoram and Meghalaya.
- **Pakistan:** the 2023 census counted about 3.3 million Christians (1.37%), most of them in Punjab. Some church leaders say the real number is higher.
- **Sri Lanka:** about 6.9% of people were Christian in the 2024 census, most of them Roman Catholic, among Sinhala, Tamil and Burgher communities.

In India as a whole, Christians were 2.3% of the population in 2011, about 28 million people. South Asian churches celebrate Christmas with local touches: star lanterns, carols in regional languages and festive sweets.

5.10 Smaller Communities, Long Histories

Two communities in South Asia are small in number but have long, important histories.

Zoroastrians (Parsis)

Zoroastrians (Parsis) are followers of Zoroastrianism, an ancient faith founded by the prophet Zoroaster (Zarathustra) in Iran. In South Asia, most belong to the Parsi community, whose ancestors came from Iran. *Parsi* means "Persian." According to the community's own story, the *Qissa-i Sanjan*, Zoroastrians left Iran to keep practicing their faith and landed on the coast of Gujarat. Historians place the migration somewhere between the 8th and 10th centuries.

In the story, the local king worried that his kingdom was already full. A Parsi priest answered by stirring sugar into a vessel of milk: like the sugar, the newcomers would blend in and sweeten life without making it overflow. Parsis often tell this story to explain how they settled in.

Zoroastrians teach the ideals of good thoughts, good words and good deeds, and believe each person chooses between good and evil. They pray in fire temples, where a sacred fire is kept burning. The Iranshah fire at Udvada, Gujarat, is the most revered in India, and tradition dates it to the community's earliest years. Parsis celebrate Navroz, the New Year. Most Parsis in South Asia live in Mumbai (formerly Bombay), and there are smaller communities in Karachi and other cities.

Jewish Communities

Jewish Communities in South Asia are the old Jewish groups that settled in India, especially on the west coast, long before modern times. Jews believe in one God and a covenant (a sacred agreement) between God and the Jewish people, and they study the Torah. Their place of worship is a synagogue.

There were three main communities:

- **Cochin Jews** in Kerala. The Paradesi Synagogue in Kochi, built in 1568, is the oldest active synagogue in the Commonwealth.
- **Bene Israel**, who lived for centuries in villages of the Konkan coast and later moved to Mumbai, where they opened their first synagogue in 1796.
- **Baghdadi Jews**, traders from the Middle East who settled first in Surat (from 1730) and later in Mumbai and Kolkata.

India's Jewish population peaked in the 1940s and declined quickly after 1948, as most moved to the new state of Israel. Most Cochin Jews left in the mid-1950s. Small communities remain, and their synagogues are still cared for.

5.11 Pilgrimage: Journeys of Faith

Pilgrimage is a journey to a sacred place for prayer, blessing, remembrance or renewal. Every faith in this chapter has pilgrimage places, and South Asia is full of them.

Faith	Pilgrimage example	Where
Hinduism	The Kumbh Mela, where millions bathe in a sacred	Prayagraj (Allahabad),

Faith	Pilgrimage example	Where
	river. It rotates among four cities	Haridwar, Ujjain and Nashik, India
Hinduism	Hinglaj Yatra	Balochistan, Pakistan
Buddhism	The Buddha's birthplace and place of enlightenment	Lumbini, Nepal; Bodh Gaya, India
Buddhism	The Temple of the Tooth Relic	Kandy, Sri Lanka
Islam	The hajj to Mecca, plus visits to Sufi shrines such as Ajmer and Data Darbar	Saudi Arabia; Rajasthan, India; Lahore, Pakistan
Sikhism	The Golden Temple; Nankana Sahib and Kartarpur	Amritsar, India; Punjab, Pakistan
Christianity	The Basilica of Bom Jesus	Old Goa, India
Zoroastrianism	The Iranshah fire temple	Udvada, Gujarat, India

UNESCO lists the Kumbh Mela as part of humanity's Intangible Cultural Heritage (2017) and calls it the largest peaceful gathering of pilgrims on Earth.

Some pilgrimage places are shared. Adam's Peak (Sri Pada) in Sri Lanka is a 2,243 m mountain with a footprint-shaped rock at the top. In Buddhist tradition it is the Buddha's footprint; many Hindus see it as Shiva's; and in some Muslim and Christian traditions it is the footprint of Adam or of St. Thomas. Pilgrims of all four faiths climb it, often through the night to watch

the sunrise. The Ajmer dargah of Moinuddin Chishti, too, draws many Hindus as well as Muslims.

5.12 Religious Pluralism

Religious Pluralism means many faiths living side by side in the same society, and, as an ideal, people of different faiths respecting each other's right to believe and practice. South Asia has lived with pluralism for thousands of years. That history includes deep friendships and shared traditions, and also real conflict and discrimination.

Some signs of shared life:

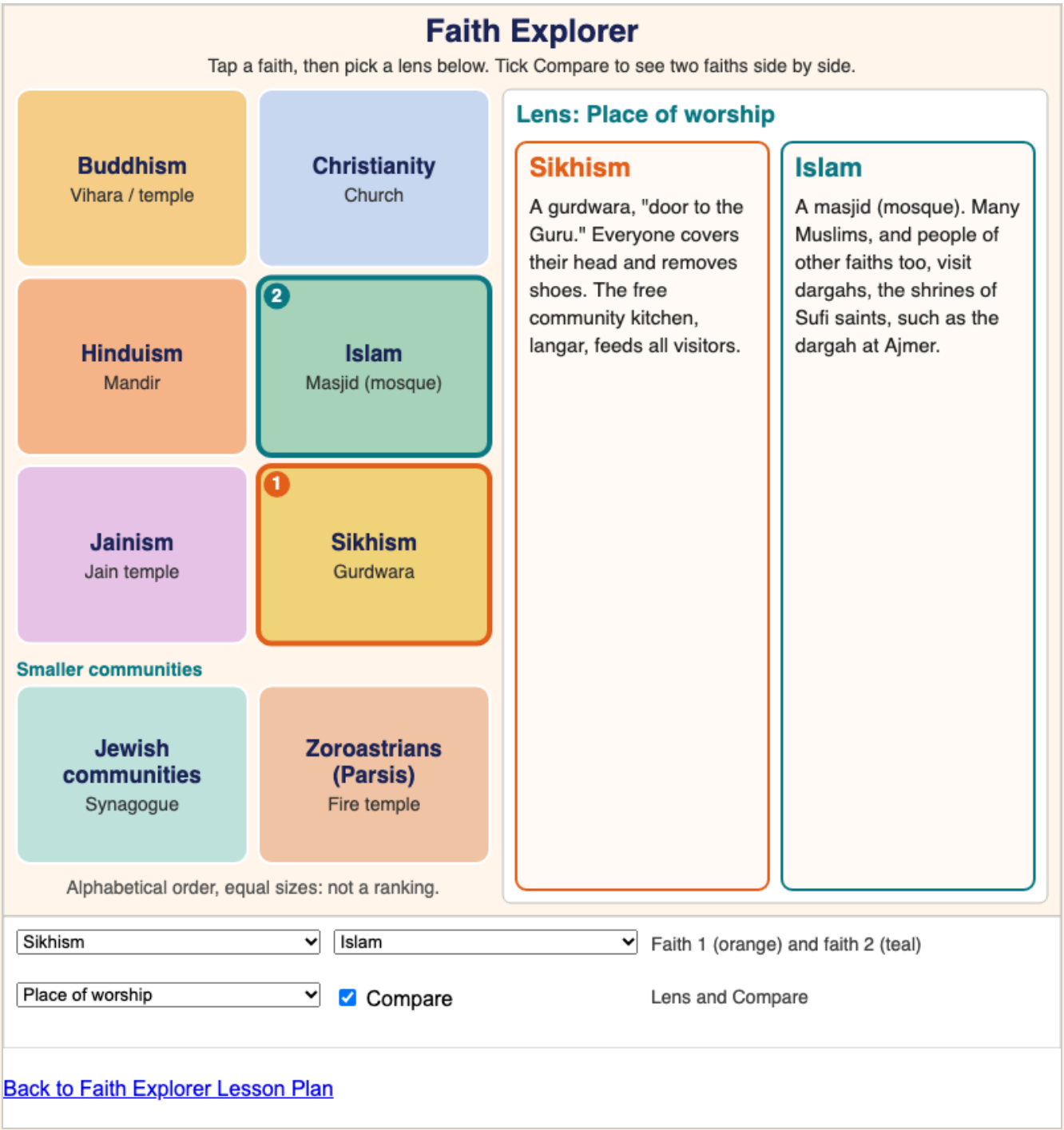
- **Shared ideas.** In Pew's 2021 survey of India, the same share of Hindus and Muslims (77%) said they believe in karma.
- **Shared places.** Hindus visit Sufi dargahs; Buddhists, Hindus, Muslims and Christians climb Adam's Peak; anyone may eat at a gurdwara's langar.
- **Shared scripture.** The Guru Granth Sahib includes hymns by Hindu and Muslim saints.
- **Shared values.** In the same survey, most Indians of every major faith said respecting all religions is very important to being truly Indian.

But the same Pew report was titled "Tolerance and Segregation." It found that many people in India, while valuing respect for other faiths, said their close friends came mostly from their own group, and large majorities of both Hindus and Muslims said it was very important to stop members of their community from marrying outside the faith. Across the region, religious minorities have at times faced discrimination and violence, and communal violence has caused terrible suffering on all sides, as Chapter 4 shows for Partition.

Whose Story?

Who gets to define a faith? Many Hindus prefer the name Sanatana Dharma to "Hinduism," a label that grew from an outsider's word. Many Sikhs object when textbooks call Sikhism a "mix" of Hinduism and Islam, because in Sikh understanding it is a distinct revelation through Guru Nanak. In Pakistan, some church leaders say the 2023 census undercounted Christians, whom it counted at 1.37% of the population. Ahmadis describe themselves as Muslims, but most other Muslims reject their belief that their founder, Mirza Ghulam Ahmad, was a prophet. Since 1974, Pakistan's constitution has classified them as non-Muslims, so the same people are counted differently depending on who is counting. That's why this book describes each faith the way its own followers usually describe it, and notes where counts are disputed.

Diagram: Faith Explorer



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch05-faith-explorer/main.html

Open the Faith Explorer fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Faith Explorer

sim-id: ch05-faith-explorer
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Analyze
Bloom Verb: compare
Learning Objective: The learner will compare South Asian faiths on the same five dimensions (origins, sacred texts, place of worship, a major festival, a core idea) without ranking them.

Canvas: responsive width; 690 px drawing area plus 100 px control area.

Controls: first-faith menu, second-faith menu, lens menu, Compare checkbox; click or tap any faith tile.

Behavior: Eight equal-sized tiles in alphabetical order (Buddhism, Christianity, Hinduism, Islam, Jainism, Sikhism, then a "Smaller communities" row with Jewish communities and Zoroastrians (Parsis)) with a note that the order is not a ranking. Choosing a faith and a lens shows a short card written in followers' terms. Compare mode (on at start) shows two faiths side by side through the same lens; the sim opens on Sikhism and Islam through the "Place of worship" lens.

The sim opens in Compare mode with Sikhism and Islam side by side through the Place of worship lens. Start there, then switch the lens to Sacred texts, A major festival and A core idea, and read both cards each time. Then tap different tiles to compare other pairs: Hinduism and Jainism on "A core idea," or Buddhism and Christianity on "Origins."

As you compare, notice what is similar and what is different, and notice the note under the tiles: the order is alphabetical and every tile is the same size. Try writing one sentence for each pair that compares them without saying either is better. That's harder than it sounds.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about what faith practice meant in their childhood home, and how they practice now. If your family is not religious, ask about the values they grew up with and how those values were passed down. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Faith can be personal. Ask if they're comfortable talking about it, let them skip any question, and ask permission before taking notes.

Questions to ask

1. When you were a child, what did a normal day or week of faith (or family values) look like in your home?
2. Is there a prayer, song, story or ritual you remember from childhood? What did it mean to you then?
3. Where did your family go to worship or celebrate, and what was it like inside?
4. Did you have friends or neighbors of other faiths? What did you learn from them, or share with them?
5. How has your practice changed over your life, or since moving to a new country?
6. What do you most want younger people in our family to understand or keep?

Listen for: practices such as Puja, Langar or the Five Pillars of Islam in South Asia; moments of Pilgrimage; and stories of Religious Pluralism, such as neighbors of different faiths sharing festivals or food.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's description of their faith (or values) with how this chapter describes it. What did the chapter get right, and what did your elder add that a short summary can't capture? If a friend interviewed someone of a different faith, list one practice that is similar and one that is different, without ranking them.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Hinduism has one holy book, like a Hindu Bible.
Reality: Hinduism has many sacred texts, including the Vedas, the Upanishads, the Ramayana, the Mahabharata (with the Bhagavad Gita) and the Puranas, and different communities value different ones most.

Myth: Sikhism is a mix of Hinduism and Islam.
Reality: Sikhs understand their faith as a distinct revelation through Guru Nanak and the Gurus who followed him, with its own scripture, the Guru Granth Sahib, and its own practices such as langar. The scripture includes some hymns by Hindu and Muslim saints, but that doesn't make Sikhism a blend.

Myth: All Buddhists are the same.
Reality: Buddhism has several schools. Sri Lanka follows Theravada, with the Pali Canon, while Bhutan and Himalayan Nepal follow Vajrayana, with Tibetan teachings and rituals. Their temples, festivals and practices differ.

Myth: South Asian Muslims are recent converts or outsiders.
Reality: Muslims have lived in South Asia for well over a thousand years, starting with traders on the coasts in the 600s and 700s. Most South Asian Muslims descend from families who have lived in the region for many centuries.

Myth: Religion and country map one-to-one: India is Hindu, Pakistan is Muslim, Sri Lanka is Buddhist.
Reality: Every South Asian country is home to several faiths. India had about 172 million Muslims in 2011, Bangladesh has millions of Hindus, Sri Lanka has large Hindu, Muslim and Christian communities, and Sikhism's holiest sites include places in Pakistan.

Check Yourself

1. Name the four faiths in this chapter that began in South Asia.

Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism.

2. What is the difference between Theravada and Vajrayana Buddhism, and where is each found in South Asia?

Theravada uses the Pali Canon and is the Buddhism of Sri Lanka. Vajrayana developed later, uses Mahayana and Tibetan teachings and rituals, and is the Buddhism of Bhutan and Himalayan Nepal.

3. What is langar, and what idea does it express?

Langar is the free community kitchen of a gurdwara, where everyone sits together and eats the same meal regardless of religion, caste, gender or wealth. It expresses the Sikh teaching that all people are equal.

4. Why did Sunni and Shia Islam separate?

They disagreed about who should lead the Muslim community after the Prophet Muhammad died in 632: Sunnis accept the choice of Abu Bakr, while Shias believe the Prophet named Ali.

5. What does ahimsa mean, and which faith puts it at the very center of life?

Ahimsa means non-violence toward all living beings. Jainism puts it at the center, which is why many Jains are strict vegetarians.

Exercises

Remember

1. Match each faith to its place of worship: Hinduism, Islam, Sikhism, Zoroastrianism, Judaism.

Answer

Hinduism: mandir (temple). Islam: masjid (mosque). Sikhism: gurdwara. Zoroastrianism: fire temple. Judaism: synagogue.

2. Who compiled the first version of the Guru Granth Sahib, and in what year?

Answer

Guru Arjan, the fifth Sikh Guru, in 1604.

Understand

1. Explain the idea of karma and rebirth in your own words, and name two faiths besides Hinduism that use the idea.

Answer

Karma is the belief that a person's actions and intentions have effects, in this life and in future lives, as the soul is reborn in a cycle. Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism also speak of karma and rebirth, each in its own way.

2. Explain why India's 14.2% Muslim share in 2011 still meant one of the largest Muslim populations in the world.

Answer

India's total population is so large that 14.2% was about 172 million people, more than the total population of most countries.

Apply

1. Use the Faith Explorer in Compare mode. Pick two faiths and one lens, and write three sentences comparing them without using the words "better," "worse," "real" or "true." *Hint: start with "Both…" and "In contrast…"*
2. Your school is planning a multi-faith calendar for the club. Choose four faiths from this chapter and list one major festival for each, with one sentence explaining what it marks. *Hint: the "A major festival" lens in the sim will help.*

Analyze

1. Look at the faith map table in 5.3. Identify two countries where a minority faith includes millions of people, and explain why "minority" doesn't mean "small" in South Asia. *Hint: compare percentages with each country's total population from Chapter 1.*
2. Analyze Adam's Peak as an example of religious pluralism. What does it show, and what are the limits of using one shared site to describe relations between faiths? *Hint: the Pew report title "Tolerance and Segregation" is a useful clue.*

Evaluate

1. A classmate's slide says "Sikhism = Hinduism + Islam." Evaluate the slide and suggest a fairer one-sentence description. *Hint: think about how Sikhs describe their own faith.*
2. Some people say it's impossible to compare faiths fairly. Using the five lenses and the ground rules in 5.2, evaluate whether this chapter's approach works, and suggest one improvement. *Hint: what might the five lenses leave out?*

Create

1. Design a respectful "visitor's guide" card for one place of worship in your area (or one from the chapter): what to wear, what to do with shoes, how to behave, and one question to ask a member. *Hint: check the place's own website or ask a member before finishing.*
2. Write a short scene (150 to 200 words) in which two friends of different faiths explain one festival to each other. Show curiosity and respect. *Hint: use at least three concept labels from this chapter.*

Key Takeaways

- South Asia is home to Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism and Sikhism, which began there, and to Islam, Christianity, Zoroastrianism and Judaism, which arrived long ago and took deep root.
- Comparing faiths fairly means using the same lenses for each, describing beliefs as their followers do, and never ranking them.
- Hinduism has no single founder or book. Its key ideas include dharma, karma and rebirth, and puja, the offering of worship.
- Buddhism in South Asia includes Theravada (Sri Lanka) and Vajrayana (Bhutan, Himalayan Nepal). Jainism puts ahimsa, non-violence, at its center.
- Most South Asian Muslims are Sunni, with an important Shia minority. Muslims are the majority in Pakistan, Bangladesh, Afghanistan and the Maldives, and number about 172 million in India (2011).
- Sikhs honor the Guru Granth Sahib as their living Guru, and the langar feeds everyone as equals.

- Pilgrimage and shared sites show religious pluralism in action, but pluralism also involves real tensions that communities must work to overcome.

Shoes back on!

You can now explain eight faith traditions through the same five lenses, without ranking any of them. Next, in Chapter 6, we follow the languages and scripts in which so many of these prayers, songs and stories are written.

Quiz: Faiths of South Asia

Test your understanding of Chapter 5. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

Which school of Buddhism is followed by most Buddhists in Sri Lanka?

A. Vajrayana

B. Zen

C. Theravada

D. Pure Land

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Sri Lanka follows Theravada Buddhism, whose scriptures are the Pali Canon. Vajrayana is the main distractor: it is the Buddhism of Bhutan and Himalayan Nepal, not Sri Lanka.

Concept Tested: Theravada and Vajrayana **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 2

What is the Guru Granth Sahib?

A. The Sikh scripture, which Sikhs honor as their living Guru

B. The founder of Sikhism

C. The holiest gurdwara in Amritsar

D. A collection of Hindu epics translated into Punjabi

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The Guru Granth Sahib is the Sikh scripture, first compiled by Guru Arjan in 1604. Guru Nanak founded Sikhism, and the Golden Temple is the holiest gurdwara, which is why B and C can sound plausible.

Concept Tested: Guru Granth Sahib **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 3

What does ahimsa mean?

A. Devotional singing in a temple

B. Non-violence toward all living beings

C. A pilgrimage to a sacred river

D. Fasting during a holy month

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Ahimsa means non-violence in action, word and thought. Jains put it at the center of their lives, and Hindus and Buddhists also value it. Fasting (D) is part of some Jain festivals, but it is not what the word means.

Concept Tested: Ahimsa **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Which statement best describes Hinduism?

A. A religion founded by one teacher, with one holy book

B. A branch of Buddhism that began in Nepal

C. A religion that began in Arabia and spread to India

D. A family of related traditions with no single founder and many sacred texts

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Hinduism grew over thousands of years from many traditions and has many sacred texts, including the Vedas, Upanishads, epics and Puranas. Option A describes the common misconception that Hinduism has "one holy book."

Concept Tested: Hinduism **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

Why did Sunni and Shia Islam become separate branches?

A. They disagreed about who should lead the Muslim community after the Prophet Muhammad died.

B. They use different holy books.

C. Shia Muslims do not follow the Five Pillars.

D. Sunni Islam began in South Asia, while Shia Islam began in Arabia.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Sunnis accept the community's choice of Abu Bakr as the first leader, while Shias believe the Prophet named Ali. Both branches share the Quran and the Five Pillars, so B and C are wrong.

Concept Tested: Sunni and Shia Islam **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 6

What idea does langar, the free community kitchen of a gurdwara, express?

A. That only Sikhs may eat food blessed in a gurdwara

B. That fasting is the most important form of worship

C. That all people are equal, so everyone eats together regardless of religion, caste, gender or wealth

D. That food should be offered to the scripture before anyone eats

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Langar is served free to anyone who comes, and everyone sits together as equals, reflecting Guru Nanak's teaching of equality. Option A is the opposite of the truth: visitors of every faith are welcome.

Concept Tested: Langar **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

Ben visits a gurdwara for the first time with Simran. Based on the chapter, what should he expect to do?

A. Keep his shoes on and stand during the service

B. Remove his shoes, cover his head, and sit on the floor, possibly eating langar afterward

C. Bring an offering of meat for the community meal

D. Show proof that he is a Sikh before entering

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Visitors to a gurdwara remove their shoes and cover their heads, sit on the floor, and are welcome at langar. Option C is wrong because langar is vegetarian, and D is wrong because gurdwaras welcome respectful visitors of every faith.

Concept Tested: Sikhism **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

A classmate writes, "Pakistan is Muslim, India is Hindu, and Sri Lanka is Buddhist, so each faith has its own country." Which fact from the chapter best shows the problem with this claim?

A. SAARC was founded in 1985.

B. Bhutan follows Vajrayana Buddhism.

C. The Kumbh Mela rotates among four cities.

D. India had about 172 million Muslims in 2011, and Sri Lanka's 2024 census found large Hindu, Muslim and Christian communities.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Every South Asian country is home to several faiths, and even minority shares can mean millions of people. Option B is true but doesn't address the claim that religion and country line up one-to-one.

Concept Tested: Religious Pluralism **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Adam's Peak in Sri Lanka is visited by Buddhists, Hindus, Muslims and Christians, who each explain its footprint differently. What does this example best show?

A. That the four faiths have merged into one religion in Sri Lanka

B. That one faith's explanation of the footprint is the correct one

C. That a single sacred place can hold different meanings for different faiths, an example of religious pluralism

D. That pilgrimage is only important in Buddhism

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Shared sites like Adam's Peak show people of different faiths valuing the same place in their own ways. The faiths remain distinct (so A is wrong), and the book does not rank one explanation above another (so B is wrong).

Concept Tested: Pilgrimage **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

Pew Research Center's 2021 report on religion in India was titled "Tolerance and Segregation." Which conclusion does the evidence in the chapter best support?

A. Most Indians value respect for all religions, yet many keep their friendships and marriages within their own faith.

B. Indians of different faiths share no beliefs at all.

C. Religious tension in India has completely disappeared.

D. Only Hindus in India believe in karma.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The survey found that respect for all religions is widely valued, but many people's friends come mostly from their own group, and many oppose interfaith marriage. Option D is contradicted by the finding that 77% of both Hindus and Muslims said they believe in karma.

Concept Tested: Religious Pluralism **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts

Summary

South Asia is one of the most multilingual places on Earth. India's 2011 census counted 121 languages with at least 10,000 speakers each, and Pakistan, Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Afghanistan, Bhutan and the Maldives add many more. This chapter sorts those languages into five big families, explains the difference between a language and a script, and shows how most of the region's scripts grew from one ancestor, Brahmi. You'll learn how an abugida writes vowels, why Hindi and Urdu are so close in speech yet so different on paper, and what it means to grow up with a heritage language that you understand but don't always speak.

Concepts Covered

1. Language Family
2. Indo-Aryan Languages
3. Dravidian Languages
4. Tibeto-Burman Languages
5. Austroasiatic Languages
6. Iranian Languages
7. Eighth Schedule
8. Hindi-Urdu (Hindustani)
9. Bengali Language

10. Tamil Language
11. Brahmi Script
12. Abugida
13. Devanagari
14. Gurmukhi
15. Perso-Arabic Script
16. Code-Switching
17. Heritage Language

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia? for the eight countries and the map.
- Chapter 2: Ancient Roots helps with Ashoka and the Indus cities, but it isn't required.
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia helps with the Sikh Gurus and with the languages of scripture.

So many ways to say hello

Hi, I'm Mora! Maybe you understand your grandparents perfectly but answer them in English, or maybe you can speak your family's language but can't read a single letter of it. You're not alone, and this chapter is for you. By the end, you'll be able to look at a page of Bangla, Hindi or Tamil and see the family resemblance, even if you can't read it yet.

6.1 Three Names, Three Alphabets

It's the third meeting of the South Asian Student Association at Prairie Ridge High School, and the club is making name tags. Zara Hossain grabs a marker and writes her name in English, then adds the name of her family's language underneath in Bangla letters: বাংলা. Her friend Arjun Reddy, whose family speaks Telugu, writes తెలుగు on his. Simran Kaur Gill, the club treasurer, writes ਪੰਜਾਬੀ, the word for Punjabi, in the script her grandparents taught her.

Ben Lindqvist leans over the table and stares at the three name tags. Zara's letters hang from a straight line along the top. Arjun's look round, like little loops and curls. Simran's have a line on top too, but the shapes are different from Zara's. "Okay," Ben says. "Are these even related? They look like three totally different alphabets from three different planets."

Arjun laughs. "My grandpa says they're all cousins." Simran isn't so sure. Zara realizes she has never asked. She can read Bangla slowly, but she has no idea where its letters came from, or why Simran's look a little like hers but Arjun's don't. Are these scripts related, and if they are, why do they look so different?

6.2 A Language Is Not a Script

Start with something you already know. English, Spanish, French and Swedish are four different languages, but they are all written with the same 26-ish Latin letters (Swedish adds å, ä and ö). Ben's grandparents in Sweden could read the letters on a Spanish menu even if they couldn't understand the words. Now flip it around: Serbian is one language that is regularly written in two scripts, Cyrillic and Latin.

So there are two separate questions you can ask about any piece of writing:

- **What language is it?** A **language** is a system of words and grammar that people speak (or sign) to communicate.
- **What script is it written in?** A **script** is a set of written symbols used to write one or more languages.

South Asia is full of examples where the two don't line up neatly. Punjabi is usually written in the Gurmukhi script in India and in a Perso-Arabic script called Shahmukhi in Pakistan. Tamil and Telugu are completely different languages from Hindi, yet their scripts are distant cousins of the one used for Hindi. Keep the two questions apart, and much of this chapter becomes easy.

	Same language?	Same script?
English and Spanish	No	Yes (Latin)
Punjabi in India and Punjabi in Pakistan	Yes	No (Gurmukhi and Shahmukhi)
Hindi and Marathi	No	Yes (Devanagari)
Hindi and Urdu	Very close in everyday speech	No (Devanagari and Perso-Arabic)

Try this

Next time you see South Asian writing on a grocery bag, a temple or mosque sign, or a phone screen, ask yourself two questions: which script is this, and which language? I promise they aren't always the answer you'd guess.

6.3 The Five Big Language Families

Languages have family trees too. A **language family** is a group of languages that all descend from one older ancestor language. Linguists spot family members by comparing basic words (like numbers, body parts and "mother") and grammar. English and Swedish, for example, are both in the Germanic branch of the large Indo-European family, which is why Swedish *tre* and English *three* sound alike.

Five language families matter most in South Asia. India's 2011 census (the latest with language results as of 2026, since the next census counts people in early 2027) grouped its 121 counted languages by family, and the shares of people who speak each family as a mother tongue show how unevenly they're spread.

Family	Share of India's people, by mother tongue (2011 census)	Some languages in this family	Where in South Asia
Indo-Aryan (part of Indo-European)	78.05%	Hindi, Urdu, Bangla, Punjabi, Marathi, Gujarati, Odia, Nepali, Sindhi, Sinhala, Dhivehi	Across northern, central and western India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka, the Maldives
Dravidian	19.64%	Tamil, Telugu, Kannada,	Mostly southern India; also

Family	Share of India's people, by mother tongue (2011 census)	Some languages in this family	Where in South Asia
		Malayalam, Tulu, Gondi, Brahui	northern Sri Lanka; Brahui in Pakistan
Austroasiatic (Census: "Austro-Asiatic")	1.11%	Santali, Mundari, Ho, Khasi	Parts of eastern and northeastern India; also Bangladesh and Nepal
Tibeto-Burman (part of Sino-Tibetan)	1.01%	Manipuri (Meitei), Bodo, Mizo, Dzongkha, Newar, Sherpa, Tamang	The Himalaya and India's northeast; Bhutan, Nepal
Iranian (part of Indo-European)	tiny in India	Pashto, Dari (a form of Persian), Balochi	Afghanistan and western Pakistan

The census numbers above are for India only. In Afghanistan and Pakistan, Iranian languages are very large, and in Bhutan, Tibeto-Burman languages are the majority.

Indo-Aryan languages

Indo-Aryan Languages are the South Asian branch of the Indo-European family, the same giant family that includes English, Persian, Russian and Greek. They descend from Old Indo-Aryan, the language of the Vedas (an early form of Sanskrit), through everyday languages called Prakrits. Hindi, Urdu, Bangla, Punjabi, Marathi, Gujarati, Odia, Assamese, Nepali and Sindhi are all Indo-Aryan. So are two island languages you might not expect: Sinhala in Sri Lanka and Dhivehi in the Maldives, which are each other's closest relatives.

Indo-Aryan languages are spoken by the largest number of people in the region. In India's 2011 census, the biggest single mother tongue was Hindi, with 528 million speakers (43.63% of India's people), followed by Bangla (8.03%) and Marathi (6.86%). In Pakistan's 2023 census, the largest mother tongue was Punjabi, at about 37% of the population, while Urdu, the national language, was the mother tongue of 9.25%. In Nepal's 2021 census, Nepali was the mother tongue of 44.86% of people, among 124 mother tongues recorded.

Iranian languages

Iranian Languages are another branch of Indo-European, closely related to Indo-Aryan but separate from it. Persian (Farsi in Iran, Dari in Afghanistan) is the best-known one. In South Asia the big Iranian languages are Pashto and Dari, the two most widely used languages of Afghanistan, plus Pashto and Balochi in Pakistan. Pashto is the second-largest mother tongue in Pakistan, after Punjabi.

Dravidian languages

Dravidian Languages form a completely separate family, not related to Indo-European at all. The four big ones are Tamil, Telugu, Kannada and Malayalam, spoken mostly in the south, and in 2011 the Dravidian family as a

whole was the mother tongue of about 20% of India's people. Tamil is also an official language of Sri Lanka, and Tamil-speaking communities live in Singapore, Malaysia and around the world. A Dravidian language even survives far to the northwest: **Brahui** is spoken mainly in Balochistan, Pakistan, and is usually written in Arabic script.

Dravidian languages have borrowed many words from Sanskrit over the centuries, especially for religion and learning, and Indo-Aryan languages have borrowed from Dravidian ones too. But their grammar and core vocabulary come from a different ancestor. That matters for one of the most common myths about South Asia, which we'll get to in Common Misconceptions.

Tibeto-Burman languages

Tibeto-Burman Languages are the South Asian members of the huge Sino-Tibetan family, which also includes Chinese and Burmese. They're spoken mostly in the Himalaya and in India's northeast. India's 2011 census counted 66 different Tibeto-Burman languages, more than any other family, even though together they have only about 1% of India's speakers. Dzongkha, the national language of Bhutan, belongs here, as do Sherpa and Tamang in Nepal, Newar (spoken in the Kathmandu Valley), and Manipuri (Meitei) and Bodo in India. Nima Sherpa, whose family comes from Solukhumbu in Nepal, speaks Nepali with friends from Nepal, but his grandparents speak Sherpa at home.

Austroasiatic languages

Austroasiatic Languages are a family spread from eastern India to Vietnam and Cambodia (Vietnamese and Khmer belong to it). In South Asia the best known are the Munda languages, such as Santali, Mundari and Ho, spoken mainly by Adivasi (Indigenous) communities in Jharkhand, Odisha, West

Bengal and nearby states, plus Khasi in Meghalaya. Santali also has speakers in northern Bangladesh and eastern Nepal, and in 2003 it was added to India's Eighth Schedule. Santali has its own script, Ol Chiki, created in 1925 by Raghunath Murmu. Unlike most Indian scripts, Ol Chiki is a true alphabet, with full letters for vowels.

6.4 One Language or Two? Hindi-Urdu

Ayesha Qureshi's family is from Lahore, Pakistan, and speaks Urdu at home. Arjun's mom grew up in Hyderabad, where she learned Hindi in school. When Ayesha and Arjun's mom chat at a club potluck, they understand each other almost perfectly. Ask for water and both will say *pani*. But when they write the word down, it looks completely different:

	Hindi	Urdu
"water"	पानी	پانی
Name of the language	हिन्दी	اردو
Script	Devanagari, left to right	Perso-Arabic (Nastaliq style), right to left

Hindi-Urdu (Hindustani) is the name linguists use for the shared spoken language underneath both. Hindi (हिन्दी, *HIN-dee*) and Urdu (اردو, *OOR-doo*) are two standard forms of it. Their everyday grammar and most common words are the same, which is why speakers understand each other in casual conversation, and why one Bollywood song can be enjoyed in both Lahore

and Lucknow. The base of both comes from Khariboli, the speech of the region around Delhi.

The differences show up in three places:

1. **Script.** Hindi is written in Devanagari, Urdu in a Perso-Arabic script, usually in the flowing, slanted style called Nastaliq.
2. **Formal vocabulary.** For formal, literary or technical words, standard Hindi tends to draw on Sanskrit, and standard Urdu on Persian and Arabic. "Book" is usually *kitab* in both, but the formal word for "knowledge" might be *gyan* in Hindi and *ilm* in Urdu.
3. **Identity and history.** Urdu is Pakistan's national language and is also an official language in several Indian states, including Telangana, Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. Hindi is an official language of India's central government. For many families, which name they use is tied to religion, region and history, especially since Partition (see Chapter 4).

Whose Story?

Is Hindi-Urdu one language or two? Many linguists answer "one language with two standard forms," because ordinary speakers understand each other so easily. Many people in India describe Hindi as its own language rooted in Sanskrit, and many people in Pakistan describe Urdu as its own language shaped by Persian, Arabic and Muslim literary culture. From the 1860s on, arguments over whether courts and schools in British India should use Hindi in Devanagari or Urdu in Perso-Arabic script became one of the issues dividing Hindus and Muslims. After 1947, Pakistan chose Urdu as its national language and India gave Hindi official status. Poets, film songwriters and ordinary families often ignore the line completely and mix both vocabularies. All of these answers describe something real, which is why the question still sparks debate.

6.5 Two Languages Up Close: Bangla and Tamil

The Bengali language

The **Bengali Language**, which its speakers call Bangla (বাংলা, *BAANG-laa*), is an Indo-Aryan language. It's the official and national language of Bangladesh and an official language of the Indian states of West Bengal and Tripura and of Assam's Barak Valley. In India's 2011 census, about 97 million people spoke it as their mother tongue, second only to Hindi, and Bangladesh has about 176 million people (2025, World Bank). In October 2024, India's government declared Bangla one of its "classical languages," a title for languages with very old, original literary traditions.

Bangla has a special place in the story of language rights. After 1947, Bangladesh was East Pakistan. In 1948 Pakistan's leader, Muhammad Ali Jinnah, declared in Dhaka that Urdu alone would be the state language, even though most people in East Pakistan spoke Bangla. Students in Dhaka protested. On **21 February 1952**, police opened fire on student protesters in Dhaka, and several were killed. That day is remembered in Bangladesh as Language Martyrs' Day. In 1956 Bangla became an official language of Pakistan alongside Urdu, and in 1999, after a proposal from Bangladesh, UNESCO declared 21 February **International Mother Language Day**, and it has been observed around the world since 2000. Zara's Nanu remembers walking barefoot to the Shaheed Minar, the martyrs' monument, on that day as a girl.

The Tamil language

The **Tamil Language** (தமிழ், *THUH-mizh*) is a Dravidian language spoken by about 69 million people in India in 2011 (5.70% of the population), mostly in Tamil Nadu. It is also one of the two official and national languages of Sri Lanka, alongside Sinhala, and one of the official languages of Singapore.

Tamil literature goes back roughly two thousand years, to a collection of poetry known as the Sangam literature.

In 2004 India's government created a new category of "classical languages," and on 12 October 2004 Tamil became the first language to receive the title. By October 2024 there were 11 classical languages: Tamil, Sanskrit, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Odia, Marathi, Pali, Prakrit, Assamese and Bangla.

Tamil is a good reminder that "South Asian languages" don't all come from Sanskrit. Tamil has its own grammar, its own ancient vocabulary and its own literary tradition, even though it has also exchanged words with Sanskrit for centuries.

6.6 Official Languages and the Eighth Schedule

Every country in South Asia has to decide which languages its government, schools and courts will use. The eight countries handle it like this:

Country	Official or national language(s)	Script(s)
Afghanistan	Pashto and Dari (the main official languages)	Perso-Arabic
Bangladesh	Bangla	Bengali-Assamese
Bhutan	Dzongkha (རྫོང་ཁ, *DZONG-kha*, "language of the fortress")	Tibetan

Country	Official or national language(s)	Script(s)
India	Hindi and English for the central government; 22 languages in the Eighth Schedule	Many, including Devanagari
Maldives	Dhivehi (ދިވެހި, *DHI-veh-hi*, "of the islanders")	Thaana
Nepal	Nepali	Devanagari
Pakistan	Urdu (national) and English (official)	Perso-Arabic; Latin for English
Sri Lanka	Sinhala (සිංහල, *SING-huh-luh*) and Tamil, with English as a "link language"	Sinhala and Tamil scripts

India's system needs a closer look. Article 343 of the Constitution of India says that the official language of the Union (the central government) shall be Hindi in the Devanagari script. A 1963 law, the Official Languages Act, lets English keep being used alongside Hindi for official work. Each state also chooses its own official language or languages, so Tamil Nadu works in Tamil, West Bengal in Bangla, and so on.

The **Eighth Schedule** is a list attached to the Constitution of India that names the languages the government officially recognizes and promises to develop. When the Constitution was adopted it listed 14 languages. Amendments have added more, and today there are **22**: Assamese, Bangla (Bengali), Bodo, Dogri, Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Kashmiri, Konkani, Maithili, Malayalam, Manipuri, Marathi, Nepali, Odia, Punjabi, Sanskrit, Santali, Sindhi, Tamil, Telugu and Urdu. Being on the list matters, because these languages get official

support for their development, teaching and literature. In 2011, 96.71% of India's people had one of these 22 as their mother tongue.

Many communities want their languages added. India's Ministry of Home Affairs has for years listed demands to include 38 more languages, among them Bhojpuri, and no new language has been added since 2003.

Notice that English is not in the Eighth Schedule, even though it is used for official purposes. And notice what's missing from the Constitution entirely: the phrase "national language."

The national language trap

You'll hear people say "Hindi is India's national language." India's Constitution doesn't name any national language. Hindi and English are the official languages of the central government, and 22 languages are recognized in the Eighth Schedule. Pakistan is different: its constitution does name Urdu as the national language.

6.7 One Ancestor for Many Scripts: Brahmi

Now back to Ben's question at the name-tag table. Bangla, Telugu and Gurmukhi letters look like they come from three planets. In fact, all three descend from one ancient script.

The **Brahmi Script** is the ancestor of most scripts used in South Asia today, and of many in Southeast Asia and Tibet. It was in use by the 3rd century BCE. Its best-known early examples are the edicts of the emperor Ashoka, messages about ethics and good government carved on rocks and pillars across his empire in the mid-3rd century BCE. Over the centuries, people

forgot how to read Brahmi. In the 1830s, James Prinsep, secretary of the Asiatic Society of Bengal in Kolkata (then Calcutta), deciphered it, which let historians read Ashoka's words again. (The Indus Valley cities in Chapter 2 had their own signs much earlier, but that Indus script still hasn't been deciphered.)

Brahmi changed slowly as scribes in different regions wrote it with different tools, on stone, palm leaves, birch bark and paper. One common explanation for why many southern scripts look rounder is that scribes there wrote on palm leaves, where long straight lines could split the leaf. Over about two thousand years, regional styles drifted so far apart that today they look unrelated. A simplified version of the family looks like this:

- **Northern branch** (through the Gupta script): Devanagari and its close cousin Gujarati; Gurmukhi (through the Sharada script of Kashmir); Bengali-Assamese and Odia (through an eastern script called Gaudi); and Tibetan, which Bhutan uses for Dzongkha.
- **Southern branches**: Kannada and Telugu (through the Kadamba script), and Tamil, Malayalam and Sinhala (through the Pallava and Grantha scripts).

Script families and language families are different trees. Telugu and Tamil are Dravidian languages, but their scripts are Brahmi's descendants, just like Hindi's. Sinhala is an Indo-Aryan language, but its rounded script grew up under strong influence from south Indian scripts. That's exactly the language-versus-script difference from Section 6.2.

6.8 How an Abugida Works

Brahmi and its descendants share one clever design. In English, a vowel is a separate letter: *k* plus *a* makes *ka*. Brahmi-family scripts work differently.

Each consonant letter already includes a short "a" sound, and you change or remove that vowel by adding a mark.

An **abugida** is a writing system in which each consonant letter carries a built-in vowel (usually a short "a"), and other vowels are shown by marks attached to the consonant. The built-in vowel is called the **inherent vowel**. A small mark called a **virama** (in Hindi, *halant*) "kills" the inherent vowel so you get a bare consonant.

Here is the syllable "ka" and its family in six scripts. Every character below is the real Unicode character, not a picture.

Script	ka	ki	ku	k (no vowel)
Brahmi	𑀓	𑀓𑀺	𑀓𑀼	𑀓𑁆
Devanagari (Hindi, Nepali, Marathi)	क	कि	कु	क्
Bengali-Assamese (Bangla)	ক	কি	কু	ক্
Gurmukhi (Punjabi)	ਕ	ਕਿ	ਕੁ	ਕ੍
Tamil	க	கி	கு	க்
Sinhala	ක	කි	කු	ක්

Look down the "ka" column first: one letter, no extra mark. Then look across a row. The base letter stays the same, and a small mark appears for each vowel. Notice something odd in Devanagari, Bangla and Gurmukhi: the "i"

mark is written *before* the consonant even though you say it after. Readers learn to take in the whole cluster at once. One more detail: Gurmukhi has a virama character, but everyday Punjabi spelling almost never uses it.

If your browser shows any of these as empty boxes, your device is missing a font for that script. The MicroSim below loads free Noto fonts so every script displays.

Devanagari (देवनागरी, *day-vuh-NAA-guh-ree*) is the abugida used for Hindi, Marathi, Nepali, Sanskrit, Maithili and several other languages. Its name joins the Sanskrit words *deva* ("god" or "divine") and *nagari* (from *nagara*, "city"). You can recognize it by the line that runs along the top of most letters, with the letters hanging below it like laundry on a line. It is the script named in Article 343 for Hindi, and in Nepal it is used for Nepali.

Gurmukhi (ਗੁਰਮੁਖੀ, *GUR-moo-khee*) is the abugida used to write Punjabi in India and the Sikh scripture, the Guru Granth Sahib. Its name is often explained as "from the mouth of the Guru." Its standard form took shape in the 16th century and is popularly credited to Guru Angad, the second Sikh Guru. Gurmukhi has 35 base letters, traditionally arranged in seven rows of five. Simran learned them at her gurdwara's Sunday school. In Pakistan, where most Punjabi speakers live, Punjabi is usually written in Shahmukhi, a Perso-Arabic script.

Learn one, unlock many

Because most South Asian scripts share the abugida design and even the same order of letters (k, kh, g, gh…), learning one makes the next one much easier. If you can read Devanagari, learning Gujarati or Bangla is more like learning a new handwriting than a whole new system.

6.9 The Other Root: Aramaic, Arabic and Thaana

Not every script in South Asia comes from Brahmi. A second family of scripts came from the west.

Aramaic was the script the Persian Empire used for government business. In the northwest of South Asia, in the region called Gandhara (today's northern Pakistan and eastern Afghanistan), it gave rise to **Kharoshthi**, which was written right to left. Some of Ashoka's edicts, at Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra in present-day Pakistan, were carved in Kharoshthi rather than Brahmi. Kharoshthi fell out of use around the 3rd to 5th centuries CE, but it shows that two script traditions lived side by side in Ashoka's empire.

Much later, Arabic script, which also descends from Aramaic through older Semitic scripts, came to South Asia with Persian- and Arabic-speaking traders, scholars and rulers. Persian writers had already adapted it by adding letters, and South Asian writers added still more for sounds like the retroflex "ṭ" and "ḍ" that Arabic lacks.

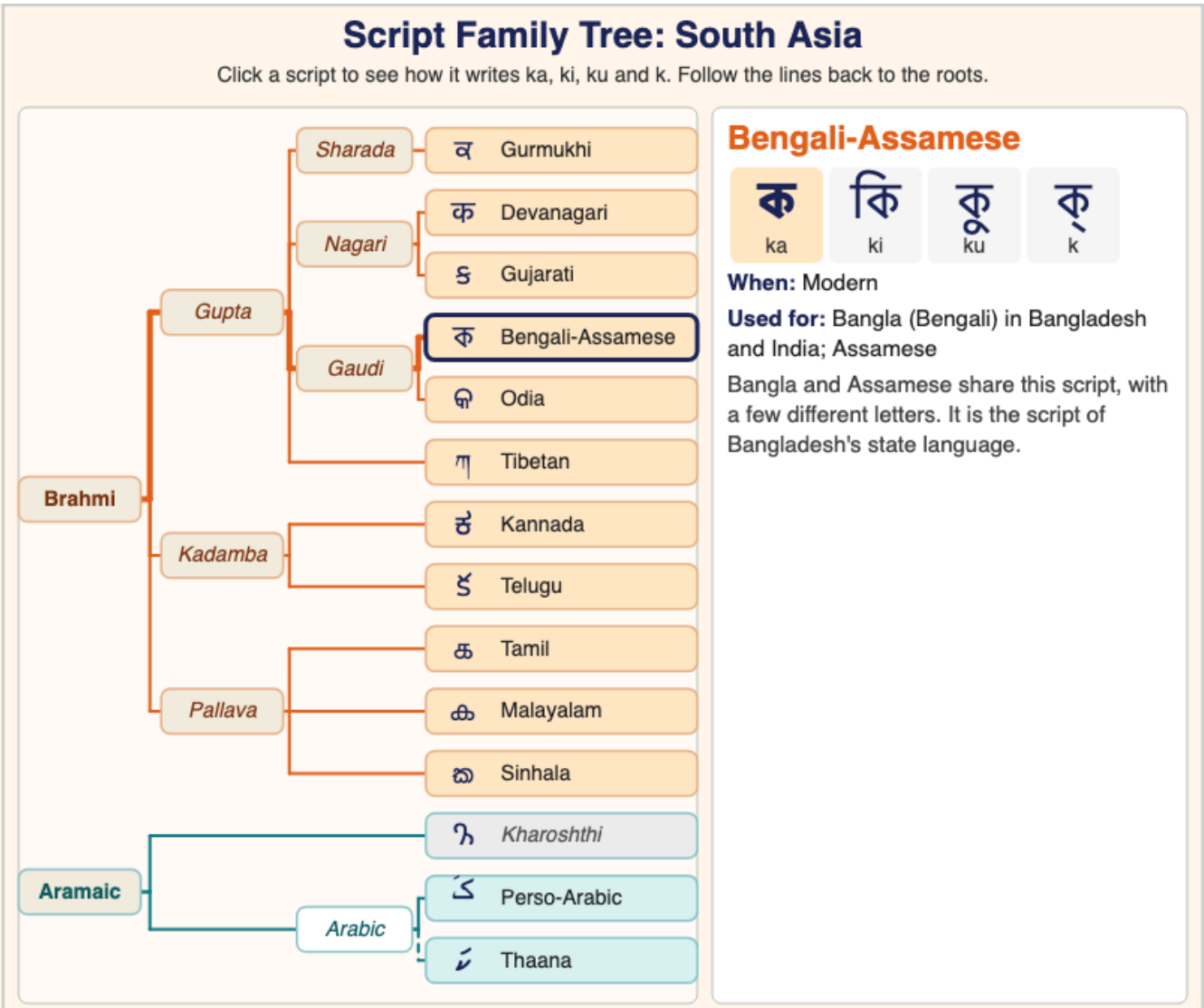
The **Perso-Arabic Script** is the Arabic script as adapted for Persian and then for many South Asian languages. Today it is used for Urdu, Pashto, Dari, Sindhi, Balochi, Kashmiri and Shahmukhi Punjabi, and for Brahui. It's written right to left. It works mostly as an **abjad**, a script that writes consonants and long vowels but usually leaves short vowels out. Readers fill them in from context, the way you can read "txt msgs" without vowels. Small optional marks can show the short vowels when needed, for example in children's books or the Quran. Urdu is usually written in Nastaliq, an elegant hanging style in which many words slope downward from right to left.

Thaana, the script of Dhivehi in the Maldives, has an unusual history. It is written right to left like Arabic, and its first nine letters were formed from Arabic numerals, while the next nine came from old Dhivehi numerals. Every vowel must be written, as a mark called a *fili* placed above or below the

consonant, so Thaana sits somewhere between an abugida and a true alphabet. The oldest surviving Thaana writing, carved on the door posts of a mosque in the northern Maldives, is dated 1599, and over the following centuries Thaana replaced the older Maldivian script, Dives Akuru.

So when people say "South Asian scripts," they mean at least two big families, plus newer inventions like Ol Chiki, and the Latin alphabet used for English and for typing on phones.

Diagram: Script Family Tree



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch06-script-family-tree/main.html

Open the Script Family Tree fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Script Family Tree

sim-id: ch06-script-family-tree
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: explain
Learning Objective: The learner will explain that many South Asian scripts share Brahmi as a common ancestor, and explain how an abugida changes one consonant's inherent vowel with marks.

Canvas: responsive width; 700 px drawing area plus 80 px control area.

Controls: script menu, sound menu (ka, ki, ku, k with no vowel), "Show debated link" checkbox; click or tap any script on the tree.

Behavior: A simplified tree with two roots. Brahmi branches through Gupta (to Sharada, Nagari, Gaudi and Tibetan), Kadamba and Pallava to eleven modern scripts. Aramaic leads to Kharoshthi and, through Arabic, to the Perso-Arabic script, with a dashed line to Thaana. Each modern script shows the selected syllable in real Unicode text (Noto web fonts load so all scripts display). Selecting a script shows ka, ki, ku and k side by side, when and where it was used, and which languages use it. The checkbox adds a dashed "debated" link from Aramaic to Brahmi. A caption notes that the tree is simplified.

Start with Bengali-Assamese selected and read the four boxes in the panel: one base letter, four sounds. Then use the **Show** menu to switch the whole tree from *ka* to *ki*. Watch every Brahmi-family script add a vowel mark to the same base letter, sometimes before it, sometimes after, above or below. Switch to **k (no vowel)** and find the one Brahmi-family script that shows "none" (the panel explains why).

Next, follow the lines. Click Tamil, then Devanagari, and trace each one back to Brahmi. Then click Perso-Arabic and Thaana and notice that they hang from a different root entirely. Finally, tick **Show debated link**. Most scholars think the people who created Brahmi borrowed the idea of writing from an Aramaic-family script, then redesigned it for South Asian sounds. Others argue Brahmi developed locally, and a few link it to the Indus signs, though the evidence for that is very thin. That's why the line is dashed.

6.10 Living Between Languages

Most people in South Asia, and many South Asian families in the United States, use more than one language every day, and that shapes how they talk.

Code-Switching is moving back and forth between two or more languages (or styles of speaking) in the same conversation, or even the same sentence. A teen in Mumbai might say, "Yaar, the exam was *bahut* hard," mixing Hindi and English. Mixes like this are sometimes nicknamed "Hinglish." Zara's family does the same in "Banglish," and Dilan Perera's cousins in Kandy slide between Sinhala and English. Code-switching isn't a sign that someone speaks either language badly. Linguists study it as a skill: speakers switch to fit the topic, show closeness, make a joke land, or use the word that simply fits best.

Your mix counts

If you answer your parents in English, mix languages mid-sentence, or understand far more than you can say, you're not "losing" your language. You're a heritage speaker, and that is a real foundation you can build on at any age.

A **Heritage Language** is a language that a person learned at home from family, while growing up in a place where a different language is the main one. Zara is a heritage speaker of Bangla: she understands her Nanu easily, but she answers in English, and reading Bangla is slow for her. That's a very common pattern. Heritage speakers often understand more than they speak, speak more than they read, and feel shy about their accent or grammar. Some US colleges offer classes designed for heritage learners of languages such as Hindi, Urdu and Bangla, and many temples, mosques, gurdwaras and cultural centers run weekend language classes, like the one where Simran learned Gurmukhi.

When heritage speakers text, they often write their family language in English letters: *kemon acho?* for Bangla "How are you?" or *kya haal hai?* in Hindi-Urdu. Writing one script's words in another script's letters is called transliteration, and there's a guide to it in this book's Pronunciation Guide.

Back at the name-tag table, Zara pulls up the Script Family Tree on her phone. She taps Bangla, then Telugu, then Gurmukhi, and follows each line back to Brahmi. "Cousins," she says, holding up her name tag next to Arjun's. Ben squints at বাংলা and తెలుగు. "So it's like Swedish and Spanish using the same alphabet," he says, "but backwards. Different alphabets, same great-great-grandparent." Simran nods. "And Ayesha's Urdu is from the other side of the family." Zara decides that tonight she'll ask Nanu to teach her one new Bangla word, and to write it down for her, too.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about the languages they grew up with, at home, at school and in the street. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Ask them to write a few words in their script on a piece of paper (their name, their town, or a favorite word), and ask if you can keep it and take notes.

Questions to ask

1. What language or languages did you speak at home when you were little? Was it different at school or with friends?
2. When did you learn to read and write, and in which script? Who taught you?
3. Is there a word in your language that has no good English translation? What does it mean, and when do you use it?
4. Do you mix languages when you talk? Which words do you say in English and which in your language?
5. How has the way our family uses its language changed since you were young, or since moving to a new country?
6. Do you worry about our language being lost? What is one thing about it you hope I keep?

Listen for: whether they grew up speaking a Heritage Language or a regional language at home and another at school; examples of Code-Switching; and which script they write in, so you can find it on the Script Family Tree (is it

Devanagari, Gurmukhi, a Perso-Arabic Script, or another descendant of the Brahmi Script?).

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Find your elder's script on the Script Family Tree and trace it back to its root. Then compare with a friend's interview: do your two families' scripts share a parent, a grandparent, or no ancestor at all? Did either elder mention a word with no English translation, and could you guess its meaning from context?

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Hindi is India's national language.
Reality: India's Constitution does not name a national language. Hindi in Devanagari is the official language of the central government, English is also used officially, and 22 languages are listed in the Eighth Schedule. States choose their own official languages.

Myth: Hindi and Urdu are unrelated languages.
Reality: Hindi and Urdu are two standard forms of one spoken language, Hindi-Urdu (Hindustani). Everyday speakers understand each other well. They differ in script (Devanagari versus Perso-Arabic) and in formal vocabulary (more Sanskrit words versus more Persian and Arabic words).

Myth: Sanskrit is the mother of all South Asian languages.
Reality: Sanskrit is an ancestor of many Indo-Aryan languages, like Hindi and Bangla, but Tamil, Telugu, Kannada and Malayalam belong to the separate

Dravidian family. Tibeto-Burman, Austroasiatic and Iranian languages have their own ancestors too. Languages have borrowed words from each other for centuries, but borrowing is not descent.

Myth: A script and a language are the same thing.
Reality: A language is spoken; a script is a way to write it. Punjabi is written in Gurmukhi in India and Shahmukhi in Pakistan, and Devanagari is used for Hindi, Marathi, Nepali and Sanskrit.

Myth: If you answer your parents in English, you've lost your family language.
Reality: Understanding a language you grew up hearing is real knowledge. Heritage speakers usually understand far more than they speak, and they often learn to speak, read and write faster than beginners when they get the chance.

Check Yourself

1. What is the difference between a language and a script? Give one South Asian example.

A language is a system of spoken words and grammar, and a script is a set of written symbols. Punjabi is one language written in two scripts: Gurmukhi in India and Shahmukhi (Perso-Arabic) in Pakistan.

2. Name the language family that Tamil, Telugu, Kannada and Malayalam belong to, and one language from that family spoken outside India.

They are Dravidian languages. Brahui, spoken mainly in Balochistan, Pakistan, is also Dravidian (and Tamil is spoken in Sri Lanka).

3. How many languages are in India's Eighth Schedule, and what does the Constitution say about a national language?

The Eighth Schedule lists 22 languages. The Constitution names no national language. Article 343 makes Hindi in Devanagari the official language of the Union, with English still used officially.

4. In an abugida, what does the plain consonant letter क sound like, and what does the virama do?

A plain consonant letter includes the inherent vowel "a," so क is "ka." The virama removes that vowel, so क् is a bare "k."

5. Why did UNESCO choose 21 February for International Mother Language Day?

On 21 February 1952, students in Dhaka protesting for Bangla to be a national language of Pakistan were shot and killed by police. Bangladesh proposed the day, and UNESCO declared it in 1999.

Exercises

Remember

1. List the five language families of South Asia named in this chapter, with one language from each.

Answer

Indo-Aryan (Hindi, Bangla, Sinhala), Iranian (Pashto, Dari), Dravidian (Tamil, Telugu), Tibeto-Burman (Dzongkha, Manipuri), Austroasiatic (Santali, Khasi). Any one correct example per family is fine.

2. Which scripts are used to write Hindi, Urdu, Punjabi in India, and Dhivehi?

Answer

Hindi: Devanagari. Urdu: Perso-Arabic (Nastaliq style). Punjabi in India: Gurmukhi. Dhivehi: Thaana.

Understand

1. Explain in your own words why Telugu and Hindi use related scripts even though they are in different language families.

Answer

Scripts and languages have separate family trees. Telugu is Dravidian and Hindi is Indo-Aryan, but both communities write with scripts that grew out of Brahmi, which spread across the region and changed over time in different places.

2. Explain why speakers of Hindi and Urdu can usually understand each other in conversation but may struggle with each other's newspapers.

Answer

Spoken Hindi and Urdu share grammar and everyday words, so conversation works. Newspapers use different scripts (Devanagari and Perso-Arabic) and more formal vocabulary drawn from Sanskrit in Hindi and from Persian and Arabic in Urdu.

Apply

1. Use the Script Family Tree. Switch the menu to *ki*. Pick three scripts and describe where the "i" mark sits (before, after, above or below the consonant) in each. *Hint: zoom in on the panel glyphs, which are larger.*
2. A classmate shows you a sign written right to left with flowing, slanted letters that seem to have few vowel marks. Using this chapter, name the most likely script family and two languages it might be. *Hint: which scripts on the tree are written right to left?*

Analyze

1. Compare the language-family table in Section 6.3 with the script tree in the MicroSim. Find two cases where languages in different families share a script family, and one case where one language uses scripts from two different families. *Hint: look at Dravidian languages and at Punjabi.*
2. Bangla is the state language of Bangladesh, but Urdu was the planned sole national language of Pakistan in 1948 to 1952. Analyze why a language decision could lead to protests and, later, to a new international day. *Hint: think about what it means to be educated and governed in a language you don't speak at home.*

Evaluate

1. Should India name a single national language? Using facts from this chapter (the Eighth Schedule, the census numbers and the different language families), argue for or against, and address the strongest point on the other side. *Hint: who would be helped and who might feel left out?*
2. Someone says code-switching is "lazy" and shows a person doesn't really know either language. Evaluate this claim using evidence from the chapter and from your own experience. *Hint: why might a speaker choose one word over another?*

Create

1. Design a name tag for your club that shows one person's name or one word in two scripts from different branches of the Script Family Tree, with a one-line caption explaining how the scripts are related. *Hint: verify the spelling with someone who reads that script, or with a dictionary.*
2. Write a short dialogue (8 to 12 lines) between a heritage speaker and a grandparent that includes realistic code-switching. Afterward, add two sentences explaining why each switch happens. *Hint: switches often happen for food, feelings, jokes and school words.*

Key Takeaways

- A language is spoken; a script is how it's written. One language can use two scripts, and one script can write many languages.
- South Asia's languages belong to five main families: Indo-Aryan and Iranian (both Indo-European), Dravidian, Tibeto-Burman and

Austroasiatic. In India's 2011 census, 78.05% of people spoke an Indo-Aryan mother tongue and 19.64% a Dravidian one.

- India's Constitution names no national language. Hindi in Devanagari is the Union's official language, English is also used officially, and the Eighth Schedule recognizes 22 languages.
- Hindi and Urdu are two standard forms of one spoken language, Hindi-Urdu (Hindustani), written in different scripts with different formal vocabulary.
- Most South Asian scripts, from Devanagari and Gurmukhi to Bangla, Tamil, Sinhala and Tibetan, descend from Brahmi, in use by the 3rd century BCE. The Perso-Arabic script and Thaana come from a different root.
- Brahmi-family scripts are abugidas: each consonant carries an inherent "a," and marks change or remove the vowel.
- Code-switching and heritage-language skills are normal and valuable, not signs of "losing" a language.

You can see the family resemblance!

You can now tell a language from a script, name South Asia's five language families, and read the "ka" family in several scripts. Next, in Chapter 7, we follow the calendar around the year to see why Diwali and Eid move on different schedules.

Quiz: Languages and Scripts

Test your understanding of Chapter 6. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

How many languages are listed in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution of India?

A. 14

B. 22

C. 121

D. 270

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The Eighth Schedule lists 22 languages today. It started with 14 when the Constitution was adopted, and 121 is the number of languages India's 2011 census counted with at least 10,000 speakers, not the number on the official list.

Concept Tested: Eighth Schedule **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

Which language family do Tamil, Telugu, Kannada and Malayalam belong to?

A. Indo-Aryan

B. Tibeto-Burman

C. Austroasiatic

D. Dravidian

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. These four are the largest Dravidian languages. Many people assume they are Indo-Aryan because they borrowed many Sanskrit words, but their grammar and core vocabulary come from a separate ancestor.

Concept Tested: Dravidian Languages **Bloom's Level:** Remember

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Question 3

Which script is the common ancestor of Devanagari, Bengali-Assamese, Gurmukhi, Tamil and Sinhala?

A. Brahmi

B. Kharoshthi

C. Perso-Arabic

D. Thaana

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. All five descend from Brahmi, which was in use by the 3rd century BCE. Kharoshthi was a separate script of the northwest that came from Aramaic and died out; it is not their ancestor.

Concept Tested: Brahmi Script **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

What does it mean to say that Devanagari is an abugida?

A. It writes only consonants and leaves all vowels out.

B. Each letter stands for a whole word.

C. Each consonant letter carries a built-in "a," and marks change or remove the vowel.

D. Every vowel is a separate full letter, as in English.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. In an abugida, क already reads "ka"; adding a mark makes कि ("ki") or कु ("ku"), and the virama makes क् ("k"). Option A describes an abjad, like the Perso-Arabic script, which usually leaves short vowels out.

Concept Tested: Abugida **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

Why can Hindi and Urdu speakers usually chat easily but have trouble reading each other's newspapers?

A. They share everyday grammar and words but use different scripts and different formal vocabulary.

B. They are unrelated languages that happen to share a few words.

C. Urdu is written left to right and Hindi right to left, so the letters are reversed.

D. Hindi has no written form, so newspapers use English.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Hindi and Urdu are two standard forms of Hindi-Urdu (Hindustani). Speech is shared, but Hindi uses Devanagari and more Sanskrit-based formal words, while Urdu uses Perso-Arabic script, written right to left, and more Persian and Arabic formal words. Option C has the directions backward.

Concept Tested: Hindi-Urdu (Hindustani) **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 6

Which statement about India's languages is accurate?

A. Hindi is India's national language under the Constitution.

B. English is one of the 22 languages in the Eighth Schedule.

C. Every Indian state must use Hindi as its official language.

D. The Constitution names no national language; Hindi in Devanagari is the official language of the Union.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Article 343 makes Hindi in Devanagari the official language of the central government, English is still used officially, and the Constitution names no national language. Option A is the common "national language" myth, and states choose their own official languages.

Concept Tested: Eighth Schedule **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 7

Ben finds an old family letter from a classmate's grandfather. It's written right to left, in flowing letters, with almost no vowel marks. Which language could it most likely be in?

A. Tamil

B. Urdu

C. Bangla

D. Gujarati

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Urdu is written in the Perso-Arabic script, right to left, usually without short vowel marks. Tamil, Bangla and Gujarati are written left to right in Brahmi-family abugidas that mark their vowels.

Concept Tested: Perso-Arabic Script **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

At dinner, Zara's cousin says, "Ammu, the *biryani* is so good, *aro dao* please." Which idea from the chapter best describes what she is doing?

A. Transliteration

B. Abugida

C. Code-switching

D. Classical language status

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. She moves between English and Bangla in one sentence, which is code-switching. Transliteration is writing one language's words in another script's letters, which is about writing, not about mixing languages while speaking.

Concept Tested: Code-Switching **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Telugu is a Dravidian language and Hindi is an Indo-Aryan language, yet the Telugu and Devanagari scripts are both descendants of Brahmi. What does this best show?

A. Telugu must really be an Indo-Aryan language.

B. Language families and script families are separate trees, so unrelated languages can share a script ancestor.

C. Brahmi was invented for Telugu and later borrowed by Hindi speakers.

D. All South Asian languages come from Sanskrit.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. A script can spread to communities speaking unrelated languages. Telugu's grammar and core words are Dravidian, while its script descends from Brahmi. Option D is the "Sanskrit is the mother of all languages" myth.

Concept Tested: Language Family **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

Zara understands her Nanu's Bangla easily but answers in English and reads Bangla slowly. Which conclusion is best supported by the chapter?

A. She is a heritage speaker, a common pattern in which understanding runs ahead of speaking and reading.

B. She has lost Bangla and cannot relearn it.

C. She is code-switching because she doesn't know English well.

D. Bangla is not her family's language.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. A heritage language is learned at home while growing up where another language dominates, and heritage speakers often understand more than they speak or read. Option B is the misconception the chapter corrects: understanding is real knowledge to build on.

Concept Tested: Heritage Language **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year

Summary

South Asia's festivals follow three different kinds of calendar. Some follow the sun and land on almost the same date every year. Some follow the moon alone and slide about 11 days earlier each year. Many follow both, so they wobble by a few weeks but stay in the same season. This chapter explains those three calendars first. Then it goes through the year's major festivals across the eight countries: what each one marks, who celebrates it, and how celebrations differ from place to place. By the end you'll be able to predict, roughly, when a festival will fall next year and explain why.

Concepts Covered

1. Lunisolar Calendar
2. Islamic Lunar Calendar
3. Diwali
4. Holi
5. Navaratri and Durga Puja
6. Dashain and Tihar
7. Ramadan
8. Eid al-Fitr

9. Eid al-Adha
10. Ashura
11. Vaisakhi
12. Pohela Boishakh
13. Pongal and Makar Sankranti
14. Onam
15. Vesak
16. Losar
17. Nowruz
18. Christmas in South Asia

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia? for the eight countries and the monsoon seasons.
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia for the basic ideas of Hinduism, Islam, Sikhism, Buddhism, Jainism and Christianity.
- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts helps with the festival names, which come from many languages.

Festival season is every season

Hi, I'm Mora! If you've ever had to explain to a teacher why you'll miss a test for Eid, or why Diwali "moved" this year, this chapter is for you. Festivals are when families pass down food, stories and music, and knowing how their calendars work helps you plan for them and explain them to friends. Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

7.1 Ben Builds a Calendar

It's a Thursday in late August, and Ben Lindqvist has volunteered for a job nobody else wanted: building the South Asian Student Association's calendar for the whole school year. Zara Hossain wants the club to mark every big festival its members celebrate, so nobody schedules a meeting on someone's Eid or Diwali. Ben figures it'll take ten minutes. He'll just copy last year's dates.

Twenty minutes later he's frowning at his laptop. "Zara, something's broken. Last year Diwali was on 20 October. This year it says 8 November. And Eid al-Fitr was 31 March in 2025, then 21 March in 2026, and next year it's around 10 March. Do people just pick new dates every year?" Zara laughs, then stops, because she realizes she doesn't know why. Her Nanu always says "Eid depends on the moon," but Diwali follows the moon too, and it moved *later*, not earlier. If both festivals follow the moon, why don't they move the same way?

7.2 Three Ways to Count a Year

Start with something Ben already knows. His birthday falls on the same date every year because the calendar on his wall follows the sun. The **Gregorian calendar**, the one used for school, sports schedules and taxes in the United States, is a **solar calendar**: its year is built to match one trip of the Earth around the sun, about 365.24 days. That's why the seasons stay put, and hockey season always starts when it's cold.

Now imagine a second calendar that ignores the sun and counts only the moon. The moon goes from new moon to full moon and back to new moon in about 29.53 days. That cycle is a **lunar month**. Twelve lunar months add up to about

$$12 \times 29.53 \approx 354.4 \text{ days},$$

which is about 11 days shorter than a solar year. A calendar built only on the moon is a **lunar calendar**.

There's also a third option: count months by the moon, but every few years add an extra month so the calendar catches up with the sun. That's a **Lunisolar Calendar**, a calendar whose months follow the moon but whose years are kept in step with the sun and the seasons by adding a leap month from time to time. In many Hindu calendars of South Asia, this extra month is called *adhik maas*, "added month," and it is inserted about once every 32.5 months on average, roughly every two and a half to three years.

Calendar type	Months follow	Year length	What happens to festival dates on the Gregorian calendar	South Asian examples
Solar	The sun	About 365 days	Almost the same date every year	Vaisakhi, Pohela Boishakh in Bangladesh, Pongal, Nowruz, Christmas
Lunisolar	The moon, with a leap month	354 days in most years, about 384 in a leap year	Jumps back and forth by up to about a month, but stays in the same season	Diwali, Holi, Navaratri, Dashain, Vesak, Losar
Lunar	The moon only	354 or 355 days	About 11 days earlier every year, moving through all seasons	Ramadan, Eid al-Fitr, Eid al-Adha, Ashura

The **Islamic Lunar Calendar** (also called the Hijri calendar) is a purely lunar calendar of 12 months, with a year of 354 or 355 days and no leap month. It is the calendar Muslims use for religious dates, from the start of Ramadan to

the two Eids. Because it never adds a month to catch up, its dates drift backward through the Gregorian year. A little arithmetic shows how fast:

$$365.24 - 354.37 \approx 10.9 \text{ days per year.}$$

To slide all the way around the Gregorian year, an Islamic date needs about

$$\frac{365.24}{10.9} \approx 33.5 \text{ Gregorian years.}$$

So someone who fasts during Ramadan for most of their life will fast through every season, more than once.

That answers Ben's puzzle. Eid al-Fitr follows a lunar calendar, so it moved about 11 days earlier from 2026 to 2027. Diwali follows a lunisolar calendar. In most years it also lands about 11 days earlier than the year before, but whenever a leap month is added, it jumps about 19 days later instead. Between 2025 and 2026, a leap month was added, so Diwali jumped from 20 October to 8 November.

Try the math yourself

If Eid al-Fitr is on 21 March in 2026 and moves about 11 days earlier each year, roughly when will it fall in 2028? In what year might it land near New Year's Day? Check your guesses with the Festival Wheel at the end of the chapter.

Why a festival can be "a day off"

Calendars that follow the moon raise one more question: who decides when a month starts? In Islamic practice, a new month traditionally begins when

people see the thin crescent moon just after sunset, and committees in many countries confirm the sighting. The crescent can be visible in one place and not another, so Eid can fall on different days in, say, Saudi Arabia and Bangladesh, or even in two cities of one country.

In July 2025, for example, the Government of India published its holiday list for 2026 and set the Eid al-Adha holiday (often called Bakrid in India) for 27 May 2026, "subject to change" depending on the moon. On 22 May 2026, after the moon was sighted, the government moved the holiday in Delhi to 28 May. Lunisolar calendars have their own version of this: many Hindu festivals are tied to a *tithi* (a lunar day), and regional calendars sometimes disagree about which sunrise or evening it falls on, so a festival can be marked on two neighboring days in different places.

7.3 Festivals of Light and Color: Diwali and Holi

Diwali

Diwali (दिवाली, *dee-VAH-lee*), from the Sanskrit *Deepavali*, "row of lamps," is the festival of lights, held on the new moon at the end of the lunar month of Ashvin (Kartika in some regional calendars), usually in October or November. Families clean and decorate their homes, light small clay oil lamps called *diyas*, draw colored designs at the doorway (you'll learn about rangoli and kolam in Chapter 11), wear new clothes, share sweets and set off fireworks.

What Diwali celebrates depends on who you ask.

- **Many Hindus** celebrate the victory of light over darkness and of good over evil. In much of North India, Diwali recalls the god Rama returning home after defeating Ravana. Many families worship Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth and good fortune, on the main night. In Bengal and

among Hindus in Bangladesh, the same new moon night is Kali Puja, honoring the goddess Kali.

- **Sikhs** celebrate Bandi Chhor Divas, "day of liberation," on the same day. In Sikh tradition, it marks the release of the sixth Guru, Guru Hargobind, from imprisonment in Gwalior Fort by the Mughal emperor Jahangir, along with 52 imprisoned kings.
- **Jains** mark Diwali as the anniversary of the *nirvana* (final liberation) of Mahavira, the last of the Jain Tirthankaras.
- **Newar Buddhists** of Nepal's Kathmandu Valley also celebrate the festival, which they call Swanti.

Diwali is a public holiday in India (8 November in 2026, according to the Government of India's holiday list), and Hindu communities in Pakistan, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka celebrate it too. In Nepal, the five-day festival of the same season is called Tihar (Section 7.4). In the United States, California made Diwali a state holiday under a law signed in October 2025 that took effect in 2026, following Pennsylvania (2024) and Connecticut (2025). That same month, a resolution introduced in the US House of Representatives described Diwali as a festival celebrated by "Hindus, Sikhs, Jains, and others" across the country.

Holi

Holi (होली, *HOH-lee*) is the spring festival of colors, held on the full moon of the month of Phalguna and the day after it, usually in March. On the first evening, communities light a bonfire called Holika Dahan. On the main day, people of all ages chase each other through the streets throwing colored powder and water, and old arguments are supposed to be forgiven.

Holi carries several meanings at once. Many Hindus connect the bonfire to the story of the young devotee Prahlad, who survived when his aunt Holika tried to burn him. Holi also celebrates the love of Radha and Krishna, the end

of winter and the coming spring harvest. In Bengal (West Bengal in India, and Bangladesh) it is often called Dol Jatra or Basanta Utsab, "spring festival." Nepal celebrates Holi as Fagu Purnima, and Hindu communities in Pakistan and Bangladesh celebrate it too. In 2026, India's holiday list put Holi on 4 March.

Because Holi follows a lunisolar calendar, it can fall anywhere from late February to late March, but the leap month keeps it from ever leaving spring.

7.4 Nine Nights and the Tenth Day

Navaratri and Durga Puja

Navaratri and Durga Puja are two names for the great autumn festival of the goddess. *Navaratri* (नवरात्रि, *nuh-vuh-RAHT-ree*) means "nine nights." It begins the day after the new moon that opens the month of Ashvin (so about a month before Diwali's new moon), usually in September or October, and the tenth day is Vijayadashami, often called Dussehra, "the tenth day of victory." In 2026, India's central government listed Dussehra on 20 October.

The same nine nights look very different across the region.

- **In Gujarat**, people dance Garba, a circle dance around a lamp or an image of the goddess, night after night. UNESCO added the Garba of Gujarat to its list of intangible cultural heritage in 2023.
- **In Bengal, Assam and Odisha**, and among Hindus in Bangladesh, the festival is **Durga Puja**, the worship of the goddess Durga (दुर्गा, *DOOR-gah*), who in many Hindu traditions defeats the buffalo demon Mahishasura. Artisans spend months sculpting images of Durga and her children from clay. Communities build temporary decorated structures called *pandals* to house them, and on the last day the images are carried to a river and immersed. UNESCO inscribed "Durga Puja in Kolkata"

on its Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2021.

- **In much of North India**, the tenth day recalls Rama's victory over Ravana. Plays called Ramlila retell the story, and towering effigies of Ravana are burned with fireworks.

Dashain and Tihar

Dashain and Tihar are Nepal's two biggest festivals, about three weeks apart in the autumn.

Dashain (दशैं, *duh-SHAIN*) falls on the same autumn days as Navaratri. It is the longest and most important festival in the country's calendar, lasting 15 days, usually in September or October. On the first day, families plant barley seeds indoors. By the tenth day the seeds have grown into pale yellow shoots called *jamara*. On that day, elders put a *tika* (a mark of red rice and yogurt) on the foreheads of younger relatives, tuck *jamara* behind their ears and give their blessing. Dashain is celebrated by Nepali families of many backgrounds, and also in Bhutan and in Nepali-speaking parts of India. It is not shared by everyone in Nepal, though. Since the 1990s some Indigenous (Janajati) groups have chosen not to celebrate it, because they see it as a Hindu festival the old Hindu monarchy expected every community to keep, while other Janajati families celebrate it in their own way.

Tihar (तिहार, *tee-HAAR*) is Nepal's five-day festival of lights, in the same season as Diwali. Each day honors someone different: crows on the first day, dogs on the second (Kukur Tihar, when dogs get flower garlands and treats), cows and the goddess Lakshmi on the third, oxen on the fourth, and siblings on the last day, Bhai Tika, when sisters bless their brothers. Children go house to house singing songs called Deusi and Bhailo, a little like caroling. Among Newar communities of the Kathmandu Valley the festival is called Swanti.

Same night, different names

If a friend from Kolkata says "Durga Puja," a friend from Ahmedabad says "Navaratri," and a friend from Kathmandu says "Dashain," they're often talking about the very same days in the calendar. Ask how *their* family celebrates before you assume it's the same festival in every way.

7.5 The Islamic Year

Muslims make up most of the population of Afghanistan, Pakistan, Bangladesh and the Maldives, and large communities in India and Sri Lanka. For all of them, the year's most important religious dates follow the Islamic Lunar Calendar.

Ramadan

Ramadan (Arabic رمضان, *rah-mah-DAHN*; in Bangla রমজান, *rom-JAHN*) is the ninth month of the Islamic calendar, a month of fasting, prayer and charity that lasts 29 or 30 days, from one sighting of the crescent moon to the next. Fasting during Ramadan is one of the Five Pillars of Islam. Adult Muslims go without food and drink from dawn until sunset. People who are ill, traveling, elderly, pregnant or breastfeeding are excused, and many can make up the days later.

Zara's family wakes up before dawn for *sehri* (the predawn meal; in Arabic it's called *suhur*) and gathers at sunset for *iftar*, the meal that breaks the fast, often starting with dates and water. In Minnesota, where summer days are long and winter days are short, the length of the fast changes a lot depending on which season Ramadan falls in. Over a lifetime, Zara will fast through Minnesota summers and winters alike.

Eid al-Fitr

Eid al-Fitr (Bangla ঈদুল ফিতর, *EED-ul FIT-er*), "the festival of breaking the fast," begins on the first day of the month of Shawwal, when the new crescent is sighted at the end of Ramadan. The night of the sighting is celebrated as *Chand Raat*, "night of the moon," with last-minute shopping and henna. On Eid morning, families put on new clothes and attend special prayers. Before the prayer, Muslims give a required charity called *zakat al-fitr* so that people in need can celebrate too. Children receive *Eidi* (gifts of money), and visits to relatives last all day, often with sweet vermicelli (*shemai* in Bangla, *sheer khurma* or *seviyan* in Urdu and Hindi). Eid al-Fitr is celebrated for one to three days depending on the country. In 2026, India's holiday list put it on 21 March.

Eid al-Adha

Eid al-Adha (Bangla ঈদুল আযহা, *EED-ul AD-ha*), "the festival of sacrifice," falls on the 10th day of Dhu al-Hijjah, the last month of the Islamic year, during the Hajj pilgrimage to Mecca. In Islamic tradition, it honors the prophet Ibrahim's (Abraham's) willingness to sacrifice his son at God's command. Families who can afford it sacrifice an animal (a goat, sheep, cow or camel) and share the meat with relatives, neighbors and people in need. In Pakistan and Bangladesh, busy animal markets appear in cities in the weeks before. In India it is often called Bakrid, and in 2026 it fell on 28 May in Delhi, one day after the date first printed on the holiday list.

Ashura

Ashura (Persian عاشورا, *aa-SHOO-rah*, "the tenth") is the 10th day of Muharram, the first month of the Islamic year. It means different things to different Muslims.

- For **Shia Muslims**, Ashura is the most solemn day of the year, a day of mourning for Husayn ibn Ali, grandson of the Prophet Muhammad, who

was killed with his companions at the Battle of Karbala, in present-day Iraq, on 10 Muharram in 680 CE. During the first ten days of Muharram, Shia communities hold gatherings called *majlis* where Husayn's story is retold, and on Ashura they hold processions. In Dhaka, the Hussaini Dalan, a Shia hall first built in the 17th century under Mughal rule, is the center of Muharram gatherings. Large Muharram processions also take place in cities across Pakistan and India.

- **Sunni Muslims** also regard Husayn's death as a tragedy and remember it in sermons. Many Sunnis also fast on Ashura, a practice linked in Islamic tradition to the day Moses and the Israelites were saved from Pharaoh.

Not every festival is a party

Wishing someone "Happy Ashura" can hurt, because for many Shia families it is a day of grief. If you're not sure how a friend's family observes a day, ask, and listen.

7.6 New Years and Harvests Set by the Sun

Many of South Asia's new years land in mid-April. That's because many regional calendars start the year when the sun enters Mesha (the sign of Aries in the Indian zodiac), around 13 to 15 April. Since these festivals follow the sun, their dates barely move.

Vaisakhi

Vaisakhi (*VAI-saa-khee*), also spelled Baisakhi, falls on 13 or 14 April and is both a harvest festival and a new year in Punjab and in much of North India. For Sikhs, it is one of the most important days of the year. In Sikh tradition, on

Vaisakhi in 1699 the tenth Guru, Guru Gobind Singh, founded the Khalsa, the community of initiated Sikhs, at Anandpur. Sikhs mark the day with prayers at the gurdwara and *nagar kirtan*, processions with hymn singing through the streets. Because many of Sikhism's holiest sites are in present-day Pakistan, thousands of Sikh pilgrims from India cross the border for Vaisakhi in most years (Pakistan issued more than 2,800 visas for it in April 2026). The main ceremony has traditionally been held at Gurdwara Panja Sahib in Hasan Abdal, in Pakistan's Punjab province. Simran Kaur Gill, the club treasurer, tells Ben that her grandparents in Ludhiana start the day at the gurdwara and spend the afternoon at a fair.

The same mid-April date is also Vishu in Kerala, Puthandu (Tamil New Year) in Tamil Nadu, and Bohag Bihu in Assam. In Sri Lanka, Sinhala and Tamil families celebrate the Sinhala and Tamil New Year on 13 or 14 April. Dilan Perera's family in Kandy waits for the exact auspicious time, set by astrologers, to light the hearth and cook *kiribath* (milk rice), and many neighbors do the same at the same minute.

Pohela Boishakh

Pohela Boishakh (পহেলা বৈশাখ, *po-HEH-la boy-SHAKH*), "the first of Boishakh," is the Bengali New Year. In Bangladesh it is a national holiday on 14 April every year. That date is fixed because Bangladesh revised its version of the Bengali calendar: a committee led by the scholar Muhammad Shahidullah proposed the reform in 1966, and Bangladesh officially adopted it in 1987. In West Bengal and other Indian states, which still use the traditional Bengali calendar, Pohela Boishakh falls on 14 or 15 April. India's 2026 holiday list put "Vaisakhadi (Bengal)" on 15 April.

In Dhaka, the day starts at dawn with songs by the cultural group Chhayanaut in Ramna Park. Students and teachers from the Faculty of Fine Art at the University of Dhaka lead a huge street procession with giant masks

and floats. That tradition began in 1989, when students under military rule wanted to bring people hope, and UNESCO added it to its intangible heritage list in 2016 as Mangal Shobhajatra. Its official name was changed in 2025 and debated again in 2026, so you may hear it called by different names.

Shopkeepers close the old year's accounts and open new account books, a custom called *haal khata*. In recent decades many families in Dhaka have also made *panta bhat* (cooked rice soaked overnight in water) part of the day's breakfast.

Whose Story?

Who invented the Bengali year? Many Bangladeshi textbooks and writers credit the Mughal emperor Akbar, who in the 1500s wanted a calendar that matched the harvest so taxes could be collected after the crops came in. Other historians point to older Bengali rulers, and to temple inscriptions that suggest a Bengali year was counted before Akbar's time. Some writers stress the festival's roots in Hindu solar new year traditions, while in Bangladesh it is also celebrated as a shared, secular Bengali holiday by Muslims, Hindus, Buddhists and Christians alike. The date also differs across the border. Dhaka celebrates on the 14th every year, while Kolkata sometimes celebrates on the 15th, because the two cities now use different versions of the same calendar.

Pongal and Makar Sankranti

Pongal and Makar Sankranti are winter harvest festivals that mark the sun's move into Makara (Capricorn in the Indian zodiac), usually on 14 or 15 January. India's 2026 holiday list put both on 14 January. Because they follow the sun, they're among the most predictable dates in the South Asian year.

Pongal (பொங்கல், *PONG-gul*), "boiling over," is the Tamil harvest festival, held over three or four days at the start of the Tamil month of Thai. On the main day, families cook rice with milk and jaggery (unrefined cane sugar) in a new

pot outdoors until it boils over, and everyone shouts "Pongalo pongal!" On Mattu Pongal, cattle are bathed, their horns painted and garlanded, to thank them for their work. Tamil communities in Sri Lanka celebrate Thai Pongal too.

Makar Sankranti (मकर संक्रांति) is the name used in much of India for the same solar moment. In Gujarat it's a kite festival called Uttarayan; in Assam it's Magh Bihu; in Nepal it is Maghe Sankranti. In Punjab, the bonfire festival Lohri falls the night before, usually on 13 January, and Hindus, Sikhs and some Muslims also mark it in rural Pakistani Punjab and in cities such as Lahore and Faisalabad.

Onam

Onam (ഓണം, *OH-num*) is the harvest festival of Kerala, celebrated by Malayali families of many faiths. It falls in the Malayalam month of Chingam (August to September), on the day of the star Thiruvonam. In 2026, India's holiday list put Thiru Onam on 26 August. In Kerala tradition, Onam is when the generous king Mahabali, who once ruled Kerala, returns each year to visit his people. Families make a *pookalam*, a round carpet of flower petals at the doorway, and share a *sadya*, a feast of many dishes served on a banana leaf. In some towns, long snake boats race on the backwaters. Onam's date depends on both a solar month and the moon's position among the stars, so it moves around within late August and September.

Nowruz

Nowruz (نوروز, *noh-ROOZ*), "new day," is the Persian New Year, which begins at the March equinox, on 20 or 21 March. In Afghanistan, where it's called Nawruz, it was long the start of the official calendar year. Families prepare *haft mewa*, a dish of seven dried fruits and nuts soaked in water, and the biggest celebrations took place at Mazar-i-Sharif, where a banner-raising ceremony drew crowds from across the country. After the Taliban took power

in 2021, their government stopped observing Nowruz as an official holiday in 2022, while saying people could celebrate privately. In India, Parsi and Irani families, who trace their roots to Iran, also celebrate Navroz. UNESCO lists Nowruz as shared heritage of many countries; its 2024 listing includes Afghanistan, India and Pakistan.

7.7 Full Moons and Mountain New Years

Vesak

Vesak (Sinhala වෙසක්, *VAY-suck*), also called Buddha Purnima in India and Nepal, is the most important Buddhist festival in South Asia. It falls on the full moon of the month of Vesak (Vaisakha), usually in May, and Buddhists in South Asia remember the Buddha's birth, enlightenment and passing away all on this one day. In 1999 the United Nations General Assembly formally recognized the Day of Vesak.

In Sri Lanka, Vesak is a two-day national celebration. Streets glow with colored paper lanterns called *Vesak kudu*, and huge electrically lit panels called *pandols* (or *thoranas*) tell Jataka tales, stories of the Buddha's earlier lives. Many people set up free food stalls for anyone passing by, and the sale of alcohol and meat is usually stopped for the celebrations. In Sri Lanka every full-moon day, called Poya, is a public holiday, and Vesak Poya is the biggest of them. Dilan's family visits the temple in Kandy dressed in white. Nepal, where Lumbini (traditionally the Buddha's birthplace) lies, celebrates Buddha Jayanti, and Buddhists in Bangladesh, Bhutan and India also mark the day. In 2026, India's holiday list put Buddha Purnima on 1 May.

Losar

Losar (Tibetan ལོ་གསར་, *LOH-sar*), "new year," is the new year of the Tibetan lunisolar calendar, usually in February or March, celebrated for up to 15 days

with the main celebrations in the first three. In Bhutan it is called Dawa Dangpa Losar. It is also celebrated by Sherpa, Tibetan and other Himalayan communities in Nepal and by people in Ladakh and Sikkim in India. Families clean their homes thoroughly beforehand, make special foods, visit monasteries and hang new prayer flags.

Nepal is a good reminder that one festival name can cover several dates. Nima Sherpa's family in Solukhumbu celebrates Gyalpo Losar, the Tibetan-calendar new year, in February or March. The Tamang community's Sonam Lhosar usually comes about a month earlier (19 January in 2026), and the Gurung community's Tamu Lhosar falls in late December or early January. Tamu Lhosar is a public holiday in Nepal.

7.8 Christmas in South Asia

Christmas in South Asia is the celebration of the birth of Jesus on 25 December by the region's Christian communities. Christianity in South Asia goes back a long way. Christians in Kerala trace their church to the apostle Thomas, who in their tradition arrived on India's southwest coast in the first century. According to India's 2011 census, about 2.3% of Indians, roughly 28 million people, were Christian. Kerala has the largest Christian population of any Indian state, and Christians are the majority in the northeastern states of Nagaland, Mizoram and Meghalaya. Goa has a long Catholic history from the centuries of Portuguese rule, and many families there go to midnight Mass on Christmas Eve.

Christmas is a public holiday in India. In Bangladesh it is called Borodin (বড়দিন, *BOH-roh-din*), "the big day." In Pakistan, 25 December is a public holiday for two reasons: Christmas, and Quaid-e-Azam Day, the birthday of Muhammad Ali Jinnah, Pakistan's founder. Christians in Sri Lanka, both Sinhala- and Tamil-speaking, celebrate with church services and family

gatherings. Because Christmas follows the Gregorian calendar, which is solar, it's the easiest date on Ben's calendar.

You can read any calendar now

Notice the pattern: the sun-based festivals (Vaisakhi, Pohela Boishakh, Pongal, Nowruz, Christmas) are the ones you could predict years ahead, and now you know why.

7.9 The Whole Year at a Glance

Here is the full list, sorted by calendar type. The 2026 dates come from the Government of India's holiday list for central government offices in Delhi (where it lists the festival); dates in other countries can differ by a day or more.

Festival	Calendar	Usual time of year	2026 date in India's holiday list	Celebrated in (examples)
Pongal and Makar Sankranti	Solar	14-15 January	14 January	India, Sri Lanka (Tamil communities), Nepal (Maghe Sankranti)
Losar	Lunisolar	February-March	Not listed	Bhutan, Nepal, India (Ladakh, Sikkim)

Festival	Calendar	Usual time of year	2026 date in India's holiday list	Celebrated in (examples)
Holi	Lunisolar	Late February–March	4 March	India, Nepal, Hindu communities in Pakistan and Bangladesh
Nowruz	Solar	20–21 March	Not listed in March (Parsi New Year listed 15 August)	Afghanistan, Parsi communities in India
Vaisakhi	Solar	13–14 April	14 April	India and Pakistan (Punjab), Sikh communities worldwide
Pohela Boishakh	Solar	14 April (Bangladesh); 14–15 April (India)	15 April	Bangladesh, West Bengal, Tripura and Assam
Vesak	Lunisolar	April–May full moon	1 May	Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bhutan, Bangladesh, India

Festival	Calendar	Usual time of year	2026 date in India's holiday list	Celebrated in (examples)
Onam	Solar month, star day	Late August–September	26 August	Kerala and Malayali communities
Navaratri and Durga Puja	Lunisolar	September–October	Dussehra 20 October	India, Bangladesh
Dashain	Lunisolar	September–October	Not listed (Nepal)	Nepal, Bhutan, parts of India
Diwali and Tihar	Lunisolar	October–November	8 November	India, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Pakistan, Bangladesh
Christmas	Solar	25 December	25 December	Christian communities across South Asia
Ramadan	Lunar	Moves through all seasons	Not listed (computed: about 19 February to 20 March)	Muslim communities across South Asia

Festival	Calendar	Usual time of year	2026 date in India's holiday list	Celebrated in (examples)
Eid al-Fitr	Lunar	Moves through all seasons	21 March	Muslim communities across South Asia
Eid al-Adha	Lunar	Moves through all seasons	28 May (moved from 27 May)	Muslim communities across South Asia
Ashura	Lunar	Moves through all seasons	26 June (listed as Muharram)	Pakistan, India, Bangladesh, Afghanistan

India's holiday list also puts "Parsi New Year's Day" in August, not March, because many Parsi families in India also follow a traditional Zoroastrian calendar whose new year now falls in late summer.

Diagram: Festival Wheel

Festival Wheel: Why Do Dates Move?

Drag the Year slider. Watch which festivals move, and how far. Click a dot.

Eid al-Fitr

Lunar: about 11 days earlier each year

In 2026: about 21 March

Next year: about 10 March, 11 days earlier.

Where: Muslim communities across South Asia. A public holiday in Pakistan, Bangladesh, India and elsewhere.

Why it moves: It begins when the new moon of Shawwal is seen, so the exact day can differ by country.

Key

- Solar: same date every year
- Lunisolar: moves within a season
- Lunar: about 11 days earlier each year

Computed dates are approximate. Local calendars and moon sighting set the real day.

Play years | Year: 2026

Color by calendar type | Eid al-Fitr

☑ Show Islamic dates from the past 4 years

Back to Festival Wheel Lesson Plan

Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch07-festival-wheel/main.html

Open the Festival Wheel fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Festival Wheel

sim-id: ch07-festival-wheel
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: explain
Learning Objective: The learner will explain why solar festivals keep the same Gregorian date, lunisolar festivals move within a season, and Islamic lunar festivals move about 11 days earlier each year.

Canvas: responsive width; 620 px drawing area plus 112 px control area.

Controls: Play years / Pause button, Year slider (1990 to 2060), "Color by" menu (calendar type or faith), festival menu, "Show Islamic dates from the past 4 years" checkbox; click or tap any festival dot or label.

Behavior: A 12-month wheel with 1 January at the top. Solar festivals sit at fixed dates. Diwali, Holi, Navaratri and Vesak are computed each year from new and full moons (Meeus's algorithm) and Hindu month rules; Onam and Losar show their usual windows. Ramadan, the two Eids and Ashura are computed from the Moon and a crescent-visibility rule, so they slide about 11 days earlier each year, with faint dots trailing behind for the past four years. The info panel shows the selected festival's computed date, where it is celebrated, and why it moves. Starts paused, set to 2026.

Start in 2026 and click a few dots to read about them. Then drag the **Year** slider forward one year at a time and watch the three colors. The gold dots (solar festivals) never move. The teal dots (lunisolar festivals) hop back and forth, but Holi always stays in spring and Diwali always stays in autumn. The orange dots (Islamic festivals) march steadily counterclockwise, and the faint trail behind them shows where they were in earlier years.

Now select Eid al-Fitr and press **Play years**. Pause when Eid reaches December. How many years did it take to get there from March? Try the year 2033, when Eid al-Fitr falls twice in one Gregorian year. And notice the small print in the panel: the sim's dates are calculated, so they can be a day off from the date your community actually uses. The Government of India had to move Eid al-Adha in 2026 for the same reason.

Ask Your Elders

> **Your interview for this chapter**
>
> Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about the festivals they grew up with and how they celebrate them now. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Pick a quiet time that isn't the busy day of a festival itself, and ask if it's okay to take notes. If your family has a calendar (a printed panjika, a mosque timetable or a wall calendar from a community center), bring it along.

Questions to ask

1. What was your favorite festival when you were a child? What do you remember about the day?
2. What foods, clothes, sounds or smells do you connect with that festival?
3. How did your family find out the exact date each year? Did anyone check the moon, a printed almanac, a radio announcement or a phone?

4. Which festivals did your neighbors celebrate that your family didn't? Did you join in?
5. How is celebrating in Minnesota (or wherever you live now) different from celebrating back home?
6. What is one festival tradition you hope I keep, and why?

Listen for: whether their festivals follow the Islamic Lunar Calendar or a Lunisolar Calendar, which of this chapter's festivals they mention (Eid al-Fitr, Diwali, Pohela Boishakh, Vaisakhi or others), and stories about how dates were decided.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's description of a festival with the description in this chapter. What did they mention that the chapter left out? If a friend interviewed someone who celebrates a different festival, compare the two: do both families describe new clothes, special food or visiting relatives?

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Diwali is only a Hindu festival.
Reality: Hindus, Sikhs, Jains and some Buddhists all celebrate on the same night, each for their own reasons. For Sikhs it is Bandi Chhor Divas, and for Jains it marks Mahavira's nirvana.

Myth: Eid is "the Muslim Christmas."
Reality: There are two Eids, with different meanings: Eid al-Fitr ends the fasting month of Ramadan, and Eid al-Adha honors Ibrahim's willingness to sacrifice and falls during the Hajj. Neither celebrates anyone's birth, and both move through the year on the lunar calendar.

Myth: Holi is just about throwing colors.
Reality: Holi begins with the Holika Dahan bonfire and carries religious stories (Prahlad, and Radha and Krishna), the welcome of spring, and a tradition of forgiving old quarrels.

Myth: Festivals that follow the moon all move the same way.
Reality: Islamic festivals follow a purely lunar calendar and move about 11 days earlier every year. Lunisolar festivals like Diwali add a leap month every two to three years, so they jump back later and stay in the same season.

Myth: Every festival is celebrated the same way everywhere.
Reality: The same autumn nights are Garba in Gujarat, Durga Puja in Kolkata and Dhaka, Ramlila in North India, and Dashain in Nepal. Even the date of Pohela Boishakh differs between Bangladesh and West Bengal.

Check Yourself

1. What is the difference between a lunar calendar and a lunisolar calendar?

Both count months by the moon. A lunar calendar, like the Islamic calendar, never adds extra months, so its year is about 354 days. A lunisolar calendar adds a leap month every two to three years to stay in step with the sun and the seasons.

2. Why does Eid al-Fitr come about 11 days earlier each year on the Gregorian calendar?

Twelve lunar months add up to about 354 days, roughly 11 days less than a solar year of about 365 days. The Islamic calendar never adds a month to catch up, so each new Eid comes about 11 days earlier.

3. Name the three groups who celebrate on Diwali night and one thing each group remembers.

Many Hindus celebrate light over darkness (Rama's return, Lakshmi puja); Sikhs celebrate Bandi Chhor Divas, Guru Hargobind's release from Gwalior Fort; Jains remember Mahavira's nirvana. Some Buddhists celebrate too.

4. Why is Pohela Boishakh always on 14 April in Bangladesh but sometimes on 15 April in West Bengal?

Bangladesh adopted a revised Bengali calendar in 1987 (based on a 1966 proposal), which fixes the new year on 14 April. West Bengal still uses the traditional calendar, whose new year falls on 14 or 15 April.

5. What is Ashura, and how do Shia and many Sunni Muslims observe it?

Ashura is the 10th of Muharram. For Shia Muslims it is a day of mourning for Husayn, killed at Karbala in 680 CE, with gatherings and processions. Many Sunni Muslims fast on Ashura.

Exercises

Remember

1. List two festivals that follow a solar calendar, two that follow a lunisolar calendar, and two that follow the Islamic Lunar Calendar.

   Answer

   Solar: any two of Vaisakhi, Pohela Boishakh (Bangladesh), Pongal and Makar Sankranti, Nowruz, Christmas. Lunisolar: any two of Diwali, Holi, Navaratri and Durga Puja, Dashain, Vesak, Losar. Lunar: any two of Ramadan, Eid al-Fitr, Eid al-Adha, Ashura.

2. Which festival is celebrated with *jamara* and *tika*, and in which country is it the biggest festival of the year?

   Answer

   Dashain, the biggest and longest festival in Nepal.

Understand

1. Explain why Holi always falls in spring even though it follows the moon.

   Answer

   Holi follows a lunisolar calendar. Every two to three years, a leap month is added so that the lunar months stay lined up with the solar year. That keeps Holi between late February and late March.

2. Explain why many Indian holiday lists say Islamic holiday dates are "subject to change."

Answer

Islamic months traditionally begin when the new crescent moon is sighted. The government prints its list months in advance using an expected date, but the actual sighting can push the holiday a day later, as happened with Eid al-Adha in 2026.

Apply

1. Use the Festival Wheel to find the first year after 2026 when Ramadan begins in January. Then calculate how many years that is after 2026 and check whether it fits the "about 11 days a year" rule. *Hint: count how many days Ramadan's start has to move back from 19 February to reach January.*
2. Your club wants to hold a "festivals of spring" night in April. Using this chapter, list at least four festivals from at least three different countries that could be featured, with a one-line description of each. *Hint: look for festivals that follow the sun into mid-April.*

Analyze

1. Compare how Navaratri is celebrated in Gujarat, Kolkata and Nepal. What stays the same across all three, and what changes? *Hint: think about the dates, the goddess, and what people actually do.*
2. Ben's calendar shows Diwali moving from 20 October 2025 to 8 November 2026, but Eid al-Fitr moving from 31 March 2025 to 21 March 2026. Analyze why one moved later and the other moved earlier. *Hint: what happened in the lunisolar calendar between those two Diwalis?*

Evaluate

1. A school is deciding whether to give students a day off for Diwali, for Eid, or for neither. Evaluate the challenge of fixing those dates a year in advance, and suggest a fair policy. *Hint: consider moon sighting, different communities' dates, and how many students celebrate.*
2. Some people say a festival like Pohela Boishakh or Onam is "cultural, not religious." Others disagree. Using evidence from the chapter, evaluate this claim for one festival. *Hint: the Whose Story? box is a good place to start.*

Create

1. Design your club's festival calendar for the next school year. Include at least eight festivals from at least four countries, the expected date for each, its calendar type, and a note on any date that could shift. *Hint: use the Festival Wheel for computed dates, then check an official holiday list.*
2. Write a short guide (150 to 200 words) for a new club member explaining how to greet friends respectfully during three different festivals, including one that is a day of mourning. *Hint: include Ashura and explain why "happy" is the wrong word for it.*

Key Takeaways

- South Asian festivals follow three kinds of calendar: solar (fixed dates), lunisolar (moves within a season) and lunar (moves through every season).
- The Islamic Lunar Calendar has 12 months and about 354 days, so Ramadan, Eid al-Fitr, Eid al-Adha and Ashura come about 11 days earlier each Gregorian year and circle the whole year in about 33 years.

- Lunisolar calendars add a leap month about every 32.5 months, which keeps Diwali in autumn, Holi in spring and Vesak near May.
- Many festivals are shared across faiths and borders: Diwali by Hindus, Sikhs, Jains and some Buddhists; Pohela Boishakh by Bengalis of every faith; Vesak across five South Asian countries.
- The same season can carry different names and customs: Navaratri, Durga Puja, Dussehra and Dashain; Diwali and Tihar; Vaisakhi, Pohela Boishakh and the Sinhala and Tamil New Year.
- Exact dates depend on local calendars and, for Islamic months, on sighting the moon, so official holiday lists sometimes change, as India's did for Eid al-Adha in 2026.

Your calendar is ready!

You can now explain why Eid moves earlier, why Diwali jumps around, and why Pohela Boishakh stays put. Every festival comes with a feast, so in Chapter 8 we head to the table to see what South Asia eats and why.

Quiz: Festivals Through the Year

Test your understanding of Chapter 7. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

About how long is a year in the Islamic Lunar Calendar?

A. 365 or 366 days

B. 354 or 355 days

C. 384 or 385 days

D. 330 days

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The Islamic calendar has 12 lunar months of about 29.5 days each, which adds up to 354 or 355 days. 365 or 366 days is the length of the solar Gregorian year, and about 384 days is the length of a lunisolar year that includes a leap month.

Concept Tested: Islamic Lunar Calendar **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 2

For Sikhs, the day of Diwali is also celebrated as Bandi Chhor Divas. What does it remember?

A. The founding of the Khalsa by Guru Gobind Singh

B. The birth of Guru Nanak

C. The nirvana of Mahavira

D. The release of Guru Hargobind from Gwalior Fort

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. In Sikh tradition, Bandi Chhor Divas marks Guru Hargobind's release from imprisonment in Gwalior Fort, along with 52 imprisoned kings. The founding of the Khalsa is remembered on Vaisakhi, and Mahavira's nirvana is what Jains remember on Diwali.

Concept Tested: Diwali **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

Which festival does UNESCO list as "Durga Puja in Kolkata," inscribed in 2021?

A. The autumn worship of the goddess Durga, ending with immersion of clay images

B. The spring festival of colors held on the full moon of Phalguna

C. The new year procession held on 14 April in Dhaka

D. The five-day festival of lights in Nepal that honors crows, dogs and cows

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Durga Puja is the autumn festival, part of the Navaratri season, in which communities worship Durga and then immerse the clay images. The spring festival of colors is Holi, the Dhaka procession is part of Pohela Boishakh, and the five-day festival in Nepal is Tihar.

Concept Tested: Navaratri and Durga Puja **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 4

Why does Diwali stay in October or November every year, even though it follows the moon?

A. Because the Indian government fixes the date by law each year

B. Because it is set by the sun entering Capricorn

C. Because a lunisolar calendar adds a leap month every two to three years to keep in step with the sun

D. Because the moon's cycle is exactly one-twelfth of a solar year

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Diwali follows a lunisolar calendar, which adds an extra month about every 32.5 months so the lunar months don't drift away from the seasons. The government publishes holiday lists but doesn't decide the festival's date, and the sun entering Capricorn is the moment for Makar Sankranti and Pongal, not Diwali.

Concept Tested: Lunisolar Calendar **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 5

Why do Shia Muslims and many Sunni Muslims observe Ashura differently?

A. Shia Muslims celebrate it as a new year party, while Sunnis ignore it

B. For Shia Muslims it is a day of mourning for Husayn, killed at Karbala, while many Sunnis observe it mainly by fasting

C. Sunnis mourn Husayn, while Shia Muslims fast to remember Moses

D. It falls on different months for the two groups

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Ashura, the 10th of Muharram, is the most solemn day of the year for Shia Muslims, who mourn Husayn and his companions killed at Karbala in 680 CE. Many Sunnis also regard his death as a tragedy but mark the day mainly by fasting. Ashura is not a celebration for either group, and both observe it on the same date, the 10th of Muharram.

Concept Tested: Ashura **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 6

Why is Pohela Boishakh fixed on 14 April in Bangladesh?

A. Bangladesh officially adopted a revised Bengali calendar (adopted in 1987, based on a 1966 proposal) that fixes the new year on that date

B. The date is set by the first sighting of the new moon in April

C. It is the day the Mughal emperor Akbar was born

D. It always falls on the full moon of Boishakh

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. A committee led by Muhammad Shahidullah proposed a revised calendar in 1966, and Bangladesh officially adopted it in 1987, fixing the new year on 14 April. West Bengal still uses the traditional calendar, so there it falls on 14 or 15 April. The date isn't based on the moon at all, because the Bengali calendar follows the sun.

Concept Tested: Pohela Boishakh **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 7

Eid al-Fitr fell on 21 March 2026 in India. About when would you expect it to fall in 2027?

A. About 21 March 2027, the same date

B. About 1 April 2027, 11 days later

C. About 21 February 2027, one month earlier

D. About 10 March 2027, 11 days earlier

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The Islamic year is about 11 days shorter than the solar year, so Islamic festivals arrive about 11 days earlier each Gregorian year. Staying on the same date is what a solar festival does, and the Islamic calendar never adds a leap month that could push Eid later.

Concept Tested: Eid al-Fitr **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

Your club is planning an event for the week of 13 to 15 April. Which group of festivals could you feature, all from that week?

A. Diwali, Tihar and Kali Puja

B. Pongal, Lohri and Makar Sankranti

C. Vaisakhi, Pohela Boishakh and the Sinhala and Tamil New Year

D. Holi, Losar and Onam

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Vaisakhi, Pohela Boishakh and the Sinhala and Tamil New Year are all solar new years that mark the sun entering Mesha (Aries) in mid-April. Pongal, Lohri and Makar Sankranti are in mid-January, and Diwali, Tihar and Kali Puja fall in October or November.

Concept Tested: Vaisakhi **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Ben notices that Diwali moved from 20 October 2025 to 8 November 2026, while Eid al-Fitr moved from 31 March 2025 to 21 March 2026. What best explains the difference?

A. Both follow the moon, but the Hindu calendar added a leap month in 2026, pushing Diwali later, while the Islamic calendar never adds one

B. Diwali follows the sun and Eid follows the moon

C. The Indian government moved Diwali to a weekend

D. Eid is decided by moon sighting, but Diwali is chosen by a vote each year

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Both festivals follow lunar months. The Hindu lunisolar calendar inserted an extra month (Adhik Jyeshtha) in May and June 2026, so Diwali jumped about 19 days later. The purely lunar Islamic calendar never adds a month, so Eid kept sliding about 10 to 11 days earlier. Option B is wrong because Diwali does not follow the sun.

Concept Tested: Lunisolar Calendar **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

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Question 10

A friend from Kathmandu talks about Dashain, a friend from Kolkata about Durga Puja, and a friend from Ahmedabad about Navaratri and Garba. What is the best conclusion?

A. These are three unrelated festivals held in different seasons

B. Only one of them is a "real" Hindu festival

C. They fall in the same autumn season and honor the goddess, but local customs differ a lot

D. They are identical in every way, just with different names

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. All three belong to the autumn Navaratri season tied to the goddess and the tenth day, Vijayadashami. But the customs differ: jamara and tika from elders in Nepal, clay images and pandals in Bengal, and Garba dancing in Gujarat. No version is more "real" than the others, and they are not identical.

Concept Tested: Dashain and Tihar **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 8: Food and the Table

Summary

There is no single "South Asian food." What people eat depends on which grain grows near them, how much rain falls, which traders and rulers passed through, and what their faith and family teach about food. This chapter starts with the staple grains and the regional cuisines built on them, then opens up a thali to look at its parts: dal, masala, tadka, breads and rice. It follows biryani, chili peppers and chai through history, visits street stalls and sweet shops, and ends at the table itself, with food rules, eating with hands and the customs of hospitality.

Concepts Covered

1. Staple Grains
2. Regional Cuisines
3. Thali
4. Masala
5. Tadka
6. Dal
7. Roti and Naan
8. Biryani
9. Columbian Exchange

10. Chai
11. Street Food
12. Mithai
13. Dietary Rules and Faith
14. Vegetarianism in South Asia
15. Halal
16. Eating With Hands
17. Hospitality Customs

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia? for the rivers, plains, deltas and monsoon that decide which crops grow where.
- Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters for the Mughals and the traders who arrived by sea.
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia for the faiths whose teachings shape many food rules.
- Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year for the feasts and fasts that go with the calendar.

Pull up a chair

Food is often the first thing friends ask about, and the last tradition people let go of after they move far from home. If you've ever had to explain your lunch at school, or wondered why your family cooks the way it does, this chapter gives you the words and the history. Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

8.1 "Your Plate Is Missing Something"

The South Asian Student Association's first potluck is set up on three folding tables in the Prairie Ridge cafeteria. Ben Lindqvist, who has been looking forward to this all week, takes a paper plate and puts a little of everything on it: a piece of naan, two samosas, a spoonful of chickpeas, a scoop of butter chicken, and one gulab jamun soaking through the plate.

He sits down proudly next to Zara Hossain and three other club members. Ayesha Qureshi, whose family is from Lahore, looks at his plate and says, "Where's the raita? And you need a proper biryani, not just bread." Arjun Reddy, whose family is from Hyderabad, shakes his head: "No rice? And no pickle? That's not a meal." Dilan Perera, whose family is from Kandy in Sri Lanka, laughs. "Where's the rice and curry? Where's the coconut sambol?"

Ben looks at Zara for help. She shrugs. "At my Nanu's table it would be rice, dal and fish. Every time." Ben stares at his plate. "Okay. So which one of you has the *real* South Asian meal?"

That's the question this chapter answers.

8.2 Start With the Grain

Think about food in the United States. A barbecue in Texas, a crab feast in Maryland, a hotdish at a church supper in Minnesota and a plate of tamales in New Mexico are all "American food," but nobody would call any one of them the only real version. Each grew from what was easy to farm or catch nearby, who settled there, and what they brought with them. South Asia works the same way, on a bigger scale, with about 1.99 billion people (2025, World Bank).

The best place to start is the grain. **Staple Grains** are the grains a community eats nearly every day and builds most meals around. In South Asia there are three big families of them.

- **Rice** needs warm weather and lots of water. It grows best in the wet, low lands that the monsoon soaks every summer: the Ganga-Brahmaputra delta in Bangladesh and eastern India, the coasts of southern India, Sri Lanka's paddy fields, and the terraced valleys of Nepal and Bhutan. In Bangla, cooked rice is ভাত (*BHAHT*), and a meal without it can feel incomplete to many Bengali families.
- **Wheat** prefers cooler, drier winters. It grows on the irrigated plains of the Indus and its tributaries in Pakistan and northwest India, and in Afghanistan. Here bread, not rice, sits at the center of most meals.
- **Millets** are small, hardy grains such as pearl millet (bajra), sorghum (jowar) and finger millet (ragi). They grow in dry places with poor soil and little water, like parts of Gujarat, Rajasthan, the Deccan Plateau and the hills of Nepal. The United Nations named 2023 the International Year of Millets, at India's suggestion, to draw attention to grains that can handle a changing climate.

These lines are not neat. Many families in central India eat both rice and wheat. In the high hills of Nepal, where rice is hard to grow, many people have long eaten dhido, a thick porridge made from millet, maize or buckwheat flour. Still, if you know a family's staple grain, you can often guess a lot about the rest of their meal.

Look back at the map

Remember the monsoon from Chapter 1? Rice country lines up closely with the places that get the heaviest summer rain. Before you read on, guess which grain Zara's family in Chattogram eats most, and which one Ayesha's family in Lahore does.

8.3 Regional Cuisines: One Region, Many Kitchens

A **Regional Cuisine** is the style of cooking that grows up in one area, shaped by its grain, its climate, its coast or mountains, its history of trade, and the communities who live there. South Asia has dozens of them, and borders drawn in 1947 or 1971 often run right through them. Punjabi food is eaten on both sides of the India-Pakistan border, and Bengali food in both Bangladesh and India's West Bengal.

Here are a few regional cuisines from across the eight countries. The table shows only a handful, and every family cooks a little differently.

Region	Country	Staple	A few well-known foods	What shapes it
Punjab	Pakistan and India	Wheat	Roti, chickpeas, mustard greens with maize bread, lassi	Irrigated wheat plains, dairy cattle, cool winters

Region	Country	Staple	A few well-known foods	What shapes it
Sindh	Pakistan	Rice and wheat	Sindhi biryani, sai bhaji (greens with lentils)	The lower Indus valley, a hot, dry climate
Bengal	Bangladesh and India	Rice	Fish such as ilish (hilsa), red lentils, sweets made from milk	A wet river delta full of fish
Gujarat	India	Wheat, rice, millet	Sweet-and-sour dal, steamed snacks like dhokla	Dry land, and strong vegetarian traditions
Kerala	India	Rice	Coconut, fish curries, avial, banana-leaf feasts	Heavy rain, coconut palms, the old pepper trade
Sri Lanka	Sri Lanka	Rice	Rice and curry,	Island climate,

Region	Country	Staple	A few well-known foods	What shapes it
			hoppers, pol sambol, kottu	coconut, cinnamon, many trading partners
Nepal hills	Nepal	Rice, maize, millet	Dal bhat tarkari, gundruk (fermented greens), momos	Mountain farming, terraces, trade with Tibet
Bhutan	Bhutan	Red rice	Ema datshi (chili and cheese stew)	Himalayan valleys, dairy from cows and yaks
Maldives	Maldives	Rice, flatbread	Mas huni (tuna, coconut, chili, lime)	Coral islands surrounded by tuna fishing grounds
Afghanistan	Afghanistan	Wheat, rice	Naan, qabili palaw (rice with	Dry mountains and valleys,

Region	Country	Staple	A few well-known foods	What shapes it
			carrots, raisins and meat)	Central Asian trade routes

Notice how often the sea or the river shows up. Bengal, Kerala, Sri Lanka and the Maldives all eat a lot of fish. Bangladesh lists the ilish as its national fish and catches most of the world's supply. In dry, inland places, dairy, lentils and grains carry more of the meal.

8.4 The Thali: A Whole Meal on One Plate

If you want to see a regional cuisine at a glance, look at a thali. A **Thali** (थाली, *TAH-lee*, "plate") is a large round plate, usually metal, holding a complete meal: a staple in the middle and several small dishes around it. The small bowls along the edge are called katori (कटोरी, *ka-TOH-ree*, "small bowl"). The word "thali" means both the plate and the meal served on it.

A typical thali tries to balance flavors and textures: something soft and something crisp, something sour, something salty, something mildly bitter and something sweet. A Gujarati family might call their everyday thali "dal, bhat, rotli, shaak": lentils, rice, thin wheat bread and a vegetable dish. A festive Gujarati thali can hold more than a dozen items.

The same idea shows up across the region under other names.

- In Kerala, a festival feast called a sadya is served on a banana leaf instead of a plate. Rice sits in the middle, and a long row of vegetarian

dishes is placed in set spots on the leaf. Sadyas are cooked for the harvest festival Onam (see Chapter 7), for Vishu and for weddings.

- In Nepal, the everyday meal is dal bhat tarkari: lentil soup, rice and a vegetable curry, often with a sharp pickle on the side.
- In Sri Lanka, "rice and curry" means a mound of rice with several small curries around it, made from vegetables, lentils, fish or meat, plus a sambol (a fresh relish).
- In Bangladesh and West Bengal, a family meal is often rice with dal, a vegetable dish or mashed vegetables, and fish, with sweet yogurt or a sweet to finish when there are guests.

A thali is a useful tool for comparing cuisines because it has slots. Every region fills the "staple," "lentil," "vegetable," "main" and "sweet" slots, but with different foods. The Thali Builder MicroSim later in this chapter works the same way.

8.5 The Building Blocks: Dal, Masala and Tadka

Open the katori on almost any thali and you'll find three building blocks that most South Asian kitchens share.

Dal

Dal (दाल, *DAHL*) means split pulses, the dried seeds of plants like lentils, peas and beans, and also the soupy or thick dish made from them. Red lentils (masoor), yellow split pigeon peas (toor), split mung beans (moong), black gram (urad) and split chickpeas (chana) are all dals. Pulses are cheap, keep for a long time and are full of protein, which matters a lot in a region where many people eat little or no meat.

Every region makes dal its own way. A Gujarati dal is thin and often a little sweet and sour, with jaggery (unrefined cane sugar) or a squeeze of lemon. A Bengali masoor dal is light and fragrant. Punjabi cooks slow-cook whole black urad; the rich restaurant version, dal makhani, with butter and cream, is usually credited to Punjabi cooks in Delhi in the 1950s who had moved from Peshawar after Partition. In Nepal, cooks flavor dal with jimbu, a dried Himalayan herb fried in ghee. In Sri Lanka, red-lentil parippu is often cooked with coconut milk.

Masala

Masala (मसाला, *ma-SAH-lah*) means "spices" or "seasoning," and it usually refers to a mixture of spices, whole or ground. Garam masala, for example, is a warm blend that often includes cinnamon, cloves, cardamom, cumin and black pepper, though the mix changes by region and by family; in Bengal and Bangladesh it may be just cardamom, cinnamon and cloves. A masala can also be a wet paste of onion, ginger, garlic, tomato and spices that forms the base of a dish.

There's no single correct masala. Cooks change the mix to fit the dish, the season and their own taste. Some families still roast and grind their own; others buy ready-made blends. Notice, too, that a spice mixture is about *flavor*, not just heat. Cumin, coriander, turmeric, cardamom and fennel aren't hot at all.

Curry is not one dish

The English word "curry" probably comes from the Tamil word *kari*, a spiced dish eaten with rice. British traders used it for hundreds of different dishes, and "curry powder" was a blend sold mostly to Europeans. In South Asia, people usually call a dish by its own name: dal, korma, sambar, jhol, karahi.

Tadka

Tadka (तड़का, *TUD-kah*) is a cooking step called "tempering" in English: whole spices, and sometimes garlic, dried chili or curry leaves, are fried for a few seconds in hot oil or ghee (clarified butter) and then poured, sizzling, over a finished dish. The hot fat pulls flavor out of the spices and carries it through the food. It goes by many names: chhaunk in parts of north India, baghaar in Urdu, vaghar in Gujarati, and phoron in Bangla.

Each region has favorite tadka spices:

- Many South Indian and Sri Lankan cooks use black mustard seeds and curry leaves.
- Bengali and Bangladeshi cooks often use **panch phoron**, a "five-spice" mix of whole seeds: fenugreek, cumin, nigella, black mustard and fennel.
- Gujarati cooks often add a pinch of asafoetida (hing), a strong-smelling resin, along with mustard and cumin.
- Punjabi and Pakistani cooks often use cumin, onion, garlic and dried red chili.

Tadka is a good example of how the same technique can taste completely different from one kitchen to the next. Ask anyone who cooks at home what goes into their tadka, and you'll learn a lot about their region.

8.6 Breads and Rice Dishes: Roti, Naan and Biryani

Roti and naan

In wheat country, bread is the staple. **Roti and Naan** are the two names most people outside South Asia know, and they are not the same thing.

Roti (रोटी, *ROH-tee*) is a flat, unleavened bread made from whole-wheat flour (atta) and water and cooked on a flat griddle called a tava. It's also called chapati or phulka, and in Pakistan and Bangladesh a similar thin bread is also simply "roti." For many families in northern India and Pakistan, roti is eaten at nearly every meal, torn by hand and used to scoop up dal and vegetables. "Roti" can even mean "food" or "a living," the way "bread" sometimes does in English.

Naan (नान, Urdu نان, *NAHN*) comes from the Persian word *nan*, which simply means "bread." It is usually made from white flour, leavened (allowed to rise), and slapped onto the inside wall of a tandoor, a very hot clay oven. The earliest mention of naan in South Asia is in the memoirs of the poet Amir Khusrau, in the 1300s. Because few homes have a tandoor, naan in India is mostly a restaurant or special-occasion bread. In Afghanistan and in Pakistani cities, though, naan from a neighborhood tandoor bakery is an everyday bread.

Other breads fill out the picture: paratha (layered, pan-fried bread), puri (puffed, deep-fried bread), bajra rotla (millet bread) in Gujarat, the Maldivian roshi, and the godamba roti of Sri Lanka.

Biryani

Biryani (Urdu بریانی, *bir-YAH-nee*) is a dish of rice layered and slow-cooked with meat (or vegetables), yogurt and spices, often with saffron. The word comes from the Persian *biryan*, "fried" or "roasted." A biryani record appears in the *Ain-i-Akbari*, an account of the Mughal emperor Akbar's court written in the 1590s, which lists it alongside pilau.

Historians don't agree on where biryani was born. Some argue it developed in the Mughal court kitchens, where Persian rice cooking met the spicier rice dishes of the subcontinent. Others think rice-and-meat dishes from Persia

had already reached the Deccan in the south before the Mughals. Either way, biryani spread and changed everywhere it went:

- **Hyderabadi biryani** (India) is one of the best-known styles; in 2009 Hyderabad's biryani makers even tried, and failed, to get an official place-of-origin tag for it.
- **Kolkata biryani** includes potato, a habit linked to the court of Wajid Ali Shah, the last king of Awadh, who was exiled to Kolkata in 1856 with his cooks and musicians.
- **Sindhi biryani** (Pakistan), one of the most popular dishes in the country, adds potatoes, tomatoes and yogurt to meat or fish and rice.
- **Kacchi biryani** with mutton is the classic wedding dish of Old Dhaka in Bangladesh.

Biryani shows how a dish can belong to many places at once, which comes up again in the Whose Story? box below.

8.7 Chili Peppers and the Columbian Exchange

South Asian cooking had no chili peppers until about 500 years ago, which surprises a lot of people.

Chili peppers come from the Americas. So do potatoes, tomatoes, maize (corn), peanuts, cashews, pineapples and papaya. After Christopher Columbus crossed the Atlantic in 1492, plants, animals, people and diseases began moving between the Americas and the rest of the world. Historian Alfred Crosby named this the **Columbian Exchange** in a 1972 book. It changed diets around the world: wheat and cattle went to the Americas, and corn, potatoes and chilies went to Europe, Africa and Asia.

The Portuguese reached India by sea in 1498 and took the port of Goa in 1510. Their ships carried chili peppers from Brazil, and by the 1500s chilies were growing in Goa. Chilies were easy to grow and cheaper than black pepper, the region's older source of heat, so farmers and cooks across the subcontinent took them up. Within a few centuries chilies were everywhere.

Think about how deep that change went:

- Bhutan's national dish, ema datshi, is basically chilies cooked in cheese. Before chilies arrived, Bhutanese cooks seasoned food with other local plants.
- Punjab's winter favorite, sarson da saag (mustard greens) with makki di roti, is eaten with a bread made from maize, another American crop.
- Potatoes appear in Kolkata and Sindhi biryani, in Gujarati vegetable dishes and in countless street snacks.
- Tomatoes now form the base of many masala pastes.

None of this makes these foods "less South Asian." Cooks took new ingredients and made them their own, just as Mexican and Italian cooks did.

8.8 Chai: How Tea Became Everyone's Drink

Chai (चाय, Urdu چائے, *CHAI*) just means "tea." In much of South Asia it means black tea boiled with milk and sugar, and often spiced with cardamom, ginger, cinnamon, cloves or black pepper (that spiced version is masala chai). Today a cup of chai is offered to guests, sold at railway stations and roadside stalls from Karachi to Kolkata, and drunk at nearly every break in the day.

Many people assume chai is thousands of years old, but it isn't. Tea plants grew wild in the hills of Assam, but for most of history most people in the

region did not drink tea as an everyday drink. The change came in steps:

1. **The 1830s:** The British East India Company wanted to stop depending on China, which controlled the world tea trade. It began growing tea on plantations in Assam. British planters later spread tea to Darjeeling and the Nilgiri hills, and from 1867 to Ceylon (Sri Lanka), where tea replaced coffee after a plant disease wiped out the coffee estates. Plantation work was hard and poorly paid, and many workers were brought in under harsh labor contracts.
2. **By 1900:** Tea from India and Ceylon had largely replaced Chinese tea in Britain. Almost all of it was grown for export.
3. **The early 1900s to the 1940s:** The Indian Tea Association, run by British planters, set out to sell tea to Indians too. It paid salesmen to visit grocers, set up tea stalls at factories, mines and railway stations, and later sent sellers door to door. The campaign took off in the 1930s.
4. **The result:** People did start drinking tea, but they made it their own way, with lots of milk, sugar and spices, and fewer tea leaves than the planters hoped.

So chai is both a product of colonial business and a very South Asian creation. Sri Lanka still exports "Ceylon tea," Bangladesh grows tea in the Sylhet hills where commercial planting began in 1857, and in Pakistan and Bangladesh the tea stall is a meeting place for friends, workers and arguments about cricket and politics.

8.9 Street Food and Mithai

Street food

Street Food is food made and sold by vendors at stalls, carts and tiny shops, eaten standing up or on the go. It's often cheap and fast, and it's one of the

things people miss most after they move abroad.

One snack shows how street food changes from city to city: a hollow, crisp ball of fried dough filled with potato or chickpeas and dipped in spiced, tangy water. In Mumbai and much of India, and in Nepal, it's called panipuri. In Delhi and Pakistan it's golgappa. In Kolkata and Bangladesh it's phuchka, often sour and very spicy, and in Bangladesh it's filled with chotpoti and topped with egg. Phuchka even crossed oceans: by 2018 a Bangladeshi immigrant was selling it from a cart in Jackson Heights, New York City.

Many other street foods belong to a family called chaat (चाट, *CHAHT*), from the Hindi word for "lick," because they're tangy, sweet and spicy all at once. And street food goes far beyond chaat:

- **Sri Lanka:** kottu roti, chopped flatbread stir-fried on a hot griddle with vegetables, egg or meat. It began as an inexpensive street meal in eastern Sri Lanka in the 1960s or 1970s.
- **Nepal:** momos, steamed dumplings filled with meat or vegetables and served with a tomato-based achar.
- **Pakistan:** nihari, a slow-cooked meat stew whose name comes from the Arabic *nahar* (daytime) because it was first eaten as a morning meal, became a Karachi favorite after 1947, when migrants from north India opened restaurants there.
- **India and Bangladesh:** samosas, pakoras, and endless fried and grilled snacks.

Mithai

Mithai (मिठाई, *mi-THAI*) is the word for South Asian sweets, the kind sold in sweet shops and boxed for guests. In Bangla, sweets are মিষ্টি (*MISH-tee*). Many mithai are made from milk: fresh cheese curds (chhena), milk boiled

down until thick (khoa), or sweet yogurt. Others use chickpea flour, nuts, semolina or jaggery.

Some well-known examples:

- Gulab jamun: fried milk-dough balls in rose-scented syrup.
- Rasgulla (roshogolla in Bangla): spongy balls of chhena cooked in light syrup.
- Mishti doi: sweet set yogurt, a specialty of Bogura (Bogra) in Bangladesh and of West Bengal.
- Barfi and ladoo: dense squares and balls of milk, nuts or chickpea flour.
- Sel roti: a ring-shaped sweet bread of rice flour fried for the Nepali festivals Dashain and Tihar.
- Watalappam: a Sri Lankan coconut and jaggery custard linked to the island's Malay community.

Mithai are tied to big moments. Families hand out sweets for good exam results, new babies, weddings, Eid and Diwali, and a box of sweets is one of the most common gifts when visiting someone's home.

Whose Story?

Who does a dish belong to? In 2017 India's registry of Geographical Indications (labels that tie a product to a place) gave West Bengal a tag for "Banglar Rasogolla," and in 2019 it gave Odisha one for "Odisha Rasagola." Many people in Odisha trace the sweet to offerings at the Jagannath temple in Puri, while many in Bengal credit a Kolkata confectioner, Nobin Chandra Das, in the 1860s, and food historians still disagree about how much evidence supports each story. Biryani's origin is debated in a similar way: some historians credit the Mughal court, others earlier Persian travelers to the Deccan, and Hyderabad, Lucknow, Kolkata, Karachi and Dhaka each defend their own version. The two tags went to two *different versions* of the sweet and did not settle which one came first.

8.10 Food and Faith

Food in South Asia is closely tied to religion, and many families follow rules about what, when and with whom to eat. **Dietary Rules and Faith** is the name for those rules: the foods a tradition asks its followers to avoid, the ways food must be prepared, and the days for fasting and feasting. Practices vary a great deal, even inside one faith and one family, so the examples below say "many" on purpose.

Ask, don't assume

You can't tell what someone eats from their name, faith or country. If you're hosting, the polite move is simple: ask your guests if there's anything they don't eat, and label dishes at a potluck.

Vegetarianism in South Asia

Vegetarianism in South Asia refers to diets without meat (and often without fish or eggs), which are more common here than almost anywhere else in the world. But "most South Asians are vegetarian" is a myth. A large Pew Research Center survey of nearly 30,000 adults in India, carried out in 2019-2020 and published in 2021, found:

Group (India)	Say they are vegetarian
All adults	39%
Jains	92%
Hindus	44%
Christians	10%
Muslims	8%

The same survey found that 81% of Indian adults limit meat in some way, for example by avoiding certain meats or not eating meat on certain days. People defined "vegetarian" for themselves, and the answers varied by region: among Hindus, vegetarianism was much rarer in the east (18%), northeast (19%) and south (30%) than in the north and west. So most people in India eat some meat, but many have rules about it.

India is only one country, though: in Pakistan, Bangladesh, Afghanistan and the Maldives, where most people are Muslim, meat and fish are everyday foods for those who can afford them, and in Sri Lanka, Nepal and Bhutan, many people eat fish or meat too.

Rules in different faiths

Here is how a few traditions shape the plate. Remember that observance differs from person to person.

- **Hinduism:** Many Hindu texts praise vegetarianism, and many Hindus avoid beef because the cow is traditionally seen as sacred. Some also avoid onion and garlic; in the Pew survey, about one in five Hindus said they don't eat root vegetables such as onion and garlic.
- **Jainism:** Jains follow ahimsa, non-harm to living beings, very strictly. Their diet excludes meat, fish, eggs and honey, and many Jains avoid root vegetables such as potatoes, onions and garlic, because pulling them up destroys the whole plant and the tiny lives in the soil. Many avoid eating after sunset. Jain families in Gujarat and Rajasthan developed whole styles of cooking without onion and garlic.
- **Islam:** Muslims eat food that is halal (see below) and avoid pork and alcohol. During the month of Ramadan, many Muslims fast from dawn to sunset and break the fast together at iftar, often with dates.
- **Sikhism:** In the same Pew survey, 59% of Sikhs in India said they were vegetarian; others eat meat. Every gurdwara runs a langar (ਲੰਗਰ, *LUNG-gur*), a free community kitchen that serves a vegetarian meal to anyone who comes, of any faith, caste or background, seated together on the floor. Sikh tradition credits Guru Nanak with starting it around 1500, and the third Guru, Guru Amar Das, made eating together a rule. The langar at the Golden Temple in Amritsar serves about 100,000 people a day, cooked by volunteers (2023 report).
- **Buddhism:** Buddhist teaching discourages killing, and some Buddhists are vegetarian, while many in Sri Lanka, Bhutan and Nepal eat fish or meat. Practices differ by community.

Sharing food has also been shaped by caste. For centuries, rules about who could cook for or eat with whom kept people apart. The langar's rule of eating side by side was one challenge to this, and India's Constitution outlawed "untouchability" in 1950. You'll read more in Chapter 13.

Halal

Halal (حلال, *ha-LAHL*) is an Arabic word meaning "permitted." In Islamic law it describes food Muslims may eat. Pork is forbidden (haram), and so are alcohol and blood. For meat to be halal, the animal must be a permitted kind and must be slaughtered in a set way, with the name of God (Allah) said at the moment of slaughter. Most vegetarian food is halal, as long as it has no alcohol or other forbidden ingredients. In Muslim-majority countries such as Pakistan, Bangladesh, Afghanistan and the Maldives, halal is the everyday norm, and in the United States, many Muslim families look for a halal butcher or a halal symbol on packages. Halal is a matter of faith and care, much like kosher rules for Jewish families, though the two sets of rules differ in their details.

8.11 At the Table: Hands, Guests and Manners

Eating with hands

In many South Asian homes, people eat with their fingers. **Eating With Hands** is an old and widespread custom, not a sign of having no utensils. Rice is gathered with the fingertips and mixed with dal or curry, and the thumb pushes each bite into the mouth. Roti or naan is torn with one hand and used as a scoop. People usually eat with the right hand only, since the left is used for washing, and wash their hands before and after the meal.

Done well, it's a skill that children learn at the family table, and many people say food tastes better this way. Plenty of families use spoons and forks too,

especially for rice in some regions, at restaurants, or outside the home. Neither way is "more correct."

Hospitality Customs

Hospitality Customs are the expected ways of welcoming and feeding guests. In many families across South Asia, being a generous host is a matter of family honor. A Sanskrit line from the Taittiriya Upanishad, *atithi devo bhava*, "the guest is like a god," is still quoted in India today. Families in Pakistan, Bangladesh, Afghanistan and Nepal have their own sayings and strong traditions of welcoming guests, too.

Some customs that many families share:

- A guest is offered something right away, usually chai or a cold drink, and a snack or sweet.
- Hosts may offer second and third helpings and insist, even after the guest says no. In many families, a polite guest refuses once before accepting.
- Guests often bring sweets or fruit, and many families never send a guest away with an empty dish: a borrowed container goes back with food in it.
- Elders, guests and sometimes men are served first in more traditional homes, while the cooks (often women) may eat last. Many families have changed this.

When Ben finally sits down with a second plate at the potluck, Zara puts a spoonful of her mother's dal and a piece of fish on it. "Rice in the middle," she says. "Now you're eating like my Nanu." Ayesha adds raita, Arjun adds a little mango pickle, and Dilan brings coconut sambol. Ben looks at the crowded plate. "So there's no one real South Asian meal," he says. "There's a whole map of them." Zara grins. "Now you get it. Every plate is somebody's real meal."

Diagram: Thali Builder

Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch08-thali-builder/main.html

Open the Thali Builder fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Thali Builder

sim-id: ch08-thali-builder
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Analyze
Bloom Verb: compare
Learning Objective: The learner will compare the thalis of seven regions and connect each region's staple grain, dal, vegetables, main dish, sweet and spices to its climate, crops and trade history.

Canvas: responsive width; 560 px drawing area plus 90 px control area.

Controls: Region menu (Punjab, Bengal, Kerala, Gujarat, Sindh, Sri Lanka, Nepal), "Non-vegetarian version" checkbox, Previous and Next region buttons; click or tap any katori on the plate.

Behavior: A round thali with a staple in the center and six katori around it (dal, vegetable, main, side, sweet, spices). Selecting a region refills the plate and shows a "Why here?" note about grain, climate and trade. Clicking a katori shows a short note about that item. The checkbox swaps the main katori between a common vegetarian dish and a common non-vegetarian dish from the same region, with a green or brown marker. No map or borders are drawn.

Start with **Bengal**, then switch to **Punjab**. Click the center of the plate each time and read the "Why here?" note. What changed in the middle of the plate, and why? Then try **Kerala** and **Sri Lanka** and look for the ingredient they share in almost every katori (hint: it grows on palm trees).

Next, tick **Non-vegetarian version** and step through all seven regions with the **Next** button. Notice which main dishes are fish and which are meat, and connect that to whether the region sits on a coast or a delta. Finally, look at **Gujarat**: what does its non-vegetarian note tell you about why that thali is

usually vegetarian? Every plate in the sim is one common example, not the only one. Real families cook many more dishes.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about food: a dish only your family makes, who taught them to cook it, what an ordinary weekday meal looked like when they were young, and the food rules in their house. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Try to do the interview in the kitchen while they cook, or over a cup of chai. Ask if it's okay to take notes or photos of the dish.

Questions to ask

1. What did you eat on an ordinary weekday when you were my age? Who cooked it?
2. Is there a dish that only our family makes, or makes in a special way? Who taught you to make it?
3. What spices go in your tadka or your everyday masala, and why those?
4. Were there food rules in your house, like foods we don't eat, days we fast, or how to serve guests? Where did those rules come from?
5. What ingredients or dishes were hard to find after you moved, and what did you use instead? Has the way our family cooks changed?
6. Which recipe do you most want me to learn and keep making?

Listen for: the family's Staple Grains (rice, wheat or millet), signs of their Regional Cuisine, the spices in their Tadka or Masala, and Dietary Rules and Faith or Hospitality Customs that shape how they cook and serve food.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's everyday meal with the thali for their region in the Thali Builder, or with the regional table in Section 8.3. What matches, and what's different? If a friend interviewed someone from another country or region, list two differences in staple grain, spices or food rules between the two families, and one thing they have in common.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: "Curry" is one dish that people eat all over South Asia.
Reality: "Curry" is an English umbrella word, probably borrowed from the Tamil *kari*, that British traders applied to hundreds of different dishes. In South Asia people call dishes by their own names, such as dal, korma, sambar, karahi or jhol, and they taste very different from one another.

Myth: All South Asian food is fiery hot.
Reality: Many dishes are mild, sweet, sour or tangy. Spices like cumin, cardamom, cinnamon and turmeric add flavor, not heat, and many everyday dishes, like a Gujarati dal or Bengali mishti doi, are not spicy at all. Heat levels also vary by region and family.

Myth: Most South Asians are vegetarian.
Reality: In India, 39% of adults said they were vegetarian in a 2019-2020 Pew survey, though 81% limit meat in some way. In Pakistan, Bangladesh, Afghanistan and the Maldives, most people eat meat or fish, and many people in Sri Lanka, Nepal and Bhutan do too.

Myth: Chili peppers are native to India.
Reality: Chilies come from the Americas. Portuguese traders brought them to India in the 1500s, through Goa, as part of the Columbian Exchange. Before that, heat came from black pepper and other local spices.

Myth: Naan is the everyday bread of every South Asian family.
Reality: Naan is baked in a tandoor, which most homes in India don't have, so there it's mainly a restaurant or special-occasion bread. Everyday bread in northern India and much of Pakistan is roti, and in Bengal, Kerala, Sri Lanka and Nepal, rice is the everyday staple. In Afghanistan and many Pakistani cities, though, bakery naan is everyday bread.

Check Yourself

1. What is a staple grain, and what are the three main staple grains of South Asia?

A staple grain is the grain a community eats almost every day and builds meals around. In South Asia the three main ones are rice, wheat and millets.

2. What is a thali, and what is a katori?

A thali is a large round plate holding a complete meal, with a staple in the middle. Katori are the small bowls around its edge that hold dal, vegetables, a sweet and other dishes.

3. What is tadka, and what is panch phoron?

Tadka (tempering) is frying whole spices briefly in hot oil or ghee and pouring them over a dish to add flavor. Panch phoron is a Bengali and Bangladeshi five-seed mix (fenugreek, cumin, nigella, black mustard and fennel) often used for it.

4. How did chili peppers reach South Asia?

Chilies are native to the Americas. After 1492 they spread as part of the Columbian Exchange, and Portuguese traders brought them to India through Goa in the 1500s.

5. What does halal mean?

Halal is Arabic for "permitted." It describes food Muslims may eat, which excludes pork and alcohol and requires that meat be slaughtered in a set way.

Exercises

Remember

1. Name the five seeds in panch phoron.

Answer

Fenugreek, cumin, nigella, black mustard and fennel.

2. What share of Indian adults described themselves as vegetarian in Pew's 2019-2020 survey, and what share limit meat in some way?

> **Answer**
>
> 39% said they were vegetarian, and 81% said they limit meat in some way.

Understand

1. Explain why rice is the staple in Bangladesh while wheat is the staple in Punjab.

> **Answer**
>
> Rice needs heat and lots of water, which the monsoon and the wet Ganga-Brahmaputra delta provide in Bangladesh. Wheat prefers cooler, drier winters and grows well on the irrigated plains of the Indus and its tributaries in Punjab.

2. Explain how chai can be both a result of British colonial business and a South Asian creation.

> **Answer**
>
> British companies grew tea on plantations from the 1830s and ran campaigns in the early 1900s to get Indians to drink it. But people made tea their own way, boiled with lots of milk, sugar and spices, turning it into a drink that is now part of daily life across the region.

Apply

1. Use the Thali Builder to plan a meal for a friend from Kerala who is vegetarian. List what goes in each katori, and explain one choice using what you learned about the region's climate or crops. *Hint: keep the non-vegetarian box unticked and check the "Why here?" note.*
2. Your club is planning a potluck. Write a three-sentence note for the sign-up sheet that helps guests with different dietary rules feel welcome. *Hint: think about labels, halal meat and vegetarian dishes.*

Analyze

1. Compare the thalis of Sindh and Gujarat in the Thali Builder. Which parts are similar, and which are different? Connect at least one difference to faith or food rules and one to geography. *Hint: both regions are dry and both border the Arabian Sea.*
2. Pick one food from the Columbian Exchange (chili, potato, tomato or maize) and trace how it shows up in at least three South Asian dishes from three different countries. *Hint: Section 8.7 has examples; the regional table has more.*

Evaluate

1. West Bengal and Odisha each received a Geographical Indication tag for their own version of the rasgulla. Do you think giving tags to both was a fair decision? Support your view with evidence from the Whose Story? box. *Hint: think about what a GI tag is for.*
2. A restaurant near your school advertises "Authentic Indian curry and naan." Evaluate the phrase using at least two ideas from this chapter. *Hint: what does "curry" mean, and how common is naan at home?*

Create

1. Design a thali for your own family (or an imagined family from a region in this chapter). Draw or describe the plate, name each katori, and write one sentence explaining why each item is there. *Hint: start with the staple grain.*
2. Write a short guide (150 to 200 words) titled "How to Be a Great Guest at a South Asian Home" for a friend like Ben, using what you learned about eating with hands and hospitality customs. *Hint: include what to do when the host offers a third helping.*

Key Takeaways

- What people eat in South Asia depends on staple grains (rice, wheat, millet), which depend on rain, rivers and soil.
- Regional cuisines often cross modern borders: Punjabi food is shared by Pakistan and India, and Bengali food by Bangladesh and India.
- A thali puts a whole meal on one plate. Dal, masala and tadka are building blocks that almost every region uses in its own way.
- Roti is the everyday bread of wheat country, while tandoor-baked naan is everyday bread in some places and a restaurant food in others. Biryani's origin is debated, and every region has its own version.
- Chili peppers, potatoes, tomatoes and maize came from the Americas through the Columbian Exchange, and chai became a daily drink only in the 20th century.
- Faith shapes food: vegetarianism is common in India but not universal (39% of Indian adults in Pew's 2019-2020 survey), halal rules guide Muslim families, and Sikh langars feed everyone together.

- Eating with the right hand and generous hospitality to guests are widely shared customs, though every family does them differently.

Everyone's plate is real

You can now read a thali like a map of grain, rain, trade and faith. Next, in Chapter 9, we listen to South Asia: the ragas, rhythms, qawwalis and film songs that fill the air at those same family gatherings.

Quiz: Food and the Table

Test your understanding of Chapter 8. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

What is a thali?

A. A spice blend that always includes cinnamon and cloves

B. A large round plate holding a full meal, with small bowls around a staple

C. A clay oven used to bake naan

D. A sweet made from milk boiled down until thick

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. A thali is a round plate, usually metal, holding a complete meal: a staple in the center and katori (small bowls) of dal, vegetables, a sweet and more around it. The clay oven is a tandoor, and the spice blend described is a masala.

Concept Tested: Thali **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

Where did chili peppers originally come from?

A. The Western Ghats of India

B. The hills of Assam

C. Persia, by way of the Mughal court

D. The Americas, carried by Portuguese traders

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Chili peppers are native to the Americas. They spread around the world in the Columbian Exchange, and Portuguese traders brought them to India through Goa in the 1500s. Many people assume chilies are native to India because they are now used so widely there.

Concept Tested: Columbian Exchange **Bloom's Level:** Remember

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Question 3

In a 2019-2020 Pew Research Center survey of Indian adults, about what share said they were vegetarian?

A. 39%

B. 81%

C. 92%

D. 8%

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. 39% of Indian adults said they were vegetarian. 81% is the share who limit meat in some way, 92% is the figure for Jains only, and 8% is the figure for Muslims only.

Concept Tested: Vegetarianism in South Asia **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Why is rice the staple grain in Bangladesh while wheat is the staple in Punjab?

A. Religious rules in Bangladesh forbid eating wheat

B. Wheat was brought by the British and only reached Punjab

C. Rice needs heat and lots of water, which the delta provides, while wheat grows well in Punjab's cooler, drier winters on irrigated plains

D. Rice is cheaper to import by sea than wheat

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Staple grains follow climate and water. The monsoon-soaked Ganga-Brahmaputra delta suits rice, and the irrigated plains of the Indus and its tributaries, with cool winters, suit wheat. No faith in the region forbids wheat, and wheat was grown in South Asia long before British rule.

Concept Tested: Staple Grains **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

Which statement best describes tadka?

A. Whole spices fried briefly in hot oil or ghee and poured over a dish to add flavor

B. A ready-made curry powder sold mainly in Europe

C. A way of slow-cooking rice and meat in layers

D. A rule about which hand to eat with

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Tadka (tempering) means frying whole spices for a few seconds in hot fat and pouring the sizzling mix over dal or another dish. Layered rice and meat describes biryani, not tadka.

Concept Tested: Tadka **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 6

Why is naan less common as everyday home food in India than roti?

A. Naan is forbidden by several faiths

B. Naan is usually baked in a tandoor, which most homes don't have

C. Naan can only be made from millet flour

D. Naan was invented in the United States

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Naan is a leavened bread slapped onto the wall of a very hot tandoor oven, so in India it is mostly a restaurant or special-occasion bread. Roti is cooked on a simple flat griddle at home. In Afghanistan and many Pakistani cities, though, bakery naan is everyday bread.

Concept Tested: Roti and Naan **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

Ben is hosting a club movie night. Ayesha keeps halal, Simran's family is vegetarian, and Arjun eats everything. Which plan is most respectful of

everyone's dietary rules?

A. Order pepperoni pizza, since most people like it

B. Order only chicken wings and tell everyone to pick off what they can't eat

C. Order one vegetarian dish and assume it covers everyone

D. Ask guests about food rules ahead of time, include clearly labeled vegetarian food, and get any meat from a halal source

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Asking ahead and labeling dishes is the chapter's advice, and halal meat plus vegetarian options covers both guests. Pepperoni usually contains pork, which isn't halal. A single vegetarian dish without asking could still miss other rules, such as avoiding alcohol in sauces.

Concept Tested: Dietary Rules and Faith **Bloom's Level:** Apply

---

Question 8

Zara's Nanu is making dal and starts by frying fenugreek, cumin, nigella, black mustard and fennel seeds in oil. Based on the chapter, which region's tradition is she most likely following?

A. Punjab

B. Kerala

C. Bengal, using panch phoron

D. Gujarat, using hing alone

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Those five whole seeds make panch phoron, the five-spice mix used in tadka in Bangladesh and eastern India. That fits Zara's family from Chattogram. Kerala cooks more often temper with mustard seeds and curry leaves.

Concept Tested: Masala **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

West Bengal received a Geographical Indication tag for "Banglar Rasogolla" in 2017, and Odisha received one for "Odisha Rasagola" in 2019. What does this best show?

A. Two places can each have a real, distinct version of a sweet, and its single origin may stay debated

B. The government decided Odisha invented the rasgulla

C. Rasgulla is no longer made in Bengal

D. Mithai can only be sold where they were invented

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The tags were given to two different versions of the sweet, not to one "true" origin, and the history of where rasgulla began is still debated. The 2019 tag did not cancel West Bengal's tag or declare an inventor.

Concept Tested: Mithai **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

Which comparison best explains why Bhutan's ema datshi and Punjab's makki di roti are both examples of the Columbian Exchange?

A. Both were invented by Portuguese cooks in Goa

B. Both depend on crops from the Americas: chili in ema datshi and maize in makki di roti

C. Both are sweets served at festivals

D. Both use wheat brought from Europe

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Ema datshi is built on chili peppers and makki di roti on maize, and both crops came from the Americas after 1492. Local cooks, not Portuguese ones, created these dishes from the new ingredients.

Concept Tested: Columbian Exchange **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 9: Music

Summary

South Asian music runs on two big ideas: raga, a set of rules for building a melody, and tala, a repeating cycle of beats. This chapter explains both in plain terms, then compares the two classical systems, Hindustani music in the north and Carnatic music in the south, and the instruments and teaching traditions that carry them. It moves on to songs of devotion and poetry (qawwali, ghazal and Baul music), the folk music of all eight countries, bhangra, and the film songs that many people in the region hum every day. By the end you'll be able to clap a tala and find its first beat.

Concepts Covered

1. Raga
2. Tala
3. Sargam
4. Hindustani Music
5. Carnatic Music
6. Gharana
7. Guru-Shishya Tradition
8. Sitar
9. Tabla

10. Veena
11. Qawwali
12. Ghazal
13. Baul Music
14. Folk Music
15. Bhangra
16. Film Music (Filmi)

Prerequisites

- Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters for the Delhi Sultanate and the Mughal courts where much of northern music took shape.
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia for Sufism, bhakti and the devotional settings of many songs.
- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts for Urdu, Bangla, Punjabi, Tamil and Telugu, the languages these songs are sung in.

Turn it up

Maybe you've heard a film song at a wedding, a qawwali on your parents' playlist, or a tabla beat sampled in a hip-hop track and wondered how it all fits together. Music is one of the easiest ways into a culture, and one of the hardest to explain. This chapter gives you the vocabulary to talk about it, and even to count along. Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

9.1 "Where Is Beat One?"

Zara Hossain has played violin since she was seven, so when her friend Arjun Reddy invites her to a South Indian classical concert at a community hall in Minneapolis, she's curious. Ben Lindqvist comes too, mostly for the snacks at intermission.

The first surprise is the violinist. He sits cross-legged on a low stage, and instead of tucking the violin under his chin, he rests its scroll against his foot and holds it against his chest. Next to him a singer and a drummer with a long, two-headed drum face the audience. The second surprise is the audience. All around Zara, people are slapping their thighs with an open palm, tapping their fingers one at a time, then flipping their hands over and back, in perfect time with the music.

Zara tries to tap along the way she would in orchestra, counting "one, two, three, four." It doesn't work. The melody seems to float over the beat, and the musicians land together on some moments with a huge smile, as if they've all arrived home at once. "Where is beat one?" she whispers. Arjun grins and shows her his hand: palm, pinky, ring, middle, palm, flip, palm, flip. "It's Adi tala. Eight beats. Watch where they all land."

How does a whole room know where "one" is when Zara, a trained musician, can't find it? That's what this chapter is about.

9.2 Two Big Ideas: Melody Rules and Beat Cycles

Think about how most pop songs work. A song is in a key, like C major, which tells you which notes to use, and it has a time signature, usually four beats to a bar, which tells you where to clap. Western classical and pop music add harmony on top: chords, several notes at once.

South Asian classical music works with similar ingredients but puts the weight in different places. There is usually no chord harmony. Instead there's

a steady drone, a note held underneath everything, often from a stringed instrument called a tanpura (or tambura) or an electronic box. Over that drone, one melody unfolds in great detail, guided by a **raga**, while a drummer keeps a repeating beat cycle called a **tala**.

A cooking comparison helps. A scale is like a list of ingredients. A raga is more like a recipe: it tells you not just which ingredients to use but how to combine them, which ones to feature, and which steps give the dish its character. Two cooks can follow the same recipe and make different meals, and two musicians can play the same raga and sound completely different. The rest of this chapter fills in that picture.

9.3 Raga and Sargam

Sargam: the names of the notes

Before you can talk about a raga, you need names for the notes. In South Asian music the seven basic notes are **sa, re, ga, ma, pa, dha, ni**, then sa again an octave higher. Singing the notes with these syllables is called **Sargam** (a word made from the first four: sa-re-ga-ma). It works a lot like "do, re, mi" in Western solfege, which you may know from music class or *The Sound of Music*. In the south, re is often called ri.

There's one big difference from a piano keyboard. Sa isn't fixed to one pitch. The singer or main player chooses a comfortable note to be sa, and everything else is measured from it. Sa and pa (the fifth note) never change. Four of the other notes (re, ga, dha and ni) can each be lowered (komal, "soft"), and ma can be raised (tivra, "sharp"), which gives twelve notes in all, the same twelve as in Western music.

Raga: a melodic framework

A **Raga** (राग, *RAH-ga*) is a framework for creating melody. The word comes from a Sanskrit root meaning "color" or "feeling," because each raga is meant to color the listener's mood. A raga sets:

- **which notes** may be used (often five, six or seven of them),
- **how to go up and down**: the ascending line (aroha) and descending line (avaroha) can use different notes,
- **which notes to emphasize** and where to rest,
- **characteristic phrases** that instantly identify the raga, a bit like a musical signature, called the pakad,
- and **how to ornament** notes with slides and shakes.

That's why a raga is *not* just a scale. Two ragas can use exactly the same notes and still sound different because of their phrases and emphasis. For example, the Hindustani ragas Bhoopali and Deshkar share the same five-note scale (sa, re, ga, pa, dha) but are treated as separate ragas. In Carnatic music, the raga with Bhoopali's notes is called Mohanam.

In northern India, Pakistan and Bangladesh, many ragas are linked to a time of day or a season. Some are traditionally performed at dawn, some at dusk, some during the monsoon. Southern musicians pay less attention to these timings. A raga performance can last a few minutes or more than an hour, often starting slowly, with no beat at all, while the musician explores the raga note by note, then speeding up as the drum enters.

Try singing it

Pick a comfortable note as your sa and sing "sa re ga pa dha sa," skipping ma and ni. You've just sung the five notes of Bhoopali (Mohanam in the south). Now try singing them in a different order or lingering on ga. Does it start to sound like a tune?

9.4 Tala: The Beat That Comes Back Around

A **Tala** (ताल, *TAAL*) is a repeating cycle of beats that organizes time in a piece of music. The word also means "clapping of the palms," which makes sense, because talas are traditionally counted with claps, waves and finger taps.

The key idea is the *cycle*. Western music thinks in bars that go by one after another. A tala is more like a clock face: the beats go around and around, and the most important moment is when the cycle comes back to the start. That first beat is called the **sam** (pronounced like the English word "sum"). Musicians may improvise wildly in the middle of a cycle, playing across the beat or against it, but they aim to land together on sam. When they do, listeners often nod, smile or clap. That's what Zara saw in the concert hall.

A tala is divided into sections, called vibhag in the north. Each section starts with either:

- a **clap** (tali), a strong hand clap or palm slap, or
- a **wave** (khali, ख़ाली, *KHAA-lee*, "empty"), a sideways wave of the hand or the back of the hand. On the tabla, the khali section is played mostly with light strokes that leave out the deep, ringing bass, so it sounds lighter. Hearing the khali tells a listener that sam is coming soon.

In written notation, sam is marked **X**, khali is marked **0**, and the other claps are numbered 2, 3 and so on.

Four talas to count

Here are four common talas. The first three are Hindustani; Adi tala is Carnatic. Read the "how to count" column out loud while clapping, the same way beginning music students are taught.

Tala	System	Beats	Sections	How to count it
Teentaal (Tintal)	Hindustani	16	4 + 4 + 4 + 4	Clap on 1 (sam), clap on 5, **wave on 9** (khali), clap on 13
Rupak	Hindustani	7	3 + 2 + 2	**Wave on 1** (sam is also khali), clap on 4, clap on 6
Dadra	Hindustani	6	3 + 3	Clap on 1 (sam), wave on 4 (khali)
Adi tala	Carnatic	8	4 + 2 + 2	Palm on 1, then pinky, ring, middle finger on 2-4; palm on 5, flip hand on 6; palm on 7, flip on 8

Teentaal ("three claps") is one of the most common talas in Hindustani music, used for countless compositions. Rupak is unusual: it's the only popular Hindustani tala that begins with a wave, so sam is a quiet beat. That can be confusing at first, and it's a good test of whether you're really

counting or just waiting for the loudest beat. Dadra's six beats are often used in lighter classical songs and film music. Adi tala ("first" or "primary" tala) is the most widely used tala in Carnatic music. In Adi tala the hand keeps counting the same eight beats while the singer fits two, four or more notes into each beat, so the music can feel faster or slower even when the beat itself stays steady.

Listen for the wave

When you're lost in Teentaal, listen for the stretch where the deep bass goes quiet. It starts at khali, beat 9, and sam is eight beats from khali. Count "9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16" and you'll land on one with everyone else.

9.5 Two Classical Systems: Hindustani and Carnatic

South Asia has two great classical traditions. They share raga, tala and sargam, and grow from the same old music theory, but by about the 1500s they were treated as separate systems with their own repertoires, styles and vocabularies.

Hindustani music

Hindustani Music is the classical music of the northern part of the subcontinent: northern and central India, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Nepal. It took shape over centuries in temples and in the courts of the Delhi Sultanate and the Mughal Empire, where musicians blended older Indian traditions with ideas from Persian music. The poet and musician Amir Khusrau (1253–1325) is a major figure from this time, and Tansen, a singer at the court of the Mughal

emperor Akbar, is remembered as one of the greatest musicians in the tradition.

Hindustani performances often give a lot of time to improvisation. A typical performance opens with a slow, unaccompanied exploration of the raga (the alap), followed by a composition set to a tala, with the tabla keeping time. The main vocal styles include the older, solemn dhrupad and the more flexible khyal. In the 20th century, state radio stations, including All India Radio, Radio Pakistan and Bangladesh Betar, helped classical musicians reach huge new audiences after the royal courts that once paid them disappeared.

Carnatic music

Carnatic Music is the classical music of southern India, especially Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Kerala, and of Tamil communities in Sri Lanka and around the world. It centers on composed songs, many of them devotional, in languages such as Telugu, Tamil, Kannada, Sanskrit and Malayalam. The composer Purandara Dasa (1484-1564) is called the "father" of Carnatic music because he set out the basic lessons students still learn. Three composers who lived around the same time, Tyagaraja, Muthuswami Dikshitar and Syama Sastri, are known as the Trinity of Carnatic music, and their songs are still the core of concerts today.

A typical Carnatic concert has a singer, a violinist who follows and answers the singer, a mridangam (a double-headed drum made of jackfruit wood) and a drone. Improvisation happens too, inside and around the compositions. Chennai's December music season, which grew out of a music conference held in Madras in December 1927 (the Music Academy that runs it opened in 1928), now fills the city with hundreds of concerts every winter.

The violin Zara saw came from Europe. Balaswami Dikshitar, a brother of the composer Muthuswami Dikshitar, heard Western orchestral music at Fort St.

George in Madras (now Chennai) and pioneered the violin in Carnatic music. Players sit on the floor, rest the scroll on the foot, and tune the strings to sa and pa. Today the violin is so central to Carnatic music that many listeners no longer think of it as a foreign instrument.

	Hindustani Music	Carnatic Music
Where	Northern and central India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal	Southern India, Tamil communities in Sri Lanka and worldwide
Main drum	Tabla (also pakhawaj)	Mridangam (also ghatam, kanjira)
Common instruments	Sitar, sarod, bansuri (flute), sarangi, harmonium	Veena, violin, flute, nadaswaram
Emphasis	Long improvisation on the raga	Composed songs, with improvisation around them
Common languages	Hindi, Urdu, Braj, Punjabi, Bangla	Telugu, Tamil, Kannada, Sanskrit, Malayalam
Counting the tala	Claps and waves (tali and khali)	Palm beats, finger counts and hand flips
Famous tala	Teentaal (16 beats)	Adi tala (8 beats)

9.6 Instruments: Sitar, Tabla and Veena

Hundreds of instruments are played across South Asia. Three of them have become symbols of its classical music.

Sitar

The **Sitar** (सितार, *si-TAAR*) is a long-necked plucked string instrument with a round gourd body. Its name comes from the Persian *sehtar*, "three strings," after a small Persian lute. A modern sitar has 18 to 21 strings: six or seven are played, and the rest are **sympathetic strings** that run under the frets and ring by themselves when the played strings sound the same notes. That's what gives the sitar its shimmering, buzzing sound. Its curved metal frets can be moved, and players pull the string sideways across them to bend a note smoothly, a technique called meend.

The sitar is most closely linked with Ravi Shankar (1920-2012), a Bengali musician born in Benares (now Varanasi). In the 1960s he performed at the Monterey Pop Festival and Woodstock and taught George Harrison of the Beatles, who put the sitar on Beatles records. In 1971 Shankar told Harrison about the millions of refugees who had fled the war in what is now Bangladesh, and together they organized the Concert for Bangladesh, held on 1 August 1971 at Madison Square Garden in New York, to raise money for them. Shankar received India's highest civilian honor, the Bharat Ratna, in 1999.

Tabla

The **Tabla** (तबला, *TUB-la*) is a pair of hand drums and the main drum of Hindustani music. The smaller, wooden drum, played with the dominant hand, is called the dayan (right) and produces clear, tuned tones. The larger drum, often made of metal or clay, is the bayan (left) and produces deep

bass sounds that the player can bend by pressing the heel of the hand. Each drumhead has a black circle of paste that gives it its ringing tone.

Tabla players learn every stroke as a spoken syllable, called a bol, like *dha*, *dhin*, *na* and *tin*. A tala's basic pattern of bols, called its theka, is recited and played over and over. That makes the tabla an instrument you can practice with your voice on a school bus.

Veena

The **Veena** (वीणा, Tamil வீணை, *VEE-nah*) is an ancient name for stringed instruments, used in Indian texts for about 3,000 years, and today it means several instruments. In Carnatic music, the Saraswati veena is a large plucked lute carved from jackfruit wood, with 24 fixed frets, four playing strings and three drone strings. It's named after Saraswati, the Hindu goddess of learning and the arts, who is usually shown holding one. Muthuswami Dikshitar was himself a veena player. In the north, older forms like the rudra veena belong to the dhrupad tradition.

Other instruments you'll hear: the sarod (a fretless lute), bansuri (bamboo flute), shehnai and nadaswaram (double-reed wind instruments for weddings and temples), sarangi (a bowed instrument that imitates the voice), and the harmonium, a small hand-pumped keyboard that arrived from Europe in the mid-1800s. Indian craftsmen redesigned it to be played sitting on the floor, and it is now everywhere, even though All India Radio banned it from broadcasts from 1940 to 1971 because it can't slide between notes the way a voice can.

9.7 How Music Is Passed On: Gharana and Guru-Shishya

For most of history, nobody learned South Asian classical music from a book. They learned it from a person.

The **Guru-Shishya Tradition** (गुरु-शिष्य, *GOO-roo SHISH-ya*, "teacher-disciple") is the practice of learning an art through a long, close relationship with a teacher. A student might live with or near the guru for years, listening, copying and practicing for hours a day, and serving the teacher's household in return. Lessons were given orally, phrase by phrase, so the music lived in memory rather than on paper. Muslim musicians often call a master teacher ustad, and pandit is a common title for Hindu masters. Today many students learn in music schools, colleges and online lessons, but the respect for the teacher remains: many students touch their teacher's feet or bow before a lesson or a concert.

In Hindustani music, these teaching lines grew into the **Gharana** (घराना, *gha-RAA-na*), from *ghar*, "house." A gharana is a "musical household": a lineage of musicians connected by family or by teacher and student, sharing a recognizable style. Most gharanas are named after a place, often the court where their founders worked: Gwalior, Agra, Kirana, Jaipur-Atrauli and Patiala are well-known singing gharanas, and Delhi, Lucknow, Benares and Punjab are known tabla gharanas. Many gharana families are Muslim, many are Hindu, and students from one faith have often learned from masters of another. After 1947, some gharana families found their members living in two different countries. The Patiala gharana, for example, has well-known singers on both sides of the India-Pakistan border.

You're part of a lineage too

If you learned a song from a grandparent, a dance from an aunty or a tabla rhythm from a teacher at your temple, mosque or gurdwara, you're already part of a guru-shishya chain. Ask who taught *them*, and you might trace your music back several generations.

9.8 Songs of Devotion and Poetry

Some of the most loved music in South Asia was made to express faith, longing and love, and to set great poems to melody.

Qawwali

Qawwali (Urdu قوالی, *kuh-WAH-lee*) is a form of Sufi Muslim devotional music. Sufism is a tradition within Islam that focuses on inner devotion and the love of God (see Chapter 5), and qawwali is sung at Sufi shrines, called dargahs, to help listeners feel closer to God. Its development is credited to Amir Khusrau, a follower of the Sufi saint Nizamuddin Auliya of Delhi, who blended Persian poetry with Indian ragas in the 1200s and 1300s.

A qawwali group, called a party, usually has a lead singer, side singers, harmoniums, tabla or dholak, and a chorus that claps hard on the beat. A song often starts slowly and quietly, then repeats key lines, faster and louder, building toward a feeling of spiritual ecstasy. Performances can last a very long time. Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan (1948-1997), from Faisalabad in Pakistan, brought qawwali to audiences around the world and recorded over 125 qawwali albums. The Sabri Brothers of Pakistan are another famous qawwali group, and the Wadali Brothers of India sing closely related Sufi music. Qawwali is entertainment for many listeners, but at its root it is prayer.

Ghazal

A **Ghazal** (Urdu غزل, *GUZ-ul*) is a form of love poetry, and the music made from it. The form began in Arabic poetry, flourished in Persian, and from the 1700s became the leading poetic form in Urdu. A ghazal is built from at least five rhyming couplets, each called a sher. Each couplet can stand alone, like a tiny complete poem, but the second line of every couplet (and both lines of the first) ends with the same refrain word or phrase, called the radif. The "beloved" in a ghazal can be a human love, God, or both at once, and that double meaning is part of what readers love about the form. Great Urdu ghazal poets include Mir Taqi Mir and Mirza Ghalib (1797-1869), and Kazi Nazrul Islam, the national poet of Bangladesh, wrote ghazals in Bangla.

Sung ghazals became hugely popular in the 20th century through singers like Begum Akhtar and Jagjit Singh in India and Mehdi Hassan (1927-2012) in Pakistan, who was called the "Emperor of Ghazal." Ghazal singing is quieter and more intimate than qawwali: the poem is the star.

Baul music

Baul Music is the music of the Bauls (বাউল, *BAH-ool*), wandering singers of Bangladesh and India's West Bengal. The word can mean "mad" in Bangla, in the sense of being mad with love for God. Bauls draw on both Sufi Islam and Vaishnava Hindu devotion, and many reject divisions of caste and religion. Many play the ektara, a one-stringed instrument made from a gourd and bamboo, while singing and dancing.

The most famous Baul, Lalon (c. 1774-1890), lived near Kushtia in present-day Bangladesh. His songs ask why people divide themselves by religion and caste, and they are still sung at a large festival at his shrine. Baul songs also influenced Rabindranath Tagore. UNESCO proclaimed the Baul songs of Bangladesh a masterpiece of humanity's intangible heritage in 2005 and placed them on its Representative List in 2008.

Whose Story?

Ask who invented the sitar and the tabla, and you'll get several answers. A popular story, repeated in many books and websites, credits Amir Khusrau in the 1300s with both. Many historians now doubt this: there is no record of either instrument from his time, and they suggest the sitar was developed from the small Persian setar in the 1700s, possibly by a later musician also named Khusrau, and reached its modern form in the 1800s. Others point to old Indian stringed instruments and to temple carvings of paired drums as the deeper roots of the sitar and tabla. Each account emphasizes a different strand, Persian, Indian or both, and the instruments themselves are probably the product of all of them meeting over centuries.

9.9 Folk Music Across Eight Countries

Classical music has stars and concert halls, but many South Asians grew up with **Folk Music**: songs and rhythms passed down in villages and communities, tied to work, seasons, weddings, festivals and faith, usually learned by ear and performed by ordinary people. Every region has its own, and folk music often feeds classical and film music too.

Country	Folk tradition	What to listen for
Afghanistan	Rubab music	A short-necked lute of mulberry wood, called the national instrument; UNESCO listed the art of making and playing it in 2024, jointly with Iran, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan

Country	Folk tradition	What to listen for
Bangladesh	Baul songs, boat songs (bhatiyali)	Ektara and voice; songs of rivers and longing
Bhutan	Zhungdra and boedra	Two main folk styles; zhungdra comes from the central valleys and dates to the 1600s
India	Rajasthani folk songs, Bihu (Assam), lavani (Maharashtra) and many more	Regional drums and fiddles, often for festivals and harvests
Maldives	Boduberu ("big drum")	Groups of about 20 performers with three drummers and a lead singer; the drums are made from coconut trunks
Nepal	Songs with the madal	The madal, a two-headed hand drum, is Nepal's national instrument and the backbone of its folk music
Pakistan	Sindhi Sufi songs, Pashto folk, Punjabi folk	Sufi poetry sung at shrines; dhol and tumbi in Punjab
Sri Lanka	Kandyan drumming, baila	The geta bera drum of Kandyan dance; baila, a dance music shaped by Portuguese and Afro-

Country	Folk tradition	What to listen for
		Sri Lankan communities from the 1500s onward

In some places, music is under real pressure. In Afghanistan, since the Taliban returned to power in 2021, the authorities have imposed what AFP described in December 2024 as a near-total ban on music, and musicians who make or play the rubab have been forced to work quietly or leave the country. UNESCO's 2024 listing recognized the instrument's long history across the region at a time when that history is under threat.

Bhangra

Bhangra (ਭੰਗੜਾ, *BHUNG-ra*) began as a folk dance and music of Punjab, a region split between Pakistan and India, traditionally linked with the harvest and with festivals like Vaisakhi. Its main drum is the dhol, a big two-sided drum played with two sticks, often joined by the tumbi, a high, twangy one-string instrument.

Bhangra changed when it traveled. In the 1970s and 1980s, young Punjabis in Britain, in cities like Birmingham and Southall in London, mixed folk bhangra with synthesizers, drum kits and rock and dance beats. Bands like Alaap, formed in 1977, sold huge numbers of cassettes in local shops. "British bhangra" became a sound of British Asian identity, and it later blended with hip-hop and reggae. Today Punjabi pop is a global industry. In April 2023, singer Diljit Dosanjh became the first Indian Punjabi artist to perform at the Coachella festival in California. You'll read more about bhangra as dance in Chapter 10.

9.10 Film Music and Music Today

For many people in South Asia and the diaspora, "Indian music" or "Pakistani music" means film songs. **Film Music (Filmi)** (फ़िल्मी, *FILL-mee*) is the music written for South Asian movies, especially the song-and-dance numbers that are a key part of many films. Filmi borrows from everything: ragas, folk songs, qawwali, ghazal, Western pop, jazz, disco and hip-hop.

Filmi depends on the **playback singer**, because actors rarely sing their own songs. Instead, professional singers record them in a studio, and the actors lip-sync on screen. Playback singers can become as famous as movie stars. Lata Mangeshkar (1929-2022) recorded songs in dozens of languages over about seven decades and received the Bharat Ratna in 2001. Her sister Asha Bhosle, and singers like Mohammed Rafi and Kishore Kumar, are just as loved. Film industries in Mumbai (Hindi), Chennai (Tamil), Hyderabad (Telugu), Lahore (Punjabi and Urdu), Dhaka (Bangla) and elsewhere each have their own composers and stars. You'll read more about them in Chapter 15.

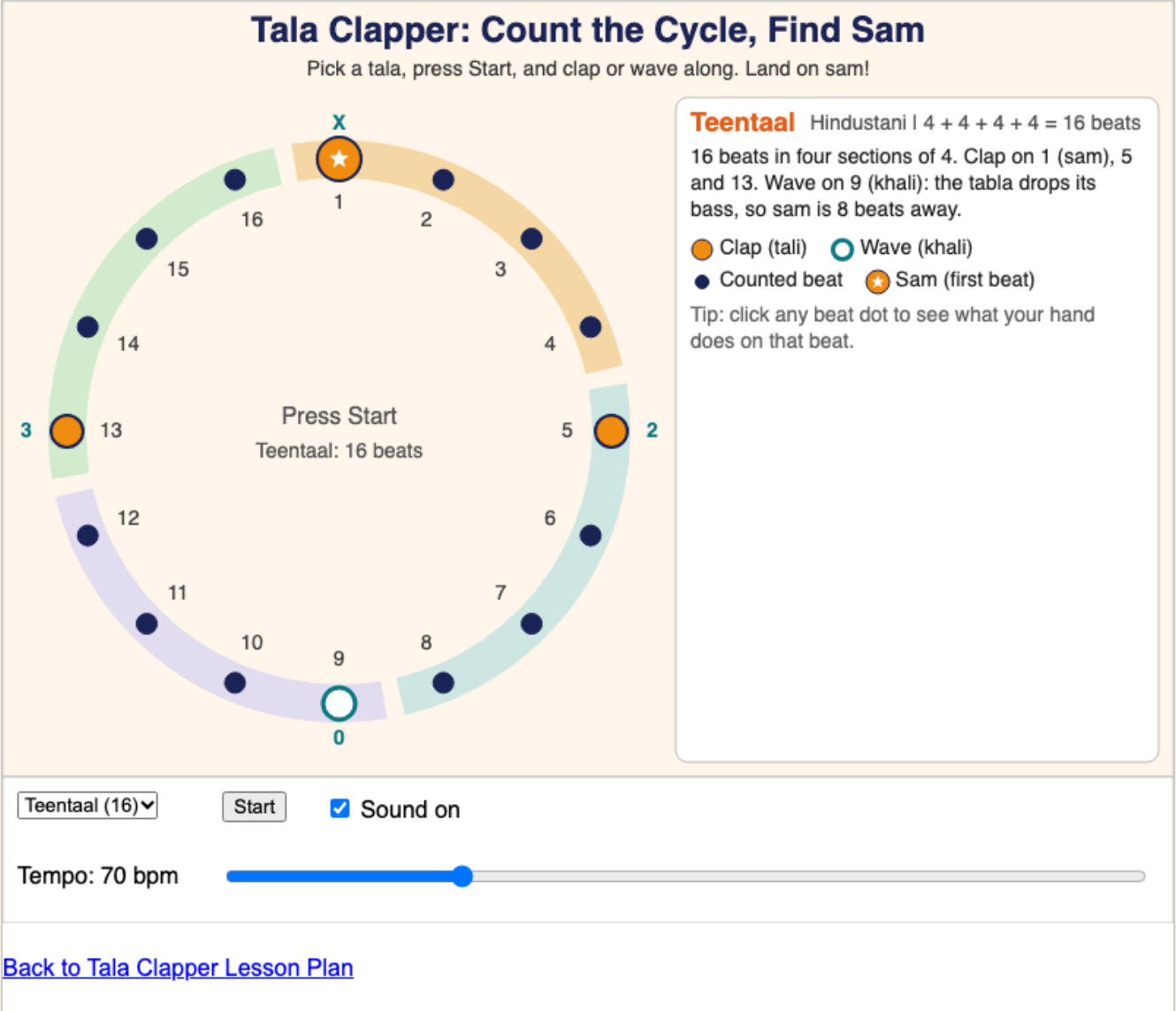
Film music has also won the world's top awards. A. R. Rahman won two Academy Awards in 2009 for the score and the song "Jai Ho" from *Slumdog Millionaire*. In 2023, "Naatu Naatu" from the Telugu film *RRR*, composed by M. M. Keeravani, became the first song from an Indian film to win the Academy Award for Best Original Song.

Not all popular music comes from films. Pakistan's television series *Coke Studio* pairs folk and classical singers with modern bands. Its 2022 song "Pasoori," sung by Ali Sethi and Shae Gill in Punjabi, was the most-streamed Pakistani song worldwide on Spotify that year and was hugely popular in India too. Bangladeshi rock bands, Nepali pop, Sri Lankan baila-pop and diaspora artists in the United States, Britain and Canada keep remixing the old sounds in new ways.

Back in the concert hall, Zara keeps her eyes on Arjun's hand through the second half: palm, pinky, ring, middle, palm, flip, palm, flip. About ten minutes

in, the singer, violinist and drummer race through a tricky passage and slam into sam together. This time Zara lands with them. She laughs out loud. Ben, who has been counting on his fingers the whole time, whispers, "I got it on the last one. I think." On the way home Zara asks Arjun to teach her the Teentaal claps, too. "Next week," he says. "Bring your violin. We'll see if you can play a raga."

Diagram: Tala Clapper



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch09-tala-clapper/main.html

Open the Tala Clapper fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Tala Clapper

sim-id: ch09-tala-clapper
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Apply
Bloom Verb: count
Learning Objective: The learner will count through a full tala cycle for Teentaal, Rupak, Dadra and Adi tala, follow the clap, wave and finger-count gestures, and identify sam (the first beat) when the cycle returns.

Canvas: responsive width; 530 px drawing area plus 100 px control area.

Controls: Tala menu (Teentaal 16, Rupak 7, Dadra 6, Adi tala 8), Start / Pause button, tempo slider (40 to 160 beats per minute), "Sound on" checkbox. Click or tap a beat dot to read about it.

Behavior: Beat dots sit in a circle like a clock, grouped into sections. Sam is a large star-marked dot at the top, khali (wave) beats are hollow, claps are filled, and Carnatic finger counts are small. The sim starts paused; Start lights each beat in turn and shows "Clap," "Wave" or a finger name in the center, with a cycle counter. Synthesized WebAudio clicks (no recordings) sound only after the user presses Start: a low, longer tone for sam, a bright click for claps, a soft muted tick for waves and a quiet tick for finger counts.

Start with **Teentaal** at a slow tempo and press **Start**. Clap along with your hands: clap when the screen says "Clap," wave your hand sideways when it says "Wave." Count the beats out loud from 1 to 16. Notice the quiet wave on beat 9 and how the next sam feels like coming home.

Then switch to **Rupak**. Before you press Start, predict: what will you do on beat 1? Finally, try **Adi tala** and use your fingers the way Arjun did, palm, pinky, ring, middle, palm, flip, palm, flip. Speed up the tempo slider until you can't keep up, then slow it down and try to land on sam without looking at the screen.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about music: the songs from their childhood, the film songs they love, whether anyone in the family learned an instrument or classical singing, and the songs they sing at weddings and festivals. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Have a phone ready so they can play you a song they love while you talk. Ask if it's okay to take notes.

Questions to ask

1. What songs do you remember from when you were my age? Where did you hear them: the radio, films, the temple or mosque, family gatherings?
2. Who is your favorite singer or musician, and why?
3. Did anyone in our family learn an instrument, classical singing or devotional songs? Who was their teacher?
4. What songs are sung at weddings or festivals in our family? Who leads them?

5. How has the music you listen to changed over your life, or since you moved to this country?
6. Is there one song you'd like me to learn, and what does it mean to you?

Listen for: names of forms like Qawwali, Ghazal, Baul Music, Folk Music, Bhangra or Film Music (Filmi), any mention of a teacher and the Guru-Shishya Tradition, and any instrument like the Tabla, Sitar or Veena.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's favorite song with the forms in this chapter. Is it a film song, a ghazal, a qawwali, a folk song or something else? If a friend interviewed someone from a different country or community, compare the two songs: what language is each in, what is it about, and where would people hear it?

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Indian classical music is just improvised, with no rules.
Reality: Improvisation is important, but it happens inside strict frameworks. The raga sets which notes, phrases and emphases are allowed, and the tala sets a cycle that every musician must track. Musicians train for years to improvise freely while landing exactly on sam.

Myth: A raga is just a scale.
Reality: A raga includes a set of notes, but also rules for going up and down,

notes to stress, signature phrases and ornaments. Two ragas, such as Bhoopali and Deshkar, can share the same notes and still be different ragas.

Myth: Bollywood music is all of South Asian music.
Reality: Hindi film songs are hugely popular, but South Asia also has two classical systems, qawwali, ghazal, Baul songs, folk music in every country, bhangra, and film industries in many languages, plus pop and rock scenes from Lahore to Dhaka to Kathmandu.

Myth: Qawwali is just party music.
Reality: Qawwali can be thrilling to hear, but it began as Sufi devotional music sung at shrines to bring listeners closer to God. For many performers and listeners it is still a form of prayer.

Check Yourself

1. What is the difference between a raga and a tala?

A raga is a framework for melody: which notes to use and how to combine them. A tala is a repeating cycle of beats that organizes time.

2. What is sam, and what is khali?

Sam is the first beat of a tala cycle, where musicians aim to land together. Khali ("empty") is a section marked with a wave instead of a clap; on the tabla it is played mostly without the deep bass.

3. How many beats are in Teentaal, and on which beat is the wave?

Teentaal has 16 beats in four sections of four. The wave (khali) is on beat 9; claps fall on beats 1, 5 and 13.

4. Name one main difference between Hindustani and Carnatic music.

Possible answers: Hindustani music is from the north and puts more weight on long improvisation, with tabla and sitar; Carnatic music is from the south and centers on composed songs, with mridangam, violin and veena.

5. What is a playback singer?

A professional singer who records film songs in a studio while actors lip-sync them on screen.

Exercises

Remember

1. Name the seven sargam syllables in order.

Answer

Sa, re, ga, ma, pa, dha, ni (then sa again an octave higher).

2. Which UNESCO list includes Baul songs, and in what year were they placed on it?

Answer

UNESCO's Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity, in 2008. They were first proclaimed a masterpiece in 2005.

Understand

1. Explain why Rupak tala can be tricky for beginners.

> **Answer**
>
> Rupak's first section is khali, so sam (beat 1) is a wave, not a clap. Listeners waiting for the loudest beat may mistake beat 4 for the start of the cycle.

2. Explain what a gharana is and why gharanas are usually named after places.

> **Answer**
>
> A gharana is a lineage of musicians, connected by family or by teacher and student, who share a style. Most are named after the city or court where the founders worked, such as Gwalior or Patiala.

Apply

1. Use the Tala Clapper to count three full cycles of Dadra at 80 beats per minute. Write down how many claps and how many waves you made, and how long one cycle took in seconds. *Hint: at 80 beats per minute, each beat lasts 60 ÷ 80 seconds.*
2. Your club is planning a five-minute "music around South Asia" playlist for a meeting. Choose four songs or pieces from four different countries using this chapter, and write one sentence per choice naming its form (for example qawwali, Baul, boduberu or filmi). *Hint: the folk table in 9.9 covers all eight countries.*

Analyze

1. Compare qawwali and ghazal. How are they alike, and how do they differ in setting, sound and purpose? *Hint: think about shrines versus small gatherings, and chorus versus solo voice.*
2. The violin came from Europe and the harmonium from Europe too, yet both are now central to South Asian music. Analyze what this tells you about how musical traditions change. Use at least one other example from the chapter. *Hint: consider the sitar's Persian name or British bhangra.*

Evaluate

1. Some people say film music has "watered down" classical music; others say it has brought ragas to millions who would never attend a concert. Which view do you find more convincing? Support your answer with evidence from the chapter. *Hint: a strong answer considers both sides.*
2. The Whose Story? box gives several accounts of the sitar's and tabla's origins. Evaluate which kind of evidence (written records, instrument names, temple carvings) you find most convincing, and why. *Hint: ask what each kind of evidence can and cannot prove.*

Create

1. Invent your own tala of 10 or 12 beats. Decide how to divide it into sections, mark sam, claps and at least one wave, and write out how to count it with your hands. Teach it to a friend. *Hint: Jhaptaal, a real Hindustani tala, has 10 beats divided 2 + 3 + 2 + 3.*
2. Write a short "liner note" (100 to 150 words) introducing a South Asian song your family loves to a friend who has never heard it. Explain its form,

language and where people hear it, without quoting the lyrics. *Hint: use at least two concept words from this chapter.*

Key Takeaways

- A raga is a framework for melody (notes, movement, emphasis and signature phrases), not just a scale; sargam (sa re ga ma pa dha ni) names its notes.
- A tala is a repeating cycle of beats counted with claps, waves and finger taps. Sam, the first beat, is where musicians land together; khali is the "empty" wave.
- Teentaal has 16 beats (wave on 9), Rupak 7 (starting on a wave), Dadra 6 and the Carnatic Adi tala 8.
- Hindustani music (north) and Carnatic music (south) share roots but differ in instruments, emphasis and repertoire; both pass from teacher to student through the guru-shishya tradition, and in the north through gharanas.
- The sitar, tabla and veena are classical icons, and instruments like the violin and harmonium show how traditions absorb new sounds.
- Qawwali (Sufi devotion), ghazal (sung poetry) and Baul songs (sung by wandering Bengali devotional singers) express faith and love; every one of the eight countries has its own folk music, and bhangra went global from Punjab and Britain.
- Film music, sung by playback singers, is among the most widely heard music in the region, and it has won Academy Awards in 2009 and 2023.

You found beat one!

You can now count a tala, tell a raga from a scale, and name the music of all eight countries. Next, in Chapter 10, we add movement: the classical dances and theater that turn these rhythms into stories.

Quiz: Music

Test your understanding of Chapter 9. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

What is sam?

A. The drone note held under a raga

B. A five-note raga sung in the evening

C. The first beat of a tala cycle, where musicians aim to land together

D. The bass drum of the tabla

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Sam is the first beat of a tala cycle and its most important arrival point. The drone comes from a tanpura or similar instrument, and the tabla's bass drum is the bayan.

Concept Tested: Tala **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

Which instrument is a pair of hand drums, with a smaller tuned drum for the right hand and a larger bass drum for the left?

A. Tabla

B. Mridangam

C. Dhol

D. Veena

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The tabla is a pair of drums: the dayan (right) and the bayan (left). The mridangam is a single drum with two heads, used in Carnatic music, and the dhol is a large two-sided drum played with sticks in bhangra.

Concept Tested: Tabla **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

Baul songs, placed on UNESCO's Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2008, come mainly from which region?

A. Punjab, in Pakistan and India

B. Kerala, in southern India

C. The Kathmandu Valley of Nepal

D. Bangladesh and India's West Bengal

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The Bauls are wandering devotional singers of Bangladesh and West Bengal, and their most famous figure, Lalon, lived near Kushtia in present-day Bangladesh. Punjab is the home of bhangra, not Baul music.

Concept Tested: Baul Music **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Why is a raga not the same thing as a scale?

A. A raga always uses all twelve notes

B. A raga also sets how to move up and down, which notes to stress, and signature phrases

C. A raga is a rhythm, not a melody

D. A raga can only be played on the sitar

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. A raga includes a set of notes but also rules for ascending and descending, emphasis, ornaments and characteristic phrases. That's why two ragas, like Bhoopali and Deshkar, can share the same notes and still be different. A rhythm cycle is a tala, not a raga.

Concept Tested: Raga **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

What does it mean that Hindustani music developed through gharanas?

A. Musicians learned in lineages, linked by family or teacher and student, each with its own recognizable style

B. Music was written down in printed books for each city

C. Every musician belonged to the same national music school

D. Musicians were only allowed to play in temples

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. A gharana is a "musical household," a lineage of musicians connected by family or apprenticeship who share a style, usually named after a place such as Gwalior or Patiala. The music was traditionally passed on orally, not through printed books.

Concept Tested: Gharana **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 6

Which statement best describes qawwali?

A. A Punjabi harvest dance with the dhol

B. Love poetry in rhyming couplets, sung softly by a solo singer

C. Sufi devotional music sung at shrines, building in energy to bring listeners closer to God

D. A style of film song recorded by playback singers

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Qawwali is Sufi Muslim devotional music, traditionally sung at dargahs, with a lead singer, chorus, harmonium and percussion. Option B describes the ghazal, a related but quieter, more intimate form built around the poem.

Concept Tested: Qawwali **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

Zara is counting Teentaal with the Tala Clapper. She hears the deep bass go quiet and sees "Wave" on beat 9. How many more beats until sam?

A. 4

B. 8

C. 9

D. 16

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The wave (khali) in Teentaal falls on beat 9, so sam comes after beats 9 through 16, eight beats later. Answer C confuses the beat number of khali with the distance to sam.

Concept Tested: Tala **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

At a concert, Ben notices a musician playing a long-necked instrument with a round gourd body. Many extra strings ring by themselves under the frets whenever she plays. Which instrument is it most likely to be?

A. Tabla

B. Harmonium

C. Ektara

D. Sitar

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The sitar has a gourd body, movable curved frets and sympathetic strings that run under the frets and ring in sympathy with the played strings. The ektara has just one string, and the harmonium is a hand-pumped keyboard.

Concept Tested: Sitar **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Compare Hindustani and Carnatic music. Which pairing is correct?

A. Hindustani: mridangam and veena; Carnatic: tabla and sitar

B. Hindustani: composed songs only; Carnatic: no compositions at all

C. Hindustani: tabla, long raga improvisation, Teentaal; Carnatic: mridangam, composed songs at the center, Adi tala

D. Hindustani is only from Pakistan; Carnatic is only from Sri Lanka

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Hindustani music (northern India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal) uses the tabla and gives long time to improvising on the raga, with Teentaal as a famous tala. Carnatic music (southern India and Tamil communities) centers on composed songs, with the mridangam and Adi tala. Option A swaps the two systems' instruments.

Concept Tested: Carnatic Music **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

The violin came from Europe, yet it is now at the heart of Carnatic concerts. What does this best show about South Asian music?

A. Traditions absorb new instruments and make them their own, as with the harmonium and the sitar's Persian roots

B. Carnatic music was invented in Europe

C. South Asian music has never changed over time

D. Only Western instruments can play ragas

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Balaswami Dikshitar adapted the violin to Carnatic music, and it is now played seated with the scroll on the foot. The harmonium and the sitar's Persian-derived name show the same pattern of borrowing and adapting. Carnatic music itself grew in southern India, not Europe.

Concept Tested: Carnatic Music **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 10: Dance and Theater

Summary

South Asia has many ways to tell a story with the body. This chapter starts with the Natya Shastra, an old Sanskrit handbook on performance, and two of its big ideas: rasa (the feeling an audience tastes) and mudra (hand gestures that work like words). It then tours the eight classical dances that India's national academy recognizes, from Bharatanatyam in Tamil Nadu to Sattriya in Assam, and shows how to tell them apart. Finally it widens the circle to folk dances and theater across the region, including Garba, Bhangra, Attan, Kandyan dance, Bhutan's masked dances and shadow puppetry.

Concepts Covered

1. Natya Shastra
2. Rasa
3. Mudra
4. Classical Dance
5. Bharatanatyam
6. Kathak
7. Odissi
8. Kathakali
9. Kuchipudi

10. Manipuri Dance
11. Mohiniyattam
12. Sattriya
13. Folk Dance
14. Garba
15. Kandyan Dance
16. Attan
17. Shadow Puppetry

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?, for the map and the eight countries.
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia, because many dances tell stories from Hindu, Buddhist and other traditions.
- Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year, since many folk dances belong to festivals such as Navaratri and Vaisakhi.
- Chapter 9: Music, for raga, tala and the drums that dancers move to.

Let's dance!

Hi, I'm Mora! Maybe you've been dragged onto the floor at a wedding, or watched a cousin's dance recital, or seen a viral Bhangra video and wondered where it came from. This chapter helps you see what is happening when a South Asian dancer moves, so the next time you watch, you can read the story, not just the costume. Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

10.1 "Great Bharatanatyam, Arjun!"

It's culture night at Prairie Ridge High School, the first big event of the new South Asian Student Association. The cafeteria has been turned into a stage with string lights and a borrowed speaker. Zara Hossain is running the slideshow. Ben Lindqvist is in charge of snacks, which means he has already eaten half of them.

Their friend Arjun Reddy steps out in a bright silk costume with a pleated fan at the front, bells around his ankles, and his eyes lined in black. For eight minutes he stamps out fast rhythms, freezes into poses like a temple statue, and acts out a whole story with his face and hands. Near the end, he jumps onto the rim of a brass plate and keeps dancing on it. The room goes wild.

Afterward, Ben finds him by the water fountain. "Dude. Great Bharatanatyam!"

Arjun laughs so hard he has to sit down. "It's Kuchipudi! My family is from Hyderabad. Kuchipudi comes from a village in Andhra Pradesh. Bharatanatyam is from Tamil Nadu."

Ben looks at Zara for help. Zara shrugs. She has seen both at weddings and festivals, and honestly, she isn't sure she could tell them apart either. Both have bells, both have hand gestures, both have that bent-knee stance. So what makes one dance different from another, and who decides which ones count as "classical"?

10.2 Dance as a Language

Before learning any names, think about how you already "read" people's bodies. A referee's arm signals tell you a foul happened. A friend's raised eyebrow says "really?" without a word. American Sign Language turns hand

shapes into full sentences. And a good actor can make you cry without saying anything.

Many South Asian dance traditions combine all of these at once. A dancer might:

- keep a **beat** with the feet, like a drummer,
- make **hand shapes** that stand for a lotus, a bird, a king or the moon,
- use the **face and eyes** to show feelings such as love, anger or wonder,
- and **act out a story**, often from an epic like the Ramayana or Mahabharata, or a poem about Krishna.

Teachers often break a performance into three layers, using Sanskrit words:

Layer	What it means	Example
Nritta (pure dance)	Rhythm and shapes with no story, like a drum solo for the body	A fast run of footwork that lands exactly on the last beat
Nritya (expressive dance)	Movement that carries meaning through gestures and the face	Hands become a blooming lotus while the face shows delight
Natya (drama)	Acting a full story with characters	One dancer plays both a worried mother and her mischievous child

Once you can spot these three layers, you can start to see what a dancer is doing even if you've never seen that style before.

10.3 The Natya Shastra: An Old Handbook for the Stage

Where did these ideas come from? Many dancers trace them to one famous text.

The **Natya Shastra** (नाट्य शास्त्र, *NAHT-yuh SHAHS-truh*), "treatise on drama," is a Sanskrit handbook on the performing arts. Tradition credits it to a sage named Bharata. Nobody knows exactly when it was written. Scholars think it grew over a long time, and most place its first complete version somewhere between about 200 BCE and 200 CE, though estimates range more widely, from about 500 BCE to 500 CE.

It is a big book: about 6,000 verses in 36 chapters. It covers playwriting, stage building, acting, makeup, costumes, body movement, hand gestures and music, so it works like a drama textbook and a choreography manual in one. Later writers added their own books on top of it. One of the most used by dancers today is the *Abhinaya Darpana* ("Mirror of Gesture"), credited to a writer named Nandikeshvara, which describes hand gestures in detail.

In April 2025, UNESCO added manuscripts of the Natya Shastra, together with the Bhagavad Gita, to its Memory of the World Register, a list of documents considered important to all of humanity.

Old text, living art

The Natya Shastra is old, but no dance today is a frozen copy of it. Each classical style took its present shape much later, often in the last few hundred years, and teachers keep changing it. A good question to ask any dancer is: "Which parts come from the old books, and which parts did your own teachers create?"

10.4 Rasa: The Flavor of a Performance

Have you ever left a movie feeling a mood you couldn't shake, like the warm glow after a happy ending or the shivers after a scary scene? The Natya Shastra has a word for that.

Rasa (रस, *RUH-suh*) literally means "juice," "taste" or "essence." In the arts, a rasa is the emotional flavor that a performance creates in the audience. The idea is that the performer shows a feeling (called a *bhava*), and a sensitive audience member "tastes" it as a rasa. In Sanskrit, an ideal audience member is called a *sahridaya*, "one who has heart."

The Natya Shastra lists eight rasas. Later thinkers argued for centuries about adding a ninth, *shanta* (peace), and it was eventually widely accepted. That's why dancers often talk about the *navarasa*, the "nine rasas."

Rasa	Feeling	A dancer might show it by...
Shringara	Love, beauty	Soft eyes, a shy smile, a gentle tilt of the head
Hasya	Laughter, comedy	Playful eyebrows, a cheeky grin
Karuna	Sorrow, compassion	Drooping shoulders, eyes filling with tears
Raudra	Fury	Wide eyes, flaring nostrils, sharp stamps
Vira	Heroism, courage	Tall posture, firm gaze, strong steps

Rasa	Feeling	A dancer might show it by...
Bhayanaka	Fear	Darting eyes, shrinking back
Bibhatsa	Disgust	Turning away, wrinkling the nose
Adbhuta	Wonder, amazement	Wide-open eyes, raised brows, an open mouth
Shanta (added later)	Peace, calm	Stillness, a soft and even face

Rasa isn't only for dance. The same idea shaped music, poetry, painting and sculpture in South Asia.

10.5 Mudra: Speaking with Your Hands

If rasa is the feeling, mudras are a big part of the vocabulary.

A **mudra** (मुद्रा, *MOO-druh*) is a hand gesture with a set shape and set meanings. In Hindi the word can also mean a seal or a stamp, which fits: each mudra "stamps" an idea into the air. Dancers also use the Sanskrit word *hasta*, "hand." The *Abhinaya Darpana* describes 28 single-hand gestures (*asamyuta hasta*) and about two dozen two-hand gestures (*samyuta hasta*; versions of the text count 23 or 24), and teachers add many more.

A single mudra can mean many different things, depending on where the hand is, how it moves, and what the face is doing. It works like a word with several meanings, where context tells you which one is meant. Here are six of the first single-hand mudras that students learn, with a few of the meanings listed in a 1917 English translation of the *Abhinaya Darpana*:

Mudra	Name means	Hand shape	A few meanings
Pataka	Flag	Fingers straight and pressed together, thumb bent in	Clouds, forest, waves, a blessing, saying "Go!"
Tripataka	Three parts of the flag	Like Pataka, but the ring finger is bent	A crown, a tree, an arrow, a lamp's flame
Ardhapataka	Half flag	Like Tripataka, with the little finger also bent	Young leaves, a knife, a tower, a riverbank
Kartarimukha	Scissors face	First two fingers spread like scissor blades, the others folded	Separation, lightning, the corner of the eye
Mayura	Peacock	Ring finger touches the thumb tip, the other fingers up	A peacock's beak, wiping away tears, putting a mark on the forehead
Alapadma	Full-bloomed lotus	All fingers spread and curved, like a flower opening	A blooming lotus, the full moon, a mirror, praise

Teachers and styles describe some of these shapes a little differently, so don't worry if your cousin's dance teacher holds Kartarimukha a bit differently

from the drawing in the MicroSim.

You'll also see hand gestures outside dance, in Hindu and Buddhist statues and paintings, such as an open palm raised to mean "do not fear." Dancers, sculptors and painters shared much of this visual language. (Chapter 11 looks at the sculpture and painting side.)

10.6 What Makes a Dance "Classical"?

Now back to Ben's question: what does "classical" mean?

In this book, **Classical Dance** means a dance tradition with a long, written theory behind it (usually traced to the Natya Shastra), a fixed technique that takes years of training with a teacher, a set order of pieces in a performance, and official recognition as a classical art. It's similar to how people use "classical" for Western ballet or for Carnatic and Hindustani music: it describes a trained, codified art form, not something better than other dance.

So who decides which dances count? In India, the main official body is the **Sangeet Natak Akademi**, the national academy of music, dance and drama, created by the Indian government in 1952. It recognizes eight classical dances:

1. Bharatanatyam
2. Kathak
3. Kuchipudi
4. Odissi
5. Kathakali
6. Sattriya
7. Manipuri

8. Mohiniyattam

Sattriya was the most recent addition. The Akademi recognized it on 15 November 2000.

Is it eight, nine or more?

Be careful with "India has eight classical dances." That's the Sangeet Natak Akademi's list, but India's Ministry of Culture also lists Chhau, a masked dance from eastern India, which makes nine, and some lists add more. Scholars disagree too, so the honest answer is "eight, according to the national academy."

Chhau comes from eastern India and has three main styles, named after the places they grew up: Seraikella, Purulia and Mayurbhanj. It mixes dance with martial-arts moves and is traditionally taught to men. The Seraikella and Purulia styles use masks. UNESCO added Chhau to its list of the world's intangible cultural heritage in 2010.

Other countries draw the line differently. In Bangladesh, *Banglapedia* (the national encyclopedia) says classical dance there mainly means Kathak, Bharatanatyam, Kathakali, Odissi and Manipuri, learned from teachers of those schools. In Sri Lanka, the Kandyan dance tradition has its own long training and rules, even though it isn't on India's list.

10.7 A Tour of the Eight Classical Dances

Here's a quick guide to all eight. Use it like a field guide: notice where each comes from, what the dancers wear, and one or two things that make it easy to spot.

Dance	Home region (today)	Easy-to-spot features
Bharatanatyam	Tamil Nadu	Half-sitting bent-knee stance, crisp geometric lines, fan-pleated costume
Kathak	North India, also Pakistan and Bangladesh	Straight legs, fast spins, hundreds of ankle bells, footwork "conversations" with the tabla
Odissi	Odisha	S-shaped *tribhangi* pose, square *chauka* stance, silver jewelry
Kathakali	Kerala	Painted green faces, huge skirts and crowns, all-night dance-dramas
Kuchipudi	Andhra Pradesh	Dance-drama roots, quick leaps, dancing on the rim of a brass plate
Manipuri Dance	Manipur, also Sylhet (Bangladesh)	Soft rounded moves, no stamping, stiff barrel-shaped mirrored skirt
Mohiniyattam	Kerala	Gentle swaying, white-and-gold sari, a hair bun to one side

Dance	Home region (today)	Easy-to-spot features
Sattriya	Assam	Born in monasteries, played with the *khol* drum, Krishna stories

Bharatanatyam

Bharatanatyam (பரதநாட்டியம், *BHUH-ruh-tuh-NAHT-yum*) comes from Tamil Nadu in southern India. Its older name was *Sadir*. For centuries the dance was closely linked to Hindu temples and royal courts in the Tamil region. Later, four musicians and teachers known as the Thanjavur Quartet organized much of the order of pieces still used today.

In the late 1800s and early 1900s, colonial officials, missionaries and some Indian reformers attacked temple dance and the hereditary women dancers who performed it, and the dance nearly disappeared. In the 1930s, revivalists including Rukmini Devi Arundale and E. Krishna Iyer helped bring it to concert stages under a new name, Bharatanatyam, adopted in 1932.

You can spot Bharatanatyam by its *aramandi*, a half-sitting position with bent knees turned out, a steady upper body, and sharp, geometric arm lines. The dancer usually performs solo for up to two hours, with a singer, drummer and a *nattuvanar* (conductor) keeping the rhythm with small cymbals.

Kathak

Kathak (*KUH-thuk*) comes from northern India. Its name comes from *katha*, the Sanskrit word for "story." Many dancers trace it to traveling storytellers who acted out tales, especially about Krishna, though historians debate how direct that link is. Later it was also danced in royal courts, including Mughal

courts and the court of Awadh in Lucknow, where Persian poetry and music shaped it. That double history, in temples and storytelling on one side and Muslim-ruled courts on the other, is part of why Kathak is danced today in India, Pakistan and Bangladesh.

Kathak dancers keep their legs straight and wear ankle bells called *ghungroo*, sometimes with more than a hundred bells on each ankle. Footwork patterns called *tatkar* trade rhythms with the tabla player, and dancers finish phrases with dizzying spins. Different schools, called *gharanas*, are named after cities such as Jaipur, Lucknow and Banaras (Varanasi).

Odissi

Odissi (*oh-DIS-ee*) comes from Odisha on India's east coast. Dancing figures carved on the walls of Odisha's old temples, such as the Sun Temple at Konark, show poses that dancers still use. Like Bharatanatyam, Odissi was attacked under colonial rule and rebuilt in the twentieth century.

Look for two poses. The *chauka* is a strong, square stance with bent knees. The *tribhangi* ("three bends") curves the body into an S-shape at the neck, waist and knee, like a statue come to life. Many pieces are devotional poems about Jagannath (whom many devotees see as a form of Vishnu) and Krishna, especially from the twelfth-century Sanskrit poem *Gita Govinda*.

Kathakali

Kathakali (കഥകളി, *KUH-thuh-kuh-lee*), "story play," comes from Kerala in southwest India. It developed from older temple and folk arts and took its full form a few centuries ago. Unlike most classical dances, it grew up mainly in the courts and theaters of local kings.

Kathakali is easy to recognize. Performers wear thick makeup, giant skirts and tall crowns, and the makeup color tells you who a character is. *Pacha*

(green) faces with bright red lips are noble heroes and gods such as Krishna and Rama. *Kathi* ("knife") faces, green with red marks, are proud or villainous characters, and *kari* (black) is for demons and forest beings. Performances were traditionally all-night shows by male actors, with the story sung by vocalists while the actors "speak" only through mudras, eyes and face.

Kerala is also home to **Kutiyattam**, a form of Sanskrit theater that UNESCO describes as one of India's oldest living theater traditions. Male actors traditionally performed it in special theaters inside Hindu temples, and a full performance can last up to 40 days. UNESCO first recognized it in 2001.

Kuchipudi

Kuchipudi (కూచిపూడి, *KOO-chee-POO-dee*) is named after a village in Andhra Pradesh. As Arjun said, it's from the Telugu-speaking region. It began as a dance-drama performed by troupes of men from the village, who played every role. Tradition credits a seventeenth-century devotee named Siddhendra Yogi with shaping it. In the twentieth century it also became a solo dance, often performed by women.

Kuchipudi shares a lot with Bharatanatyam, which is why Ben mixed them up. Both use a bent-knee stance, mudras and Carnatic music. But Kuchipudi tends to be faster and bouncier, with more leaps and a strong acting side, and the songs are usually in Telugu. Its best-known feature is the *tarangam*, where the dancer performs on the rim of a brass plate, sometimes balancing a pot of water on the head.

Manipuri Dance

Manipuri Dance comes from Manipur in northeastern India, where it is part of the culture of the Meitei people. The best-known form is the *Raas Leela*, dances about Krishna and Radha. A Meitei king, Bhagyachandra, who ruled

in the second half of the 1700s, is credited with organizing the style and designing its famous costume.

Manipuri movement is soft and rounded, with no hard stamping, and the dancers' faces stay calm and gentle. Women playing the *gopis* (cowherd girls who love Krishna) wear the *potloi*, a stiff, barrel-shaped skirt decorated with mirrors and embroidery that makes them look as if they're floating. Manipuri is also danced in Bangladesh, especially in Sylhet. In 1919 the poet Rabindranath Tagore saw a Manipuri performance in Sylhet and later brought Manipuri teachers to his school at Shantiniketan, which helped make the dance known across Bengal.

Mohiniyattam

Mohiniyattam (*mo-hi-nee-YAHT-tum*) is Kerala's second classical dance. It is named after Mohini, the enchanting female form of the Hindu god Vishnu. Mohiniyattam is traditionally a solo dance by women. Its movements sway gently from side to side, a little like palm trees in the breeze or waves on the backwaters, and it uses the soft, graceful style that the Natya Shastra calls *lasya*. Dancers wear an ivory-white sari with a gold border, and a round hair bun worn to one side.

By the early 1900s, colonial-era prejudice against temple and court dancers had pushed Mohiniyattam almost out of sight. The Malayalam poet Vallathol Narayana Menon led its revival. In 1930 he founded the Kerala Kalamandalam, a school for Kerala's performing arts, and in the early 1930s it began teaching Mohiniyattam.

Sattriya

Sattriya (*SUT-tree-yuh*) comes from Assam in northeastern India. It began in the *sattras*, Vaishnava (Krishna-worshipping) monasteries started by the teacher, poet and playwright Srimanta Sankardev (1449 to 1568) and his

followers. Sankardev wrote short dance-dramas, and for centuries male monks called *bhokots* performed them as part of worship.

In the second half of the twentieth century, Sattriya moved from the monasteries to public stages, and women began to perform it too. Its music features the *khol*, a two-headed clay drum played with the fingers, along with cymbals. When the Sangeet Natak Akademi recognized it in 2000, it became the eighth classical dance on the list.

10.8 Folk Dance: Dance for Everyone

Classical dance usually needs years of lessons, but most dancing in South Asia doesn't. A **folk dance** is a dance that grows out of a community's everyday life: harvests, weddings, festivals, worship and seasons. Anyone in the community can join. The steps are passed on by watching and doing rather than from textbooks, and they change from village to village.

"Folk" doesn't mean simple or less skilled. Bhangra dancers and Garba circles can be fiercely athletic and complex. The difference is about who dances, where and how the dance is learned, not about quality.

Garba (India)

Garba (ગરબા, *GUR-bah*) comes from Gujarat in western India. It's danced during **Navaratri**, the "nine nights" festival honoring the Hindu goddess (see Chapter 7). Traditionally, dancers move counterclockwise in circles around a clay pot with holes in it and a lamp burning inside, or around an image of the goddess Amba. The circle starts slowly with clapping and singing, then speeds up into fast, whirling steps. A related dance, *dandiya raas*, uses pairs of decorated sticks that dancers clack together.

In 2023, UNESCO added Garba of Gujarat to its Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. Today Garba nights draw huge crowds in Indian cities and in diaspora communities, and many community and campus Garba nights in North America welcome anyone who wants to join the circle.

Bhangra and Luddi (India and Pakistan)

Bhangra comes from Punjab, a region split between India and Pakistan in 1947 (see Chapter 4). It began with farmers celebrating the harvest, especially around the spring festival of Vaisakhi. Dancers leap, kick and pump their shoulders with raised arms to the heavy beat of the *dhol*, a big two-headed drum, while singers shout short verses called *boliyan*. Bhangra today has grown into a whole music genre and a competitive college sport in the UK, US and Canada.

Luddi is another Punjabi folk dance, danced on both sides of the border. Men and women dance it in circles at weddings and celebrations, clapping, snapping their fingers and doing half-turns.

Attan (Afghanistan and Pakistan)

Attan (اتڼ, *uh-TUN*) is a Pashtun circle dance and is widely called the national dance of Afghanistan. Pashtuns in Pakistan dance it too, and other Afghan communities have taken it up. Dancers move in a big circle around the drummer, clapping and spinning, with the *dhol* starting slow and building to a fast finish. A performance can last from about 5 to 30 minutes. Historically it was danced before battles to build courage. Today it's most often seen at weddings and celebrations, including in Afghan communities around the world.

Different regions have their own versions, such as Kabuli and Kandahari styles. In northwestern Pakistan, the *Khattak* dance, a fast sword-and-

handkerchief version danced by men of the Khattak tribe, is a famous relative of Attan.

Kandyan Dance (Sri Lanka)

Kandyan Dance comes from the hill country around Kandy in Sri Lanka's central highlands. In Sinhala it's called *Uda Rata Natum*, "up-country dance." Legend traces it to a healing ritual called the *Kohomba Kankariya*, and for generations its dancers served the Temple of the Sacred Tooth Relic in Kandy and performed in the city's great yearly procession, the *Perahera*.

Kandyan dancers are known for high leaps, fast spins and strong, athletic footwork. The most famous costume is the *ves*, with a shining metal headdress, a beaded net over the chest and rattling anklets. The music is mostly drumming, led by the *geta bera*, the main drum of Kandyan dance, though some pieces also have sung verses. There are 18 classic *vannam*, solo dances that each describe an animal or idea, such as the elephant, the monkey or the eagle. Traditionally only men trained in the dance, but today many schools teach women too. Many Sri Lankans, especially Sinhalese, see Kandyan dance as a symbol of their culture, at home and in the diaspora.

More dances across the region

- **Bhutan:** Buddhist monasteries hold festivals with *cham*, masked dances that teach moral lessons and honor Buddhist teachers. One of them, the *Drametse Ngacham* ("mask dance of the drums from Drametse"), features sixteen masked men and ten musicians. UNESCO first recognized it in 2005.
- **Nepal:** In the Kathmandu Valley, Newar communities perform the *Lakhey* dance at festivals. A dancer in a fierce mask with fangs and a long mane of hair plays a forest demon who became a protector of the town.

- **The Maldives:** *Boduberu* ("big drum") is the Maldives' best-known music and dance. A group of about 15 to 20 performers, usually with three drummers and a lead singer, starts slow and builds to a fast finish while one or two dancers move to the beat.
- **Bangladesh:** Besides Manipuri in Sylhet, Bangladesh has many folk dances and a famous folk theater, *jatra*, described in the next section.

10.9 Theater and Shadow Puppetry

Many South Asian dance forms are really dance-drama. The same region also has theater traditions where acting, singing and puppetry come first.

Jatra (যাত্রা, *JAH-trah*), "journey," is a lively folk theater of Bengal, performed in Bangladesh and in India's West Bengal, Odisha and Assam. It goes back at least to the 1500s, when it grew out of devotional plays about Krishna. Jatra was traditionally played on open ground with the audience all around, and it mixed songs, dances, loud dialogue and comic characters. Over time it took up history, social issues and, in the twentieth century, patriotic themes. Jatra troupes still tour villages and towns today.

Yakshagana from coastal Karnataka is an all-night dance-drama with huge headdresses, painted faces and a lead singer who narrates the story. It isn't on any official "classical" list.

Shadow Puppetry is a form of storytelling in which flat cut-out figures are held between a light and a thin cloth screen, so the audience sees moving shadows. South India has several shadow puppet traditions, and they share a word for leather:

Tradition	Where	What the name means
Tholu bommalata	Andhra Pradesh	"Dance of leather dolls" (Telugu)
Togalu gombeyaata	Karnataka	"Play of leather dolls" (Kannada)
Tholpavakoothu	Kerala and Tamil Nadu	"Leather doll play" (Malayalam and Tamil)

The puppets are cut from animal hide, scraped so thin that light shines through, and painted in bright colors, so the shadows glow with color. Puppeteers sit behind the screen, move the jointed puppets with sticks, sing and speak all the voices, and often perform stories from the Ramayana all night. In Kerala, *Tholpavakoothu* is performed in temples of the goddess Bhadrakali, and a full Ramayana cycle can run for weeks of night-long shows. Many historians think South Asian shadow theater influenced shadow puppet traditions in Southeast Asia, though how and when are still debated.

Whose Story?

Who gets to say which dances are "classical"? India's Sangeet Natak Akademi lists eight, India's Ministry of Culture adds Chhau, and dancers in West Bengal and elsewhere have argued for other styles to join the list. In Bangladesh, the national encyclopedia uses "classical dance" mainly for styles such as Kathak and Manipuri that Bengali dancers learned from teachers of those schools, while many Sri Lankans see Kandyan dance as their own classical tradition with its own rules. Historians also tell the revival story of the 1930s in different ways. Some celebrate the revivalists who saved Bharatanatyam and Odissi from colonial attacks. Others point out that the hereditary women performers who had kept these dances alive for generations were often pushed aside in the process.

10.10 Dance Today

A week after culture night, Arjun is teaching Ben the basic Kuchipudi stance in the school hallway. Ben's knees are shaking. "How long did you have to practice this?"

"Eight years," Arjun says. "And I still have a teacher." He shows Ben a Pataka hand, then turns it into a wave rolling across the sea.

Many classical dancers study for years before a first full-length solo recital, which in Bharatanatyam is called an *arangetram*.

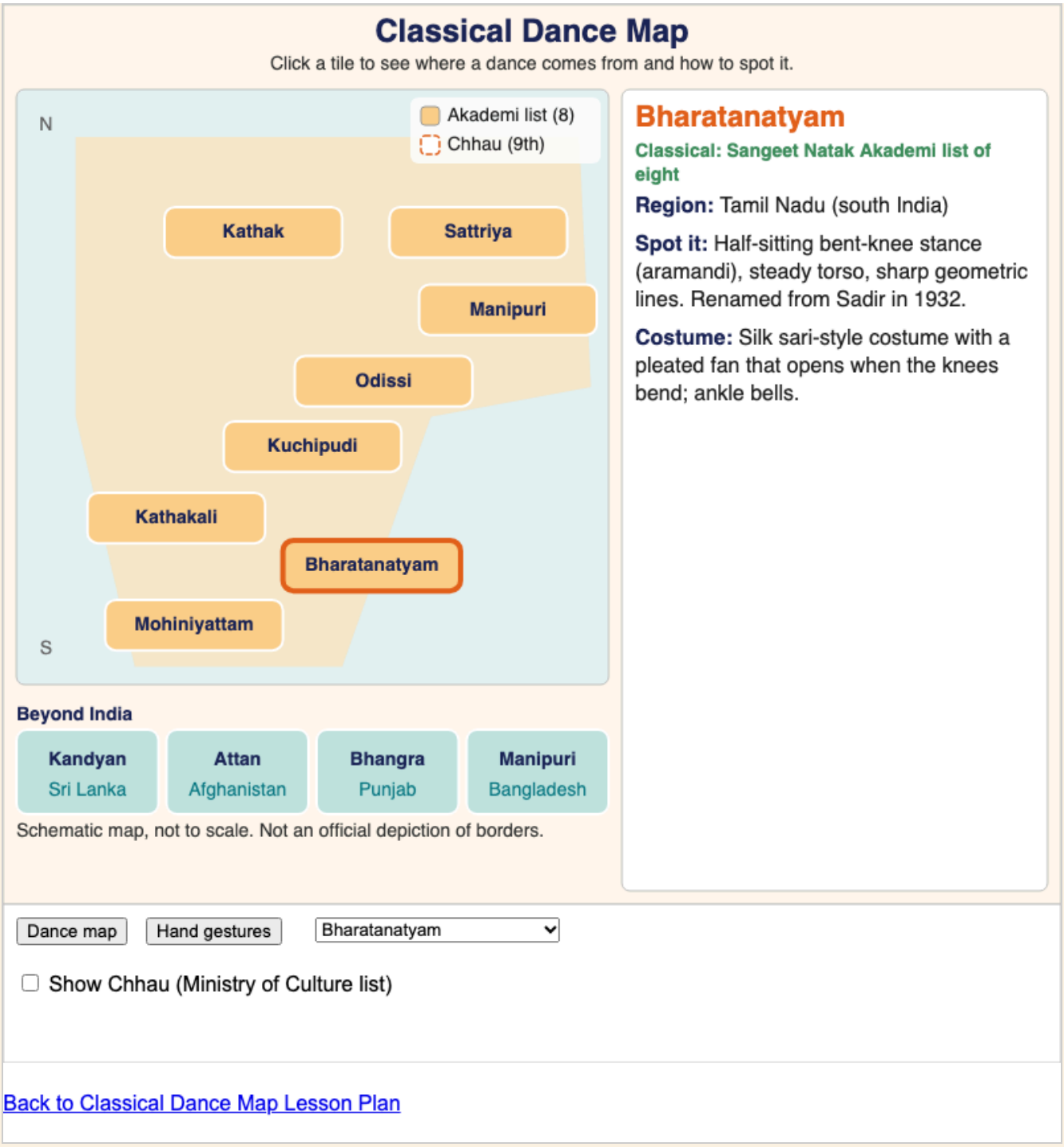
At the same time, dance keeps changing. Film songs from Mumbai (formerly Bombay), Lahore, Dhaka and Chennai mix classical gestures, folk steps and hip-hop. College teams compete in Bhangra, Garba-Raas and "fusion" contests. Kandyan dancers perform at Sri Lankan community events abroad, and Afghan families dance Attan at weddings far from Afghanistan. "Bollywood dance" (popular film dance from India's Hindi film industry) is its

own fun, mixed style. It borrows from many traditions, but it isn't the same as any one classical dance.

How to watch a dance like an expert

Next time you watch a performance, ask three questions: Is this pure rhythm (*nritta*), expression (*nritya*) or drama (*natya*)? Which rasa is the dancer showing right now? And what is that hand saying? You'll notice far more than before.

Diagram: Classical Dance Map



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch10-classical-dance-map/main.html

Open the Classical Dance Map fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Classical Dance Map

sim-id: ch10-classical-dance-map
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: distinguish
Learning Objective: The learner will distinguish the eight classical dances recognized by the Sangeet Natak Akademi by home region, key movement features and costume, and identify six basic single-hand mudras and their meanings.

Canvas: responsive width; 680 px drawing area plus 120 px control area.

Controls: "Dance map" and "Hand gestures" buttons, a menu of dances or mudras, a "Show Chhau (Ministry of Culture list)" checkbox; click or tap any tile or hand.

Behavior: The map view shows schematic region tiles (no borders) for the eight classical dances in roughly their home regions, plus a "Beyond India" row with Kandyan dance (Sri Lanka), Attan (Afghanistan and Pakistan), Bhangra and Luddi (Punjab, India and Pakistan) and Manipuri in Sylhet (Bangladesh). Selecting a tile shows the region, key features and costume. The checkbox adds Chhau as a dashed tile to show the eight-versus-nine debate. The hand gestures view draws six single-hand mudras with simple shapes; selecting one shows its name, meaning of the name and several meanings. The caption "Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders." is drawn inside the drawing area.

Start in the **Dance map** view. Click each of the eight classical tiles and read the panel. Try to find one feature for each dance that would help you tell it apart from its neighbors, especially the two Kerala dances (Kathakali and Mohiniyattam) and the two southern dances Ben confused (Bharatanatyam

and Kuchipudi). Then tick the Chhau checkbox and notice how the "official" list changes depending on who is counting.

Next, switch to **Hand gestures**. Look at how each mudra is built from the one before it: Pataka, then bend one finger for Tripataka, then another for Ardhapataka. Try making each shape with your own hand as you read its meanings. Notice that one shape can mean very different things, like Pataka meaning both "clouds" and "Go!"

Ask Your Elders

> **Your interview for this chapter**
>
> Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about dance in their life: dances at weddings and festivals, whether anyone in the family learned a classical dance, and folk dances from their village, town or region. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Ask if they have any old photos or videos of a wedding, festival or recital, and look at them together. Ask permission before taking notes or recording.

Questions to ask

1. What is the first dance you remember seeing or doing, and where were you?
2. What dances happened at weddings, festivals or religious events in your family or community?

3. Did you or anyone in the family learn a classical dance? What was the teacher like, and how long did it take?
4. Was there a folk dance special to your village, town or region? Can you show me a step?
5. How has dancing at weddings or festivals changed since you were young, or since moving to a new country?
6. Is there a dance, song or step you hope I'll learn and keep?

Listen for: names of classical styles such as Bharatanatyam, Kathak or Kandyan Dance; folk dances such as Garba, Bhangra or Attan; and any mention of hand gestures (Mudra) or the feelings a dance should bring out (Rasa).

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's memories with a friend's interview. Did one family talk mostly about classical dance and the other about folk dance at weddings? List two things that were the same and two that were different, and connect one of them to this chapter's idea that "folk" is about who dances and how it's learned, not about skill.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: All Indian dance is basically Bollywood dance.
Reality: Bollywood dance is a modern, mixed film style. South Asia has many separate classical dances, such as Bharatanatyam, Kathak and Odissi, plus

hundreds of folk dances, each with its own steps, music and history. Film choreographers borrow from them, but they are not the same thing.

Myth: Classical dance is only religious.
Reality: Many classical pieces tell religious stories, but dancers also perform pure rhythm pieces, love poetry, court traditions (Kathak grew up partly in Mughal and Awadh courts) and modern themes. Dancers of many faiths learn and perform these styles.

Myth: There is one official list of classical dances.
Reality: India's Sangeet Natak Akademi recognizes eight, the Ministry of Culture also lists Chhau, and scholars and other countries draw the line differently. It's more accurate to say "eight, according to the Sangeet Natak Akademi."

Myth: Folk dances are just simple party dances.
Reality: "Folk" describes how a dance is passed on, through community life rather than formal schools. Folk dances such as Bhangra and Attan can be highly athletic and skilled, and UNESCO has listed some, such as Garba, as world heritage.

Myth: Bharatanatyam and Kuchipudi are the same dance.
Reality: They're related and share some technique, but Bharatanatyam comes from Tamil Nadu and is usually performed as a solo with Tamil and other songs, while Kuchipudi comes from Andhra Pradesh, grew out of Telugu dance-drama, and is known for leaps, acting and the brass-plate *tarangam*.

Check Yourself

1. What is the Natya Shastra, and roughly when was it compiled?

It is a Sanskrit handbook on the performing arts, credited to the sage Bharata. Most scholars date its first complete version to between about 200 BCE and 200 CE, though estimates range wider.

2. What is rasa? Give two examples.

Rasa is the emotional "flavor" a performance creates in the audience. Examples include shringara (love), karuna (sorrow), vira (heroism) and adbhuta (wonder).

3. How many classical dances does the Sangeet Natak Akademi recognize, and which was added most recently?

Eight. Sattriya, from Assam, was the most recent, recognized in 2000.

4. Name one way to tell Kathakali apart from Mohiniyattam, even though both come from Kerala.

Kathakali uses heavy painted makeup, huge costumes and crowns, and was traditionally performed by men in all-night dance-dramas. Mohiniyattam is a gentle, swaying solo dance traditionally performed by women in a white-and-gold sari.

5. What makes shadow puppetry work, and where in South Asia is it found?

Flat, see-through leather puppets are held between a light and a cloth screen, so the audience sees colored shadows. Traditions include Tholu bommalata in Andhra Pradesh, Togalu gombeyaata in Karnataka and Tholpavakoothu in Kerala and Tamil Nadu.

Exercises

Remember

1. List the eight classical dances recognized by the Sangeet Natak Akademi and the home state of each.

   Answer

   Bharatanatyam (Tamil Nadu), Kathak (North India, such as Uttar Pradesh), Odissi (Odisha), Kathakali (Kerala), Kuchipudi (Andhra Pradesh), Manipuri (Manipur), Mohiniyattam (Kerala), Sattriya (Assam).

2. Name the folk or regional dance from each place: Gujarat, Punjab, Kandy (Sri Lanka), and the Pashtun regions of Afghanistan and Pakistan.

   Answer

   Gujarat: Garba. Punjab: Bhangra (or Luddi). Kandy: Kandyan dance. Pashtun regions: Attan.

Understand

1. Explain the difference between *nritta*, *nritya* and *natya* in your own words.

> **Answer**
>
> Nritta is pure rhythm and movement with no story. Nritya adds meaning through gestures and facial expression. Natya is full drama, with characters and a story acted out.

2. Explain why a single mudra, such as Pataka, can mean many different things.

> **Answer**
>
> A mudra works like a word with several meanings. Where the hand is held, how it moves, and what the face shows tell the audience which meaning is intended. Pataka can be clouds, a wave or "Go!" depending on context.

Apply

1. Use the Classical Dance Map. Choose two dances from different regions and write a short "how to tell them apart" guide for a friend, using region, movement and costume. *Hint: the info panel has all three.*
2. Watch a short performance clip chosen by your teacher or club leader. Identify one moment of *nritta*, one of *nritya*, and the main rasa the dancer seems to show. *Hint: look at the face during the expressive part.*

Analyze

1. Compare how Bharatanatyam and Kathak were each shaped by the places where they were performed (temples, courts, concert stages). How do those places show up in the dance today? *Hint: think about Mughal and Awadh courts, temple sculpture and the 1930s revival.*
2. The Sangeet Natak Akademi lists eight classical dances, while the Ministry of Culture includes Chhau. Analyze what criteria might lead two official bodies to different lists. *Hint: think about written theory, training, history and who is on the committee.*

Evaluate

1. Some people say folk dances should be put on official "classical" lists so they get more funding and respect. Others say this would change them. Which side do you find more convincing, and why? *Hint: use Garba, Yakshagana or shadow puppetry as an example.*
2. Ben says, "Bollywood dance is fake Indian dance." Evaluate his claim using what you learned about how dance traditions mix and change. *Hint: a fair answer looks at what film dance borrows and what makes it different.*

Create

1. Choreograph a 30-second "mudra story" using at least four of the six mudras in this chapter. Write out the story, the mudra for each moment and the rasa you want the audience to feel. *Hint: Pataka can be waves, Alapadma the moon.*
2. Design a one-page program for your club's culture night that introduces three dances from at least three different South Asian countries, with two

sentences on each that would help a newcomer like Ben enjoy them. *Hint: include one classical and one folk dance.*

Key Takeaways

- The Natya Shastra, a Sanskrit handbook credited to Bharata and usually dated between about 200 BCE and 200 CE, gave South Asian performing arts many of their core ideas.
- Rasa is the emotional flavor a performance creates; the Natya Shastra lists eight, and a ninth, shanta (peace), was added later.
- Mudras are hand gestures with set shapes and many meanings; context tells the audience which meaning is intended.
- India's Sangeet Natak Akademi recognizes eight classical dances: Bharatanatyam, Kathak, Kuchipudi, Odissi, Kathakali, Sattriya, Manipuri and Mohiniyattam. Other bodies and countries draw the list differently.
- Folk dances, such as Garba, Bhangra, Luddi, Attan and Kandyan dance, grow from community life and can be just as skilled as classical forms.
- Theater and shadow puppetry, from Bengal's jatra to South India's leather puppets, tell epic and everyday stories across the region.
- Dance in South Asia and its diaspora keeps changing, mixing classical, folk, film and global styles.

You can read a dance now!

You can now tell a Kuchipudi dancer from a Bharatanatyam dancer, and you know what their hands and faces are saying. Next, in Chapter 11, we look at the art that stays still: temples, mosques, paintings and the kolam patterns drawn fresh on doorsteps every morning.

Quiz: Dance and Theater

Test your understanding of Chapter 10. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

What is the Natya Shastra?

A. A Mughal court history that describes Kathak performances

B. A Sanskrit handbook on the performing arts, credited to the sage Bharata

C. A list of classical dances published by the Sangeet Natak Akademi

D. A Tamil epic poem about a dancer

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The Natya Shastra is a Sanskrit treatise on drama, dance and music, traditionally credited to Bharata and usually dated between about 200 BCE and 200 CE. It is much older than the Sangeet Natak Akademi's list, which dates from modern India.

Concept Tested: Natya Shastra **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

How many classical dances does India's Sangeet Natak Akademi recognize?

A. Six

B. Nine

C. Twelve

D. Eight

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The Akademi recognizes eight: Bharatanatyam, Kathak, Kuchipudi, Odissi, Kathakali, Sattriya, Manipuri and Mohiniyattam. Nine is a common mix-up because India's Ministry of Culture also lists Chhau.

Concept Tested: Classical Dance **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

Which dance is widely called the national dance of Afghanistan?

A. Attan

B. Bhangra

C. Kandyan dance

D. Garba

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Attan is a Pashtun circle dance danced around a dhol drummer, and Pashtuns in Pakistan dance it too. Bhangra is a Punjabi harvest dance, Kandyan dance is from Sri Lanka, and Garba is from Gujarat.

Concept Tested: Attan **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

In the Natya Shastra's theory of rasa, what is a rasa?

A. A hand gesture with a fixed meaning

B. The rhythm cycle a drummer keeps

C. The emotional flavor that a performance creates in the audience

D. A costume worn only for religious stories

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Rasa, literally "juice" or "taste," is the feeling the audience experiences, such as love, wonder or sorrow. A fixed hand gesture is a mudra, not a rasa.

Concept Tested: Rasa **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

Why can a single mudra, such as Pataka, stand for clouds in one moment and the word "Go!" in another?

A. Because its meaning depends on context: where the hand moves and what the face shows

B. Because each dance style gives every mudra exactly one meaning

C. Because the audience is expected to guess randomly

D. Because Pataka is only decorative and has no real meaning

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Like a word with several meanings, a mudra's meaning comes from context, including its position, movement and the dancer's expression. The idea that each mudra has only one meaning is a common misunderstanding.

Concept Tested: Mudra **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 6

Which statement best explains the difference between folk dance and classical dance, as this chapter describes it?

A. Folk dances are always simpler and less skilled than classical dances.

B. Classical dances are never performed at festivals.

C. Folk dances come only from India, while classical dances come from all eight countries.

D. Folk dances grow out of community life and are learned by joining in, while classical dances follow a codified technique learned over years with a teacher.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The difference is about how a dance is learned and who dances it, not about skill. Option A is the misconception the chapter corrects: Bhangra and Attan can be highly athletic and complex.

Concept Tested: Folk Dance **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

At a culture night, a dancer from Andhra Pradesh performs fast footwork, acts out a story in Telugu songs, and ends by dancing on the rim of a brass plate. Which dance is this most likely to be?

A. Bharatanatyam

B. Kuchipudi

C. Odissi

D. Manipuri Dance

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Kuchipudi comes from Andhra Pradesh, uses Telugu songs, and is famous for the brass-plate *tarangam*. Bharatanatyam is the most likely mix-up because the two share a bent-knee stance and mudras, but it comes from Tamil Nadu.

Concept Tested: Kuchipudi **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

Your club wants to show one dance that uses green painted faces for heroes, huge skirts and crowns, and all-night storytelling. Which dance should you look for?

A. Mohiniyattam

B. Sattriya

C. Kathakali

D. Kathak

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Kathakali, from Kerala, uses color-coded makeup such as green *pacha* faces for noble heroes. Mohiniyattam also comes from Kerala, but it is a gentle solo dance with natural makeup and a white-and-gold sari.

Concept Tested: Kathakali **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Kathak is danced today in India, Pakistan and Bangladesh. Which part of its history best explains this?

A. It grew from storytellers and was also danced in royal courts across northern India, including Mughal and Awadh courts.

B. It was invented in the twentieth century for film.

C. It began in Buddhist monasteries in Bhutan.

D. It was created by the Sangeet Natak Akademi in 1953.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Kathak's roots in traveling storytellers and in courts across northern India, including Muslim-ruled courts, made it part of the shared culture of a region now divided among several countries. The Akademi recognized Kathak; it did not create it.

Concept Tested: Kathak **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

The Sangeet Natak Akademi lists eight classical dances, India's Ministry of Culture also lists Chhau, and Bangladesh's national encyclopedia names its own set. What is the best conclusion?

A. Only one of these lists can be correct, so the others are mistakes.

B. Chhau must be older than the eight Akademi dances.

C. Lists made in Bangladesh do not count because the dances are from India.

D. "Classical" is a label that institutions apply using their own criteria, so the list depends on who is counting.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Different bodies use different criteria and serve different communities, which is why the chapter says "eight, according to the Sangeet Natak Akademi." Option A assumes there is one true list, which is the misconception the chapter warns against.

Concept Tested: Classical Dance **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft

Summary

South Asian art is everywhere: carved into hillside monasteries, built into temple towers and marble tombs, painted on palace walls and paper, and drawn in rice flour on a doorstep every morning. This chapter starts with the art people make at home, kolam and rangoli, and the dots and symmetry behind them. It then tours the region's great buildings, from Buddhist stupas and Hindu temples to Mughal tombs and gardens, and its traditions of painting, from Mughal miniatures and Sri Lanka's Sigiriya to Himalayan thangkas and Mithila painting. It ends on the street, with mehndi, terracotta, block printing, and the painted trucks and rickshaws of Pakistan and Bangladesh.

Concepts Covered

1. Stupa
2. Hindu Temple Architecture
3. Jali
4. Mughal Architecture
5. Calligraphy
6. Mughal Miniature Painting
7. Sigiriya

8. Thangka
9. Madhubani Painting
10. Rangoli
11. Kolam
12. Mehndi
13. Terracotta
14. Block Printing
15. Truck Art
16. Rickshaw Art

Prerequisites

- Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters for the Mauryas, the Cholas and the Mughals, who built many of the monuments here.
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia for the basic ideas behind Buddhist, Hindu, Jain and Islamic sacred buildings.
- Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year for the festivals when rangoli, alpona and mehndi appear.

Art is something you do

Hi, I'm Mora, and yes, I have opinions about color! Some of the most skilled art in South Asia isn't in a museum. It's on a doorstep, a pair of hands, or the back of a truck, and you might already have some of it at home. This chapter helps you see it, name it and maybe make some yourself. Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

11.1 Rice Flour on the Doorstep

It's the morning of Pohela Boishakh, the Bengali New Year, and Zara Hossain comes downstairs to find her Nanu kneeling at the front door with a bowl of white rice paste. Nanu dips her fingertips in the paste and draws a flower, then vines curling out from it, then a border of tiny leaves, all without lifting her eyes from the floor. "This is *alpona*," she tells Zara in Bangla. "We did it at home in Chattogram every new year."

That afternoon at the South Asian Student Association meeting, Zara shows the club a photo. Arjun Reddy leans over. "My grandmother does something like that in Hyderabad, but every single morning, before sunrise. She calls it *muggu*. In Tamil it's called kolam. First she puts down a grid of dots, then she draws lines around them." Ben Lindqvist zooms in on the photo, then on Arjun's. "Wait. How do they get them so perfect? It's not like they use a ruler." Arjun shrugs. "She just knows." But how do you "just know" a design that perfect, and what else across South Asia is made with that same kind of knowledge?

11.2 Art at the Threshold: Rangoli, Kolam and Their Cousins

Start with something you've probably done: drawing on graph paper. The little squares tell you where to put each line, so even a complicated pattern comes out even. Or think of cutting a paper snowflake: fold once, cut once, and the shape repeats around the center by itself. South Asian floor art uses both tricks: a hidden grid and symmetry.

All across the region, families decorate the floor at the doorway, especially for festivals, weddings and new years. The threshold matters because it's

where the outside world meets the home. Each region has its own name and style.

Rangoli (रंगोली, *rung-GOH-lee*) is a design made on the floor or ground using dry materials such as colored powders, rice flour, colored sand, crushed limestone or flower petals. Rangoli is made most often for Diwali (and for Tihar in Nepal), and also for Onam, Pongal and other festivals. Rangolis can be geometric, floral, or pictures of deities, peacocks and lamps, and modern ones often use bright synthetic colors.

Kolam (கோலம், *KOH-lum*), a Tamil word meaning "form" or "beauty," is a line drawing made with white rice flour on the swept and dampened ground outside a home, traditionally drawn each morning before dawn by women in Tamil Nadu. In Telangana and Andhra Pradesh the same practice is called *muggu* (ముగ్గు, *MOOG-goo*), and Tamil families in Sri Lanka and around the world draw kolams too. The artist holds a pinch of flour between thumb and first finger and lets it fall in a steady line as her hand moves.

The most traditional style is the *pulli kolam*, "dot kolam." The artist first sets down a grid of dots (*pulli*). Then she draws lines that loop around the dots, usually without touching them. In the hardest designs, a single line winds around every dot and joins back to where it started, with no loose ends. That answers Ben's question. The dots work like graph paper, and the rules (go around, don't touch, keep the line moving) work like a recipe. Learning those rules takes years of watching relatives draw, and many women keep a notebook of designs and swap the hardest ones.

Kolams are meant to disappear. During the day, feet, wind and rain wear them away, and ants and birds eat the rice flour. Many families see that as part of the point. They believe a kolam welcomes prosperity into the home, the flour feeds small creatures, and the next morning it's drawn again.

Kolam meets computer science

In 1974, the Indian mathematicians and computer scientists Gift Siromoney, Rani Siromoney and Kamala Krithivasan published a paper describing kolam patterns with "array grammars," a way of writing drawing rules a computer can follow. Why do you think a pattern drawn by hand on a doorstep turned out to be a good puzzle for computer scientists?

The region has many more cousins. In Bangladesh and West Bengal, **alpona** (আলপনা, *AL-po-na*) is painted, not sprinkled: a wet paste of rice flour and water is applied with the fingertips or a twig or cloth, for Pohela Boishakh, Durga Puja and weddings. In Bangladesh, alpona is also painted for national days such as International Mother Language Day on 21 February. In Kerala, the Onam flower carpet is called *pookalam*. Gujarat has *sathiya*, Rajasthan *mandana* and Odisha *chita*.

Tradition	Where	Material	How it's made	Typical occasions
Rangoli	Across India and Nepal	Dry colored powder, rice flour, sand, petals	Sprinkled by hand, often freehand or from outlines	Diwali, Tihar, festivals, weddings
Kolam / muggu	Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh; Tamil	Dry white rice flour	Lines drawn around a grid of dots, often in one	Every morning; bigger designs in the month

Tradition	Where	Material	How it's made	Typical occasions
	communities in Sri Lanka		continuous line	of Margazhi and at Pongal
Alpona	Bangladesh and West Bengal	Wet rice-flour paste	Painted with fingertips, twig or cloth	Pohela Boishakh, Durga Puja, weddings, national days
Pookalam	Kerala	Flower petals	Petals arranged in circular designs	Onam

11.3 Sacred Buildings: Stupas and Temples

The stupa

A **Stupa** (स्तूप, *STOO-puh*) is a Buddhist monument shaped like a dome or mound, built over relics, such as the remains of the Buddha or of revered teachers, or sacred objects. Buddhists honor a stupa by walking around it clockwise, a practice called *pradakshina*, and by meditating near it. A classic stupa has a round, solid dome, a small square railing on top, and a pole with umbrella-like discs, a sign of honor.

The Great Stupa at Sanchi, in central India, was first commissioned by the Mauryan emperor Ashoka in the 3rd century BCE as a simple brick dome over relics of the Buddha. In the 1st century BCE, four richly carved stone gateways (*toranas*) were added, covered with scenes from the Buddha's life and earlier lives. UNESCO, which made Sanchi a World Heritage Site in 1989, calls it the oldest Buddhist sanctuary still in existence.

As Buddhism spread, the stupa took new shapes and names.

- In **Sri Lanka**, a stupa is called a *dagoba*. The huge white Ruwanwelisaya in Anuradhapura, a city UNESCO lists as the Sacred City of Anuradhapura (1982), was built by King Dutugemunu more than 2,000 years ago.
- In **Nepal**, the Kathmandu Valley (a World Heritage Site since 1979) includes the great stupas of Swayambhu and Boudhanath. Boudhanath is one of the largest spherical stupas in the world.
- In **Bhutan**, stupas are called *chortens*. Chorten Kora in eastern Bhutan, built in 1740, was modeled on Boudhanath.
- In **Pakistan**, the hilltop Buddhist monastery of Takht-i-Bahi, founded in the 1st century CE in the old region of Gandhara, is so well preserved that UNESCO listed it in 1980.
- In **Afghanistan**, the Bamiyan Valley held two giant Buddha figures carved into a cliff, probably in the 6th and early 7th centuries, surrounded by painted caves. The Taliban destroyed them in March 2001, despite pleas from around the world to spare them. The valley became a World Heritage Site in 2003.
- In **Bangladesh**, the great Buddhist monastery at Paharpur (Somapura Mahavihara), built under the Pala kings from the late 8th century, was a center of learning until the 12th century and is a World Heritage Site (1985).

The Hindu temple

Hindu Temple Architecture is the set of shared design traditions used to build Hindu temples, which many Hindus see as homes for a deity. At the heart of a temple is the *garbhagriha* ("womb chamber"), a small, dark sanctum holding the image of the deity. Above it rises a tower: a *shikhara* (शिखर, *SHIK-huh-ruh*, "mountain peak") in the north, or a *vimana* in the south. In front there is usually a *mandapa*, a hall where worshippers gather, and a path for walking around the sanctum. The tower is often shaped like a mountain, and the walls are covered with sculpture.

Historians describe two main regional styles.

	Nagara (northern) style	Dravida (southern) style
Tower over the sanctum	Curved *shikhara*, often with smaller towers clustered around it	Stepped, pyramid-like *vimana*
Gateways	Usually modest	Huge, sculpture-covered gate towers called *gopuram* (கோபுரம், *GO-pu-rum*), often taller than the main tower in later temples
Famous examples	Khajuraho, Madhya Pradesh, India (built mostly 950 to 1050 under the Chandella kings; about 20 Hindu and Jain temples survive)	Brihadisvara Temple, Thanjavur, Tamil Nadu, India (built by the Chola emperor Rajaraja I, 1003 to 1010)

The Brihadisvara Temple is part of the Great Living Chola Temples, a World Heritage Site since 1987, and its granite *vimana* is one of the tallest in South

India. Nepal developed its own style of tiered, pagoda-roofed temples, like Pashupati in the Kathmandu Valley, and Bangladesh and West Bengal developed temples made of brick and terracotta (Section 11.6).

11.4 Mughal Architecture: Domes, Gardens and Stone Lace

Mughal Architecture is the building style that developed under the Mughal emperors, who ruled much of the subcontinent from the 1500s to the 1700s (you met them in Chapter 3). It blended Persian and Central Asian ideas, such as tall domes, arched gateways and walled gardens, with Indian building skills, materials and decoration. Its signatures are red sandstone and white marble, perfect symmetry, and the *charbagh*, a garden divided into four parts by water channels, which in Islamic tradition recalls the four rivers of Paradise.

Three sites show how the style grew.

1. **Humayun's Tomb, Delhi.** Commissioned by Bega Begum, Emperor Humayun's widow, after his death in 1556, and designed by the Persian architect Mirak Mirza Ghiyas and his son, it was finished around 1570. It was the first garden-tomb in the subcontinent and the first building to use red sandstone on such a scale. UNESCO calls it the model that inspired the Taj Mahal.
2. **The Taj Mahal, Agra.** Shah Jahan ordered it in 1631 as a tomb for his wife Mumtaz Mahal, who died that year. The white marble mausoleum was built between 1631 and 1648, and the whole complex, with its gardens and red sandstone buildings, was finished around 1653. More than 20,000 workers and artisans worked on it under a board of architects led by Ustad Ahmad Lahori. It is a World Heritage Site (1983).

3. **The Lahore Fort and Shalimar Gardens, Pakistan.** The fort holds marble palaces, a hall of mirrors (Sheesh Mahal) and the enormous Picture Wall, covered in glazed tile mosaics of court life, begun under Jahangir and finished under Shah Jahan around 1632. Shah Jahan's Shalimar Gardens (1641 to 1642) step down three terraces with pools, cascades and fountains. Both became a World Heritage Site in 1981. Across from the fort stands the Badshahi Mosque, built by Emperor Aurangzeb from 1671 to 1673, one of the largest mosques the Mughals ever built.

Islamic architecture in the region didn't start with the Mughals. In southern Bangladesh, the Historic Mosque City of Bagerhat (a World Heritage Site since 1985) was founded in the 15th century by Khan Jahan Ali. Despite its name, its great brick Sixty Dome Mosque has 81 domes held up by 60 columns. And in the Maldives, builders cut mosques from coral stone: the Malé Friday Mosque (Hukuru Miskiy), completed in 1658, is built from blocks of coral that fit together without mortar. It is on UNESCO's tentative list, and on 21 January 2026 the Maldives submitted a full World Heritage nomination for it and four other coral stone mosques, which was still being evaluated in 2026.

Jali

A **Jali** (जाली, *JAA-lee*, "net") is a stone screen carved with holes in a geometric, floral or calligraphic pattern. Jalis let in air and soft, filtered light while blocking harsh sun and rain and giving privacy, which is a clever answer to South Asia's hot climate. Geometric jalis appear by 1311 in the Alai Darwaza gateway in Delhi. The Mughals carved finer, plant-like designs, as in the marble screens of the Taj Mahal. Some of the most famous jalis are in the Sidi Saiyyed Mosque in Ahmedabad, built in 1572 to 1573, whose stone windows are carved with intertwining trees and leaves.

Calligraphy

Calligraphy is the art of beautiful writing. In Islamic art it holds a special place, because many Muslims believe the words of the Qur'an deserve the most beautiful form possible, and because Islamic religious art usually avoids pictures of people in mosques and tombs. So instead of statues, Mughal buildings carry words. The Taj Mahal's gateways and walls are framed with Qur'anic verses in a flowing script called *thuluth*, made of jasper or black marble set into white marble. The calligrapher was Abdul Haq, whom Shah Jahan honored with the title Amanat Khan.

Calligraphy runs through the region in many scripts. Urdu is usually written in the elegant, slanting Nastaliq style (see Chapter 6). Sikh scripture is written in the Gurmukhi script, and Buddhist monasteries in Bhutan and Nepal treasure texts written in Tibetan script. You'll even find calligraphy on the back of a Pakistani truck (Section 11.6).

Whose Story?

Who gets the credit for a masterpiece? Tour guides say Shah Jahan "built" the Taj Mahal, but historians point to a board of architects led by Ustad Ahmad Lahori, a calligrapher, inlay workers, stone carvers and more than 20,000 laborers whose names were mostly never recorded. Some historians call Mughal buildings "Islamic architecture," others "Indian architecture," and many prefer "Indo-Islamic," because the style mixed Persian designs with local craftsmanship. The same question comes up for art made at home: kolam, alpona and Mithila wall paintings were made for centuries by women who were rarely called "artists" at all. Museums and scholars now debate whether labels like "folk art" honor these traditions or rank them below "fine art."

11.5 Painting on Paper, Rock and Cloth

Mughal Miniature Painting

Mughal Miniature Painting is the style of small, detailed paintings made in the workshops of the Mughal emperors, either to illustrate books or to be collected in albums. It grew out of Persian miniature painting, made a tentative start under Emperor Humayun, and soon mixed with the styles of Indian painters. Under Akbar, a large workshop of artists often worked in teams: senior artists might draw the outlines, and junior artists fill in the colors, especially the backgrounds. Akbar's most ambitious project was the *Hamzanama*, a giant illustrated adventure story begun around 1562. According to his court historian, it had illustrations for 1,400 passages of the story.

Mughal painters were known for realistic portraits, court scenes and nature studies. Under Emperor Jahangir, the artist Ustad Mansur became famous for his studies of birds, animals and flowers. One of his best-known works is a careful study of a Siberian crane. Pages were made with fine brushes and rich colors, sometimes on paper flecked with gold. Rajput kings in Rajasthan and Pahari kings in the Himalayan foothills also kept painters at court, so related miniature styles grew up in both places.

Sigiriya

Sigiriya (*SEE-gi-ri-ya*, from Sinhagiri, "Lion Rock") is a royal fortress and palace built on top of a granite rock about 180 m (590 ft) high in central Sri Lanka by King Kashyapa I, who ruled from 477 to 495 CE. Visitors once entered through a gateway shaped like a giant lion. Today only its huge brick paws remain on either side of the stairs.

Partway up, the king had the rock face painted with colorful frescoes, and some still survive. Next to them runs the polished Mirror Wall, where visitors scratched well over a thousand poems and comments, most of them between the 8th and 10th centuries. Below the rock lie water gardens with

pools and channels. After Kashyapa's reign, the site became a Buddhist monastery until the 13th or 14th century. UNESCO listed the Ancient City of Sigiriya in 1982.

Thangka

Thangka (Tibetan ཐང་ཀ, *TAHNG-kah*) is a Buddhist painting on cotton or silk that can be rolled up like a scroll, showing a deity, a scene from the Buddha's life, or a *mandala* (a circular diagram of the universe used in meditation). Thangkas are made in Nepal, Bhutan, Tibet and the Himalayan parts of India, and they are used as teaching tools and as aids for personal meditation. Painters follow precise, traditional rules about the proportions, postures and measurements of each figure, a little like the kolam artist's rules for her dot grid. Thangka painting grew in part from the Newar painting tradition of Nepal's Kathmandu Valley, called *paubha*.

Bhutan is known for giant thangkas. A *thongdrel* is a giant appliqué religious image, sewn from colored cloth, that covers the side of a building. It is unveiled only once a year, usually on the last day of a district's *tsechu*, Bhutan's main religious festivals. Nima Sherpa tells the club that the monastery near her family's village in Solukhumbu keeps its thangkas rolled up and brings them out for special days.

Madhubani Painting

Madhubani Painting, also called Mithila painting, is a style of bold, colorful painting from the Mithila region, which spans northern Bihar in India and the Terai lowlands of southern Nepal around Janakpur. For centuries, women of the region painted gods, goddesses, lotus ponds, fish, birds and wedding scenes on the freshly plastered mud walls and floors of their homes, especially for marriages. Every space is filled with pattern, and figures are

outlined in double lines. Artists use fingers, twigs, brushes, nib pens and even matchsticks, with natural pigments such as ochre and lampblack.

In the late 1960s, during a severe drought, a few women began painting these designs on paper to sell for family income. Over the following decades, hundreds of women from many different castes and communities took it up, and Madhubani painting became known worldwide. It's named after Madhubani district in Bihar, still its busiest center.

11.6 Craft at Home and on the Road

Mehndi

Mehndi (Urdu مہندی, *MEH-hn-dee*), also called henna, is the art of decorating the skin, usually hands and feet, with a paste made from the dried, powdered leaves of the henna plant (*Lawsonia inermis*). The paste leaves a reddish-brown stain that lasts about one to three weeks. Across South Asia, mehndi is part of weddings (many families hold a separate "mehndi night" before the wedding), Eid, Karva Chauth, Teej and other festivals. Zara's cousins line up on Chand Raat, the night before Eid, to have fine, detailed vines and paisleys piped onto their palms from a cone.

Real henna isn't black

Natural henna stains orange-brown to reddish-brown. "Black henna" often contains a hair-dye chemical called PPD, which the US Food and Drug Administration warns can cause dangerous skin reactions and scarring in some people. This is safety information, not medical advice: if you react to any skin product, talk to a doctor.

Terracotta

Terracotta (Italian for "baked earth") is clay that is shaped and then fired, usually to an orange-red color. In the delta of Bengal, where there is plenty of river clay but little building stone, builders turned brick and terracotta into an art form. Temple walls were covered with fired-clay panels showing gods, epics, hunting scenes and daily life.

- The Kantajew Temple in Dinajpur, **Bangladesh**, built between 1704 and 1752, has walls covered in clay panels showing scenes from the epics and daily life.
- The Malla kings of Bishnupur, in West Bengal, **India**, built a group of terracotta temples in the 17th and 18th centuries.
- Earlier still, the walls of the great Buddhist monastery at Paharpur in Bangladesh were decorated with rows of terracotta plaques.

Terracotta is also a living village craft. The long-necked Bankura horse, made in Panchmura village in West Bengal, was first made for village rituals and is now a symbol of Indian folk art around the world.

Block Printing

Block Printing is a way of printing patterns on cloth by carving a design into a wooden block, dipping it in dye, and stamping it by hand, over and over, to build up the pattern. A single cloth may need several blocks, one for each color, lined up by eye.

In Sindh, **Pakistan**, the block-printed cloth called *ajrak* is a symbol of Sindhi identity. It uses deep indigo blue and crimson red, with white and black outlining geometric patterns, and it is made with carved wooden blocks and resist-dyeing, where parts of the cloth are covered so dye can't reach them. Ajrak is also made by Sindhi communities in Kutch, Gujarat, in **India**, in the village of Ajrakhpur. In Rajasthan, the town of Bagru is known for hand block

printing with natural dyes by the Chhipa community of printers. You'll see more of South Asia's textiles in Chapter 12.

Truck Art

Truck Art is the tradition of decorating trucks (and buses) with paintings, calligraphy, carved wood, mirrors and reflective strips, best known in Pakistan and also common in India and Afghanistan. A decorated Pakistani truck can carry mountain landscapes, birds, film stars, the winged horse Buraq, poetry and religious verses in calligraphy, and painted eyes meant to ward off bad luck. A tall carved wooden "crown" rises above the cab. The art grew up in the colonial era, when trucks first came into the region and drivers began decorating them with local folk designs.

Karachi is one of the biggest centers of the trade. In 2002, the Karachi truck painter Haider Ali and bodywork expert Jamil Uddin decorated a 1976 Bedford truck on the National Mall in Washington, D.C., at the Smithsonian Folklife Festival, and the finished truck joined the Smithsonian's permanent collection. Ayesha Qureshi tells the club her uncle in Lahore insists the most beautiful trucks are the ones that carry poetry. In India, painted trucks often carry the phrase "Horn OK Please."

Rickshaw Art

Rickshaw Art is the painting and decoration of cycle rickshaws, best known in Dhaka, Bangladesh. Almost every part of a rickshaw, from the back panel to the hood and seat, is painted with flowers, birds, animals, scenes from history and fables, national heroes, movie stars and text, then decorated with tassels, plastic flowers and tinsel. Because rickshaws move slowly through the streets, they work like a moving art gallery. Rickshaw builders, who are all men, learn in workshops by hands-on training. The painters include both men and women, and they usually teach the craft to their children and close

relatives. In 2023, UNESCO added "Rickshaws and rickshaw painting in Dhaka" to its Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity.

You're surrounded by art

Look around your own home: a block-printed tablecloth, a brass lamp, a framed calligraphy panel, a henna cone in the kitchen drawer. Every one of them came from a craft with a long history. Pick one and find out who made it and where.

11.7 Countries and Crafts at a Glance

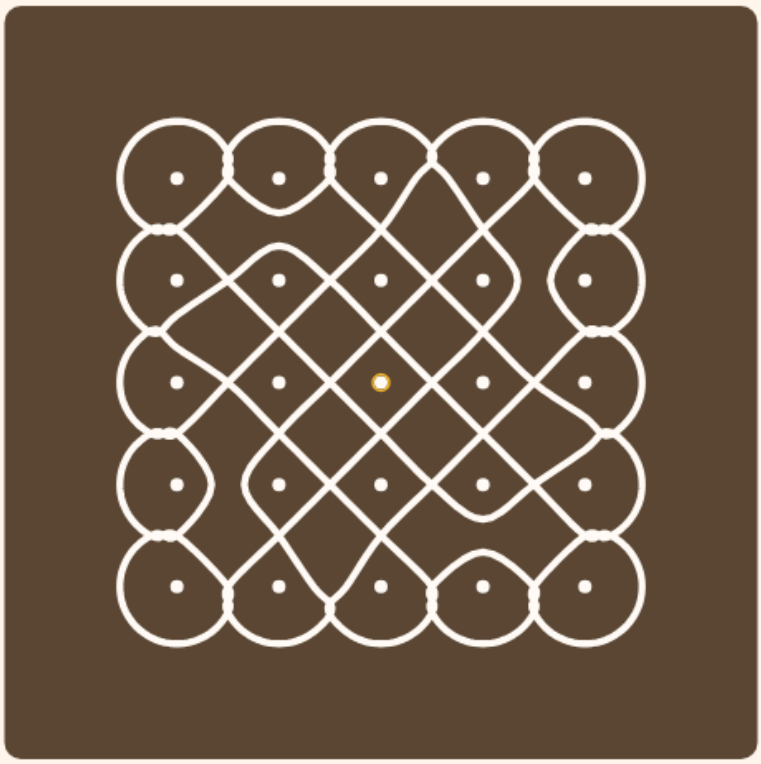
Country	Examples from this chapter
Afghanistan	Bamiyan Valley Buddhist art (Buddhas destroyed 2001); decorated trucks
Bangladesh	Alpona; rickshaw art (UNESCO 2023); Sixty Dome Mosque, Bagerhat; Kantajew terracotta temple; Paharpur monastery
Bhutan	Chortens such as Chorten Kora; thangkas and giant thongdrels
India	Sanchi stupa; Khajuraho and Thanjavur temples; Humayun's Tomb and the Taj Mahal; jalis; kolam, rangoli and muggu; Madhubani painting; block printing
Maldives	Coral stone mosques such as the Malé Friday Mosque

Country	Examples from this chapter
Nepal	Swayambhu and Boudhanath stupas; Newar paubha and thangkas; Mithila painting around Janakpur
Pakistan	Takht-i-Bahi; Lahore Fort, Shalimar Gardens and Badshahi Mosque; ajrak block printing; truck art
Sri Lanka	Sigiriya; Ruwanwelisaya dagoba in Anuradhapura; kolam in Tamil homes

Diagram: Kolam Maker

Kolam Maker: Dots and Symmetry

Draw on the ground with your mouse or finger. Loop around the dots; try not to touch them.



Demo: one unbroken line circles all 25 dots.

5 x 5 dots | Rice flour white

4-fold symmetry (copy each stroke 4 ways)

Trace demo | Clear | Save

Back to Kolam Maker Lesson Plan

Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch11-kolam-maker/main.html

Open the Kolam Maker fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Kolam Maker

sim-id: ch11-kolam-maker
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Create
Bloom Verb: design
Learning Objective: The learner will create a symmetric dot-grid design and explain how the dots (pulli) and rotational symmetry guide the drawing of a kolam.

Canvas: responsive width; 565 px drawing area plus 115 px control area.

Controls: grid size menu (3 x 3 to 7 x 7 dots), ink color menu, "4-fold symmetry" checkbox, Trace demo / Pause button, Clear button, Save button; draw with mouse or finger.

Behavior: A dark "ground" square with a grid of white dots. The sim starts with a demo pulli kolam already drawn: on odd grids it is one continuous line around every dot; on even grids, several closed loops. Trace demo animates the drawing. Learner strokes are copied four times around the center when symmetry is on. Save downloads the design as a PNG. The demo is computed as a mirror curve (diagonal lines through the gaps between dots, bouncing off the edge and off a few symmetric inner walls).

Start by tracing the demo with your eyes, or press **Trace demo** and watch. On the 5 x 5 grid, the line is a single unbroken loop that passes around all 25 dots and never touches one. Notice the two rules that make it work: the line always travels diagonally through the gaps between dots, and when it reaches the edge, it swings around the outside of the edge dot and heads back in.

Then press **Clear** and make your own. With **4-fold symmetry** on, draw one small curve near a corner and watch it appear in all four corners at once. Try

to make a design that loops around the dots the way the demo does. Then turn symmetry off and try to draw the same design by hand. You'll quickly see why kolam artists rely on the dot grid, and how much skill it takes to make a balanced design on a doorstep at dawn without any help from a computer. Finally, switch to the 4 x 4 grid and notice that the demo needs four separate loops instead of one.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about the art and craft in their home and life: floor designs, mehndi, embroidery, pottery, painted objects, or buildings they love. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Ask them to show you one handmade object in the house (a cloth, a dish, a painting, a piece of jewelry) and hold it while you talk. Ask if you can take a photo of it for your notes.

Questions to ask

1. When you were young, who in your family made art or did crafts at home? What did they make?
2. Did anyone draw alpona, kolam, rangoli or other designs at the door? When, and how did they learn?
3. Who put mehndi on your hands for weddings or Eid or festivals? What designs do you remember?

4. What is the most beautiful building you have ever seen, in South Asia or anywhere? What made it beautiful to you?
5. Have the crafts you grew up with changed, or are fewer people making them now? Why do you think that is?
6. Is there a handmade object or a skill in our family that you hope I keep?

Listen for: mentions of Kolam, Rangoli or alpona at the doorway, Mehndi at celebrations, and buildings that show Mughal Architecture, Hindu Temple Architecture or a Stupa.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare the object or craft your elder described with one from this chapter. Was it made for a ritual, for beauty, for sale, or all three? If a friend interviewed someone from a different country, compare: did both elders learn their craft by watching relatives, or in another way?

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Rangoli and kolam are the same thing.
Reality: They are related doorstep arts, but kolam is traditionally drawn in white rice flour, often as lines looping around a grid of dots, and is made daily in many Tamil homes. Rangoli usually uses colored powders or petals and is made most often for festivals like Diwali. Alpona in Bengal is different again: it's painted with wet rice paste.

Myth: The Taj Mahal is the only Mughal building worth knowing.
Reality: Humayun's Tomb in Delhi was the model the Taj Mahal grew from, and the Lahore Fort, Shalimar Gardens and Badshahi Mosque in Pakistan are among the greatest Mughal works. Earlier Islamic buildings like Bagerhat's Sixty Dome Mosque in Bangladesh are worth knowing too.

Myth: Folk art is less skilled than fine art.
Reality: A pulli kolam that circles every dot in one unbroken line takes years to master and follows rules complex enough to interest mathematicians and computer scientists. Madhubani and rickshaw painting are recognized worldwide, and rickshaw painting is on UNESCO's heritage list.

Myth: Truck art is just graffiti.
Reality: Pakistani truck art is a skilled, commissioned trade with specialist painters, woodcarvers and metalworkers who follow established styles. One Karachi-decorated truck is in the Smithsonian's permanent collection.

Check Yourself

1. What is a pulli kolam, and what are the dots for?

A pulli kolam is a kolam drawn on a grid of dots (pulli). The dots guide the drawing: lines loop around them without touching, which keeps the design even and symmetric.

2. Name the two main styles of Hindu temple architecture and one difference between them.

The northern Nagara style has a curved shikhara tower over the sanctum. The southern Dravida style has a stepped, pyramid-like vimana and often huge gateway towers called gopurams.

3. Why are Mughal tombs and mosques decorated with calligraphy rather than statues?

Islamic religious art usually avoids images of people in sacred buildings, and many Muslims believe the words of the Qur'an deserve the most beautiful form. So builders decorated with calligraphy, geometric patterns and plant designs.

4. What is a thongdrel, and when is it shown?

A thongdrel is a giant appliqué thangka made in Bhutan. It is displayed only once a year, usually at dawn on the last day of a district's tsechu festival.

5. What did UNESCO add to its heritage list in 2023 from Bangladesh?

"Rickshaws and rickshaw painting in Dhaka," the colorful painting and decoration of cycle rickshaws.

Exercises

Remember

1. Match each place to its country: Sigiriya, Takht-i-Bahi, Bagerhat, Boudhanath, Sanchi.

Answer

Sigiriya: Sri Lanka. Takht-i-Bahi: Pakistan. Bagerhat: Bangladesh. Boudhanath: Nepal. Sanchi: India.

2. What material is a kolam traditionally made from, and at what time of day is it usually drawn?

> **Answer**
>
> White rice flour, drawn in the early morning before or around dawn.

Understand

1. Explain why a jali is both beautiful and practical in South Asia's climate.

> **Answer**
>
> Its carved holes create patterns of light and shadow, while letting in air and soft light and blocking harsh sun, rain and outside views, which keeps rooms cooler and private.

2. Explain how Madhubani painting changed from a wall art to a famous art on paper.

> **Answer**
>
> Women of the Mithila region painted it on the mud walls of their homes for centuries. During a drought in the late 1960s, some began painting on paper to sell for income, and over the following decades hundreds of women took it up and it became known around the world.

Apply

1. Use the Kolam Maker to design a kolam on a 5 x 5 grid with 4-fold symmetry. Describe in two sentences where the center of rotation is and how many times each of your strokes appears. *Hint: look for the small gold circle.*
2. Your club wants to decorate the entrance for a Pohela Boishakh event and a Diwali event. For each, choose a floor art tradition from this chapter and list the materials you'd need. *Hint: compare alpona and rangoli in the table in Section 11.2.*

Analyze

1. Compare the stupa at Sanchi with a Hindu temple like the Brihadisvara at Thanjavur. How does each building guide what visitors do with their bodies? *Hint: think about walking around, entering, and where the most sacred spot is.*
2. Truck art and rickshaw art are both "moving art." Analyze two ways they are similar and two ways they differ. *Hint: think about vehicle, country, materials and recognition.*

Evaluate

1. Should everyday crafts like kolam or mehndi be displayed in museums next to Mughal paintings? Evaluate the pros and cons. *Hint: the Whose Story? box raises the question of labels like "folk art."*
2. Hand-painted crafts can lose customers when cheaper machine-made or printed options appear. Evaluate one way a community could keep a craft like rickshaw painting alive. *Hint: think about who learns it, who pays for it, and where people see it.*

Create

1. Design a club poster or slide that teaches one South Asian craft in five steps, with a simple drawing for each step. *Hint: kolam, alpona, block printing or mehndi all work well.*
2. Create a short "museum label" (80 to 120 words) for a handmade object from your own home or an elder's home, including what it is, where it comes from, who made it and why it matters. *Hint: use your Ask Your Elders interview.*

Key Takeaways

- Doorstep arts differ by region: kolam (rice flour lines around dots, Tamil Nadu and Sri Lankan Tamil homes), muggu, rangoli (colored powder, festivals) and alpona (wet rice paste, Bengal).
- Dots and symmetry are the hidden structure of a pulli kolam, and the best designs use one unbroken line around every dot.
- Stupas (Sanchi, Anuradhapura, Boudhanath, Takht-i-Bahi) and Hindu temples (Nagara and Dravida styles) are designed for walking around and approaching a sacred center.
- Mughal Architecture blended Persian and Indian traditions, from Humayun's Tomb and the Taj Mahal to the Lahore Fort and Shalimar Gardens, with jalis and calligraphy as signature details.
- South Asian painting ranges from Mughal miniatures and Sigiriya's frescoes to Himalayan thangkas and Mithila (Madhubani) painting.
- Living crafts like mehndi, terracotta, block printing (ajrak), truck art and rickshaw art (UNESCO 2023) connect art to everyday life across all eight countries.

What a gallery!

From rice flour to marble, you've toured South Asia's art in every size. Next, in Chapter 12, we look at what people wear: cotton, silk, jamdani, ikat and the stories woven into saris, kurtas and shalwar kameez.

Quiz: Art, Architecture, and Craft

Test your understanding of Chapter 11. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

In which country is the rock fortress of Sigiriya, built by King Kashyapa I in the 5th century CE?

A. Nepal

B. Bangladesh

C. Sri Lanka

D. Pakistan

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Sigiriya, the "Lion Rock," is in central Sri Lanka, and Kashyapa I ruled from 477 to 495 CE. The Buddhist monastery of Takht-i-Bahi is the major ancient site in Pakistan from this chapter, and Bagerhat is in Bangladesh.

Concept Tested: Sigiriya **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

What is a jali?

A. A carved stone screen with holes that lets in air and filtered light

B. A dome built over the relics of the Buddha

C. A gateway tower on a South Indian temple

D. A garden divided into four parts by water channels

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. A jali is a perforated stone screen carved in geometric, floral or calligraphic patterns. A dome over relics is a stupa, a temple gateway tower is a gopuram, and a four-part garden is a charbagh.

Concept Tested: Jali **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

In 2023, UNESCO added which Bangladeshi tradition to its list of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity?

A. Truck art in Karachi

B. Terracotta temples in Dinajpur

C. Alpona painting for Pohela Boishakh

D. Rickshaws and rickshaw painting in Dhaka

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. UNESCO inscribed "Rickshaws and rickshaw painting in Dhaka" in 2023. Truck art is best known in Pakistan, not Bangladesh, and the terracotta temples and alpona are Bangladeshi traditions but were not the 2023 listing.

Concept Tested: Rickshaw Art **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Why do pulli kolam artists start by placing a grid of dots?

A. The dots are where the colored powder will be piled highest

B. The dots guide the lines, which loop around them, keeping the design even and symmetric

C. The dots mark where guests should step

D. Each dot stands for one member of the family

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. In a pulli kolam, lines loop around the dots, usually without touching them, so the dots work like graph paper for an even, symmetric design. Kolam is traditionally drawn in white rice flour lines, not piles of colored powder, which is closer to rangoli.

Concept Tested: Kolam **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

Why is Mughal Architecture described as a blend of traditions?

A. It combined Persian and Central Asian ideas like domes and walled gardens with Indian materials, skills and decoration

B. It copied Greek temples exactly

C. It was designed entirely by European architects

D. It used only wood and bamboo from the Himalaya

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Mughal buildings such as Humayun's Tomb, designed by Persian architects and built with Indian red sandstone and craftsmanship, mixed Persian and Central Asian forms with local building traditions. They were not copies of Greek or European buildings.

Concept Tested: Mughal Architecture **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 6

Why is calligraphy, rather than statues of people, the main decoration on the Taj Mahal?

A. Statues were too heavy for marble walls

B. Shah Jahan did not like sculpture of any kind

C. Islamic religious art usually avoids images of people in sacred buildings, and the words of the Qur'an are honored in beautiful script

D. Calligraphy was cheaper than carving

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Islamic religious buildings are usually decorated with calligraphy, geometric patterns and plant designs instead of human figures, and Qur'anic verses are given the most beautiful form possible. Cost and weight had nothing to do with it. The Taj's inlaid calligraphy was itself expensive, skilled work.

Concept Tested: Calligraphy **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

A friend offers to give you a "black henna" design before a wedding, saying it's darker than regular mehndi. Based on the chapter, what's the best response?

A. Accept, because all henna is made from the same plant

B. Be cautious, because "black henna" often contains PPD, a hair-dye chemical the FDA warns can cause dangerous skin reactions

C. Accept, as long as it's washed off within an hour

D. Refuse, because mehndi is only for Eid

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Natural henna stains reddish-brown, but "black henna" often contains PPD, which can cause dangerous reactions and scarring. Mehndi is used for weddings, Eid, Diwali, Karva Chauth and many other occasions, so it isn't "only for Eid." This is safety information, not medical advice.

Concept Tested: Mehndi **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

Your club is decorating for a Pohela Boishakh celebration and wants to use the floor art Zara's Nanu made. Which materials and method should you use?

A. Dry colored powders sprinkled in a freehand design

B. Flower petals arranged in circles

C. White rice flour dropped in lines around a grid of dots

D. A wet rice-flour paste painted on with fingertips

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Alpona, the Bengali floor art made for Pohela Boishakh, is painted with a wet paste of rice flour and water using the fingertips, a twig or cloth. Dry colored powder describes rangoli, petals describe pookalam, and rice flour lines around dots describe kolam.

Concept Tested: Rangoli **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Compare a stupa with a Hindu temple. Which statement is most accurate?

A. Both are built only in India

B. A stupa is a solid mound walked around by worshippers, while a temple has an inner sanctum (garbhagriha) that worshippers approach

C. Both always have gopuram gateway towers

D. A stupa holds an image of a Hindu deity, while a temple holds relics of the Buddha

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. A stupa is a solid dome over relics, honored by walking around it clockwise, while a Hindu temple is built around a sanctum holding the deity's image, with a tower above it. Stupas are found in Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bhutan, Pakistan and Bangladesh as well as India, and gopurams belong to South Indian temples, not stupas.

Concept Tested: Stupa **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

Madhubani painting moved from mud walls to paper in the late 1960s. What does this change best show about the tradition?

A. It stopped being made by women

B. It was invented in the 1960s

C. Women adapted a long-standing wall art to a new material during hard times, which helped it reach audiences worldwide

D. It became a form of truck art

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Women of Mithila had painted walls for centuries. During a severe drought in the late 1960s, some began painting on paper to earn income, and hundreds of women from many communities later took it up. The art was not invented in the 1960s, and women remained its main artists.

Concept Tested: Madhubani Painting **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles

Summary

South Asia has been growing, spinning and weaving fiber for thousands of years, and its cloth has traveled the world. This chapter starts with three fibers (cotton, silk and pashmina wool), then looks at famous ways of weaving and dyeing them, such as Jamdani from Bangladesh, ikat from India and ajrak from Pakistan. Next it sorts everyday clothes into draped garments (the saree, dhoti and lungi) and stitched garments (the kurta, shalwar kameez and dupatta), and visits national dress in Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka and Afghanistan. It ends with the turban, the bindi and bangles, and the many meanings people give them.

Concepts Covered

1. Cotton in South Asia
2. Silk Weaving
3. Jamdani
4. Ikat
5. Pashmina
6. Khadi
7. Saree
8. Dhoti
9. Lungi

10. Kurta
11. Shalwar Kameez
12. Dupatta
13. Gho and Kira
14. Turban (Dastar)
15. Bindi
16. Bangles

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia? for the eight countries, the rivers and the monsoon climate.
- Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition helps with the khadi story in Section 12.5.
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia helps with the turban and bindi in Section 12.9.
- Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft introduces motifs and craft traditions that show up again on cloth.

Clothes that carry stories

Hi, it's Mora! Maybe you have a kurta you only wear to weddings, or an aunt's saree folded in a closet that nobody explains. Clothes are one of the first ways people read your background, sometimes wrongly. By the end of this chapter you'll be able to tell the story behind what's in that closet, and answer the questions your friends ask about it.

12.1 Culture Day Guessing Game

The South Asian Student Association at Prairie Ridge High School is holding its first culture day, and everyone has been asked to wear something from home. Zara Hossain comes in a cream-and-gray cotton saree her Nanu brought from Bangladesh, covered in tiny woven flowers. Ayesha Qureshi, whose family is from Lahore, wears a green shalwar kameez with a long scarf. Simran Kaur Gill wears a shalwar kameez too, with a bright embroidered scarf from her grandmother in Ludhiana. Dilan Perera wears a white shirt and a checked cloth wrapped around his waist, and Nima Sherpa has brought a small brimmed cloth cap with a busy pattern.

Ms. Okafor turns it into a game. Ben Lindqvist has to guess which country each outfit comes from. "Saree, so India," he says, pointing at Zara. Wrong: Bangladesh. "Shalwar kameez is Pakistani," he says. Right for Ayesha, but Simran's family is from India. He guesses Dilan's wrap is "a Bangladeshi lungi," which is close but not quite: Dilan's family is from Sri Lanka, where a similar wrap is called a sarama. He gets Nima's cap right only because she gives him a hint. Ben scores two out of five and groans. "How is anyone supposed to know? Half of these are worn in, like, four countries." He has stumbled onto the big question of this chapter: if the same clothes cross so many borders, what can a garment tell you about where someone is from?

12.2 Clothes Speak a Language

Ben already knows the answer from his own family. His grandmother in Minnesota has a Norwegian **bunad**, a folk costume with embroidery and silver jewelry. Norway has hundreds of kinds of bunad (counts run from about 200 to more than 400, depending on what is counted), and each is tied to a region. People usually choose the one from the place their family comes from, then wear it for weddings, confirmations and especially Norway's

National Day on 17 May. A bunad doesn't tell you "Norwegian" so much as "my grandmother's people came from this valley."

South Asian clothing works in a similar way, with one big difference: the region is far bigger and its borders are much newer than its clothes. The saree, the kurta and the turban are much older than the countries of India, Pakistan or Bangladesh, which became independent in 1947 and 1971. So a garment usually tells you less about a passport and more about these things:

- **Where the cloth was made.** A Jamdani weave points to Dhaka. An ajrak print points to Sindh.
- **What the occasion is.** Many families keep everyday cotton for home and heavy silk for weddings.
- **Sometimes, faith or community.** A Sikh man's dastar, a married Bengali Hindu woman's white and red bangles, or a Bhutanese man's white ceremonial scarf each carry a specific meaning.
- **Personal taste.** Plenty of teens wear a kurta with jeans simply because they like it.

To read clothes well, it helps to start one layer down, with the fibers themselves.

12.3 Three Fibers: Cotton, Silk and Pashmina

Cotton

Cotton in South Asia is the long history of growing, spinning and weaving the cotton plant's soft seed fibers in the region, a history that goes back more than 7,000 years. The oldest known cotton fibers in the world come from Mehrgarh, an early farming village in Balochistan, Pakistan. Archaeologists

found a set of eight copper beads next to the wrist of a skeleton buried there in the first half of the sixth millennium BCE, roughly 7,500 to 8,000 years ago. (Some news stories round this up to 8,500 years.) When the copper corroded, its salts soaked into the thread that once strung the beads and preserved it. Under a microscope, French researchers identified the fibers as cotton.

Cotton suited South Asia well. It grows in warm places, and cotton cloth is light and breathable in the heat and humidity of the monsoon. Later, cotton cloth from the region became one of the most traded goods in the world. Merchants carried fine Indian cotton to the Roman Empire, to Baghdad and Basra, and east toward China.

The finest of all was **muslin** from Bengal, especially around Dhaka and Sonargaon in present-day Bangladesh. Weavers there used a local cotton called phuti karpas, which grew along the banks of the Meghna River, and spun it into thread so thin that travelers wrote that a whole length of muslin could be pulled through a ring. Mughal emperors prized it, and so did European nobles in the 1700s. Under British colonial rule the trade collapsed as cheap machine-made cloth from British factories flooded the market and weavers lost their livelihoods. The special cotton plant was eventually lost. In recent years, researchers and artisans in Bangladesh have been working to revive Dhaka muslin.

Count the cotton

Check the labels on three things in your closet right now. How many say "cotton," and how many say "Made in" Bangladesh, India, Pakistan or Sri Lanka? The cloth trade I'm describing never really stopped. It just moved into factories.

Silk

Silk comes from the cocoons of silkworms, the caterpillars of certain moths. **Silk Weaving** in South Asia means raising silkworms, unwinding or spinning their cocoon thread, and weaving it into cloth, usually for festive and wedding clothes. India's government recognizes four main kinds of silk:

Kind of silk	What the silkworms eat	Where it is mostly made	What it is known for
Mulberry	Mulberry leaves	Karnataka, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir	By far the most common; smooth and shiny
Tasar	Oak, asan and arjuna tree leaves	Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Bihar and nearby states	A rougher, textured silk
Eri	Castor leaves	Assam and the northeast	Spun rather than reeled; warm, with a copper tint
Muga	Som and soalu leaves	Almost entirely in Assam	A natural golden color

Some of the most famous silk sarees are named after the towns that weave them:

- **Banarasi** sarees come from Varanasi (also called Banaras or Benares), on the Ganga. They are known for **zari**, thread wrapped in gold or silver

color, woven into flowers, vines and net-like patterns. A complex Banarasi saree can take from about two weeks to several months to finish. In 2009, weavers' groups in Uttar Pradesh won Geographical Indication (GI) status for Banaras brocades and sarees. A GI is a legal label, like the one that protects the name "Champagne," which says a product's quality comes from a particular place.

- **Kanjivaram** (or Kanchipuram) sarees come from the town of Kanchipuram in Tamil Nadu. They are woven from mulberry silk with wide borders in a contrasting color, often with a classic "temple" border design. In a traditional Kanjivaram saree the border and the body are woven separately and then interlocked so firmly that the border stays attached even if the saree tears. The Government of India recognized Kanchipuram sarees as a GI in 2005-06.
- **Rajshahi silk** comes from Rajshahi in northwestern Bangladesh, where people trace silk production back to the 13th century. Bangladesh gave it GI status in 2021.

Pashmina

Pashmina is the very fine wool from the soft undercoat of goats that live high in the Himalaya, and also the name for the shawls made from it. The word comes from *pashm*, the Persian word for wool. In Hindi it is written पश्मीना (*push-MEE-nah*).

The classic source is the Changthangi goat, raised by nomadic Changpa herders on the high, cold Changthang plateau of Ladakh. Winter temperatures there can fall below -30 °C (-22 °F), so the goats grow a thick, fine undercoat. Each spring, when the goats shed, herders comb the undercoat out by hand rather than shearing it. Weavers in Kashmir turned this wool into the famous Kashmir shawl. Mughal emperors gave pashmina

shawls as "robes of honor" to reward nobles, and in the 1800s the shawls became high fashion in Britain and France.

One pashmina design traveled farther than the wool itself. The teardrop-shaped **buta** motif on Kashmir shawls was copied by factories in the town of Paisley, Scotland, in the early 1800s. That's why English speakers today call the shape "paisley," even though it began on South Asian looms.

Nepal has its own pashmina tradition. There the high-mountain goat is called the chyangra, and Nepal's pashmina makers, working with the International Trade Centre, created a "Chyangra Pashmina" brand to mark genuine Nepali products.

A disputed region

Kashmir, where the famous shawls are woven, is a region whose control is disputed among India, Pakistan and China, and people from all sides claim its crafts with pride. When I say "Kashmir shawl," I mean the craft of the region, not a statement about whose territory it is.

12.4 Weaving and Dyeing: Making Pattern

Once you have thread, there are two main ways to put a pattern on cloth. You can **weave** the pattern in, by choosing which colored threads go over and under each other. Or you can **dye or print** the pattern on, by blocking color from some parts of the thread or cloth. South Asia has famous examples of both.

A quick piece of vocabulary helps here. On a loom, the **warp** threads run the long way and are stretched tight. The **weft** thread is passed back and forth

across them.

Jamdani

Jamdani (জামদানী, *JAHM-dah-nee*) is a fine, sheer cotton cloth from the Dhaka region of Bangladesh, with patterns woven directly into it on a hand loom. Its name comes from Persian. The weaver adds each little flower, leaf or diamond by hand, using extra weft threads that go back and forth only across that one small motif instead of the full width of the cloth. This is called a **discontinuous weft** technique. It is slow, careful work, so a single saree can take weeks or months, and the result is light and breathable.

In 2013, UNESCO added the traditional art of Jamdani weaving to its Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity. UNESCO notes that the skills pass mostly from parents to children in home workshops around Dhaka, and that many Bengali women wear Jamdani sarees as a symbol of identity, both in Bangladesh and abroad. In 2016, Bangladesh also gave the Jamdani saree GI status. Zara's culture-day saree, with its woven flowers, is a Jamdani.

Ikat

Ikat (*EE-kaht*) is a way of patterning cloth in which the threads are tied and dyed before they are ever woven. The word comes from Indonesia, where it means "to bind," and similar techniques grew up independently in many parts of the world. It works in four steps:

1. The weaver wraps tight bindings around small sections of a bundle of threads, following a planned pattern.
2. The threads are dyed. The tied sections resist the dye and stay their original color.

3. The bindings are moved or added, and the threads are dyed again in a new color. This can repeat many times.
4. Finally the bindings are removed, and the patterned threads are set up on the loom and woven.

Because the pattern is in the threads, the edges of each shape come out slightly feathery and blurred, which is ikat's signature look. In **double ikat**, both the warp and the weft are tie-dyed, and the weaver has to line them up exactly. It's so hard that it is woven in only a few places in the world.

India has several famous ikat centers:

- **Pochampally**, in Telangana, known for bold geometric ikat sarees in cotton and silk.
- **Sambalpur** and nearby districts in Odisha, where ikat is called *bandha* and often uses motifs such as the conch, the wheel and the flower.
- **Patan**, in Gujarat, home of **patola**, a silk double ikat. Dutch traders once used patola as prized trade cloth in the spice trade with Indonesia.

Ajrak

Ajrak is a cloth printed by hand with carved wooden blocks, made mostly in the Sindh region of Pakistan, and also by families in Kutch, in the Indian state of Gujarat, who trace their craft to Sindh. The printers use natural dyes, especially deep indigo blue and crimson red, and "resist" techniques that keep some areas from taking the dye, skills passed down through generations of the same families. Its dense patterns of stars, circles and lattices are easy to recognize.

For many people in Sindh, ajrak is a badge of identity. Families give an ajrak shawl to honor a guest, and it appears at weddings and cultural events. Some writers even point out that the famous stone bust of a "priest-king"

from Mohenjo-daro, more than 4,000 years old, wears a robe with a trefoil (three-lobed) pattern that looks a little like ajrak. That link can't be proven, but it shows how strongly people feel the cloth belongs to the Indus region.

Whose Story?

Cloth often crosses borders that were drawn long after the craft began, so different groups tell its story differently. In Pakistan, ajrak is celebrated as a symbol of Sindhi culture, and in 2025 the Government of Sindh even put an ajrak-inspired design on new vehicle license plates. Across the border, block printers in Kutch in India make ajrak too, and they tell it as the story of their own families, who brought the craft from Sindh. In Bhutan, the government describes the gho and kira as national dress that protects a distinct Bhutanese identity, but many Lhotshampa (Nepali-speaking Bhutanese in the south) saw the 1989 dress rule as forcing another community's tradition on them. The rule was part of wider identity and citizenship policies, and after protests in 1990 more than 100,000 Lhotshampa left or were forced out to refugee camps in Nepal, events that Bhutan's government and the refugees still describe very differently. Asking "whose cloth is this?" usually has more than one true answer.

12.5 Khadi: Cloth as Protest

Khadi (खादी, *KHAH-dee*) is cloth that is both hand-spun and hand-woven, made from cotton, silk or wool. Its importance comes from the role it played in India's freedom movement.

Under British rule, raw cotton was often shipped from India to mills in Britain, woven there by machine, and sold back to Indians as finished cloth. Mohandas K. Gandhi, a leader of the Indian independence movement, argued that buying that cloth kept India poor and dependent. He called on

people to boycott foreign cloth and to spin their own thread on a **charkha**, a hand-turned spinning wheel. This was part of **swadeshi**, a movement whose name means "of one's own country."

The first piece of hand-woven cloth at Gandhi's Sabarmati Ashram, in Gujarat, was made in 1917-18. He began spinning himself in 1919 and asked members of the Indian National Congress to spin and even pay their dues in yarn. In 1921, he began wearing only a simple dhoti, often without a shirt, to show his solidarity with India's rural poor. That same year, according to local histories, he visited the Comilla region, now in Bangladesh, to encourage local weavers, and weaving centers grew up there.

After independence, India's government set up the Khadi and Village Industries Commission in April 1957, under a 1956 law, to support khadi and other village crafts. Khadi is still sold across India today. In Bangladesh, a khadi tradition continued in the Comilla area too, and in May 2025 Bangladesh gave Comilla khadi Geographical Indication status.

Khadi is also a symbol of self-reliance, and many politicians in India still wear it for that reason.

12.6 Draped Garments: Saree, Dhoti and Lungi

Many South Asian clothes are not cut and sewn at all. They are long, unstitched rectangles of cloth that are wrapped, pleated and tucked around the body. This makes them easy to weave on a hand loom and easy to adjust to any body size.

The saree

The **Saree** (also spelled sari; Hindi साड़ी, Bangla শাড়ি, *SAH-ree*) is a long, unstitched length of cloth that a woman wraps around her waist and drapes

over one shoulder. A saree is usually between 4.5 and 9 yards (about 4 to 8 meters) long. It is worn over a petticoat (a long underskirt) and a fitted blouse, which is called a choli in northern India and a cholo in Nepal. The loose end that hangs over the shoulder is the **pallu**, and it is often richly decorated.

The saree is worn in India, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka and parts of Pakistan. In Bangladesh it is widely seen as the national dress for women, which is why Zara's Jamdani makes perfect sense there. Sri Lanka has its own famous style, the **osariya** or Kandyan saree, which comes from the old Kandyan kingdom in the hill country. It has a frill at the waist and is worn with a full blouse that covers the midriff, and many women in Sri Lankan public life wear it.

There isn't one right way to drape a saree. The most common style today is the **Nivi** drape, with pleats tucked in at the front and the pallu over the shoulder. But there are many regional drapes. In the Deccan region of western and central India, for example, the Nauvari style passes the pleats between the legs and tucks them in at the back, which makes it easy to move in. Some Newar women in Nepal traditionally fold the saree to knee length and wrap a shawl across the chest instead of the pallu.

Ask for a draping lesson

If someone in your family wears sarees, ask them to show you their drape slowly, step by step. Many people learned their style from their own mother or grandmother, so the way they pleat and tuck is a little piece of family history.

The dhoti

The **Dhoti** (धोती, *DHOH-tee*) is a man's unstitched lower garment, a rectangle of cloth about 4 yards (3.7 meters) long that is wrapped around the waist and then passed between the legs and tucked in, so it looks a bit like loose trousers. It is often white or cream cotton, and silk dhotis are worn for weddings and religious occasions. It has local names too. In parts of South India, the formal style is called *panchakacham*. The dhoti is common in India and in Nepal, and it is the garment Gandhi made famous worldwide in the 1920s.

The lungi

The **Lungi** (लुङ्गि, *LOONG-gee*) is a length of cloth worn by men around the waist like a skirt, without passing between the legs. It is usually cotton, often in checks or stripes, and it is loved for staying cool in hot, humid weather. In Bangladesh, the lungi is the most commonly seen everyday clothing for men, usually sewn into a tube, though it is not worn for formal occasions.

Wrapped garments like this have different names in different places. In Kerala, a white or cream wrap with a decorative border is called a **mundu**. In Sri Lanka, it is a **sarama**, which is what Dilan wore to culture day. Across the Bay of Bengal in Myanmar, it is a longyi.

12.7 Stitched Garments: Kurta, Shalwar Kameez and Dupatta

Other South Asian clothes are cut and sewn. Many of these styles came to South Asia from Central Asia and Persia over centuries, then took on local forms.

The kurta

The **Kurta** (कुरता, *KOOR-tah*) is a loose tunic, traditionally collarless, with straight sleeves and side seams left open at the bottom. It can be short or long, plain or embroidered, cotton for every day or silk for festivals. Both men and women wear kurtas, over loose trousers, fitted trousers or, increasingly, jeans. Lucknow in India is famous for **chikankari**, a delicate embroidery traditionally done in white thread on light cotton or muslin, often seen on kurtas.

Two close relatives show how widely the idea spread. In Nepal, men's national dress is the **daura-suruwal**: the daura is a kurta-like shirt that closes with ties, and the suruwal is a pair of trousers that is loose at the hips and narrow at the ankles. It is often worn with a patterned cloth cap, the **Dhaka topi**, the cap Nima brought to culture day. Under King Mahendra, who ruled from 1955 to 1972, men were required to wear the Dhaka topi in official photos for passports and documents. In Afghanistan, many men wear the **perahan tunban**, a long, loose shirt over very full trousers. The style from Kandahar is known for fine geometric embroidery on the chest.

The shalwar kameez

The **Shalwar Kameez** (Urdu شلوار قمیض, *SHUL-war ka-MEEZ*) is a two-piece outfit of loose trousers and a long tunic, worn by both men and women. The **shalwar** is wide at the waist, held up by a drawstring, and narrows to the ankle. The **kameez** is a long shirt with slits up both sides, which makes it easy to walk, sit and move in.

The shalwar kameez spread across northern South Asia over many centuries, especially in the Punjab region. Today it is Pakistan's national dress, and it is worn every day by millions of men and women there. It is also very common in India, especially in Punjab, where many people call the women's version a "Punjabi suit," and in Bangladesh and Afghanistan. So Ben was half right:

Ayesha's outfit is Pakistani national dress, and Simran's matching outfit is just as much a part of her family's Punjabi Sikh tradition in India.

The dupatta

The **Dupatta** (Hindi दुपट्टा, Urdu دوپٹہ, *doo-PUT-tah*) is a long scarf or shawl, usually worn by women with a shalwar kameez or with a long skirt and blouse. Its name roughly means "a doubled strip of cloth." A dupatta can be draped over one or both shoulders, wrapped across the chest, or worn over the head, for example in a place of worship or in front of elders. Families and communities have different customs about when and how to wear it.

Dupattas are often where the most beautiful handwork goes. In Punjab, on both sides of the India-Pakistan border, women have long made **phulkari**, which means "flower work," a bright darned embroidery in silk thread on coarse cotton. Simran's culture-day scarf is a phulkari dupatta.

Garment	Draped or stitched	Mainly worn by	Countries where you'll often see it
Saree	Draped	Women	India, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka, parts of Pakistan
Dhoti	Draped	Men	India, Nepal
Lungi (and mundu, sarama)	Draped	Men	Bangladesh, India, Sri Lanka

Garment	Draped or stitched	Mainly worn by	Countries where you'll often see it
Kurta	Stitched	Men and women	India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, the diaspora
Shalwar kameez	Stitched	Men and women	Pakistan, India, Bangladesh, Afghanistan
Dupatta	Draped over stitched clothes	Mostly women	Pakistan, India, Bangladesh

12.8 National Dress: Bhutan and Its Neighbors

Some countries in South Asia have an official or widely accepted national dress. The clearest example is Bhutan.

Gho and kira

Gho and Kira are the national dress of Bhutan: the gho (གཿ, *GOH*) for men and the kira (*KEE-rah*) for women.

- The **gho** is a heavy, knee-length robe that is folded and tied at the waist with a woven belt called a **kera**. The fold creates a large pouch above the belt that people use like a pocket. Under it, men wear a white jacket called a **tego**, whose long white cuffs are folded back over the gho's sleeves.

- The **kira** is an ankle-length dress made from one large rectangle of woven cloth. It is wrapped around the body, pinned at both shoulders with brooches called **koma**, and belted at the waist. Women wear a long-sleeved blouse called a **wonju** underneath and often a short jacket called a **toego** on top.

Everyday gho and kira are usually cotton or wool in simple checks and stripes. For festivals, many people wear richly patterned silk kira woven by hand. Weaving, called *thagzo*, is one of Bhutan's traditional arts, and the Royal Textile Academy of Bhutan, founded in 2005 in Thimphu, runs a weaving school and a textile museum to keep it alive.

Bhutan's national dress is connected to the **driglam namzha**, Bhutan's official code of etiquette and dress. Its roots go back to the 17th century, when Ngawang Namgyal, the first Zhabdrung, worked to unify Bhutan and give it a distinct identity.

In 1989, the government made the dress code mandatory in public during business hours. Today men who work in government offices or schools are required to wear the gho, and both gho and kira are worn for formal occasions. When visiting a dzong (a fortress-monastery) or meeting officials, men add a ceremonial scarf called a **kabney**. Ordinary citizens wear a white one, while other colors are reserved for officials and monks. Women wear a narrow embroidered cloth called a **rachu** over the shoulder.

Other national dress in the region

Country	Often-named national dress	Notes
Bhutan	Gho (men), kira (women)	Required in government offices and schools and for formal occasions
Nepal	Daura-suruwal with Dhaka topi (men); saree with cholo blouse (women)	Many communities in Nepal also have their own dress
Pakistan	Shalwar kameez (men and women)	Worn every day across the country
Bangladesh	Saree (women)	Jamdani is the best-known weave
Sri Lanka	Osariya, the Kandyan saree (women)	Widely treated as national dress for women
Afghanistan	Perahan tunban (men)	Regional styles, such as Kandahari embroidery

"National dress" is always a simplification. Each of these countries has many communities with their own clothing, and a single official outfit can leave some of them out, as the Whose Story? box showed.

12.9 Head, Forehead and Wrist: Turbans, Bindis and Bangles

Some of the most noticeable things people wear are small, and many of them carry religious or family meanings.

The turban and the dastar

A turban is a long cloth wound around the head. Turbans are worn in many parts of the world and by people of many faiths. In South Asia, you can see turbans on Sikh men and some Sikh women, on many Pashtun men in Afghanistan and Pakistan, on village elders in Rajasthan, where it's often called a **pagri** (पगड़ी), on some Hindu monks, and on some Muslim religious scholars. Its style, color and way of tying can show region, occasion or community.

The **Turban (Dastar)** is, for Sikhs, an article of faith. The dastar (ਦਸਤਾਰ, *dus-TAAR*) is the Sikh turban, and the word comes from Persian through Punjabi. In Sikh tradition, the Gurus adopted the turban, which in South Asia was once worn mainly by royalty, as a way of declaring the sovereignty and equality of all people. Sikhs who have formally committed to the faith keep their hair uncut (*kesh*), one of the five articles of faith, and the dastar covers it. According to the Sikh Coalition, a US Sikh civil rights group, both men and women may wear a turban, and wearing one is a public commitment to values such as service, compassion and honesty. Tying a dastar neatly every day, turn by turn, is a skill many Sikh children learn from a parent.

A good question to ask

If you're curious about a friend's turban, it's fine to ask a respectful question like "What does your dastar mean to you?" Just never touch someone's turban or ask them to take it off. For many Sikhs it's as personal and sacred as anything they own.

The bindi

The **Bindi** (बिंदी, *BIN-dee*) is a dot, traditionally red or maroon, worn in the center of the forehead, often between the eyebrows. The word comes from the Sanskrit *bindu*, meaning "point" or "drop." Traditional bindis are made with powders such as kumkum. Today many people wear small stick-on bindis in every color and shape.

The bindi is worn mainly by Hindu women, and also by some Jains and Buddhists, in India, Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and in Hindu communities in Pakistan and Bhutan. In Hindu tradition, many people link the spot between the eyebrows with spiritual focus. For some women, a red bindi has also been a sign of being married, though customs vary a lot by region and family, and many unmarried girls wear decorative bindis too. In Nepal, a related forehead mark, the tika, is placed on people's foreheads by elders as a blessing during festivals such as Dashain.

Bangles

Bangles are rigid bracelets, usually worn in sets, made from glass, metal, shell, lac, plastic or other materials. They have a very long history in the region. The famous "Dancing Girl," a small bronze figure from Mohenjo-daro in what is now Pakistan, made sometime between about 2300 and 1750 BCE, wears a stack of bangles on her left arm. Hindi speakers call a bangle a चूड़ी (*CHOO-ree*), and Urdu speakers call it a چوڑی, the same word in a different script.

Bangles can carry very specific meanings:

- **Weddings:** many brides across South Asia wear sets of glass or gold bangles, and the sound of bangles is part of wedding celebrations. Many Punjabi Hindu and Sikh brides wear a **chooda**, a set of red and white bangles, on their wedding day.

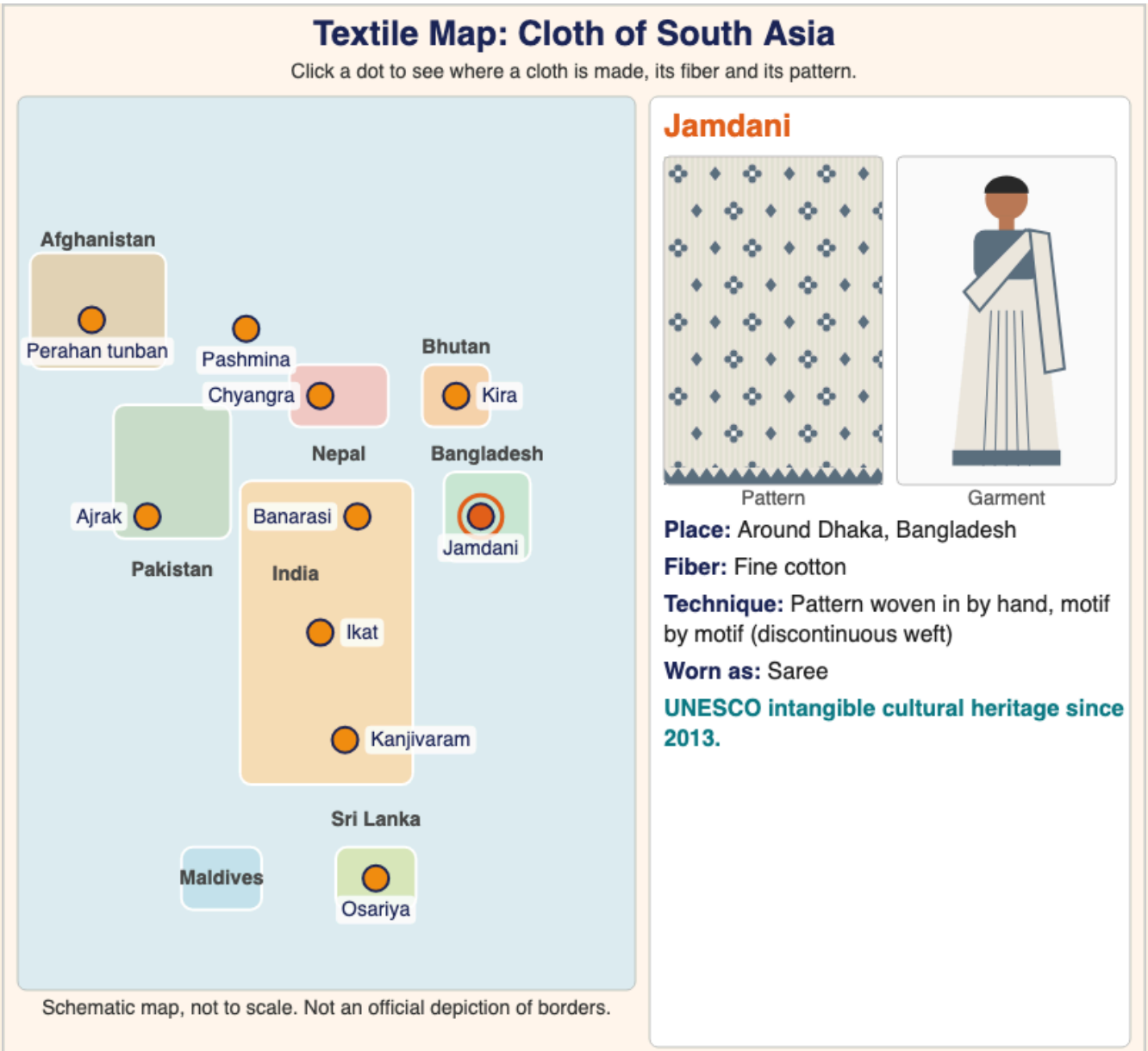
- **Marriage in Bengal:** many married Bengali Hindu women, in both Bangladesh and the Indian state of West Bengal, wear a white conch-shell bangle called a **shankha** (শাঁখা, *SHAN-kha*) together with a red bangle called a **pola**. These are traditionally given to the bride at her wedding.
- **Faith:** many Sikhs wear a **kara**, a single plain steel or iron bangle, which is one of the five articles of faith in Sikh tradition. It is worn by men and women.
- **Everyday style:** gold bangles are often given to babies and little girls, and plenty of people wear bangles just because they like them.

The town of Firozabad in Uttar Pradesh, India, is famous as a center of glass bangle making.

12.10 The Textile Map

Now that you know the fibers, techniques and garments, it's time to put them on the map. Look back at how many of these traditions are tied to a single town or region: Jamdani to Dhaka, ajrak to Sindh, Banarasi to Varanasi, Kanjivaram to Kanchipuram, kira weaving to Bhutan. That's the main idea of the sim below.

Diagram: Textile Map



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch12-textile-map/main.html

Open the Textile Map fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Textile Map

sim-id: ch12-textile-map
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Remember / Understand
Bloom Verb: identify, explain
Learning Objective: The learner will connect ten South Asian garments and textiles to the regions where they are made and to their fiber and technique.

Canvas: responsive width; 740 px drawing area plus 100 px control area.

Controls: textile menu, Previous and Next buttons, Quiz me / Show answer button, "Show place names" checkbox; click or tap any dot.

Behavior: A schematic tile map shows the eight countries (no borders) with ten labeled dots. Selecting a dot shows the textile's place, fiber, technique and the garment it is often used for, a simple drawing of that garment in the textile's colors, and a procedurally drawn pattern swatch (for example scattered woven flowers for Jamdani, feathery diamonds for ikat, buta shapes for pashmina, indigo and crimson stars for ajrak). In quiz mode the name is hidden and the learner clicks the dot they think matches the swatch. The caption "Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders." is drawn inside the drawing area.

Start by clicking every dot and reading the panel. For each one, notice three things: the fiber (cotton, silk or wool), whether the pattern is woven in, dyed into the thread first, or printed on, and which garment it usually becomes. Then press **Quiz me**. The sim will show you only a pattern swatch and a garment, and you have to find the right dot.

As you play, look for the pattern behind the details. The cotton traditions cluster in hot, humid places like the Bengal delta and Sindh. The pashmina dots sit high in the mountains, where goats need warm undercoats. The silk

dots are in places with long weaving traditions and wealthy patrons, such as the old temple town of Kanchipuram and the holy city of Varanasi. The map is simplified, but the link between land, fiber and cloth is real.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about the clothes they wore growing up, the clothes they wear for special days, and any garment in the family that has a story. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Ask if they have one special garment, like a wedding saree, a shawl, a turban or a set of bangles, that they would be willing to show you. Ask permission before you take a photo of it.

Questions to ask

1. What did you wear on an ordinary school day when you were my age? What did you wear for festivals or weddings?
2. Is there one piece of clothing in our family that has a story? Who made it, wore it or gave it?
3. How is a saree, turban, dupatta, gho or other garment tied or worn in our family? Who taught you?
4. Where did your family buy cloth or clothes? Did a tailor make them, or did anyone weave, embroider or block-print at home?

5. How have the clothes you wear changed since you were young, or since you moved to a new country?
6. Is there a garment, a weave or a way of dressing you hope I'll keep wearing or pass on?

Listen for: names of weaves or fibers (Jamdani, Ikat, Pashmina, silk, Khadi, Cotton in South Asia), which garments are draped and which are stitched (Saree, Dhoti, Lungi, Kurta, Shalwar Kameez, Dupatta), and the meaning of anything worn for faith or marriage, such as a Turban (Dastar), a Bindi or Bangles.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's description of everyday clothes with a friend's interview. Did one family wear mostly draped clothes and the other mostly stitched ones? Did either garment cross a border, like a saree in Bangladesh or a shalwar kameez in India? Write two sentences about what surprised you.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: The saree is only Indian.
Reality: The saree is worn in India, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka, and in parts of Pakistan. It is widely seen as the national dress for women in Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka has its own Kandyan style, the osariya.

Myth: The shalwar kameez is only Pakistani.
Reality: It is Pakistan's national dress, but it is also widely worn in India

(especially Punjab), Bangladesh and Afghanistan, by people of many faiths.

Myth: A turban means a person belongs to one particular religion.
Reality: Turbans are worn by Sikhs, by many Pashtun men, by elders in Rajasthan, by some Hindu monks and by some Muslim scholars, among others. For Sikhs, the dastar has a specific religious meaning, but the turban itself belongs to many traditions.

Myth: Khadi is just another word for cotton.
Reality: Khadi means cloth that is both hand-spun and hand-woven. It can be cotton, silk or wool, and it became a symbol of self-reliance in India's freedom movement.

Myth: "Paisley" is a Scottish design.
Reality: The shape began as the buta motif on Kashmir shawls. Factories in Paisley, Scotland, copied it in the 1800s, and the town's name stuck to the pattern.

Check Yourself

1. Where were the oldest known cotton fibers found, and about how old are they?

At Mehrgarh, an early village in Balochistan, Pakistan. They were preserved inside copper beads buried roughly 7,500 to 8,000 years ago, in the first half of the sixth millennium BCE.

2. What is the difference between Jamdani and ikat?

In Jamdani, the pattern is woven in on the loom, with extra weft threads added motif by motif. In ikat, the threads are tied and dyed in a pattern before weaving, which gives the shapes blurred edges.

3. Name one draped garment and one stitched garment, and say who usually wears each.

Draped: the saree (women), the dhoti or lungi (men). Stitched: the kurta (men and women) or the shalwar kameez (men and women).

4. What are the gho and kira, and when are they required?

They are Bhutan's national dress: the gho is a knee-length belted robe for men, and the kira is an ankle-length wrapped dress for women. Under Bhutan's dress code, men in government offices and schools must wear the gho, and both are worn for formal occasions.

5. Why did Gandhi promote khadi?

He wanted Indians to stop buying British machine-made cloth, which kept India dependent, and to spin and weave their own. Khadi became a symbol of self-reliance and the freedom movement.

Exercises

Remember

1. List the four kinds of silk that India's government recognizes, and name the one that is made almost entirely in Assam.

Answer

Mulberry, tasar, eri and muga. Muga, a natural golden silk, is made almost entirely in Assam.

2. In what year did UNESCO recognize Jamdani weaving, and in which country is it centered?

Answer

a. It is centered around Dhaka, Bangladesh.

Understand

1. Explain why ikat patterns have blurry, feathered edges.

Answer

The pattern is tied and dyed into the threads before weaving. When the threads are stretched on the loom and woven, they never line up perfectly, so the edges of each shape come out slightly soft.

2. Explain in your own words why the "paisley" pattern is named after a Scottish town.

Answer

The teardrop buta motif came from Kashmir shawls. When factories in Paisley, Scotland, made cheaper copies in the 1800s, English speakers started calling any shawl with that motif a Paisley shawl, and the name stuck to the shape.

Apply

1. Use the Textile Map. Find every dot whose main fiber is silk. What do the places have in common, and how are they different? *Hint: look at where each dot sits and what garment each makes.*
2. A friend shows you a white conch-shell bangle and a red bangle her mother wears every day. Using the chapter, explain what they might mean and which region the custom comes from. *Hint: look at Section 12.9.*

Analyze

1. Compare draped garments (saree, dhoti, lungi) with stitched garments (kurta, shalwar kameez). Give two practical reasons a family might choose one over the other. *Hint: think about weather, weaving, fit and occasion.*
2. Ben scored two out of five at culture day. Analyze why guessing someone's country from their clothes is so hard in South Asia, using at least three garments from the chapter as evidence. *Hint: compare when the countries were formed with how old the clothes are.*

Evaluate

1. Bhutan requires the gho and kira in certain settings to protect its national identity. Some Bhutanese in the south resented the rule. Evaluate the benefits and drawbacks of a required national dress. *Hint: the Whose Story? box gives two viewpoints.*
2. A clothing company sells a cheap machine-printed scarf labeled "pashmina." Evaluate whether that label is fair, using what you learned about pashmina and Geographical Indication tags. *Hint: what makes pashmina pashmina?*

Create

1. Design a label card for one garment or textile from your own family or from this chapter, as if it were in a museum. Include its name in English and its original script (if you can verify it), the fiber, the technique, where it comes from and one sentence of family or community meaning. *Hint: museum labels are short, so choose your details carefully.*
2. Plan a culture day for your own club where people bring clothes from home. Write a one-paragraph guide that helps guests ask good questions instead of guessing countries. *Hint: use the "Clothes Speak a Language" list in Section 12.2.*

Key Takeaways

- South Asia has spun and woven cotton for more than 7,000 years. The oldest known cotton fibers come from Mehrgarh in Pakistan, and Bengal's muslin was once famous worldwide.
- Silk (mulberry, tasar, eri and muga) and pashmina wool from Himalayan goats are the region's other great fibers, behind Banarasi, Kanjivaram and Rajshahi silks and Kashmir and Nepali shawls.
- Patterns can be woven in (Jamdani, recognized by UNESCO in 2013), dyed into the thread first (ikat) or printed on (ajrak from Sindh).
- Khadi, hand-spun and hand-woven cloth, became a symbol of self-reliance in India's freedom movement.
- Draped garments (saree, dhoti, lungi) and stitched ones (kurta, shalwar kameez, dupatta) cross national borders. Bhutan's gho and kira are a clear example of official national dress.
- Turbans, bindis and bangles can carry religious or marriage meanings, like the Sikh dastar and kara or the Bengali shankha, but meanings vary

by family, region and faith.

You can read the cloth now!

You can now look at a saree, a kurta or a gho and ask where its thread came from and how its pattern was made. Next, in Chapter 13, we meet the people who wear these clothes at life's biggest moments: families, names and weddings.

Quiz: Clothing and Textiles

Test your understanding of Chapter 12. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

Where were the oldest known cotton fibers in the world found?

A. In a tomb near Varanasi, India

B. Inside copper beads at Mehrgarh, Pakistan

C. In a weaver's workshop near Dhaka, Bangladesh

D. In a monastery in Bhutan

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Cotton fibers preserved inside copper beads in a burial at Mehrgarh, in Balochistan, Pakistan, date to the first half of the sixth millennium BCE, roughly 7,500 to 8,000 years ago. Dhaka became famous for fine cotton muslin much later, so it is a tempting but wrong choice.

Concept Tested: Cotton in South Asia **Bloom's Level:** Remember

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Question 2

Which of these best defines khadi?

A. Any cloth made of cotton

B. A silk saree woven in Varanasi

C. Cloth printed with wooden blocks in Sindh

D. Cloth that is both hand-spun and hand-woven

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Khadi is hand-spun and hand-woven cloth, and it can be cotton, silk or wool. Option A is a common misconception: khadi is defined by how it is made, not by the fiber.

Concept Tested: Khadi **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

What are the gho and kira?

A. The national dress of Bhutan for men and women

B. Two styles of saree draping from Nepal

C. Turbans worn by Pashtun men in Afghanistan

D. Silk weaves from Assam

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The gho is the knee-length belted robe worn by men in Bhutan, and the kira is the ankle-length wrapped dress worn by women. Nepal's national dress for men is the daura-suruwal, not the gho.

Concept Tested: Gho and Kira **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Why do ikat patterns usually have soft, feathery edges?

A. The pattern is painted on with a brush after weaving.

B. The cloth is washed many times to fade the colors.

C. The threads are tie-dyed before weaving and never line up perfectly on the loom.

D. Weavers add extra weft threads one motif at a time.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. In ikat, bundles of thread are tied and dyed in a pattern before they are woven, and small shifts on the loom blur the edges. Option D describes Jamdani, where the pattern is woven in with extra weft threads.

Concept Tested: Ikat **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

Why did Gandhi ask Indians to spin and wear khadi?

A. Because khadi was cheaper than any other cloth

B. To make India less dependent on British machine-made cloth and show self-reliance

C. Because British law banned Indians from wearing silk

D. To start a new fashion trend for weddings

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Under colonial rule, Indian cotton was often shipped to British mills and sold back as cloth. Gandhi's swadeshi movement urged people to boycott foreign cloth and spin their own. Option A is wrong: hand-spun yarn was often more expensive than mill yarn.

Concept Tested: Khadi **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 6

What makes the saree and the dhoti "draped" garments rather than "stitched" garments?

A. They are long unstitched lengths of cloth wrapped and tucked around the body.

B. They are always made of silk.

C. They are only worn at weddings.

D. They are sewn into a tube before being worn.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Both are rectangles of cloth that are wrapped, pleated and tucked rather than cut and sewn. Option D describes the Bangladeshi lungi, which is often sewn into a tube, and even that is wrapped rather than tailored.

Concept Tested: Saree **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

At a community event, you see a man wearing a turban. Based on the chapter, what is the best conclusion?

A. He must be Sikh.

B. He must be Muslim.

C. He must be from Rajasthan.

D. You can't tell his religion or region from the turban alone; it's best to ask respectfully if you want to know.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Turbans are worn by Sikhs, many Pashtun men, elders in Rajasthan, some Hindu monks and some Muslim scholars, among others. Option A is the most common mistake: the Sikh dastar has a specific meaning, but not every turban is a dastar.

Concept Tested: Turban (Dastar) **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

Your friend's mother, who is from Bangladesh, wears a white conch-shell bangle and a red bangle every day. What do they most likely signify?

A. She has completed a pilgrimage.

B. She is a member of a weavers' guild.

C. She is a married Bengali Hindu woman wearing shankha and pola.

D. She is a Sikh wearing a kara.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Many married Bengali Hindu women in Bangladesh and West Bengal wear the white shankha and the red pola, traditionally given at the wedding. Option D is wrong because the Sikh kara is a single plain steel or iron bangle.

Concept Tested: Bangles **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

The shalwar kameez is Pakistan's national dress, yet Simran's family from Ludhiana, India, wears it too. What does this best show?

A. Many South Asian garments are older than today's borders and are shared across countries.

B. Simran's family must have moved from Pakistan recently.

C. The shalwar kameez was invented in India and later copied by Pakistan.

D. National dress laws in Pakistan also apply in India.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The shalwar kameez spread across the Punjab region over centuries, long before the 1947 border, so it is worn on both sides. Option C wrongly turns a shared tradition into a contest over who invented it.

Concept Tested: Shalwar Kameez **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

Jamdani, ajrak and Banarasi brocade are all patterned cloth. Which comparison is correct?

A. All three are printed with wooden blocks.

B. Jamdani and Banarasi patterns are woven in on the loom, while ajrak is block-printed.

C. Jamdani is silk, ajrak is wool and Banarasi is cotton.

D. All three are tie-dyed before weaving.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Jamdani motifs are woven in with extra weft threads, Banarasi brocade weaves in zari, and ajrak is printed with carved blocks and natural dyes. Option D describes ikat, and none of these three is ikat.

Concept Tested: Jamdani **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events

Summary

Family sits at the center of social life in much of South Asia, and you can hear that in the words people use. Many South Asian languages have separate words for your father's brother and your mother's brother, for your father's mother and your mother's mother. This chapter explains those kinship words, joint families and respect for elders, then looks at how names are chosen and why not everyone has a surname. It explains caste honestly, including the laws against caste discrimination, and walks through the rituals that mark birth, growing up, marriage and death in Hindu, Muslim, Sikh, Buddhist and other families, ending with how gender roles are changing.

Concepts Covered

1. Joint Family
2. Kinship Terms
3. Respect for Elders
4. Naming Traditions
5. Surnames
6. Varna and Jati
7. Caste System

8. Caste Discrimination Laws
9. Life-Cycle Rituals
10. Coming-of-Age Rites
11. Weddings
12. Arranged Marriage
13. Mehndi Night and Sangeet
14. Nikah
15. Anand Karaj
16. Funeral Customs
17. Gender Roles and Change

Prerequisites

- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia, for the basics of Hinduism, Islam, Sikhism, Buddhism and other faiths.
- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts, for the languages and scripts you'll see in the kinship words.
- It helps to have read Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year, since some family rituals happen at festivals.

Who's Who at the Party?

Hi, I'm Mora! If you've ever stood at a family wedding or a dinner and had no idea what to call the aunt who just pinched your cheek, this chapter is for you. Knowing the right word for each relative, and the story behind your own name, is one of the easiest ways to feel at home in your family. And if your friends are South Asian, it will help you follow what's happening at their family events.

13.1 Four Uncles, One English Word

It's a Saturday evening in June, and Zara Hossain's cousin is getting married in a rented hall in St. Paul. Ben Lindqvist is the only guest in a hockey-team blazer, and Zara is steering him through the crowd.

"Ben, this is my Chacha," Zara says, and a smiling man shakes Ben's hand. Five minutes later: "This is my Mama." Another man, another handshake. Then a woman in a green saree hugs Zara and calls her by a name Ben has never heard. "That's my Khala," Zara explains. "And over there by the cake, that's my Fufu." Ben leans in. "Okay, wait. Your mama is a man? And those are all your uncles and aunts? In English I'd just say uncle, uncle, aunt, aunt."

Zara laughs, but then she thinks about it. Chacha is her father's brother. Mama is her mother's brother. Khala is her mother's sister. Fufu is her father's sister. Her Nanu, her mother's mother, is sitting at the head table, and Zara would never mix that word up with Dadi, her father's mother. Ben wants to know why one language needs four words where English uses two. And then he asks the bigger question: what else about a South Asian family works differently from his own?

13.2 One Word or Ten? Kinship Terms

Ben's family already gives him a head start. His relatives are from Sweden and Norway, and in Swedish you don't say "uncle" either. Your father's brother is your *farbror* ("father-brother") and your mother's brother is your *morbror* ("mother-brother"). Your father's mother is *farmor* and your mother's mother is *mormor*. Swedish speakers can tell, from one word, which side of the family someone is on. Many South Asian languages work the same way, and often go further.

Kinship Terms are the words a language uses for relatives: mother, uncle, cousin, grandmother and so on. Every language has them, but languages slice the family tree differently. English has one word, "uncle," for at least four different people: your father's older brother, your father's younger brother, your mother's brother, and the husbands of your aunts. Many South Asian languages give most of those people their own word.

This table compares a few of them, using Hindi-Urdu, the language family many people in northern India and Pakistan speak (Hindi is usually written in Devanagari script and Urdu in Nastaliq script; see Chapter 6).

Relative	English	Hindi-Urdu (many families)
Father's older brother	uncle	tau (Hindi) or taya (Urdu)
Father's younger brother	uncle	chacha
Father's sister	aunt	bua (Hindi) or phuphi (Urdu)
Mother's brother	uncle	mama (Urdu also mamun)
Mother's sister	aunt	mausi (Hindi) or khala (Urdu)

Relative	English	Hindi-Urdu (many families)
Father's mother	grandmother	dadi
Mother's mother	grandmother	nani

Two patterns jump out. First, **side matters**: the father's side and the mother's side get different words. Second, **age matters**: in many languages your father's older brother and younger brother are not the same kind of uncle.

Zara's family speaks Bangla, and the words she used at the wedding come straight from that table. In Bangla her mother's mother is নানী (*NAA-nee*), and Zara uses the affectionate form, নানু (*NAA-noo*), "Nanu." Her mother's sister is খালা (*KHAA-laa*), "khala," and her father's sister is ফুফু (*FOO-foo*), "phuphu" or "fufu."

Why separate words for each side?

Part of the answer is about who you live with and who you inherit from. Many South Asian families have traditionally been **patrilineal**: the family name and property passed mainly through the father's line. Your father's brothers might live in your house, while your mother's brothers live in her birth family's home, often far away. They play different roles in your life, so they get different words.

Languages of South India and Sri Lanka show a second pattern. In Tamil and Sinhala, your father's older brother is literally your "big father" (Tamil பெரியப்பா, *peh-ree-YAP-paa*; Sinhala ලොකු තාත්තා, *LO-ku TAAT-taa*), and your mother's older sister is your "big mother." Your father's sister and your mother's brother, though, get completely separate words.

Anthropologists call this a **Dravidian** kinship system: relatives linked through a same-sex pair of siblings (your father's brother, your mother's sister) are treated almost like extra parents, while relatives linked through an opposite-sex pair (your father's sister, your mother's brother) belong to a different category. In this system, the children of your father's sister or your mother's brother were traditionally seen as possible marriage partners in some communities, which is one reason those relatives have their own terms.

Not every language marks every difference. Tamil and Sinhala use the same word for both grandmothers (Tamil பாட்டி, *PAAT-tee*; Sinhala ආච්චි, *AACH-chee*), while Hindi-Urdu, Punjabi and Bangla split them by side (dadi and nani in Hindi-Urdu and Punjabi; many Hindu Bangla speakers say thakuma and didima instead).

Same language, different words

Kinship words change with region and community, even inside one language. Many Muslim Bangla speakers in Bangladesh say chacha and khala, while many Hindu Bangla speakers in West Bengal say kaka and mashi for the same relatives. Ask your family which words they use before assuming the dictionary is right.

Words for people who aren't related

Kinship words also travel outside the family. Kids are often taught to call a parent's friend "Uncle" or "Auntie," or "khala" or "chacha ji," which turns the whole community into a kind of extended family.

13.3 The Joint Family and Respect for Elders

Imagine living with your parents, your father's parents, and your father's brother with his wife and kids. Meals are cooked for twelve, and your cousins are more like siblings. That is a joint family.

A **Joint Family** is a household where several generations and branches of one family live together and often share a kitchen, money and property. In the traditional form found in many parts of South Asia, the joint family is built around brothers: married sons stay in their parents' home with their wives and children, while daughters move to their husbands' families when they marry. In India, the law even recognizes a "Hindu undivided family" as a unit for income tax.

Living with extended family is common across the region. A 2019 Pew Research Center study of household types found that extended-family households were the most common household type in the world, covering 38% of people. It also found that the average person in Afghanistan lived in a household of about 9.8 people, and in Pakistan about 8.5, far above the Asia-Pacific average of 5.0 (counting from each individual's point of view).

Not every South Asian family is a joint family. Many city families are **nuclear families** (parents and children only), and many mix the two, like a diaspora family that brings a grandparent to live with them, as Zara's family did with Nanu.

Respect for Elders

Respect for Elders is the value that older relatives and community members deserve special honor, care and obedience, and that families should look after them as they age. You can see it in small daily habits across South Asia:

- **Speech.** In Hindi-Urdu, you address an elder with the polite pronoun आप (*aap*), not the more casual तुम (*tum*). Many families add "ji" to a name or title as a mark of respect, like "Chacha ji." In many families children never

call an older sibling or relative by their first name alone. They use a kinship word or "bhai" (brother) or "apa," "didi" or "baji" (sister), depending on the language.

- **Greetings.** In many Hindu and Sikh families, younger people bend to touch an elder's feet as a greeting of respect, and the elder gives a blessing. In many Muslim families, younger people greet elders first with "salaam" and may be expected to stand when an elder enters.
- **Care.** In many families, grown children are expected to care for aging parents at home rather than in a care facility.

Respect for elders doesn't mean elders always get their way, and many teens feel a push and pull between honoring grandparents and making their own choices.

13.4 What's in a Name?

Ben's name is simple: a first name, Ben, and a family name, Lindqvist, which his father and his grandfather also had. Many people assume every name in the world works like that. In South Asia, it often doesn't.

Naming Traditions are the customs a family follows to choose a child's name: who chooses, when, and what the name should mean or sound like. Here are some you might meet:

- **Sikh families.** In Sikh tradition, a baby's name is often chosen in a **Naam Karan** ceremony at a gurdwara. The Guru Granth Sahib, the Sikh scripture, is opened at random, and the first letter of the first hymn on that page becomes the first letter of the child's name. Most Sikh first names can be used for boys or girls. Then comes a shared name: **Singh** for men and **Kaur** for women. Sikh tradition links these names to Guru Gobind Singh, the tenth Sikh Guru, and one aim of giving everyone the

same name was to reduce caste prejudice. That's why Simran, the club's treasurer, is Simran Kaur Gill: Kaur is her Sikh name and Gill is her family name.

- **Muslim families.** In many Muslim families, a baby is named in the first week, often on the seventh day, sometimes with an **aqiqah**, a celebration in which an animal is sacrificed and meat is shared with family and the poor. Many names are Arabic or Persian in origin and are chosen for their meaning or to honor a prophet or a relative.
- **Hindu families.** The Hindu naming ceremony, the **namakarana**, is one of the traditional samskaras (Section 13.6). Some families ask a priest or consult astrology for a lucky first sound for the name.
- **Bengali families**, both Hindu and Muslim, often give a child two names: a "good name," ভালো নাম (*BHAA-lo naam*, "bhalo nam"), used at school and on documents, and a "call name," ডাক নাম (*DAAK naam*, "dak nam"), a nickname used at home. Zara has one too, but she only lets her family use it.
- **Sherpa families** in Nepal, like Nima's, traditionally name a child after the day of the week the baby was born. Nima (also spelled Nyima, "sun") is the name for Sunday, Dawa for Monday, Mingma for Tuesday, Lhakpa for Wednesday, Phurba for Thursday, Pasang for Friday and Pemba for Saturday. That's why so many Sherpas share the same few names.
- **Bhutanese families** usually do not have family names at all. A Buddhist lama is often asked to choose the baby's name in the first weeks of life, and most people have two given names, such as Sonam or Tshering, Dorji or Karma. The names don't show which family a person belongs to, and many of them are given to both boys and girls.

Surnames

A **Surname** is a family name that is passed down from one generation to the next. In much of South Asia surnames exist, but they don't always work the way they do in Minnesota.

- **Many people have none.** Traditionally, many Afghans used only a single given name, and so do many Bhutanese today. In Afghanistan, people were told apart by their tribe, birthplace or profession.
- **Some use the father's name.** In many Tamil families in India and Sri Lanka, there is no inherited family name. Instead, a person's father's given name, often written as an initial, comes before their own name. So R. Karthik would be Karthik, son of someone whose name starts with R. His children would then use K as their initial. Some Tamils who move abroad turn the father's name into a last name so forms make sense.
- **Some reflect history.** In Sri Lanka, Portuguese rule in the 1500s and 1600s left behind surnames such as Perera and Fernando, which became some of the most common names in the country. Dilan Perera's family name carries that history.
- **Some point to caste or community.** In many parts of India and Nepal, a family name can show a person's caste or community. This is one reason some people have dropped their family names, used a religious name like Singh or Kaur, or chosen a new surname.
- **Some change at marriage, and some don't.** In many families a woman takes her husband's family name when she marries, but many women keep their own.

Getting a name right

If a South Asian classmate's name doesn't fit the "first name, last name" boxes on a form, it isn't a mistake. Ask them how they'd like their name written and said, and use it.

13.5 Caste: Varna, Jati, and the Law

"Is caste still a thing?" Ben asks Ms. Okafor at a club meeting. She tells him it's a fair and serious question, and the honest answer is yes, in different ways, in many places.

Varna and Jati

People often use "caste" to mean two different things, so it helps to separate them.

Varna and Jati are the two ideas behind what English speakers call caste. **Varna** (वर्ण, *VAR-na*) is a fourfold social classification described in old Brahmanical texts written in Sanskrit, such as the *Manusmriti*. Those texts list four varnas, Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Shudras, and assign each one duties and occupations. **Jati** (जाति, *JAA-tee*, "birth" or "kind") is the group a person is born into. There are thousands of jatis across South Asia. A jati is usually local, often linked in the past to a traditional occupation, and in many communities people were expected to marry within it. In everyday life, jati is what matters most. Varna is the textbook framework that people later tried to fit the jatis into.

Communities that the varna texts left outside the four varnas were treated as "untouchable" and faced the harshest exclusion: they were kept out of temples, wells, schools and many jobs. Today many of these communities call themselves **Dalit** (दलित, *DUH-lit*), a word meaning "broken" or "crushed," which reformers began using in the 1800s and which Dalit activists have made a word of pride and protest.

Mahatma Gandhi used the term "Harijan" ("children of God") for these communities in the 1930s. That word is now a historical term: many Dalits reject it as patronizing, and B. R. Ambedkar, the Dalit leader who chaired the committee that drafted India's Constitution, disliked it. Many tribal

communities in India and Bangladesh call themselves **Adivasi**, a 20th-century word meaning "ancient inhabitants." They have their own histories and were largely outside the varna system.

The caste system

The **Caste System** is the social system, built over many centuries, in which people are born into ranked groups that shape whom they marry, what work they are expected to do, and how others treat them. It is historical and continuing: its roots go back more than two thousand years, and it still affects people's lives today. Three points help you understand it fairly.

1. **It isn't only Hindu.** A 2021 Pew Research Center survey of about 30,000 adults in India found that Indians of every major religion, including Muslims, Christians and Sikhs, identify with a caste category. Sikh teachings reject caste, and Islam and Christianity teach the equality of believers, yet caste distinctions still appear in many of those communities.
2. **It isn't only in India.** Caste shapes society in Nepal too, and caste-based communities also exist in other parts of South Asia and in the diaspora.
3. **It still affects marriage most of all.** In the same Pew survey, 64% of Indians said it was very important to stop women in their community from marrying outside their caste, and 62% said the same about men. Most said their close friends were mostly from their own caste. Only about one in five said there was a lot of discrimination against Scheduled Castes, the government's legal term for Dalit communities.

Caste Discrimination Laws

Caste Discrimination Laws are laws that ban treating people unfairly because of their caste, and that protect communities who faced

untouchability. The most important ones in South Asia are in India's Constitution, which came into effect on 26 January 1950:

- **Article 15** says the state shall not discriminate against any citizen only because of religion, race, caste, sex or place of birth.
- **Article 17** abolished "untouchability" and forbids practicing it in any form. Enforcing any disability that comes from untouchability is a crime.

Parliament later passed laws to enforce these rules, including the Protection of Civil Rights Act (first passed in 1955 as the Untouchability (Offences) Act and renamed in 1976) and the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act of 1989. India also reserves a share of seats in legislatures, government jobs and public universities for Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes and other disadvantaged groups, a policy usually called **reservations**.

Nepal passed the Caste-Based Discrimination and Untouchability (Offence and Punishment) Act in 2011, which made caste discrimination a crime in private places such as homes, not just in public ones. Human rights groups still report that these laws are not always enforced in both countries.

The debate has reached the United States. In February 2023, **Seattle** became the first US city to add caste to its anti-discrimination laws. In September 2023, Fresno, California, did the same. That October, California's governor vetoed a bill that would have added caste to the state's civil rights law, saying existing protections against discrimination by ancestry already covered it. South Asian Americans were divided: some argued the laws protect people who face real discrimination, and others argued the laws single out South Asians and their faiths.

Whose Story?

People tell the story of caste very differently. Many Dalit writers and activists, following B. R. Ambedkar, describe caste as a system of oppression that religious texts helped justify and that must be ended completely. Many Hindus describe varna as a flexible idea about duty and talent that was later hardened into birth-based caste, and say that caste discrimination goes against their faith. Many Indian Muslims, Christians and Sikhs point out that their faiths reject caste, while researchers have documented caste divisions inside those same communities. In the United States, some South Asian groups see caste laws as civil rights protection, while others see them as unfairly targeting Hindus and Indians. Listening to all of these voices, and especially to people who have faced caste discrimination, is part of understanding the topic.

Handle with care

Never ask a classmate "what caste are you?" or guess someone's caste from their surname. It can be hurtful and is often discriminatory. If caste comes up, talk about the system and the laws, not about ranking any person or community.

13.6 Life-Cycle Rituals and Coming of Age

Every family marks big moments in a life: a birth, a first step into adulthood, a wedding, a death. **Life-Cycle Rituals** are the ceremonies that mark these turning points. In South Asia they are shaped by faith, region and family, and they usually bring the whole extended family together.

In Hindu tradition: the samskaras

In Hindu tradition, the life-cycle rituals are called **samskaras** (संस्कार, *sun-SKAA-ruh*, "making ready" or "refining"). Old texts list different numbers of them; a list of 16 became the best known, and the number and details vary by region and family. Some you'll hear about:

- **Namakarana**, the naming ceremony.
- **Annaprashana** ("first eating of rice"), when a baby eats solid food, often sweet rice pudding, for the first time, around six months old. In Nepal this is called **pasni**.
- **Mundan** or **chudakarana**, a child's first haircut, when the head is shaved.
- **Upanayana**, the sacred-thread ceremony (see Coming-of-Age Rites below).
- **Vivaha**, marriage.
- **Antyeshti**, the "last rite," the funeral.

Muslim, Sikh, Buddhist and other traditions

Muslim families mark a birth with prayers, by naming the baby and, in many families, with the **aqiqah** around the seventh day.

Sikh families mark a birth with Naam Karan. Buddhist families in Sri Lanka, Bhutan and Nepal often invite monks to bless a new baby, and many Christian families in South Asia mark a child's place in the church with baptism.

Coming-of-Age Rites

Coming-of-Age Rites are ceremonies that mark the move from childhood toward adulthood or full membership in a community. Some examples from the region:

- **Upanayana** (उपनयन, *oo-puh-NUH-yun*, "initiation"). In this Hindu ceremony, traditionally for boys from certain communities, a child receives the sacred thread, worn over the left shoulder, and is accepted as a student by a teacher. In Nepal it is called **Bratabandha** (व्रतबन्ध). Boys have their heads shaved, receive the thread, and make a symbolic first round asking relatives for alms.
- **Amrit Sanchar**. In Sikh tradition, people who are ready to commit fully to the faith take amrit (water stirred with a double-edged sword called a khanda) in a ceremony led by five initiated Sikhs, recalling the Panj Pyare ("beloved five") whom Guru Gobind Singh first initiated, and join the Khalsa. There is no fixed age.
- **Puberty ceremonies for girls.** In many Tamil families in Tamil Nadu and in the Tamil diaspora, a girl's first period has traditionally been marked by a family celebration, sometimes called manjal neerattu vizha, with a turmeric-water bath, new clothes, food and gifts. Rituals differ by community and region. Some families still hold big celebrations, while others, including some critics in Tamil Nadu, argue the custom puts unfair attention on girls and should change.

Your family counts

Your family might do some of these rituals, all of them, none of them, or a mix of old and new. That's normal. A short ceremony in a Minnesota apartment is just as real as a big one in Lahore or Dhaka.

13.7 Weddings

Weddings in South Asia are often multi-day events that join two families as well as two people, with separate ceremonies before, during and after the

main rite. Guest lists of hundreds are common. Details differ a lot by faith, region and family budget, but a few pieces show up again and again.

Arranged Marriage

An **Arranged Marriage** is a marriage in which parents or other relatives help find and suggest a partner, and the couple then decides whether to go ahead. Arranged marriage has been common in South Asia for centuries and still is, alongside "love marriages," where the couple meets on their own.

What arranged marriage looks like has changed a lot. In many families today, parents or relatives suggest possible matches, sometimes through friends, community networks or matrimonial websites and apps. The two young people meet, talk, sometimes over months, and either can say no. Some couples meet on their own and then ask their families to "arrange" the rest, which some writers call a "self-arranged" marriage.

The most important word here is **consent**. An arranged marriage, where both people freely agree, is very different from a **forced marriage**, where one or both people are pressured or made to marry against their will. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (Article 16) says marriage must be entered into only with the "free and full consent" of both people. Islamic law requires both the bride and the groom to consent, and Sikh teaching expects the couple to agree. In India, the Hindu Marriage Act of 1955 lets a court annul a marriage if consent was obtained by force or fraud. Forced marriage is a human rights abuse, and arranged marriage done with real consent is not.

Mehndi Night and Sangeet

The days before a wedding are often the most fun. **Mehndi Night and Sangeet** are two pre-wedding celebrations popular in many North Indian, Pakistani and diaspora families.

- At a **mehndi** night, the bride's hands and feet are decorated with **mehndi** (henna), a paste made from a plant that stains the skin reddish brown. Artists draw flowers, vines, paisleys and peacocks, and female relatives and friends get small designs too. There's usually music, food and dancing.
- A **sangeet** (संगीत, *sun-GEET*, "music") is a night of singing and dancing. In many families it was once a smaller gathering of women singing folk songs. Today many families stage dance performances by both sides of the family, often to film songs.

In Bangladesh and West Bengal, both Muslim and Hindu families hold a **gaye holud** (গায়ে হলুদ, *GAA-ye HO-lood*, "turmeric on the body"), where friends and relatives smear turmeric paste on the bride and groom amid songs and yellow and orange clothes.

Nikah

A **Nikah** (نکاح, *ni-KAAH*) is the Islamic marriage contract and ceremony. At its heart, the bride and groom each give their consent in front of witnesses, and the groom agrees to give the bride the **mahr**, a gift of money or property that belongs to her alone. An imam or other officiant often leads the ceremony, recites prayers and verses from the Quran, and the couple and witnesses sign a marriage contract, called a nikah nama in Pakistan and Bangladesh. Afterward comes the **walima**, a wedding feast hosted and paid for by the groom's side. Many South Asian Muslim families combine the nikah with older regional customs like mehndi or gaye holud.

Anand Karaj

The **Anand Karaj** (ਅਨੰਦ ਕਾਰਜ, *uh-NUND KAA-raj*, "blissful ceremony") is the Sikh wedding ceremony. It takes place in front of the Guru Granth Sahib, usually in a gurdwara. Many Sikh weddings take place in the morning. The center of the

ceremony is the **laavan**, four hymns composed by Guru Ram Das, the fourth Sikh Guru. As each hymn is sung, the couple walks around the Guru Granth Sahib, the groom leading the bride, who holds one end of a scarf that he holds too. After the fourth round, the couple is married. The Anand Marriage Act of 1909 gave Sikh marriages by this rite legal recognition in British India, and India amended the law in 2012 to let these marriages be registered under it.

Hindu and Buddhist weddings

In many Hindu weddings, the couple's marriage is witnessed by a sacred fire. The central moment is often the **saptapadi** ("seven steps"), when the couple takes seven steps or circles the fire together, making a promise at each one. Rituals vary a lot between, say, a Telugu wedding in Hyderabad like the ones Arjun's cousins have had, a Gujarati wedding and a Nepali wedding. In Sri Lanka, many Sinhala couples marry on a poruwa, a decorated wooden platform, in a ceremony with a traditional officiant, betel leaves and blessings from both families. Buddhist monks do not usually lead the wedding itself, and many Sri Lankans trace the poruwa custom to before Buddhism reached the island.

Wedding	Tradition	Where the key moment happens	Key moment
Hindu (many regions)	Hindu	Around a sacred fire, under a canopy	Saptapadi, seven steps or rounds
Nikah	Muslim	Home, mosque or hall	Consent before witnesses; mahr; contract signed

Wedding	Tradition	Where the key moment happens	Key moment
Anand Karaj	Sikh	Gurdwara, before the Guru Granth Sahib	Four laavan, four rounds of the scripture
Poruwa ceremony	Sinhala (Sri Lanka)	Decorated wooden platform (poruwa)	Rituals with an officiant; both families bless the couple

13.8 Funeral Customs

Death is hard to talk about in any culture, but knowing what a friend's family is doing helps you show up for them. **Funeral Customs** are the rites families follow when someone dies: how the body is cared for, the funeral itself, and the period of mourning afterward.

- **Hindu families** usually cremate the body, often within a day. In the Antyeshti, a son or close relative traditionally lights the funeral pyre, and the ashes are later placed in a river, for many families the Ganga. A period of mourning follows, and rituals called shraddha honor the dead in later years. Details vary by region, community and the age of the person who died.
- **Muslim families** bury the body as soon as possible, often within a day. The body is washed and wrapped in simple white cloth, a funeral prayer called the janazah is said, and the person is buried lying on their right

side, with the face turned toward Mecca. Cremation is not allowed in Islam.

- **Sikh families** usually cremate the body. In the Antim Sanskar ("final rite") the family recites prayers, and the ashes are scattered in running water. Sikh tradition discourages gravestones or monuments.
- **Buddhist families** in Sri Lanka, Nepal and Bhutan may cremate or bury. In Sri Lanka, families often offer food (dana) to monks on the seventh day after a death, again about three months later, and at the end of a year, dedicating the merit to the person who has died.
- **Parsi (Zoroastrian) families** in Mumbai have traditionally placed the dead in a dakhma, or "tower of silence," where the body is exposed to the sun and birds instead of being buried or burned. As vultures have become rare, some families now choose cremation or burial.

If a friend's relative dies, a simple "I'm so sorry" is always welcome. Ask your friend before attending a service so you know what to expect.

13.9 Gender Roles and Change

Back at the wedding, Ben notices that the women are mostly in the kitchen and the men are mostly greeting guests. Then he notices Zara's Khala, a surgeon, giving a speech, and Zara's cousin, the bride, signing her own marriage contract. Both scenes are common in South Asian families today.

Gender Roles and Change is about the expectations families and societies have for women and men, and how those expectations are shifting. In many traditional South Asian families, men were expected to earn money and represent the family in public, and women were expected to run the home, raise children and care for elders, often in their husband's family's house. Daughters often received less schooling than sons and moved away at marriage.

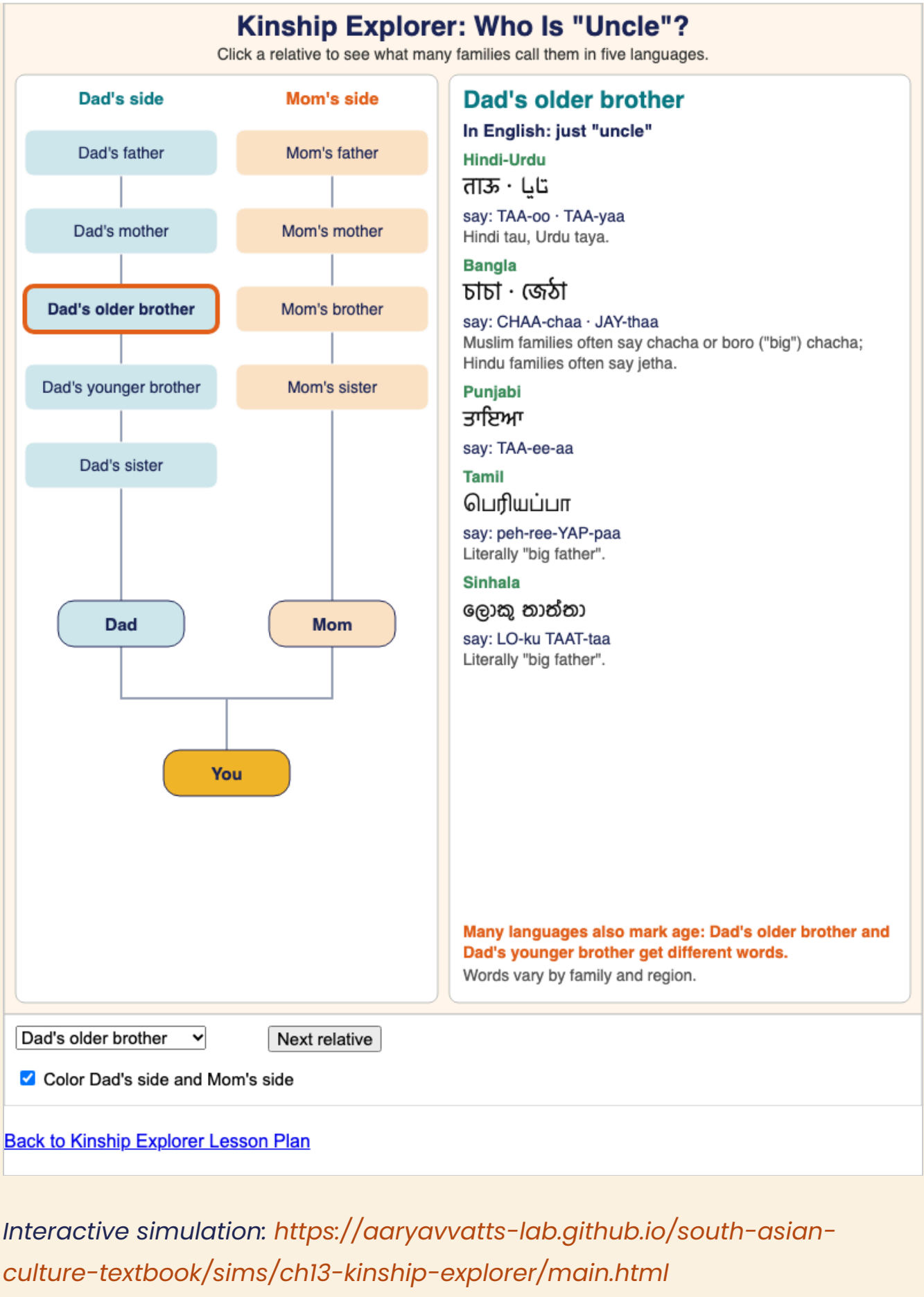
Surveys show that many of these expectations remain strong, but views differ. In a Pew Research Center survey of about 30,000 Indian adults, carried out in 2019 and 2020 and published in 2022:

- 54% said both men and women should be responsible for earning money for the family, while 43% said it is mainly men's job.
- 62% said both parents should share responsibility for taking care of children, while 34% said it is mainly women's job.
- About nine in ten agreed, at least mostly, that a wife must always obey her husband.

At the same time, South Asia has been home to some of the world's firsts for women in politics. In 1960, Sirimavo Bandaranaike of Sri Lanka (then Ceylon) became the world's first woman elected prime minister. In 1988, Benazir Bhutto of Pakistan became the first woman elected to lead a democratic government in a Muslim-majority country. Women have also led governments in India and Bangladesh, and in 2025 Sushila Karki became Nepal's first woman prime minister, leading an interim government until a new government took office after the March 2026 election.

Change is happening at home too, as more couples choose each other and many diaspora families split chores in new ways, while keeping roles they value, like grandparents' place in raising children. Change looks different in a village in Sindh, an apartment in Dhaka and a Minnesota suburb.

Diagram: Kinship Explorer



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch13-kinship-explorer/main.html

Open the Kinship Explorer fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Kinship Explorer

sim-id: ch13-kinship-explorer
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: explain
Learning Objective: The learner will explain why many South Asian languages have separate words for relatives on the father's side and the mother's side, and for older and younger relatives, by comparing kinship terms in five languages.

Canvas: responsive width; 880 px drawing area plus 80 px control area.

Controls: relative menu, Next relative button, "Color Dad's side and Mom's side" checkbox; click or tap any relative in the tree.

Behavior: A family tree centered on "You" shows nine relatives, with Dad's side on the left (teal) and Mom's side on the right (marigold). Selecting a relative shows the single English word next to the term many families use in Hindi-Urdu, Bangla, Punjabi, Tamil and Sinhala, in the original script with a respelling. Notes mark where usage varies by family, religion or region (for example, Muslim and Hindu Bangla speakers). Every spelling is logged in the chapter fact log.

Start with "Dad's older brother" and "Dad's younger brother." In English both are "uncle," but notice how many of the five languages give them different words, and how Tamil and Sinhala call them "big father" and "little father." Then click "Mom's brother." Which word stays almost the same across all five languages?

Next, compare "Dad's mother" with "Mom's mother." Then untick the color checkbox and see if you can guess from the words alone which side a relative is on. If your family uses a different word, your family isn't wrong.

Ask Your Elders

> **Your interview for this chapter**
>
> Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about family words, names and big family events. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Bring a sheet of paper and draw a simple family tree together as you talk. Ask if it's okay to take notes.

Questions to ask

1. What did you call each of your aunts, uncles and grandparents when you were a child? Did anyone have a nickname?
2. How was your name chosen, and who chose it? Does it have a meaning? How were names chosen for me and my siblings?
3. Did you grow up in a joint family or a smaller household? Who lived in the house?
4. Tell me about one wedding, naming ceremony or other family celebration you remember well. What happened, and what did you eat?
5. How have family roles changed since you were young, or since our family moved? Who cooks, who earns, who decides?
6. Is there a family custom, word or name you hope I'll keep and pass on?

Listen for: the Kinship Terms your elder uses and whether they split the father's side and mother's side; how the family's Naming Traditions and Surnames work; and any signs of Gender Roles and Change between their childhood and yours.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare the kinship words your elder used with the words in the Kinship Explorer. Which matched, and which were different? If a friend interviewed someone from another language or faith, make a two-column list of the words each family uses for the same relatives.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: All South Asian marriages are forced.
Reality: Many marriages are arranged, which means families help find a partner, but in an arranged marriage both people freely agree and can say no. Forced marriage, without real consent, is a human rights abuse that South Asian faiths and laws reject. Many South Asians also choose their own partners.

Myth: Caste only exists in India, and only in the past.
Reality: Caste is a historical and continuing system. It still shapes marriage and social life in India and Nepal, appears among people of many faiths, and has become a civil rights issue in the diaspora, including in Seattle and

California in 2023. Laws in India and Nepal make caste discrimination a crime.

Myth: Everyone has a first name and a family surname.
Reality: Many Bhutanese people and, traditionally, many Afghans have no family name. Many Tamils use their father's name as an initial instead of a surname, and Sherpa children are often named for the day they were born.

Myth: Joint families are disappearing everywhere.
Reality: Living patterns are changing, especially in cities and abroad, but extended-family households are still common in South Asia. A 2019 Pew study found that the average person in Afghanistan and Pakistan lived in a household of more than eight people, and many diaspora families still bring grandparents to live with them.

Check Yourself

1. Why do many South Asian languages have different words for a father's brother and a mother's brother?

In many patrilineal families, the father's brothers belonged to the same household and line of inheritance, while the mother's brothers belonged to another family and played a different role, such as a special part at weddings. Different roles led to different words.

2. What is the difference between varna and jati?

Varna is a fourfold classification described in old Sanskrit texts. Jati is the local birth group a person actually belongs to; there are thousands of them, and they shape marriage and community life.

3. What did Article 17 of India's Constitution do?

It abolished "untouchability," forbade practicing it in any form, and made enforcing any disability arising from it a crime.

4. What is the difference between an arranged marriage and a forced marriage?

In an arranged marriage, families help find a partner, but both people freely consent and can refuse. In a forced marriage, at least one person is made to marry without real consent.

5. What happens during the laavan in an Anand Karaj?

Four hymns by Guru Ram Das are sung, and as each one is sung the couple walks around the Guru Granth Sahib. After the fourth round, they are married.

Exercises

Remember

1. Name the four varnas listed in the old Brahmanical texts.

   Answer

   Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas and Shudras.

2. What is the Sikh name given to all women, and what is the name given to all men?

Answer

Kaur for women and Singh for men.

Understand

1. Explain in your own words what a joint family is and why it might lead to different words for relatives on each side.

Answer

A joint family is a household of several generations and branches, traditionally married brothers living with their parents, wives and children. Because the father's relatives live together and the mother's relatives live elsewhere, they play different roles, and languages give them different names.

2. Explain why a Tamil speaker might call their father's older brother "big father."

Answer

In the Dravidian kinship system, relatives linked through same-sex siblings (like a father's brother) are treated almost like parents, so the father's older brother is periyappa, "big father."

Apply

1. A new student at your school writes her name as "S. Lakshmi" and seems annoyed when a teacher calls her "Ms. S." Using what you learned about

Tamil naming, explain what might be going on and how the teacher could fix it.

Hint: what might the initial stand for?

2. Draw your own family tree with at least eight relatives. Label each one with the word your family actually uses, and mark which side they're on.

   Hint: ask a parent if you're not sure of a word.

Analyze

1. Compare the Nikah, the Anand Karaj and a Hindu wedding with saptapadi. What do all three require or include, and what is different about where and how the key moment happens?

   Hint: look at consent, witnesses and the role of scripture or fire.

2. The Pew survey found most Indians say there isn't a lot of caste discrimination, but most also say it's very important to stop inter-caste marriage. What might explain both answers being true at once?

   Hint: think about the difference between how people see discrimination and what they practice.

Evaluate

1. Seattle added caste to its anti-discrimination law, while California's governor vetoed a similar bill. Using the arguments on both sides from this chapter, which approach do you find more convincing, and why?

   Hint: consider both protection for people who face discrimination and the worry about singling out communities.

2. Some people say "joint families are disappearing." Evaluate this claim using evidence from the chapter and from your own community.

Hint: is there one answer for a village, a big city and the diaspora?

Create

1. Design a one-page "Who's Who at a South Asian Wedding" guide for a friend like Ben who has never been to one. Include at least six kinship words, two pre-wedding events and three tips for being a good guest.

   Hint: check each word with someone in your family or a classmate's family.

2. Write a short scene (one page) in which a teen asks a grandparent how their name was chosen. Show what each of them learns.

   Hint: use real details from your own interview if you can.

Key Takeaways

- Many South Asian languages use different **kinship terms** for the father's side and mother's side, and for older and younger relatives, while English often uses one word like "uncle."
- **Joint families** and **respect for elders** are strong traditions across the region, but households are flexible and changing, especially in cities and abroad.
- **Naming traditions** vary widely: Sikh names chosen from the Guru Granth Sahib, Sherpa day names, Bengali "good names" and "call names," and many people without family **surnames**.
- The **caste system** (built on **varna and jati**) is historical and continuing. India's Constitution and laws in India and Nepal ban caste discrimination, and the issue now reaches the diaspora.

- **Life-cycle rituals** and **coming-of-age rites** differ by faith and region, from samskaras and Bratabandha to aqiqah and Amrit Sanchar.
- South Asian **weddings** often last several days. An **arranged marriage** depends on the couple's consent, unlike a forced marriage, and the **Nikah** and **Anand Karaj** each have their own heart: consent and contract, or four hymns around the scripture.
- **Funeral customs** differ by faith, and **gender roles** are changing at different speeds in different places.

You know the family now!

You can now tell your chacha from your mama and explain why it matters. Next, in Chapter 14, we'll open the books and bedtime stories that families have passed down for centuries.

Quiz: Family, Names, and Life Events

Test your understanding of Chapter 13. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

In Hindi-Urdu, Bangla and Punjabi, what relative do many families call "mama"?

A. Mother

B. Father's younger brother

C. Mother's brother

D. Mother's mother

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. In all five languages in the Kinship Explorer, mama is the word many families use for the mother's brother. It does not mean "mother," which is the misunderstanding Ben has in the chapter's opening scene.

Concept Tested: Kinship Terms **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

Which article of India's Constitution abolished "untouchability" and forbade its practice in any form?

A. Article 15

B. Article 17

C. Article 16

D. Article 370

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Article 17 abolished untouchability and made enforcing any disability arising from it a crime. Article 15 is related, since it bans the state from discriminating on grounds such as caste, but it is not the article that abolished untouchability.

Concept Tested: Caste Discrimination Laws **Bloom's Level:** Remember

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Question 3

What is at the center of the Sikh Anand Karaj wedding ceremony?

A. Seven steps around a sacred fire

B. Signing a contract with a mahr before witnesses

C. Standing on a decorated wooden platform called a poruwa

D. Four hymns (laavan) sung as the couple walks around the Guru Granth Sahib

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. In the Anand Karaj, four laavan composed by Guru Ram Das are sung, and the couple circles the Guru Granth Sahib once for each hymn. Seven steps around a fire (saptapadi) belong to many Hindu weddings, not the Anand Karaj.

Concept Tested: Anand Karaj **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Which statement best describes the difference between varna and jati?

A. Varna is a fourfold scheme in old Sanskrit texts; jati is the local birth group people actually belong to, and there are thousands of them.

B. Varna is the modern legal term for caste; jati is the ancient religious term.

C. Varna applies only to Muslims and jati only to Hindus.

D. They are two names for exactly the same four groups.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Varna is the four-part classification described in Brahmanical texts, while jatis are the thousands of local birth groups that shape marriage and community life. Treating them as the same four groups is a common mistake.

Concept Tested: Varna and Jati **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

Why do Tamil and Sinhala call a father's older brother "big father"?

A. Because he is always the head of the household by law

B. Because the languages have no word for uncle at all

C. Because in the Dravidian kinship pattern, relatives linked through same-sex siblings are treated almost like parents

D. Because he is usually physically taller than the father

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. In the Dravidian pattern, a father's brother or a mother's sister is grouped with the parents ("big father," "big mother"), while a father's sister and a mother's brother get separate words. Tamil and Sinhala do have separate uncle words, such as mama, so option B is wrong.

Concept Tested: Kinship Terms **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 6

What makes an arranged marriage different from a forced marriage?

A. Arranged marriages happen only in villages.

B. In an arranged marriage, families suggest a partner but both people freely consent and can refuse.

C. Forced marriages are legal if the families agree.

D. Arranged marriages never involve the couple meeting before the wedding.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Consent is the dividing line: in an arranged marriage the couple decides, while a forced marriage happens without real consent and is a human rights abuse. Many arranged matches today involve long conversations and meetings, so option D is wrong.

Concept Tested: Arranged Marriage **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 7

Nima, a Sherpa student whose family is from Solukhumbu, Nepal, tells the club that her cousin was born on a Monday. Based on Sherpa naming traditions, which name might the cousin have?

A. Pemba

B. Nima

C. Phurba

D. Dawa

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Sherpa children are traditionally named for the day they were born, and Dawa is the Monday name. Nima (Nyima) is the Sunday name, so a child born on Monday would not usually get it.

Concept Tested: Naming Traditions **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

A teacher is setting up a class roster. A student from Bhutan has two given names and no family name. What is the best way for the teacher to respond?

A. Ask the student how they'd like their name written and said, since many Bhutanese people have no family surname.

B. Use the second name as the surname, since every name has one.

C. Ask the student to choose a new surname for school.

D. Use the student's father's name as the surname.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Many Bhutanese people have no family name, and names are often chosen by a lama. Assuming the second name is a surname (option B) is the most common mistake, so asking the student is the respectful choice.

Concept Tested: Surnames **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

The 2021 Pew survey of India found that only about one in five Indians said there was a lot of discrimination against Scheduled Castes, yet 64% said it was very important to stop women marrying outside their caste. What does this comparison suggest?

A. Caste no longer matters in India.

B. Caste matters only to people who say there is a lot of discrimination.

C. Caste still shapes choices like marriage, even when many people don't see it as discrimination.

D. The survey only asked about people living in the diaspora.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Many people did not describe caste discrimination as widespread, but most still wanted to keep marriage within caste, which shows caste continues to shape social life. Option A ignores the marriage finding entirely.

Concept Tested: Caste System **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

Compare a Hindu cremation, a Muslim burial and a Sri Lankan Buddhist almsgiving. Which statement correctly analyzes them?

A. All three require burial within 24 hours.

B. Muslim tradition calls for prompt burial and forbids cremation, while many Hindu families cremate, and Sri Lankan Buddhist families often offer food to monks at set times after a death.

C. All three forbid any ritual after the funeral day.

D. Hindu and Muslim families both scatter ashes in a river.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Islam calls for burial as soon as possible and does not allow cremation. Many Hindu families cremate and place ashes in a river, and Sri Lankan Buddhist families often give dana to monks after seven days, about three months and a year. Option D is wrong because Muslims do not cremate.

Concept Tested: Funeral Customs **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 14: Stories and Literature

Summary

South Asia has been telling stories for thousands of years, first out loud and later in writing, in dozens of languages. This chapter starts with oral tradition and the two great Sanskrit epics, the Ramayana and the Mahabharata, then follows the animal fables of the Jatakas and the Panchatantra as they travel to Persia, the Arab world and Europe. You'll meet Tamil Sangam poetry, the playwright Kalidasa, the poet-saint Kabir, the ghazals of Mirza Ghalib, and three modern poets who became symbols of nations: Rabindranath Tagore, Kazi Nazrul Islam and Allama Iqbal. The chapter ends with the literature of Partition and with South Asian writing in English and in translation. The big idea is that good stories rarely stay in one language, faith or country.

Concepts Covered

1. Oral Tradition
2. Ramayana
3. Mahabharata
4. Bhagavad Gita
5. Jataka Tales
6. Panchatantra
7. Sangam Literature
8. Kalidasa

9. Kabir
10. Akbar and Birbal Tales
11. Mirza Ghalib
12. Rabindranath Tagore
13. Kazi Nazrul Islam
14. Allama Iqbal
15. Partition Literature
16. South Asian English Writing

Prerequisites

- Chapter 2: Ancient Roots, for the early history behind the epics
- Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition, for the events behind Partition literature
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia, for Hindu, Buddhist, Sikh and Muslim traditions that shaped many stories
- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts, for the languages these works were written in

Pull up a chair

Hi, it's Mora! You probably already know some of these stories, from a bedtime tale, a cartoon, a holiday play or a line your grandparent quotes at dinner. This chapter shows you where those stories came from and how they keep changing, so the next time a relative says "that's not how it goes," you'll know why both of you might be right. Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

14.1 Two Ramayanas at One Lunch Table

It's Thursday lunch at Prairie Ridge High School. "I watched six episodes of an animated Ramayana series last night," Ben Lindqvist says. "Prince Rama gets sent into the forest, the demon king Ravana kidnaps Sita, and a monkey army builds a bridge to an island to rescue her. It's basically a superhero movie."

Dilan Perera, whose family is Sinhala-speaking and Buddhist and comes from Kandy in Sri Lanka, laughs a little. "That island is supposed to be Lanka," he says. "My grandfather tells some of it differently. In his version Ravana isn't really a monster. He's a brilliant king, a scholar who played music. Some people back home are proud of him."

Zara Hossain jumps in. "My Nanu knows the story too, from growing up in Bangladesh, and she tells it with Bengali details I've never seen in any cartoon." Ben puts his fork down. "Okay, wait. If everyone tells it differently, which one is the *real* Ramayana?" This chapter is the long answer.

14.2 Stories Are Like Songs With Many Covers

Think about a famous song that many artists have covered. Each cover keeps the melody you recognize but changes the speed, the instruments, maybe a few words, and nobody calls it "fake." Many South Asian stories work the same way. For most of history they were not books. They were performances.

Oral Tradition is the passing of stories, poems, songs and knowledge from person to person by speaking, singing and memorizing, often across many generations, instead of by writing them down. In South Asia, oral tradition has carried everything from holy texts to grandmothers' bedtime stories. Many languages have an everyday word for a story told this way. In Hindi it might

be a katha (कथा, *KUH-thaa*), "story," a word borrowed from Sanskrit. Zara's Nanu calls a story a golpo (গল্প, *GOL-po*), the everyday Bangla word for "story." In Urdu, a long, adventure-filled tale is a dastan (داستان, *daas-TAAN*), a word that came from Persian.

Performers learned long poems by heart, often with music and rhythm to help, and sang or acted them at festivals, temples, shrines, courts and village gatherings. Each teller could add local details, jokes and lessons for the audience in front of them.

Oral tradition is still alive. Two examples are on UNESCO's list of the world's living cultural heritage. **Ramlila**, "Rama's play," is a cycle of open-air plays retelling the Ramayana, performed across northern India during the autumn Dussehra festival. UNESCO first proclaimed it in 2005 and inscribed it on its Representative List in 2008. The **Baul songs** of Bangladesh (also sung in West Bengal, India) are devotional songs by wandering minstrels called Bauls, passed down orally from teacher to student and recognized by UNESCO on the same timeline.

In Sindh, in today's Pakistan, the poems of the Sufi poet Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai were passed around by memory and song during his lifetime and only gathered into a book, the *Shah Jo Risalo*, after he died.

Think about your own family

Is there a story your family only tells out loud, never from a book? Notice which details change when a different relative tells it. That change is oral tradition happening right in your living room.

14.3 The Two Great Epics

An **epic** is a very long poem about heroes, gods, wars and journeys that a culture treats as one of its foundation stories. South Asia's two most famous epics were composed in Sanskrit, the classical language you met in Chapter 6, and for many Hindus they are sacred texts. This section describes what they say and how scholars date them, not whether anyone's beliefs are true.

The Ramayana

The **Ramayana** (रामायण, *raa-MAA-yuh-nuh*), "the story of Rama," is a Sanskrit epic about Prince Rama of the kingdom of Ayodhya. The best-known version is traditionally credited to the poet-sage Valmiki. Here is the story in brief:

1. Rama's stepmother persuades his father, King Dasharatha, to send Rama into the forest for fourteen years.
2. Rama goes, joined by his wife Sita and his brother Lakshmana.
3. Ravana, the ten-headed king of Lanka, kidnaps Sita and carries her to his island kingdom.
4. Rama allies with an army of vanaras (monkey-like forest people), including the devoted Hanuman.
5. They cross to Lanka, defeat Ravana and rescue Sita, and Rama returns home to be crowned.

Valmiki's Ramayana has nearly 24,000 verses, arranged in seven books. Scholars think its oral core took shape around 750 to 500 BCE, with later additions. Many Hindus see Rama as a form of the god Vishnu, and the story's themes of duty, loyalty and doing what is right run through South Asian culture. Diwali, which you met in Chapter 7, is linked in many North Indian families to Rama's return home.

The Mahabharata

The **Mahabharata** (महाभारत, *muh-haa-BHAA-ruh-tuh*), "the great story of the Bharatas," is a Sanskrit epic about a struggle for a throne between two sets of royal cousins, the Pandavas and the Kauravas, that ends in a huge war at Kurukshetra. It is traditionally credited to the sage Vyasa, who is also a character in the story. Its longest version has more than 100,000 verses, making it one of the longest poems ever composed. Most of it was probably put together between about 300 BCE and 300 CE.

The Mahabharata is famous for being morally complicated: heroes make bad choices, villains have reasons, and characters argue about what is right.

The Bhagavad Gita

The most famous section inside the Mahabharata is the **Bhagavad Gita** (भगवद्गीता, *BHUG-uh-vud GEE-taa*), "God's song," a poem of about 700 verses found in the epic's sixth book. Just before the great battle, the warrior prince Arjuna sees relatives and teachers on the other side and loses the will to fight. His charioteer, Krishna, whom Hindus revere as a form of Vishnu, answers his doubts in a long conversation about duty, action, devotion and the self. Scholars disagree about when it was composed. Many place it around the second or first century BCE, while others argue for earlier or later dates.

For many Hindus, the Gita is one of the most important sacred texts. Thinkers over the centuries have written commentaries on it that disagree about its deepest meaning.

Work	Language	Rough date (scholars' estimate)	Size	What it's about
Ramayana (Valmiki)	Sanskrit	Oral core about 750 to 500 BCE	Nearly 24,000 verses, 7 books	Rama's exile, Sita's capture by Ravana, her rescue
Mahabharata	Sanskrit	Mostly about 300 BCE to 300 CE	More than 100,000 verses	A war between royal cousins and the questions it raises
Bhagavad Gita	Sanskrit	Debated; often placed about 2nd to 1st century BCE	About 700 verses	Krishna's answers to Arjuna's doubts before battle

14.4 One Story, Many Tellings

Now back to Ben's question. Valmiki's Ramayana is the oldest well-known version, but it is far from the only one. Over the centuries, poets retold Rama's story in their own languages, for their own audiences.

- **Tamil:** In the 12th century the poet Kamban wrote the *Ramavataram*, often called the Kamba Ramayanam. Many readers count it among the greatest works of Tamil literature.
- **Bangla:** Krittibas Ojha's Bengali Ramayana, the *Krittivasi Ramayan*, dates from around the 15th century. It is full of the food, customs and village life of Bengal, and for centuries it was one of the most popular books in the region.
- **Awadhi (a language of North India):** In the 16th century, Tulsidas wrote the *Ramcharitmanas* in everyday Awadhi rather than Sanskrit, so that ordinary people could follow the story. It is the basis of the Ramlila plays.
- **Nepali:** Bhanubhakta Acharya (1814 to 1868) made the first Nepali translation of the Ramayana, which spread at first by word of mouth.
- **Beyond South Asia:** Around 870 CE, poets on the island of Java (in today's Indonesia) wrote the *Kakawin Ramayana*. Its second half is very different from Valmiki's. Thailand's *Ramakien* is one of that country's national epics. The Malay *Hikayat Seri Rama* mixes in elements from Islamic tradition.

There are also Buddhist and Jain tellings, in which parts of the plot and the meaning change.

In 1987 the scholar A. K. Ramanujan presented an essay called "Three Hundred Ramayanas: Five Examples and Three Thoughts on Translation." He chose the word **tellings** instead of "versions" on purpose, because "version" suggests there is one true original and the rest are copies. His point was that Valmiki's Ramayana is one telling among many. The essay became controversial: Delhi University assigned it to history students for several years, then voted in October 2011 to remove it from the course after objections.

Many tellings is not the same as 'made up'

For many Hindus the Ramayana is sacred, and Rama is worshipped as divine. Saying there are many tellings is a fact about how the story has been passed on, not a claim about whether anyone's faith is true, so talk about it with the same respect you'd want for your own traditions.

So what about Dilan's grandfather? In Sri Lanka, Ravana is remembered in more than one way. Many places on the island are popularly linked with scenes from the Ramayana, and the country's tourism industry promotes a "Ramayana trail" for visitors from India. At the same time, some Sinhala Buddhists have recast Ravana as a wise and noble king of the island, and that view became more popular from the 1980s on. Sri Lanka even named its first satellite, launched in 2019, Raavana-1. In Tamil literature in Sri Lanka and in South India, Ravana also appears in a positive light. One Tamil poet wrote a whole epic in which he is the hero. Historians also debate whether the Lanka of the epic was the same place as today's Sri Lanka.

Whose Story?

The same epic means very different things depending on who is telling it. For many Hindus in India, Nepal and the diaspora, the Ramayana is a sacred story of a divine king, and Ravana's defeat is celebrated each year at Dussehra by burning his effigy. In Thailand the Ramakien is a national epic illustrated on the walls of Bangkok's Wat Phra Kaew temple, and Indonesia, a mostly Muslim country, has its own Ramayana tellings from Java and Bali. Some Sinhala Buddhists in Sri Lanka see Ravana as a proud ancient king of their island, while Tamil writers in South India and Sri Lanka have also honored him as a hero. Scholars like A. K. Ramanujan argue that none of these is the single "real" one, while others feel that treating a sacred text as one telling among many misses what makes it holy to them.

Ben gets it now. "So it's like a song with a hundred covers," he says. "The covers aren't wrong. They're for different crowds." Dilan grins. "And my grandfather would say his cover is the best one."

14.5 Animals Who Teach: Jatakas, Panchatantra and Birbal

Some of the most widely traveled stories in history star monkeys, jackals, lions and tortoises.

The Jataka Tales

The **Jataka Tales** (जातक, *JAA-tuh-kuh*), "birth stories," are Buddhist stories about the earlier lives of the Buddha, before he was born as Prince Siddhartha. In these stories the future Buddha appears as a person or an animal (a monkey, a deer, a parrot, an elephant) and shows qualities like generosity, patience and courage. The Theravada Buddhist collection in the Pali language contains 547 Jatakas in a mix of verse and prose. Scholars think the verses are older than the prose stories around them, and the collection in its present form was put together around 500 CE.

Jatakas were also carved and painted: some of the earliest Jataka pictures are on the stone gateways and railings of the Buddhist stupas at Sanchi and Bharhut in India, and later murals fill the caves at Ajanta. Theravada Buddhism is the main tradition in Sri Lanka, so Jataka stories are part of many Sri Lankan childhoods, Dilan's included, as well as in Myanmar, Thailand and Laos.

The Panchatantra

The **Panchatantra** (पञ्चतन्त्र, *PUNCH-uh-TUN-truh*), "five treatises," is a Sanskrit collection of animal fables arranged inside a frame story. In the frame, a wise teacher uses clever stories to teach three slow-learning princes how to live and rule wisely. Inside, the animals argue, scheme, make friends and pay for bad choices, and each tale has a lesson about trust, friendship or good judgment. Its author is unknown. Some versions name a teacher called Vishnu Sharma, but that may be a pen name. The Panchatantra shares many of its stories with the Jatakas, which shows how fables flowed between Hindu and Buddhist storytellers.

Then the Panchatantra went on one of the longest journeys of any book:

The Arabic version, *Kalila wa Dimna*, is named after two jackals who narrate and star in the stories. The Persian scholar Ibn al-Muqaffa's Arabic translation is still admired as a masterpiece of Arabic prose. The Library of Congress holds a digital copy of an illustrated Arabic manuscript of *Kalila wa Dimna* made in Egypt around 1310, with 73 painted pictures. From Arabic, the stories passed into many other languages, and some European writers openly credited "Bidpai" or "Pilpay, the Indian sage" as their source. One count finds about 200 versions of the Panchatantra in more than 50 languages.

Akbar and Birbal Tales

Not all South Asian folk stories are ancient. The **Akbar and Birbal Tales** are funny stories about the Mughal emperor Akbar and his quick-witted minister Birbal, in which Birbal solves impossible puzzles, outsmarts jealous courtiers, and sometimes teases the emperor himself. Birbal was a real person: born Mahesh Das in 1528, he became one of Akbar's closest courtiers and a

member of the group of advisers later called the *navaratnas*, the "nine jewels." He died in 1586, killed in battle in the Swat region of today's Pakistan. Most of the famous tales, though, are folk stories that spread much later, mainly in the 1800s, across what are now India and Pakistan, and they are still retold for children today.

14.6 Classical Poetry: Sangam Poems and Kalidasa

Sangam Literature

Sangam Literature is the earliest known body of Tamil poetry, composed roughly between 300 BCE and 300 CE. The word Sangam (சங்கம், *SUNG-gum*) means "gathering" or "academy." According to Tamil tradition, the poems were approved by great assemblies of poets in the city of Madurai. Historians treat those legendary assemblies as tradition rather than history, but the poems themselves are very real.

The Sangam collections hold 2,381 poems by 473 poets, 102 of them anonymous. The poems fall into two big kinds:

- **Akam** (inner) poems are about love: longing, meeting, separation and jealousy.
- **Puram** (outer) poems are about public life: kings, war, generosity, death and fame.

Sangam poets also sorted poems by landscape, such as hills, pastures or seashore, so the setting of a poem helped signal its mood. Many readers find them surprisingly modern: short, vivid and about ordinary emotions. Tamil is spoken today in India's Tamil Nadu, in northern and eastern Sri Lanka, and in a large diaspora, and many Tamils around the world take pride in Sangam poetry.

Kalidasa

Kalidasa was a poet and playwright who wrote in Sanskrit, probably in the fourth to fifth century CE, during the time of the Gupta kings. Very little is known about his life, and even his birthplace is debated. His surviving works include three plays and several poems. Two are especially famous:

- **Shakuntala** (full title *Abhijnanashakuntalam*), a play about a king who falls in love with a young woman raised in a forest hermitage, forgets her because of a curse, and finally recognizes her again.
- **Meghaduta**, "The Cloud Messenger," a poem in which a yaksha (a nature spirit) exiled for a year asks a passing cloud to carry a message to his wife in the Himalaya, describing the sights the cloud will pass on its way north.

The British scholar William Jones translated *Shakuntala* into English in the late 1700s, and from English it went into German, where the poet Goethe admired it.

14.7 Poet-Saints and the Ghazal

From around the 1400s, some of South Asia's most loved poetry came from poet-saints, devotional poets who wrote in the languages people spoke every day.

Kabir

Kabir was a 15th-century poet-saint from Varanasi, in North India. Historians are unsure of his exact dates (some say 1398 to 1448, others 1440 to 1518). Tradition says he was raised by a Muslim weaver family, and he is often described as a weaver himself. Kabir composed songs and short, sharp couplets (called *dohe* or *sakhi*) in the everyday Hindi of his time. Many were

passed on orally, and later admirers added verses in his name. He questioned empty ritual and hypocrisy in both Hinduism and Islam and taught that the divine is found within each person. During his lifetime he was criticized by both Hindus and Muslims, and after his death both communities claimed him.

Kabir's verses are included in the Guru Granth Sahib, the holy scripture of the Sikhs, and a community called the Kabir Panth ("Path of Kabir") honors him as its founder. Five hundred years later, Rabindranath Tagore was among the writers influenced by him.

Mirza Ghalib and the ghazal

To understand the next poet you need one form. A **ghazal** (غزل, *GHUZ-ul*) is a poem made of separate two-line couplets that share a rhyme and a repeated ending phrase. Each couplet can stand alone like a tiny poem. The form came to South Asia through Persian and became central to Urdu poetry and music.

Mirza Ghalib (1797 to 1869) is the most famous ghazal poet in the Urdu language. Born in Agra, he lived most of his life in Delhi and wrote in both Urdu and Persian. He wrote far more in Persian than in Urdu, but his fame rests on his Urdu ghazals. He lived through the violence of 1857 in Delhi and spent much of his life short of money.

Before Ghalib, ghazals were mostly about painful love. Ghalib stretched the form to cover philosophy, doubt, faith, loss and the strangeness of life, often with wit. He was also a brilliant letter writer: his chatty, funny Urdu letters helped make Urdu prose more natural and easy to read. Today his couplets are quoted in India, Pakistan and the diaspora, and ghazal singers still perform them.

How to spot a ghazal

Listen for the same word or phrase coming back at the end of every couplet, like a chorus. Many famous film songs and qawwali performances are built on ghazals, so you may have heard one without knowing its name.

Poets of the northwest

The northwest of the region, in today's Pakistan and Afghanistan, has its own beloved poets:

- **Rahman Baba** (about 1632 to 1706), a Sufi poet from Peshawar, wrote in Pashto about God, kindness and humility. He is among the most popular poets of the Pashto language, loved by Pashto speakers in both Pakistan and Afghanistan.
- **Waris Shah** wrote *Heer* in 1766, the most famous telling of Heer and Ranjha, a tragic Punjabi love story that already existed in oral and earlier written forms.
- **Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai**, as you saw in 14.2, composed Sindhi Sufi poetry that was sung and memorized before it was ever collected.

14.8 Poets Who Became Symbols of Nations

In the late 1800s and early 1900s, three poets became so important that countries now treat them as national symbols. All three were born in British India. Today their memories belong to India, Bangladesh and Pakistan in different ways.

Rabindranath Tagore

Rabindranath Tagore (1861 to 1941) was a Bengali poet, songwriter, novelist, playwright, painter and educator from Calcutta (now Kolkata). He wrote some 2,000 songs, many novels and short stories, and founded Visva-Bharati University at Santiniketan. In 1913 he won the Nobel Prize in Literature, the first person from outside Europe to win that prize and the first Asian to win any Nobel Prize. The Nobel committee praised his "profoundly sensitive, fresh and beautiful verse," much of it from *Gitanjali* (Song Offerings), a book of song-poems he translated into English himself.

Tagore wrote the words of two countries' national anthems:

- India's anthem, "Jana Gana Mana," is the first stanza of a song Tagore wrote in Bengali. It was first sung publicly in Calcutta in 1911 and adopted as India's national anthem in January 1950.
- Bangladesh's anthem, "Amar Sonar Bangla" (আমার সোনার বাংলা, *AA-mar SHO-nar BANG-la*), "My Golden Bengal," was written by Tagore and adopted by Bangladesh's provisional government in 1971.

Sri Lanka's anthem has a Tagore connection too, but a debated one. Most historians say the Sri Lankan composer Ananda Samarakoon, who had studied under Tagore at Santiniketan, wrote both the words and music, inspired by his teacher. A minority claim Tagore wrote part or all of it, and some historians in both India and Sri Lanka reject that claim.

Kazi Nazrul Islam

Kazi Nazrul Islam (1899 to 1976) was a Bengali poet, songwriter and journalist who is honored as the national poet of Bangladesh. People called him that for decades, and in December 2024 the government made the title official in a gazette notice. Born into a Muslim family in a village in what is now West Bengal, India, he served in the British Indian Army and then became a journalist in Calcutta. In 1922 he published "Bidrohi" ("The Rebel"), a thundering poem against injustice and oppression that earned him the title

of *Bidrohi Kobi*, the "Rebel Poet." His writing against British rule landed him in prison more than once.

Nazrul wrote and composed nearly 4,000 songs, now known as *Nazrul Geeti*. He brought the ghazal into Bengali and also wrote Islamic devotional songs alongside Hindu devotional songs to the goddess Kali, called *Shyama Sangeet*, which upset some people on both sides. He looked up to Tagore as a mentor, and in 1923 Tagore dedicated a play, *Basanta*, to him while Nazrul was in prison. In 1942 an illness began to take away his voice and memory, and he could no longer write. In 1972 Nazrul was brought to the new country of Bangladesh, where he spent his last years.

Allama Iqbal

Allama Iqbal (Sir Muhammad Iqbal, 1877 to 1938) was a poet and philosopher born in Sialkot, Punjab, in today's Pakistan. *Allama* is an honorific meaning "learned scholar." He studied in Lahore, Cambridge and Munich and wrote in Urdu and Persian. In his famous 1930 Allahabad Address he called for a separate political home for Muslims in the northwest of British India, an idea that helped shape the movement for Pakistan, which was founded nine years after his death.

Iqbal is honored as Pakistan's national poet, and his birthday, 9 November, is a public holiday there (the government restored the holiday in 2022 after dropping it in 2015). One of his best-known Persian books, *Asrar-e-Khudi* (Secrets of the Self), urges readers to build their inner strength, or selfhood. Iqbal's life shows how poetry crosses borders: one of his early Urdu songs, "Saare Jahan Se Achha" (also called "Tarana-e-Hindi"), written for children, is still a popular patriotic song in India, and his Persian poems are so loved in Iran that people there call him *Iqbal-e Lahori*, "Iqbal of Lahore."

And in Nepal

Nepal has its own modern classic. Laxmi Prasad Devkota's long poem *Muna Madan* (1936) tells of a young husband who leaves Kathmandu for Lhasa, in Tibet, to earn money, and the wife who waits for him. Devkota and Bhanubhakta (14.4) are both major figures in Nepali literature.

Poet	Lived	Main languages	Remembered as	Countries that honor him
Rabindranath Tagore	1861 to 1941	Bangla, English	Nobel laureate (1913); anthem writer	India and Bangladesh
Kazi Nazrul Islam	1899 to 1976	Bangla	The "Rebel Poet"; national poet	Bangladesh (and India)
Allama Iqbal	1877 to 1938	Urdu, Persian	National poet; thinker	Pakistan (and admirers in India and Iran)

14.9 Partition Literature

In 1947 British India was divided into India and Pakistan, and in the violence and mass migration that followed, as you read in Chapter 4, huge numbers of people were killed and millions were forced from their homes, with Hindus, Muslims and Sikhs all suffering. Writers on every side tried to make sense of it.

Partition Literature is the poetry, fiction and memoir written about the 1947 Partition and its aftermath, in Urdu, Hindi, Punjabi, Bangla, Sindhi, English and other languages. Rather than heroes and villains, the best of it focuses on ordinary people, loss and the absurdity of drawing a line through a shared home. Three classics:

- **"Ajj Aakhaan Waris Shah Nu"** ("Today I Call on Waris Shah," 1947), a Punjabi poem by **Amrita Pritam**, who left Lahore for India in 1947. In it she calls on the 18th-century poet of *Heer* to witness the suffering of Punjab. The poem is loved on both sides of the border, and Pritam remained popular in Pakistan all her life.
- **"Toba Tek Singh"** (1955), an Urdu short story by **Saadat Hasan Manto**. It follows patients in a mental hospital in Lahore who are to be divided between India and Pakistan a few years after Partition, and one man who cannot accept that his home village has been assigned to a country. Critics read it as a bitter satire of the whole process.
- ***Train to Pakistan*** (1956), an English novel by **Khushwant Singh**, set in a fictional village on the new border where Sikhs and Muslims had lived side by side, until trains full of the dead begin to arrive.

Notice the link the Story Web will show you: Amrita Pritam's 1947 poem talks directly to Waris Shah's 1766 *Heer*. A Partition poem reached back nearly two centuries to a shared Punjabi classic, to say that the land being split had one literature.

14.10 South Asian English Writing

South Asian English Writing is literature written in English by writers from South Asia and its diaspora, as well as works translated into English that reach readers worldwide. Some milestones:

- **1905:** Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain, a Muslim writer and reformer born in 1880 in Pairaband, Rangpur (now in Bangladesh), published "Sultana's Dream" in English in a Madras magazine. It imagines "Ladyland," where women run the country and scientists use solar power and flying cars. It is one of the earliest feminist science fiction stories anywhere. Bangladesh marks her birthday, 9 December, as Rokeya Day.
- **1930s onward:** R. K. Narayan (1906 to 2001) created Malgudi, a fictional South Indian town, in his first novel, *Swami and Friends*, and returned to it again and again. His stories focus on the everyday lives of ordinary people.
- **1981:** Salman Rushdie's *Midnight's Children*, about a boy born at the very moment of India's independence, won the Booker Prize.
- **2022:** Shehan Karunatilaka, from Sri Lanka, won the Booker Prize for *The Seven Moons of Maali Almeida*, a darkly comic story about a war photographer's ghost in Colombo in 1990, during the civil war.

Translation is also bringing more South Asian books to English readers. The International Booker Prize honors books translated into English. In 2022 *Tomb of Sand* by Geetanjali Shree, translated from Hindi by Daisy Rockwell, became the first book translated from an Indian language to win it. In 2025 *Heart Lamp*, Banu Mushtaq's short stories about Muslim women in southern India, translated from Kannada by Deepa Bhasthi, became the first Kannada book and the first story collection to win.

People still debate English's place. Some argue that writing in the colonizers' language cuts writers off from the people they describe. Others answer that English is now a South Asian language too, and that, along with translation, it carries stories to readers who never learned Bangla, Urdu or Kannada.

Your languages count

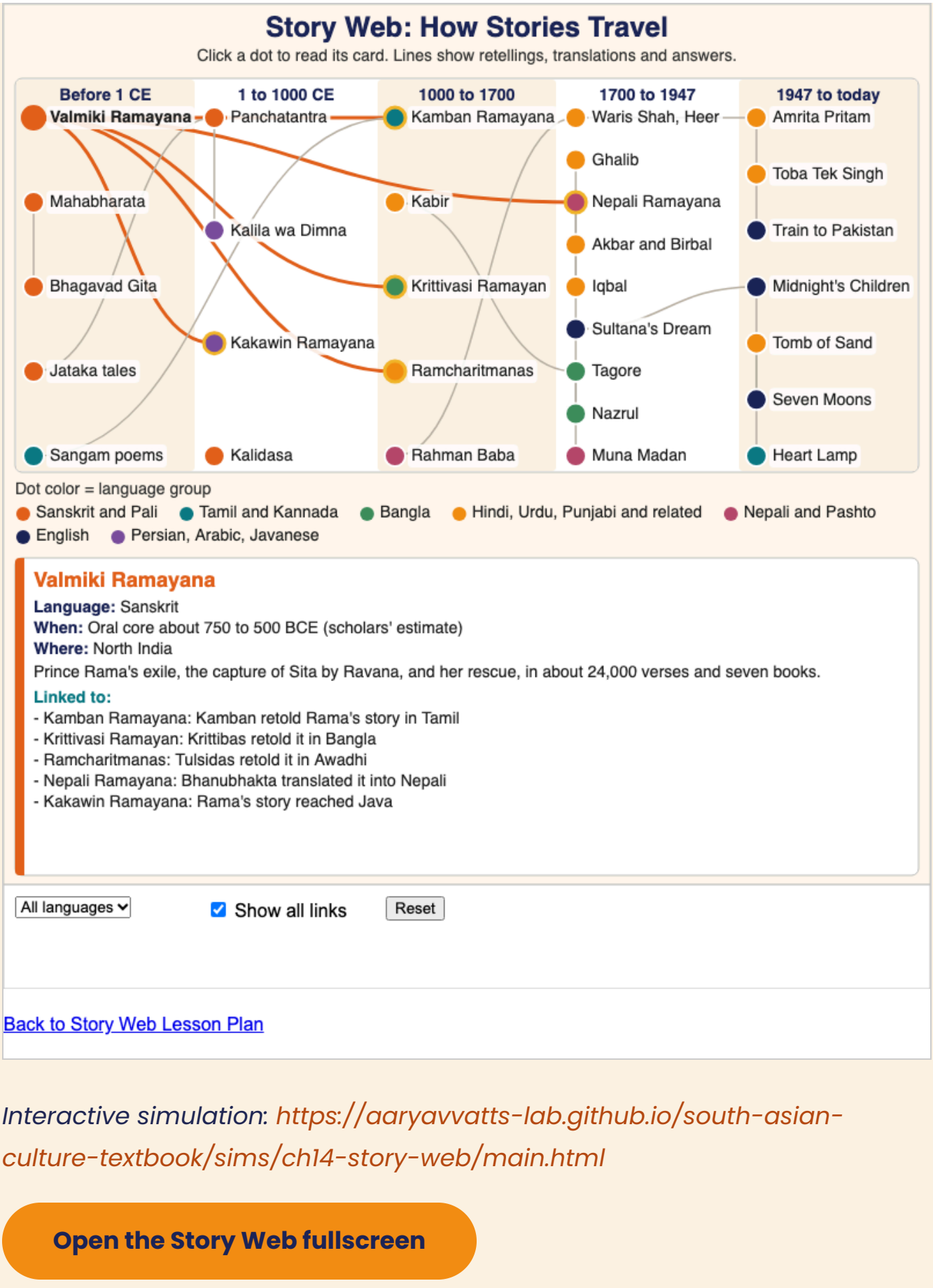
If you understand your family's language better than you speak it, like Zara does with Bangla, you already have a way into two literatures. Even reading one translated poem or story from your heritage language is a real start.

On the bus home, Zara thinks about her Nanu's golpo, Tagore's songs, Nazrul's rebel poem and Rokeya's Ladyland. They all belong to one Bengali literature, in Bangla and in English, on both sides of a border that didn't exist when most of them were written. She decides the South Asian Student Association needs a story night.

14.11 The Story Web

The Story Web puts thirty works and writers from this chapter on one timeline. Dots run left to right by era, colors show language groups, and lines connect works that retell, translate or answer each other.

Diagram: Story Web



Back to Story Web Lesson Plan

Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch14-story-web/main.html

Open the Story Web fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Story Web

sim-id: ch14-story-web
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Analyze
Bloom Verb: trace
Learning Objective: The learner will trace how a single story or form traveled across languages, faiths and borders by following links between works on a timeline.

Canvas: responsive width; 760 px drawing area plus 90 px control area.

Controls: language filter menu, "Show all links" checkbox, Reset button; click or tap any dot.

Behavior: Thirty works and writers are placed in five era columns (before 1 CE, 1 to 1000 CE, 1000 to 1700, 1700 to 1947, 1947 to today) and colored by seven language groups. Twenty links connect related works, such as the Valmiki Ramayana to its Tamil, Bangla, Awadhi, Nepali and Javanese tellings, the Panchatantra to *Kalila wa Dimna*, and Waris Shah to Amrita Pritam. Selecting a dot highlights its links and shows a card with language, date, place, a one-line summary and the reason for each link. The language filter fades works not written in the chosen language. The sim starts with the Valmiki Ramayana selected.

Start with the Valmiki Ramayana, which is already selected, and follow its orange links out to the Tamil, Bangla, Awadhi, Nepali and Javanese tellings. Read the card for each and notice how many centuries and how many languages one story crossed. Then click the Panchatantra and follow it into *Kalila wa Dimna*. Which link takes a story out of South Asia entirely?

Next, use the language menu to pick "Persian," then "English," and see which eras light up. Find a link that crosses a modern border, such as Waris Shah to

Amrita Pritam. Two dots, Kalidasa and Akbar and Birbal, have no links yet. What link would you draw?

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about the stories, poems and books they grew up with: bedtime stories, a poet or song they love, and books they read in school. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Ask if you can record or take notes. If they mention a poem or song, write down its title and the poet's name rather than trying to copy the whole thing, and look it up together afterward.

Questions to ask

1. What stories did someone tell you at bedtime or when you were small? Who told them?
2. Do you remember a story with talking animals, a clever trickster, or a hero from an epic? How did it go when you heard it?
3. Is there a poet or a song you love? What is its title, and when do you think of it?
4. What books or poems did you study in school back home? Which one stuck with you?
5. Have you heard the same story told differently by someone from another region, faith or country? How has the way you tell it changed since you

moved, or since you were young?

6. Which story would you most like me to remember and someday tell my own kids?

Listen for: signs of Oral Tradition (a story they only know from hearing it), tellings of the Ramayana or Mahabharata, animal fables like the Panchatantra or Jataka Tales, and names like Rabindranath Tagore, Kazi Nazrul Islam, Allama Iqbal or Mirza Ghalib.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare the bedtime story your elder told with a friend's. Did either story come from an epic or a fable collection in this chapter? Find one detail that changed between your two tellings and explain what it might tell you about the place, faith or family it came from.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: There is one true Ramayana, and other versions are copies or mistakes.
Reality: Valmiki's Sanskrit Ramayana is the oldest well-known telling, but the story has been retold for centuries in Tamil, Bangla, Awadhi, Nepali, Thai, Javanese, Malay and more, plus Buddhist and Jain tellings. Scholars such as A. K. Ramanujan call them "tellings" because each is a real performance of the story for its own audience.

Myth: South Asian literature is all religious.
Reality: Some of the most famous works are sacred texts, but the region also has Sangam love and war poems, Kalidasa's romantic plays, Ghalib's witty ghazals and letters, Akbar and Birbal comedies, Rokeya's feminist science fiction, Partition stories and modern novels about everyday life.

Myth: Urdu poetry is only about romantic love.
Reality: The ghazal began as love poetry, but Mirza Ghalib used it for philosophy, doubt and loss, and Allama Iqbal wrote Urdu and Persian poems about selfhood, faith and politics. Urdu literature also includes Manto's sharp Partition stories.

Myth: Writing in English isn't "real" South Asian literature.
Reality: South Asians have written in English for more than a century, from Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain's "Sultana's Dream" (1905) to Booker Prize winners from India and Sri Lanka. Translation into English, such as the International Booker winners of 2022 and 2025, also carries Hindi and Kannada stories to readers worldwide.

Check Yourself

1. What is oral tradition, and why does it lead to many versions of the same story?

Oral tradition is passing stories and poems from person to person by speaking, singing and memorizing. Because each performer adapts the story for a new audience, details change from teller to teller and place to place.

2. How is the Bhagavad Gita related to the Mahabharata?

The Bhagavad Gita is a section of about 700 verses inside the Mahabharata's sixth book. It is the conversation between Krishna and Arjuna just before the great battle.

3. Name two places outside South Asia where the Panchatantra's stories traveled, and what the Arabic version is called.

The stories went to Persia (in a Middle Persian translation around 550 CE) and the Arab world, and from there to Europe. The Arabic version, translated by Ibn al-Muqaffa around 750 CE, is called *Kalila wa Dimna*.

4. Which poet's words are used in the national anthems of both India and Bangladesh?

Rabindranath Tagore wrote both "Jana Gana Mana" (India) and "Amar Sonar Bangla" (Bangladesh). He also won the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1913.

5. What does Amrita Pritam's Partition poem have to do with an 18th-century poet?

Her 1947 Punjabi poem calls on Waris Shah, who wrote the famous *Heer* in 1766, to witness the suffering of Punjab during Partition. It links a Partition poem to a classic shared by Punjabis in both India and Pakistan.

Exercises

Remember

1. List three languages, other than Sanskrit, in which the Ramayana has been retold, and name the poet for each.

> **Answer**
>
> Any three of: Tamil (Kamban, 12th century), Bangla (Krittibas Ojha, about 15th century), Awadhi (Tulsidas, 16th century), Nepali (Bhanubhakta Acharya, 19th century).

2. Match each poet to the country that honors him as its national poet: Kazi Nazrul Islam, Allama Iqbal.

> **Answer**
>
> Kazi Nazrul Islam is the national poet of Bangladesh. Allama Iqbal is the national poet of Pakistan.

Understand

1. Explain the difference between akam and puram poems in Sangam Literature.

> **Answer**
>
> Akam ("inner") poems are about love and private feelings such as longing and separation. Puram ("outer") poems are about public life, such as kings, war, generosity and fame.

2. Explain why A. K. Ramanujan preferred the word "tellings" to "versions."

Answer

"Version" suggests there is one original and everything else is a copy. "Telling" treats each Ramayana as a real performance of the story in its own language and setting, with Valmiki's as one telling among many.

Apply

1. Use the Story Web to find every work in the 1700 to 1947 column that is written in Bangla. For each one, write the link the sim shows and the reason for it. *Hint: use the language menu, then click each lit dot.*
2. Your little cousin asks why Birbal is in stories with Emperor Akbar if "they're just cartoons." Using facts from 14.5, write a three-sentence answer that separates the real Birbal from the folk tales. *Hint: think about dates, and when the stories spread.*

Analyze

1. Compare the journey of the Ramayana with the journey of the Panchatantra. How are the routes different, and what does each journey tell you about how stories travel (through faith, trade, translation or performance)? *Hint: one moved mainly east and the other mainly west.*
2. Tagore, Nazrul and Iqbal were all born in British India, but today they are honored by different countries. Analyze how the borders drawn in 1947 and 1971 changed the way each poet is remembered. *Hint: look at the "Countries that honor him" column in the table in 14.8.*

Evaluate

1. Some say students should read South Asian literature only in the original languages, not in translation. Evaluate this claim. What is gained and lost in translation? *Hint: think about Heart Lamp, Tomb of Sand and your own family's language.*
2. Delhi University removed A. K. Ramanujan's essay from a course in 2011 after objections. Was that a reasonable decision? Give arguments on at least two sides before stating your own view respectfully. *Hint: consider academic study and the feelings of people for whom the Ramayana is sacred.*

Create

1. Plan a 30-minute club "Story Night" with three short pieces from three different countries in this chapter, and write a one-sentence introduction for each. *Hint: retell or summarize; don't copy long passages.*
2. Write your own short fable (150 to 250 words) in the style of the Panchatantra or the Jatakas, with animal characters and a lesson for a teen today. Then write two sentences explaining which features of the tradition you used. *Hint: a frame story or a clear moral are good places to start.*

Key Takeaways

- Oral tradition carried South Asian stories for centuries, which is why a story like the Ramayana exists in many tellings. Ramlila and Baul songs keep oral performance alive today.
- The Ramayana and the Mahabharata are the two great Sanskrit epics, and the Bhagavad Gita is a 700-verse section of the Mahabharata. For many Hindus these are sacred texts.

- Animal fables traveled farther than almost any other stories: the Jatakas through Buddhist Asia, and the Panchatantra through Persia and the Arab world (as *Kalila wa Dimna*) to Europe.
- Tamil Sangam poems, Kalidasa's Sanskrit plays, Kabir's verses and Ghalib's Urdu ghazals show the range of classical and devotional poetry across languages and faiths.
- Tagore, Nazrul and Iqbal became national symbols of India, Bangladesh and Pakistan, yet each crossed borders: Tagore wrote two nations' anthems, and Iqbal's song is still sung in India.
- Partition literature by Pritam, Manto and Khushwant Singh focuses on ordinary people caught in 1947, while South Asian English writing and translation now carry the region's stories worldwide.

You followed the stories!

You can now trace a story from a Sanskrit epic to a Javanese palace, or from a Punjabi love tale to a Partition poem. Next, in Chapter 15, the stories jump onto the big screen and the cricket pitch, from Bollywood and Lollywood to the India-Pakistan rivalry.

Quiz: Stories and Literature

Test your understanding of Chapter 14. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

What is the Bhagavad Gita?

A. A separate epic that tells the story of Rama's exile

B. A collection of Buddhist animal fables in Pali

C. A section of about 700 verses inside the Mahabharata

D. A book of Urdu ghazals written in Mughal Delhi

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The Bhagavad Gita is a conversation between Krishna and Arjuna found in the sixth book of the Mahabharata. It is not a separate Rama story. That is the Ramayana.

Concept Tested: Bhagavad Gita **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

Which poet is honored as the national poet of Pakistan?

A. Allama Iqbal

B. Kazi Nazrul Islam

C. Rabindranath Tagore

D. Kabir

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Allama Iqbal (1877 to 1938), born in Sialkot, is Pakistan's national poet, and his birthday is a public holiday there. Kazi Nazrul Islam is the national poet of Bangladesh, a common mix-up because both wrote in the early 1900s.

Concept Tested: Allama Iqbal **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

What is the Arabic version of the Panchatantra called?

A. Ramakien

B. Shah Jo Risalo

C. Kakawin Ramayana

D. Kalila wa Dimna

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Ibn al-Muqaffa translated the fables into Arabic around 750 CE as *Kalila wa Dimna*, named after two jackals. The Ramakien and the Kakawin Ramayana are tellings of the Ramayana in Thailand and Java, not of the Panchatantra.

Concept Tested: Panchatantra **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Why do scholars say there are many "tellings" of the Ramayana rather than one original and many copies?

A. Because Valmiki's Sanskrit text was lost and no one knows what it said

B. Because the story lived for centuries in performance and was retold in many languages for different audiences

C. Because every telling was written by the same poet at different times in his life

D. Because the Ramayana was first written in English and later translated

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Through oral tradition and later retellings in Tamil, Bangla, Awadhi, Nepali, Thai, Javanese and more, each telling became a real performance of the story for its own audience. Valmiki's text survives, so A is wrong. It is one telling among many.

Concept Tested: Ramayana **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

What is the difference between akam and puram poems in Sangam Literature?

A. Akam poems are in Sanskrit; puram poems are in Tamil

B. Akam poems are religious hymns; puram poems are comic stories

C. Akam poems are about love and inner feelings; puram poems are about public life, such as war and kings

D. Akam poems were written down; puram poems were only spoken

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. "Akam" means inner and covers love, and "puram" means outer and covers public life. Both kinds are Tamil, so A is wrong.

Concept Tested: Sangam Literature **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 6

Which statement best describes the Akbar and Birbal Tales?

A. They are folk tales about a real courtier of Emperor Akbar, and most of them spread centuries after he lived

B. They are a Sanskrit epic composed before the Mughal Empire existed

C. They were written by Birbal himself as a record of his life at court

D. They are Buddhist stories about the Buddha's earlier lives

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Birbal (1528 to 1586) was a real member of Akbar's court, but most of the funny tales about him spread later, mainly in the 1800s. They are folk tales, not a record Birbal wrote.

Concept Tested: Akbar and Birbal Tales **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 7

At a club story night, a member reads a poem whose couplets each end with the same repeated phrase, and each couplet makes sense on its own. Which form is she most likely reading?

A. A Jataka tale

B. A ghazal

C. An epic

D. A frame story

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. A ghazal is built from separate two-line couplets that share a rhyme and a repeated ending phrase. Mirza Ghalib is its most famous Urdu master. An epic is a long continuous narrative, not a set of stand-alone couplets.

Concept Tested: Mirza Ghalib **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

Zara wants to add a South Asian work written in English to her club's reading list, from a writer born in what is now Bangladesh. Which work fits best?

A. "Bidrohi" by Kazi Nazrul Islam

B. "Toba Tek Singh" by Saadat Hasan Manto

C. *Gitanjali* in its original Bengali

D. "Sultana's Dream" by Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain, born in Rangpur in today's Bangladesh, published "Sultana's Dream" in English in 1905. "Bidrohi" is a Bangla poem and "Toba Tek Singh" is an Urdu story, so they don't meet the English requirement.

Concept Tested: South Asian English Writing **Bloom's Level:** Apply

---

Question 9

Amrita Pritam's 1947 Punjabi poem calls on Waris Shah, who wrote *Heer* in 1766. What does this link best show about Partition Literature?

A. That Partition writers mostly ignored older literature

B. That Punjabi literature only began after 1947

C. That writers used a classic shared on both sides of the new border to mourn the splitting of one land and culture

D. That Partition poems were mainly about romantic love, like *Heer*

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. By calling on the poet of a classic loved across Punjab, Pritam treated the divided land as having one shared literature and asked its old poet to witness the suffering. The poem is about Partition's suffering, not romance, so D is wrong.

Concept Tested: Partition Literature **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

---

Question 10

Tagore wrote India's and Bangladesh's anthems, and one of Iqbal's early Urdu songs is still sung in India. What does this pattern best suggest?

A. That only Indian poets are remembered outside their home countries

B. That poets' work can belong to several countries, because their lives began before the borders of 1947 and 1971 were drawn

C. That national poets are chosen at random

D. That poetry has little to do with national identity

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Tagore, Nazrul and Iqbal were all born in British India, so their work crosses today's borders even though each is honored as a national symbol. Iqbal is Pakistan's national poet yet his song is popular in India, which shows A is wrong.

Concept Tested: Rabindranath Tagore **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture

Summary

Movies, songs, TV dramas and sports are how many people around the world first meet South Asian culture, and how many South Asian families spend their evenings. This chapter shows that "Bollywood" is only one of many film industries, introduces the filmmaker Satyajit Ray and the cinemas of Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka and Bhutan, and explains playback singing, Pakistani dramas and Coke Studio. It follows South Asian pop as it goes global and asks how South Asians are shown in Western media. Then it teaches the basics of cricket and the India-Pakistan rivalry, plus field hockey, kabaddi and carrom.

Concepts Covered

1. Bollywood
2. Regional Cinemas
3. Satyajit Ray
4. Pakistani Cinema
5. Playback Singing
6. Pakistani Dramas
7. Coke Studio

8. Global South Asian Pop
9. Streaming Era
10. Representation in Media
11. Cricket
12. India-Pakistan Rivalry
13. Field Hockey
14. Kabaddi
15. Carrom

Prerequisites

- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts, because each film industry is built around a language.
- Chapter 9: Music, for film music (filmi) and the classical and folk traditions it borrows from.
- Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition, for the history behind cricket's arrival and the India-Pakistan rivalry.

Lights, Camera, Cricket!

Hi, I'm Mora! The movies your family watches on weekends, the songs at every wedding, and the cricket match that makes your uncle shout at the TV are culture too, and they're the culture your friends are most likely to ask you about. This chapter gives you the background to explain them, and to enjoy them more.

15.1 "So What's an Over?"

It's a Sunday morning, and the South Asian Student Association is having a watch party in Ms. Okafor's classroom. A cricket match is streaming on the projector, and two club members are already arguing. Ayesha Qureshi, whose family is from Lahore, Pakistan, says the best India-Pakistan match ever was the 2017 Champions Trophy final, when Pakistan beat India by 180 runs in London. Simran Kaur Gill, the club's treasurer, whose grandparents are from Ludhiana, India, insists it was the 2007 T20 World Cup final, which India won. They have clearly had this argument before.

Ben Lindqvist has been watching for twenty minutes. He plays hockey and understands periods, power plays and penalty boxes. But he has no idea what's happening on the screen. "Okay," he finally says. "What's an over? Why did everyone cheer when nothing happened? And why does your whole family, Zara, know the words to every song in that movie you made me watch?"

Zara Hossain laughs. Her Nanu watches Bangladeshi films, her dad follows cricket scores from Dhaka at 3 a.m., and her cousins in London send her Pakistani dramas and Coke Studio songs. She realizes Ben is asking a real question: how do movies, music and sports tie together a region of eight countries, and millions of people far from home?

15.2 Not Just Bollywood

Start with something Ben already knows. "Hollywood" means the big American film studios in Los Angeles. But nobody thinks Hollywood is the same as all film made in English, or all film made in North America. Britain, Canada and Australia have their own film industries, and so do Sweden and Norway, where Ben's family comes from.

South Asia works the same way, only with many more languages.

Bollywood is the popular name for the Hindi-language film industry based in Mumbai (formerly Bombay). The word blends "Bombay" and "Hollywood." Bollywood is the best known South Asian film industry outside the region, famous for big stars, long running times, and song-and-dance numbers. But Bollywood means Hindi films only. It is a common mistake to use "Bollywood" for all Indian films, or all South Asian films.

Indian film history starts before sound. Raja Harishchandra (1913), a silent film by Dadasaheb Phalke, is often considered the first full-length Indian feature film. Alam Ara (1931), directed by Ardeshir Irani, was India's first sound film, and it opened the way for songs to become a central part of Indian movies.

Regional Cinemas

Regional Cinemas are the film industries that make movies in South Asia's many other languages, each with its own stars, studios, history and fans. Many have their own nicknames, often built on the "-ollywood" pattern.

Industry	Language	Main center	One early landmark
Bollywood	Hindi	Mumbai, India	Raja Harishchandra (1913, silent); Alam Ara (1931, first Indian sound film)
Telugu cinema ("Tollywood")	Telugu	Hyderabad, India	Bhishma Pratigna (1921), generally called the first Telugu feature

Industry	Language	Main center	One early landmark
Tamil cinema ("Kollywood")	Tamil	Chennai, India	Kalidas (1931), the first sound film with Tamil in it
Kannada cinema ("Sandalwood")	Kannada	Bengaluru, India	Sati Sulochana (1934), the first Kannada talkie
Malayalam cinema ("Mollywood")	Malayalam	Kerala, India	Vigathakumaran (released 1930), the first Malayalam feature
Bengali cinema ("Tollywood")	Bengali	Tollygunge, Kolkata, India	Pather Panchali (1955) by Satyajit Ray
Bangladeshi cinema ("Dhallywood")	Bangla	Dhaka, Bangladesh	Mukh O Mukhosh (1956), first Bengali feature made in what is now Bangladesh
Pakistani cinema ("Lollywood")	Urdu and Punjabi	Lahore, and now Karachi, Pakistan	See Section 15.4
Nepali cinema	Nepali and other	Kathmandu, Nepal	Aama (1964), first film produced in

Industry	Language	Main center	One early landmark
	languages of Nepal		Nepal
Sri Lankan cinema	Sinhala and Tamil	Sri Lanka	Kadawunu Poronduwa (1947), first Sinhala-language film
Bhutanese cinema	Dzongkha	Thimphu, Bhutan	Gasa Lamai Singye (1989), first Bhutanese feature

Notice the two "Tollywoods." The Telugu industry and the Bengali industry in Kolkata (named for the Tollygunge studio neighborhood) both use the nickname, which is a good reminder that these labels are informal. The Tamil nickname "Kollywood" comes from Kodambakkam, a Chennai neighborhood full of film studios.

How big are the regional cinemas? In 2023, India's film certification board (the Central Board of Film Certification, CBFC) listed feature films in more than 25 languages. By our count of its 2023 list (which includes dubbed versions), Telugu, Tamil, Kannada and Malayalam films together outnumbered Hindi films by more than two to one. Bollywood gets the attention abroad, but it is only one part of Indian film.

Regional films also cross borders. Telugu director S. S. Rajamouli's RRR (2022) became a worldwide hit, and its song "Naatu Naatu," composed by M. M. Keeravaani with lyrics by Chandrabose, won the Academy Award for Best Original Song in 2023. That same year, the Indian documentary The Elephant Whisperers won the Oscar for Best Documentary Short Film.

Name it right

If a friend recommends a movie, ask which language it's in instead of calling it "a Bollywood movie." A Malayalam thriller and a Hindi musical are as different as a Swedish crime drama and a Hollywood blockbuster.

15.3 Satyajit Ray

Not all South Asian cinema is about stars and songs. **Satyajit Ray** (1921 to 1992) was a Bengali filmmaker from Kolkata who is widely considered one of the greatest directors in the history of cinema. He was also a writer, illustrator, magazine editor and composer.

Ray's first film, Pather Panchali ("Song of the Little Road," 1955), is based on a Bengali novel and follows a poor family in a village through the eyes of a young boy, Apu, and his older sister, Durga. Ray shot much of it outdoors with a small budget and mostly amateur actors, and the sitar player Ravi Shankar wrote the music. Production stopped again and again for lack of money; the West Bengal government finally helped fund it. Pather Panchali became the first part of the Apu Trilogy (1955 to 1959), which follows Apu into adulthood.

Ray's films are quiet, realistic and close to everyday life, and they have influenced filmmakers around the world. In 1992 the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences gave him an honorary Oscar for lifetime achievement. Ray was too ill to travel, so he accepted it by video from a hospital bed in Kolkata. He died a few weeks later, on 23 April 1992.

Ray belongs to a wider tradition of art and "parallel" cinema in South Asia: films that focus on real social problems and often skip the big song numbers. Sri Lanka's Lester James Peries is another example. His film Rekava (1956),

about village life and beliefs, is often described as the first Sinhala film shot entirely in Ceylon (as Sri Lanka was then called), and it was selected for the main competition at the 1957 Cannes Film Festival.

15.4 Pakistani Cinema and Pakistani Dramas

Pakistani Cinema

Pakistani Cinema is the film industry of Pakistan, making films mainly in Urdu and Punjabi, with Pashto films made in Peshawar. From independence in 1947 until the 2000s, its center was Lahore, and the industry there was nicknamed "Lollywood" (Lahore plus Hollywood). Lahore's studios struggled badly by around 2000, and many filmmakers moved to Karachi, which has since become a major center of new Pakistani film.

In the 2010s and 2020s, a new generation of Pakistani filmmakers drew attention at home and abroad:

- **The Legend of Maula Jatt** (2022), directed by Bilal Lashari, is a Punjabi-language action epic based on characters from a famous 1979 film, Maula Jatt.
- **Joyland** (2022), directed by Saim Sadiq, became the first Pakistani film in the official selection of the Cannes Film Festival, where it won the Jury Prize in the Un Certain Regard section.

Pakistani Dramas

Many South Asians would say Pakistan's biggest screen export is its TV, more than its films. **Pakistani Dramas** are Pakistani television serials, usually in Urdu, known for family stories, romance and social issues, and for running a set number of episodes instead of going on for years.

One famous example is **Humsafar** (2011 to 2012), a 23-episode drama on Hum TV based on a novel by Farhat Ishtiaq and starring Fawad Khan and Mahira Khan. In 2014 an Indian channel called Zindagi launched and began airing Pakistani dramas, including Humsafar, for Indian audiences, and promoted their short runs compared with India's very long serials. Today many families in the diaspora, like Zara's cousins in London, watch Pakistani dramas online.

Whose Story?

The same films and songs mean different things on different sides of a border. Many films made in Lahore and Bombay before 1947 belong to the shared history of both India and Pakistan, and stars, singers and writers crossed between the two industries in the early years. Before 1971, films made in Dhaka were part of Pakistani cinema; in Bangladesh today, that period is remembered as the start of Bangladeshi film. Politics has often decided who could watch what: after the 1965 war, for example, Pakistan banned Indian films in its cinemas, and political tensions have shaped what audiences on both sides could see ever since. Fans in the diaspora, watching on the same streaming services in Minnesota or London, often feel these borders less sharply than their grandparents did.

15.5 Playback Singing

In most song scenes in South Asian movies, the actor on screen isn't really singing. That surprises a lot of people who are new to these films.

Playback Singing is the practice of recording songs with professional singers, called playback singers, whose voices are then played back while actors lip-sync on camera. Playback singers don't appear in the scene, but in

South Asia many of them are as famous as the actors, sometimes more. Many Indian and Pakistani films include six or seven songs.

A few of the best known:

- **Lata Mangeshkar** (India) recorded songs in more than 36 Indian languages over a career of decades and received the Bharat Ratna, India's highest civilian honor, in 2001.
- **Asha Bhosle** (India), Lata Mangeshkar's sister, was recognized by Guinness World Records in 2011 as the most recorded artist in music history.
- **Noor Jehan** (Pakistan) was a singer and actress whose career began before Partition and continued for decades in Pakistan. She recorded songs in Urdu, Punjabi and Sindhi, and in 1951 became Pakistan's first female film director.
- **Runa Laila** (Bangladesh) began her career in Pakistani films in the late 1960s and became popular across Bangladesh, Pakistan and India.
- **Mohammed Rafi** (India) and **Ahmed Rushdi** (Pakistan) are often named as two of the most influential male playback singers.

Film songs, often called *filmi* (फ़िल्मी, *FIL-mee*, "of the films") music, have been South Asia's main pop music for most of the last century. They play at weddings, on buses, in shops and in cars, which is why Zara's family knows every word. (You'll find more on filmi music in Chapter 9.)

15.6 Coke Studio, Global Pop, Streaming and Representation

Coke Studio

Coke Studio is a TV and online music series in which established and new artists perform live studio recordings, often mixing folk, Sufi, classical, rock and pop. The idea started in Brazil, but **Coke Studio Pakistan**, launched in 2008 and first produced by Rohail Hyatt, a former member of the band Vital Signs, became the most famous version. It is the longest-running annual TV music show in Pakistan. Its songs, which often pair singers from different regions and generations, have drawn huge audiences online across South Asia and the diaspora.

Global South Asian Pop

Global South Asian Pop is South Asian music, film and entertainment that reaches audiences around the world, including people with no South Asian background. Some milestones:

Year	Milestone
2009	Slumdog Millionaire, a British film set in Mumbai, wins eight Oscars; A. R. Rahman wins two (Original Score, and Original Song for "Jai Ho" with lyricist Gulzar), and Resul Pookutty shares the award for Sound Mixing
2022	Pakistani American singer Arooj Aftab wins a Grammy for Best Global Music Performance for "Mohabbat," widely reported as the first Pakistani woman to win a Grammy
2022	Bhutan's Lunana: A Yak in the Classroom is nominated for the Oscar for Best International Feature Film
2023	"Naatu Naatu" from RRR wins the Oscar for Best Original Song

Year	Milestone
2023	Punjabi singer Diljit Dosanjh performs at the Coachella music festival in California, widely reported as the first Punjabi artist to do so

Bhangra beats, Punjabi pop and Bollywood dance have also become regular parts of college dance competitions and weddings across North America and the UK, performed by teams that include plenty of people like Ben.

The Streaming Era

Streaming Era describes the period, mainly since the late 2010s, when films and TV shows began reaching audiences through online services such as Netflix, Amazon Prime Video, Disney+ and YouTube instead of only through theaters and TV channels. For South Asian entertainment, streaming changed two things. First, a Malayalam thriller or a Pakistani drama can now be watched with subtitles anywhere in the world on the day it comes out. Second, streaming services began paying for new South Asian shows, so audiences abroad can find stories in many languages, not just Hindi.

For diaspora families, streaming has replaced the stacks of rented DVDs and videotapes that many parents remember. Zara's Nanu watches Bangladeshi films on her tablet, with Zara helping her find them.

Representation in Media

Representation in Media is about how a group of people is shown on screen and in the news: how often they appear, what roles they play, who writes their stories, and whether the portrayals are accurate or rely on stereotypes.

For decades, South Asians on American TV were rare and often stereotyped. A well-known example is Apu, the convenience-store owner on The Simpsons, voiced by a white actor, Hank Azaria. In 2017, comedian Hari Kondabolu made a documentary, *The Problem with Apu*, arguing that the character's accent and storylines reinforced stereotypes. In 2020, Azaria announced he would stop voicing Apu.

Since then, South Asian characters created by South Asian writers have become more common:

- **Never Have I Ever** (Netflix, 2020 to 2023), co-created by Mindy Kaling, followed Devi, a Tamil Indian American teen in California.
- **Ms. Marvel** (Disney+, 2022) made Kamala Khan, a Pakistani American teen in Jersey City, a Marvel superhero on screen.
- British Pakistani actor **Riz Ahmed** was nominated for the Oscar for Best Actor in 2021 for *Sound of Metal*.

Representation is not "solved." Many South Asian Americans point out that most roles still come from a few backgrounds, that some communities (such as Bangladeshi, Nepali or Sri Lankan Americans) rarely appear at all, and that stereotypes still show up.

Count it yourself

Pick the last five shows or movies you watched. How many South Asian characters were there, what languages did they speak, and who wrote them? A simple count like that is how media researchers start.

15.7 Cricket

The basics

Cricket is a bat-and-ball game played between two teams of eleven players on a large oval field. At its center is the **pitch**, a strip 22 yards (20.12 m) long with a set of three wooden stumps, called a wicket, at each end. One team bats while the other bowls and fields, and then they switch.

If you know baseball, a rough comparison helps. The **bowler** is like the pitcher, but runs up and bowls the ball with a straight arm, usually bouncing it off the pitch. The **batter** defends the wicket and tries to hit the ball. Unlike baseball, there's no foul territory: the batter can hit the ball in any direction, all the way around the field.

Scoring works like this:

- After hitting the ball, the two batters can **run** between the wickets. Each time they swap ends, they score **1 run**.
- If the ball reaches the **boundary** rope after bouncing, that's **4 runs**. If it crosses the boundary without bouncing, that's **6 runs**.
- A batter is **out** in several ways. For example, they're **bowled** if the ball hits the stumps, and **caught** if a fielder catches the hit before it bounces.

Now for Ben's first question. An **over** is a set of **6 legal balls** bowled by one bowler from one end of the pitch. After each over, the next over is bowled from the other end, and the rules say the same bowler cannot bowl two overs in a row. If a bowler sends down a **wide**, a ball too far from the batter to hit, the batting side gets **1 extra run** and the ball doesn't count toward the six, so it has to be bowled again. That's why everyone cheered when "nothing happened": a dot ball (no runs) under pressure, or a wide that gave away a free run, can be a big moment.

Three formats

Cricket comes in different lengths, which is why some matches take an evening and others take days.

Format	Overs per side	How long it takes
Test cricket	No limit (up to two innings each)	Up to five days
One Day International (ODI)	50 overs	About a day
Twenty20 (T20)	20 overs	About three to four hours

Cricket across South Asia

The British brought cricket to South Asia during colonial rule, and over the 20th century people across the region made it their own. Today it is a national passion in India, Pakistan, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh, and it has a growing following in Afghanistan and Nepal.

- **Bangladesh** became the tenth Test-playing nation on 26 June 2000, and played its first Test against India in Dhaka that November.
- **Afghanistan's** team grew up largely among refugees: many of its first players learned the game in camps in Pakistan in the 1980s and 1990s. Afghanistan became a full member of the International Cricket Council (ICC), with Test status, in 2017, and reached the semi-finals of the 2024 T20 World Cup.
- **Nepal** played its first One Day International, against the Netherlands, in August 2018.

South Asian teams have won many of cricket's biggest titles (as of October 2026):

Tournament	South Asian winners
Men's Cricket World Cup (ODI)	India (1983, 2011), Pakistan (1992), Sri Lanka (1996)
Men's T20 World Cup	India (2007, 2024, 2026), Pakistan (2009), Sri Lanka (2014)
Women's Cricket World Cup (ODI)	India (2025, its first title)

The 2024 Men's T20 World Cup was co-hosted by the United States and the West Indies, and the India-Pakistan match was played at a new stadium in Nassau County, New York. Many of cricket's fans in the US are South Asian Americans, and you might find a cricket league in your own city.

Try it out

You don't need a real pitch to learn cricket. A tennis ball, a flat piece of wood and a trash can for a wicket is how millions of kids in South Asia learned in streets and parking lots.

The India-Pakistan Rivalry

The **India-Pakistan Rivalry** is the competition between the national cricket teams of India and Pakistan, often called the most intense rivalry in the sport. The two teams first played Test matches in 1952, when Pakistan toured India. Politics has shaped the rivalry ever since. No cricket was played between

them from 1961 to 1978, a period that included the wars of 1965 and 1971. Cricket has also been used for diplomacy, with leaders and fans crossing the border for matches.

The last full tour with Test matches was Pakistan's tour of India in 2007. After the 2008 Mumbai attacks, bilateral cricket almost stopped: the only series since then was a short one-day and T20 series in India in 2012 to 2013, so the two teams now meet mostly at ICC tournaments and the Asia Cup.

When they do meet, huge audiences watch, and families in the diaspora, including Indian and Pakistani families who are friends and neighbors, often watch together. Ayesha and Simran's argument is part of the fun: each side has its favorite victories, like Pakistan's win in the 2017 Champions Trophy final and India's in the 2007 T20 World Cup final.

Cricket's history in South Asia also includes hard stories about caste and community. Palwankar Baloo (1876 to 1955), born into a Dalit family, was one of the best Indian bowlers of the early 1900s and toured England in 1911. Yet at some matches he was served tea outside the pavilion in a disposable cup while his teammates drank inside. Historians use his story to show how caste discrimination (see Chapter 13) reached even the cricket field.

15.8 Hockey, Kabaddi and Carrom

Cricket isn't the only sport people love in South Asia.

Field Hockey

Field Hockey is a team sport played on grass or artificial turf with curved sticks and a hard ball, eleven players a side. (Ben's ice hockey is a cousin.) For decades, India and Pakistan dominated Olympic field hockey. India's men's team won Olympic gold eight times (1928, 1932, 1936, 1948, 1952, 1956,

1964 and 1980), and Pakistan's men's team won gold three times (1960, 1968 and 1984). In the 1960 final in Rome, Pakistan beat India. After a long gap, India's men won bronze medals at the Tokyo 2020 and Paris 2024 Olympics.

Kabaddi

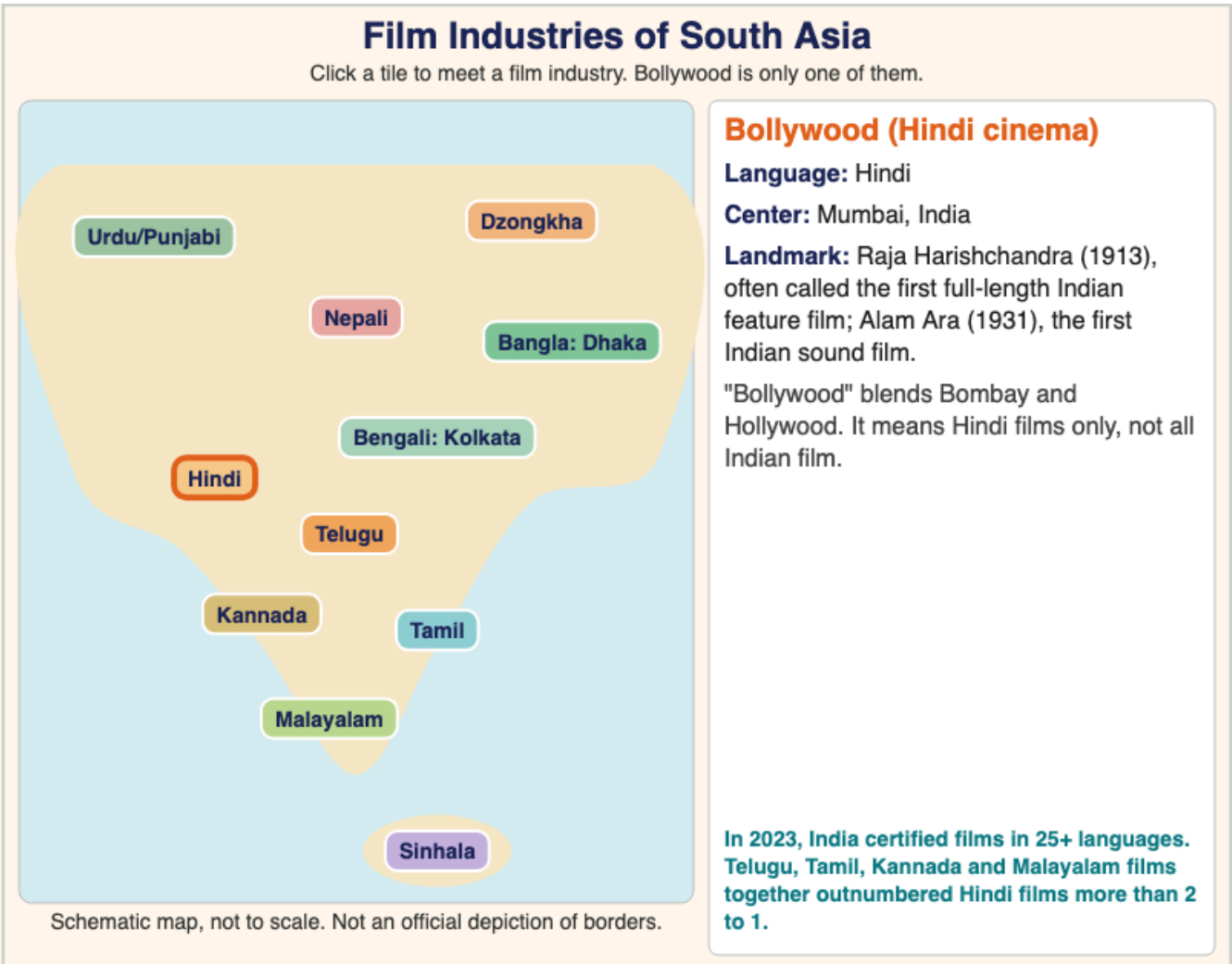
Kabaddi (Hindi कबड्डी, Bangla কাবাডি, *kuh-BUD-dee*) is a contact team sport, seven players a side, that combines tag and wrestling. One player, the **raider**, runs into the other team's half, tries to tag defenders, and must get back to their own side without being tackled, traditionally while chanting "kabaddi, kabaddi" in one breath. Kabaddi was named the national sport of Bangladesh in 1972. It became part of the Asian Games in 1990, and India's professional Pro Kabaddi League, launched in 2014, turned it into a TV sport with big crowds. A circle-style version, often called Punjabi kabaddi, is played on a round field and is popular in Punjab and the Punjabi diaspora.

Carrom

Carrom is a tabletop game of Indian origin in which players flick a heavy disc, the striker, to knock smaller wooden pieces into the four corner pockets of a square board. It's a bit like pool played with fingers. Carrom is played by families, at parties and in clubs and cafés across South Asia. Sri Lanka and India both formed carrom federations by 1958, and the International Carrom Federation was founded in Chennai in 1988. Many South Asian American families keep a carrom board in the basement, and it's an easy game to bring to a club meeting.

Sport	Players per side	Where it's especially popular	One fact
Cricket	11	India, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Afghanistan, Nepal	An over is 6 legal balls
Field hockey	11	India, Pakistan	India: 8 Olympic golds; Pakistan: 3
Kabaddi	7	Bangladesh, India, Punjab region	National sport of Bangladesh since 1972
Carrom	2 or 4 players	Homes and clubs across South Asia	International federation founded in Chennai, 1988

Diagram: Film Industries Map and Cricket Basics



Interactive simulation: *https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch15-film-industries/main.html*

Open the Film Industries Map fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Film Industries Map and Cricket Basics

sim-id: ch15-film-industries
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: explain
Learning Objective: The learner will explain that Bollywood is one of many language-based film industries in South Asia, and describe the basic structure of a cricket over (6 legal balls, with runs adding up).

Canvas: responsive width; 630 px drawing area plus 90 px control area.

Controls: "Film industries" and "Cricket: one over" tabs; Start/Pause and Reset buttons on the cricket tab; click or tap any film tile.

Behavior: The film tab shows eleven schematic tiles placed roughly where each industry is based, with no borders. Selecting a tile shows the language, center, a landmark film or figure with its year, and a short note. The caption "Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders." is drawn inside the drawing area. The cricket tab starts paused; Start animates one over: a single, a dot ball, a four, a wide (1 extra run, not counted), two runs, a wicket and a six, for 14 runs and 1 wicket from 6 legal balls.

Start on the film tab. Click every tile and keep a tally: how many different languages do you see, and how many countries? Notice that the Hindi tile, Bollywood, is just one of eleven. Find the two tiles for Bengali-language film, one in Kolkata and one in Dhaka, and think about why one language has two industries.

Then switch to the cricket tab and press **Start**. Watch the scoreboard: the "Legal balls" counter goes up by one for every ball except the wide, which adds a run but doesn't count. Pause after each ball and predict the score before it updates. When the over ends, you should be able to explain to Ben

exactly what an over is, and why the over had seven deliveries but only six balls.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about the movies, music, TV and sports they grew up with. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Ask them to pick one favorite song or film scene, and watch or listen to it together before you start your questions. Ask if it's okay to take notes.

Questions to ask

1. What was the first film you remember seeing in a theater? Who took you, and what was the theater like?
2. Who was your favorite actor or singer when you were my age? Why?
3. Do you have a cricket (or hockey, or kabaddi) memory you'll never forget? Where were you, and who were you with?
4. What TV shows or dramas did the whole family watch together?
5. How has the way you watch movies and sports changed, from theaters and TV to videotapes, DVDs and streaming, or after moving to a new country?
6. Is there a film, song or sport you hope I'll love the way you do?

Listen for: whether their favorite films came from Bollywood or one of the Regional Cinemas; names of Playback Singing stars; stories about Cricket or the India-Pakistan Rivalry; and how the Streaming Era changed their habits.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's favorite films and songs with a friend's elder from a different country or language group. Did they grow up with the same industry, or different ones? Did any song or star cross the border between them?

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Bollywood means all Indian films.
Reality: Bollywood is the Hindi-language industry in Mumbai. India also has large Telugu, Tamil, Kannada, Malayalam, Bengali, Marathi and other industries; in 2023 India certified films in more than 25 languages. Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka and Bhutan have their own cinemas too.

Myth: Cricket is only an Indian sport.
Reality: Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Afghanistan and Nepal all have national teams, and Pakistan and Sri Lanka have each won the men's World Cup. The game also has big followings in England, Australia, South Africa, New Zealand and the Caribbean, and is growing in the United States.

Myth: South Asian pop culture is only for South Asians.
Reality: "Naatu Naatu" won an Oscar, Arooj Aftab won a Grammy, and Diljit Dosanjh played Coachella. Plenty of fans with no South Asian background

love these films, songs and sports, and many dance teams and cricket clubs welcome everyone.

Myth: Representation of South Asians in Western media is now solved.
Reality: There are more South Asian characters and creators than twenty years ago, but many communities still rarely appear on screen, and stereotypes haven't disappeared.

Check Yourself

1. What does the word 'Bollywood' refer to?

The Hindi-language film industry based in Mumbai. The name blends "Bombay" and "Hollywood." It does not include India's other language industries.

2. What is an over in cricket?

A set of 6 legal balls bowled by one bowler from one end of the pitch. Wides and no-balls don't count toward the six.

3. What is playback singing?

Songs are recorded by professional singers, then played back while actors lip-sync on screen. Many playback singers are as famous as the stars.

4. Why did Satyajit Ray receive an honorary Oscar in 1992?

For his lifetime achievement in filmmaking. His realistic films, starting with Pather Panchali (1955), influenced directors around the world.

5. Which sport is the national sport of Bangladesh, and how does a raid work?

Kabaddi. A raider enters the other team's half, tries to tag defenders, and must return to their own side without being tackled.

Exercises

Remember

1. Name four film industries in South Asia other than Bollywood, with the language each uses.

Answer

Any four, such as Telugu (Hyderabad), Tamil (Chennai), Kannada (Bengaluru), Malayalam (Kerala), Bengali (Kolkata), Bangla (Dhaka, Bangladesh), Urdu and Punjabi (Lahore and Karachi, Pakistan), Nepali (Kathmandu), Sinhala and Tamil (Sri Lanka), Dzongkha (Bhutan).

2. Which South Asian countries have won the men's Cricket World Cup (ODI), and in which years?

Answer

India (1983 and 2011), Pakistan (1992) and Sri Lanka (1996).

Understand

1. Explain why there are two "Bengali" film industries.

Answer

Bengali (Bangla) is spoken in both the Indian state of West Bengal and in Bangladesh. Since 1947, and Bangladesh's independence in 1971, each side of the border has had its own film industry: one centered in Kolkata and one in Dhaka.

2. Explain why a wide in cricket gives the batting team a run but makes the over longer.

Answer

A wide is a ball the batter can't reach, so the batting side gets 1 extra run as a penalty, and because it isn't a legal ball it doesn't count toward the six balls of the over, so another ball must be bowled.

Apply

1. In one over, a bowler bowls: 4, dot, wide, 1, 6, dot, 2. How many runs were scored, how many legal balls were bowled, and is the over finished?

   Hint: count the wide as a run but not as a ball.

2. Plan a short "South Asian Movie Night" for your school club. Choose three films from three different countries or languages, and write one sentence for each explaining why you chose it.

   Hint: use the table in Section 15.2 and the Film Industries Map.

Analyze

1. Compare Bollywood with Pakistani dramas. What does each do best, and why might one be more popular than the other in a particular family?

   Hint: think about length, format, language and how people watch.

2. Cricket arrived in South Asia with British colonial rule, yet it is now a source of national pride in India, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh and Afghanistan. What might explain this change?

   Hint: think about winning, shared viewing, and stories like Palwankar Baloo's.

Evaluate

1. Is it fair to judge the progress of South Asian representation in Western media by awards like Oscars and Grammys? Make a case for one side, using at least two examples from the chapter.

   Hint: consider who wins awards and who is still missing from the screen.

2. Some people say sports rivalries like India vs Pakistan make political tensions worse; others say they bring people together. Which view does the evidence in this chapter support better, and why?

   Hint: consider the 1961 to 1978 gap, cricket diplomacy and diaspora watch parties.

Create

1. Design a poster for a cricket or kabaddi demonstration at your school, aimed at students who have never played. Include the basic rules in five bullet points or fewer.

   Hint: test your bullet points on a friend like Ben.

2. Write a pitch (one paragraph) for a TV show about a South Asian American teen that avoids the stereotypes discussed in Section 15.6. Who is the main character, what's their family like, and what language(s) do they speak?

   Hint: give the character a specific region, language and faith.

Key Takeaways

- **Bollywood** is the Hindi film industry in Mumbai; South Asia's **regional cinemas** in Telugu, Tamil, Kannada, Malayalam, Bengali and other languages, plus the cinemas of Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka and Bhutan, are just as much a part of the story.
- **Satyajit Ray** showed the world a realistic, quiet kind of South Asian film and received an honorary Oscar in 1992.
- **Pakistani cinema** moved from Lahore toward Karachi, and **Pakistani dramas** and **Coke Studio** became some of Pakistan's most loved cultural exports.
- **Playback singing** made singers like Lata Mangeshkar, Noor Jehan and Runa Laila stars across borders.
- **Global South Asian pop**, the **streaming era** and new South Asian creators have changed **representation in media**, but the work isn't finished.
- **Cricket** is built on overs of 6 legal balls, comes in Test, ODI and T20 formats, and is shared across the region; the **India–Pakistan rivalry** is shaped by history and politics as well as sport.
- **Field hockey**, **kabaddi** and **carrom** are also part of South Asia's sporting life. Hockey brought India and Pakistan Olympic golds, and carrom is played in homes across the region.

That's a wrap!

You can now explain an over, name a dozen film industries, and settle (or start) a debate at the next watch party. Next, in Chapter 16, we'll trade the cricket field for the classroom and look at the numbers and ideas that came from South Asia.

Quiz: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture

Test your understanding of Chapter 15. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

What does "Bollywood" refer to?

A. All films made in India

B. All films made in South Asia

C. The Hindi-language film industry based in Mumbai

D. The Bengali film industry in Kolkata

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Bollywood, a blend of "Bombay" and "Hollywood," is the Hindi-language industry in Mumbai. Using it for all Indian films (option A) is the most common mistake, since India also has big Telugu, Tamil, Kannada, Malayalam, Bengali and other industries.

Concept Tested: Bollywood **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

In cricket, how many legal balls make up one over?

A. 6

B. 4

C. 10

D. 20

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. An over is 6 legal balls bowled by one bowler from one end. Twenty (option D) is the number of overs per side in a T20 match, not the number of balls in an over.

Concept Tested: Cricket **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

Which Pakistani TV and online music series, launched in 2008, pairs artists from different regions and styles in live studio recordings?

A. Humsafar

B. Zindagi

C. Joyland

D. Coke Studio

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Coke Studio Pakistan launched in 2008 and became the longest-running annual TV music show in Pakistan. Humsafar is a Pakistani drama, not a music show.

Concept Tested: Coke Studio **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Which statement best describes playback singing?

A. Actors record their own songs live on set without music.

B. Professional singers record songs that are played back while actors lip-sync on screen.

C. Old songs are replayed at the end of a film's credits.

D. Singers appear on screen next to the actors during song scenes.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Playback singers record the songs, and actors lip-sync to them; the singers usually don't appear on screen. Many, like Lata Mangeshkar and Noor Jehan, became as famous as the stars.

Concept Tested: Playback Singing **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 5

Why are there two separate film industries working in the Bengali (Bangla) language?

A. Bengali is spoken in both West Bengal, India, and Bangladesh, which became separate countries' film centers in Kolkata and Dhaka.

B. One industry makes silent films and the other makes sound films.

C. One industry makes films for children and the other for adults.

D. The Dhaka industry only makes films in English.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The language is shared across the border, so Kolkata (India) and Dhaka (Bangladesh) each developed their own industry. Mukh O Mukhosh (1956) was the first Bengali feature made in what is now Bangladesh.

Concept Tested: Regional Cinemas **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 6

What is a key reason the India-Pakistan cricket rivalry is so intense?

A. The two teams play each other every week.

B. It is the only international cricket either team plays.

C. Politics and shared history shape it, and the teams now meet mostly at major tournaments.

D. Only fans in the diaspora watch it.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The rivalry has been shaped by history and politics, including no matches from 1961 to 1978 and no bilateral series since a short one in 2012 to 2013, so rare tournament meetings carry huge weight. Option A is wrong: they meet rarely, which is part of what makes each match special.

Concept Tested: India-Pakistan Rivalry **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 7

In one over, a bowler bowls: 1, dot, 4, wide, 2, wicket, 6. How many runs did the batting team score, and how many legal balls were bowled?

A. 13 runs, 7 legal balls

B. 14 runs, 6 legal balls

C. 13 runs, 6 legal balls

D. 14 runs, 7 legal balls

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The runs are 1 + 0 + 4 + 1 (the wide) + 2 + 0 + 6 = 14, and the wide does not count as a legal ball, so there are 6 legal balls. Option D counts the wide as a legal ball, which is the most common error.

Concept Tested: Cricket **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

Ben wants to watch a South Asian film that is not from Bollywood, made outside India, and nominated for an Oscar. Using the chapter, which film fits best?

A. Alam Ara (1931)

B. RRR (2022)

C. Pather Panchali (1955)

D. Lunana: A Yak in the Classroom (2019)

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Lunana is a Bhutanese film in Dzongkha that was nominated for Best International Feature Film at the 2022 Oscars. RRR (option B) won an Oscar for its song, but it is an Indian Telugu film, so it doesn't meet the "outside India" condition.

Concept Tested: Global South Asian Pop **Bloom's Level:** Apply

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Question 9

Hank Azaria stopped voicing Apu on The Simpsons in 2020, and shows like Never Have I Ever and Ms. Marvel were created with South Asian writers. What does this comparison suggest about representation in media?

A. Representation is now fully solved.

B. South Asian characters no longer appear on American TV.

C. Only awards matter for measuring representation.

D. Who creates and voices a character has become an important part of how South Asians are shown.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The shift from a stereotyped character voiced by a white actor to characters created by South Asian writers shows that who tells the story matters. Option A goes too far, since many communities still rarely appear on screen.

Concept Tested: Representation in Media **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

---

Question 10

Compare cricket and field hockey in South Asia. Which statement is best supported by the chapter?

A. India and Pakistan dominated Olympic field hockey for decades, while cricket's biggest titles have been won by India, Pakistan and Sri Lanka.

B. Field hockey is more popular than cricket in every South Asian country.

C. Neither India nor Pakistan has ever won an Olympic hockey gold.

D. Only India has won cricket World Cups among South Asian countries.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. India won eight Olympic hockey golds and Pakistan three, while India, Pakistan and Sri Lanka have all won the men's Cricket World Cup. Option D ignores Pakistan's 1992 and Sri Lanka's 1996 titles.

Concept Tested: Field Hockey **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas

Summary

The digits you write every day, 0 through 9, have a long history that runs through South Asia. This chapter follows that history from Brahmi numerals carved on stone, to the place value system and the zero, to the scholars who carried "Indian reckoning" to Baghdad and on to Europe. It also meets mathematicians such as Aryabhata, Brahmagupta and the Kerala School, the grammarian Panini, healing traditions like Ayurveda and Unani, the board game chaturanga, wootz steel, and modern scientists from India, Pakistan and Bangladesh. Along the way, it shows how historians test big claims and sometimes change their minds.

Concepts Covered

1. Brahmi Numerals
2. Place Value System
3. Zero
4. Aryabhata
5. Brahmagupta
6. Hindu-Arabic Numerals
7. Al-Biruni
8. Kerala School
9. Panini's Grammar

10. Ayurveda
11. Sushruta Samhita
12. Unani Medicine
13. Yoga
14. Chaturanga
15. Wootz Steel
16. Srinivasa Ramanujan
17. C. V. Raman

Prerequisites

- Chapter 2: Ancient Roots, for the Gupta period and the early kingdoms.
- Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters, for trade routes and the arrival of new rulers and scholars.
- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts, for Brahmi and the scripts that grew from it.

Numbers have a family tree too

Hi, it's Mora! Every time you type a phone number, check a game score or scroll a price tag, you're using an idea that people in South Asia helped build more than a thousand years ago. Knowing that story can make you proud without needing to exaggerate it, and it helps you answer when someone says the region "never invented anything." Every tradition has a story. Let's find it!

16.1 "Why Are They Called Hindu-Arabic?"

It's a Wednesday in October, and Ben Lindqvist walks out of geometry class at Prairie Ridge High School looking puzzled. He catches up with Zara Hossain at her locker.

"Okay, weird question," he says. "Mr. Dahl just said our numbers aren't 'Arabic numerals.' He called them 'Hindu-Arabic numerals.' He said they started in India. Is that true? Did your family know that?"

Zara thinks about it. Her Nanu does sums in her head faster than anyone Zara knows, and she counts in Bangla under her breath when she's measuring rice. But Zara has never once wondered where the digits themselves came from. "I honestly don't know," she admits. "I didn't even know numbers *had* a place they came from."

They decide to make it the first "ideas" topic for their club, and they write the question on the whiteboard: how did a way of writing numbers from South Asia end up in every math class on Earth, and what else did people in the region figure out along the way?

16.2 Start With an Odometer

Before any history, try a thought experiment.

Picture the mileage counter in an old car, the kind with rolling number wheels. When the ones wheel passes 9, it rolls back to 0 and nudges the tens wheel up by one. When the tens wheel passes 9, it nudges the hundreds. Every wheel uses the same ten symbols, but each wheel is worth ten times as much as the wheel to its right.

That is the whole trick behind the way you write numbers today. In 507, the 5 means five hundreds, the 0 means "no tens," and the 7 means seven ones.

Notice the 0. Without it, 507 and 57 would look alike. The zero is holding an empty seat so the other digits stay in the right places.

Now compare that with Roman numerals, which you've seen on clocks and in movie credits. In Roman numerals, 507 is DVII: D (500) plus V (5) plus I plus I. The letters keep their value wherever they sit, and there is no symbol for "nothing in this place." That makes Roman numerals fine for labels like "Super Bowl LX," but slow for multiplying or dividing large numbers on paper.

Idea	Roman numerals	Our digits today
Number of symbols	7 letters (I, V, X, L, C, D, M)	10 digits (0–9)
Does position change value?	Mostly no	Yes, each place is worth 10 times the next
Symbol for an empty place	None	0
2026 written out	MMXXVI	2026
Easy to do long multiplication?	Hard	Much easier

Keep the odometer in mind. The story of this chapter is how people in South Asia, building on ideas from many places, put those wheels together.

16.3 Brahmi Numerals: The Oldest Branch

Brahmi Numerals are the number signs written with the Brahmi script, the ancestor of most South Asian scripts that you met in Chapter 6. They appear on inscriptions from the 3rd century BCE. One of the earliest examples is the number 256 written in an edict of the emperor Ashoka at Sasaram, in today's Bihar, from about 250 BCE.

Brahmi numerals were not yet a place value system. They had separate signs for 1 through 9, and then extra signs for 10, 20, 30 and so on, and for 100 and 1,000. To write 256, a scribe would use the sign for 200, then the sign for 50, then the sign for 6. There was no zero, because no empty place ever needed filling.

Even so, our digits grew out of them. Historians of mathematics trace the shapes of our modern digits, through many small changes over many centuries, back to Brahmi. The first three signs seem to have started as simple strokes, one, two and three lines, which is easy to imagine if you've ever kept score with tally marks.

Some descendants of Brahmi numerals are still used today. Look at the same ten digits in four South Asian writing systems:

Value	Our digits	Devanagari (Hindi, Marathi, Nepali)	Bengali-Assamese (Bangla)	Tamil	Urdu (Eastern Arabic style)
zero	0	०	০	௦	۰
one	1	१	১	௧	۱
two	2	२	২	௨	۲

Value	Our digits	Devanagari (Hindi, Marathi, Nepali)	Bengali-Assamese (Bangla)	Tamil	Urdu (Eastern Arabic style)
five	5	५	৫	௫	۵
nine	9	९	৯	௯	۹

Zara's Nanu can read the Bangla digits at a glance, because they still appear in newspapers and on calendars in Bangladesh. Urdu newspapers and shop signs in Pakistan often use the Eastern Arabic style of digits, which, as you'll see in Section 16.6, came back to the region after a long journey through the Arab and Persian world. Tamil is a special case: traditional Tamil numbering had its own signs for ten (௰), one hundred (௱) and one thousand (௲), and in everyday life today most Tamil speakers use the digits 0 to 9.

16.4 Place Value and the Zero

The place value system

A **Place Value System** is a way of writing numbers in which a digit's value depends on its position, with each position worth a fixed multiple of the one beside it. Ours is base ten, so each place is worth ten times the place to its right:

$$507 = 5 \times 100 + 0 \times 10 + 7 \times 1$$

People in several parts of the world came up with place value. The Babylonians of ancient Iraq used a base-60 system (which is why an hour

has 60 minutes). The Maya of Central America used a base-20 system. The South Asian version was base ten, used just nine signs plus a zero, and turned out to be the one that spread around the world.

By around 600 CE, Indian scribes were writing dates and other numbers in place value form. The oldest dated Indian document that uses place value numbers is a donation charter from 594 CE, though some historians think its date was added later by a forger.

Zero as a placeholder and as a number

Zero is both a symbol that marks an empty place in a number and a number in its own right, the number you get when you subtract any number from itself. Those are two different ideas, and they didn't arrive at the same time.

The first idea, an empty-place marker, appeared in more than one civilization. Babylonian scribes started inserting a special mark for an empty place by about 400 BCE. Greek astronomers, including Ptolemy around 130 CE, used a small circle as a placeholder in their tables. The Maya had a zero sign by 665 CE, completely on their own. In South Asia, early manuscripts marked an empty place with a dot.

In Sanskrit and Hindi, the word for zero is शून्य (*SHOON-yuh*), which also means "empty" or "void." In Bangla it is শূন্য (*SHOON-no*). The idea of "emptiness" was also important in Buddhist philosophy, and some historians think that way of thinking made it natural to treat "nothing" as something you could name and work with. That's a reasonable suggestion, but it's hard to prove.

The second idea, zero as a number you can add, subtract and multiply, is where South Asian mathematicians made a clear first. You'll meet the person who wrote the rules down in Section 16.5.

The oldest securely dated zero in an Indian inscription that every historian accepts is carved in a small temple at Gwalior, in today's Madhya Pradesh, from 876 CE. It appears in ordinary numbers written into the inscription. By then, zero was already so normal that nobody bothered to explain it.

The Bakhshali manuscript: a lesson in how history works

In 1881, a farmer digging in a field at the village of Bakhshali, near Peshawar in what is now Pakistan, found a bundle of birch-bark pages covered in mathematics. The Bakhshali manuscript is a set of 70 fragile leaves with rules and worked problems, and it uses a dot for zero many times. In 1902 it was given to the Bodleian Library at the University of Oxford, where it is still kept.

In 2017, the Bodleian announced that radiocarbon tests suggested some of its leaves dated from as early as the 3rd or 4th century CE. Newspapers around the world reported that the "oldest zero" had been found. But a group of historians of Indian mathematics, writing in the journal *History of Science in South Asia*, pushed back. They pointed out that the test results for different leaves were centuries apart, so the oldest leaf could not date the whole manuscript. The latest leaf, they argued, was a better guide to when the scribe actually wrote it. They also criticized announcing the result by press release before other experts could check it.

Then, in 2024, Oxford's radiocarbon lab published a new report on five leaves. It said the very early result for one leaf had been inaccurate, and all five leaves now dated to roughly the late 700s to the early 1000s CE. So the Bakhshali manuscript is still an important early mathematical text, but it is no longer counted as older than the Gwalior inscription.

Notice what happened. A big claim was made, experts questioned it, the lab tested again, and the answer changed. That is how good history and good science are supposed to work.

Two kinds of nothing

Here's a way to keep the two ideas straight. The 0 in 507 is a parking spot saved for "no tens," while the 0 in "5 minus 5 equals 0" is an actual answer you can do math with. Which one do you think is harder to invent, and why?

16.5 Aryabhata and Brahmagupta

Two names come up again and again when people talk about early South Asian mathematics.

Aryabhata

Aryabhata (476 to 550 CE) was a mathematician and astronomer who worked at Kusumapura, probably near Pataliputra (today's Patna, in Bihar), during the time of the Gupta kings. He wrote that he finished his book, the *Aryabhatiya*, in 499, when he was just 23 years old. It's a short book written in verse, so students could memorize it.

Some of what's in it:

- He gave a rule that works out to $\pi \approx \frac{62832}{20000} = 3.1416$, which is correct to four decimal places.
- He explained that the stars seem to wheel across the sky because the Earth itself rotates on its axis. Many later astronomers rejected that idea, but Aryabhata was right.
- He worked with place value, using the Sanskrit word *kha* ("space") for an empty position, and gave methods for square and cube roots.

India named its very first satellite *Aryabhata*, after the 5th-century astronomer. It was launched on 19 April 1975 on a Soviet rocket. You'll meet India's space agency in Chapter 17.

Brahmagupta

Brahmagupta (born 598 CE) was an astronomer and mathematician who wrote the *Brahmasphutasiddhanta* in 628 CE at Bhillamala (today Bhinmal, in Rajasthan). He later led the astronomical observatory at Ujjain.

Brahmagupta's book is the first known text to treat zero as a number with its own rules. He defined zero as what you get when you subtract a number from itself. He also wrote rules for negative numbers, which he called "debts," and positive numbers, which he called "fortunes." A few of his rules, in modern words:

- A fortune plus zero is a fortune. A debt minus zero is a debt.
- Zero times any number is zero.
- A debt times a debt is a fortune. (In other words, a negative times a negative is positive.)

He didn't get everything right. He said that zero divided by zero is zero, which mathematicians today say is undefined. Later Indian mathematicians, such as Mahavira and Bhaskara, also struggled with dividing by zero. That's nothing to be embarrassed about, since dividing by zero still confuses people today, and Brahmagupta was the first person we know of who even tried to write down the rules.

	Aryabhata	Brahmagupta
Dates	476 to 550 CE	born 598 CE

	Aryabhata	Brahmagupta
Where he worked	Kusumapura, near Patna	Bhillamala (Bhinmal), later Ujjain
Main book	*Aryabhatiya* (499)	*Brahmasphutasiddhanta* (628)
Best-known idea	Earth's rotation; $\pi \approx 3.1416$	First rules for zero and negative numbers

16.6 How the Numbers Traveled: Hindu-Arabic Numerals

Hindu-Arabic Numerals are the ten digits 0 through 9 and the place value system that goes with them, which began in South Asia and reached Europe through scholars writing in Arabic. Historians use the double name to give credit to both parts of the journey. (Here "Hindu" is an old word meaning "Indian," the way people used it at the time, not a statement about religion.)

This simplified timeline shows that journey.

When	Where	What happened
662 CE	Syria (on the Euphrates)	A Christian bishop, Severus Sebokht, praised the Indians' way of calculating with nine signs.
770s CE	Baghdad	An Indian scholar brought an astronomy book to the court of the caliph al-Mansur, and it was translated into Arabic. (Sources give

When	Where	What happened
		dates from 771 to 776.) Some historians think it was Brahmagupta's.
800s	Baghdad	The scholar al-Khwarizmi wrote a book on Indian reckoning. Its Latin title was *Algoritmi de numero Indorum*, and his name gave English the word **algorithm**.
mid-900s	Arab world	Al-Uqlidisi wrote the oldest surviving book on "Hindu arithmetic" for pen and paper.
976	Spain	A monk copied the digits into a manuscript, the first surviving example in Europe.
1202	Pisa, Italy	Fibonacci published *Liber abaci*, teaching the nine figures and zero, which he had learned as a boy in North Africa.
1600s	Europe	Zero and the new digits finally came into wide everyday use.

In Arabic, the zero was called صفر (*SIFR*), meaning "empty." That word passed into Latin and then into English as "cipher."

The digits changed shape as they moved. Scribes in Baghdad and Persia developed one set of forms, the Eastern Arabic digits that many Urdu, Persian and Dari writers still use. Scribes in North Africa and Spain developed another, which became the digits in this book. So when Ben's teacher said "Hindu-Arabic," he was describing a real relay race across three continents.

A math word with a passport

Next time your computer science teacher says "algorithm," remember it comes from al-Khwarizmi, a scholar in Baghdad who wrote about Indian numbers. That one word has passed through three regions over more than a thousand years.

16.7 Al-Biruni: A Scholar Who Asked Questions

Al-Biruni (973 to 1048) was a Muslim scholar born in Khwarazm in Central Asia, who wrote one of the most careful early books about South Asian science and society. After 1017 he went to Ghazni (in today's Afghanistan) after Mahmud of Ghazni conquered his home region, probably as a prisoner at first, and he spent the rest of his life connected to that court. He traveled into the Punjab and northern India with Mahmud's expeditions and measured the positions of towns there.

Al-Biruni is remembered for how he studied. He learned Sanskrit so he could read Indian texts in the original, and he translated several of them into Arabic. Around 1030 he finished a long book usually called *India*. It describes Indian religion, philosophy, social customs, writing, numbers, geography, astronomy and the calendar. He compared Indian ideas with Greek ones, pointed out where he thought each side was right or wrong, and tried to describe beliefs as their followers understood them.

He wrote it during a time of war, when Mahmud's armies were raiding Indian cities and temples. So al-Biruni is a complicated figure: a scholar who admired Indian learning, working for a ruler many people in India remember as a destroyer of temples, while some in Afghanistan and Pakistan remember him as a hero. Historians read his book both as a valuable record and as one outsider's view.

16.8 The Kerala School: Infinite Series

Jump forward to the 1300s and travel to the southwestern coast of India, to Kerala.

The **Kerala School** was a line of astronomers and mathematicians in Kerala, beginning in the 1300s, who discovered ways to write some important quantities as infinite series, sums that go on forever but get closer and closer to an exact value. Its founder was Madhava of Sangamagrama (about 1350 to 1425), who lived near Kochi (formerly Cochin). His own writings are lost, but students such as Nilakantha and Jyesthadeva recorded his methods. Jyesthadeva's book, the *Yuktibhasha* (about 1550), was written in Malayalam, the language of Kerala, rather than Sanskrit, and it explains the proofs.

One of Madhava's results is a series for π:

$$\frac{\pi}{4} = 1 - \frac{1}{3} + \frac{1}{5} - \frac{1}{7} + \frac{1}{9} - \cdots$$

Madhava also found series for sine, cosine and arctangent, the same ones you'll meet if you take calculus, and he used extra correction terms to calculate π to 11 decimal places.

European mathematicians found the same series independently more than two centuries later. The Scottish mathematician James Gregory rediscovered the arctangent series in the 1600s, and Isaac Newton found the sine and cosine series around 1676. (The π series above is often called the Madhava-Leibniz series, after Madhava and the German mathematician Gottfried Leibniz.)

Some writers claim the Kerala results traveled to Europe through missionaries and traders, but there is no solid evidence for that, so historians call the European results rediscoveries. It is fair to say that the Kerala School

found infinite series centuries before Europe. It is not accurate to say that Kerala "invented calculus," because calculus as a full system, with derivatives and integrals linked together, was built later.

16.9 Panini's Grammar

Not every big idea in this chapter is about numbers.

Panini's Grammar, the *Ashtadhyayi* ("eight chapters"), is a complete description of the Sanskrit language written as just under 4,000 short rules called *sutras*. Panini came from Shalatula, a town near Attock on the Indus River, in what is now Pakistan. Nobody knows exactly when he lived. Scholars have suggested dates from about the 7th to the 4th century BCE.

A grammar book belongs in a science chapter because of how it works. Panini's rules are written like a computer program. Short rules apply in a set order, some rules override others, and special marker sounds act like labels that tell you which rule to use. Feed the rules a root word and some endings, and they produce correct Sanskrit sentences.

In 1959, the computer scientist John Backus created a notation for describing programming languages, now called Backus-Naur Form. In 1967 the computer scientist Peter Ingerman suggested calling it "Panini-Backus Form," because Panini had used a notation just as powerful more than 2,000 years earlier. That's why Panini is often called a forerunner of the formal language theory used in computer science, and why linguists around the world still study him.

Whose Story?

Ask "Who invented zero?" and you'll hear different answers depending on who is speaking. Many popular books and speeches in India tell it as a proud national achievement, sometimes with dates pushed earlier than the evidence supports. In the Arab world the digits are often called "Indian numbers," while for centuries Europeans called the same digits "Arabic," because that's who they learned them from. Historians of mathematics such as the team behind the MacTutor archive tell a longer relay story: Babylonian placeholders, Greek astronomers, Indian place value and zero, Arabic-language scholars, then Europe. And the Bakhshali debate shows that even experts in Britain, the United States, France, Japan, New Zealand and Canada can disagree about the evidence until new tests settle it.

16.10 Healing Traditions

Not medical advice

This section describes healing traditions as history and culture. They are traditions, not proven treatments, and nothing here is medical advice. If you or someone in your family has a health problem, talk to a doctor or pharmacist, and tell them about any traditional remedies you use.

Many South Asian families keep healing traditions alive at home: turmeric in warm milk for a cold, ginger tea for an upset stomach, oil massages for babies, morning stretches. These habits connect to long written traditions. Here are four of the best known.

Ayurveda

Ayurveda (आयुर्वेद, *AA-yur-vay-duh*, "knowledge of life" or "science of health") is a traditional medical system from South Asia, based on old Sanskrit texts, that uses diet, herbs, daily routines, exercise and sometimes minerals to try to keep the body in balance. It is still widely practiced in India, Nepal and Sri Lanka, often alongside modern medicine, and India has a government ministry for traditional systems called AYUSH.

What does science say? The US National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health (NCCIH), part of the National Institutes of Health, reports (in its fact sheet last updated in January 2019) that only a few well-designed studies have tested Ayurvedic treatments, and that scientific evidence for most uses is limited. It also warns about safety: some Ayurvedic products sold online or abroad have been found to contain toxic levels of lead, mercury or arsenic, and the US Food and Drug Administration has warned about them. Many families value Ayurveda as part of their heritage, and that heritage is worth understanding. But it is not a substitute for medical care.

The Sushruta Samhita

The **Sushruta Samhita** is an old Sanskrit medical text, traditionally linked to a physician named Sushruta, that is famous for its detailed descriptions of surgery. Its 186 chapters describe surgical instruments, how to practice cutting on gourds and other objects before operating on people, and many operations. The most famous is a way to rebuild a damaged nose using a flap of skin from the cheek, a forerunner of what surgeons later called the "Indian method" of nose reconstruction.

When was it written? Traditional accounts place Sushruta very early, but the text we have was built up in layers over a long time. Many scholars think its composition began in the last centuries BCE and that the version we read today took shape by around the 3rd or 4th century CE. The oldest surviving manuscript is a palm-leaf copy kept at the Kaiser Library in Kathmandu,

Nepal, dated 878 CE. The book was later translated into Arabic in Baghdad, another example of ideas moving west.

Unani medicine

Unani Medicine (یونانی, *yoo-NAA-nee*, "Greek") is a healing tradition that began with the ancient Greek physicians Hippocrates and Galen, was developed by doctors writing in Arabic and Persian such as Ibn Sina (Avicenna), and came to South Asia by the 1100s. It grew under the Delhi Sultanate and the Mughal emperors, and its practitioners are often called *hakims*. Unani is based on the old Greek idea that health depends on balancing four "humors" in the body, an idea that came long before scientists discovered germs.

Today Unani is officially recognized in India, where it is part of the AYUSH system, and in Pakistan, where practitioners register with the National Council for Tibb (*tibb* is the Arabic and Urdu word for medicine). Like Ayurveda, it is a tradition with a long history, not a proven way to cure disease.

Yoga

Yoga (योग, *YOH-guh*, "joining" or "union") is a set of practices rooted in South Asian philosophy that combines body postures, breathing and meditation, and that began as a spiritual discipline aimed at training the mind. It is important in Hindu, Buddhist and Jain traditions. The poses many Americans learn at a gym are only one part of a much bigger tradition.

On 11 December 2014, the United Nations proclaimed 21 June the International Day of Yoga. The NCCIH says research suggests yoga may help with stress, sleep, balance and some kinds of pain, but it does not claim yoga cures any disease, and it notes that beginners should avoid extreme poses and practice with a qualified teacher.

Tradition	Where it comes from	Key idea	Status today
Ayurveda	Sanskrit texts of South Asia	Balance through diet, herbs, routine	Practiced widely; limited scientific evidence; some products unsafe
Sushruta Samhita	Sanskrit medical text	Surgery, instruments, nose repair	Studied as medical history
Unani	Greek medicine, developed in Arabic and Persian	Balance of four humors	Recognized in India and Pakistan; traditional, not proven
Yoga	South Asian philosophy	Posture, breath, meditation	Practiced worldwide; may help stress and some pain

16.11 Games and Metals: Chaturanga and Wootz Steel

Chaturanga

Chaturanga is an old board game from India, first clearly mentioned in the 6th or 7th century CE, that is the earliest known ancestor of chess. The name is Sanskrit for "four limbs," meaning the four parts of an old Indian army: elephants, chariots, cavalry (horses) and infantry (foot soldiers). It was played on an 8-by-8 board called the *ashtapada*. One of the earliest texts to

name it is the *Harshacharita*, a biography of King Harsha written around 625 CE.

From India the game traveled to Persia, where it became *chatrang* and then *shatranj*. Arabic-speaking players spread shatranj across the Middle East and North Africa, and it reached Europe in the Middle Ages. Over the centuries the pieces changed. The elephant became the bishop, the chariot (*rukh* in Persian) became the rook, and the counselor, a weak piece that moved one square, was renamed the queen in Europe and later became the strongest piece on the board. So the chess you play today began in India and was reshaped in Persia, the Arab world and Europe.

Wootz steel

Wootz Steel is a high-carbon steel made in South India and Sri Lanka by melting iron with carbon-rich material inside sealed clay pots called crucibles, and it was famous for centuries for its strength and its wavy surface pattern. The English word "wootz" is a garbled form of *ukku*, the word for steel in Kannada and Telugu. Archaeological finds in Tamil Nadu suggest crucible steel was being made there before the Common Era.

Traders carried wootz ingots west, and smiths in the Middle East forged them into the famous "Damascus" swords, which had very high carbon content, about 1.5 to 2.0 percent. In the early 1800s, European scientists, including Michael Faraday, studied wootz to learn how it was made.

Sri Lanka has its own steel story. At Samanalawewa, in Sri Lanka's hill country, archaeologist Gill Juleff found many ancient furnaces built along the western edges of hills and ridges. Her experiments, published in the journal *Nature* in 1996, showed that these furnaces used the strong monsoon winds to blow air through the fire and could make high-carbon steel. They supported a major industry there during the first millennium CE.

16.12 Modern Scientists of the Region

The story doesn't stop in the distant past. Here are four modern scientists, born or working in three of today's countries.

Srinivasa Ramanujan

Srinivasa Ramanujan (1887 to 1920) was a mathematician from Tamil Nadu, mostly self-taught, whose discoveries about numbers, infinite series and fractions still keep mathematicians busy today. He was born in Erode and grew up in Kumbakonam. In 1912 he took a job as a clerk at the Madras Port Trust in Madras (now Chennai), and he kept filling notebooks with formulas. In January 1913 he wrote to the Cambridge mathematician G. H. Hardy, who was amazed and invited him to England. Ramanujan arrived in 1914.

In 1918 he was elected a Fellow of the Royal Society, one of the highest honors in science, and a Fellow of Trinity College, Cambridge. But he was often ill in England. He was a strict vegetarian, and during World War I the foods he needed became hard to find. He returned to India and died in Kumbakonam in 1920, at just 32.

C. V. Raman

C. V. Raman (Chandrasekhara Venkata Raman, 1888 to 1970) was a physicist born in Tiruchirappalli, Tamil Nadu, who discovered that when light bounces off molecules, a tiny part of it comes back with a slightly different color. This is now called the Raman effect. He won the Nobel Prize in Physics in 1930 "for his work on the scattering of light and for the discovery of the effect named after him," while working at Calcutta University (now the University of Calcutta). Today, scientists around the world use Raman's discovery, in a method called Raman spectroscopy, to identify what materials are made of.

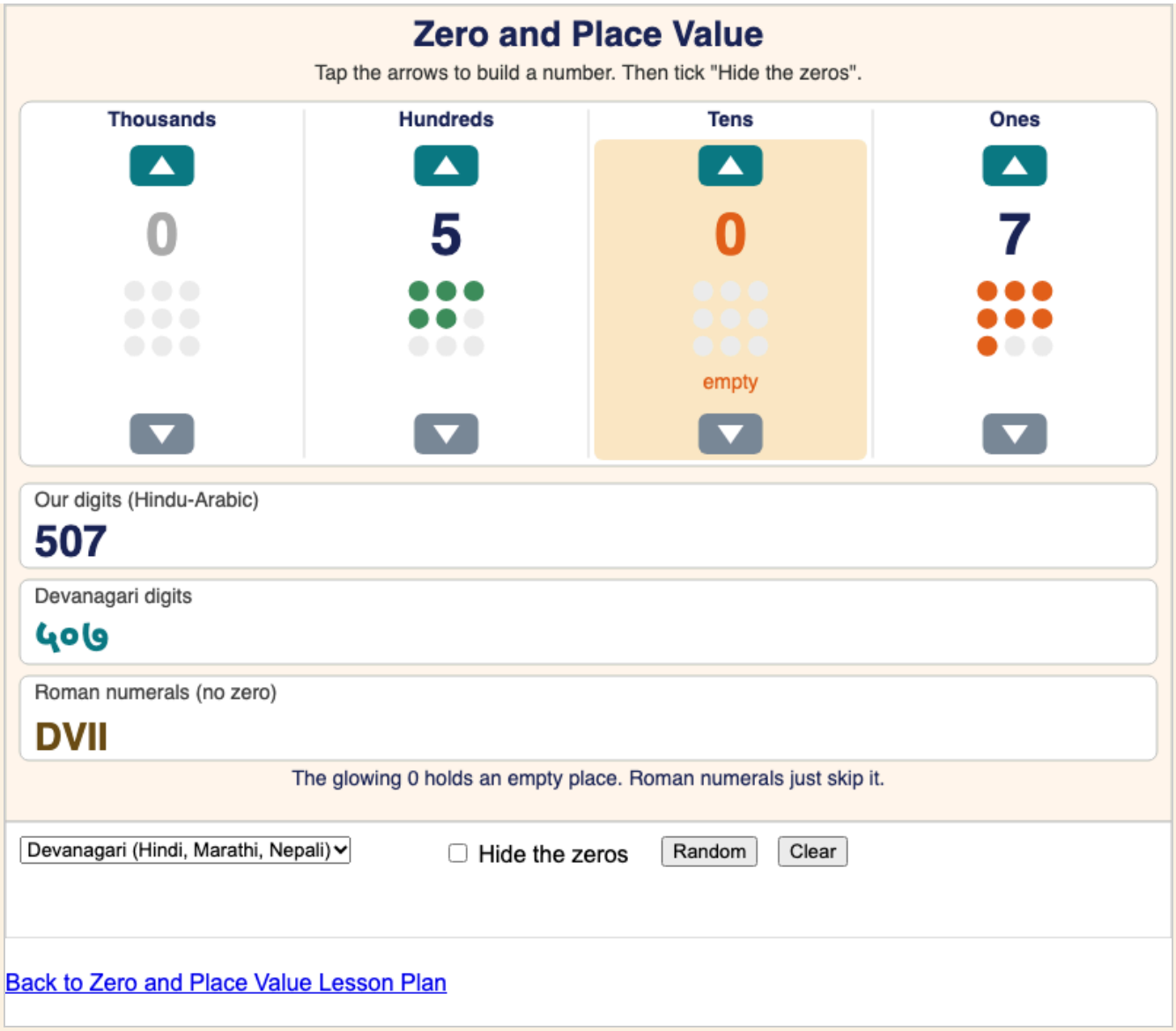
Satyendra Nath Bose and Abdus Salam

Two more names show how science in the region crosses today's borders.

- **Satyendra Nath Bose** (1894 to 1974) was a physicist born in Calcutta who taught at the University of Dhaka, in today's Bangladesh, from 1921. In 1924 he sent a short paper to Albert Einstein, who was so impressed that he translated it into German and had it published. Particles that follow Bose's rules are called **bosons** in his honor, including the famous Higgs boson.
- **Abdus Salam** (1926 to 1996) was born in Jhang, in the Punjab of British India, now in Pakistan. He shared the 1979 Nobel Prize in Physics for helping show that two of nature's basic forces, electromagnetism and the weak force, are two sides of one force.

Back at Prairie Ridge, Zara and Ben add a slide to their club presentation called "Not just ancient history." Ben wants to put Ramanujan first. Zara wants Bose, because Dhaka is her parents' capital city. They compromise and put them side by side.

Diagram: Zero and Place Value



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch16-zero-place-value/main.html

Open the Zero and Place Value MicroSim fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Zero and Place Value

sim-id: ch16-zero-place-value
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: explain
Learning Objective: The learner will explain why a symbol for zero makes a place value system work, by comparing the same number in Roman numerals, in a place value table and in a South Asian digit set.

Canvas: responsive width; 560 px drawing area plus 80 px control area.

Controls: up and down arrows in each column (thousands, hundreds, tens, ones), tapped or clicked on the canvas; a digit-set menu (Devanagari, Bengali, Tamil, Urdu); a "Hide the zeros" checkbox; Random and Clear buttons.

Behavior: The learner builds a number from 0 to 9,999. The sim shows it as a place value table with counters in each column, as Roman numerals (with a note that Roman numerals have no zero), and in the chosen South Asian digit set using real Unicode digits. Empty columns are highlighted with a glowing zero. Ticking "Hide the zeros" removes the zero symbols, so the digits slide together and the learner sees the number become a different, wrong number.

Start by building 507 with the arrows. Look at all three rows: the place value table, the Roman numeral DVII and the Devanagari 507. Then tick **Hide the zeros**. The digits squeeze together into "57," and the sim warns you the number now reads as a completely different value. That's exactly the problem a zero solves. Try it with 2,026, 1,000 and 9,009 too.

Then switch the digit set to Bengali, Tamil and Urdu and watch the same number change costume. Notice that the Roman numeral never needs a

zero, but it gets long and clumsy (try 3,888). Ask yourself: which of the three ways would you want to use for long multiplication?

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about how they learned math, the home remedies their family used, and a scientist or thinker from the region they admire. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Bring a pencil and paper and ask them to show you how they would add or multiply two numbers in their head. Ask if it's okay to take notes.

Questions to ask

1. How did you learn math in school? Did you memorize times tables, and in which language did you say them?
2. Do you know any mental math tricks, or ways of counting on your fingers, that you learned growing up?
3. When you were young, what did your family do for a cold, a cough or a stomachache? Who in the family knew the most about home remedies? (Remember, this is about family history, not medical advice.)
4. Did anyone in your family or town play chess, carrom or another board game? Who taught you?

5. How has the way children learn math or take care of their health changed since you were young, or since you moved?
6. Is there a scientist, mathematician or thinker from South Asia you're proud of? What do you hope I remember about them?

Listen for: whether they write or count in Devanagari, Bangla, Urdu or other digit sets (connect this to Brahmi Numerals and Hindu-Arabic Numerals), remedies that come from Ayurveda or Unani Medicine, and names like Srinivasa Ramanujan, C. V. Raman or Abdus Salam.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare the way your elder does mental math with the way you learned in school. Do they use place value in the same way, for example by breaking 47 × 6 into 40 × 6 and 7 × 6? If a friend interviewed someone from a different country, compare the remedies each family used and notice which ones overlap.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Indians invented all of mathematics.
Reality: South Asian mathematicians made major contributions, especially place value with zero, rules for zero and negative numbers, and early infinite series. But mathematics was built by many peoples, including Babylonians, Egyptians, Greeks, Chinese, Maya and scholars writing in Arabic and Persian. Overclaiming hides the real achievements.

Myth: Zero was invented by one person on one day.
Reality: Zero grew over centuries. Placeholder marks appeared in Babylon, Greece, the Maya world and South Asia. Brahmagupta, in 628 CE, was the first known writer to give rules for zero as a number, but he was building on earlier Indian place value and the dot used for an empty place.

Myth: Ayurveda is proven medicine that can cure diseases.
Reality: Ayurveda is a long-standing tradition that many families value. The US National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health says there are few well-designed studies of it, and some products have contained dangerous levels of lead, mercury or arsenic. It is not a substitute for medical care. This is not medical advice.

Myth: Chess was invented in India in its modern form.
Reality: Chaturanga, the ancestor of chess, comes from India. But the game changed a lot as it moved through Persia, the Arab world and Europe. The powerful queen, for example, is a much later European change.

Myth: "Arabic numerals" were invented by Arabs.
Reality: The digits and place value system began in South Asia. Scholars writing in Arabic, such as al-Khwarizmi and al-Uqlidisi, developed and spread them, and Europeans learned them from Arabic books, which is why historians say "Hindu-Arabic."

Check Yourself

1. What job does the zero do in the number 305?

It holds the empty tens place, so the 3 stays in the hundreds place. Without the zero the number would look like 35.

2. Why couldn't Brahmi numerals be called a place value system?

They used separate signs for tens, hundreds and thousands instead of reusing nine digits in different positions, and they had no zero.

3. What did Brahmagupta do in 628 CE that made him famous?

In the *Brahmasphutasiddhanta* he wrote the first known rules for zero as a number, along with rules for negative numbers ("debts") and positive numbers ("fortunes").

4. Why do historians say 'Hindu-Arabic numerals' instead of 'Arabic numerals'?

The digits and place value began in South Asia, and scholars writing in Arabic developed and spread them to Europe. The double name credits both parts of the journey.

5. What changed about the Bakhshali manuscript's date between 2017 and 2024?

In 2017, radiocarbon tests suggested some leaves were from the 3rd or 4th century CE. After other historians questioned this, a 2024 Oxford report said the early result was inaccurate and dated all five tested leaves to roughly the late 700s to early 1000s CE.

Exercises

Remember

1. Name the book Aryabhata finished in 499 and the book Brahmagupta wrote in 628.

> **Answer**
>
> Aryabhata wrote the *Aryabhatiya*. Brahmagupta wrote the *Brahmasphutasiddhanta*.

2. What are the four "limbs" in the name chaturanga?

> **Answer**
>
> Elephants, chariots, cavalry (horses) and infantry (foot soldiers), the four parts of an old Indian army.

Understand

1. Explain in your own words the difference between zero as a placeholder and zero as a number.

> **Answer**
>
> As a placeholder, zero marks an empty position, like the tens place in 507. As a number, zero is a quantity you can add, subtract and multiply, the answer to 5 minus 5.

2. Explain why the work of the Kerala School is described as a "rediscovery" in Europe rather than a source for European calculus.

Answer

Gregory, Leibniz and Newton found the same series in the late 1600s, but there is no solid evidence that Madhava's results reached them. So historians say Kerala came first, but the Europeans found the series independently.

Apply

1. Use the Zero and Place Value MicroSim to build 2,026, 3,888 and 1,000. For each, write the Roman numeral and the number of symbols it needs. Which number is the most work to write in Roman numerals, and why?

   Hint: count the letters, and think about which values have no single Roman letter.

2. Write your birth year in Devanagari, Bengali and Tamil digits using the table in Section 16.3 and the MicroSim. Then explain where the zero (if any) is doing its job.

   Hint: the sim's digit menu shows all four digit sets.

Analyze

1. Compare how Aryabhata, al-Biruni and Fibonacci each helped the numbers you use reach your classroom. What role did each one play: inventor, explainer or carrier?

   Hint: use Sections 16.5 to 16.7, including the timeline in Section 16.6.

2. The Bakhshali manuscript's date changed after new tests. Analyze what this teaches about how to read a news headline that says "oldest ever."

   Hint: who made the claim, who checked it, and what happened next?

Evaluate

1. A video online says, "Ancient Indians knew everything modern science knows." Evaluate this claim using at least three examples from this chapter, including one where an early scholar was wrong.

   Hint: Brahmagupta's division by zero is a good place to start.

2. Your cousin says a home remedy "cured" her cold, so it must work. Evaluate this reasoning. What kind of evidence would scientists want to see?

   Hint: colds usually go away on their own; think about how a fair test would work.

Create

1. Design a one-page "relay race" poster that shows how the digits 0 to 9 traveled from Brahmi inscriptions to your math textbook. Include at least five stops with dates and places from this chapter.

   Hint: draw it as a route with handoffs, not a single inventor.

2. Write a short dialogue (150 to 200 words) between Ramanujan and C. V. Raman, imagining they meet as students. Have them each explain one idea from their field in simple words, without inventing quotes from real speeches.

   Hint: keep the facts from Section 16.12 accurate, and make the conversation clearly imaginary.

Key Takeaways

- Brahmi numerals, from the 3rd century BCE, are the ancestors of the shapes of our digits 1 to 9, but they were not yet a place value system.
- A place value system gives each digit a value by its position. Zero holds empty places, and South Asian mathematicians were the first known to treat zero as a number, with Brahmagupta writing its rules in 628 CE.
- The digits traveled from South Asia through Baghdad and North Africa to Europe, which is why they're called Hindu-Arabic numerals; al-Khwarizmi's name gave us "algorithm."
- Aryabhata, Brahmagupta, the Kerala School and Panini made real, specific contributions. Describing them accurately, including their mistakes, honors them more than exaggerating.
- Ayurveda, the Sushruta Samhita, Unani medicine and yoga are long healing traditions with real history; they are traditions, not proven cures, and this is not medical advice.
- Chaturanga is the ancestor of chess, and wootz steel from South India and Sri Lanka was prized across the world.
- Modern scientists born or working in what are now India, Pakistan and Bangladesh, including Ramanujan, Raman, Bose and Salam, continued the story into the 20th century.

You've cracked the code of zero!

You can now explain why a tiny circle changed math forever, and you know how to spot an overclaim when you hear one. Next, in Chapter 17, we tour the biggest country in the region, India, with its 28 states and 8 union territories.

Quiz: Science, Math, and Ideas

Test your understanding of Chapter 16. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

Who wrote the *Brahmasphutasiddhanta* in 628 CE, the first known text to give rules for zero as a number?

A. Aryabhata

B. Brahmagupta

C. Al-Biruni

D. Madhava of Sangamagrama

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Brahmagupta wrote the *Brahmasphutasiddhanta* at Bhillamala in 628 CE. Aryabhata is a common wrong guess, but he lived earlier (476 to 550 CE) and is best known for the *Aryabhatiya* and his value of pi.

Concept Tested: Brahmagupta **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

The word "chaturanga," the name of the ancestor of chess, refers to which of these?

A. The four seasons of the year

B. The four directions on a compass

C. The four corners of the board

D. The four divisions of an old Indian army

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Chaturanga means "four limbs," the elephants, chariots, cavalry and infantry of an old Indian army. The game was played on an 8-by-8 board, but the name is about the army, not the board's corners.

Concept Tested: Chaturanga **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

Panini, author of a famous grammar of Sanskrit, came from a town near Attock on the Indus River. In which present-day country is that?

A. Pakistan

B. Nepal

C. Bangladesh

D. Sri Lanka

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Panini came from Shalatula, near Attock on the Indus, in present-day Pakistan. Many people assume all early Sanskrit scholars lived in today's India, but the Indus region was a major center of learning.

Concept Tested: Panini's Grammar **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Why did the place value system need a symbol for zero, while Roman numerals did not?

A. Roman numerals were only used for small numbers, so zero never came up.

B. Place value uses fewer symbols, so it needed an extra one to reach ten.

C. In place value a digit's worth depends on its position, so an empty position must be marked; Roman letters keep their value wherever they sit.

D. The Romans had a zero symbol but chose not to write it on clocks.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. In 507, the 0 keeps the 5 in the hundreds place; without it the number would read 57. Roman numerals add up fixed-value letters (DVII), so there is no empty position to hold. Option A is wrong because Romans wrote large numbers too, using letters like M and D.

Concept Tested: Place Value System **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 5

Why do historians use the name "Hindu-Arabic numerals" instead of "Arabic numerals"?

A. Because the digits were invented in Arabia and later adopted in India

B. Because the system began in South Asia and was developed and passed to Europe by scholars writing in Arabic

C. Because Hindu and Muslim mathematicians invented the digits together on the same day

D. Because the digits are only used in India and the Arab world today

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The digits and place value began in South Asia, and scholars such as al-Khwarizmi spread them through the Arabic-speaking world to Europe. Option A reverses the direction of travel, which is the very mistake the double name is meant to correct.

Concept Tested: Hindu-Arabic Numerals **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 6

What is the best description of how the Kerala School's infinite series relate to European mathematics?

A. Madhava found series for pi, sine and cosine centuries before European mathematicians rediscovered them independently.

B. Madhava's notebooks were carried to England, where Newton copied them.

C. The Kerala School invented the complete system of calculus, including derivatives and integrals.

D. European mathematicians found the series first, and Kerala scholars learned them from traders.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Madhava (about 1350 to 1425) found these series, and Gregory and Newton found them again in the 1600s. Option B is a popular claim, but there is no solid evidence that the Kerala results reached Europe, so historians call the European work a rediscovery.

Concept Tested: Kerala School **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 7

Why are Ayurveda, Unani medicine and yoga described in this chapter as "traditions" rather than proven treatments?

A. Because they are no longer practiced anywhere

B. Because they come from religious texts, and science cannot study them

C. Because they were banned by governments in South Asia

D. Because few well-designed studies support their health claims, and some products have even been unsafe

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The US National Center for Complementary and Integrative Health reports limited scientific evidence for most Ayurvedic treatments and warns that some products contain lead, mercury or arsenic. Option A is wrong: these traditions are widely practiced today, and Unani is officially recognized in India and Pakistan. This is not medical advice.

Concept Tested: Ayurveda **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 8

Using the Zero and Place Value MicroSim, Ben builds the number 3,008 and ticks "Hide the zeros." What number does it appear to become?

A. 308

B. 3,800

C. 38

D. 3,008 (nothing changes)

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Removing both zero symbols squeezes the 3 and the 8 together, so 3,008 looks like 38. Option A only removes one of the two zeros; both the hundreds and tens places are empty.

Concept Tested: Zero **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Zara's Nanu writes a number on a recipe card in Bangla digits: ২০৫. Using what you learned about Bengali digits and place value, what number is it?

A. 205

B. 25

C. 250

D. 502

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. 𑁒 is 2, 𑁦 is 0 and 𑁕 is 5, and they are read left to right in the hundreds, tens and ones places, just like our digits. Option B forgets that the zero is holding the empty tens place.

Concept Tested: Brahmi Numerals **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 10

In 2017 the Bodleian Library announced that the Bakhshali manuscript might date to the 3rd or 4th century CE. In 2024, new radiocarbon results dated the tested leaves to roughly the late 700s to early 1000s CE. What is the best conclusion?

A. Radiocarbon dating is useless, so the manuscript's age can never be known.

B. Testing and re-testing corrected an early claim, which is how good science and history are supposed to work.

C. The 2024 results prove that zero was invented in Europe.

D. The manuscript must be a modern fake.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Experts questioned the 2017 result, the lab tested more leaves, and the date was revised. Option A goes too far: the method worked when applied carefully. The manuscript is still a genuine early text; it just isn't older than the Gwalior inscription of 876 CE.

Concept Tested: Zero **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 17: India

Summary

India is the most populous country on Earth and the largest country in South Asia, home to about 1.46 billion people in 2025. This chapter explains how such a big and varied country holds together: its constitution, its parliament and elections, its capital, and its 28 states and 8 union territories, many of them drawn around languages. You'll visit South India and Northeast India, meet India's Adivasi communities, and see how the idea of unity in diversity shows up in its national symbols, its money and its space program. Along the way you'll learn why one visitor from Hyderabad calls India "28 countries in one," and why that is both true and not quite true.

Concepts Covered

1. Republic of India
2. Constitution of India
3. Parliament of India
4. Elections in India
5. New Delhi
6. States and Union Territories
7. Linguistic States
8. Northeast India
9. South India

10. Adivasi Communities
11. Unity in Diversity
12. National Symbols of India
13. Indian Economy
14. Indian Rupee
15. ISRO

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia? for the eight countries and the land
- Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition for India's independence in 1947
- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts for language families and the Eighth Schedule
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia is helpful for the faiths mentioned here

One country, many homes

Hi, I'm Mora! India is where my own feathers come from: the peacock is India's national bird. If your family is from India, you've probably noticed that "Indian" can mean very different things to a cousin in Chennai and an uncle in Lucknow. If it isn't, India still touches your world in more ways than you might expect, even the phone in your pocket. This chapter walks you across the whole map, from Ladakh to Kerala.

17.1 "Like 28 Countries in One"

It's the first Saturday of the school year, and Arjun Reddy's cousin Kavya is visiting Minnesota from Hyderabad, in India. Arjun brings her to the South Asian Student Association's welcome picnic, where Zara Hossain is handing out samosas and Ben Lindqvist is handing out napkins (and eating most of the samosas).

Ben asks Kavya what India is like. She laughs. "Which part? India is like 28 countries in one. At home we speak Telugu. If I take the train to Bengaluru, the signs are in Kannada. My friend from Kolkata speaks Bengali, and my roommate from Delhi speaks Hindi. We all have to use English or Hindi to talk to each other sometimes." Zara jumps in: "Bengali? That's what my family speaks, and we're from Bangladesh." Kavya nods. "Exactly. Some of India's languages are also other countries' languages."

Ben is confused. He always thought India was one country with one language and one kind of food. Now he's hearing that it has dozens of languages, dozens of governments and a cousin who needs English to talk to her own roommate. So what holds India together, and what does Kavya mean by "28 countries in one"?

17.2 A Country the Size of a Continent

One way to picture it is the European Union, which has 27 member countries, more than 20 official languages, and about 450 million people. Each country has its own government, but they share some laws and many share a currency. Now imagine something with about three times as many people, more than 20 major languages, and 36 states and territories, but with one national government, one constitution, one army, one currency and one passport. That's India.

Or think about the United States, where Minnesota and Texas have their own governors and capitals inside one country. Now imagine if Minnesota's

official language were Swedish and Texas's were Spanish. That's closer to India, where many states were drawn around languages.

The Republic of India

The **Republic of India** is the official name of the country: a sovereign, democratic republic and a union of states, with an elected parliament and a constitution that has been in force since 1950. The constitution begins its very first article by naming the country twice: "India, that is Bharat, shall be a Union of States." Bharat (भारत, *BHAH-rut*) is the Hindi name for India, borrowed from Sanskrit, and many Indians use it in everyday speech.

India became independent from British rule on 15 August 1947, as you saw in Chapter 4. It became a republic, with an elected president instead of the British king as head of state, on 26 January 1950.

How many people?

India had **1,463,865,525 people in 2025** (about 1.46 billion, World Bank). It became the world's most populous country in 2023, passing China. About one in every six people on Earth lives in India.

Most Indians live in villages and small towns. In 2025, about 36% of Indians lived in cities, according to the World Bank. That still means hundreds of millions of city dwellers, in huge cities like Delhi, Mumbai (formerly Bombay), Kolkata, Chennai, Bengaluru and Hyderabad.

India's last full census was taken in 2011. The next one is under way, with houses counted in 2026 and people counted in early 2027. Until it is finished, many of India's detailed numbers about religion and language come from 2011.

17.3 The Constitution of India

A rulebook for a billion people

The **Constitution of India** is the supreme law of the country: the document that sets up India's government, divides power between the center and the states, and lists the rights of every citizen. It was adopted on 26 November 1949 and came into effect on 26 January 1950, a day Indians celebrate every year as Republic Day. It is famous for being one of the longest written national constitutions in the world.

The constitution was drafted by a committee chaired by B. R. Ambedkar, a lawyer and scholar who was born into a Dalit family and fought against caste discrimination all his life. Among many other things, the constitution:

- makes all citizens equal before the law;
- abolishes "untouchability" (Article 17), so discrimination by caste is illegal;
- protects freedom of religion, speech and assembly;
- names Hindi in the Devanagari script as the official language of the Union, with English continuing for official use (Article 343);
- lists the Eighth Schedule of languages, which today has **22** languages (Chapter 6).

India is officially secular, which in India means the state has no official religion and treats all faiths equally. In the 2011 census, about 79.8% of Indians were Hindu, 14.2% Muslim, 2.3% Christian, 1.7% Sikh, 0.7% Buddhist and 0.4% Jain, with smaller Parsi, Jewish, Bahá'í and tribal-faith communities. India has one of the largest Muslim populations of any country in the world.

Federal, but with a strong center

India is a **federal** country: power is shared between the national government (often called "the center" or "the Union") and the state governments. The constitution lists which subjects belong to whom. Defense, foreign affairs and money belong to the center. Police, public health and farming mostly belong to the states. Education is shared. Under Article 345, each state can choose its own official language or languages. That rule is the key to the states you'll meet in Section 17.6.

The Indian system gives the center more power than the American one does. For example, Parliament can create new states, change state borders or rename states by an ordinary law.

Think about it

The constitution let each state pick its own official language. Why might that help a big, many-language country stay united, instead of pulling it apart? Keep your answer in mind for Section 17.7.

17.4 Parliament and Elections

The Parliament of India

The **Parliament of India** is the national legislature, the body that makes India's laws. It has two houses, plus the president:

House	Hindi name	Members	How they are chosen
House of the People	Lok Sabha (लोकसभा,	543 elected seats	Directly elected by voters, one member

House	Hindi name	Members	How they are chosen
(lower house)	*LOKE-sub-ha*)		per constituency, at least every five years
Council of States (upper house)	Rajya Sabha	245 today, up to 250 allowed (12 appointed by the president)	Mostly elected by the members of state assemblies

India uses a **parliamentary** system, like the United Kingdom and unlike the United States. The prime minister, who runs the government day to day, is the leader of the party or coalition that controls a majority in the Lok Sabha. The president is head of state and has mostly ceremonial powers, acting on the advice of the prime minister and the cabinet.

As of October 2026, India's prime minister is Narendra Modi, in office since 2014 and in his third term, and its president is Droupadi Murmu, in office since 2022. President Murmu, from the Santal community, is the first person from a tribal community to hold the office. Parliament meets in New Delhi, in a new Parliament building opened in May 2023.

Elections in India

Elections in India are the regular votes, run by the independent Election Commission of India, in which adult citizens choose members of Parliament and of state assemblies. Every citizen aged 18 or older can vote.

The 2024 general election shows the size of it. Voting took place in seven phases between 19 April and 1 June 2024, and results were announced on 4 June. About 968 million people were registered to vote, and about 642 million voted, the largest number of voters in any election in history. Turnout at

polling stations was 65.79%, according to the Election Commission. The highest turnout was in Lakshadweep, at 84.16%, and the lowest in Bihar, at 56.19%.

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) won 240 seats, short of a majority on its own, and formed a coalition government, the National Democratic Alliance, with 293 seats. The opposition alliance, called INDIA and led by the Indian National Congress, won 234 seats. Like any democracy's, India's politics is lively and argued over; this book describes how the system works and leaves the arguments to the news.

Each state also elects its own legislative assembly, which chooses a chief minister, the state's head of government.

17.5 New Delhi

New Delhi is the capital of India and the seat of its national government, home to Parliament, the President's House (Rashtrapati Bhavan) and the Supreme Court. It sits inside the larger city and union territory of Delhi, on the Yamuna River.

New Delhi is younger than it looks. Under British rule, Kolkata (then Calcutta) was the capital until 1911. That year, King George V announced that the capital would move to Delhi, an old imperial city that had been a Mughal capital (Chapter 3). British architects Edwin Lutyens and Herbert Baker designed a new government district south of the old city, and New Delhi was inaugurated in 1931. After independence, the new republic kept it as the capital.

Delhi is a city of layers: Mughal monuments in Old Delhi, the colonial avenues of New Delhi, and huge modern suburbs where people from every state now live.

Delhi or New Delhi?

"Delhi" is the whole city and union territory; "New Delhi" is the district inside it where the national government sits. If someone says India's capital is Mumbai, gently point out that Mumbai is the biggest business city, but the capital is New Delhi.

17.6 States and Union Territories

Two kinds of pieces

India is divided into **States and Union Territories**: 28 states, which have their own elected governments and share power with the center, and 8 union territories, which are governed more directly by the national government. This is the count as of October 2026, according to the National Portal of India.

- A **state** has its own elected legislative assembly, a chief minister and a governor appointed by the president. It makes its own laws on state subjects.
- A **union territory** (UT) is run by an administrator appointed by the president. Some UTs, like Delhi, Puducherry and Jammu and Kashmir, also have elected assemblies with limited powers.

Why have union territories at all? Some are small islands far from the mainland (the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Lakshadweep). Some were once ruled by France or Portugal and stayed separate after they joined India (Puducherry; Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu). Chandigarh is the shared capital of two states. Delhi holds the national capital. And Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh became union territories in 2019, as you'll see below.

All 36 at a glance

Here is the full list, with the capitals given by the National Portal of India. The languages are the main official ones; many states also have additional official languages for some districts or purposes.

State or UT	Type	Capital	Main official language(s)
Andhra Pradesh	State	Amaravati	Telugu
Arunachal Pradesh	State	Itanagar	English
Assam	State	Dispur	Assamese, Bodo (Bengali in the Barak Valley)
Bihar	State	Patna	Hindi (Urdu additional)
Chhattisgarh	State	Raipur	Hindi
Goa	State	Panaji	Konkani (Marathi and English also used)
Gujarat	State	Gandhinagar	Gujarati
Haryana	State	Chandigarh	Hindi

State or UT	Type	Capital	Main official language(s)
Himachal Pradesh	State	Shimla	Hindi (Sanskrit second)
Jharkhand	State	Ranchi	Hindi (many additional)
Karnataka	State	Bengaluru	Kannada
Kerala	State	Thiruvananthapuram	Malayalam
Madhya Pradesh	State	Bhopal	Hindi
Maharashtra	State	Mumbai	Marathi
Manipur	State	Imphal	Manipuri (Meitei)
Meghalaya	State	Shillong	English (Khasi and Garo associate)
Mizoram	State	Aizawl	Mizo, English
Nagaland	State	Kohima	English
Odisha	State	Bhubaneswar	Odia

State or UT	Type	Capital	Main official language(s)
Punjab	State	Chandigarh	Punjabi
Rajasthan	State	Jaipur	Hindi
Sikkim	State	Gangtok	Nepali, English and others
Tamil Nadu	State	Chennai	Tamil
Telangana	State	Hyderabad	Telugu (Urdu additional)
Tripura	State	Agartala	Bengali, Kokborok, English
Uttar Pradesh	State	Lucknow	Hindi (Urdu additional)
Uttarakhand	State	Dehradun	Hindi (Sanskrit second)
West Bengal	State	Kolkata	Bengali, English
Andaman and Nicobar Islands	UT	Sri Vijaya Puram (formerly Port Blair)	Hindi, English

State or UT	Type	Capital	Main official language(s)
Chandigarh	UT	Chandigarh	English
Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu	UT	Daman	Gujarati, Hindi (English used in administration; sources differ)
Delhi	UT (National Capital Territory)	Delhi	Hindi, English
Jammu and Kashmir	UT	Srinagar (summer), Jammu (winter)	Kashmiri, Dogri, Urdu, Hindi, English
Ladakh	UT	Leh	Bhoti, Purgi, Urdu, Hindi, English
Lakshadweep	UT	Kavaratti	English (Malayalam widely used)
Puducherry	UT	Puducherry	Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam (by area), plus English and French

The map has changed many times since 1947, and it changes still. Dadra and Nagar Haveli merged with Daman and Diu on 26 January 2020. In 2024 the capital of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Port Blair, was renamed Sri Vijaya Puram. In June 2025, a new regulation made Bhoti and Purgi official languages in Ladakh alongside Urdu, Hindi and English.

Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh

Until 2019, Jammu and Kashmir was a state with special autonomy under Article 370 of the constitution. In August 2019, India's government revoked that special status, and Parliament passed a law splitting the state into two union territories, Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, from 31 October 2019. In December 2023, India's Supreme Court upheld the change and directed that statehood be restored to Jammu and Kashmir "as soon as possible." As of October 2026, both remain union territories.

These two territories are part of a much larger region whose status is disputed, as the box below explains.

Whose Story?

Ask someone in Delhi, Islamabad and Beijing to draw "Kashmir," and you'll get three different maps. In 1947 the Hindu ruler of the princely state of Jammu and Kashmir, with a Muslim-majority population, joined India during fighting with forces from Pakistan, and war followed. Today India administers about 55% of the region's land, Pakistan about 30% (Azad Jammu and Kashmir and Gilgit-Baltistan) and China about 15% (including Aksai Chin). India's position is that the whole former princely state is part of India. China's position is that Aksai Chin is part of China. Pakistan's position is that the region's future should be decided by its people through the vote the United Nations called for in 1948. Many Kashmiris themselves hold their own views, which do not always match either government's, and people of every community there have suffered through decades of conflict.

17.7 Linguistic States

How languages drew the map

Linguistic States are states whose borders were drawn so that most people inside share one main language, which usually becomes the state's official language. Most of India's states today are linguistic states.

At independence, India inherited a patchwork: big British provinces like Madras and Bombay that held speakers of several languages, plus more than 500 princely states. Many people wanted states that matched their languages, so that they could go to school, go to court and deal with officials in their own tongue. India's first leaders worried that language-based states might divide the country, and moved slowly.

In 1952, Potti Sriramulu, an activist demanding a separate state for Telugu speakers, died on the 58th day of a hunger strike. Protests followed, and in 1953 the government created Andhra State from the Telugu-speaking north of Madras State, the first state formed for one language. A States Reorganisation Commission followed, and the **States Reorganisation Act of 1956** redrew much of the map on linguistic lines from 1 November 1956. Kerala, for example, was created that day for Malayalam speakers.

The process continued:

Year	Change
1953	Andhra State formed for Telugu speakers
1956	States Reorganisation Act redraws the map; Kerala, Mysore (later Karnataka) and others formed around languages

Year	Change
1960	Bombay State split into Maharashtra (Marathi) and Gujarat (Gujarati) on 1 May
2000	Chhattisgarh, Uttarakhand and Jharkhand formed, more for regional and tribal identity than for language
2014	Telangana formed from Andhra Pradesh on 2 June, after a long regional movement; both states speak Telugu
2019	Jammu and Kashmir state split into two union territories

Notice the later changes. Telangana and Andhra Pradesh share the Telugu language, yet they split, because people in Telangana felt their region's history and needs were different. Language matters a great deal, but it isn't the only thing that makes people feel like a "state."

So was Kavya right that India is "28 countries in one"? In one sense, yes: many states have their own language, literature, film industry, food and festivals. But they are not countries. They share one constitution, one parliament and one army, and people move freely between them. Kavya can fly from Hyderabad to Kolkata without a passport.

Hindi, English and the language question

India's constitution named Hindi in Devanagari script as the official language of the Union and planned for English to be phased out by 1965. In South India, especially in Tamil Nadu, many people strongly opposed having Hindi imposed on them. After protests in Tamil Nadu, the Official Languages Act of

1963, and an amendment to it in 1967, settled the issue for now: English continues alongside Hindi for official purposes, with no end date.

How many Indians speak Hindi? In the 2011 census, about 43.6% of Indians named Hindi as their mother tongue. That number includes many related regional tongues, such as Bhojpuri and Braj, that the census groups under Hindi. So Hindi is the biggest single language, but more than half of India grows up speaking something else. Bengali came second, at about 8%.

17.8 South India

South India is the southern part of the peninsula, usually meaning the five states of Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Telangana, plus Puducherry and Lakshadweep, where the main languages belong to the Dravidian family.

The four big Dravidian languages are Telugu, Tamil, Kannada and Malayalam, each with its own script, literature and film industry (Chapter 6, Chapter 15). Dravidian languages are a completely different family from Hindi, which is Indo-Aryan, in the same way that Finnish is unrelated to Swedish even though Finland and Sweden are neighbors. That is why a Hindi-speaking student who moves to Chennai has to learn a whole new language.

South India has long faced the sea. Its ports traded with Rome, Arabia and Southeast Asia for centuries (Chapter 3). Kerala has old Christian, Jewish and Muslim communities whose faiths first reached its coast by sea, through trade. The south is also home to big technology cities, Bengaluru and Hyderabad, where many software companies have offices. Arjun's family is from Hyderabad, the capital of Telangana, and he dances Kuchipudi, a classical dance style named after a village in Andhra Pradesh (Chapter 10).

"South Indian" is a useful label, but it has limits: a family from Kochi and a family from Hyderabad may speak, eat, pray and celebrate quite differently.

17.9 Northeast India

Northeast India is the easternmost region of the country, made up of eight states: Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland and Tripura (often called the "Seven Sisters") and Sikkim. It is connected to the rest of India by a narrow strip of land in West Bengal, the Siliguri Corridor, and it borders five countries: China, Myanmar, Bangladesh, Bhutan and Nepal.

The Northeast covers almost 8% of India's area but held only about 4% of its people in 2011. It is one of the most linguistically varied places on Earth. Many of its languages belong to the Tibeto-Burman family, related to Tibetan and Burmese rather than to Hindi or Tamil. Assamese and Bengali are Indo-Aryan, and Khasi in Meghalaya is Austroasiatic. Because no single local language is shared across Nagaland or Arunachal Pradesh, those states chose English as their official language.

Faiths vary widely too. Assam and Tripura have Hindu majorities and Assam has a large Muslim population. Nagaland, Mizoram and Meghalaya have Christian majorities. Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh have important Buddhist communities. Many communities keep Indigenous faiths alongside or instead of these.

Many people from the Northeast who move to big Indian cities have reported facing prejudice and being treated as "foreigners" in their own country. This chapter treats the Northeast as a full part of India's story.

Not all Indians look alike

If a classmate says they're from India and they don't match the picture you had in your head, that picture is too small. India includes people from Ladakh, Nagaland, Kerala and Gujarat, and none of them is "less Indian" than the others.

17.10 Adivasi Communities

Adivasi Communities are India's Indigenous or tribal peoples, many of whom have their own languages, faiths, governance and ways of life tied to forests, hills and land. Adivasi (आदिवासी, *AH-dee-VAH-see*) means "original inhabitants" in Hindi. The government's official term is **Scheduled Tribes**, groups listed in a schedule under the constitution for special protection and support. Some officials avoid the word Adivasi, but many communities and activists use it with pride, and this book uses both respectfully.

In the 2011 census, about 104 million Indians, 8.6% of the population, belonged to Scheduled Tribes, and hundreds of different groups are listed. That is more than the entire population of most countries. Madhya Pradesh has the largest tribal population of any state (about 15 million in 2011), and in several northeastern states tribal peoples are the majority. Most live in rural areas.

Adivasi communities include the Santal, Gond, Bhil, Munda, Oraon and many more, with very different histories. Santali, an Austroasiatic language, was added to the Eighth Schedule in 2003. The state of Jharkhand was created in 2000 partly in response to a long movement for tribal self-rule; its first chief minister took office on 15 November 2000, the birth anniversary of the Munda leader Birsa Munda, who led a movement against British rule and the loss of tribal land in the 1890s.

Adivasi communities have faced serious problems, especially losing land and forests to dams, mines and other projects. They have also shaped Indian art, music and politics, and today an Adivasi woman, Droupadi Murmu, is president of India.

17.11 Unity in Diversity

Unity in Diversity is the idea that a country can hold many languages, faiths, peoples and cultures and still be one nation, with the differences seen as a strength rather than a threat. Indian leaders, schools and textbooks have used the phrase since independence to describe what India hopes to be.

You've already seen the diversity: 22 scheduled languages and hundreds more spoken; Hindus, Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Parsis and others; deserts, rainforests, Himalayan valleys and coral islands. What provides the unity?

- **Shared institutions:** one constitution, one parliament, one Supreme Court and one election system.
- **Shared history:** the independence movement, which brought people from every region together against colonial rule.
- **Shared culture across lines:** cricket (Chapter 15), Hindi and regional films, festivals that neighbors of different faiths often celebrate together, and food that travels between states.

Unity in diversity is a goal that India keeps working toward. India has seen violence between religious communities, conflicts in Kashmir and parts of the Northeast, and arguments over language. Indians debate, loudly, how a big democracy should balance majority and minority, center and state. Those debates are part of how a diverse country works out living together.

17.12 National Symbols of India

National Symbols of India are the official emblems, chosen by the government, that stand for the country as a whole: a flag, an emblem, an anthem, a song, an animal, a bird, a flower and more.

Symbol	What it is	Adopted or notes
National flag	The tricolor, or tiranga (तिरंगा, *ti-RUNG-ah*): saffron, white and green bands with a navy blue wheel (the Ashoka Chakra) in the center	Adopted 22 July 1947
State emblem	Three lions from the Lion Capital of Ashoka at Sarnath, with the motto *Satyameva Jayate*, "Truth alone triumphs"	Adopted 26 January 1950
National anthem	"Jana Gana Mana," written in Bengali by Rabindranath Tagore	Adopted 24 January 1950
National song	"Vande Mataram," by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee	Honored equally with the anthem
National animal	Tiger	
National bird	Indian peafowl (peacock)	Since 1963

Symbol	What it is	Adopted or notes
National flower	Lotus	Listed on the National Portal of India, though a 2019 government answer in Parliament said no official notice names a national flower
National calendar	The Saka calendar, used alongside the Gregorian calendar	Adopted 22 March 1957

Many of these symbols reach back into older history. The wheel on the flag and the lions on the emblem come from the reign of the emperor Ashoka in the 200s BCE (Chapter 2). The anthem connects India to its neighbors: Tagore also wrote "Amar Shonar Bangla," the national anthem of Bangladesh, which you'll meet in Chapter 19.

17.13 The Indian Economy and the Rupee

The Indian Economy

The **Indian Economy** is the system of farms, factories, services and trade through which India's 1.46 billion people make and buy goods. It is huge in total but still modest per person. In 2025, India's gross domestic product (GDP), the value of everything produced in a year, was about 3.96 trillion US dollars, the sixth-largest in the world by the World Bank's figures in US dollars, close behind the United Kingdom. But because that output is shared among so many people, India's income per person (gross national income per

person) was about 2,760 US dollars in 2025, according to the World Bank, far below that of the United States.

India's economy has many layers at once:

- **Farming** still employs a very large share of Indians, growing rice, wheat, cotton, sugarcane, tea and spices.
- **Services** are the biggest part of the economy, including software and IT companies in Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Pune, banking in Mumbai, and call centers that serve customers worldwide.
- **Manufacturing** includes cars, medicines and, increasingly, phones.
- **The informal economy:** millions of street vendors, small shops and family workshops that are not registered businesses.

Since economic reforms in 1991 opened India more to trade and investment, its economy has grown fast, and hundreds of millions of people have risen out of extreme poverty. At the same time, India still has many people living in poverty, and the gaps between rich and poor, and between booming and struggling states, are large.

The Indian Rupee

The **Indian Rupee** is India's currency, written ₹ and divided into 100 paise. The word "rupee" comes from the Hindi rupaya (रुपया, *ROOP-yah*), from a Sanskrit word for wrought silver. The rupee goes back to a silver coin called the rupiya, first issued by the ruler Sher Shah Suri between 1540 and 1545 and later by the Mughals, and several neighbors also call their money rupees: Pakistan, Nepal and Sri Lanka all do.

The ₹ symbol is new. In 2010, India's government held an open competition for a rupee sign, and on 15 July 2010 it chose a design by D. Udaya Kumar, a young designer from IIT Bombay. The symbol blends the Devanagari letter र

(*ra*) with the Latin letter R, and its two horizontal lines echo the flag. In 2026, one US dollar cost more than 90 rupees (US Federal Reserve exchange-rate data, February 2026).

17.14 ISRO and India in Space

ISRO, the Indian Space Research Organisation, is India's national space agency, which builds and launches rockets and satellites and sends missions to the Moon and beyond. It grew out of a space research committee set up in 1962, at the urging of the physicist Vikram Sarabhai, and took the name ISRO in 1969. Its headquarters are in Bengaluru, and it launches rockets from Sriharikota, an island on the coast of Andhra Pradesh.

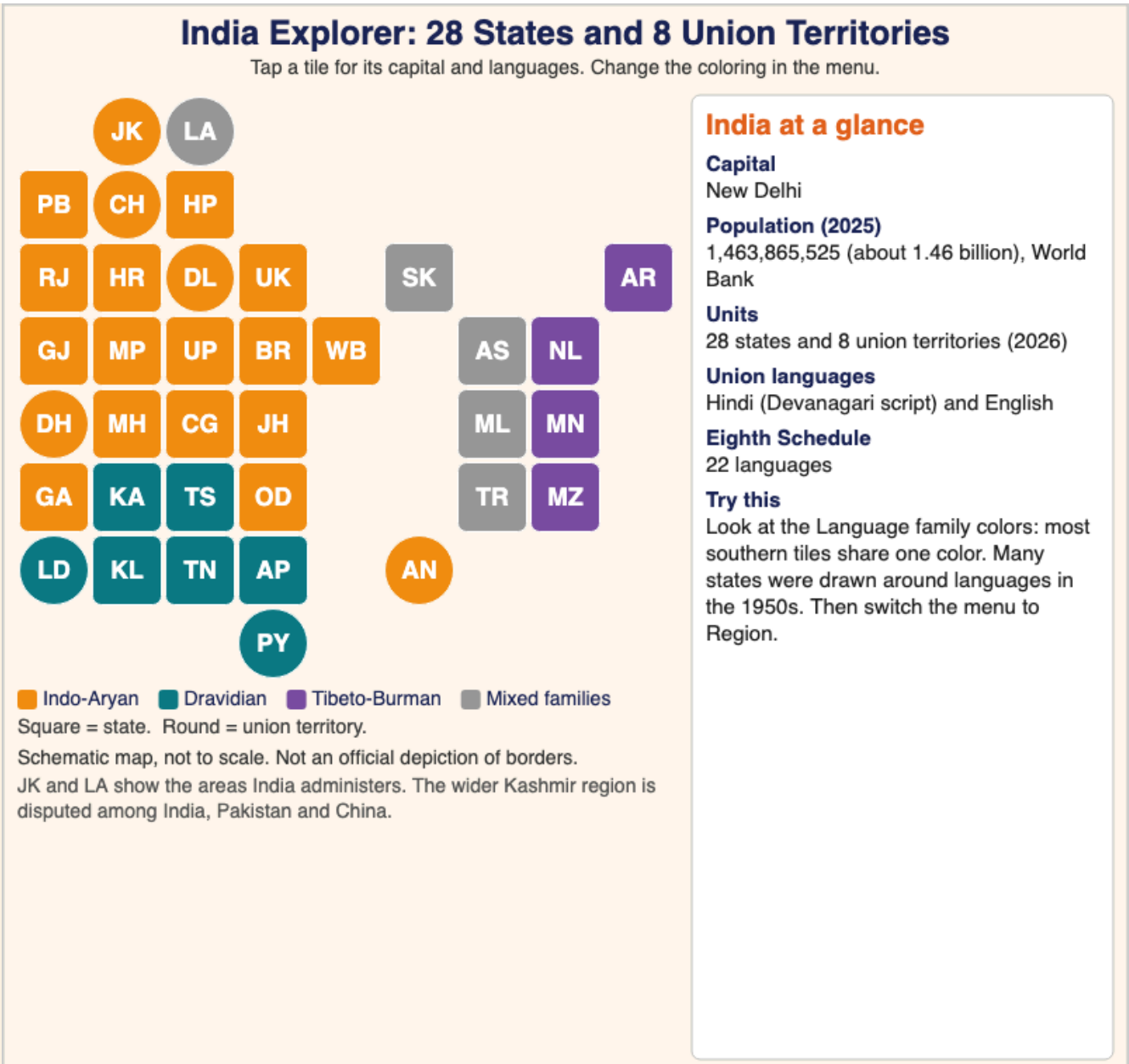
ISRO is known for doing ambitious things on small budgets: its Mars Orbiter Mission, which reached Mars in September 2014, cost about 450 crore rupees (roughly 74 million US dollars). Its satellites forecast weather, map crops, guide fishing boats and broadcast TV across the country.

Its most famous recent mission is **Chandrayaan-3** ("Moon craft"). Launched on 14 July 2023, it landed its Vikram lander near the Moon's south pole on 23 August 2023, and a small rover called Pragyan drove across the surface. India became the fourth country to land softly on the Moon, after the Soviet Union, the United States and China, and the first to land near the lunar south pole, a region scientists study because it may hold water ice. The rover's instruments confirmed sulfur in the soil near the pole.

Connect the dots

Chandrayaan-3 was built by engineers from many states and launched from Andhra Pradesh by an agency based in Karnataka. Why might a national science project like this be a good example of "unity in diversity"?

Diagram: India Explorer



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch17-india-explorer/main.html

Open the India Explorer fullscreen

MicroSim specification: India Explorer

sim-id: ch17-india-explorer
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: explain, classify
Learning Objective: The learner will explain how India's states and union territories connect to its languages, by classifying each one by language family and region.

Canvas: responsive width; 760 px drawing area plus 80 px control area.

Controls: "Color the tiles by" menu (Language family, Region); "Highlight the 8 union territories" checkbox; click or tap any tile.

Behavior: A tile cartogram shows 36 equal tiles (squares for the 28 states, rounded tiles for the 8 union territories), placed roughly where each sits in India, with no borders drawn. Tiles are colored by the language family of each place's main official language(s) (Indo-Aryan, Dravidian, Tibeto-Burman, mixed families) or by informal region. Tapping a tile shows its capital, official languages, family, region and a short note. A card summarizes India's capital, 2025 population (World Bank), 28 + 8 units and languages. The caption "Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders." and a neutral note that the wider Kashmir region is disputed appear inside the drawing area.

Start with the **Language family** coloring. Look at the teal block in the south (Dravidian) and the purple tiles in the northeast (Tibeto-Burman). Then tap Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Karnataka, Telangana and Andhra Pradesh. Notice that each southern state has its own language, but they all belong to the same family. Now tap the gray tiles: Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura, Sikkim and Ladakh. Each one has official languages from two different families.

Then switch to **Region** and check **Highlight the 8 union territories**. Tap each union territory and ask why it isn't a state. Is it an island group, a former French or Portuguese territory, a capital city, or a place that changed in 2019? Finally, find Hyderabad in the Telangana tile and imagine Kavya's train ride to Bengaluru in Karnataka: how many tiles, and how many languages, would she pass?

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about the place in India their family comes from: which state, which language, and what makes it different from the rest of India. If your family isn't from India, ask an elder about a place in India they have visited or would like to visit. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Pull up the India Explorer MicroSim on a phone or tablet so your elder can tap their home state. It gives you an easy way to start talking.

Questions to ask

1. Which state, city or village is our family (or your family) from? What is one thing you remember most about it?
2. Which language did you speak at home there? Which languages did you learn at school?
3. What food, festival or custom from your state do you think people from other states don't really know about?

4. When you met people from other parts of India, what surprised you about them, or about yourself?
5. How has your home state changed since you were young, or since you moved away?
6. What is one thing from your state that you hope I keep, even if I never live there?

Listen for: whether their state is one of the Linguistic States and which language it was drawn around; whether they are from South India, Northeast India or another region; and moments where they describe Unity in Diversity, like friends from different states or faiths celebrating together.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Find your elder's state in the table in Section 17.6. Does the official language there match the language your family speaks at home? If a friend interviewed someone from a different state, compare the two: what is different, and what do they share as Indians?

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: India has one culture.
Reality: India has 28 states and 8 union territories, 22 scheduled languages and hundreds more, and many faiths, cuisines and festivals. A family in Kerala and a family in Punjab can differ in language, food and customs as

much as Swedes and Spaniards do, while sharing one country, one constitution and a lot of history.

Myth: Everyone in India speaks Hindi.
Reality: Hindi is the largest language, but in the 2011 census only about 44% of Indians named it as their mother tongue. Most people in South India, Northeast India, West Bengal, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Punjab and Odisha grow up speaking another language, and English is widely used to bridge the gaps.

Myth: India's capital is Mumbai.
Reality: The capital is New Delhi, inside the National Capital Territory of Delhi. Mumbai, the capital of Maharashtra, is India's biggest business and film city.

Myth: India is mostly big cities.
Reality: India has some of the world's largest cities, but in 2025 only about 36% of Indians lived in urban areas, according to the World Bank. Most Indians still live in villages and small towns.

Check Yourself

1. How many states and union territories does India have, and what is the difference between them?

As of 2026, India has 28 states and 8 union territories. States have their own elected governments that share power with the center; union territories are governed more directly by the national government through an administrator, though some also have elected assemblies.

2. What is a linguistic state, and which was the first?

A linguistic state is one whose borders were drawn around a shared language, which usually becomes its official language. Andhra State, formed in 1953 for Telugu speakers, was the first.

3. What are the two houses of the Parliament of India?

The Lok Sabha (House of the People), with 543 directly elected seats, and the Rajya Sabha (Council of States), mostly elected by state assemblies.

4. What happened on 23 August 2023, and why did it matter?

ISRO's Chandrayaan-3 landed near the Moon's south pole. India became the fourth country to make a soft landing on the Moon and the first to land near the lunar south pole.

5. What are Adivasi communities, and what share of India's population did they make up in 2011?

Adivasi communities are India's Indigenous or tribal peoples, officially called Scheduled Tribes. In the 2011 census they made up about 8.6% of the population, about 104 million people.

Exercises

Remember

1. Name India's capital, its 2025 population (World Bank) and the date its constitution came into effect.

Answer

New Delhi; 1,463,865,525 (about 1.46 billion); 26 January 1950, celebrated as Republic Day.

2. List the eight states of Northeast India.

Answer

Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Tripura and Sikkim.

Understand

1. Explain why Nagaland and Arunachal Pradesh use English as their official language.

Answer

Each is home to many peoples speaking many different languages, mostly Tibeto-Burman, with no single local language shared by everyone, so English works as a neutral common language for government.

2. Explain the difference between Delhi and New Delhi.

Answer

Delhi is the whole city and the National Capital Territory, a union territory. New Delhi is the district inside it, built by the British and inaugurated in 1931, that holds Parliament and the national government.

Apply

1. Use the India Explorer MicroSim. Switch the coloring to **Language family** and list every gray ("mixed families") tile. For each, name the two families its official languages come from.

   Hint: tap each gray tile and read the note.

2. A new student says her family is from Thiruvananthapuram and speaks Malayalam at home. Using the table in Section 17.6, write two sentences that show you know which state she is from and how that state got its borders.

   Hint: think about 1 November 1956.

Analyze

1. Compare the creation of Telangana in 2014 with the creation of Andhra State in 1953. Why was language the main reason for one but not the other?

   Hint: both states speak Telugu.

2. Kavya said India is "like 28 countries in one." Analyze what is accurate and what is misleading about that statement, using at least two facts from the chapter.

   Hint: think about languages and governments, then about the constitution, Parliament and passports.

Evaluate

1. Some Indians argue that Hindi should be used more widely as a common national language; others, especially in South India, argue that this would

be unfair to non-Hindi speakers. Evaluate both positions and say which you find more convincing, and why.

Hint: use the 2011 census number and the history of the Official Languages Act of 1963.

2. India's national symbols include a flag, an emblem from Ashoka's era, an anthem in Bengali and a calendar. Evaluate how well this set of symbols represents a country of many languages and faiths. What would you add or change, and why?

   Hint: look at where each symbol comes from.

Create

1. Design a "welcome to my state" poster for one of India's 36 states or union territories. Include its capital, its official language, one festival or food, and one fact that would surprise someone from another state.

   Hint: start from the MicroSim card, then add from your own research or interview.

2. Write a short news report (150 to 200 words) of the Chandrayaan-3 landing as it might have been told in two different Indian languages' newspapers. What would be the same in both, and what local detail might each add?

   Hint: use the dates and facts in Section 17.14.

Key Takeaways

- The Republic of India, with 1,463,865,525 people in 2025 (World Bank), is the world's most populous country; its constitution came into effect on 26 January 1950.

- India is a federal parliamentary democracy: the Lok Sabha's 543 seats are directly elected, and in 2024 about 642 million people voted in the largest election in history.
- India has 28 states and 8 union territories (2026), and its capital is New Delhi, inside the National Capital Territory of Delhi.
- Many states are linguistic states, drawn around a shared language, beginning with Andhra State in 1953 and the States Reorganisation Act of 1956.
- South India's main languages are Dravidian, Northeast India's are largely Tibeto-Burman, and Hindi was the mother tongue of about 44% of Indians in 2011.
- Adivasi communities (Scheduled Tribes) made up 8.6% of Indians in 2011, and India's national symbols, economy, rupee and space program all reflect the goal of unity in diversity.
- Kashmir is disputed: India, Pakistan and China each administer part of the region, and their positions differ.

You toured India!

You can now explain how 36 states and territories, 22 scheduled languages and 1.46 billion people fit into one republic, and why Kavya's "28 countries in one" is half right. Next, in Chapter 18, we cross India's western border to tour Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Quiz: India

Test your understanding of Chapter 17. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

As of 2026, how is India divided?

A. 29 states and 7 union territories

B. 28 states and 8 union territories

C. 36 states and no union territories

D. 22 states, one for each scheduled language

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. India has 28 states and 8 union territories, according to the National Portal of India. The count of 29 states and 7 union territories was correct before 2019, when Jammu and Kashmir became a union territory and Ladakh was separated from it.

Concept Tested: States and Union Territories **Bloom's Level:** Remember

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Question 2

When did the Constitution of India come into effect?

A. 15 August 1947

B. 26 November 1949

C. 1 November 1956

D. 26 January 1950

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The constitution came into effect on 26 January 1950, now celebrated as Republic Day. It was adopted on 26 November 1949, which is why option B is tempting, and 15 August 1947 is Independence Day.

Concept Tested: Constitution of India **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 3

What did ISRO's Chandrayaan-3 mission achieve on 23 August 2023?

A. It made India the first country to land near the Moon's south pole.

B. It made India the first country ever to land on the Moon.

C. It put the first Indian astronaut on the Moon.

D. It sent India's first spacecraft into orbit around Mars.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Chandrayaan-3's Vikram lander touched down near the lunar south pole, making India the fourth country to land softly on the Moon and the first near the south pole. It was not the first Moon landing overall: the Soviet Union, the United States and China landed first, and the mission carried no astronauts.

Concept Tested: ISRO **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Which statement best explains what a linguistic state is?

A. A state where English is banned from government use

B. A state where everyone must learn Hindi first

C. A state whose borders were drawn so that most people share one main language

D. A state created for people who speak more than three languages

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Linguistic states were drawn around a shared language, which usually became the state's official language, starting with Andhra State in 1953. They do not require Hindi; in fact, many linguistic states have non-Hindi official languages such as Telugu, Tamil or Marathi.

Concept Tested: Linguistic States **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 5

Why do Nagaland and Arunachal Pradesh use English as their official language?

A. Because English is the only language taught in their schools

B. Because each is home to many peoples with different languages and no single shared local language

C. Because they were British colonies until 2000

D. Because the constitution requires all northeastern states to use English

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. These states are home to many communities speaking many languages, mostly Tibeto-Burman, so English works as a neutral common language. The constitution does not require it; each state chooses its own official language under Article 345.

Concept Tested: Northeast India **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 6

Which statement about Hindi in India is accurate?

A. In the 2011 census, about 44% of Indians named Hindi as their mother tongue, so most Indians grow up speaking another language.

B. Hindi is the mother tongue of almost every Indian.

C. Hindi is the only official language of India's national government.

D. Hindi belongs to the Dravidian language family.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Hindi is the largest single language, but about 43.6% of Indians named it as their mother tongue in 2011. English continues alongside Hindi for national official use under the Official Languages Act of 1963 (amended in 1967), and Hindi is Indo-Aryan, not Dravidian.

Concept Tested: Unity in Diversity **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 7

A new classmate tells you her family is from Chennai and speaks Tamil at home. Using the chapter, which description fits her family's home region?

A. Northeast India, where most languages are Tibeto-Burman

B. A union territory governed directly from New Delhi

C. The capital region, where Hindi and English are the official languages

D. South India, where the main languages belong to the Dravidian family

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Chennai is the capital of Tamil Nadu, a state in South India, and Tamil is a Dravidian language. Tamil Nadu is a state, not a union territory, so option B does not fit.

Concept Tested: South India **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

Your club is making a poster about India's government. Which pair correctly describes India's leaders as of October 2026?

A. President Narendra Modi and Prime Minister Droupadi Murmu

B. Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and President Asif Ali Zardari

C. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Droupadi Murmu

D. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Rabindranath Tagore

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Narendra Modi is prime minister (in his third term) and Droupadi Murmu has been president since 2022. Option A swaps their offices, and option B names Pakistan's leaders.

Concept Tested: Parliament of India **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Telangana was split from Andhra Pradesh in 2014, even though both states mainly speak Telugu. What does this case show?

A. Language matters, but regional history and identity can also shape how states are drawn.

B. The States Reorganisation Act of 1956 required every state to split in two.

C. Telugu speakers do not live in Telangana.

D. Linguistic states were abolished in 2014.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Telangana's movement was about regional history and needs, not a different language, so it shows that language is only one reason states form. Linguistic states were not abolished, and Telugu is Telangana's official language.

Concept Tested: Linguistic States **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

The India Explorer MicroSim draws Goa and Rajasthan as tiles of the same size. What is the best reason a tile cartogram is used instead of a traced map?

A. Goa and Rajasthan really are the same size.

B. Equal tiles make every state and territory easy to see and compare, and avoid drawing disputed borders.

C. Tile cartograms show each state's exact population.

D. Traced maps of India are not allowed to show capitals.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Equal tiles let tiny places like Goa or Chandigarh be seen and tapped as easily as big ones, and a schematic layout avoids drawing official borders, including the disputed Kashmir region. Goa is actually India's smallest state by area, and Rajasthan its largest.

Concept Tested: States and Union Territories **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan

Summary

Pakistan and Afghanistan are neighbors on the western side of South Asia, with a long mountain frontier between them and a famous road that crosses it. This chapter tours Pakistan first: how the country is governed, its capital, its four provinces, and the many languages that sit beside Urdu, its national language. Then it turns to Afghanistan: its mountains and capital, its two official languages, the Pashtun code of Pashtunwali, its heritage sites and its carpets, along with a brief, dated look at who governs it today. Along the way you'll see how cultural regions like the Punjab and the Pashtun belt cross the lines on a modern map.

Concepts Covered

1. Islamic Republic of Pakistan
2. Islamabad
3. Provinces of Pakistan
4. Punjab Region
5. Lahore
6. Sindh
7. Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

8. Balochistan
9. Urdu as National Language
10. Afghanistan
11. Kabul
12. Dari and Pashto
13. Pashtunwali
14. Khyber Pass
15. Buddhas of Bamiyan
16. Afghan Carpets

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia? for the eight countries, the Hindu Kush and the Indus River
- Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters for the Mughal Empire
- Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition for how Pakistan was created in 1947
- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts is helpful for the Perso-Arabic script

Two neighbors, one old road

Hi, I'm Mora! Pakistan and Afghanistan show up in the news a lot, usually in short, scary headlines that leave out the people, the poetry, the food and the festivals. If your family is from either country, this chapter gives you words for the places you hear about at home. If it isn't, it helps you see your classmates' homelands as more than a headline.

18.1 Dinner at the Qureshis'

On a Saturday in October, Ayesha Qureshi's family invites Zara Hossain and Ben Lindqvist over for dinner. Ayesha's family is from Lahore, in Pakistan, and they speak Urdu at home. The table is crowded: a big pot of biryani, a bowl of chickpeas, flatbread still warm from the pan, and a plate of kebabs. Ayesha spends most of dinner arguing with her cousin about cricket.

Ben sits next to Ayesha's uncle, who asks him what he knows about Pakistan. Ben admits that he knows almost nothing, except that it is next to India and next to Afghanistan, "which I always thought was in the Middle East." The uncle laughs. "Afghanistan is our neighbor, beta. Lahore and Kabul were tied together by the same roads and the same empires for centuries. The first Mughal emperor ruled from Kabul before he ever saw Lahore, and he chose to be buried in Kabul. My grandfather bought carpets that came down through the Khyber Pass."

Ben looks at Zara. Zara shrugs; her family is from Bangladesh, at the other end of South Asia. "I know Pakistan and Bangladesh used to be one country," she says. "But I don't really know what's in Pakistan, or in Afghanistan." Ben pulls out his phone and opens a map. There's a line between the two countries. So how can two places on either side of a border, with different governments and different flags, be "tied together"?

18.2 Borders and Cultural Regions

Start with an example from closer to home. The Ojibwe (Anishinaabe) people have lived around the Great Lakes for centuries, on land that today is split between Minnesota, other US states and Canada. The US-Canada border runs right through their homeland. A family in northern Minnesota and a

family in Ontario can share a language, ceremonies and relatives, even though they carry different passports.

South Asia is full of situations like this. A **country** is a political unit with a government and borders, as you learned in Chapter 1. A **cultural region** is an area where people share a language, customs or history, whether or not a border runs through it. In this chapter you'll meet two big cultural regions that cross borders:

- **The Punjab**, split in 1947 between Pakistan and India.
- **The Pashtun homeland**, split in 1893 between British India (today Pakistan) and Afghanistan.

So when you compare Pakistan and Afghanistan, ask two kinds of questions. How are the two countries governed, and what are their official languages and capitals? And which cultures, roads and families reach across the line?

18.3 Pakistan: A Country Born in 1947

Pakistan became independent on 14 August 1947, the day Pakistan celebrates as Independence Day, when British India was divided (Chapter 4). At first Pakistan had two wings, West Pakistan and East Pakistan, on opposite sides of India. In 1971, after a war, East Pakistan became the independent country of Bangladesh, which you'll meet in Chapter 19. Today's Pakistan is the old western wing.

The Islamic Republic of Pakistan

The country's full name is the **Islamic Republic of Pakistan**: a federal, parliamentary republic in which Islam is the state religion. The name was adopted in Pakistan's first constitution, which took effect on 23 March 1956. The constitution in force today dates from 1973. *Federal* means power is

shared between a national government and provincial governments. *Parliamentary* means the prime minister, who runs the government day to day, is chosen by the elected National Assembly, while the president is head of state.

As of October 2026, Pakistan's prime minister is Shehbaz Sharif, in office since March 2024, and its president is Asif Ali Zardari, who took the oath of office on 10 March 2024. Like any country's politics, Pakistan's is lively and contested, and this book leaves the arguments to the news.

How many people?

Pakistan had **255,219,554 people in 2025** (about 255 million, World Bank), making it one of the ten most populous countries on Earth. Pakistan's own 2023 census, the country's seventh, counted 241.49 million people, with a growth rate of 2.55% a year. (The two numbers differ because they are from different years and use different methods.)

About 96% of Pakistanis are Muslim, most of them Sunni, with a large Shia minority. The 2023 census counted Hindus at 1.61% of the population, the largest religious minority, and Christians at 1.37%. Some Christian leaders believe their community was undercounted. There are also smaller communities of Sikhs and Parsis, and of Ahmadis, who see themselves as Muslims but whom Pakistan's constitution has classed as non-Muslims since 1974.

Islamabad

Islamabad (*is-LAHM-ah-bahd*) is the capital of Pakistan. Its name means "City of Islam" or "City of Peace." It is a planned city, which means it was designed from scratch rather than growing over centuries. When Pakistan was founded, the capital was Karachi, a busy port on the Arabian Sea. In 1959 a commission chose a new site in the north, on the Potwar Plateau below the

Margala Hills, next to the older city of Rawalpindi, which served as the temporary capital. Construction began in 1961. The city is laid out in zones, including government, diplomatic, residential and commercial areas, a greenbelt and a national park.

Just outside Islamabad lie the ruins of Taxila, an ancient city on the UNESCO World Heritage List since 1980. From the 400s BCE to the 100s CE it was an important Buddhist center of learning, shaped in turn by Persia, Greece and Central Asia. Keep that in mind; we'll come back to those roads in Section 18.9.

18.4 The Provinces of Pakistan

The **Provinces of Pakistan** are the four large regions, each with its own elected assembly and government, into which the country is divided: Punjab, Sindh, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan. The capital city has its own federal territory, the Islamabad Capital Territory. In the far north, Gilgit-Baltistan and Azad Jammu and Kashmir are areas administered by Pakistan that are part of the larger Kashmir region, whose status is disputed among Pakistan, India and China. Pakistan administers them under special arrangements and says the region's final status should be settled by the vote the United Nations called for in 1948, India claims them as part of India, and the dispute is unresolved.

Province	Capital	Population (2023 census)	Main first languages
Punjab	Lahore	127.68 million	Punjabi, Saraiki
Sindh	Karachi	55.69 million	Sindhi, Urdu

Province	Capital	Population (2023 census)	Main first languages
Khyber Pakhtunkhwa	Peshawar	40.85 million	Pashto
Balochistan	Quetta	14.89 million	Balochi, Pashto
Islamabad Capital Territory	(Islamabad)	2.36 million	Punjabi, Urdu and others

More than half of all Pakistanis live in Punjab, and each province has its own main language: Pakistan is a country of several large peoples.

Punjab and the Punjab Region

The **Punjab Region** is the cultural and geographic region of the five rivers that feed the Indus, today divided between Pakistan's Punjab province and India's Punjab state. The name comes from Persian words for "five" and "water." The five rivers are the Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas and Sutlej. Their water and rich soil made the Punjab one of the great farming regions of the subcontinent.

In 1947 the British province of Punjab was split in two. West Punjab, slightly more than half, went to Pakistan, and East Punjab went to India. Millions of people crossed the new line in both directions, a painful story told in Chapter 4. Today most people in Pakistani Punjab are Muslim, and Sikhs are the majority in Indian Punjab. Yet people on both sides still share the Punjabi language, much of the same music and food, and in many cases family memories of the other side. Even the script tells this story: Punjabi in Pakistan

is written in Shahmukhi, a Perso-Arabic script, while in India it is mostly written in Gurmukhi.

Lahore

Lahore (لاہور, *lah-HOR*) is Pakistan's second-largest city and the capital of Punjab province. It sits on the Ravi River in the upper Indus plain. Lahore has been a royal city many times: a Ghaznavid capital in the 1100s, a favorite Mughal residence in the 1500s and 1600s, and the seat of the Sikh ruler Ranjit Singh from 1799 to 1839.

Lahore's Mughal buildings are its pride. The Lahore Fort was built in part by the emperor Akbar and expanded by the emperors who followed him. The Shalamar Gardens, laid out in 1642 for the emperor Shah Jahan, are terraced, walled gardens with hundreds of fountains. Together the fort and the gardens became a UNESCO World Heritage site in 1981. Nearby stands the Badshahi Mosque, built by the emperor Aurangzeb in 1671 to 1673, still one of the largest mosques in the world. A popular Punjabi saying claims that whoever hasn't seen Lahore hasn't really been born, and Ayesha's uncle repeats it at every family dinner.

Sindh

Sindh is Pakistan's southeastern province, the land of the lower Indus River and its delta, with Karachi as its capital. The province takes its name from the river's ancient name, Sindhu. Sindh was one of the heartlands of the Indus Valley Civilization more than 4,000 years ago, and its most famous city, Mohenjo-daro, is a UNESCO World Heritage site (1980) (Chapter 2).

Sindh also has a special place in the history of Islam in South Asia: the Arab conquest of Sindh in 711 CE was one of the first ways Islam came into the subcontinent. Today Karachi, on the Arabian Sea, is Pakistan's largest city and main port, drawing people from every part of the country. In the 2023

census, about 60% of people in Sindh spoke Sindhi as their first language and about 22% spoke Urdu.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (*KY-ber pukh-TOON-khwah*) is Pakistan's northwestern province, bordering Afghanistan, with Peshawar as its capital. Until 2010 it was called the North-West Frontier Province. Its new name joins two ideas: "Khyber," after the famous pass, and "Pakhtunkhwa," roughly "land of the Pashtuns."

The province rises from the fertile Vale of Peshawar into the Hindu Kush. Most people are Pashtuns, Pashto is the main language (spoken by 81% as a first language in the 2023 census), and nearly everyone is Muslim. Peshawar is one of the oldest cities in the region and a center of Pashtun culture.

In October 2026 the province was in the news. On 11 October the federal government declared an emergency there and imposed governor's rule, suspending the provincial government, which had been led by the PTI party. The government cited worsening law and order and militant attacks. On 15 October a joint sitting of Parliament approved the measures (news reports differed on how long governor's rule would last). PTI leaders called the move undemocratic. Events were still unfolding as this book was written.

Balochistan

Balochistan is Pakistan's westernmost province, bordering Iran and Afghanistan, with Quetta as its capital. It is the largest province by area and the most thinly populated. Much of it is dry plateau, desert and mountains outside the reach of the monsoon, and sheep raising is a major way of life.

Balochistan has two main peoples: the Baloch and the Pashtuns. In the 2023 census, about 40% of the province spoke Balochi as their first language and

about 34% spoke Pashto. Brahui and Sindhi are also spoken.

Try this

Look back at the province table. If you only met people from Lahore, what would you assume "Pakistani food" or "the Pakistani language" is? Now imagine a friend from Quetta or Karachi reading your answer. What would they add?

18.5 Urdu and Pakistan's Many Mother Tongues

Urdu as National Language

Urdu as National Language means that Urdu (اردو, *OOR-doo*) is the language Pakistan's constitution names as the language of the whole nation, even though only a small share of Pakistanis speak it as their first language. Article 251 of the 1973 constitution says that Urdu is the national language of Pakistan, that English may be used for official purposes, and that provinces may promote their own provincial languages alongside Urdu.

Urdu is written right to left in a flowing Perso-Arabic style called Nastaliq, and everyday spoken Urdu is very close to everyday Hindi, as you saw in Chapter 6.

What people speak at home

In practice, most Pakistanis grow up speaking another language at home and learn Urdu at school, on TV and in the city. Here are the most common first languages in the 2023 census:

First language (mother tongue)	Share of Pakistan's population, 2023 census
Punjabi	about 37%
Pashto	about 18%
Sindhi	about 14%
Saraiki	about 12%
Urdu	about 9%
Balochi	about 3%
Other languages	about 6%

So Urdu is everybody's second language more than it is anybody's first. That's exactly why it works as a national language: it belongs to no single province. Urdu's share has been growing, though, from about 7% in the 2017 census to about 9% in 2023, as more families in big cities raise their children in Urdu. Ayesha's family is one of them: her grandparents spoke Punjabi at home in Lahore, but her parents mostly spoke Urdu to her. English is widely used in government, law and higher education, and many Pakistanis switch between two or three languages in one conversation.

One country, many languages

If a Pakistani friend says "my language is Punjabi" or "Pashto" instead of "Urdu," they aren't being unusual. Ask "What do you speak at home?" instead of assuming.

18.6 Afghanistan: Mountains, Valleys and Many Peoples

Afghanistan is a landlocked, mountainous country where South Asia meets Central Asia and Iran, and the eighth member of SAARC, which it joined in 2007. Landlocked means it has no coastline; the nearest sea, the Arabian Sea, is about 480 km to the south. Afghanistan had **43,844,111 people in 2025** (about 44 million, World Bank).

The Hindu Kush runs through the middle of the country (Chapter 1), and most of the land gets its rain and snow in winter and spring rather than from the monsoon. For thousands of years, Afghanistan's passes linked South Asia, Central Asia, Iran and China.

Afghanistan has many peoples. Pashtuns are the largest group. Tajiks, Hazaras, Uzbeks and Turkmen are other large communities, along with many smaller ones. Nearly all Afghans are Muslim: most are Sunni, and a Shia minority (estimates range from about 10% to 15%) includes most Hazaras. Afghanistan once had Sikh and Hindu communities estimated in the hundreds of thousands in the 1970s, but nearly all have left; only small numbers remain, mostly in Kabul, Jalalabad and Ghazni.

Afghanistan was never formally colonized. Britain fought wars there in the 1800s and controlled Afghanistan's foreign relations until the Treaty of Rawalpindi in 1919.

Kabul

Kabul (کابل, *KAH-bool*) is the capital and largest city of Afghanistan. It sits about 1,800 m (5,900 ft) above sea level in a valley ringed by mountains, along the Kabul River, which flows east to join the Indus in Pakistan. People have lived at or near Kabul for about 3,500 years.

Kabul has long depended on trade, and its bazaars are famous across the region. It is also a city of many peoples: Pashtuns, Tajiks, Hazaras, Uzbeks, Turkmen and others live side by side. Babur, who founded the Mughal Empire in 1526, ruled from Kabul before he marched into India, and he chose a garden in Kabul as his final resting place. That garden, Bagh-e Babur, was restored between 2003 and 2007 and now draws more than 400,000 visitors a year.

Dari and Pashto

Dari and Pashto are Afghanistan's two official national languages, a status first set out in the 1964 constitution.

- **Dari** (دری, *dah-REE*) is the form of Persian spoken in Afghanistan. It is close enough to the Persian of Iran (Farsi) that speakers understand each other easily. Dari has long been the language that Afghans of different groups use to talk to each other, and it is understood by most people in the country.
- **Pashto** (پښتو, *PUSH-toh*) is the language of the Pashtuns, spoken on both sides of the Afghanistan-Pakistan border. As you saw above, it is also Pakistan's second-most-common first language.

Both are written in versions of the Perso-Arabic script, right to left, and both belong to the Iranian branch of the Indo-European language family. Many Afghans speak both, and many also speak Uzbek, Turkmen or another language. The 2004 constitution of the former republic gave several of these,

including Uzbek, Turkmen and Balochi, official status in areas where most people speak them.

18.7 Afghanistan Today

Afghanistan's last half century has been marked by war: a Soviet invasion and occupation (1979 to 1989), civil war, the first Taliban government (1996 to 2001), a US-led war that removed it in 2001, and two decades of an internationally backed republic.

In August 2021, as US and NATO forces withdrew, the Taliban, an Islamist movement, took control of Kabul and the country. The Taliban call their government the Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan. It is led by a supreme leader and rules by its own interpretation of Islamic law.

Most countries have not formally recognized the Taliban as Afghanistan's government. In July 2025 Russia became the first country to do so, and as of October 2026 it was still the only one, though several countries, including China and the United Arab Emirates, keep diplomatic ties and talk with Taliban officials. Much of the world's hesitation centers on restrictions on women and girls. Girls have been barred from secondary school since March 2022, and women from universities since December 2022. In August 2026, UNESCO estimated that about 2.4 million girls were shut out of secondary education, and said Afghanistan was the only country in the world with such a ban. The government has rejected calls to lift the ban, calling it an internal matter.

Culture has changed too. For example, Nowruz, the spring new year on 21 March that many Afghans have celebrated for centuries, has not been an official public holiday since 2022. As recently as 2025, the government said people could still mark it privately.

Ordinary Afghans carry on, keeping traditions alive at home and in a large worldwide diaspora. Millions of Afghans have lived as refugees in Pakistan and Iran over the decades. Since 2023, Pakistan has sent more than a million Afghans back across the border under a campaign against people living in Pakistan without legal status.

Check the date on the news

This section describes Afghanistan as of October 2026, and news here changes fast. When you read about the Taliban, remember that a government and a people are not the same thing: many Afghan families, at home and abroad, hold very different views about how their country should be run.

18.8 Pashtunwali: The Pashtun Way

The **Pashtuns** (also called Pakhtuns, and in older English "Pathans") are an ethnic group of tens of millions of people who live mainly in the region between the Hindu Kush in Afghanistan and the Indus River in Pakistan. They are the largest group in Afghanistan, and in fact the word "Afghan" once meant a Pashtun before it came to mean anyone from Afghanistan. What unites Pashtuns is their language, Pashto, along with Islam (most Pashtuns are Sunni) and a shared code of conduct.

Pashtunwali (*push-toon-WAH-lee*) is that code: the traditional, unwritten rules of honor, hospitality and justice that guide Pashtun social life. It is older than Islam in the region and is a matter of custom, not religious law, though for most Pashtuns it sits comfortably alongside their faith. Its main ideas include:

Idea	Pashto word	What it means
Hospitality	melmastia (*mel-mus-TEE-ah*)	Welcome every guest generously, whoever they are, and expect nothing back.
Sanctuary	nanawatai (*nah-nah-wah-TAI*)	Protect someone who comes to you asking for shelter, even from their enemies.
Honor	nang (*nung*)	Defend your family's honor and protect the weak.
Justice	badal (*BAH-dul*)	A wrong must be answered; this can mean revenge, but often it is settled by compensation instead.
Council	jirga (*JEER-gah*)	Settle disputes in an assembly of elders who talk until they reach agreement.

Kinship is the base of Pashtun society. Tribes trace descent from a common ancestor and are divided into clans and families.

Like any code, Pashtunwali is lived differently by different families, in the city and the village, at home and abroad. Outsiders often focus on badal and blood feuds, but hospitality is just as central. Ben's welcome at the Qureshis' table (a Punjabi family, not a Pashtun one) shows how seriously hospitality is taken across this whole region.

Whose Story?

The border between Pakistan and Afghanistan is called the Durand Line, after the British official who negotiated it with Afghanistan's ruler in 1893. It runs about 2,600 km and split the Pashtun homeland in two. Pakistan inherited the line in 1947 and treats it as a settled international border; it began building a fence along it in 2017. Every Afghan government since 1947, whoever was in power, has refused to accept the line as the border, and many have called it void because it was imposed by the British. Some Pashtuns on both sides see it as cutting through one people. Since 2025, fighting and disputes along the border have closed crossings such as Torkham several times, once for weeks. Ask a Pakistani and an Afghan to draw "the border," and you may get two different answers.

18.9 The Khyber Pass

The **Khyber Pass** (*KY-ber*) is the mountain pass that connects Peshawar in Pakistan with Kabul in Afghanistan, crossing the hills at the end of the Spin Ghar ("White Mountains") range. The pass winds about 53 km (33 miles) from near the town of Jamrud, Pakistan, to the border post of Torkham. In places it is a narrow gorge between cliffs of shale and limestone 180 to 300 m high. Its highest point, at Landi Kotal, is about 1,072 m above sea level.

Armies, traders and pilgrims have used the pass for more than 2,000 years:

- In the 500s BCE, the Persian king Darius I conquered the area around Kabul and marched through the pass to the Indus.
- In the 200s BCE, under the Mauryan emperor Ashoka, Buddhism flourished in and around the Khyber, and Buddhist stupas still stand near the pass.

- The pass was part of the Silk Road, linking Taxila (near today's Islamabad) with Kabul.
- In 1526 Babur, then ruler of Kabul, came through the Khyber before defeating the Delhi sultan at the First Battle of Panipat and founding the Mughal Empire.
- The British fought for control of the pass during the Anglo-Afghan wars of the 1800s. A railway with 34 tunnels opened in 1925 from Peshawar to near the border, though services stopped in 2007.

The pass carried traders and goods as well as armies, and it carried ideas and faiths too: Buddhism spread through these valleys in Ashoka's time, and later Muslim rulers, scholars and artists came the other way. That's what Ayesha's uncle meant when he said Lahore and Kabul were tied together. The road ran from Kabul down the Kabul River valley to Jalalabad, through the Khyber to Peshawar, past Taxila and on across the Punjab plain to Lahore and beyond to Delhi.

Since 1947 the pass has been in Pakistani territory. It is still an important road, but traffic is often interrupted by violence and by disputes between the two governments.

18.10 Heritage in Stone: Bamiyan, Jam and Pakistan's Ancient Sites

The Buddhas of Bamiyan

The **Buddhas of Bamiyan** were two giant standing statues of the Buddha carved into a sandstone cliff in the Bamiyan Valley of central Afghanistan, destroyed by the Taliban in March 2001. The larger statue was 55 m (180 ft) tall and the smaller one 38 m (125 ft). Radiocarbon dating suggests they were made in the late 500s and early 600s CE.

Why were giant Buddhas in the middle of the Hindu Kush? Bamiyan was a stopping place on a branch of the Silk Road linking China and India. Buddhist monks carved many caves into the cliffs as monasteries and chapels, some with wall paintings mixing Indian, Greek, Roman and Persian influences in the style called Gandharan art. Later, Muslim dynasties built fortresses in the valley.

In March 2001, during its first period in power, the Taliban ordered the destruction of all statues in Afghanistan and blew up both Buddhas. The destruction was condemned around the world. In 2003 UNESCO added the Cultural Landscape and Archaeological Remains of the Bamiyan Valley to the World Heritage List and to its List of World Heritage in Danger. Today the two empty niches remain. People still debate whether the statues should be rebuilt from fragments, or whether the empty niches should stay as a memorial.

The Minaret of Jam

In a remote river valley in central Afghanistan, about 1,900 m above sea level, stands the Minaret of Jam, a brick tower 65 m tall built in 1194 by the Ghurid sultan Ghiyas-od-din. It is covered in geometric patterns and a band of Arabic calligraphy in turquoise tile. UNESCO listed it as a World Heritage site in 2002, Afghanistan's first.

Pakistan's World Heritage sites

Pakistan's heritage stretches across every era of South Asian history. Here are four of its UNESCO World Heritage sites:

Site	Where	Inscribed	What it shows
Archaeological Ruins at Moenjodaro	Sindh	1980	A planned city of the Indus Valley Civilization
Taxila	Punjab, near Islamabad	1980	An ancient city and Buddhist center on the old trade routes
Buddhist Ruins of Takht-i-Bahi	Khyber Pakhtunkhwa	1980	A Buddhist monastery founded in the 1st century CE on a high hilltop
Fort and Shalamar Gardens in Lahore	Punjab	1981	Mughal palaces and gardens

Put these next to Bamiyan and Jam and a pattern appears. The Buddhist sites of Takht-i-Bahi and Taxila in Pakistan and Bamiyan in Afghanistan belong to the same Gandharan world, joined by the same roads, long before the modern border existed.

18.11 Afghan Carpets

Afghan Carpets are hand-knotted wool rugs woven in Afghanistan, especially in the north and west, in traditions passed down within families for

generations. They are one of the country's best-known crafts and an important source of income for many households.

How is a knotted carpet made? A weaver stretches strong threads on a loom. Then, row by row, she ties small knots of colored wool around those threads and cuts them short, so the cut ends stand up to form a soft, tufted surface called the pile. Weavers also make flatweave rugs, whose threads aren't knotted, along with bags and animal trappings for daily use.

Most Afghan carpet weaving was traditionally done by women of nomadic and semi-nomadic herding groups, such as the Turkmen and the Baluch, in the north and west of the country. Each tradition has its own look:

- **Turkmen carpets** are mostly red, with rows of repeated abstract motifs called guls (*goolz*). Each gul pattern was linked to a particular clan.
- **Baluch carpets** are more colorful and, while mostly abstract, often include floral designs and figures.

Hazara, Uzbek and Kyrgyz communities have their own weaving traditions too. Weaving was a family skill, passed down at home; red dyes were long made from the root of the madder plant. In refugee families of the 1980s, boys and young men also wove alongside women.

During the wars of the 1980s, millions of Afghans fled to Pakistan, and refugee weavers kept the craft alive in camps there. After Soviet troops invaded in December 1979, some weavers began making "war rugs," which worked tanks, helicopters and other military images into traditional patterns, a record of what weavers lived through. The British Museum has exhibited them as a form of history told in wool. Peshawar became the biggest market for Afghan carpets, and the carpets traveled down the same Khyber road that Ayesha's great-grandfather knew.

Carpets aren't Afghanistan's only famous craft. In 2025 UNESCO added Afghanistan's tradition of miniature painting in the style of Kamal ud-Din

Behzad, a famous painter whose style many Afghan artists still use as their model, to its list of intangible cultural heritage. In 2024 it listed the art of crafting and playing the rubab, a string instrument carved from mulberry wood and one of the oldest instruments in the region, as heritage shared by Afghanistan, Iran, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan.

18.12 Putting It Together

Back at the Qureshis', Ben has stopped eating to listen to Ayesha's uncle, which, for Ben, is a big deal. He finally understands the line on the map. It's real: it marks two countries with different governments, laws and official languages. But it doesn't mark where Punjabi or Pashto stops, where the old road ends, or where hospitality begins.

This table compares the two countries:

	Pakistan	Afghanistan
Capital	Islamabad	Kabul
Population (2025, World Bank)	255,219,554 (about 255 million)	43,844,111 (about 44 million)
Official or national languages	Urdu (national), English (official)	Dari and Pashto
Most common first language	Punjabi	No recent census; Dari is the most widely understood
Main faith	Islam (about 96%)	Islam (nearly all)

	Pakistan	Afghanistan
Coastline?	Yes, on the Arabian Sea	No, landlocked
Government (October 2026)	Federal parliamentary republic	Taliban government, recognized only by Russia
A UNESCO site	Fort and Shalamar Gardens in Lahore	Minaret of Jam; Bamiyan Valley

Diagram: Country Compare

Country Compare: Pakistan and Afghanistan

Pick a country or region in the menu. Tap a dot. Press Start to travel the Khyber road.

Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders.

The dashed orange line is the old road from Kabul to Lahore. Press Start to travel it.

Pakistan

A country

Capital
Islamabad

Population (2025)
255,219,554 (about 255 million), World Bank

Languages
Urdu is the national language; English is official. Most common first language: Punjabi (about 37%, 2023 census)

Main faith
Islam (about 96%); Hindu and Christian minorities

UNESCO site
Fort and Shalamar Gardens in Lahore (1981)

Food
Biryani, nihari and karahi; chapli kebab in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

Festivals
Eid al-Fitr, Eid al-Adha; Independence Day, 14 August

Pakistan — Compare card: country or region

Start the Khyber road | Reset

Back to Country Compare Lesson Plan

Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch18-pakistan-afghanistan-compare/main.html

Open the Country Compare fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Country Compare

sim-id: ch18-pakistan-afghanistan-compare
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Analyze
Bloom Verb: compare
Learning Objective: The learner will compare Pakistan and Afghanistan on the same set of features and analyze how cultural regions (the Punjab and the Pashtun belt) and the Khyber road connect places on both sides of today's border.

Canvas: responsive width; 700 px drawing area plus 100 px control area.

Controls: card view menu (Pakistan, Afghanistan, Punjab region, Pashtun belt), Start the Khyber road / Pause button, Reset button; click or tap any city dot.

Behavior: A schematic map of labeled dots (no borders) shows cities and heritage sites, the Hindu Kush and the Indus and Kabul rivers, with soft shaded areas for the two countries and dashed areas for the two cultural regions. The comparison card shows capital, 2025 population (World Bank), languages, main faith, a UNESCO site, foods and festivals, or a region's description. The animation starts paused; Start moves a traveler along the old road from Kabul through the Khyber Pass to Peshawar, Islamabad and Lahore, with a caption for each stop. The caption "Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders." is drawn inside the drawing area.

Start with the comparison card. Read the Pakistan card, then switch to Afghanistan and go row by row. Which rows are most alike? Which are most different? Then switch to **Punjab region** and **Pashtun belt** and watch where the shaded areas fall. Notice that each one spreads across the place where the two countries meet, or across the Pakistan-India border.

Then press **Start the Khyber road** and follow the traveler from Kabul to Lahore. Pause at the Khyber Pass. Think about what it would have meant to carry carpets, fruit or a holy book through that gorge on a camel or a horse, and why so many empires wanted to control it. Click the dots for Bamiyan, Jam and Mohenjo-daro to see how much older this region's history is than its current borders.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about a city or region they know in Pakistan or Afghanistan, or the place their own family comes from: the food, the way guests are welcomed, and the languages spoken at home. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Ask if you can take notes. If you can, bring a cup of tea or a snack to share; in many families from this region, a conversation starts with food.

Questions to ask

1. Which city, town or region does our family (or your family) come from? What do you remember most about it?
2. What did a typical meal look like there? Is there one dish that tastes like home to you?
3. When guests came to the house, what did the family always do or serve?

4. Which languages did people speak at home, at school and in the market? Which ones do you still use?
5. How has that place, or the way your family lives, changed since you were young, or since you moved?
6. What is one custom or value from that place that you hope I keep?

Listen for: which of the Provinces of Pakistan or which part of Afghanistan they mention; whether they speak Urdu, Punjabi, Pashto, Dari or another language (connect to Urdu as National Language and Dari and Pashto); and hospitality customs that echo Pashtunwali, even in families that aren't Pashtun.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare the languages your elder named with the 2023 census table in Section 18.5. Does your family's story fit the pattern (a home language plus Urdu or Dari), or is it different? If a friend interviewed someone from another region, compare how each family welcomes guests.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Afghanistan is in the Middle East.
Reality: Afghanistan is a landlocked country in south-central Asia, where South Asia meets Central Asia and Iran. It is a member of SAARC, so this book counts it as South Asian, and some scholars group it with Central Asia. Some organizations do group it with the Middle East for statistics; since 2025 the

World Bank has put Afghanistan and Pakistan in a "Middle East, North Africa, Afghanistan and Pakistan" region. Which label is used depends on the purpose.

Myth: Everyone in Pakistan speaks Urdu as their first language.
Reality: Urdu is the national language, but in the 2023 census only about 9% of Pakistanis spoke it as their first language. Punjabi (about 37%), Pashto (about 18%), Sindhi (about 14%) and Saraiki (about 12%) are all more common mother tongues. Most Pakistanis learn Urdu as a second language.

Myth: Pashtunwali is a religious law.
Reality: Pashtunwali is a customary code of honor, hospitality and justice that is older than Islam in the region. Most Pashtuns are Muslim and see the two as fitting together, but Pashtunwali comes from tribal custom, not from religious scripture or courts.

Myth: The Taliban and the people of Afghanistan are the same thing.
Reality: The Taliban have governed Afghanistan since August 2021, but Afghans are about 44 million people (2025) of many ethnic groups, languages and opinions, plus millions more in the diaspora. Many Afghans, inside and outside the country, disagree with the government's policies.

Check Yourself

1. What are the four provinces of Pakistan and their capitals?

Punjab (Lahore), Sindh (Karachi), Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (Peshawar) and Balochistan (Quetta).

2. Why is Urdu a good fit as Pakistan's national language, even though few people speak it as a first language?

Because it isn't the home language of any single large province, it belongs to everyone equally and lets Punjabi, Pashto, Sindhi, Saraiki and Balochi speakers talk to one another. Article 251 of the constitution names it the national language.

3. What are Afghanistan's two official languages, and how are they related to Pakistan?

Dari (a form of Persian) and Pashto. Pashto is also spoken by millions of Pashtuns in Pakistan, especially in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and northern Balochistan.

4. What is melmastia, and which code is it part of?

Melmastia is the duty of generous hospitality to every guest, without expecting anything back. It is one of the main ideas of Pashtunwali, the Pashtun code of conduct.

5. What happened to the Buddhas of Bamiyan, and when?

The two giant Buddha statues, 55 m and 38 m tall and carved around 1,400 to 1,500 years ago, were destroyed by the Taliban in March 2001. The valley became a UNESCO World Heritage site in 2003.

Exercises

Remember

1. Name the capitals of Pakistan and Afghanistan and give each country's 2025 population (World Bank).

> **Answer**
>
> Pakistan: Islamabad, 255,219,554 (about 255 million). Afghanistan: Kabul, 43,844,111 (about 44 million).

2. Which two cities does the Khyber Pass connect, and about how long is the pass?

> **Answer**
>
> Peshawar in Pakistan and Kabul in Afghanistan. The pass itself runs about 53 km (33 miles) from near Jamrud to the border at Torkham.

Understand

1. Explain why the Punjab Region is called a cultural region rather than a country.

> **Answer**
>
> The Punjab is an area defined by shared geography (five rivers), language (Punjabi) and culture, not by one government. Since 1947 it has been split between Pakistan's Punjab province and India's Punjab state.

2. Explain why Islamabad was built, and why it is called a planned city.

Answer

Karachi was found unsuitable as the permanent capital, so in 1959 a commission chose a new site near Rawalpindi, and construction began in 1961. It is a planned city because it was designed from scratch with separate zones for government, homes, business and parks.

Apply

1. Use the Country Compare MicroSim. Switch the card to **Pashtun belt** and list four cities inside the shaded area. Then say which country each city is in.

   Hint: tap the dots inside the dashed area.

2. A new classmate says her family speaks Saraiki at home and comes from southern Punjab. Using the census table, write two sentences you could say to show you understand where Saraiki fits among Pakistan's languages.

   Hint: look at the share of Saraiki speakers and the Punjab province row.

Analyze

1. Compare how the Durand Line and the 1947 line through the Punjab affected the peoples who lived across them. What is similar, and what is different?

   Hint: think about language, faith and what each government says about the line today.

2. The Buddhist sites of Taxila, Takht-i-Bahi and Bamiyan are now in two different countries. Analyze what this tells you about the relationship between modern borders and older cultural history.

Hint: think about the roads that connected them.

Evaluate

1. Some people want the Buddhas of Bamiyan rebuilt; others want the empty niches left as a memorial. Which position do you find more convincing, and why? Consider the views of Afghans, Buddhists around the world and historians.

   Hint: a strong answer considers at least two points of view before choosing.

2. A news site describes Afghanistan only by its government. Evaluate how fair that is to Afghans, using evidence from Sections 18.6, 18.7 and 18.11.

   Hint: think about population, languages, crafts and the diaspora.

Create

1. Design a one-page "welcome guide" for a new student whose family has just moved from Peshawar or Kabul to your town. Include three things your school could do to make them feel at home, using what you learned about hospitality and language.

   Hint: melmastia goes both ways.

2. Write a short travel diary (150 to 200 words) from a carpet trader in the 1800s carrying rugs from Kabul through the Khyber Pass to Lahore. Mention at least three real places from this chapter.

   Hint: use the MicroSim's road stops to plan the route.

Key Takeaways

- Pakistan, the Islamic Republic of Pakistan, became independent on 14 August 1947; it is a federal parliamentary republic with its capital at Islamabad and 255,219,554 people in 2025 (World Bank).
- Pakistan has four provinces, Punjab, Sindh, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan, each with its own main language; more than half of Pakistanis live in Punjab, whose capital is Lahore.
- Urdu is Pakistan's national language, but in the 2023 census only about 9% spoke it first; Punjabi, Pashto, Sindhi and Saraiki are all more common mother tongues.
- Afghanistan is a landlocked, mountainous country of many peoples with 43,844,111 people in 2025 (World Bank); Dari and Pashto are its official languages and Kabul is its capital.
- The Taliban have governed Afghanistan since August 2021; as of October 2026 only Russia formally recognized the government, and girls were barred from secondary school.
- Pashtunwali, the Pashtun code of hospitality, sanctuary, honor, justice and the jirga, is custom, not religious law, and it is shared by Pashtuns on both sides of the Durand Line.
- The Khyber Pass, the Buddhas of Bamiyan and Afghan carpets show how roads, faiths and crafts tied Kabul and Lahore together long before today's border.

You traveled the Khyber road!

You can now find Pakistan's provinces, name Afghanistan's two languages, and explain why a line on a map doesn't stop a culture. Next, in Chapter 19, we head to the far side of South Asia: the river delta of Bangladesh and the island of Sri Lanka.

Quiz: Pakistan and Afghanistan

Test your understanding of Chapter 18. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

What is the capital of Pakistan?

A. Karachi

B. Islamabad

C. Lahore

D. Peshawar

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Islamabad is a planned capital whose construction began in 1961. Karachi was Pakistan's first capital and is still its largest city, which is why it is a common wrong answer, and Lahore is the capital of Punjab province.

Concept Tested: Islamabad **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

Which two languages are the official national languages of Afghanistan?

A. Urdu and Pashto

B. Arabic and Dari

C. Uzbek and Turkmen

D. Dari and Pashto

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Dari, the form of Persian spoken in Afghanistan, and Pashto are the country's two official languages. Urdu is Pakistan's national language, and Uzbek and Turkmen were given official status only in regions where most people speak them.

Concept Tested: Dari and Pashto **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

Which of the following is NOT one of the four provinces of Pakistan?

A. Kashmir

B. Sindh

C. Balochistan

D. Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Pakistan's four provinces are Punjab, Sindh, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan. The areas of Kashmir that Pakistan administers (Gilgit-Baltistan and Azad Jammu and Kashmir) are part of a disputed region and are not provinces.

Concept Tested: Provinces of Pakistan **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 4

According to Pakistan's 2023 census, about what share of Pakistanis speak Urdu as their first language?

A. About 75%

B. About 37%

C. About 9%

D. Less than 1%

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Only about 9% of Pakistanis spoke Urdu as their first language in 2023, even though it is the national language. The 37% figure belongs to Punjabi, the most common mother tongue, and the two are easy to mix up.

Concept Tested: Urdu as National Language **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 5

Which statement best describes Pashtunwali?

A. A religious law written by Islamic scholars and enforced by courts

B. A traditional, unwritten code of honor, hospitality and justice among Pashtuns

C. The official constitution of Afghanistan

D. A style of Pashto poetry sung at weddings

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Pashtunwali is a customary code that is older than Islam in the region and includes hospitality (melmastia), sanctuary, honor, justice and the jirga. Most Pashtuns are Muslim and see the two as fitting together, but Pashtunwali is custom, not religious law.

Concept Tested: Pashtunwali **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 6

Why is the Punjab described as a cultural region rather than as a single country?

A. Its shared language and culture span Pakistan's Punjab province and India's Punjab state, which were split in 1947.

B. It is a separate country that has not yet been recognized.

C. It is a province of Afghanistan with its own language.

D. It is only a river, not a place where people live.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The Punjab, the "land of five waters," shares the Punjabi language and much culture on both sides of the 1947 line, even though it is governed by two countries. It is not a country of its own, and it is not part of Afghanistan.

Concept Tested: Punjab Region **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

Ben reads a headline that says "Afghanistan, in the Middle East..." Using the chapter, what is the most accurate way to correct it?

A. Afghanistan is in East Asia, next to China.

B. Afghanistan has a coastline on the Persian Gulf, so it is in the Middle East.

C. Afghanistan is part of India.

D. Afghanistan is a landlocked country where South Asia meets Central Asia and Iran; it belongs to SAARC, though some groupings place it differently.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Afghanistan is a SAARC member, which is why this book counts it as South Asian, and some scholars group it with Central Asia. It is landlocked, so it has no Persian Gulf coast, and it has never been part of India.

Concept Tested: Afghanistan **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

A trader in the 1800s wants to carry carpets from Kabul to Lahore by the old road. Which order of places would she pass through?

A. Kabul, Kandahar, Quetta, Karachi, Lahore

B. Kabul, Bamiyan, Jam, Lahore

C. Kabul, Jalalabad, the Khyber Pass, Peshawar, Lahore

D. Kabul, Islamabad, Peshawar, the Khyber Pass, Lahore

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The old road ran east from Kabul down to Jalalabad, through the Khyber Pass to Peshawar, and across the Punjab plain to Lahore. Option D puts the stops in the wrong order (the Khyber Pass comes before Peshawar when traveling from Kabul), and Islamabad did not exist until the 1960s.

Concept Tested: Khyber Pass **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

The Buddhist sites of Taxila and Takht-i-Bahi (in Pakistan) and Bamiyan (in Afghanistan) belong to the same Gandharan art world. What does this best suggest?

A. Pakistan and Afghanistan were always one country.

B. Old trade roads connected communities long before today's border existed, so shared culture crosses the modern line.

C. Buddhism is the main religion of both countries today.

D. The sites were built recently to attract tourists.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. These sites grew along the same roads, such as the route through the Khyber Pass, centuries before the Durand Line was drawn in 1893. Today both countries are overwhelmingly Muslim, and the sites are many centuries old.

Concept Tested: Buddhas of Bamiyan **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

---

Question 10

Turkmen carpets are mostly red with repeated motifs called guls, while Baluch carpets are more colorful and often include floral designs. What does this comparison show about Afghan carpets?

A. All Afghan carpets look the same.

B. Afghan carpets are made only in factories.

C. Afghan carpets are traditionally woven only by men in big cities.

D. Different communities have their own weaving traditions, so a carpet's style can point to the people who made it.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Afghan carpet weaving was traditionally done by women of groups like the Turkmen and Baluch, and each group's style is different; Turkmen gul patterns were even linked to particular clans. So carpets were not made only by men in cities: most weavers were women, often in herding communities.

Concept Tested: Afghan Carpets **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka

Summary

Bangladesh and Sri Lanka sit on opposite sides of the Bay of Bengal, and the land in each could hardly be more different. One is a huge, flat river delta, the other a mountainous island. This chapter tours Bangladesh first: its capital, the rivers and floods that shape daily life, the Sundarbans mangrove forest, the language movement that gave the world International Mother Language Day, and its garment and microfinance industries. Then it crosses to Sri Lanka: its capital cities, the ancient city of Anuradhapura, the Sinhala and Tamil peoples, the long civil war, Ceylon tea and the sacred mountain of Sri Pada. For both countries you'll also get a short, dated look at who is in charge as of October 2026.

Concepts Covered

1. People's Republic of Bangladesh
2. Dhaka
3. Bengal Delta
4. Sundarbans
5. Rivers and Floods
6. Ekushey February
7. Garment Industry

8. Microfinance
9. Sri Lanka
10. Colombo
11. Anuradhapura
12. Sinhala Language
13. Sri Lankan Tamils
14. Sri Lankan Civil War
15. Ceylon Tea
16. Sri Pada (Adam's Peak)

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia? for the monsoon and the great rivers
- Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition for 1947 and the Liberation War of 1971
- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts for Bangla, Sinhala and Tamil
- Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year is helpful for the April new years

Across the Bay of Bengal

Hi, I'm Mora! The shirt you're wearing may well have been sewn in Bangladesh, and the tea in your cupboard may say "Ceylon" on the box. These two countries touch your daily life more than you might think. If your family comes from either one, this chapter gives you words for the rivers, mountains and stories you hear about at home.

19.1 Two New Years in One Week

It's April, and Zara Hossain is excited. At home, her family is getting ready for Pohela Boishakh, the Bengali New Year, with new clothes, sweets and her Nanu's stories about the big parade in Dhaka. At the South Asian Student Association meeting, she brings a plate of sweets and announces, "Shubho Noboborsho! Happy New Year!"

Dilan Perera, whose family is from Kandy in Sri Lanka, looks up from his phone. "Wait, it's our New Year this week too." His family celebrates the Sinhala and Tamil New Year, with oil lamps, a special milk rice and games in the yard at his grandparents' house. "My grandmother says the exact time for lighting the hearth is set by astrologers, down to the minute."

Ben Lindqvist is lost. "Hang on. You're from Bangladesh, and you're from Sri Lanka. Those aren't even next to each other. How do you both have New Year in the same week of April? And why isn't it in January?" Zara and Dilan look at each other. Neither has ever thought about it. And Ben's next question is even bigger: "What are your countries actually like?"

19.2 A Delta and an Island

Start with a river you know. The Mississippi begins at Lake Itasca in northern Minnesota and flows about 3,766 km (2,340 miles) south to a delta in the Gulf of Mexico. A **delta** is the flat, fan-shaped land a river builds where it meets the sea, as it drops the mud and sand it has carried for hundreds of miles. Delta land is low, fertile and often flooded. New Orleans sits near the Mississippi's delta.

Now imagine a country that is almost all delta, where three great rivers come together, two of them carrying about as much water as the Mississippi or

more, and where tens of millions of people live on land only a few meters above the sea. That is Bangladesh.

Then imagine an island with mountains in the middle, beaches all around, and a history of kingdoms going back more than 2,000 years. That is Sri Lanka.

The two countries face each other across the Bay of Bengal, the big bay of the Indian Ocean east of India. The monsoon shapes both of them (Chapter 1). But one lives with rivers, and the other with the sea and the mountains. As you read, keep asking how the land shapes the way people live.

As for Ben's question about April: both new years follow old South Asian calendars that start the year in spring. In Sri Lanka, the new year marks the moment the sun moves into the sign of Aries, usually on 13 or 14 April. In Bangladesh, Pohela Boishakh (পহেলা বৈশাখ, *PO-heh-la BOI-shakh*), "the first of Boishakh," falls on 14 April. Neighbors in India, Nepal and Southeast Asia celebrate new years in the same season, as you saw in Chapter 7.

19.3 The People's Republic of Bangladesh

A country born from a language and a war

The **People's Republic of Bangladesh** is the official name of Bangladesh: a parliamentary republic in the eastern part of the old region of Bengal, independent since 1971, with Bangla (Bengali) as its state language. The name means "country of the Bengalis." Bangla (বাংলা, *BANG-lah*) is both the name of the language and an old name for the region.

Bangladesh's story runs through Chapter 4. In 1947, when British India was divided, the Muslim-majority eastern half of Bengal became East Pakistan, part of a Pakistan whose two wings were separated by the whole width of northern India. Many Bengalis felt the government in West Pakistan treated

them unfairly, starting with language, as you'll see in Section 19.6. After years of tension and a brutal war, Bangladesh declared independence on 26 March 1971, and the Liberation War ended on 16 December 1971. Its constitution was adopted on 4 November 1972.

Bangladesh had **175,686,899 people in 2025** (about 176 million, World Bank), making it one of the ten most populous countries in the world. Fit that many people into an area of about 148,000 km², about the size of Iowa, and you get one of the most densely populated large countries on Earth. In Bangladesh's 2022 census, about 91% of people were Muslim and about 8% Hindu, with smaller Buddhist and Christian communities, including Indigenous peoples such as the Chakma and Marma of the Chittagong Hill Tracts.

Bangladesh's national anthem, "Amar Shonar Bangla" ("My Golden Bengal"), was written by Rabindranath Tagore, the same poet who wrote India's anthem (Chapter 17). Tagore wrote the song in 1905, more than 40 years before either country existed.

Dhaka

Dhaka (ঢাকা, *DHAH-kah*) is the capital and largest city of Bangladesh, on the Buriganga River in the middle of the country. It is one of the most crowded cities in the world, full of rickshaws, buses, markets, mosques and universities.

Dhaka has been a capital before. In the 1600s it was the capital of the Mughal province of Bengal and was named Jahangirnagar, "city of Jahangir," after the emperor. Under the Mughals it became a center of trade and of fine cotton cloth called muslin (Chapter 12). Today the city's most famous modern landmark is the National Parliament building, the Jatiya Sangsad Bhaban, designed by the American architect Louis Kahn.

Zara's family is from Chattogram (formerly Chittagong), Bangladesh's main seaport on the Bay of Bengal, in the southeast. When her Nanu talks about

"going to Dhaka," she means a long trip to the big, busy capital.

19.4 The Bengal Delta, Rivers and Floods

The world's largest delta

The **Bengal Delta** (also called the Ganges-Brahmaputra Delta) is the vast, low plain built by the Ganges, Brahmaputra and Meghna rivers where they flow into the Bay of Bengal. It is the largest river delta in the world, and most of Bangladesh, along with the Indian state of West Bengal, sits on it.

Three great rivers meet here, and in Bangladesh they go by local names:

River	Name in Bangladesh	Where it comes from
Ganges	Padma	From the Himalaya, across northern India
Brahmaputra	Jamuna	From Tibet, through Northeast India
Meghna	Meghna	From the hills of Northeast India and eastern Bangladesh

The Padma and the Jamuna join, then meet the Meghna, and the combined water pours into the sea. These rivers carry huge amounts of mud from the Himalaya, and over thousands of years that mud built the land. About 83% of Bangladesh is floodplain, land that rivers flood and rebuild.

Rivers and Floods

Rivers and Floods in Bangladesh means the yearly rhythm in which monsoon rain and Himalayan meltwater raise the rivers, which spread across the low delta, bringing both fertile soil and danger. Life in Bangladesh moves with this rhythm.

Most of the water in Bangladesh's rivers comes from rain that falls outside the country, upstream in India, Nepal, Bhutan and China. It flows in mostly through the Ganges, the Brahmaputra and the Meghna. So when heavy monsoon rain falls on India, Nepal, Bhutan and Tibet, Bangladesh feels it.

- **In an average year,** about 21% of Bangladesh floods (about 31,000 km²).
- **In severe years,** much more. In 1998, more than two-thirds of the country was under water, including half of Dhaka.

Floods are not only disasters. A normal flood soaks the fields and leaves behind fresh silt, the fine mud that makes delta soil so fertile for rice, jute and fish. Many farmers depend on it. The trouble comes when floods are too high, too long, or arrive at the wrong time.

The coast faces another danger: cyclones, the Indian Ocean's hurricanes. The Bhola cyclone of November 1970 killed at least 300,000 people and possibly as many as 500,000, the deadliest tropical cyclone on record. Since then, Bangladesh has built cyclone shelters along the coast and trained tens of thousands of volunteers to warn villages, and cyclone deaths have fallen sharply.

Think about it

Most of Bangladesh's river water comes from other countries. What kinds of agreements might Bangladesh need with its neighbors, and why would sharing rivers be tricky?

19.5 The Sundarbans

The **Sundarbans** (সুন্দরবন, *SHOON-dor-bon*) is the world's largest mangrove forest, on the coast of the Bengal Delta, shared by Bangladesh and India. Its name means "beautiful forest" in Bangla, and may refer to the sundari trees that grow there.

A **mangrove** is a tree that grows in salty coastal water, standing on tangled roots, some of which poke up out of the mud to breathe. The Sundarbans covers about 10,000 km², and about 60% of it lies in Bangladesh. It is a maze of tidal rivers, mudflats and small islands that flood and drain twice a day with the tides.

The forest is famous for the Bengal tiger, which here swims between islands, along with about 260 bird species and estuarine crocodiles. UNESCO listed India's part of the Sundarbans as a World Heritage site in 1987 and Bangladesh's part in 1997. The mangroves also protect the coast, softening storm surges from cyclones before they reach villages.

People live around the forest's edges and enter it to fish, collect honey and cut wood, which can be dangerous because of the tigers. Communities living near the Sundarbans have long told stories of Bonbibi, a forest guardian honored by both Muslim and Hindu families, which you can explore with your elders.

19.6 Ekushey February: Dying for a Language

Ekushey February (একুশে ফেব্রুয়ারি, *ay-KOO-sheh FEB-roo-ah-ree*), "the twenty-first of February," is the day in 1952 when students in Dhaka were killed while protesting for Bangla to be a state language of Pakistan, now remembered in Bangladesh as Language Martyrs' Day and around the world as International Mother Language Day.

After 1947, Pakistan's leaders wanted Urdu to be the only national language. But most people in East Pakistan spoke Bangla, and in fact Bangla speakers were the majority of all Pakistanis. Students at the University of Dhaka and others organized protests. On 21 February 1952 they defied a ban on gatherings, and police opened fire. Several protesters were killed.

The killings strengthened the movement. In 1956, Pakistan made Bengali one of its official languages. The language movement also helped build the Bengali national identity that led to independence in 1971.

Today, every 21 February, people in Bangladesh walk barefoot at dawn to the Shaheed Minar (Martyrs' Monument) near Dhaka Medical College to lay flowers. In 1999, UNESCO declared 21 February **International Mother Language Day**, so the whole world now marks a date that began in Dhaka.

Zara thinks about this a lot. She understands Bangla but usually answers her Nanu in English. Knowing that students died for the right to speak it makes her want to try harder.

19.7 Making a Living: Garments and Microfinance

The Garment Industry

Bangladesh's **Garment Industry** is the large, mostly export-oriented industry of factories that sew clothing for brands around the world, the country's biggest source of export earnings. Look at the tags on your T-shirts and jeans: "Made in Bangladesh" is very common.

- In the 2024-25 fiscal year, Bangladesh's ready-made garment exports were worth about 39 billion US dollars.
- Garments made up more than four-fifths of the country's export earnings in that period.

- Millions of people work in the factories, and many of them are women.

The industry has brought jobs and growth, but it has also brought hard questions about pay and safety. On 24 April 2013, the Rana Plaza building near Dhaka, which held several garment factories, collapsed. The final death toll was 1,134 people, most of them garment workers. The disaster led to new building-safety agreements between brands, unions and factory owners. Many people around the world began asking who made their clothes and under what conditions.

Microfinance

Microfinance is the practice of giving very small loans and other banking services to poor people, especially women, who have no property to offer as security and cannot borrow from ordinary banks. A small loan might let someone buy a cow, a sewing machine or stock for a small shop.

Bangladesh made microfinance famous. In 1976, Muhammad Yunus, an economics professor at the University of Chittagong, began a research project lending tiny sums to villagers in Jobra, near the university. In 1983 it became the Grameen Bank, an independent bank. "Grameen" means "of the village." Its borrowers were mostly women, organized in small groups that supported one another.

In 2006, Muhammad Yunus and Grameen Bank jointly won the Nobel Peace Prize for their efforts to create development "from below." Microfinance spread to dozens of countries, including the United States. Economists still debate how much it reduces poverty on its own, and some borrowers have struggled with debt.

19.8 Bangladesh Today

Bangladesh's politics have changed quickly in the last few years, so here is a short, dated summary.

- **July-August 2024:** Student-led protests against a quota system for government jobs grew into a nationwide uprising against the government of Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina, who had governed since 2009. A United Nations human rights report released in February 2025 estimated that as many as 1,400 people may have been killed between 1 July and 15 August 2024, and it blamed most of the serious violations on the former government and its security forces. Hasina's supporters rejected the report as inaccurate. On 5 August 2024, Hasina resigned and left for India.
- **August 2024 to February 2026:** An interim government led by Muhammad Yunus, the Nobel laureate, as chief adviser, took office on 8 August 2024. In November 2025, a Bangladeshi tribunal sentenced Hasina, in her absence, to death for crimes against humanity over the crackdown. She rejected the verdict and the tribunal. Her party, the Awami League, was barred from the next election.
- **February 2026:** A general election was held on 12 February 2026, along with a referendum that approved a package of reforms known as the July Charter. The Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) and its allies won more than two-thirds of the seats. Its leader, Tarique Rahman, was sworn in as prime minister on 17 February 2026, and the Jamaat-e-Islami party and its allies became the main opposition.
- **July-August 2026:** President Mohammed Shahabuddin resigned for health reasons on 24 July 2026. Parliament elected Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir of the BNP, who was sworn in as president on 21 August 2026.

As of October 2026, Tarique Rahman is prime minister and Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir is president. Bangladeshis, at home and abroad, hold strongly different views about these events, and families may disagree at the same

dinner table. This book describes what happened and leaves the arguments to the news.

Ask, don't assume

Politics in Bangladesh and Sri Lanka can be painful family topics. If you want to ask an elder about them, start with "What do you remember?" rather than "Who was right?"

19.9 Sri Lanka: An Island Nation

From Ceylon to Sri Lanka

Sri Lanka is an island country in the Indian Ocean, just across the narrow Palk Strait from the southeast tip of India, independent since 1948 and called Ceylon until 1972. Its official name today is the Democratic Socialist Republic of Sri Lanka. Europeans called the island Ceylon; the Portuguese and Dutch ruled its coasts, and the British ruled the whole island. It became independent on 4 February 1948 as the Dominion of Ceylon, and in 1972 it became a republic and took the name Sri Lanka (ශ්‍රී ලංකා in Sinhala).

Sri Lanka had **21,756,000 people in 2025** (about 22 million, World Bank). Its own 2024 census, released in October 2025, counted 21,781,800 people.

The island is not part of India, but the two are close neighbors. A narrow, shallow strait, the Palk Strait, separates them, and a chain of shoals and sandbanks almost links them. Sri Lanka has its own government, flag, currency (the Sri Lankan rupee) and history going back thousands of years.

Peoples and faiths

According to the 2024 census:

Group	Share of Sri Lanka's people (2024)
Sinhalese	74.1%
Sri Lankan Tamils	12.3%
Sri Lankan Moors (most of the island's Muslims)	10.5%
Indian-origin (Hill Country) Tamils	2.8%
Burghers, Malays, Veddas and others	0.3%

By religion, the census counted about 69.8% Buddhists, 12.6% Hindus, 10.7% Muslims and about 6.9% Christians (5.6% Roman Catholic and 1.3% other Christians). Notice that faith and language don't line up neatly: most Sinhalese are Buddhist and most Tamils are Hindu, but there are Sinhalese and Tamil Christians, and Sri Lankan Muslims mostly speak Tamil.

The Sinhala Language

The **Sinhala Language** (සිංහල, *SING-ha-la*) is the language of the Sinhalese people, the majority of Sri Lankans, an Indo-Aryan language with its own rounded script, related to the languages of North India and most closely to Dhivehi, the language of the Maldives. Sinhala is spoken by about 16 million people. Its rounded letters are written left to right, like Hindi or Bangla, and the language has a written history of more than 2,000 years, starting with inscriptions in a Prakrit close to the languages of the Buddha's time.

Language became the center of a bitter political fight. In 1956, the Sinhala Only Act made Sinhala the sole official language of Ceylon, replacing English and leaving out Tamil, the first language of about 29% of the population at the time. For many Tamils it became a symbol of being shut out of government jobs, schools and courts. In 1987 a constitutional amendment made Tamil an official language too, with English as the "link language." Today Sinhala and Tamil are both official languages.

Sri Lankan Tamils

Sri Lankan Tamils are the Tamil-speaking people whose ancestors have lived in Sri Lanka for many centuries, mostly in the north and east of the island, with a long history centered on the Jaffna Peninsula. They are different from the Indian-origin, or Hill Country, Tamils, whose ancestors were brought from South India by the British in the 1800s and 1900s to work on coffee and tea plantations.

The Jaffna Peninsula, in the far north, is the heartland of Sri Lankan Tamil culture, with Hindu temples, its own style of Tamil speech and food, and a literary tradition that goes back to the medieval Jaffna Kingdom. Tamils celebrate the April new year as Puthandu (புத்தாண்டு, *POOT-tahn-doo*), "new year," at the same time as Sinhalese families celebrate Aluth Avurudda. That is why Dilan called it the "Sinhala and Tamil New Year."

19.10 Colombo and Anuradhapura

Colombo

Colombo (කොළඹ, *koh-LUM-boh*) is Sri Lanka's largest city and its commercial capital, a major port on the west coast. Colombo's harbor has been busy for centuries, visited by Arab, Portuguese, Dutch and British ships, and it is still a major port today.

Sri Lanka has two capitals. In 1982, Parliament moved to a new building in Sri Jayawardenepura Kotte, a suburb right next to Colombo, which is the official legislative capital. Colombo remains the commercial capital and the seat of the president's offices and the courts. Most people, and most maps, still think of Colombo as "the capital."

Anuradhapura

Anuradhapura (*uh-noo-RAH-duh-POO-ruh*) is an ancient royal capital in the dry north-central plains of Sri Lanka and a holy city for Buddhists. It flourished as a political and religious capital for about 1,300 years, until it was abandoned after an invasion in 993 CE.

According to Buddhist tradition, in the 200s BCE, the nun Sanghamitta, daughter of the Indian emperor Ashoka (Chapter 2), brought a cutting of the tree under which the Buddha reached enlightenment at Bodh Gaya. The tree that grew from it, the Jaya Sri Maha Bodhi, still stands in Anuradhapura and is honored by Buddhist pilgrims as one of the oldest planted trees with a recorded history. Around it stand huge dome-shaped Buddhist monuments called stupas, monasteries, palaces and ancient water reservoirs. UNESCO listed the Sacred City of Anuradhapura as a World Heritage site in 1982.

Later capitals moved south, to Polonnaruwa and eventually to Kandy in the central hills. Kandy was the capital of the last independent Sinhalese kingdom until the British took it in 1815, and it is home to the Temple of the Tooth Relic, one of the most important Buddhist sites in the world. Dilan's family is from Kandy, and his grandmother visits the temple on full-moon days.

19.11 The Sri Lankan Civil War

A hard chapter of history

This section is about a war that many families lived through, on every side. Some classmates may have relatives who were killed, displaced or who fought. Read it with care, and talk about it with respect.

The **Sri Lankan Civil War** was an armed conflict from 1983 to 2009 between the government of Sri Lanka and the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE, also called the Tamil Tigers), an armed group fighting for an independent Tamil state, Tamil Eelam, in the north and east of the island.

How it began

The roots of the war lay in the years after independence. Many Tamils felt shut out by laws like the Sinhala Only Act and by policies they saw as favoring the Sinhalese majority. Anti-Tamil riots broke out several times, including in 1958. In 1976 the main Tamil political parties called for a separate state, and armed groups, the strongest of which became the LTTE, began attacks.

In July 1983, the LTTE killed 13 soldiers in an ambush in the north. Anti-Tamil riots followed in Colombo and across the country, known as Black July: over about a week, mobs attacked and killed Tamil civilians and burned homes and shops. Estimates of the dead range from about 400 to 3,000, and about 150,000 people were made homeless. Many historians date the start of the civil war to these events.

A long war

The war lasted 26 years. An Indian Peace Keeping Force was sent to the north and east under a 1987 accord between India and Sri Lanka; it became

caught up in fighting with the LTTE and withdrew in 1990. A ceasefire brokered by Norway was signed in February 2002, but it broke down, and full-scale war resumed. In May 2009, the Sri Lankan military defeated the LTTE, and its leader was killed.

The suffering touched every community. The LTTE carried out suicide bombings, assassinated political leaders and attacked Sinhalese and Muslim civilians, and it used child soldiers. Government forces were accused of killing and disappearing Tamil civilians, especially in the final months, when hundreds of thousands of civilians were trapped in a small area of the northeast. Hundreds of thousands of people, mostly Tamils, were displaced, and many fled abroad, building large Sri Lankan Tamil communities in Canada, the United Kingdom and elsewhere.

How many died?

Numbers are uncertain and painful, so scholars give ranges:

- Shortly after the war ended, the United Nations estimated that **80,000 to 100,000 people** had been killed since the conflict began in the early 1980s.
- A UN panel of experts reported in 2011 that credible sources estimated there could have been **as many as 40,000 civilian deaths** in the final phase of the war in 2009, many of them from shelling. The panel found credible allegations of serious violations by both the government and the LTTE.
- The Sri Lankan government has given much lower figures for the final months and rejected the panel's findings.

Whose Story?

Sri Lankans tell the story of 2009 in very different ways. For many Sinhalese, and for the government, May 2009 marks the defeat of a group that had bombed buses, temples and markets for decades, and it is remembered as the end of terror and the return of peace. For many Tamils, at home and in the diaspora, the same weeks are remembered as a time of mass civilian death, and 18 May is a day of mourning. Sri Lankan Muslims remember being expelled from the north by the LTTE in October 1990 and being caught between both sides. Human rights groups and the United Nations have called for independent investigations of what happened, while successive governments have resisted international inquiries.

Not a religious war

Because most Sinhalese are Buddhist and most Tamils are Hindu, people sometimes call it a religious war. It wasn't, mainly. The conflict was about ethnicity, language, political power and land. The LTTE's goal was a Tamil homeland, not a Hindu one, and there were Christians on both sides. Religion was part of many people's identities, but it was not what the two sides were fighting over.

19.12 Ceylon Tea and the Hill Country

Ceylon Tea is the black tea grown on Sri Lanka's hill-country plantations, still sold around the world under the island's old name. It is one of Sri Lanka's best-known exports: in 2025, tea exports earned more than 1.5 billion US dollars.

Tea isn't native to Sri Lanka. In the 1800s, British planters grew coffee in the hills. Then, starting in 1869, a fungus called coffee leaf rust destroyed the

coffee plantations. Planters switched to tea, which a British planter named James Taylor had begun growing commercially in 1867. Within a few decades, the green, terraced slopes of the central highlands were covered in tea bushes.

The plantations depended on workers brought by the British from South India, the ancestors of today's Hill Country Tamils. For generations, many lived in crowded housing on the estates, with low pay, and a 1948 citizenship law left most of them without Sri Lankan citizenship for decades. Their descendants still make up much of the tea workforce, and many families today are still pushing for better wages and housing.

19.13 Sri Pada (Adam's Peak)

Sri Pada (Adam's Peak) is a cone-shaped mountain 2,243 m (7,359 ft) high in central Sri Lanka, sacred to people of several faiths because of a footprint-shaped mark in the rock near its summit. Sri Pada (ශ්‍රී පාද) means "sacred footprint."

Each faith tells its own story about that mark:

Tradition	Whose footprint?
Buddhist	The Buddha's
Sri Lankan Hindu	Shiva's (its Tamil name, Sivanolipatha Malai, refers to Shiva)
Some Muslim and Christian traditions	Adam's, from his first step on Earth after leaving paradise (hence "Adam's Peak")

Pilgrims climb mostly between December and May, often at night by lit stairways, to reach the top at sunrise. At dawn, the mountain casts a perfect triangle of shadow across the plains below. Pilgrims of different faiths climb the same steps in the same crowd, and each honors the mark in their own way.

19.14 Sri Lanka Today

Like Bangladesh, Sri Lanka has been through big changes recently.

- **2022 economic crisis:** After years of heavy debt, tax cuts and lost tourism, Sri Lanka ran out of foreign currency. In April 2022 the government announced it was defaulting on its foreign debt, the first default in its history. Fuel, food and medicine ran short, and huge protests, called the Aragalaya ("struggle"), filled the streets. President Gotabaya Rajapaksa left the country and resigned in July 2022, and Parliament elected Ranil Wickremesinghe to serve the rest of his term.
- **Recovery:** In March 2023, the International Monetary Fund approved a four-year loan program of about 3 billion US dollars, and the economy began to stabilize.
- **2024 elections:** Anura Kumara Dissanayake, of the National People's Power (NPP) alliance, won the presidential election and took office on 23 September 2024. In the parliamentary election of 14 November 2024, the NPP won 159 of 225 seats, the first time a single party won a two-thirds majority under the proportional voting system Sri Lanka has used since 1989. Harini Amarasuriya became prime minister.
- **Cyclone Ditwah:** In late November 2025, Cyclone Ditwah brought catastrophic floods and landslides. By early December, the Disaster Management Center reported more than 600 deaths, with Kandy District hit hardest.

- **2026:** In May 2026, the IMF completed another review of Sri Lanka's program, describing performance as generally strong while warning about the cyclone's aftermath. On 4 October 2026, IMF staff reached agreement on the seventh review, with the next payment of about 345 million US dollars depending on a 2027 budget that fits the program.

As of October 2026, Anura Kumara Dissanayake is president. Sri Lankans still disagree about what caused the crisis and what the country should do next.

19.15 Putting It Together

Back at the club meeting, Ben has eaten most of Zara's sweets and is now trying Dilan's milk rice. He's figured out the April question: both families follow spring calendars that are much older than the January one. And he's starting to see that "what is your country like?" has a different answer depending on the land.

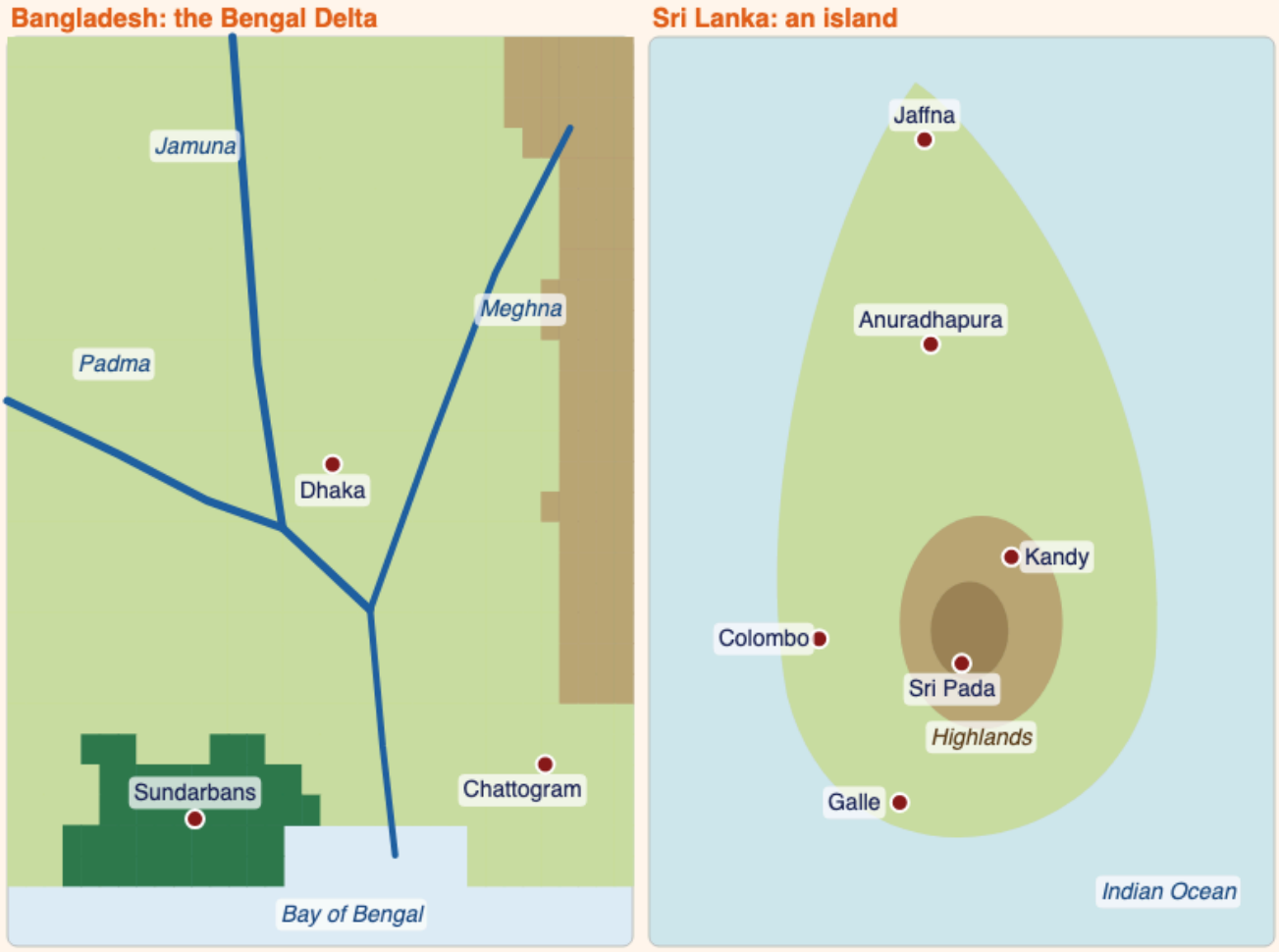
	Bangladesh	Sri Lanka
Official name	People's Republic of Bangladesh	Democratic Socialist Republic of Sri Lanka
Capital	Dhaka	Sri Jayawardenepura Kotte (legislative); Colombo (commercial)
Population (2025, World Bank)	175,686,899 (about 176 million)	21,756,000 (about 22 million)
Land	Low, flat river delta	Island with central highlands

	Bangladesh	Sri Lanka
Independence	26 March 1971 (declared); war ended 16 December 1971	4 February 1948
Main languages	Bangla	Sinhala and Tamil (official); English (link)
Main faiths	Islam (about 91%), Hinduism	Buddhism (about 70%), Hinduism, Islam, Christianity
New year in April	Pohela Boishakh (14 April)	Sinhala and Tamil New Year (13 or 14 April)
A UNESCO site	The Sundarbans (1997)	Sacred City of Anuradhapura (1982)
Government (October 2026)	PM Tarique Rahman (BNP), since February 2026	President Anura Kumara Dissanayake (NPP), since September 2024

Diagram: Delta and Island

Delta and Island: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka

Raise the monsoon slider to flood the delta. Tap any dot for a card.



Land under water: 0% (illustrative)

Average year: about 21%. 1998: more than two-thirds.

Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders.

Compare the two

Bangladesh: 175,686,899 people (2025, World Bank), most living on a flat, low river delta. Sri Lanka: 21,756,000 people (2025, World Bank) on an island whose central highlands catch the monsoon rains.

Monsoon river level: 0%

Average year | Extreme year (1998) | Dry season

[Back to Delta and Island Lesson Plan]

Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch19-bangladesh-srilanka-compare/main.html

Open the Delta and Island fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Delta and Island

sim-id: ch19-bangladesh-srilanka-compare
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: explain, compare
Learning Objective: The learner will explain how geography shapes life in each country: the floods of the low Bengal Delta in Bangladesh and the highlands, coasts and ancient capitals of Sri Lanka.

Canvas: responsive width; 830 px drawing area plus 100 px control area.

Controls: monsoon river level slider; Average year, Extreme year (1998) and Dry season buttons; click or tap any dot.

Behavior: Left panel: a schematic delta where the Padma, Jamuna and Meghna rivers meet and flow to the Bay of Bengal, with dots for Dhaka, Chattogram and the Sundarbans. Raising the slider floods the lowest land first (near the rivers and coast) and reports the share of land under water, labeled illustrative; presets match the documented average (about 21%) and 1998 (more than two-thirds). Right panel: a stylized island (not a traced outline) with schematic central highlands and dots for Jaffna, Anuradhapura, Kandy, Sri Pada, Colombo and Galle. A card shows the 2025 populations (World Bank) or the selected place. The caption "Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders." appears inside the drawing area.

Start on the delta. Press **Average year** and watch where the blue spreads: along the three rivers and toward Dhaka and the coast. Then press **Extreme year (1998)**. Notice the land that stays dry: the higher ground in the north and the hills in the east. Ask yourself where you would build a village, a school

or a cyclone shelter. Tap the Sundarbans to remember how the mangroves protect the coast when the sea rises.

Then switch your eyes to the island. Tap Anuradhapura, Kandy and Colombo in order: you're following the island's capitals from ancient times to today. Tap Sri Pada and notice that it sits right in the highlands, where the tea grows and where Cyclone Ditwah's landslides hit hardest. Finally, compare: in Bangladesh, the danger and the gift both come from rivers; in Sri Lanka, the mountains catch the rain and shape where people live.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about rivers, rain, monsoons and storms where they grew up; the language they are proudest of; tea; and how they celebrated the new year. If your family is from Bangladesh or Sri Lanka, start there; if not, ask about any of these in their own home region. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Make a cup of tea together, or bring a new-year sweet. It's an easy way to begin, and it may remind them of a story.

Questions to ask

1. What did the monsoon season feel like where you grew up? Do you remember a big flood, cyclone or storm?
2. Which language did you grow up speaking, and how do you feel when you hear it far from home?

3. How did your family celebrate the new year? What did you eat, wear or do?
4. What did tea mean in your home? Who made it, and when?
5. How has your home town or village changed since you were young, or since you left?
6. What is one thing about our language or culture that you hope I keep?

Listen for: memories of Rivers and Floods or cyclones that connect to life on the Bengal Delta; pride in a language that echoes Ekushey February or the history of the Sinhala Language and Tamil; and rituals around Ceylon Tea or the April new year.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's memory of the monsoon with what this chapter says about floods in Bangladesh. Was the rain mostly a danger, a blessing, or both? If a friend interviewed someone from a different country, compare how each family celebrates the new year.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Bangladesh is mostly desert or dry land.
Reality: Bangladesh is one of the wettest, greenest countries in the world. Most of it is a low river delta, about 83% of it floodplain, and in an average year about 21% of the country floods.

Myth: Sri Lanka is part of India.
Reality: Sri Lanka is an independent island country, independent since 4 February 1948, with its own government, languages, currency and history. India is its close neighbor across the narrow Palk Strait.

Myth: The Sri Lankan civil war was a religious war between Buddhists and Hindus.
Reality: The war (1983 to 2009) was mainly about ethnicity, language, political power and land, between the government and the LTTE, which fought for a separate Tamil state. Religion overlapped with ethnic identity, but it was not the main cause, and there were Christians and others on both sides.

Myth: Ceylon tea is a native Sri Lankan plant that has always grown there.
Reality: British planters introduced tea as a commercial crop in 1867 and expanded it after coffee leaf rust destroyed the coffee plantations from 1869. The plantations relied on workers brought from South India.

Check Yourself

1. Which three rivers meet in the Bengal Delta, and what are two of them called in Bangladesh?

The Ganges, the Brahmaputra and the Meghna. In Bangladesh the Ganges is called the Padma and the Brahmaputra the Jamuna.

2. What happened on 21 February 1952, and how is the day remembered worldwide?

Students in Dhaka were killed by police while protesting for Bangla to be a state language of Pakistan. Since 1999, UNESCO has marked 21 February as International Mother Language Day.

3. What is microfinance, and who won the Nobel Peace Prize for it in 2006?

Microfinance means very small loans and banking services for poor people who can't borrow from ordinary banks. Muhammad Yunus and Grameen Bank shared the 2006 Nobel Peace Prize.

4. What is the difference between Sri Lankan Tamils and Hill Country Tamils?

Sri Lankan Tamils have lived on the island for many centuries, mostly in the north and east. Hill Country (Indian-origin) Tamils descend from workers the British brought from South India in the 1800s and 1900s to work on plantations.

5. Why is Sri Pada sacred to more than one faith?

A footprint-shaped mark near the summit is honored by Buddhists as the Buddha's, by many Sri Lankan Hindus as Shiva's, and in some Muslim and Christian traditions as Adam's.

Exercises

Remember

1. Give the capital and 2025 population (World Bank) of Bangladesh and of Sri Lanka.

> **Answer**
>
> Bangladesh: Dhaka, 175,686,899 (about 176 million). Sri Lanka: Sri Jayawardenepura Kotte (legislative) and Colombo (commercial), 21,756,000 (about 22 million).

2. When did the Sri Lankan Civil War begin and end, and what range of deaths did the UN estimate soon after it ended?

> **Answer**
>
> It ran from 1983 to May 2009. The UN estimated 80,000 to 100,000 people killed over the whole conflict.

Understand

1. Explain why floods in Bangladesh can be both harmful and helpful.

> **Answer**
>
> Big floods destroy homes, crops and lives, but normal floods water the fields and leave fresh silt that keeps delta soil fertile for rice, jute and fish.

2. Explain how the Sinhala Only Act of 1956 contributed to tensions that led to the civil war.

Answer

It made Sinhala the only official language and left out Tamil, so many Tamils felt shut out of government jobs, schools and courts. It became a symbol of discrimination that fed the demand for a separate Tamil state.

Apply

1. Use the Delta and Island MicroSim. Press **Average year** and **Extreme year (1998)**. Name two places on the delta that stay dry in an average year and one that floods. Then explain where you would build a cyclone shelter and why. *Hint: look at the hills, the rivers and the coast.*
2. Your club is planning a joint Pohela Boishakh and Sinhala and Tamil New Year event in April. Using the chapter, write a short announcement that explains to non-South Asian students why both new years fall in the same week. *Hint: think about the sun and spring calendars.*

Analyze

1. Compare the role of language in Ekushey February (Bangladesh) and the Sinhala Only Act (Sri Lanka). What is similar about how language policy affected each country? *Hint: in both cases, a government chose one language for everyone.*
2. Analyze why the Garment Industry and Microfinance both matter especially for women in Bangladesh, and what risks each carries. *Hint: think about wages, safety, loans and debt.*

Evaluate

3. The "Whose Story?" box shows that Sri Lankans remember May 2009 very differently. Evaluate how a textbook, a museum or a memorial could fairly present the end of the war. What would you include, and what would you avoid? *Hint: consider Sinhalese, Tamil and Muslim families, and the UN's ranges.*
4. Some people say "Made in Bangladesh" labels mean we should stop buying clothes from Bangladesh; others say that would hurt the workers. Evaluate both views using evidence from the chapter. *Hint: think about the jobs the industry creates and the lessons of Rana Plaza.*

Create

5. Design a one-page "Delta and Island" travel guide for a student visiting both countries. Include one natural wonder, one historic site and one food or drink from each, using places from this chapter. *Hint: the Sundarbans, Anuradhapura, Sri Pada and Ceylon tea are good starting points.*
6. Write a short diary entry (150 to 200 words) from a student in Dhaka on 21 February, walking to the Shaheed Minar at dawn. Describe what they see and why the day matters to them. *Hint: use the facts from Section 19.6, and do not invent a real person's words.*

Key Takeaways

- Bangladesh, the People's Republic of Bangladesh, became independent in 1971; its capital is Dhaka and it had 175,686,899 people in 2025 (World Bank).
- Most of Bangladesh sits on the Bengal Delta, the world's largest, where the Padma, Jamuna and Meghna meet; about 21% of the country floods

in an average year, and floods bring both danger and fertile silt.

- The Sundarbans, the world's largest mangrove forest, protects the coast and shelters Bengal tigers; Ekushey February (21 February 1952) is now International Mother Language Day.
- Garments make up more than four-fifths of Bangladesh's exports, and Grameen Bank's microfinance won the 2006 Nobel Peace Prize; since February 2026, Tarique Rahman has been prime minister.
- Sri Lanka (Ceylon until 1972) is an island of 21,756,000 people (2025, World Bank), mostly Sinhala-speaking Buddhists, with large Tamil, Muslim and Christian communities; Colombo is its commercial capital and Anuradhapura its ancient one.
- The Sri Lankan Civil War (1983 to 2009) was mainly about ethnicity, language and power; the UN estimated 80,000 to 100,000 deaths, and families remember it in very different ways.
- Ceylon tea and Sri Pada show the island's layered history; after the 2022 crisis, President Anura Kumara Dissanayake has led Sri Lanka since September 2024.

You crossed the Bay of Bengal!

You can now explain why Bangladesh lives with its rivers, why Sri Lanka's history climbs into the hills, and why Zara and Dilan both celebrate New Year in April. Next, in Chapter 20, we head up into the Himalaya and out to the coral atolls: Nepal, Bhutan and the Maldives.

Quiz: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka

Test your understanding of Chapter 19. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

Which three rivers meet to form the Bengal Delta?

A. The Indus, the Ganges and the Yamuna

B. The Mekong, the Brahmaputra and the Irrawaddy

C. The Ganges, the Brahmaputra and the Meghna

D. The Padma, the Indus and the Kaveri

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The Ganges (called the Padma in Bangladesh), the Brahmaputra (called the Jamuna) and the Meghna meet and flow into the Bay of Bengal. The Indus flows through Pakistan to the Arabian Sea, far to the west.

Concept Tested: Bengal Delta **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

What does Ekushey February commemorate?

A. Students killed in Dhaka on 21 February 1952 while protesting for Bangla as a state language

B. The day Bangladesh declared independence in 1971

C. The founding of Grameen Bank

D. The first Bengali New Year parade in Dhaka

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. On 21 February 1952, police fired on students protesting for Bangla. The day is now Language Martyrs' Day in Bangladesh and, since 1999, UNESCO's International Mother Language Day. Independence was declared on 26 March 1971, a different date.

Concept Tested: Ekushey February **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

When did the Sri Lankan Civil War take place?

A. 1948 to 1972

B. 1971 to 1983

C. 1990 to 2002

D. 1983 to 2009

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The war began in 1983 and ended in May 2009 with the military defeat of the LTTE. 1948 is the year of independence and 1972 the year Ceylon became Sri Lanka. In 2002 a ceasefire was signed, but it later broke down.

Concept Tested: Sri Lankan Civil War **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 4

Why can monsoon floods in Bangladesh be helpful as well as harmful?

A. Because floods only happen in the desert parts of the country

B. Because normal floods water the fields and leave fresh silt that keeps the soil fertile

C. Because all of the flood water comes from rain inside Bangladesh

D. Because floods stop the rivers from carrying mud

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. A normal flood soaks the fields and deposits silt for rice, jute and fish, while extreme floods destroy homes and crops. Option C is a common mistake: most of the river water comes from outside Bangladesh.

Concept Tested: Rivers and Floods **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 5

Which statement best explains how Ceylon tea came to Sri Lanka?

A. British planters introduced it as a crop in 1867 and expanded it after coffee leaf rust destroyed the coffee plantations.

B. Tea has grown wild on the island's mountains for thousands of years.

C. Buddhist monks brought it from Anuradhapura in the 200s BCE.

D. It was first planted by the Portuguese in Galle.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Tea is not native. James Taylor began growing it commercially in 1867, and it spread after coffee leaf rust struck from 1869. The plantations depended on workers brought from South India.

Concept Tested: Ceylon Tea **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 6

Which description fits the Sinhala Language?

A. A Dravidian language closely related to Tamil

B. A dialect of Hindi brought by the British

C. An Indo-Aryan language with its own script, most closely related to Dhivehi of the Maldives

D. A language spoken mainly in the Jaffna Peninsula

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Sinhala is Indo-Aryan, written in its own rounded script, and its closest relative is Dhivehi. Tamil, not Sinhala, is the Dravidian language spoken mainly in the north, including Jaffna.

Concept Tested: Sinhala Language **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

A classmate asks whether Sri Lanka is "just a part of India." Which answer is best?

A. Yes, Sri Lanka is an Indian state in the Indian Ocean.

B. No. Sri Lanka is an independent island country, independent since 1948, with its own government, languages and currency, across the narrow Palk Strait from India.

C. Yes, but it has its own flag.

D. No, Sri Lanka is part of the Maldives.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Sri Lanka became independent on 4 February 1948 (as Ceylon) and has always been a separate country from India, though the two are close neighbors with shared history.

Concept Tested: Sri Lanka **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

Using the Delta and Island MicroSim, you press **Average year**. Which result matches the chapter?

A. The whole country floods, including the eastern hills.

B. Nothing floods, because floods only happen in extreme years.

C. Only the Sundarbans floods.

D. About a fifth of the land floods, mostly along the rivers and toward the coast, while higher ground stays dry.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. In an average year about 21% of Bangladesh floods, and the lowest land near the rivers and coast floods first. The sim's land heights are illustrative, but the preset matches the documented average.

Concept Tested: Rivers and Floods **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Both Ekushey February and the Sinhala Only Act involve language policy. What is the most important similarity?

A. In both, a government favored one language, and speakers of another language felt shut out, which fed political movements.

B. In both, English was made the only official language.

C. In both, the protests happened in the same year.

D. In both, the language being promoted was Tamil.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Pakistan's push for Urdu alone angered Bangla speakers and fed the movement that led to independence. Sri Lanka's 1956 act made Sinhala the only official language and became a grievance for Tamils that fed the conflict. The events were in 1952 and 1956, not the same year.

Concept Tested: Sinhala Language **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

Why is it misleading to call the Sri Lankan Civil War a religious war?

A. Because no one in Sri Lanka practices a religion

B. Because all Tamils and all Sinhalese share the same religion

C. Because the conflict was mainly about ethnicity, language, power and land, and the LTTE sought a Tamil homeland, not a Hindu one

D. Because the war was fought only by foreign armies

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Most Sinhalese are Buddhist and most Tamils are Hindu, so religion overlapped with identity, but the fight was over a separate Tamil state, political power and language rights, and there were Christians on both sides.

Concept Tested: Sri Lankan Tamils **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives

Summary

Bhutan and the Maldives are the two smallest countries in South Asia by population, and Nepal sits in the middle of the list, but between them the three hold both the highest point on Earth and the lowest-lying country on Earth. This chapter tours each one: Nepal's Kathmandu Valley, Lumbini, Mount Everest, the Sherpa people, the Gurkhas and the republic Nepal became in 2008; Bhutan's language, its fortress-monasteries and its idea of Gross National Happiness; and the Maldives' coral atolls, its capital Malé, its language Dhivehi and the danger that rising seas pose to it. Along the way you'll compare how altitude and sea level shape farming, faith, work and the future in all three.

Concepts Covered

1. Nepal
2. Kathmandu Valley
3. Mount Everest
4. Sherpa People
5. Gurkhas
6. Lumbini
7. Nepal's Republic (2008)

8. Bhutan
9. Dzongkha
10. Dzong
11. Gross National Happiness
12. Maldives
13. Atolls
14. Malé
15. Dhivehi
16. Sea-Level Rise

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia? (the Himalaya, the monsoon, the Indian Ocean)
- Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition (what "never colonized, with caveats" means)
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia (Hinduism, Buddhism and Islam)
- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts (language families and scripts)

From the roof of the world to the edge of the sea

Hi, it's Mora! You may know Everest from movies and the Maldives from travel ads, but real families live in both places, and some of them live in Minnesota now. This chapter helps you see these countries the way their own people do, and it also shows why a rise in the ocean you can't feel at home could decide the future of a whole nation.

20.1 "Wait, That's the Same Region?"

It's the third meeting of the South Asian Student Association at Prairie Ridge High School. Nima Sherpa, whose family comes from Solukhumbu in eastern Nepal, has brought her phone to the front of Ms. Okafor's classroom. On the projector is an old photo: her grandfather, younger than her dad is now, standing on a rocky trail with snow peaks behind him. "That's near Everest Base Camp," Nima says. "He worked on climbing expeditions before he moved to Kathmandu."

Ben Lindqvist leans forward. "Okay, the Everest guy is your grandpa? That's amazing." Zara Hossain is already scrolling the club's list of the eight South Asian countries. "And look," she says. "The Maldives is on the same list. That's the country that's basically at sea level."

Ben does the math out loud. "So the highest mountain on the planet and the lowest country on the planet are in the same region? How does that even work?" Nima laughs. "Also, my grandpa wasn't a porter because he's a Sherpa. Sherpa is who we are, not a job." The room goes quiet for a second. How do these countries, one on top of the world and one barely above the waves, fit into one region, and what does living at those heights mean for the people there? That's what this chapter is about.

20.2 Three Small Countries, One Huge Staircase

Picture a staircase that starts underwater in the Indian Ocean and climbs north. The first steps are coral islands that barely poke above the waves. Then come wide, hot river plains. Then green hills and valleys with cities in them. Then cold, steep mountain kingdoms. And at the very top, snow and rock higher than airplanes fly when they take off.

Nepal, Bhutan and the Maldives sit on different steps of that staircase. That one fact, how high or low a place sits, shapes almost everything else about life there: what grows, how people travel, how they earn a living, and what dangers they face.

	Nepal	Bhutan	Maldives
Capital	Kathmandu	Thimphu	Malé
Population (2025, World Bank)	29,618,118 (about 30 million)	796,682 (about 800,000)	529,676 (about 530,000)
Land	Plains, hills and the high Himalaya	Steep Himalayan valleys	Low coral islands in the Indian Ocean
Highest point	Mount Everest, 8,848.86 m	Gangkhar Puensum, 7,570 m	About 2.4 m (natural ground)
Main language	Nepali	Dzongkha	Dhivehi
Largest faith	Hinduism (about 81%, 2021 census), with a large Buddhist minority	Vajrayana Buddhism, with a Hindu minority	Islam (Sunni)
Government today	Federal parliamentary	Constitutional monarchy (since 2008)	Presidential republic (since 1968)

	Nepal	Bhutan	Maldives
	republic (since 2008)		

Notice something about that last row. Two of these three countries changed their whole system of government in the same year, 2008. You'll see why in the sections ahead.

There's another thing they share. None of them was ruled directly as a British colony the way India, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka were, but each dealt with British power in its own way. Nepal lost territory under the 1816 Treaty of Sugauli. Bhutan agreed in the 1910 Treaty of Punakha to let Britain guide its foreign relations. The Maldives was a British protectorate, recorded in an 1887 agreement: Britain handled its defense and foreign affairs while the sultan ran things at home. You met these caveats in Chapter 4.

20.3 Nepal: Plains, Hills and the Himalaya

Nepal is a landlocked country of about 30 million people (2025, World Bank) on the southern slope of the Himalaya, between India to the south, east and west and China's Tibet region to the north. Its capital is Kathmandu. In Nepali, the country's official language, its name is नेपाल (*nay-PAAL*).

Nepal is a fairly narrow country from south to north, yet inside that short distance the land climbs from about 59 m above sea level to the top of the world. Geographers divide it into three belts that run east to west like stripes:

- **The Terai** is the strip of flat, hot plain along the southern edge, the northern rim of the great plain you met in Chapter 1. It is low, mostly below about 300 m above sea level. Rice, wheat and sugarcane grow

here, and many of Nepal's people live here. It is the smallest of the three belts by area.

- **The Hills** (Pahad) are the largest belt. These are green ridges and valleys, many with terraced fields cut into the slopes like giant steps. Kathmandu is here.
- **The Himal** is the high mountain belt along the northern border, with snowfields, glaciers and the world's highest peaks.

Nepal is home to many ethnic groups and languages. Most Nepalis are Hindu: in the 2021 census, about 81% said they were Hindu, about 8% Buddhist and about 5% Muslim, with smaller groups following Kirat, an Indigenous faith, or Christianity. Many families mix Hindu and Buddhist practice, so the lines between faiths are often softer than a census table suggests. Nepal's flag is the only national flag in the world that isn't a rectangle: it's two stacked triangles, a shape called a double pennon.

The biggest festival of the year for many Nepali Hindu families is **Dashain** (दशैं, *duh-SHAIN*), a 15-day celebration in autumn that honors the goddess Durga's victory over the demon Mahishasura. Families gather, elders place a red *tika* mark on younger relatives' foreheads and give blessings, and many people travel home for it. A few weeks later comes **Tihar** (तिहार, *ti-HAAR*), Nepal's festival of lights, related to Diwali, which includes a day for honoring dogs with flower garlands. You can read more about festival calendars in Chapter 7.

The Kathmandu Valley

The **Kathmandu Valley** is a bowl-shaped valley in the hills of central Nepal, about 1,400 m above sea level, that holds the cities of Kathmandu, Patan (Lalitpur) and Bhaktapur and has been the country's political and cultural center for centuries. Before the 1700s, the word "Nepal" meant only this valley. It was the home of the Newar people, whose kings, artists and builders

created the temples, palaces and courtyards that still fill its old city centers. The Newars are famous for their wood carving, metalwork and multi-roofed pagoda temples.

In 1979 UNESCO listed the Kathmandu Valley as a World Heritage Site made of seven monument zones:

Monument zone	What it is
Kathmandu Durbar Square	The old royal palace square of Kathmandu
Patan Durbar Square	The palace square of Patan, packed with temples
Bhaktapur Durbar Square	The palace square of Bhaktapur
Swayambhunath	A Buddhist stupa on a hill west of Kathmandu
Boudhanath	One of the largest Buddhist stupas in the world, a center of Tibetan Buddhist life
Pashupatinath	A major Hindu temple of the god Shiva, on the Bagmati River
Changu Narayan	A Hindu temple of Vishnu, one of the oldest in the valley

That list shows Nepal's mix of faiths in one valley: Hindu temples and Buddhist stupas a short bus ride apart.

Lumbini

Lumbini is a pilgrimage site in the Terai of southern Nepal that Buddhist tradition honors as the birthplace of Siddhartha Gautama, the Buddha. According to Buddhist texts, Queen Maya Devi gave birth to him in a garden there. Today the Sacred Garden includes the Maya Devi Temple, a sacred pond and the ruins of old monasteries and stupas.

The strongest physical evidence at Lumbini is a stone pillar put up by the Mauryan emperor Ashoka in the 3rd century BCE. It carries an inscription in Brahmi script recording the emperor's visit and naming the place as the Buddha's birthplace. The pillar was rediscovered in 1896. UNESCO made Lumbini a World Heritage Site in 1997, and Buddhist pilgrims from Sri Lanka, Thailand, Japan, Tibet and around the world visit it. You met the Buddha's story and Ashoka in Chapter 2 and Chapter 5.

One person, many homes

The Buddha was born in what is now Nepal, became enlightened at Bodh Gaya in what is now India, and his teachings spread to Sri Lanka, Bhutan and far beyond. When a famous figure "belongs" to many modern countries, which one gets to tell the story? I think all of them do, each a little differently.

Mount Everest

Mount Everest is the highest mountain on Earth, 8,848.86 m (29,031.7 ft) above sea level according to a joint measurement by China and Nepal in 2020. Its summit sits on the border between Nepal and China. In Nepali it is called सगरमाथा, Sagarmatha (*suh-gur-MAA-thaa*), a name often translated as "head in the sky" (dictionaries differ on whether its first part means "sky" or "sea"; *matha* means "forehead"). In Tibetan it is called Chomolungma. The English name honors George Everest, a British Surveyor General of India in the 1800s; Britain's Royal Geographical Society adopted it in 1865.

On 29 May 1953, Tenzing Norgay, a Sherpa mountaineer, and Edmund Hillary, a beekeeper and climber from New Zealand, became the first people confirmed to reach the summit. Tenzing was also the *sirdar*, the leader of the Sherpa team, on that British expedition. Since then, thousands of people have reached the top, and climbing has become a major source of jobs and income for the region.

The mountain sits inside Sagarmatha National Park, created in 1976 in the Solukhumbu District, Nima's family's home district. UNESCO listed it as a natural World Heritage Site in 1979. The park protects glaciers, high valleys and rare animals such as the snow leopard, and it is also home to Sherpa villages and Buddhist monasteries.

Everest brings pride and income, but also crowds, trash and deaths among climbers and climbing workers. Its glaciers are shrinking too. The IPCC, the UN's climate science panel, reported in 2021 that human influence is very likely the main driver of glacier retreat worldwide since the 1990s, and that mountain glaciers will keep melting for decades or centuries.

The Sherpa People

The **Sherpa People** are an ethnic group of the high Himalaya, most of whom live in eastern Nepal, especially Solukhumbu and the Everest region, with communities in India's Sikkim and Darjeeling areas and in Tibet. Their name comes from the Tibetan words *shar*, "east," and *pa*, "people," so "Sherpa" means something like "people from the east." According to Sherpa oral history, their ancestors migrated over the mountains from eastern Tibet several centuries ago.

Sherpas speak the Sherpa language, which is related to Tibetan, and most are Tibetan Buddhists. Buddhist monasteries are the center of community life in the Everest region. Living at high altitude for generations, Sherpas became known worldwide for their skill and strength as mountain guides.

That fame has created a common mix-up. Many foreigners use "sherpa" with a small *s* to mean any mountain guide or porter, whatever their background. In business and politics, "sherpa" even means an assistant who prepares the way for a leader. But for Nima's family, Sherpa is an identity, like Swedish is for Ben's great-grandparents. Plenty of Sherpas have never worked on a mountain, and plenty of climbing workers on Everest come from other Nepali ethnic groups.

The Gurkhas

The **Gurkhas** are soldiers from Nepal (and Nepali-speaking communities in India) who have served in the British Army since 1815 and today also serve in the Indian Army and other forces. Their name comes from Gorkha (गोर्खा, *GOR-khaa*), the hill kingdom whose king, Prithvi Narayan Shah, united the many small states of Nepal in the 1700s.

Between 1814 and 1816, Nepal fought a war against the British East India Company. Nepal lost and, under the 1816 Treaty of Sugauli, gave up land in the west and south. But the British were so impressed by Nepal's soldiers that they began recruiting them even before the war ended. Gurkhas fought for Britain in both World Wars and in many other conflicts. They are known for their curved knife, the *khukuri*, and for their reputation for courage.

For many hill families, especially Gurung, Magar, Rai and Limbu families, serving as a Gurkha has been a respected path to steady income and travel, and it helped create Nepali communities in Britain and elsewhere. It also raised questions of fairness: Gurkhas long received smaller pensions than other British soldiers until public campaigns won equal pensions for those who joined after 1997 (announced in 2007) and the right for retired Gurkhas to settle in Britain (2009).

Nepal's Republic (2008)

For about 240 years, from 1768, Nepal was a kingdom ruled by the Shah dynasty, and by the late 1900s it was known as the world's only officially Hindu kingdom.

The late 1900s and early 2000s brought big changes. Protests in 1990 forced the king to accept multiparty democracy. From 1996 to 2006 a civil war between government forces and Maoist rebels killed more than 17,000 people. After mass protests in 2006 and a peace deal, Nepal held elections for a Constituent Assembly, a special body chosen to write a new constitution, on 10 April 2008.

Nepal's Republic (2008) refers to the moment Nepal ended its monarchy and became a republic: at its very first meeting, on 28 May 2008, the Constituent Assembly voted to declare Nepal a federal democratic republic. The last king, Gyanendra, left the royal palace in Kathmandu in June 2008, and it became a museum. Nepal had already been declared officially secular, with no state religion, in 2006. Writing the constitution took years, and it finally came into effect on 20 September 2015. It made Nepal a federal republic divided into seven provinces, each with its own government.

Nepal's politics have kept changing. In September 2025, large youth-led protests, often called the "Gen Z" protests, broke out against corruption, after the government banned many social media platforms. The protests turned deadly, and Prime Minister K. P. Sharma Oli resigned on 9 September 2025. Sushila Karki, a former chief justice, became interim prime minister. In an early election on 5 March 2026, the Rastriya Swatantra Party won 182 of the 275 seats in the House of Representatives, and Balendra (Balen) Shah, a former mayor of Kathmandu, was sworn in as prime minister on 27 March 2026. (Leaders change; check the news for the latest.)

Nepal's economy depends heavily on farming, tourism and money sent home by Nepalis working abroad. In 2025 these remittances equaled about

32% of Nepal's GDP (World Bank), one of the highest shares anywhere. You'll see more in Chapter 21.

20.4 Bhutan: The Thunder Dragon Kingdom

Bhutan is a small, mountainous kingdom of about 800,000 people (2025, World Bank) in the eastern Himalaya, between India and China's Tibet region. Its capital is Thimphu. Bhutanese call their country Druk Yul, often translated "Land of the Thunder Dragon," and the thunder dragon appears on the national flag. The name comes from the Drukpa lineage, the school of Buddhism that has been central to the country's history.

Bhutan's land is almost all steep. Rivers cut deep valleys running north to south, from snowy peaks over 7,000 m down to humid foothills near India. Its highest mountain, Gangkhar Puensum (7,570 m), is the highest mountain in the world that no one has ever climbed. Bhutan banned climbing peaks over 6,000 m in 1994 out of respect for local spiritual beliefs about the mountains, and has banned mountaineering altogether since 2003.

Thimphu sits in a valley between about 2,250 and 2,650 m above sea level, making it one of the highest capital cities in the world. It became the official capital in 1961, replacing the older capital, Punakha.

Most Bhutanese follow Vajrayana Buddhism, the same broad tradition as Tibet, and monks, prayer flags and painted temples are part of everyday life. A large minority, mostly in the south, is Hindu, many of them Nepali-speaking people called Lhotshampa ("southern borderlanders"). Bhutan's Constitution says at least 60% of the country must stay under forest cover "for all time," one of the strongest environmental rules in any constitution.

A kingdom that chose democracy

Bhutan's first hereditary king, Ugyen Wangchuck, was enthroned in 1907 at Punakha, and his family, the Wangchuck dynasty, still reigns. In 1910 Bhutan signed the Treaty of Punakha, agreeing to let Britain guide its foreign relations. In 1949 it signed a Treaty of Friendship with independent India. The two countries promised not to interfere in each other's internal affairs, and Bhutan agreed to be guided by India's advice on foreign relations, a clause the two countries replaced when they revised the treaty in 2007.

The fourth king, Jigme Singye Wangchuck, who ruled from 1972 to 2006, did something unusual: he pushed his own country toward democracy, even though many Bhutanese were happy with the monarchy. He stepped down in 2006 in favor of his son, Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck, the fifth king. In 2008 Bhutan held its first elections for the National Assembly (on 24 March 2008) and adopted a written constitution. Bhutan became a constitutional monarchy: the king is head of state, and an elected prime minister and parliament run the government.

Dzongkha

Dzongkha (རྫོང་ཁ, *DZONG-kaa*) is the national language of Bhutan. It belongs to the Tibetic group of languages and is written in the Tibetan script. Its name means "the language of the fortress," from *dzong*, "fortress," and *kha*, "language," because it was the language spoken by officials in the dzongs of western Bhutan.

Dzongkha is far from the only language in Bhutan, which has about two dozen. Many people in the east speak Tshangla, and many in the south speak Nepali. English has no official status but is widely used in schools, government and media, so many young Bhutanese grow up speaking several languages. That might sound familiar if you're Zara, who understands Bangla at home but answers in English.

Dzong

A **dzong** (རྫོང, *DZONG*) is a large fortress-monastery found mainly in Bhutan (and historically in Tibet) that is both the religious center and the government office for a district. Picture high white walls that slope inward, with few windows near the bottom, a red-brown stripe near the top, and golden roofs over temples inside the courtyards. Inside, the building is split roughly in half: one side holds monks and temples, and the other holds government offices.

The split is on purpose. In Bhutanese tradition, religious authority and civil government work side by side, and the dzong puts both under one roof. One of the most famous, Punakha Dzong, was built in 1637 to 1638 where two rivers, the Pho Chhu and Mo Chhu (the "male" and "female" rivers), meet. Many dzongs host a *tshechu*, a festival of *cham* dances, many of them masked, performed by monks and lay dancers, which draws families from across the district. Bhutan's districts are still called *dzongkhag*, "dzong areas," and there are 20 of them.

Gross National Happiness

Gross National Happiness (GNH) is Bhutan's idea that a country should measure its progress by the well-being of its people and environment, not only by how much money its economy makes. The fourth king, Jigme Singye Wangchuck, is credited with the phrase in the 1970s, when he said GNH mattered more than gross domestic product (GDP), the usual measure of a country's economy.

Bhutan built the idea into its 2008 Constitution, which says the state shall try to promote the conditions that let people pursue Gross National Happiness. In practice GNH rests on four "pillars": fair and sustainable development, protecting the environment, preserving culture and good government. Bhutan's Centre for Bhutan Studies (now the Centre for Bhutan and GNH

Studies) developed a GNH Index, working with researchers at Oxford University, which surveys thousands of people on nine areas of life: psychological well-being, health, education, time use, cultural diversity, good government, community life, ecology and living standards.

In the 2022 GNH Index, released in May 2023, Bhutan scored 0.781 on a scale from 0 to 1, up from 0.756 in 2015. The survey sorted people into four groups: 9.5% "deeply happy," 38.6% "extensively happy," 45.5% "narrowly happy" and 6.4% "unhappy." So about 48% were deeply or extensively happy, and some areas, such as cultural participation, got worse after 2015.

Happiness is a goal, not a fact

Don't read "Gross National Happiness" as "everyone in Bhutan is happy." It's a policy goal and a way of measuring. Bhutan's own survey found many people only narrowly happy, and some areas of life getting worse.

Whose Story?

Bhutan's story is often told abroad as a peaceful Himalayan kingdom that put happiness first, and many Bhutanese are proud of GNH and of their peaceful move to democracy. But Nepali-speaking Lhotshampa families from southern Bhutan often tell a different story about the late 1980s and 1990s, when citizenship and dress rules tightened and more than 100,000 people left or were forced out. Bhutan's government at the time said many of them were illegal immigrants, while refugees and human rights groups described expulsions and loss of citizenship. About 108,000 refugees lived in seven camps in eastern Nepal, and starting in 2007 more than 100,000 were resettled abroad, about 85,000 of them in the United States by 2015. Some of their children may sit in your classes today, and their families may tell this history very differently from a travel brochure.

20.5 The Maldives: A Nation of Atolls

Maldives (officially the Republic of Maldives, usually called "the Maldives") is an island country of about 530,000 people (2025, World Bank) in the Indian Ocean, southwest of India and Sri Lanka, made up of roughly 1,190 small coral islands. It is the smallest South Asian country by population and land area: all its land together is only about 298 square km. But that land is scattered across about 90,000 square km of ocean, so it's one of the most spread-out countries in the world.

Atolls

The islands are grouped into 26 **atolls**. An **atoll** is a ring of coral reef and small low islands surrounding a shallow lagoon. The word itself is South Asian: English borrowed "atoll" from the Dhivehi word ތަކުރު, *atholhu* (*A-tho-lu*). It traveled through French in the 1600s, and Charles Darwin made it the scientific term in the 1840s.

How does an atoll form? Darwin's explanation, still the basic model today, goes like this:

1. A volcano rises from the sea floor and forms an island.
2. Coral grows in a fringing reef around the island's shore, in warm, shallow, sunny water.
3. Over a very long time the volcano stops erupting and slowly sinks, while the coral keeps growing upward toward the light.
4. Eventually the volcano disappears below the surface. What's left is the ring of reef, with sand islands piled on it by waves, around a lagoon where the island used to be.

That's why the Maldives is so flat. Its islands aren't mountaintops; they're coral and sand piled up by the sea. The average ground level is only about

1.5 m above sea level, and the highest natural point is only about 2.4 m (some sources give a higher figure for one spot). That makes the Maldives the lowest-lying country in the world. Mount Everest is about 3,700 times taller than the Maldives' highest natural ground.

Malé

Malé (*MAA-lay*, often written Male in English) is the capital and largest city of the Maldives, built on a tiny island in North Malé Atoll. In the 2022 census about 212,000 people lived in the city of Malé, roughly two in every five people in the country. The main island covers only about 2 square km, yet in the 2014 census it held about 110,000 people, making it one of the most densely packed places on Earth. The rest of the city's people live on nearby islands that belong to the city, such as Hulhumalé. Buildings cover nearly every bit of the main island, and the city has grown onto neighboring islands, including the airport island and Hulhumalé.

Hulhumalé is an artificial island. Starting in 1997, engineers pumped sand from the sea floor to build new land, a process called land reclamation. It now houses tens of thousands of people, and it was built partly as a response to the threat of rising seas.

Dhivehi

Dhivehi (ދިވެހި, *dhi-VAY-hee*) is the language of the Maldives. Its name means roughly "islanders' language." Dhivehi is an Indo-Aryan language, part of the same big family as Hindi, Bangla and Nepali, and its closest relative is Sinhala, spoken in Sri Lanka (Chapter 19). Together the two form an "island" branch of the family.

Dhivehi is written in a script called Thaana, which is written from right to left, like Arabic. Thaana is unusual: some of its first letters were adapted from numerals, both Arabic numerals and older local ones, and its vowel marks

come from Arabic. It's a good example of how trade and faith across the Indian Ocean mixed South Asian and Arab influences.

Faith, history and life on the islands

Buddhism was the main faith in the Maldives for centuries. Arab and Persian traders crossing the Indian Ocean brought Islam, and by tradition the last Buddhist king converted in 1153. The monarchy lasted more than 800 years in all. In 1887 an agreement recorded the Maldives as a British protectorate, and it gained full independence on 26 July 1965, a date Maldivians celebrate as Independence Day. The sultanate ended and a republic was declared on 11 November 1968. Today the Maldives' constitution makes Islam the state religion and says a non-Muslim may not become a citizen; nearly all Maldivians are Sunni Muslims, and Eid al-Fitr and Eid al-Adha are major national holidays.

Life follows the sea. For centuries Maldivians were known as skilled sailors and fishers, and tuna, especially skipjack tuna, is still the most important catch. Fishing is still one of the main industries, after tourism, which began in the early 1970s and is now the largest. Many resorts take up a whole island each, while most Maldivians live on separate "local islands" with their own mosques, schools, football fields and harbors. That gap means many visitors see only resorts and never meet the 500,000 or so people who live there.

Sea-Level Rise

Sea-Level Rise is the gradual increase in the average height of the ocean, caused mainly by warming seawater expanding and by melting glaciers and ice sheets adding water. It is happening now and speeding up.

The IPCC, the UN's climate science panel, reported these findings in its 2021 assessment:

- Global average sea level rose about 0.20 m between 1901 and 2018.
- The rate has sped up, reaching about 3.7 mm per year between 2006 and 2018.
- By 2100, compared with the years 1995 to 2014, global sea level will likely rise about 0.28 to 0.55 m if the world cuts greenhouse gas emissions very deeply, and about 0.63 to 1.01 m if emissions stay very high.
- Much higher rises, approaching 2 m by 2100, can't be ruled out under very high emissions, although scientists have low confidence in that outcome.

Why does a rise of half a meter or a meter matter so much to the Maldives? Think back to that average ground level of about 1.5 m. A higher ocean doesn't just cover a strip of beach. It lets storm waves and high tides wash farther inland, pushes salt water into the thin layer of fresh groundwater under each island, and erodes shorelines. The IPCC also projects that extreme high-water events that used to happen about once a century will happen at least once a year at more than half of tide-measuring sites by 2100. For a country whose highest ground is lower than a basketball hoop, that is a question about whether whole islands remain livable.

The Maldives has worked hard to get the world to notice. On 17 October 2009, President Mohamed Nasheed and his ministers held the world's first underwater cabinet meeting, in scuba gear, to draw attention to the threat. The country has also built new land, such as Hulhumalé, with rising seas in mind.

Same planet, different worries

Warming affects both ends of South Asia's staircase. Up high in Nepal and Bhutan, it melts glaciers; down low in the Maldives, that meltwater and warmer oceans help raise the sea.

20.6 Mountains to Atolls: Comparing the Three

Now put the three countries side by side and ask the question from the hook: how does altitude, or the lack of it, shape life?

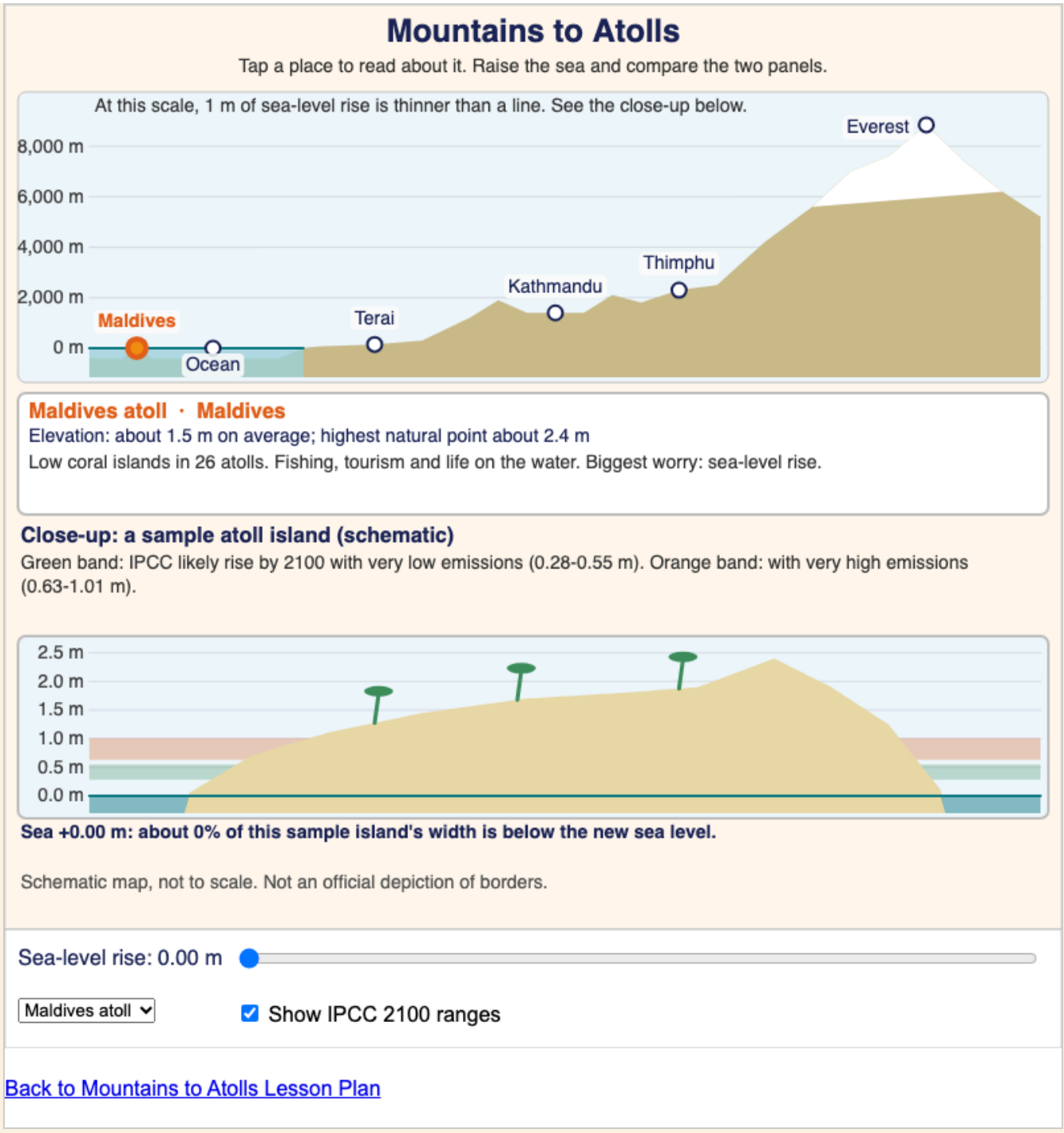
Question	Nepal	Bhutan	Maldives
Where do most people live?	Terai plains and hill valleys	River valleys in the mountains	A few crowded islands, especially Malé
How do people travel?	Roads, footpaths and small airstrips; mountain roads can close in the monsoon	Winding mountain roads; one main international airport at Paro	Boats and seaplanes between islands
What does the land give?	Rice and wheat on the plains, terraced farms in the hills, rivers for hydropower	Forests, hydropower, mountain farming	Fish (especially tuna), coconuts, coral reefs that draw tourists
Biggest climate worry	Glacier melt, floods and landslides	Glacier melt, floods and landslides	Sea-level rise, storm waves, saltwater in groundwater
Big money-maker	Remittances, tourism, farming	Hydropower, tourism	Tourism, fishing

Question	Nepal	Bhutan	Maldives
How faith shapes the landscape	Hindu temples and Buddhist stupas side by side	Dzongs, monasteries and prayer flags	Mosques on every inhabited island

In the mountain countries, steep land makes farming and travel hard, but fast rivers are good for hydropower and the peaks draw visitors. The atoll country has almost no farmland, but its ocean is full of fish and reefs. In all three, many young people leave home to study or work, and climate change threatens land that families have lived with for generations.

Back at the club meeting, Ben sketches a line on the whiteboard that starts flat at the bottom left and shoots up on the right. Zara adds a wavy blue line along the bottom. "If the ocean goes up a little, Kathmandu won't notice," she says. "Down here, it matters a lot." Ben nods. "One region, two totally different problems."

Diagram: Mountains to Atolls



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch20-mountains-to-atolls/main.html

Open the Mountains to Atolls fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Mountains to Atolls

sim-id: ch20-mountains-to-atolls
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Analyze
Bloom Verb: compare
Learning Objective: The learner will compare how altitude and sea level shape life in Nepal, Bhutan and the Maldives by reading a schematic elevation profile and testing how much of a low atoll island a given sea-level rise would cover.

Canvas: responsive width; 700 px drawing area plus 90 px control area.

Controls: "Sea-level rise" slider (0 to 2.0 m, step 0.05 m); place menu (Maldives atoll, Indian Ocean, Terai plains, Kathmandu, Thimphu, Mount Everest); "Show IPCC 2100 ranges" checkbox; click or tap a place marker on the profile.

Behavior: A schematic staircase profile runs from a Maldives atoll (highest natural point about 2.4 m) through the Terai, Kathmandu and Thimphu to Everest (8,848.86 m). The sea line there barely moves. A lower close-up floods a schematic sample atoll island (average about 1.5 m) as the slider rises and reports the share below the new sea level, with the IPCC AR6 likely 2100 ranges shaded. The caption "Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders." appears in the drawing area.

Start with the slider at zero and click each marker, from the atoll to Everest, reading each elevation. Then drag the slider to 1 m. Can you even see the sea move on the top panel? Now check the close-up: how much of the sample island is under the new sea level?

Turn on the IPCC ranges and compare the "very low emissions" band with the "very high emissions" band. Notice how much of the sample island stays dry

in each case. The island shape is schematic, built from the Maldives' average height and highest point, so the exact percentage is not a forecast for any real island, but the pattern is real: a rise you can't even see from Kathmandu can decide the future of a low island.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about mountains, islands and the landscapes of home. If your family is Nepali, Bhutanese or Maldivian, ask about the land and festivals they grew up with; if not, ask what they know or remember about mountain or island life anywhere. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Bring a photo of mountains or an island (from a family album or from this chapter) to get the conversation going, and ask if it's okay to take notes.

Questions to ask

1. What did the land around your childhood home look like: mountains, hills, plains, rivers or sea?
2. How did people get around: walking trails, roads, buses, boats? How long did it take to reach the nearest big town?
3. Which festival did your family look forward to most, and what did it look, smell and sound like? (For example Dashain or Tihar in Nepal, a tshechu in Bhutan, or Eid in the Maldives.)

4. Did anyone in your family or village work far from home, in another city or country, and send money back? How did that change things?
5. How has the weather, the snow, the rivers or the sea changed since you were young, or since you moved?
6. What do you hope I'll know or feel about that landscape, even if I've never been there?

Listen for: details that connect to the Kathmandu Valley, Mount Everest or the Sherpa People; descriptions of a Dzong, a monastery or a mosque at the center of community life; and any memories of glaciers, floods or Sea-Level Rise.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's description of the landscape they grew up in with the comparison table in Section 20.6. Did they live on a "high" step or a "low" step of the staircase? If a friend interviewed someone from a very different landscape, list two ways altitude or water changed daily life in their two stories.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: "Sherpa" means a porter or mountain guide.
Reality: The Sherpa people are an ethnic group of the Himalaya, mostly in eastern Nepal, with their own language, Buddhist traditions and history. Many

Sherpas have worked as climbing guides, but many have not, and many climbing workers on Everest come from other ethnic groups.

Myth: Gross National Happiness means everyone in Bhutan is happy.
Reality: GNH is a policy goal and a way of measuring well-being. In Bhutan's own 2022 GNH Index, 6.4% of people were classed as unhappy and 45.5% as only "narrowly happy," and the survey found some areas of life, such as cultural participation, getting worse.

Myth: The Maldives is basically just a resort.
Reality: The Maldives is a country of about 530,000 people (2025, World Bank) with its own language (Dhivehi), script (Thaana), Islamic faith, history of sultans and a capital city, Malé, that is one of the most crowded cities on Earth. Most Maldivians live on local islands, not resorts.

Myth: Nepal was a British colony, like India.
Reality: Nepal was never formally colonized. It lost land to the East India Company in the 1816 Treaty of Sugauli and had close ties with Britain, but it kept its own kings and government. Bhutan was also never colonized, though it let Britain guide its foreign relations after 1910.

Check Yourself

1. What is the difference between the Kathmandu Valley and the country of Nepal?

The Kathmandu Valley is a valley in central Nepal, about 1,400 m high, holding Kathmandu, Patan and Bhaktapur. Before the 1700s the word "Nepal" meant just this valley; today Nepal is the whole country, from the Terai plains to the Himalaya.

2. What happened in Nepal on 28 May 2008?

At its first meeting, Nepal's newly elected Constituent Assembly voted to end the monarchy and declare Nepal a federal democratic republic.

3. What does the name Dzongkha mean, and how does it connect to dzongs?

Dzongkha means "language of the fortress." A dzong is a fortress-monastery that serves as both a religious center and a district government office, and Dzongkha was the language spoken by officials there.

4. How does an atoll form, according to Darwin's model?

Coral grows around a volcanic island. The volcano slowly sinks while the coral keeps growing upward, until only a ring of reef and low sand islands remains around a lagoon.

5. Why does a sea-level rise of about 1 m matter much more to the Maldives than to Nepal?

The Maldives' average ground level is only about 1.5 m and its highest natural point about 2.4 m, so a 1 m rise would bring floods, storm waves and salt water to much of the land. Nepal's lowest land is about 59 m above sea level, so the ocean's rise doesn't reach it directly.

Exercises

Remember

1. Name the capitals of Nepal, Bhutan and the Maldives, and the main language of each.

> **Answer**
>
> Nepal: Kathmandu, Nepali. Bhutan: Thimphu, Dzongkha. Maldives: Malé, Dhivehi.

2. Who were the first two people confirmed to reach the summit of Mount Everest, and when?

> **Answer**
>
> Tenzing Norgay, a Sherpa mountaineer, and Edmund Hillary of New Zealand, on 29 May 1953.

Understand

1. Explain why "Sherpa" and "porter" are not the same thing.

> **Answer**
>
> Sherpa is the name of an ethnic group from the Himalaya with its own language and Buddhist traditions. Porter is a job. Some Sherpas work as porters or guides, but many don't, and many porters belong to other ethnic groups.

2. Explain in your own words what Gross National Happiness is and how Bhutan measures it.

Answer

GNH is Bhutan's idea that progress should be measured by people's well-being and the environment, not just the economy. Bhutan measures it with a GNH Index survey that looks at nine areas of life, such as health, education, time use, community and living standards.

Apply

1. Use the Mountains to Atolls sim. Set the slider to the low end of the IPCC "very high emissions" range (0.63 m) and then the high end (1.01 m). Record how much of the sample island is below the new sea level each time, and write two sentences about what the difference means. *Hint: remember the island is schematic, so focus on the pattern.*
2. A cousin says she's going to "Nepal's Terai" for a wedding. Using this chapter, describe what landscape, elevation and crops she will probably see there. *Hint: look at the three belts in Section 20.3.*

Analyze

1. Compare how Nepal and Bhutan each moved from monarchy toward democracy around 2008. What was similar, and what was different? *Hint: think about who pushed for the change and what happened to the king.*
2. Using the comparison table in Section 20.6, analyze why remittances matter so much to Nepal's economy while hydropower and tourism matter so much to Bhutan's. *Hint: think about land, jobs and rivers.*

Evaluate

1. Some people say Gross National Happiness is a model the whole world should copy. Others say it hides problems. Using evidence from the chapter (including the Whose Story? box), evaluate both views and state your own position. *Hint: a strong answer uses the 2022 survey numbers.*
2. The Maldives held an underwater cabinet meeting in 2009 to draw attention to sea-level rise. Evaluate how effective a dramatic event like that might be compared with other actions, such as building Hulhumalé. *Hint: consider who each action is aimed at.*

Create

1. Design a one-page "staircase" poster for your club that shows Nepal, Bhutan and the Maldives on a single elevation line, with one fact about faith, one about language and one about climate for each country. Use a schematic drawing with no official borders. *Hint: label elevations in meters with their sources.*
2. Write a short diary entry (150 to 200 words) from a fictional teenager in Malé or Kathmandu during a major festival (Eid in Malé, or Dashain or Tihar in Kathmandu). Include at least two concept words from this chapter. *Hint: use your senses: sounds, smells, colors, weather.*

Key Takeaways

- Nepal, Bhutan and the Maldives sit at the two extremes of South Asia's "staircase": Nepal holds Mount Everest (8,848.86 m), while the Maldives' highest natural ground is only about 2.4 m.
- Nepal runs from the Terai plains through the hills of the Kathmandu Valley to the Himalaya, and holds Lumbini, honored as the Buddha's birthplace.

- The Sherpa are an ethnic group, not a job title; the Gurkhas, soldiers from Nepal's hills, have served Britain since 1815.
- Nepal ended its monarchy and became a republic on 28 May 2008; after youth-led protests in 2025 and an early election in March 2026, Balendra Shah became prime minister.
- Bhutan became a constitutional monarchy with its first elections in 2008. Its national language is Dzongkha, its fortress-monasteries are called dzongs, and its constitution makes Gross National Happiness a goal of the state.
- The Maldives is a nation of about 1,190 low coral islands in 26 atolls, with Dhivehi as its language and Malé as its crowded capital; "atoll" is a Dhivehi word.
- Climate change touches all three: glaciers are retreating in the mountains, and the IPCC projects a likely global sea-level rise of about 0.28 to 1.01 m by 2100, a serious threat to the Maldives.

From the summit to the sea!

You've now toured all eight countries of South Asia, from the highest peak to the lowest islands. Next, in Chapter 21, we follow South Asians as they move around the world, to the Caribbean, East Africa, Britain, the Gulf and right here to Minnesota.

Quiz: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives

Test your understanding of Chapter 20. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

On what date did Nepal's Constituent Assembly vote to end the monarchy and declare a republic?

A. 15 August 1947

B. 28 May 2008

C. 20 September 2015

D. 5 March 2026

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. At its first meeting on 28 May 2008, the newly elected Constituent Assembly declared Nepal a federal democratic republic. The date 20 September 2015 is when Nepal's new constitution came into effect, years after the monarchy had already ended.

Concept Tested: Nepal's Republic (2008) **Bloom's Level:** Remember

---

Question 2

What does the Dzongkha word that gives Dzongkha its name, *dzong*, refer to?

A. A Buddhist prayer wheel

B. A mountain pass

C. A masked dance festival

D. A fortress-monastery that also serves as a government office

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. A dzong is a fortress-monastery in which roughly half the building holds monks and temples and half holds government offices. Dzongkha means "language of the fortress." A masked dance festival held at a dzong is a tshechu, not a dzong itself.

Concept Tested: Dzong **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 3

The English word "atoll" was borrowed from which language?

A. Dhivehi

B. Arabic

C. Sinhala

D. Portuguese

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. "Atoll" comes from the Dhivehi word *atholhu*, the language of the Maldives. It reached English through French in the 1600s. Sinhala is Dhivehi's closest relative, which makes it a tempting choice, but the word itself is Maldivian.

Concept Tested: Atolls **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Why is it inaccurate to use "Sherpa" to mean any mountain porter?

A. Because Sherpas are only found in Bhutan, not Nepal

B. Because Sherpas are not allowed to work on Everest expeditions

C. Because Sherpa is an ethnic group with its own language and traditions, and many climbing workers come from other groups

D. Because the word Sherpa means "porter" only in Tibetan, not in Nepali

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The Sherpa people are an ethnic group of the Himalaya, mostly in eastern Nepal. Their name means "people from the east." Many Sherpas have worked as guides, but many have not, and many climbing workers belong to other groups. The name does not mean "porter" in any language.

Concept Tested: Sherpa People **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 5

Which statement best describes Gross National Happiness?

A. A finding that every person in Bhutan is happy

B. A goal and measuring system that looks at well-being and the environment, not just the economy

C. Bhutan's name for its national currency

D. A ranking that shows Bhutan is the happiest country on Earth

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. GNH is Bhutan's policy goal and index for measuring well-being across nine areas of life. It does not claim everyone is happy: in the 2022 GNH Index, 6.4% of people were classed as unhappy and 45.5% as only narrowly happy.

Concept Tested: Gross National Happiness **Bloom's Level:** Understand

---

Question 6

Why is the Maldives so flat?

A. Its islands are coral reef and sand piled up by waves around lagoons, not the tops of mountains

B. Glaciers scraped the islands flat during the last ice age

C. Engineers leveled all the islands to build resorts

D. The islands are the remains of a flat river delta

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Maldivian islands sit on atolls: rings of coral reef that grew upward as old volcanoes sank, with sand islands built on top by waves. That is why average ground is only about 1.5 m. Some land, such as Hulhumalé, was reclaimed by engineers, but that is not why the whole country is flat.

Concept Tested: Atolls **Bloom's Level:** Understand

Question 7

Ben says, "Nepal must have been a British colony, since India was." Which response is most accurate?

A. He's right; Nepal was ruled directly by Britain until 1947.

B. He's right; Nepal became independent in 1965.

C. He's wrong; Nepal was part of the Mughal Empire until 2008.

D. He's wrong; Nepal kept its own rulers, though it lost land to the East India Company under the 1816 Treaty of Sugauli.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Nepal was never formally colonized, though the 1816 Treaty of Sugauli cost it territory and tied it closely to Britain. The British also began recruiting Gurkhas then. The year 1965 is the Maldives' independence date, not Nepal's.

Concept Tested: Nepal **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

A Maldivian island's ground is about 1.5 m above sea level. Using the IPCC's 2021 likely range for very high emissions, roughly how high could global sea level rise by 2100?

A. About 0.02 to 0.05 m

B. About 5 to 10 m

C. About 0.63 to 1.01 m

D. About 8.8 m

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The IPCC's likely range under very high emissions is about 0.63 to 1.01 m by 2100, relative to the years 1995 to 2014. On an island averaging about 1.5 m, that would bring much more flooding from tides and storm waves. The 5 to 10 m figure describes sea levels about 125,000 years ago, not 2100.

Concept Tested: Sea-Level Rise **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

Compare Nepal's and Bhutan's moves away from absolute monarchy in 2008. Which statement is accurate?

A. Nepal abolished its monarchy and became a republic, while Bhutan kept its king as head of state in a new constitutional monarchy.

B. Both countries abolished their monarchies and became republics.

C. Bhutan abolished its monarchy, while Nepal kept its king.

D. Neither country held elections in 2008.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Nepal's Constituent Assembly ended the monarchy on 28 May 2008. Bhutan held its first National Assembly elections on 24 March 2008 and adopted a constitution, but its king remains head of state. Both countries changed systems in 2008, which is why choice B is a tempting mistake.

Concept Tested: Bhutan **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 10

In the Mountains to Atolls sim, a 1 m sea-level rise moves the sea line on the mountain panel by less than one pixel but floods a large part of the sample island. What does this show?

A. Sea-level rise only matters in Nepal.

B. The sim has a mistake in its scale.

C. Mount Everest is getting shorter as the sea rises.

D. The same rise that is tiny compared with mountain heights is large compared with the height of atoll islands.

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. On a scale built for Everest (8,848.86 m), 1 m is too small to see, but the Maldives' highest natural ground is only about 2.4 m, so 1 m is a big share of it. The scale is correct. The two panels use very different vertical scales on purpose.

Concept Tested: Maldives **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora

Summary

Millions of people with roots in South Asia live outside the region, in places as different as Guyana, Fiji, Kenya, London, Dubai and the Twin Cities. This chapter explains what a diaspora is and follows the major waves of South Asian migration: indentured laborers sent to sugar colonies after slavery ended, workers and traders in East Africa, postwar migrants to Britain, workers in the oil-rich Gulf, and the long, uneven story of South Asians in the United States, from Punjabi farmers in California to families who arrived after 1965. It ends here at home, with Census numbers for Minnesota and a look at desi identity and families that live across borders.

Concepts Covered

1. Diaspora
2. Indentured Labor
3. Indo-Caribbean Communities
4. South Asians in East Africa
5. Uganda Expulsion of 1972
6. British South Asians
7. Gulf Migrant Workers

8. Remittances
9. Punjabi Pioneers in California
10. Bhagat Singh Thind Case
11. Immigration Act of 1965
12. South Asians in Minnesota
13. Model Minority Myth
14. Post-9/11 Backlash
15. Desi Identity
16. Transnational Families

Prerequisites

- Chapter 1: What Is South Asia? (the eight countries and the Indian Ocean)
- Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition (the British Empire and 1947)
- Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia (Sikhism, Islam and Hinduism)
- Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives (Nepal's remittances and Bhutanese refugees)

Every family has a moving story

Hi, it's Mora! If your family came from somewhere else, someone made a huge decision to leave home, and you are part of what happened next. This chapter helps you see your own family's move as one thread in a much bigger story, and it gives you the words to ask about it.

21.1 "Why Did You Come Here?"

It's a snowy Saturday, and Zara Hossain is at Ben Lindqvist's house for his grandmother's birthday. On the wall is a framed black-and-white photo of a farm couple standing beside a wooden house. "That's my great-great-grandparents," Ben says. "They came from Sweden in the 1880s. Grandma says they were poor and there wasn't enough land back home, so they came to Minnesota to farm."

Zara looks at the photo for a long time. She has heard bits of her own family's story: her parents grew up in Chattogram, Bangladesh, and moved to Minnesota in the 2000s, before she was born. But she has never asked the real questions. Why did they leave? Why Minnesota, of all places? Did they plan to stay forever?

That night at dinner, Zara asks her mother, "Why did you and Abbu come here?" Her mother laughs, then gets quiet, then says, "That's a long story. Ask Nanu about her brother first. He went to England before any of us left." Zara realizes her family's move was part of a chain of moves, across generations and continents. How did so many South Asian families end up scattered around the world, and why did they go where they went?

21.2 What Is a Diaspora?

Start with something Ben already knows. Many Swedish and Norwegian immigrants settled in the Midwest, especially Minnesota, and their descendants still keep some traditions alive, in Lutheran churches, family recipes and places like the American Swedish Institute in Minneapolis. They are Americans, but many still feel a connection to the "old country." That's the basic idea of a diaspora.

A **diaspora** (*dye-AS-puh-ruh*) is a population that lives outside its ancestral homeland but keeps some connection to it, through memory, language, faith, food, family ties or a shared sense of identity. The word comes from Greek and means "scattering," like seeds thrown across a field. People with roots in all eight South Asian countries form diasporas around the world.

Why do people move? Historians often talk about **push factors** (things that push people out, such as poverty, war, persecution or lack of land) and **pull factors** (things that pull them in, such as jobs, schools, safety or family already there). Most migrations have both. Laws and empires matter too: who is allowed to move, and who is wanted.

South Asian migration came in **waves**, each with its own causes:

Wave	When	Where to	Main cause
Indenture	1830s to about 1920	Caribbean, Fiji, Mauritius, South Africa	Plantations needed labor after slavery was abolished
East Africa	Late 1800s onward	Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania	Railway work and trade under British rule
Early North America	About 1900 to 1917	California, the US West Coast, Canada	Farm, lumber and railway jobs
Britain	After 1947, especially 1950s to 1970s	British cities	Postwar labor shortages; Commonwealth ties

Wave	When	Where to	Main cause
The Gulf	1970s onward	Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Qatar and neighbors	The oil boom
United States	After 1965	Cities and suburbs across the US	A new immigration law; jobs and study
Refugees	Many periods	Many countries	War, persecution, expulsion

Notice how many of these waves are tied to the British Empire. Britain ruled or controlled much of South Asia until 1947, and it also ran colonies in the Caribbean, Africa and the Pacific. Its ships, laws and labor needs moved South Asians around the world.

21.3 Indenture: The Sugar Ships

The first large wave began with the end of slavery. When Britain abolished slavery across its empire by an act of Parliament in 1833, plantation owners in sugar colonies such as British Guiana (now Guyana), Trinidad and Mauritius lost their enslaved workforce. They looked for a new source of cheap labor and found it in British India.

Indentured Labor was a system in which workers signed a contract, called an indenture, to work for a set number of years (usually five) on a plantation far from home, in return for passage, wages, housing and sometimes a return ticket. Indian workers called the contract *girmit*, their way of saying the English word "agreement," and the workers became known as *girmitiyas*.

On 29 January 1838, the ship *Hesperus* sailed from Calcutta (now Kolkata) with a sister ship, the *Whitby*. The *Hesperus* reached British Guiana on 5 May 1838 with 165 workers on board; thirteen others had died on the voyage. Guyanese still mark 5 May as Indian Arrival Day. Over the next eighty years, ships carried workers from the ports of Calcutta and Madras (now Chennai) to colonies across the world. Historians estimate that somewhere between about 1.3 million and more than 1.6 million South Asians went overseas under indenture before the system ended around 1920.

Destination	When indenture ran	Note
Mauritius	From 1834	Among the first and largest destinations
British Guiana (Guyana)	1838 to 1917	About 239,000 arrived
Trinidad	1845 to 1917	First ship, the *Fatel Razack*, on 30 May 1845; about 147,600 arrived
Fiji	1879 to 1916	First ship, the *Leonidas*, on 14 May 1879
Also	1800s to early 1900s	South Africa (Natal), Suriname, Jamaica and other colonies

Many recruits came from poor villages in what are now the Indian states of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, and others from the south. Some joined to escape poverty; many were misled by recruiters with false promises, and some were kidnapped outright. Colonial officials called it "free" migration, but conditions

on the plantations were often harsh. Public outrage in India and Britain over abuses helped end the system: Fiji stopped indenture in 1916, and all remaining contracts there were cancelled on 1 January 1920.

Was it a choice?

Workers signed contracts, so planters called indenture "free labor." Critics at the time called it a new form of slavery, and historians still debate how similar the two were. To me, "signing" doesn't mean much when you're poor, far from home and can be jailed for quitting.

Indo-Caribbean Communities

Most indentured workers never went back. They stayed, saved, bought land, built temples and mosques, and raised families. **Indo-Caribbean Communities** are the descendants of these South Asian migrants living in the Caribbean, especially in Guyana, Trinidad and Tobago, and Suriname, where they are the largest ethnic group. In Guyana's 2012 census about 40% of people were Indo-Guyanese, and in Trinidad and Tobago's 2011 census about 35% were of Indian descent.

Indo-Caribbean culture grew in its own direction. Over generations, families blended South Asian and Caribbean food, music, language and faith. Many Indo-Caribbeans are Hindu, many are Muslim and many are Christian. Trinidad marks Indian Arrival Day on 30 May.

Many Indo-Caribbean families have since moved again, especially to the New York area; since the 1960s a large community has grown in Richmond Hill, Queens, where a spring Phagwah (Holi) parade draws thousands of people each year. A person's family history might run from Bihar to Guyana

to Queens. The same pattern happened in Fiji, where many Indo-Fijians left after coups in 1987, and in Mauritius and South Africa.

21.4 East Africa

The Indian Ocean had linked South Asia and East Africa for a long time through trade carried by the monsoon winds (remember Chapter 1).

British colonial rule brought a much larger wave. Between 1896 and 1901, the British built the Uganda Railway, which ran from the port of Mombasa in Kenya inland to Lake Victoria. More than 30,000 workers were brought from British India to build it, many from Punjab and Gujarat. About 2,500 of them died, from disease, accidents and harsh conditions. Many who survived stayed when their contracts ended, and others followed as shopkeepers, clerks, craftspeople and civil servants.

South Asians in East Africa refers to the communities of Indian, and later Pakistani, origin that grew up in Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and neighboring countries from the late 1800s on. Under British rule they often held a middle position: below European officials, but in jobs, such as running shops and clerking, that many Africans were kept out of. That position helped some families prosper, and it also bred resentment that politicians would later use.

The Uganda Expulsion of 1972

The **Uganda Expulsion of 1972** was the forced removal of nearly all South Asians from Uganda by the military ruler Idi Amin, who announced on 4 August 1972 that they had 90 days to leave. About 80,000 people of South Asian descent lived in Uganda at the time, many of them born there. Amin accused them of disloyalty and of hurting the economy; their community leaders rejected those claims. Families had to abandon homes and businesses and could take very little with them.

Most held British passports from the colonial era, and around 28,000 went to the United Kingdom, where many first stayed in temporary resettlement camps. Thousands of others went to Canada, India, Kenya, Pakistan and elsewhere. Many rebuilt businesses and became well known in British towns such as Leicester. Uganda's later president, Yoweri Museveni, invited Asians to return, and some did.

Whose Story?

The Uganda expulsion is told very differently depending on who is telling it. In Britain it is often remembered as a story of welcome and success, with refugees who arrived with almost nothing and built successful businesses. But many families recall a colder arrival: the city council of Leicester even placed newspaper adverts in Uganda telling people not to come there. In Uganda, the expulsion is remembered as part of Amin's brutal rule, in which human rights groups estimate that somewhere between 100,000 and 500,000 Ugandans were killed, and a later president, Yoweri Museveni, encouraged Asians to come back. Some Ugandan Asians themselves remember Uganda as the only home they knew, and they don't describe it as "going back" to South Asia at all.

21.5 British South Asians

South Asians have lived in Britain for centuries. Sailors called *lascars*, many from Sylhet (in today's Bangladesh), worked on British ships and some settled in port cities. Students, servants and a few wealthy visitors came during colonial rule.

The big wave came after 1947. **British South Asians** are people in the United Kingdom with roots in South Asia, a community that grew sharply after independence when Britain needed workers to rebuild after World War II. As

Commonwealth citizens, people from India and Pakistan could come fairly easily, and many did in the 1950s and 1960s:

- **From Pakistan**, many came from Mirpur, in Pakistani-administered Kashmir, especially after the Mangla Dam, built in the 1960s, flooded villages and displaced tens of thousands. Others came from Punjab. Many worked in the textile mills of Lancashire and Yorkshire and in factories in the Midlands.
- **From India**, many came from Punjab and Gujarat, and others arrived later by way of East Africa, especially after the Uganda expulsion.
- **From Bangladesh**, most came from the Sylhet region, with migration peaking in the 1970s. Many settled in East London's Tower Hamlets, around Brick Lane, and Sylheti families opened many of the restaurants Britons call "Indian."

Britain began restricting Commonwealth immigration with the Commonwealth Immigrants Act of 1962, which allowed in mainly people with limited work vouchers, and families who came to join relatives. Many communities faced racism, including violent attacks, and organized to fight it.

Today, British South Asians are one of the largest groups in Britain. In the 2021 Census of England and Wales:

Group	Number (2021)	Share of population
Indian	1,864,304	3.1%
Pakistani	1,587,822	2.7%
Bangladeshi	644,900	1.1%

British South Asians include members of Parliament, doctors, business owners, artists and athletes, and British culture has absorbed South Asian food, music and words. Zara's great-uncle, the one who went to England, is part of this story.

21.6 The Gulf: Workers and Money Home

In the 1970s, oil prices shot up and the countries around the Gulf, such as Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates (UAE), Kuwait, Qatar, Oman and Bahrain, became very rich very fast. They needed workers to build roads, airports, hospitals and whole new cities, and to staff homes, shops and offices.

Gulf Migrant Workers are people from South Asia and other regions who go to work in the Gulf states, usually on temporary contracts, without the chance to become citizens. The wave started in the 1970s and has never stopped. Between 1972 and 1983, mass migration from the Indian state of Kerala to the Gulf was so large that it is called the "Kerala Gulf Boom." Workers also come in large numbers from Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka. Indians are the largest national group in the UAE.

Life for Gulf workers varies hugely. Some are engineers, doctors and bankers with good salaries. Many more are construction workers, drivers, domestic workers and cleaners. In most Gulf states, a sponsorship system called *kafala* has tied a worker's job and legal residence to one employer, giving employers great power. The International Labour Organization and rights groups have warned that this leaves many workers, especially domestic workers, with weak protections. Some countries, such as Qatar and Saudi Arabia, have made reforms in recent years, which critics say are not always enforced.

Don't flatten Gulf workers into one story

It's easy to picture Gulf migration as only hardship or only riches. In real families it's usually both: a father missing his kids' childhood while his salary pays for their school. Ask before you assume.

Remittances

Remittances are money that migrants send home to their families. Gulf workers send much of their pay home, and so do South Asians in Britain, the US and everywhere else. That money pays for food, school fees, weddings, medical care and new houses, and it adds up to very large sums.

Country	Remittances received, 2025 (World Bank)
India	about US$150.7 billion, the most of any country in the world
Pakistan	about US$40.5 billion
Bangladesh	about US$33.9 billion
Nepal	about US$14.7 billion, equal to about 32% of Nepal's GDP

You read in Chapter 20 how important remittances are to Nepal.

21.7 South Asians in the United States

Punjabi Pioneers in California

Many people think South Asians first came to the US in the 1960s, but they arrived more than half a century earlier. **Punjabi Pioneers in California** were the South Asian men, mostly Sikhs from Punjab, who came to the US West Coast in the early 1900s to work in mills, on railways and on farms, and who later farmed in California's agricultural valleys.

They faced hostility from the start. On 4 September 1907, a mob in Bellingham, Washington, attacked and drove out South Asian mill workers. Newspapers called them "Hindus," even though most were Sikh. In 1912 the pioneers founded a gurdwara in Stockton, California, the first Sikh house of worship in the US. The Immigration Act of 1917 then created an "Asiatic Barred Zone" that banned new immigrants from British India, Afghanistan and much of Asia.

Because almost no South Asian women could come, and because California law banned marriages between people labeled as different races, many Punjabi men married Mexican and Mexican American women who worked beside them in the fields. Almost 400 of these Punjabi-Mexican couples lived in California's farm valleys, raising children who spoke Spanish and English and ate both roti and tortillas.

The Bhagat Singh Thind Case

The Bhagat Singh Thind Case (*United States v. Bhagat Singh Thind*, 1923) was a US Supreme Court decision that ruled South Asians were not "white persons" and therefore could not become naturalized citizens. At the time, US law allowed only "free white persons" and people of African descent to naturalize.

Bhagat Singh Thind was a Sikh man born in Punjab who served in the US Army during World War I. He argued that, as an Indian of "Aryan" descent, he counted as Caucasian and therefore white. On 19 February 1923 the Court unanimously rejected his claim, saying the law used "white" in its everyday

meaning, not a scientific one. After the decision, the government moved to strip citizenship from many South Asians who had already naturalized, and it left them barred from owning farmland under California's 1913 Alien Land Law, which applied to immigrants "ineligible for citizenship."

The ruling stood for more than twenty years. Thind himself became a citizen in 1936 under a law for World War I veterans. In 1946 the Luce-Celler Act finally let Indians naturalize, with an immigration quota of just 100 people a year. One person who benefited was Dalip Singh Saund, a Punjabi farmer and judge in California, who in 1956 became the first Indian American, and the first Sikh, elected to the US Congress.

The Immigration Act of 1965

The **Immigration Act of 1965** (the Immigration and Nationality Act, also called the Hart-Celler Act) was a US law, signed by President Lyndon Johnson at the Statue of Liberty on 3 October 1965, that ended the "national origins" quota system, which had heavily favored immigrants from northern and western Europe since the 1920s. The new system gave preference to people with family already in the US and to people with skills the country needed.

The effect on South Asian immigration was huge. Doctors, engineers, scientists and students came first, and then their spouses, parents and siblings through family reunification. Later decades brought more varied arrivals: taxi drivers and shop owners as well as tech workers, refugees from Bhutan and Afghanistan, and students from every South Asian country.

This is how big South Asian American communities were in 2023, according to Pew Research Center fact sheets based on Census data:

Origin	Population in the US (2023, Pew)
Indian	about 5.2 million
Pakistani	about 680,000
Bangladeshi	about 300,000
Nepalese	about 225,000
Sri Lankan	about 85,000
Bhutanese	about 20,000

Source: Pew Research Center fact sheets (May 2025), using 2023 American Community Survey data; people who identify with the group alone or in combination.

Show the numbers as a table

Indian Americans are the second-largest Asian origin group in the US, about 21% of all Asian Americans. Most South Asian Americans are immigrants or children of immigrants: 66% of Indian Americans and 71% of Bangladeshi Americans were born abroad (2023, Pew).

The Model Minority Myth

The **Model Minority Myth** is the stereotype that Asian Americans, including South Asian Americans, are all successful, wealthy, highly educated and free of problems, often used to compare them favorably with other minority groups. It is called a myth because it hides real differences and real struggles.

Look at Pew's numbers (2023 data, published 2025):

Group	Median household income	Share living in poverty
Indian Americans	about $151,200	6%
Nepalese Americans	about $94,800	9%
Bangladeshi Americans	about $78,400	14%
All Asian Americans	about $105,600	10%

Bangladeshi-headed households earned roughly half as much as Indian-headed ones. Behind any average are taxi drivers, restaurant workers and families just getting by, as well as doctors and engineers.

The myth causes harm in several ways. It makes struggling students feel invisible or ashamed to ask for help. It pressures teens toward a few "approved" careers. It ignores how the 1965 law selected for highly educated immigrants, which explains part of the success story. And it is used to pit Asian Americans against Black and Latino Americans, as if each group's outcomes were only about effort.

Post-9/11 Backlash

After the terrorist attacks of 11 September 2001, many South Asian, Arab and Muslim Americans faced a wave of hatred. **Post-9/11 Backlash** refers to the hate crimes, harassment, profiling and discrimination aimed at people perceived as Muslim or Middle Eastern after the attacks, including many South Asians.

The first killings reported as revenge for the attacks happened on 15 September 2001. In Mesa, Arizona, Balbir Singh Sodhi, a Sikh immigrant who owned a gas station, was shot and killed by a man who wanted revenge for 9/11 and who profiled him as an Arab Muslim because of his turban and beard. Sodhi was not Muslim, and he had nothing to do with the attacks; his killer lumped together people of different faiths and backgrounds. The same day, Waqar Hasan, a Muslim immigrant from Pakistan, was shot and killed in his store in Dallas, Texas. On 4 October the same gunman killed Vasudev Patel, a Hindu immigrant from India, at a gas station in nearby Mesquite. FBI data show that reported anti-Islamic hate crime incidents jumped from 28 in 2000 to 481 in 2001, and attacks on people because of their ethnicity, including South Asians, also rose sharply.

Many communities responded by organizing. The Sikh Coalition, for example, was formed by volunteers on the night of 11 September 2001 to defend Sikh Americans' civil rights, and Sodhi's family later gave one of his turbans to the Smithsonian's 9/11 collection. Many teens today hear about this period from their parents, who remember changing how they dressed, or being stopped at airports again and again.

21.8 South Asians in Minnesota

Now bring it home. **South Asians in Minnesota** are the residents of Minnesota with roots in South Asia, a community that today includes families from every

South Asian country, with temples, mosques, gurdwaras, cultural associations and student clubs across the Twin Cities and beyond.

How many are there? The best source is the US Census Bureau's American Community Survey (ACS). Here are its estimates for Minnesota, averaged over 2020 to 2024 (the most recent five-year data available in October 2026):

Group (Census label)	Estimate in Minnesota, 2020-2024 ACS	Margin of error
Asian Indian	52,192	± 2,528
Pakistani	3,613	± 964
Nepalese	3,023	± 707
Bangladeshi	1,935	± 572
Sri Lankan	1,927	± 598
Afghan (listed by the Census as Central Asian)	1,380	± 719
Bhutanese	694	± 710

Add the six South Asian rows (leaving out the Afghan row) and you get about 63,400. The same table counts a few hundred more people under "Sikh" and "Other South Asian," which brings the total to about 64,000, a little over 1% of Minnesota's roughly 5.7 million residents (US Census Bureau, ACS 2020-2024, table B02018).

How to read a Census table

That "±" is the margin of error: the Census surveys a sample, not everyone, so small groups have big uncertainty. A person who checks two groups is counted in both, and someone who writes "Punjabi" or "Sikh" might be counted differently from their cousin, so treat these numbers as good estimates, not exact headcounts.

Minnesota's South Asian community includes people who came for work or study, Nepali, Bhutanese and Afghan families, and second- and third-generation teens like Zara and Nima. Ask around your school and you'll likely find families from several of the eight countries.

21.9 Desi Identity and Transnational Families

Desi Identity

You've probably heard the word *desi*. In Bangla it's দেশি (*DAY-shee*), and in Hindi देसी (*DAY-see*); both come from *desh*, "homeland" or "country," the word you met in Chapter 1. **Desi Identity** is the shared sense of belonging that many people of South Asian heritage, especially in the diaspora, express with the word "desi," meaning roughly "one of us, from back home."

In the diaspora, people from different countries, faiths and languages often discover they have a lot in common: similar foods, film songs, cricket and big family weddings. A Pakistani kid and an Indian kid in Minnesota may feel closer to each other than either expected. Many South Asian student clubs, like Zara's, are built on that shared desi feeling.

But "desi" doesn't fit everyone the same way. Some Afghans, Nepalis, Sri Lankans, Bhutanese and Maldivians don't use the word for themselves. Many Indo-Caribbean people have their own words and traditions. A good club makes room for people to name themselves.

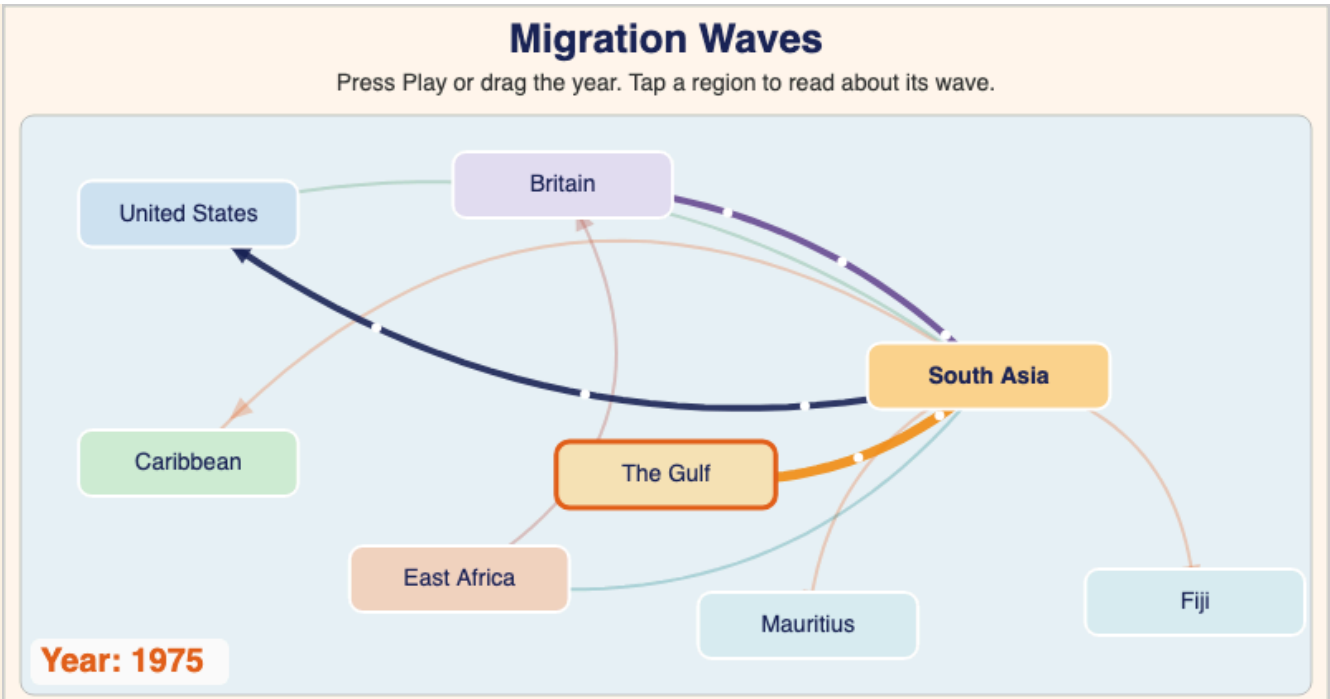
Transnational Families

Transnational Families are families whose members live in two or more countries but stay closely connected, sharing money, decisions, care and daily life across borders. Many South Asian diaspora families live this way. A grandmother in Dhaka joins dinner every night by video call. A cousin in Dubai sends money for a sister's wedding in Kerala. Parents in Minnesota debate whether to retire "back home." Teens spend summers with grandparents in Lahore or Kathmandu.

Living across borders helps families and also strains them. Families keep languages and traditions alive, and they can help each other in a crisis. But they also miss weddings and funerals, worry about relatives far away, and sometimes feel they don't fully belong in either place. Zara feels that when she answers her Nanu in English. Many second-generation teens describe it as being "too South Asian" in one place and "too American" in the other, and then slowly building an identity that is fully both.

Back at dinner, Zara's mother finally tells the story. Nanu's brother went to London in the 1970s and worked in a restaurant. Years later, he helped Zara's father get a student visa, and her parents chose Minnesota because a friend from Chattogram already lived here and said the schools were good. "So it was a chain," Zara says. "Everyone pulled the next person." Her mother nods. "That's how it always works."

Diagram: Migration Waves



Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders.

The Gulf (1970s to today)

Why: The oil boom: Gulf states needed builders, drivers, nurses, engineers and domestic workers.

Fact: Remittances to India were about US$150.7 billion in 2025, the most of any country (World Bank).

Active in 1975: Britain, The Gulf, United States after 1965

Play Reset

The Gulf

Back to Migration Waves Lesson Plan

Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch21-migration-waves/main.html

Open the Migration Waves fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Migration Waves

sim-id: ch21-migration-waves
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Understand
Bloom Verb: identify, explain
Learning Objective: The learner will identify the major waves of South Asian migration (indenture, East Africa, early North America, Britain, the Gulf and the post-1965 United States) and explain the main cause of each.

Canvas: responsive width; 670 px drawing area plus 90 px control area.

Controls: Play / Pause button, Reset button, year slider (1830 to 2020), wave menu; click or tap a region tile.

Behavior: Labeled region tiles (not a real map) surround a central South Asia tile. As the year changes, arcs light up for waves active that year and stay faintly visible after they end; a secondary arc shows the 1972 move from East Africa to Britain. Selecting a wave shows a card with its dates, cause and one sourced fact. The timeline starts paused. The caption "Schematic map, not to scale. Not an official depiction of borders." is drawn in the drawing area.

Press **Play** and watch the arcs appear as the years pass. Pause at 1850, 1910, 1960, 1980 and 2010, and list which waves are active each time. Then click each tile to read why people went there.

Notice how the causes change: plantations and empire in the 1800s, railways and trade around 1900, rebuilding Britain after 1947, oil money after the 1970s, and a new US law in 1965. Notice too that some arcs don't start in South Asia at all, like the one from East Africa to Britain in 1972. The tiles are not a map, so distances and positions are only rough.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about how and why your family (or theirs) moved: when they came, what the first weeks were like, what they brought and what they miss. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Ask if they would like to look at an old passport, ticket, photo or letter together. Objects bring back memories. Ask before you take notes or record.

Questions to ask

1. Where were you living before you moved, and what was a normal day like there?
2. Why did you decide to leave? Was there one moment when you knew you were going?
3. Why here? Did you know anyone in this country or city before you came?
4. What do you remember about your first weeks: the weather, the food, school or work, people who helped?
5. What did you bring with you, and what do you wish you had brought? How has your connection to back home changed over the years?
6. What part of where you came from do you hope I'll keep?

Listen for: push and pull factors behind their move; links to a wave in this chapter, such as the Immigration Act of 1965, Gulf Migrant Workers or British

South Asians; and signs of Transnational Families, such as Remittances, video calls or relatives in several countries.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Compare your elder's migration story with one of the waves in this chapter. Which push and pull factors match, and which are unique to your family? If a friend interviewed someone who came at a different time or from a different country, list two ways their stories differ and one way they're the same.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: South Asians only came to the US after 1965.
Reality: Punjabi Sikh workers came to the US West Coast in the early 1900s, founded a gurdwara in Stockton in 1912 and farmed in California for decades. Laws in 1917 and the 1923 Thind decision then shut most South Asians out until the 1940s and 1960s.

Myth: All South Asian Americans are doctors or engineers, and they're all well off.
Reality: That's the model minority myth. In 2023, the median household income of Bangladeshi Americans was about half that of Indian Americans, and 14% of Bangladeshi Americans lived in poverty (Pew). South Asian Americans work in every kind of job.

Myth: Indenture was just voluntary migration for better jobs.
Reality: Workers did sign contracts, but many were poor, misled by recruiters

and bound by laws that made quitting a crime. Critics at the time compared it to slavery, and historians still debate how similar the two systems were.

Myth: The South Asian diaspora is all Indian.
Reality: There are large Pakistani and Bangladeshi communities in Britain, Nepali and Bangladeshi workers in the Gulf, Sri Lankan Tamil communities in Canada, and Afghan, Bhutanese and Nepali families in the US, including in Minnesota.

Check Yourself

1. What is a diaspora?

A diaspora is a population living outside its ancestral homeland that keeps some connection to it, through family, faith, language, food or shared identity. The word comes from Greek for "scattering."

2. Why did British sugar colonies start recruiting indentured workers from India in the 1830s?

Britain abolished slavery across its empire, so plantation owners lost their enslaved workforce and turned to contract workers from British India.

3. What happened in Uganda in 1972?

Idi Amin gave about 80,000 people of South Asian descent 90 days to leave the country. Around 28,000 went to Britain, and others went to Canada, India and elsewhere.

4. What did the Supreme Court decide in the Bhagat Singh Thind case?

In 1923 it ruled unanimously that South Asians were not "white persons" under US law and so could not become naturalized citizens. Many who had already naturalized lost their citizenship.

5. What are remittances, and why do they matter to countries like Nepal?

Remittances are money migrants send home. In 2025 they equaled about 32% of Nepal's GDP (World Bank), so they pay for food, schooling and housing for many families.

Exercises

Remember

1. List three destinations of Indian indentured laborers and the year indenture began in one of them.

   Answer

   Any three of: Mauritius (from 1834), British Guiana/Guyana (1838), Trinidad (1845), Fiji (1879), South Africa, Suriname, Jamaica.

2. What did the Immigration Act of 1965 end, and who signed it?

Answer

It ended the national origins quota system that favored northern and western European immigrants. President Lyndon Johnson signed it on 3 October 1965.

Understand

1. Explain why many Punjabi men in early 1900s California married Mexican and Mexican American women.

Answer

Almost no South Asian women could immigrate, and California law banned marriages between people labeled as different races. Mexican and Mexican American women often worked beside Punjabi men in the fields, and those marriages were allowed.

2. Explain why the model minority myth is called a myth.

Answer

It hides big differences between groups and families, such as the gap in income and poverty between Indian and Bangladeshi Americans, and it ignores how US immigration law selected highly educated immigrants. It also harms people who struggle and is used to compare minority groups unfairly.

Apply

1. Use the Migration Waves sim. Set the year to 1975 and list every wave that is active. For each one, name the main cause. *Hint: some waves had ended by then but still show faintly.*
2. A classmate's grandparents came to Britain from Mirpur in the 1960s. Using this chapter, explain what push and pull factors might have shaped their move. *Hint: think about the Mangla Dam and Britain's labor needs.*

Analyze

1. Compare indentured laborers in the 1800s with Gulf migrant workers today. What is similar about their situations, and what is different? *Hint: think about contracts, citizenship, money sent home and freedom to change jobs.*
2. Analyze the Minnesota table in Section 21.8. Why might the Bhutanese estimate be less reliable than the Asian Indian estimate, and what could cause someone to be counted in two groups? *Hint: look at the margins of error and Mora's tip.*

Evaluate

1. The word "desi" brings many people together, but not everyone uses it. Should a South Asian student club call itself a "desi club"? Evaluate both sides and give your recommendation. *Hint: think about Nepali, Afghan, Sri Lankan and Indo-Caribbean members.*
2. Britain often remembers the arrival of Ugandan Asians as a success story. Using the Whose Story? box, evaluate whether that version is complete. *Hint: consider Leicester's adverts and the refugees' own memories.*

Create

1. Create a one-page "family migration map" for your family or an interviewee: a schematic drawing (not an official map) showing each move, its year and one push and one pull factor. *Hint: use arrows and labeled boxes, like the Migration Waves sim.*
2. Write a short letter (150 to 200 words) from a fictional teen in a transnational family, for example a girl in Minnesota writing to her cousin in Dhaka, describing one way their lives are connected and one way they feel different. *Hint: use at least two concept words from this chapter.*

Key Takeaways

- A diaspora is a scattered population that keeps ties to its homeland; South Asians from all eight countries form diasporas worldwide.
- After Britain abolished slavery, about 1.3 to 1.6 million South Asians went overseas as indentured laborers from the 1830s to about 1920, creating Indo-Caribbean, Indo-Fijian and other communities.
- South Asians built and traded in East Africa from the late 1800s; in 1972 Idi Amin expelled about 80,000 from Uganda, and around 28,000 went to Britain.
- British South Asians grew after 1947; in 2021 about 1.86 million Indian, 1.59 million Pakistani and 645,000 Bangladeshi people lived in England and Wales.
- The 1970s oil boom drew millions of South Asian workers to the Gulf, and remittances now total about US$150.7 billion a year for India alone (2025, World Bank).
- In the US, Punjabi pioneers arrived around 1900, the 1923 Thind decision blocked citizenship, and the 1965 Immigration Act opened the door to

today's large communities, which still face the model minority myth and faced a wave of post-9/11 hate.

- About 64,000 people in Minnesota belong to South Asian groups (ACS 2020-2024), and many live in transnational families that span continents.

You've traced the routes!

You now know the big waves that carried South Asians around the world, and where your own family's story might fit. In Chapter 22, we bring it all home: you'll turn your interviews into a real oral history project for your school or club.

Quiz: The South Asian Diaspora

Test your understanding of Chapter 21. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

Which description best fits the word "diaspora"?

A. Any group of tourists visiting a foreign country

B. A population living outside its ancestral homeland that keeps some connection to it

C. People who move from a village to a city inside the same country

D. A government program that sends workers abroad on contracts

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. A diaspora lives outside its ancestral homeland but keeps ties to it through family, faith, language, food or identity. Moving from a village to a city inside one country is migration, but it does not create a diaspora, because people have not left the homeland.

Concept Tested: Diaspora **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

Why did plantation owners in British sugar colonies begin recruiting indentured workers from India in the 1830s?

A. India's government asked Britain to send its farmers abroad

B. Sugar prices had collapsed and planters wanted cheaper machines

C. The workers were fleeing the Partition of India

D. Britain had abolished slavery, and planters wanted a new source of cheap labor

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Britain abolished slavery across its empire by an 1833 act, so planters in places like British Guiana, Trinidad and Mauritius turned to contract workers from British India. Partition happened in 1947, more than a century later, so it cannot explain this wave.

Concept Tested: Indentured Labor **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 3

In 1972, Idi Amin gave South Asians in Uganda how long to leave the country?

A. 90 days

B. 30 days

C. One year

D. Five years

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. On 4 August 1972, Amin announced that South Asians had 90 days to leave. About 80,000 people were affected, and around 28,000 went to the United Kingdom.

Concept Tested: Uganda Expulsion of 1972 **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

What did the US Supreme Court decide in *United States v. Bhagat Singh Thind* (1923)?

A. South Asians could become citizens if they had served in the army

B. California's ban on Punjabi farmers was unconstitutional

C. South Asians were not "white persons" under the law, so they could not naturalize

D. Sikhs had the right to wear turbans in the military

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The Court ruled unanimously that "white" meant its everyday meaning, so Thind, a South Asian, could not become a naturalized citizen. Thind did later become a citizen in 1936 through a law for World War I veterans, but that was not what the 1923 decision said.

Concept Tested: Bhagat Singh Thind Case **Bloom's Level:** Remember

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Question 5

Why did the Immigration Act of 1965 lead to a large increase in South Asian immigration to the United States?

A. It ended the national origins quotas that had favored northern and western Europeans

B. It gave every South Asian an automatic green card

C. It created the Asiatic Barred Zone

D. It only allowed immigrants who already spoke English

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The 1965 law replaced national origins quotas with preferences for family reunification and needed skills, which opened the door to South Asian doctors, engineers, students and then their families. The Asiatic Barred Zone came from the 1917 law and did the opposite.

Concept Tested: Immigration Act of 1965 **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 6

A worker from Kerala takes a construction job in the UAE. Under the *kafala* system, his visa and legal residence are tied to his employer, and he cannot become a citizen. Which concept from the chapter best describes him?

A. Indentured Labor

B. Gulf Migrant Workers

C. Punjabi Pioneers in California

D. Indo-Caribbean Communities

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Gulf migrant workers usually go on temporary contracts, often under kafala, without a path to citizenship. Indenture is a tempting choice because both involve contracts far from home, but the indenture system ended around 1920.

Concept Tested: Gulf Migrant Workers **Bloom's Level:** Apply

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Question 7

According to Pew Research Center (2023 data), Bangladeshi American households had a median income of about $78,400, while Indian American households had about $151,200. What does this comparison most directly show?

A. Bangladeshi Americans work fewer hours than Indian Americans

B. All Asian Americans earn more than other Americans

C. The 1965 law banned Bangladeshi immigrants

D. Treating all South Asian Americans as wealthy hides real differences between groups

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. The big gap between groups is one reason the model minority myth is called a myth: it hides real differences and struggles. The data say nothing about hours worked, so option A is an unsupported assumption.

Concept Tested: Model Minority Myth **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 8

In 2025, remittances to Nepal equaled about 32% of the country's GDP (World Bank). Which statement is the best conclusion from that number?

A. Nepal receives more remittance money than India

B. Most Nepalis live outside Nepal

C. Money sent home by migrants is a very large part of Nepal's economy

D. Nepal's government sends money to workers abroad

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. A share of nearly a third of GDP means remittances matter a great deal to Nepali families and the economy. India receives far more money in total (about US$150.7 billion in 2025), so option A confuses share with total amount.

Concept Tested: Remittances **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Question 9

Simran's family friend says, "My uncle came to California from Punjab in 1910, worked on farms, and married a Mexican woman because almost no Punjabi women could come." Which part of the chapter does his story fit?

A. Punjabi Pioneers in California

B. Post-9/11 Backlash

C. The Immigration Act of 1965

D. British South Asians

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Punjabi men came to the US West Coast in the early 1900s, and many married Mexican and Mexican American women because South Asian women could rarely immigrate and California law banned marriages across racial labels. The 1965 law came more than fifty years later.

Concept Tested: Punjabi Pioneers in California **Bloom's Level:** Apply

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Question 10

Balbir Singh Sodhi, a Sikh man, was killed on 15 September 2001 by an attacker who thought he was an Arab Muslim. What does this case best reveal about the post-9/11 backlash?

A. Only Muslims were targeted after the attacks

B. Hatred lumped together people of different faiths and backgrounds based on how they looked

C. Hate crimes fell sharply after September 2001

D. Sikh Americans were rarely affected because they are not Muslim

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Sodhi was targeted because of his turban and beard, even though he was not Muslim or Arab, which shows how attackers profiled people by appearance. Option A is wrong because Sikhs and other South Asians were also attacked. Option C is wrong because FBI data show anti-Islamic incidents rose, not fell, from 28 in 2000 to 481 in 2001.

Concept Tested: Post-9/11 Backlash **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Chapter 22: Bring It Home

Summary

This last chapter turns the book back toward you. It starts with identity: how people with roots in South Asia describe themselves, why labels and hyphens matter, and how stereotypes and colorism shape the way others see them. It then asks a question every club meets sooner or later: what is the difference between appreciating a culture and appropriating it, and what does a good ally do? Finally, it gives you the full oral history method (consent, active listening and careful preservation) so the Ask Your Elders interviews you've done across 21 chapters can become something that lasts, for your family, your club and your community.

Concepts Covered

1. Cultural Identity
2. Hyphenated Identity
3. Third Culture Kids
4. Stereotypes
5. Colorism
6. Cultural Appropriation
7. Cultural Appreciation
8. Intergenerational Dialogue
9. Oral History

10. Informed Consent
11. Active Listening
12. Cultural Preservation
13. Allyship
14. Student Clubs
15. Community Organizing
16. Community Impact

Prerequisites

This chapter draws on the whole book, but these chapters help most:

- Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition, for why some family memories are painful
- Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts, for heritage languages and what happens when they fade
- Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events, for kinship words and family roles
- Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora, for how families came to live outside South Asia

Last chapter, biggest project

Hi again, it's Mora! You've spent 21 chapters learning about the region, and maybe 21 conversations learning from the people around you. Right now, the grandparents and great-aunts who remember 1947, 1971, a village festival or a first winter in Minnesota are still here to ask. This chapter shows you how to keep their stories safe and how to use what you've learned to make your school a little better for everyone.

22.1 Twenty-One Pages of Nanu

It's the last week of May. The Prairie Ridge South Asian Student Association has one meeting left this year, and Zara Hossain is sitting on her bedroom floor with a stack of notebook pages. There are 21 of them, one for every Ask Your Elders interview she did with her Nanu. One page has the smell of the first monsoon rain in Chattogram. One has the Bangla word for the river ferry. One has a story about 1971 that Nanu told only once, very quietly, and then asked Zara to keep "just for the family."

Zara wants to do something with all of it. A booklet? A club night? A post? But she's not sure what she's allowed to share, or how.

Ben Lindqvist has a different worry. He's been the club's first non-South Asian member all year. He ran the quiz games, learned to count Teentaal and ate more biryani than anyone. Now some new freshmen are asking to join, and one of them asked him, "Is it weird that you're in it?" Ben texts Zara: "How do I help the club without being the guy who takes over? Like, what's my actual job?"

Zara and Ben have two questions between them. How do you turn what you've learned into something that lasts, and how does everyone, whatever their background, take part in a way that's fair? This chapter answers both.

22.2 Who Am I? Cultural Identity

Start with something familiar: your favorite playlist. Some songs came from your parents' car, some from friends, some from a movie or a trip. You didn't write any of them, but you chose which ones to keep, and the list keeps changing. Nobody else's playlist is exactly like yours.

Identity works a lot like that.

Cultural Identity is a person's sense of belonging to one or more cultural groups, built from family, language, faith, food, place, history and the people around them. It is partly given (you didn't choose your grandparents) and partly chosen (you decide what to carry forward), and it changes over a lifetime.

For a teen with roots in South Asia, it might include a home region like Punjab, Kerala, Kandy or Chattogram, a language a grandparent speaks, a faith or a family's values, festival foods, and a Minnesota suburb with long winters and hockey. None of these makes someone "more" or "less" South Asian. Zara understands Bangla but answers in English, and that bothers her a little. She is not alone: in a Pew Research Center analysis of 2021-23 Census Bureau survey data, 28% of Indian Americans ages 5 and older spoke only English at home. Many heritage speakers understand far more than they say, and that understanding counts.

Labels and the hyphen

People name this kind of identity in many ways.

Label	What it usually means	Notes
Bangladeshi American, Pakistani American, Sri Lankan American, Indian American	Someone in the US with roots in one country	The most specific. Many people prefer naming their own country.
South Asian American	Roots anywhere in the eight countries	Common in clubs and archives. It doesn't center one country.
Desi	An informal word many in the diaspora use for themselves	Not everyone uses it (see below).
Bengali, Punjabi, Tamil, Pashtun	A language or regional community	Often older and more personal than any country name.

The word desi (देसी, *DAY-see*) comes from Hindi-Urdu and means "of the homeland" or "local." Many young people use it warmly, but not everyone from South Asia uses it or likes it for themselves. So ask people what they call themselves before you choose a label for them.

Hyphenated Identity means belonging to two or more cultures at once, sometimes written with a hyphen, as in "Indian-American." The hyphen has a history. In the United States from about 1890 to 1920, "hyphenated American" was a put-down suggesting immigrants were not fully loyal. In March 2019 the Associated Press, whose stylebook many newspapers follow, dropped the

hyphen from dual-heritage terms like "Asian American." Some people see the hyphen as a bridge between two homes; others say it makes them sound like half of each. Zara writes "Bangladeshi American." Her cousin in London says "British Bangladeshi." Both are right for them.

Third culture kids

Third Culture Kids are people who spent a large part of their childhood living in a culture different from their parents', usually because a parent's job moved the family between countries. The term comes from Ruth Useem, a sociologist at Michigan State University, who first used it in the 1960s for the children of Americans working abroad. She had developed the idea of a "third culture" with her husband, John Useem, after a year-long research stay in India. The "first culture" is the parents' home culture, the "second" is where the family lives, and the "third" is the blend the child builds from both.

Strictly speaking, children of immigrants who settle in one country, like Zara, aren't usually called third culture kids. But many second-generation teens say the idea fits how they feel: at home in two places, and fully at home in neither. Arjun Reddy, a friend from school, says he's "Hyderabad at dinner and Minnesota at practice."

Culture moves

If culture never changed, nobody in South Asia would cook with chilies, which arrived from the Americas, probably with Portuguese traders, in the 1500s. Mixing traditions is what every generation before you did too.

22.3 Stereotypes and Colorism

Identity is how you see yourself. Other people also have ideas about you, and some of those ideas are unfair.

Stereotypes are fixed, oversimplified beliefs about a whole group of people, applied to every member of it. "South Asian kids are all good at math." "Every South Asian family wants a doctor." "They all speak Indian." (There is no language called "Indian." India alone lists 22 languages in its Constitution's Eighth Schedule, as Chapter 6 showed.)

Some stereotypes sound like compliments, but they still hurt. A student who struggles in chemistry may be ashamed to ask for help because everyone "expects" them to be good at it. And every stereotype erases the differences you've read about in this book, between eight countries, dozens of languages and many faiths. Stereotypes also live inside communities: a Punjabi family might joke about Bengalis, or a Pakistani family about Indians, and the other way around.

To push back without starting a fight, try asking a question ("What makes you say that?"), adding a real example ("My cousin is a pastry chef, actually") or naming the range ("South Asia is eight countries. Which one do you mean?"). And never ask the only South Asian student in a room to speak for everyone.

Colorism

One stereotype deserves its own section, because it often lives inside families.

Colorism is prejudice or unfair treatment based on skin tone, usually favoring lighter skin over darker skin, including among people of the same background. The American writer Alice Walker is widely credited with bringing the word into use in the early 1980s, writing about the African American community. The same pattern shows up in many places, including South Asia.

In many South Asian families and media, lighter skin has long been praised and darker skin treated as something to fix. You may have heard an aunty warn a cousin not to play in the sun, or seen matrimonial ads asking for a "fair" bride. Writers and researchers trace this preference to several roots, including older social hierarchies and the legacy of colonial rule.

One well-documented example is Fair & Lovely, a skin-lightening cream made by Hindustan Unilever. It went on sale in India in 1975 and is sold in India, Bangladesh, Pakistan, Sri Lanka and beyond. After years of criticism that its name and ads linked "fair" skin to success, the company renamed it Glow & Lovely in 2020 and said its ads would show women of many skin tones. The cream itself is still sold. The renaming shows that public pressure can change how a company talks about beauty, even when the product stays.

Be careful with this one

Colorism can be very personal. If you talk about it in a club, talk about patterns and media, not about any member's skin, and never make a joke of it.

22.4 Appreciation or Appropriation?

Picture a jacket. In one version, a friend asks to borrow your grandfather's old jacket, learns the story behind it and tells people, "This was Zara's grandfather's." In another, someone takes it without asking, wears it as a joke costume and later sells copies under their own name. It's the same jacket, but the relationship is very different.

Cultural Appropriation is when someone, usually from a more powerful or dominant group, takes an element of another group's culture (clothing,

symbols, music, sacred practices) in a way that ignores its meaning, gives no credit, or turns it into a costume or product without the community's involvement. It stings most when the people who created a tradition were mocked for the very same thing.

Cultural Appreciation is learning about, honoring and taking part in another culture with respect: understanding what something means, being invited or welcome, giving credit, and supporting the people the tradition comes from.

Situation	Leans toward appreciation	Leans toward appropriation
Saree, salwar kameez or kurta	A friend's family invites you to a wedding and helps you wear it	Wearing it as a "costume" for a theme party
Bindi	Wearing one when invited to a festival by people who explain it	Using it as a sparkly sticker for a music festival look, unaware it has religious meaning for many Hindus
Mehndi (henna)	Getting mehndi at a friend's Eid or wedding celebration	Calling it a "tribal tattoo" and selling designs without credit
Yoga	Practicing it and learning its roots in South Asian traditions	Marketing it as a brand-new Western fitness invention

Situation	Leans toward appreciation	Leans toward appropriation
Food	Learning a friend's family recipe and naming where it comes from	Claiming you "invented" a dish after stripping out what makes it South Asian

About yoga: it grew out of South Asian religious and philosophical traditions, and in 2014 the United Nations declared 21 June the International Day of Yoga. Yoga is a tradition, not a proven treatment for any disease, and nothing here is medical advice.

When you're not sure, ask yourself: Do I know what this means to the people it comes from? Was I invited? Is it sacred to anyone? Who gets the credit and the money? Would I do this the same way in front of a grandparent from that community?

Whose Story?

People inside South Asian communities don't all agree on where the line is. Many families are thrilled when a non-South Asian friend wears a lehenga to a wedding, and see it as a welcome. Others feel hurt seeing a bindi or a turban used as a costume, especially if they were teased for wearing the same thing at school. Some scholars argue that "appropriation" is used too loosely, since cultures have always borrowed through trade and migration, like chilies, tea and cricket. Others argue that borrowing is different when one side holds much more power and money. The questions above won't settle every case, but they help you think it through with the people most affected.

22.5 Being a Good Ally

Back to Ben's question: "What's my actual job?"

Allyship is the ongoing practice of supporting a group you are not part of, by listening, learning, showing up and using whatever voice or access you have to back that group, while letting its members lead and speak for themselves. You show it by what you keep doing, over and over.

For Ben, that looks like:

- **Listening first.** When a member describes being stereotyped, he doesn't jump in with "I'm sure they didn't mean it."
- **Doing his homework,** so members don't have to teach him everything.
- **Taking real jobs, not the microphone.** He runs the quiz and sets up chairs. He doesn't present "what Diwali is" to the school while South Asian members sit in the audience.
- **Speaking up where they aren't.** If a hockey teammate mocks an accent, Ben can say "Not funny" in a room no club member is in.
- **Taking correction well.** If he mispronounces a name, he says "Thanks, I'll get it right," and moves on.

Allyship works inside the club too. A Bangladeshi member can be an ally to a Sri Lankan Tamil member, and a Hindu member to a Muslim member. Nima Sherpa, whose family is from Nepal, may notice when "South Asian night" is really just "Indian night" and say so. Being South Asian doesn't make anyone an expert on all of South Asia.

A simple rule for allies

Back people up instead of replacing them. If you're about to speak for a group, first ask whether someone from that group would rather speak.

So what should Ben tell the freshman? "No, it's not weird. The club is for anyone who wants to learn. My job is to show up, listen and help."

22.6 Culture Lives in People: Oral History

Now for Zara's 21 pages.

A book can explain the monsoon, Partition or a wedding custom. It can't tell you what your Nanu smelled on the first rainy morning in Chattogram. That kind of knowledge lives in people, which is why every chapter ended with Ask Your Elders.

Intergenerational Dialogue is conversation between people of different generations, such as grandparents, parents and teens, in which each side learns from the other. Teens ask, elders tell, and sometimes elders ask back: "Why does your club do Diwali in October? We did it differently." A structured interview often opens up stories that never come out at the dinner table.

Oral History is the practice of recording people's memories of their own lives, in their own words, and keeping those recordings or notes so others can learn from them later. Two people can remember the same day differently, so oral history works alongside documents. It adds what documents leave out, like feelings, daily life and the voices of people who rarely appear in official records.

The Bangla word for "story" is গল্প (*GOL-po*), and the Urdu word is کہانی (*ka-HAA-nee*). Families across South Asia have passed down golpo and kahani for generations without writing them down. Oral history makes sure they aren't lost when the storytellers are gone.

Oral history projects in South Asia and the diaspora

You won't be the first to do this.

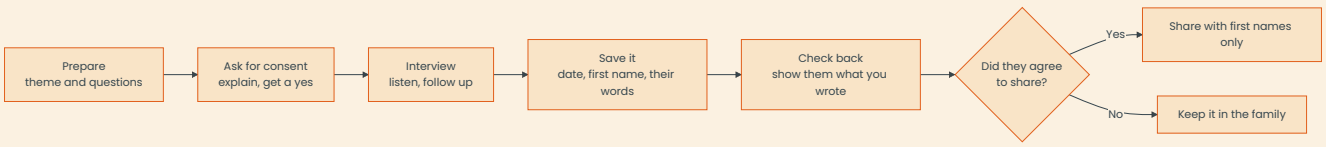
Project	Where	What it collects
South Asian American Digital Archive (SAADA)	United States, founded 2008	Documents and stories of South Asian Americans. Its First Days Project, launched in 2013, collects short stories of people's first days in the US and has gathered hundreds of them.
The 1947 Partition Archive	Based in Berkeley, California	Life stories of people who lived through Partition. It reports preserving over 12,000 oral histories, many recorded by volunteer "citizen historians."
Liberation War Museum	Dhaka, Bangladesh, established 1996	Eyewitness accounts of 1971. Since 2007 a mobile exhibit on a bus has visited schools, and students then interview elders and send in what they hear. One of its founding trustees reported more than 60,000 student-collected narratives in 2021.
Citizens Archive of	Karachi, Pakistan,	Its Oral History Project records memories from across Pakistan; the

Project	Where	What it collects
Pakistan	founded 2007	archive reports more than 5,000 oral histories.

Notice the Liberation War Museum's method. It's almost exactly what you've been doing: a student learns some history, goes home, asks an elder and writes it down. Tens of thousands of Bangladeshi teens have done what Zara did.

22.7 The Method: Consent, Listening, Preservation

The Oral History Project page has the short version and a consent script. Here is the full method, with the reasons behind it.



Step 1: Informed consent

Informed Consent means the person you interview understands what you are doing, why, how their words will be used and who might see them, and freely agrees, with the right to skip questions, stop at any time or change their mind later.

The Oral History Association, the main professional group for oral historians in the US, sets out these expectations in its Principles and Best Practices (revised in 2018) and its ethics statement: explain the purpose first, get consent (ideally in writing), tell narrators they can decline any question, and let them review the interview and limit or remove parts before anything is made public.

For a student project, that means:

- **Explain it simply** and say what you'll do with it: notes or audio, and who, if anyone, will see it.
- **Make "no" easy.** "You can skip anything, and we can stop whenever you want."
- **Get a parent or guardian's OK** if you're under 18 and plan to share anything outside the family. The Story Archive requires it.
- **Protect privacy.** First names or initials only. Never share a full name, address, phone number or photo without clear permission.
- **Let consent change.** If Nanu later says, "Don't share that part," you don't.

Nanu asked Zara to keep the 1971 story "just for the family." Informed consent means it stays there. Zara can still use the other 20 pages.

Step 2: Active listening

Active Listening is giving a speaker your full attention and showing that you understand, by focusing on their words, asking follow-up questions, reflecting back what you heard and leaving room for silence, instead of planning what you'll say next.

In an interview, that means:

- **Ask open questions.** "What was a school day like?" gets a story. "Did you like school?" gets "yes."
- **Follow the energy.** If they light up about a ferry ride, ask about the ferry. "What happened next?" and "What did that look like?" bring out the best details.
- **Let silence sit.** Count to five before your next question. Elders often add the best part after a pause.

- **Don't correct.** Memory isn't a test. If their story differs from this book, write the difference down. That's interesting, not wrong.
- **Read the room.** Partition, 1971, the Sri Lankan civil war or leaving home can bring up grief. If someone goes quiet, say "We can stop or move on," and mean it.

If your elder is more comfortable in Bangla, Urdu, Sinhala, Nepali or Pashto, let them answer in that language, and ask a parent to help translate later. You don't need to be fluent to listen well.

You're more ready than you think

If you've done even one Ask Your Elders interview in this book, you've already practiced consent and listening. This chapter just adds the "why."

Step 3: Preservation

Cultural Preservation is the work of keeping a community's traditions, knowledge, languages and memories alive for future generations, by recording them, practicing them and passing them on.

In a family, preservation can be a recipe card in Nanu's handwriting or a voice memo of a grandfather singing. For your interviews, label each one with the date, theme and the person's relationship and first name. Keep it in a private folder with a backup, and give the person a copy. Some families make a small printed booklet as a gift.

At a larger scale, UNESCO keeps lists of intangible cultural heritage, meaning living practices rather than buildings, to help protect them:

Tradition	Country	Added to UNESCO's lists
Durga Puja in Kolkata	India	2021
Mangal Shobhajatra, the Pohela Boishakh new year procession in Dhaka (its organizers renamed it Barshabaran Ananda Shobhajatra, close to its first name from 1989, in April 2025, and Baishakhi Shobhajatra in April 2026)	Bangladesh	2016
Suri Jagek, the Kalasha people's way of reading the sun, moon and stars to plan the farming year	Pakistan	2018
Rūkada Nātya, string puppet drama	Sri Lanka	2018, the country's first element
Drametse Ngacham, the mask dance of the drums from Drametse	Bhutan	proclaimed 2005, inscribed 2008

When the Drametse mask dance was first proclaimed, the listing noted that fewer people were practicing it, partly because young people were losing interest. Lists help, but a tradition survives only when people, often young people, keep doing it.

Preservation is not the same as freezing. Durga Puja in Kolkata today, with its giant themed pandals, looks different from a century ago, and it's still Durga Puja. A family that serves biryani next to the turkey at Thanksgiving is keeping its culture alive by adapting it.

22.8 Bring It Home: Clubs, Organizing and Impact

The last step is the one in the chapter's title: doing something with what you've learned.

Student Clubs are student-run groups at a school, usually with a faculty advisor, that meet regularly around a shared interest or identity. A South Asian Student Association is one kind. Clubs give students a place to belong and a chance to practice leading. Under a 2023 Minnesota law, every Minnesota public high school must offer an ethnic studies course starting this school year, 2026-27 (it is not a graduation requirement), and a club can be a natural partner for that class. The Club Kit has a two-year plan of 45-minute meetings mapped to the chapters, officer roles, food and allergy notes, and a guide to Ask Your Elders nights.

Community Organizing is people working together, in a planned way, toward a shared goal for their community, by finding out what people need, building relationships, dividing up the work and acting together. For a club, it might go like this:

1. **Listen first.** Maybe new students from Nepal feel invisible, or the library has no books by Pakistani or Sri Lankan authors.
2. **Pick one goal.** "A South Asian author display during Mother Language Day week."
3. **Build relationships.** Meet the librarian, and invite another club, such as the Black Student Union, to co-host.

4. **Divide the work and act.** One person makes the book list, one checks dates, one makes posters.
5. **Reflect.** Ask what worked and what didn't.

Community Impact is the real difference a project makes in people's lives, the changes you can see or measure, not just how busy you were. Ten meetings is activity. Five new members who say they finally feel they belong is impact.

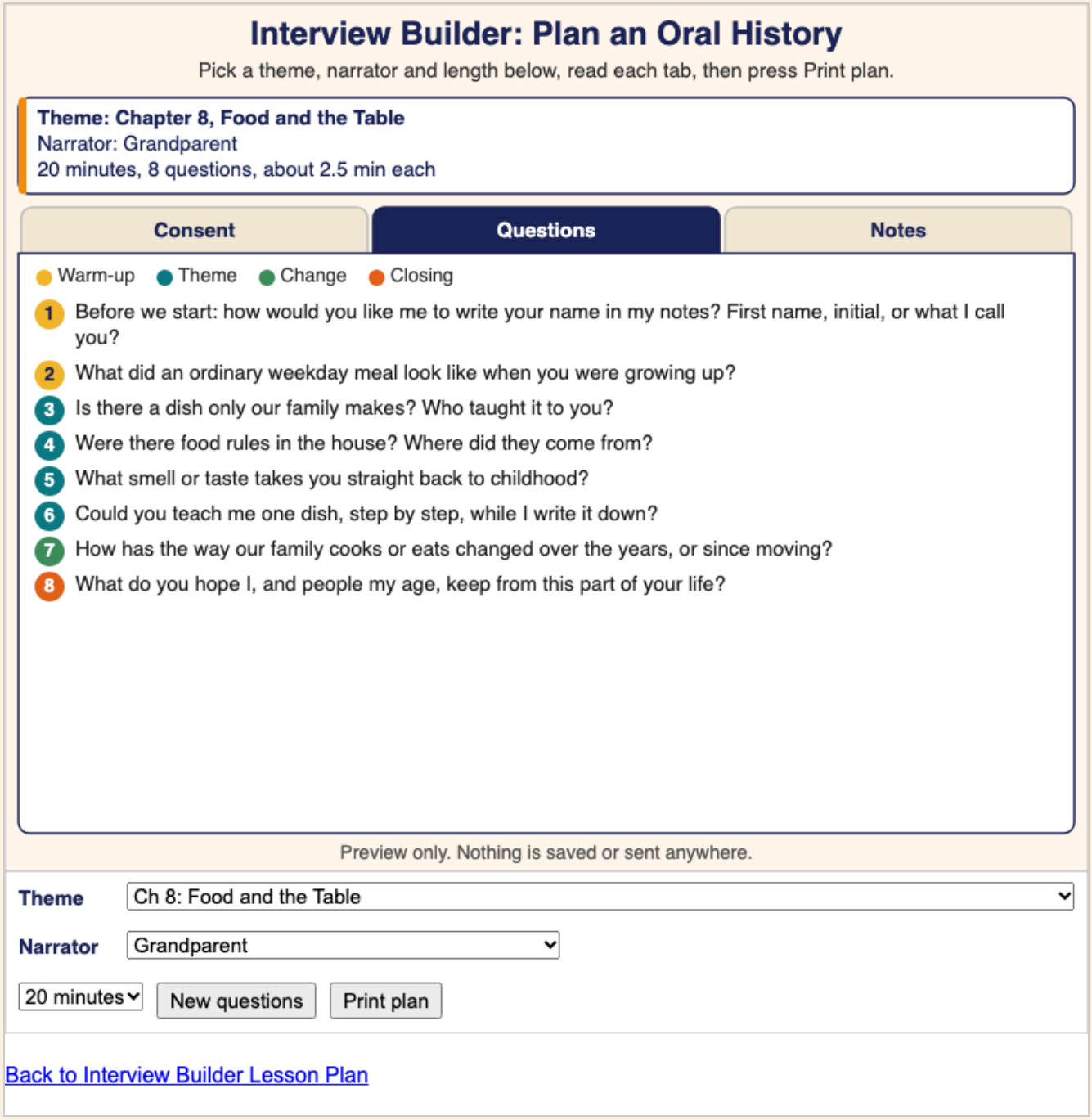
Activity (what you did)	Impact (what changed)
Held an Ask Your Elders night	Elders said nobody had asked about their childhood before; three families started their own story booklets
Ran Two Truths and a Myth for a middle school class	Students could name all eight countries afterward
Collected 12 stories for a family booklet	Grandparents and grandchildren now share a printed copy of stories that lived only in memory

A simple habit: before each project, write down one question you'll ask and one number you'll count, then check them afterward.

At the last meeting, Zara brings a stapled booklet, "Nanu's Stories, Year One." It has 20 stories, not 21; the 1971 page stayed home, as promised. Nanu comes too, and when Zara reads the ferry story aloud, she adds a detail nobody had heard before. Ben runs the "best of the year" Jeopardy game and makes sure the Nepal category is worth as many points as the India one. When a

freshman asks how to join, he points at Zara and Simran Kaur Gill, the treasurer: "Talk to them. They run it. I just help."

Diagram: Interview Builder



Interactive simulation: https://aaryavvatts-lab.github.io/south-asian-culture-textbook/sims/ch22-interview-builder/main.html

Open the Interview Builder fullscreen

MicroSim specification: Interview Builder

sim-id: ch22-interview-builder
Library: p5.js
Status: Implemented
Bloom Level: Create
Bloom Verb: design
Learning Objective: The learner will design an ethical oral history interview plan, with a consent script, theme questions, follow-up prompts and a note-taking grid, for a chosen theme, narrator and length.

Canvas: responsive width; 640 px drawing area plus 120 px control area.

Controls: Theme menu (the 21 chapter themes plus a "life story" capstone), Narrator menu (grandparent, parent, aunt or uncle, community member), Length menu (10, 20 or 30 minutes), New questions button, Print plan button; click or tap the Consent, Questions and Notes tabs on the canvas.

Behavior: A plain-text question bank in the sim, written from each chapter's Ask Your Elders topics, feeds a plan of 6, 8 or 10 questions (a warm-up, theme questions, a "how has it changed" question and a closing question), plus a consent script adjusted for the narrator, follow-up prompts and a note grid. Print calls window.print() on a clean, print-only layout. Nothing is saved or sent anywhere.

Choose the chapter you enjoyed most and the person you want to interview. Read the Consent tab first, and notice how the script changes when you switch from a grandparent to a community member. Then open the Questions tab and change the length: a 10-minute plan keeps only a few theme questions, while a 30-minute plan adds room to warm up and reflect.

Press **New questions** to see other questions from the same theme, then **Print plan** and take the page to your interview. Notice what never changes, whatever you pick: a consent script, the right to skip questions and the rule of first names only.

Ask Your Elders

Your interview for this chapter

Talk with a parent, grandparent, aunt, uncle, family friend or community elder about their life story: where they grew up, the moments that changed their life, what they carried with them and what they hope the next generation keeps. This is the capstone, a full oral history interview using everything in this chapter. If you don't have a South Asian elder to ask, interview a club advisor, a local temple, mosque, gurdwara or cultural center volunteer, or a classmate's family (with permission). Ten minutes is enough.

Before you start: Use the Interview Builder to print a plan with the "Life story" theme, read the consent script aloud first, and ask whether you may take notes or record audio. Bring a photo or object from their past if they have one.

Questions to ask

1. What is your earliest memory? Where were you, and who was with you?
2. Who were the most important people in your life when you were my age, and what did they teach you?
3. What was the biggest change you lived through, and how did it change your everyday life?

4. Is there a tradition, recipe, song or saying from your childhood that you still keep? Why that one?
5. How have you changed since you were young, or since you moved to a new place? What surprised you most?
6. What do you hope I, and people my age, keep from your life and from our family's traditions?

Listen for: moments where they describe their Cultural Identity changing over time, signs of Intergenerational Dialogue (stories passed down from their own elders), and anything they say they want kept, which is Cultural Preservation in their own words.

Save it: Write down one quote or story in their words, with their permission. If they agree, you can share it with the Roots & Rivers Story Archive.

Your turn: compare two answers

Look back at an earlier Ask Your Elders interview you did, from any chapter. Compare it with this life-story interview: did the same person tell a story differently, or add something new, when asked about their whole life instead of one topic? If a friend interviewed someone from a different country or generation, compare what each elder said they most want kept.

"Every family does it a little differently, and there is no wrong answer here."

Common Misconceptions

Myth: Culture is fixed. If you change a tradition, you lose it.
Reality: Cultures have always changed through trade, migration and new ideas. Chilies came from the Americas, and Durga Puja and Eid celebrations

look different in each generation. Adapting a tradition to a new home is a normal part of keeping it alive.

Myth: Appreciation and appropriation are the same thing, so it's either all fine or all wrong.
Reality: The difference lies in meaning, invitation, credit and power. Wearing a saree to a friend's wedding when invited is very different from wearing a bindi as a party costume or selling a tradition without credit.

Myth: You need to speak your heritage language fluently to really belong.
Reality: Many heritage speakers understand more than they speak, and in 2021-23, 28% of Indian Americans ages 5 and older spoke only English at home (Pew Research Center). Belonging grows from connection and relationships, and nobody has to pass a language test first.

Myth: One person's story speaks for the whole community.
Reality: Every oral history is one person's experience and memory. A Partition story from one family in Lahore and another from a family in Amritsar can both be true and still be very different. That's why oral historians collect many voices.

Myth: Being an ally means speaking for the group you support.
Reality: Allyship means listening, showing up and backing a group's members while they speak for themselves. Allies use their voice most in rooms where those members aren't present.

Check Yourself

1. What is the difference between cultural identity and a stereotype?

Cultural identity is a person's own sense of belonging to cultural groups, partly given and partly chosen. A stereotype is a fixed, oversimplified belief that outsiders (or insiders) apply to every member of a group.

2. Why did the Associated Press drop the hyphen from terms like \"Asian American\" in 2019?

AP made the change after talking with journalists and community groups. Many argued that the hyphen splits a person's identity in half, and it echoes the old "hyphenated American" put-down that questioned immigrants' loyalty. Without the hyphen, the heritage word simply describes the American.

3. Name two things that separate cultural appreciation from cultural appropriation.

Any two of: understanding the meaning, being invited or welcome, giving credit, making sure the community benefits, and treating sacred items with care instead of as costumes.

4. What does informed consent require in an oral history interview?

The person must understand what the project is, how their words will be used and who may see them, and must freely agree. They can skip questions, stop at any time and change their mind later, and they should be able to review what is shared.

5. Give one example of activity and one example of impact for a student club.

Activity: holding an Ask Your Elders night. Impact: elders said they had never been asked about their childhood, and families started their own story booklets. (Other pairs that show a real, visible change also work.)

Exercises

Remember

1. List the three steps of the oral history method described in Section 22.7.

Answer

Informed consent, active listening and preservation (keeping the record safe and giving it back to the narrator).

2. Name two oral history projects from this chapter and the country where each is based.

Answer

Any two of: SAADA and its First Days Project (United States), The 1947 Partition Archive (United States, Berkeley), the Liberation War Museum (Bangladesh, Dhaka), the Citizens Archive of Pakistan (Pakistan, Karachi).

Understand

1. Explain in your own words why children of immigrants who settle in one country are usually not called third culture kids, and why many still relate to the idea.

> **Answer**
>
> Strictly, third culture kids grow up moving between countries because of a parent's job, and the term isn't usually used for permanent immigrants. Many second-generation teens still relate because they also build a blended "third" culture between their parents' home culture and the one they live in.

2. Explain why "preservation" doesn't mean keeping a tradition exactly the same forever.

> **Answer**
>
> Living traditions change as people practice them in new times and places. Preservation means keeping the knowledge, meaning and practice alive and passed on, which often requires adapting, like celebrating Eid or Durga Puja in a new setting.

Apply

1. Use the Interview Builder to create a 20-minute plan for the theme you enjoyed most in this book. Print it (or save it as a PDF), then mark one question you would cut and one you would add for your specific narrator. *Hint: think about what your narrator knows best and what might be painful for them.*

2. A classmate says, "You're Pakistani, so you must love spicy food and be good at cricket." Write a short, calm reply that uses one of the moves from Section 22.3. *Hint: asking a question or adding a real example often works better than arguing.*

Analyze

1. Compare the Liberation War Museum's student oral history program with the Ask Your Elders method in this book. Identify two ways they are alike and one risk that comes with student-collected history. *Hint: think about who asks, who answers and how stories are checked.*
2. Look at the Fair & Lovely to Glow & Lovely renaming in 2020. Analyze what changed and what stayed the same, and what that suggests about how colorism can (and can't) be changed by a company. *Hint: separate the name and ads from the product and the beliefs behind it.*

Evaluate

1. Choose two rows from the appreciation and appropriation table in Section 22.4. For each, judge whether the "appreciation" column is enough, or whether you'd add a condition. Defend your choices. *Hint: the Whose Story? box shows that people in the community disagree.*
2. A club officer wants to post a member's grandmother's Partition story on the club's Instagram because "it's so powerful." Evaluate this plan using the rules of informed consent and privacy. *Hint: who agreed to what, and who might see it?*

Create

1. Design a one-semester community organizing plan for your club with one clear goal, a list of partners, a division of work and one way to measure community impact. *Hint: use the five organizing steps and the activity versus impact table.*
2. Conduct the capstone life-story interview from Ask Your Elders, then create a one-page "story card" from it: a title, the narrator's first name or relationship, one story in their words (with permission), and one sentence on what you learned about your own cultural identity. *Hint: show the card to your narrator before sharing it with anyone.*

Key Takeaways

- Cultural identity is partly given and partly chosen, and it changes over a lifetime. Labels like "South Asian American," "Bangladeshi American" or "desi" are personal, so ask people what they call themselves.
- Stereotypes, even ones that sound like compliments, erase the huge variety within South Asia. Colorism, a preference for lighter skin, is a stereotype that often lives inside families and media.
- Appreciation and appropriation differ in meaning, invitation, credit and power. Allyship means listening, showing up and backing others while they speak for themselves.
- Oral history records people's memories in their own words. Projects in the United States, Pakistan and Bangladesh have collected thousands of these stories, many gathered by students or volunteers.
- Good oral history rests on informed consent, active listening and careful preservation: explain, get a real yes, follow the story, use first names only and give the story back.

- Cultural preservation keeps traditions alive by practicing and adapting them, not by freezing them.
- Student clubs can turn learning into community organizing and real community impact. The Club Kit and Oral History Project pages show you how to start.

You brought it home!

You've finished all 22 chapters, and every tradition you met had a story behind it. Now go find the ones in your own family, ask with care, and keep them safe. That's the next chapter, and you get to write it.

Quiz: Bring It Home

Test your understanding of Chapter 22. Choose the best answer, then click **Show Answer** to check.

Question 1

What is oral history?

A. A collection of official government documents about a community

B. The practice of recording people's memories of their own lives, in their own words, and keeping them for others to learn from

C. Stories that are made up and passed around without anyone writing them down

D. A news interview with a famous person about current events

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. Oral history records people's own memories in their own words and preserves them, with permission, for the future. It is not made-up storytelling (C). It adds personal experience to what official documents (A) leave out.

Concept Tested: Oral History **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 2

Which description matches the term "third culture kids" as Ruth Useem first used it?

A. Any child of immigrants who settles permanently in a new country

B. Children who speak three languages at home

C. Children of parents from three different countries

D. Children who spent much of their childhood in a culture different from their parents', usually because a parent's job moved the family abroad

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Ruth Useem used the term in the 1960s for children of Americans working abroad. Strictly, children of immigrants who settle in one country (A) aren't usually called third culture kids, although many second-generation teens relate to the idea.

Concept Tested: Third Culture Kids **Bloom's Level:** Remember

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Question 3

In 2020, Hindustan Unilever renamed its skin-lightening cream Fair & Lovely as Glow & Lovely. Which concept from the chapter does this example mainly illustrate?

A. Colorism

B. Cultural preservation

C. Hyphenated identity

D. Community impact

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. The cream was criticized for linking lighter, "fair" skin to beauty and success, which is colorism: favoring lighter skin over darker skin. The renaming was a response to that criticism; it is not an example of preserving a tradition (B).

Concept Tested: Colorism **Bloom's Level:** Remember

Question 4

Why did many people object to the hyphen in terms like "Indian-American"?

A. Hyphens are grammatically wrong in all English writing

B. The hyphen was required only for South Asian Americans

C. "Hyphenated American" had been used as a put-down suggesting immigrants weren't fully loyal, and some felt the hyphen split them in half

D. The Constitution of India bans hyphens in names

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. From about 1890 to 1920, "hyphenated American" was used as an insult, and many people felt the hyphen made them sound only partly American. In March 2019 the Associated Press dropped the hyphen from dual-heritage terms. Hyphens aren't wrong in general (A); this is about history and identity.

Concept Tested: Hyphenated Identity **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 5

Which statement best explains the difference between cultural appreciation and cultural appropriation?

A. Appreciation means never taking part in another culture; appropriation means taking part at all

B. Appreciation involves understanding meaning, being invited, giving credit and supporting the community; appropriation takes elements while ignoring meaning, credit or the community

C. Appreciation applies only to food, and appropriation applies only to clothing

D. There is no real difference; both words mean borrowing from another culture

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. The chapter separates the two by meaning, invitation, credit and power. Appreciation does not mean staying away entirely (A); wearing a saree to a friend's wedding when invited is an example of appreciation.

Concept Tested: Cultural Appreciation **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 6

Why does the chapter say that preservation is "not the same as freezing"?

A. Living traditions survive by being practiced and adapted, so a tradition can change and still be itself

B. UNESCO forbids any change to traditions on its lists

C. Traditions only count if they are exactly as they were a thousand years ago

D. Preservation means storing objects in a museum and no longer using them

Show Answer

The correct answer is **A**. Durga Puja in Kolkata looks different from a century ago and is still Durga Puja, and families adapt festivals to new homes. Option C is the "culture is fixed" myth the chapter corrects.

Concept Tested: Cultural Preservation **Bloom's Level:** Understand

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Question 7

Dilan is about to interview his grandfather about growing up in Kandy. Which step should come first?

A. Start recording audio so nothing is missed

B. Ask the hardest question first while his grandfather has the most energy

C. Post a photo of his grandfather to the club's page to build excitement

D. Explain the project, how the notes will be used and who might see them, and ask whether it's OK, making clear he can skip questions or stop

Show Answer

The correct answer is **D**. Informed consent comes before anything else. Recording without asking (A) skips consent, and posting a photo (C) breaks the privacy rule of sharing nothing without clear permission.

Concept Tested: Informed Consent **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 8

During an interview, Ayesha's grandmother mentions a train ride to Lahore and her voice changes. Ayesha's next planned question is about cricket. What is the best active listening move?

A. Move straight to the cricket question to stay on schedule

B. Correct her if the date she gives doesn't match the textbook

C. Pause, then gently ask something like "Can you tell me more about that?" while being ready to stop or move on if the memory is painful

D. Tell her own story about a train ride to keep the conversation going

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. Active listening means following the speaker's lead, leaving room for silence and reading the room, especially with possibly painful memories. Sticking rigidly to the list (A) misses the story, and correcting memory (B) treats the interview like a test.

Concept Tested: Active Listening **Bloom's Level:** Apply

Question 9

The Liberation War Museum in Dhaka asks school students to interview elders about 1971 and send in their accounts. How is this most similar to the book's Ask Your Elders method?

A. Both rely on official government records instead of personal memories

B. Both have teens ask older relatives or community members about their own experiences and write the stories down

C. Both are run only by professional historians

D. Both collect stories only from people who left South Asia

Show Answer

The correct answer is **B**. In both, young people learn some history, then gather memories from elders in their own words. Option A describes the opposite of oral history. Option D is wrong because the museum's accounts come from people in Bangladesh, not only from people who left.

Concept Tested: Intergenerational Dialogue **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

---

Question 10

A club reports two results at the end of the year: "We held 10 meetings" and "Five new members said they finally feel they belong at school." Which analysis is correct?

A. Both are community impact, because both are numbers

B. Neither matters, because clubs can't measure anything

C. The first is activity; the second is community impact, because it describes a real change in people's lives

D. The first is community impact, because more meetings always means more change

Show Answer

The correct answer is **C**. The chapter defines community impact as the real difference a project makes, not just how busy a group was. Counting meetings (D) measures activity; impact shows up in what changed for people.

Concept Tested: Community Impact **Bloom's Level:** Analyze

Glossary

Every key term in this book, in alphabetical order. Each entry gives a short definition that matches how the chapter explains it, the word's original script and a simple respelling (stressed syllable in capitals) where the chapter gives one, an example, and a link back to the chapter where you learn it. For help reading the respellings, see Appendix A: Pronunciation and Script Guide.

A · B · C · D · E · F · G · H · I · J · K · L · M · N · O · P · Q · R · S · T · U · V · W · Y · Z

A

Abugida

A writing system in which each consonant letter carries a built-in vowel, usually a short "a," and other vowels are shown by marks attached to the consonant. A mark called a virama removes the built-in vowel.

Example: In Devanagari, the letter क is read "ka" unless a vowel mark or a virama changes it.

See also: Devanagari, Gurmukhi, Brahmi Script

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Active Listening

Giving a speaker full attention and showing understanding by focusing on their words, asking follow-up questions, reflecting back what was heard and leaving room for silence.

Example: Saying "So you moved when you were twelve?" before asking the next question is active listening.

See also: Oral History, Intergenerational Dialogue

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Adivasi Communities

India's Indigenous or tribal peoples, many with their own languages, faiths, governance and ways of life tied to forests, hills and land. The government's official term is Scheduled Tribes.

Script and sound: आदिवासी, *AH-dee-VAH-see*, "original inhabitants"

Example: Many Santali speakers in Jharkhand belong to Adivasi communities.

See also: Austroasiatic Languages, Unity in Diversity

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Afghan Carpets

Hand-knotted wool rugs woven in Afghanistan, especially in the north and west, in traditions passed down within families for generations.

Example: Afghan carpets are one of the country's best-known crafts and an important source of household income.

See also: Afghanistan

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Afghanistan

A landlocked, mountainous country where South Asia meets Central Asia and Iran, and the eighth member of SAARC, which it joined in 2007. It had about 44 million people in 2025 (World Bank).

Example: The nearest sea to Afghanistan, the Arabian Sea, is about 480 km to the south.

See also: Kabul, Dari and Pashto, South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC)

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Ahimsa

Non-violence: not harming any living being, in action, word or thought. Hindus and Buddhists value it, and Jains place it at the very center of their lives.

Script and sound: अहिंसा, *uh-HIM-sah*

Example: Many Jains avoid root vegetables such as potatoes, onions and garlic to avoid harming tiny living things.

See also: Jainism, Satyagraha, Vegetarianism in South Asia

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Akbar

The third Mughal emperor, who ruled from 1556 to 1605 and built the Mughal state into a lasting empire stretching from Kabul to Bengal.

Example: Akbar became emperor as a teenager.

See also: Mughal Empire, Akbar and Birbal Tales

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Akbar and Birbal Tales

Funny stories about the Mughal emperor Akbar and his quick-witted minister Birbal, who solves impossible puzzles and outsmarts jealous courtiers. Birbal

was real, but most of the tales are later folk creations.

Example: In many tales, Birbal answers a trick question from Akbar with a clever twist.

See also: Akbar, Oral Tradition

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Al-Biruni

A Muslim scholar born in Khwarazm in Central Asia (973 to 1048) who wrote one of the most careful early books about South Asian science and society after going to Ghazni, in today's Afghanistan.

Example: Al-Biruni measured the positions of towns in the Punjab during Mahmud of Ghazni's expeditions.

See also: Hindu-Arabic Numerals

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

All-India Muslim League

A political party founded in 1906 in Dhaka to represent the political interests of Muslims in British India. In 1940 it adopted the Lahore Resolution, later called the Pakistan Resolution.

Example: Muhammad Ali Jinnah led the All-India Muslim League in the years before Partition.

See also: Muhammad Ali Jinnah, Partition of 1947, Indian National Congress

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Allama Iqbal

Sir Muhammad Iqbal (1877 to 1938), a poet and philosopher born in Sialkot who wrote in Urdu and Persian and whose 1930 Allahabad Address called for a separate political home for Muslims in northwest British India. *Allama* means "learned scholar."

Example: Pakistan was founded nine years after Iqbal's death.

See also: All-India Muslim League, Muhammad Ali Jinnah

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Allyship

The ongoing practice of supporting a group one is not part of by listening, learning, showing up and using one's voice or access to back that group, while letting its members lead.

Example: Ben joining the South Asian Student Association and helping set up events is allyship.

See also: Cultural Appreciation, Community Organizing

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Anand Karaj

The Sikh wedding ceremony, "blissful ceremony," held in front of the Guru Granth Sahib, at the center of which the couple walks around the scripture four times as the four hymns of the *laavan* are sung.

Script and sound: ਅਨੰਦ ਕਾਰਜ, *uh-NUND KAA-raj*

Example: Many Sikh weddings take place in the morning at a gurdwara.

See also: Guru Granth Sahib, Weddings, Nikah

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Anglo-Afghan Wars

Three wars that Britain fought in Afghanistan, in 1839 to 1842, 1878 to 1880, and 1919, driven by British fear that the Russian Empire would use Afghanistan as a route to India.

Example: After the third war, the 1919 Treaty of Rawalpindi recognized Afghanistan's full independence.

See also: Afghanistan, British Raj

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Anuradhapura

An ancient royal capital in the dry north-central plains of Sri Lanka and a holy city for Buddhists, which flourished for about 1,300 years until it was abandoned after an invasion in 993 CE.

Script and sound: *uh-noo-RAH-duh-POO-ruh*

Example: Pilgrims still visit Anuradhapura's ancient stupas.

See also: Sri Lankan Kingdoms, Stupa

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Arranged Marriage

A marriage in which parents or other relatives help find and suggest a partner, and the couple then decides whether to go ahead. It is common in South Asia alongside "love marriages," where the couple meets on their own.

Example: Parents might introduce their son to a family friend's daughter, and the two meet several times before deciding.

See also: Weddings, Gender Roles and Change

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Aryabhata

A mathematician and astronomer (476 to 550 CE) who worked at Kusumapura during the time of the Gupta kings and finished his verse book, the *Aryabhatiya*, in 499 at age 23.

Example: Aryabhata wrote the *Aryabhatiya* in verse so students could memorize it.

See also: Brahmagupta, Gupta Empire

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Ashoka

The third Maurya emperor, grandson of Chandragupta, who ruled from about 268 to 232 BCE over an empire stretching from present-day Afghanistan to present-day Bangladesh.

Example: Ashoka had his messages carved on rocks and stone pillars across his empire.

See also: Maurya Empire, Edicts of Ashoka

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Ashura

The 10th day of Muharram, the first month of the Islamic year. For Shia Muslims it is a solemn day of mourning for Husayn ibn Ali, killed at Karbala in 680 CE, and many Sunni Muslims fast on it.

Script and sound: عاشورا, *aa-SHOO-rah*, "the tenth" (Persian)

Example: In Dhaka, the Hussaini Dalan is the center of Muharram gatherings.

See also: Sunni and Shia Islam, Islamic Lunar Calendar

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Atolls

Rings of coral reef and small low islands surrounding a shallow lagoon. The English word comes from the Dhivehi *atholhu*.

Script and sound: ތ*atholhu* (*A-tho-lu*)

Example: The islands of the Maldives are grouped into 26 atolls.

See also: Maldives, Dhivehi

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Attan

A Pashtun circle dance widely called the national dance of Afghanistan, in which dancers move around a drummer, clapping and spinning as the beat speeds up.

Script and sound: اتڼ, *uh-TUN*

Example: Attan is often danced at Afghan weddings, including in communities abroad.

See also: Folk Dance, Afghanistan

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Austroasiatic Languages

A language family spread from eastern India to Vietnam and Cambodia. In South Asia its best-known members are the Munda languages, spoken mainly by Adivasi communities, and Khasi in Meghalaya.

Example: Santali, written in its own Ol Chiki script, was added to India's Eighth Schedule in 2003.

See also: Adivasi Communities, Language Family

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Ayurveda

A traditional medical system from South Asia, based on old Sanskrit texts, that uses diet, herbs, daily routines, exercise and sometimes minerals to try to keep the body in balance. This is a description of a tradition, not medical advice.

Script and sound: आयुर्वेद, *AA-yur-vay-duh*, "knowledge of life"

Example: India has a government ministry, AYUSH, for traditional systems including Ayurveda.

See also: Unani Medicine, Yoga

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

B

B. R. Ambedkar

Bhimrao Ramji Ambedkar (1891 to 1956), a lawyer, economist and political leader born into a Dalit family, who fought for the rights of Dalits and chaired the committee that drafted India's Constitution.

Example: Ambedkar earned doctorates from Columbia University and the London School of Economics.

See also: Constitution of India, Caste Discrimination Laws

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Balochistan

Pakistan's westernmost and largest province by area, bordering Iran and Afghanistan, with Quetta as its capital. It is the most thinly populated province.

Example: Mehrgarh, one of South Asia's earliest farming villages, is in Balochistan.

See also: Provinces of Pakistan, Mehrgarh

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Bangladesh Liberation War

The 1971 war in which East Pakistan fought for and won independence from Pakistan, becoming Bangladesh. Independence was declared on 26 March 1971 and the war ended on 16 December 1971.

Script and sound: মুক্তিযুদ্ধ, *MOOK-tee-jud-dho*, "liberation war"

Example: About 10 million refugees fled to India during the Bangladesh Liberation War.

See also: People's Republic of Bangladesh, Language Movement of 1952

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Bangles

Rigid bracelets, usually worn in sets, made from glass, metal, shell, lac, plastic or other materials, with a very long history in the region.

Script and sound: चूड़ी, *CHOO-ree* (Hindi)

Example: The bronze "Dancing Girl" from Mohenjo-daro wears a stack of bangles on her left arm.

See also: Bindi, Harappa and Mohenjo-daro

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Battle of Plassey

The battle on 23 June 1757 near Plassey (Palashi) in Bengal in which East India Company forces under Robert Clive defeated Siraj-ud-Daulah, the Nawab of Bengal, largely because the Nawab's commander Mir Jafar kept his troops out of the fight.

Example: After the battle, the Company made Mir Jafar the new Nawab of Bengal.

See also: East India Company

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Baul Music

The music of the Bauls, wandering singers of Bangladesh and West Bengal who draw on both Sufi Islam and Vaishnava Hindu devotion, and many of whom reject divisions of caste and religion.

Script and sound: বাউল, *BAH-ool*

Example: Many Baul singers play the ektara, a one-stringed instrument of gourd and bamboo.

See also: Folk Music, Sufism

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Bay of Bengal

The northeastern part of the Indian Ocean, lying east of India and south of Bangladesh, with Myanmar on its eastern side and Sri Lanka at its southwestern edge. It covers about 2.2 million square km.

Example: The Ganga, Brahmaputra, Godavari, Krishna and Kaveri rivers all flow into the Bay of Bengal.

See also: Indian Ocean, Sundarbans

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Bengal Delta

The vast, low plain built by the Ganges, Brahmaputra and Meghna rivers where they flow into the Bay of Bengal, the largest river delta in the world. It is also called the Ganges-Brahmaputra Delta.

Example: Most of Bangladesh and the Indian state of West Bengal sit on the Bengal Delta.

See also: Sundarbans, Rivers and Floods

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Bengal Famine of 1943

A famine during the Second World War in the province of Bengal and parts of Orissa (now Odisha) in which very large numbers of people died of starvation and disease. Estimates of the death toll range from about 800,000 to 3.8 million.

Example: The economic historian Cormac Ó Gráda describes the scholarly consensus as about 2.1 million deaths.

See also: British Raj

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Bengali Language

An Indo-Aryan language, called Bangla by its speakers, that is the official and national language of Bangladesh and an official language of West Bengal, Tripura and Assam's Barak Valley.

Script and sound: বাংলা, *BAANG-laa*

Example: In India's 2011 census about 97 million people spoke Bangla as their mother tongue, second only to Hindi.

See also: Language Movement of 1952, Ekushey February

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Bhagat Singh Thind Case

United States v. Bhagat Singh Thind (1923), a US Supreme Court decision that ruled South Asians were not "white persons" and therefore could not become naturalized citizens.

Example: At the time, US law allowed only "free white persons" and people of African descent to naturalize.

See also: Punjabi Pioneers in California, Immigration Act of 1965

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Bhagavad Gita

A poem of about 700 verses in the sixth book of the Mahabharata, "God's song," in which Krishna answers the warrior Arjuna's doubts before battle in a conversation about duty, action, devotion and the self.

Script and sound: भगवद्गीता, *BHUG-uh-vud GEE-taa*

Example: Many Hindus read the Bhagavad Gita for guidance on how to act rightly.

See also: Mahabharata, Dharma

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Bhakti Movement

A wave of devotional poetry and practice within Hinduism that taught that loving devotion to God is open to everyone, whatever their caste, gender or education. It began in the Tamil country around the 6th century CE and spread north over the next thousand years.

Script and sound: भक्ति, *BHUK-tee*, "devotion"

Example: The Alvars, devoted to Vishnu, and the Nayanars, devoted to Shiva, were early Tamil poet-saints of the Bhakti Movement.

See also: Hinduism, Kabir, Sufism

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Bhangra

A folk dance and music of Punjab, traditionally linked with the harvest and festivals like Vaisakhi, driven by the dhol, a large two-sided drum.

Script and sound: ਭੰਗੜਾ, *BHUNG-ra*

Example: Bhangra is danced on both sides of the India-Pakistan border in Punjab.

See also: Folk Music, Vaisakhi, Global South Asian Pop

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Bharatanatyam

A classical dance from Tamil Nadu, closely linked for centuries with Hindu temples and royal courts of the Tamil region. Its older name was *Sadir*.

Script and sound: பரதநாட்டியம், *BHUH-ruh-tuh-NAHT-yum*

Example: The Thanjavur Quartet organized much of the order of pieces still used in Bharatanatyam today.

See also: Classical Dance, Mudra

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Bhutan

A small, mountainous kingdom of about 800,000 people (2025, World Bank) in the eastern Himalaya, between India and China's Tibet region, with Thimphu as its capital. Bhutanese call it Druk Yul, "Land of the Thunder Dragon."

Example: The thunder dragon appears on Bhutan's national flag.

See also: Dzong, Gross National Happiness, Dzongkha

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Bindi

A dot, traditionally red or maroon, worn in the center of the forehead, often between the eyebrows. The word comes from the Sanskrit *bindu*, "point" or "drop."

Script and sound: बिंदी, *BIN-dee*

Example: Many people today wear small stick-on bindis in every color and shape.

See also: Bangles, Cultural Appropriation

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Biryani

A dish of rice layered and slow-cooked with meat or vegetables, yogurt and spices, often with saffron. The name comes from the Persian *biryan*, "fried" or "roasted."

Script and sound: بریانی, *bir-YAH-nee* (Urdu)

Example: The *Ain-i-Akbari*, written at Akbar's court in the 1590s, lists biryani alongside pilau.

See also: Indo-Persian Culture, Regional Cuisines

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Block Printing

A way of printing patterns on cloth by carving a design into a wooden block, dipping it in dye and stamping it by hand over and over.

Example: A cloth with three colors may need three carved blocks, lined up by eye.

See also: Cotton in South Asia

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Bollywood

The popular name, blending "Bombay" and "Hollywood," for the Hindi-language film industry based in Mumbai. It refers to Hindi films only, not all Indian or South Asian films.

Example: A Hindi film with big stars and several song-and-dance numbers, made in Mumbai, is a Bollywood film.

See also: Regional Cinemas, Playback Singing, Film Music (Filmi)

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Brahmagupta

An astronomer and mathematician (born 598 CE) who wrote the *Brahmasphutasiddhanta* in 628 CE at Bhillamala and later led the observatory at Ujjain.

Example: Brahmagupta treated zero as a number with its own rules.

See also: Zero, Aryabhata

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Brahmaputra River

A braided river about 3,000 km (1,900 miles) long that begins in Tibet, cuts south through the Himalaya into India's Arunachal Pradesh, flows through the Assam Valley and enters Bangladesh, where it is called the Jamuna.

Example: In Tibet, near Mount Kailash, the same river is called the Yarlung Tsangpo.

See also: Bengal Delta, Rivers and Floods

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Brahmi Numerals

The number signs written with the Brahmi script, which appear on inscriptions from the 3rd century BCE.

Example: An edict of Ashoka at Sasaram, from about 250 BCE, writes the number 256 in Brahmi numerals.

See also: Brahmi Script, Hindu-Arabic Numerals

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Brahmi Script

The ancient script that is the ancestor of most scripts used in South Asia today, and of many in Southeast Asia and Tibet. It was in use by the 3rd century BCE.

Example: The Edicts of Ashoka are the best-known early examples of Brahmi, deciphered by James Prinsep in the 1830s.

See also: Edicts of Ashoka, Abugida, Brahmi Numerals

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

British Raj

Direct rule of South Asia by the British Crown from 1858 to 1947, run by a Viceroy appointed in London. *Raj* means "rule" in Hindi-Urdu.

Example: The Viceroy governed first from Calcutta (now Kolkata) and later from New Delhi.

See also: Revolt of 1857, Princely States, Partition of 1947

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

British South Asians

People in the United Kingdom with roots in South Asia, a community that grew sharply in the 1950s and 1960s when Britain needed workers to rebuild after World War II.

Example: As Commonwealth citizens, people from India and Pakistan could come to Britain fairly easily in that period.

See also: Diaspora, Uganda Expulsion of 1972

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Buddhas of Bamiyan

Two giant standing statues of the Buddha, 55 m and 38 m tall, carved into a sandstone cliff in Afghanistan's Bamiyan Valley in the late 500s and early 600s CE and destroyed by the Taliban in March 2001.

Example: Empty niches in the Bamiyan cliff show where the statues once stood.

See also: Afghanistan, Buddhism

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Buddhism

The faith based on the teachings of Siddhartha Gautama, called the Buddha ("awakened one"), whom Buddhists believe found the path to freedom from suffering.

Example: Buddhists believe the Buddha reached enlightenment while meditating under a tree at Bodh Gaya, in present-day India.

See also: Theravada and Vajrayana, Lumbini, Vesak

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

C

C. V. Raman

Chandrasekhara Venkata Raman (1888 to 1970), a physicist from Tamil Nadu who discovered that light scattered by molecules returns partly with a

slightly different color, now called the Raman effect. He won the Nobel Prize in Physics in 1930.

Example: Scientists today use Raman's discovery to identify substances.

See also: Srinivasa Ramanujan

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Calendar Conversion

Finding the date in one calendar that matches a date in another, such as working out which Gregorian day begins a month of the Islamic or a lunisolar calendar.

Example: Working out which Gregorian day will be the first of Shawwal, when Eid al-Fitr begins, is calendar conversion.

See also: Lunisolar Calendar, Islamic Lunar Calendar

Taught in Appendix C: Festival Calendar 2026-27.

Calligraphy

The art of beautiful writing, which holds a special place in Islamic art because many Muslims believe the words of the Qur'an deserve the most beautiful form possible.

Example: The Taj Mahal's gateways are framed with Qur'anic verses in a flowing script called *thuluth*.

See also: Mughal Architecture, Perso-Arabic Script

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Carnatic Music

The classical music of southern India and of Tamil communities in Sri Lanka and around the world, centered on composed songs, many of them devotional, in languages such as Telugu, Tamil, Kannada, Sanskrit and Malayalam.

Example: Purandara Dasa (1484-1564) is called the "father" of Carnatic music for setting out the basic lessons students still learn.

See also: Hindustani Music, Veena

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Carrom

A tabletop game of Indian origin in which players flick a heavy disc, the striker, to knock smaller wooden pieces into the four corner pockets of a square board.

Example: Many South Asian American families keep a carrom board in the basement.

See also: Chaturanga

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Caste Discrimination Laws

Laws that ban treating people unfairly because of their caste and that protect communities who faced untouchability.

Example: Article 17 of India's Constitution, in effect from 26 January 1950, abolished "untouchability."

See also: Caste System, Constitution of India

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Caste System

A social system, built over many centuries and still continuing, in which people are born into ranked groups that shape whom they marry, what work they are expected to do and how others treat them.

Example: Caste can still affect marriage choices in South Asia and in diaspora communities today.

See also: Varna and Jati, Caste Discrimination Laws, B. R. Ambedkar

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Ceylon Tea

Black tea grown on Sri Lanka's hill-country plantations and still sold around the world under the island's old name.

Example: In 2025, Sri Lanka's tea exports earned more than 1.5 billion US dollars.

See also: Chai, Sri Lanka

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Chai

Tea; in much of South Asia, black tea boiled with milk and sugar and often spiced with cardamom, ginger, cinnamon, cloves or black pepper.

Script and sound: चाय, Urdu چائے, *CHAI*

Example: The spiced version, masala chai, is sold at railway stations from Karachi to Kolkata.

See also: Hospitality Customs, Ceylon Tea

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Chaturanga

An old board game from India, first clearly mentioned in the 6th or 7th century CE, that is the earliest known ancestor of chess. Its Sanskrit name means "four limbs," the four parts of an old army.

Example: Chaturanga was played on an 8-by-8 board called the *ashtapada*.

See also: Carrom

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Chola Dynasty

A Tamil royal family from the Kaveri River delta in south India whose empire, founded around 848 CE by Vijayalaya, was one of the strongest powers in South Asia for about four centuries.

Example: By 1279 the Cholas had been absorbed by their Pandya rivals.

See also: Indian Ocean Trade, Sri Lankan Kingdoms

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Christianity in South Asia

The region's many Christian communities, some among the oldest in the world and others formed later through Portuguese, Dutch, British and other missions.

Example: Christians in Kerala trace their church to the apostle Thomas, who in their tradition arrived in the first century.

See also: Christmas in South Asia, Religious Pluralism

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Christmas in South Asia

The celebration of the birth of Jesus on 25 December by South Asia's Christian communities.

Example: Kerala has the largest Christian population of any Indian state.

See also: Christianity in South Asia

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Classical Dance

A dance tradition with a long written theory, usually traced to the Natya Shastra, a fixed technique learned over years with a teacher, a set order of pieces and official recognition as a classical art. The label describes a codified form, not a better one.

Example: Bharatanatyam, Kathak and Odissi are classical dances.

See also: Folk Dance, Natya Shastra

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Code-Switching

Moving back and forth between two or more languages or styles of speaking in the same conversation, or even the same sentence. Linguists study it as a skill, not a sign of weak language ability.

Example: A teen in Mumbai who says, "Yaar, the exam was *bahut* hard," is code-switching between Hindi and English.

See also: Heritage Language, Hyphenated Identity

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Coke Studio

A TV and online music series in which established and new artists perform live studio recordings, often mixing folk, Sufi, classical, rock and pop. Coke Studio Pakistan, launched in 2008, is its most famous version.

Example: A Coke Studio song might pair a qawwali singer with a young pop artist.

See also: Qawwali, Global South Asian Pop

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Colombo

Sri Lanka's largest city and commercial capital, a major port on the west coast visited for centuries by Arab, Portuguese, Dutch and British ships.

Script and sound: කොළඹ, *koh-LUM-boh*

Example: Arab, Portuguese, Dutch and British ships all used Colombo's harbor over the centuries.

See also: Sri Lanka

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Colorism

Prejudice or unfair treatment based on skin tone, usually favoring lighter skin over darker skin, including among people of the same background.

Example: Skin-lightening creams such as Fair & Lovely, renamed Glow & Lovely in 2020, reflect colorism.

See also: Stereotypes

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Columbian Exchange

The movement of plants, animals, people and diseases between the Americas and the rest of the world that began after 1492, named by the historian Alfred Crosby in 1972.

Example: Chili peppers, potatoes and tomatoes reached South Asian kitchens through the Columbian Exchange.

See also: European Traders, Regional Cuisines

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Coming-of-Age Rites

Ceremonies that mark the move from childhood toward adulthood or full membership in a community.

Example: A Sikh who formally joins the Khalsa takes part in a coming-of-age rite.

See also: Life-Cycle Rituals

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Community Impact

The real difference a project makes in people's lives, measured by changes people can see or count rather than by how busy the organizers were.

Example: Five new members who say they finally feel they belong is community impact; ten meetings is only activity.

See also: Community Organizing, Student Clubs

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Community Organizing

People working together in a planned way toward a shared goal for their community by finding out what people need, building relationships, dividing up the work and acting together.

Example: A club surveying members, then planning a food drive with a local gurdwara, is community organizing.

See also: Student Clubs, Community Impact

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Constitution of India

The supreme law of India, which sets up its government, divides power between the center and the states, and lists citizens' rights. It was adopted on 26 November 1949 and came into effect on 26 January 1950.

Example: Indians celebrate Republic Day each year on 26 January.

See also: B. R. Ambedkar, Eighth Schedule, Caste Discrimination Laws

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Cotton in South Asia

The long history of growing, spinning and weaving the cotton plant's soft seed fibers in South Asia, going back more than 7,000 years.

Example: The oldest known cotton fibers in the world were found with copper beads at Mehrgarh.

See also: Khadi, Jamdani, Mehrgarh

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Cricket

A bat-and-ball game played between two teams of eleven on a large oval field, centered on a 22-yard pitch with a wicket of three stumps at each end.

Example: One team bats while the other bowls and fields, and then they switch.

See also: India-Pakistan Rivalry

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Cultural Appreciation

Learning about, honoring and taking part in another culture with respect: understanding what something means, being invited or welcome, giving credit and supporting the people the tradition comes from.

Example: Learning what a festival means, accepting an invitation to it and thanking the hosts is cultural appreciation.

See also: Cultural Appropriation, Allyship

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Cultural Appropriation

Taking an element of another group's culture, usually by someone from a more dominant group, in a way that ignores its meaning, gives no credit, or turns it into a costume or product without the community's involvement.

Example: Wearing a sacred symbol as a party costume without knowing its meaning is cultural appropriation.

See also: Cultural Appreciation, Bindi

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Cultural Identity

A person's sense of belonging to one or more cultural groups, built from family, language, faith, food, place, history and the people around them. It is partly given, partly chosen and changes over a lifetime.

Example: Zara's Bangladeshi, Muslim and Minnesotan roots all shape her cultural identity.

See also: Hyphenated Identity, Desi Identity

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Cultural Preservation

The work of keeping a community's traditions, knowledge, languages and memories alive for future generations by recording them, practicing them and passing them on.

Example: A gurdwara Sunday school that teaches children Gurmukhi helps with cultural preservation.

See also: Oral History, Heritage Language

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

D

Dal

Split pulses, the dried seeds of plants like lentils, peas and beans, and the soupy or thick dish made from them.

Script and sound: दाल, *DAHL*

Example: Red lentils (masoor), split mung beans (moong) and split chickpeas (chana) are all dals.

See also: Tadka, Thali, Vegetarianism in South Asia

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Dari and Pashto

Afghanistan's two official national languages, a status first set out in the 1964 constitution. Dari is the form of Persian spoken in Afghanistan; Pashto is the language of the Pashtuns on both sides of the Afghanistan-Pakistan border.

Script and sound: دری, *dah-REE* (Dari); پښتو, *PUSH-toh* (Pashto)

Example: Afghans of different groups often use Dari to talk to each other.

See also: Iranian Languages, Afghanistan, Pashtunwali

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Dashain and Tihar

Nepal's two biggest festivals, about three weeks apart in the autumn. Dashain is a 15-day festival that falls on the same autumn days as Navaratri, and Tihar is a five-day festival of lights.

Script and sound: दशैं, *duh-SHAIN* (Dashain); तिहार, *tee-HAAR* (Tihar)

Example: On Kukur Tihar, the second day of Tihar, dogs get flower garlands and treats.

See also: Navaratri and Durga Puja, Diwali, Nepal

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Deccan Plateau

A large raised tableland covering much of central and southern India, with an average height of about 600 m (2,000 ft). Its name comes from the Sanskrit word for "south."

Script and sound: दक्षिण, *DUK-shin*, "south"

Example: The Western and Eastern Ghats frame the Deccan Plateau on either side.

See also: Western and Eastern Ghats

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Delhi Sultanate

A series of Muslim-ruled kingdoms based in Delhi that controlled much of northern South Asia from 1206 to 1526 under five dynasties. A *sultan* is a king, and a sultanate is the land he rules.

Script and sound: سلطنت, *sul-TUH-nut*, "rule" or "kingdom" (Urdu and Persian)

Example: The Sultanate ended when Babur defeated Ibrahim Lodi at the First Battle of Panipat in 1526.

See also: Mughal Empire, Early Islam in South Asia

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Desi Identity

The shared sense of belonging that many people of South Asian heritage, especially in the diaspora, express with the word "desi," meaning roughly "one of us, from back home."

Example: A college desi club might welcome students with roots in India, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Nepal alike.

See also: Diaspora, Cultural Identity

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Devanagari

The abugida used for Hindi, Marathi, Nepali, Sanskrit, Maithili and several other languages, recognizable by the line that runs along the top of most letters. Its name joins *deva*, "divine," and *nagari*, from *nagara*, "city."

Script and sound: देवनागरी, *day-vuh-NAA-guh-ree*

Example: The word हिन्दी (Hindi) is written in Devanagari.

See also: Abugida, Brahmi Script

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Dhaka

The capital and largest city of Bangladesh, on the Buriganga River in the middle of the country, and one of the most crowded cities in the world.

Script and sound: ঢাকা, *DHAH-kah*

Example: SAARC was founded in Dhaka in 1985.

See also: People's Republic of Bangladesh, Rickshaw Art

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Dharma

The idea of right order, duty and right conduct: the way things should be and the way a person should act. In Hindi, *dharm* can also simply mean "religion."

Script and sound: धर्म, *DHUR-muh*

Example: Many Hindus see a student's dharma as different from a parent's or a teacher's, depending on stage of life and responsibilities.

See also: Hinduism, Karma and Rebirth

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Dhivehi

The Indo-Aryan language of the Maldives, whose name means roughly "islanders' language." Its closest relative is Sinhala.

Script and sound: ދިވެހި, *dhi-VAY-hee*

Example: English borrowed the word "atoll" from Dhivehi.

See also: Sinhala Language, Atolls

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Dhoti

A man's unstitched lower garment, a rectangle of cloth about 4 yards long wrapped around the waist and passed between the legs, so it looks like loose trousers.

Script and sound: धोती, *DHOH-tee*

Example: Gandhi made the white cotton dhoti famous around the world.

See also: Lungi, Saree

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Diaspora

A population that lives outside its ancestral homeland but keeps some connection to it through memory, language, faith, food, family ties or shared identity. The Greek word means "scattering."

Script and sound: *dye-AS-pruh-ruh*

Example: Zara's family in Minnesota is part of the Bangladeshi diaspora.

See also: Desi Identity, Transnational Families

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Dietary Rules and Faith

The food rules of a religious tradition: the foods its followers are asked to avoid, the ways food must be prepared, and the days for fasting and feasting. Practices vary widely, even within one faith or family.

Example: Many Muslims eat only halal meat, and many Hindus avoid beef.

See also: Halal, Vegetarianism in South Asia, Ramadan

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Diwali

The festival of lights, held on the new moon at the end of the lunar month of Ashvin (Kartika in some regional calendars), usually in October or November. Its name comes from the Sanskrit *Deepavali*, "row of lamps."

Script and sound: दिवाली, *dee-VAH-lee*

Example: Families light small clay oil lamps called *diyas*, draw rangoli at the doorway and share sweets on Diwali.

See also: Dashain and Tihar, Rangoli, Mithai

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Dravidian Languages

A language family not related to Indo-European, whose four largest members are Tamil, Telugu, Kannada and Malayalam. In 2011 the family as a whole was the mother tongue of about 20% of India's people, mostly in the south.

Example: Brahui, spoken mainly in Balochistan, Pakistan, is a Dravidian language far to the northwest.

See also: Tamil Language, Language Family

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Dupatta

A long scarf or shawl, usually worn by women with a shalwar kameez or with a long skirt and blouse. Its name roughly means "a doubled strip of cloth."

Script and sound: Hindi दुपट्टा, Urdu دوپٹہ, *doo-PUT-tah*

Example: Some women wear the dupatta over the head in a place of worship or in front of elders.

See also: Shalwar Kameez

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Durrani Empire

An Afghan empire founded in 1747 by the Pashtun leader Ahmad Shah Durrani that stretched over Afghanistan, much of present-day Pakistan, and into Punjab and Kashmir. Many historians see it as the start of modern Afghanistan.

Example: Ahmad Shah Durrani ruled from Kandahar, and his son later moved the capital to Kabul.

See also: Afghanistan, Kabul

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Dzong

A large fortress-monastery, found mainly in Bhutan, that is both the religious center and the government office for a district, with one side for monks and temples and the other for government offices.

Script and sound: རྫོང, *DZONG*

Example: A dzong has high white walls that slope inward and a red-brown stripe near the top.

See also: Bhutan, Dzongkha

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Dzongkha

The national language of Bhutan, a Tibetic language written in the Tibetan script. Its name means "the language of the fortress."

Script and sound: རྫོང་ཁ, *DZONG-kaa*

Example: Officials in the dzongs of western Bhutan spoke Dzongkha.

See also: Dzong, Tibeto-Burman Languages

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

E

Early Islam in South Asia

The first centuries of Muslim presence in South Asia, which arrived along several routes, both peacefully and through conquest, over hundreds of years.

Example: Arab merchants already sailed to South Asia before Islam began, so Muslim traders appeared on its coasts very early.

See also: Islam in South Asia, Delhi Sultanate, Sufism

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

East India Company

An English, later British, private company owned by investors that received a royal charter on 31 December 1600 to trade in Asia and later conquered and governed large parts of South Asia.

Example: After the Battle of Plassey in 1757, the East India Company gained control of Bengal.

See also: Battle of Plassey, British Raj, European Traders

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Eating With Hands

An old and widespread South Asian custom of eating with the fingers, usually of the right hand only, with hands washed before and after the meal.

Example: Rice is gathered with the fingertips and mixed with dal, and roti is torn and used as a scoop.

See also: Roti and Naan, Hospitality Customs

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Edicts of Ashoka

Messages that the emperor Ashoka had carved on rocks and tall polished stone pillars across his empire, among the oldest readable written documents in South Asia. Most were written in Prakrit using the Brahmi script.

Example: Pillars carrying the Edicts of Ashoka still stand in parts of India and Nepal.

See also: Ashoka, Brahmi Script

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Eid al-Adha

"The festival of sacrifice," on the 10th day of Dhu al-Hijjah during the Hajj, which in Islamic tradition honors the prophet Ibrahim's willingness to sacrifice his son at God's command.

Script and sound: ঈদুল আযহা, *EED-ul AD-ha* (Bangla)

Example: Families who can afford it sacrifice an animal and share the meat with relatives, neighbors and people in need.

See also: Eid al-Fitr, Halal

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Eid al-Fitr

"The festival of breaking the fast," which begins on the first day of the month of Shawwal when the new crescent moon is sighted at the end of Ramadan.

Script and sound: ঈদুল ফিতর, *EED-ul FIT-er* (Bangla)

Example: The night of the moon sighting, *Chand Raat*, brings last-minute shopping and henna before Eid.

See also: Ramadan, Eid al-Adha

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Eighth Schedule

A list attached to the Constitution of India that names the languages the government officially recognizes and promises to develop. It began with 14 languages and today lists 22.

Example: Bangla, Tamil, Urdu, Santali and Sanskrit are among the 22 languages of the Eighth Schedule.

See also: Constitution of India, Linguistic States

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Ekushey February

"The twenty-first of February," the day in 1952 when students in Dhaka were killed while protesting for Bangla to be a state language of Pakistan, now remembered as Language Martyrs' Day and, worldwide, as International Mother Language Day.

Script and sound: একুশে ফেব্রুয়ারি, *ay-KOO-sheh FEB-roo-ah-ree*

Example: UNESCO declared 21 February International Mother Language Day in 1999.

See also: Language Movement of 1952, Bengali Language

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Elections in India

The regular votes, run by the independent Election Commission of India, in which adult citizens aged 18 or older choose members of Parliament and state assemblies.

Example: A national election chooses the members of the Lok Sabha.

See also: Parliament of India

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

European Traders

Merchants and companies from Portugal, the Netherlands, England, France and Denmark who came to South Asia by sea from 1498 onward to buy spices, cotton cloth, indigo and other goods. For most of this period they were guests and customers of South Asian rulers.

Example: Portuguese sailors reached the coast of India by sea in 1498.

See also: East India Company, Indian Ocean Trade

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

F

Field Hockey

A team sport played on grass or artificial turf with curved sticks and a hard ball, eleven players a side, long dominated at the Olympics by India and Pakistan.

Example: India's men's team won Olympic gold eight times, and Pakistan's men's team won three times.

See also: Cricket, Kabaddi

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Film Music (Filmi)

The music written for South Asian movies, especially the song-and-dance numbers in most films. It borrows from ragas, folk songs, qawwali, ghazal and Western styles.

Script and sound: फ़िल्मी, *FILL-mee*

Example: A hit Bollywood song mixing a raga melody with a disco beat is filmi.

See also: Playback Singing, Bollywood

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Folk Dance

A dance that grows out of a community's everyday life, such as harvests, weddings, festivals and worship. Anyone can join, and steps are passed on by watching and doing.

Example: Garba in Gujarat and Attan in Afghanistan are folk dances.

See also: Classical Dance, Garba, Attan

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Folk Music

Songs and rhythms passed down in villages and communities, tied to work, seasons, weddings, festivals and faith, usually learned by ear and performed by ordinary people.

Example: Bhangra began as the folk music and dance of the Punjab harvest.

See also: Bhangra, Baul Music

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Funeral Customs

The rites families follow when someone dies: how the body is cared for, the funeral itself, and the period of mourning afterward.

Example: Many Hindu families cremate the body, while Muslim families bury it as soon as possible, often within a day.

See also: Life-Cycle Rituals

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

G

Ganges (Ganga) River

A river about 2,525 km (1,569 miles) long that rises in the western Himalaya in Uttarakhand, flows east across the northern plains of India and crosses into Bangladesh, where it is called the Padma.

Script and sound: गंगा, *GUNG-gaa*

Example: The Yamuna and several rivers from Nepal are tributaries that join the Ganga on its way east.

See also: Indo-Gangetic Plain, Bengal Delta

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Garba

A circle dance from Gujarat danced during Navaratri, traditionally moving counterclockwise around a lamp in a clay pot or an image of the goddess Amba.

Script and sound: ગરબા, *GUR-bah*

Example: A related dance, *dandiya raas*, uses pairs of decorated sticks.

See also: Navaratri and Durga Puja, Folk Dance

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Garment Industry

Bangladesh's large, mostly export-oriented industry of factories that sew clothing for brands around the world, the country's biggest source of export earnings.

Example: "Made in Bangladesh" is a common label on T-shirts and jeans.

See also: People's Republic of Bangladesh

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Gender Roles and Change

The expectations that families and societies have for women and men, and how those expectations are shifting. Traditionally, many South Asian families expected men to earn money and women to run the home and care for elders.

Example: Many daughters once received less schooling than sons, a pattern that has changed in many families.

See also: Joint Family, Arranged Marriage

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Gharana

In Hindustani music, a "musical household": a lineage of musicians connected by family or by teacher and student, sharing a recognizable style. The word comes from *ghar*, "house."

Script and sound: घराना, *gha-RAA-na*

Example: Gwalior, Agra and Kirana are well-known singing gharanas, named after places.

See also: Guru-Shishya Tradition, Hindustani Music

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Ghazal

A form of love poetry, and the music made from it, built from at least five rhyming couplets that each stand alone but share a refrain. It flourished in Persian and became the leading poetic form in Urdu from the 1700s.

Script and sound: غزل, *GUZ-ul* (Urdu)

Example: The "beloved" in a ghazal can be a human love, God, or both.

See also: Mirza Ghalib, Qawwali

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Gho and Kira

The national dress of Bhutan: the gho, a knee-length robe for men tied at the waist with a woven belt, and the kira, an ankle-length wrapped dress for women pinned at the shoulders.

Script and sound: གྷོ, *GOH* (gho); *KEE-rah* (kira)

Example: The fold of a gho above the belt makes a large pouch used like a pocket.

See also: Bhutan

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Global South Asian Pop

South Asian music, film and entertainment that reaches audiences around the world, including people with no South Asian background.

Example: In 2023, "Naatu Naatu" from RRR won the Oscar for Best Original Song.

See also: Coke Studio, Streaming Era, Bhangra

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Gross National Happiness

Bhutan's idea that a country should measure progress by the well-being of its people and environment, not only by the size of its economy. The phrase is credited to the fourth king, Jigme Singye Wangchuck, in the 1970s.

Example: The king said Gross National Happiness mattered more than gross domestic product.

See also: Bhutan

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Gulf Migrant Workers

People from South Asia and other regions who work in the Gulf states, usually on temporary contracts without a path to citizenship. The wave began in the 1970s.

Example: Mass migration from Kerala to the Gulf between 1972 and 1983 is called the "Kerala Gulf Boom."

See also: Remittances, Transnational Families

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Gupta Empire

An empire that ruled much of northern and central South Asia from about 320 to 550 CE, with kings from Magadha and Pataliputra again a major capital.

Example: Nalanda was founded during the reign of the Gupta emperor Kumaragupta I.

See also: Nalanda, Maurya Empire

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Gurkhas

Soldiers from Nepal and Nepali-speaking communities in India who have served in the British Army since 1815 and today also serve in the Indian Army and other forces. Their name comes from the hill kingdom of Gorkha.

Script and sound: गोर्खा, *GOR-khaa* (Gorkha)

Example: Gorkha's king, Prithvi Narayan Shah, united the small states of Nepal in the 1700s.

See also: Nepal

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Gurmukhi

The abugida used to write Punjabi in India and the Sikh scripture, the Guru Granth Sahib. Its name is often explained as "from the mouth of the Guru," and it has 35 base letters.

Script and sound: ਗੁਰਮੁਖੀ, *GUR-moo-khee*

Example: Simran learned the Gurmukhi letters at her gurdwara's Sunday school.

See also: Guru Granth Sahib, Abugida, Perso-Arabic Script

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Guru Granth Sahib

The Sikh scripture, a collection of hymns that Sikhs honor as their living Guru. Guru Gobind Singh declared in 1708 that after him the scripture itself would be the Guru.

Example: The Guru Granth Sahib has 1,430 pages and includes hymns by Hindu bhakti saints such as Kabir.

See also: Sikhism, Gurmukhi

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Guru Nanak

A spiritual teacher and poet from Punjab (1469 to 1539) whom Sikhs honor as the founder of Sikhism and the first of the ten Sikh Gurus. A *guru* is a teacher or guide.

Script and sound: ਗੁਰੂ, *GOO-roo* (Punjabi, "guru")

Example: Guru Nanak was born in Talwandi, now called Nankana Sahib, in Punjab, Pakistan.

See also: Sikhism, Guru Granth Sahib

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Guru-Shishya Tradition

The practice of learning an art through a long, close relationship with a teacher, often lasting years, with lessons passed on orally phrase by phrase.

Script and sound: गुरु-शिष्य, *GOO-roo SHISH-ya*, "teacher-disciple"

Example: Muslim musicians often call a master teacher *ustad*, and *pandit* is a common title for Hindu masters.

See also: Gharana

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

H

Halal

An Arabic word meaning "permitted," which in Islamic law describes food Muslims may eat. Pork, alcohol and blood are forbidden, and meat must come from a permitted animal slaughtered in a set way with the name of God said.

Script and sound: حلال, *ha-LAHL*

Example: Most vegetarian food is halal as long as it contains no alcohol or other forbidden ingredients.

See also: Dietary Rules and Faith, Eid al-Adha

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Harappa and Mohenjo-daro

The two best-known cities of the Indus Valley Civilization, both in present-day Pakistan: Harappa in Punjab, where excavations began in 1921, and Mohenjo-daro in Sindh, where they began in 1922.

Example: Dholavira and Rakhigarhi in India are other large Indus cities found after Harappa and Mohenjo-daro.

See also: Indus Valley Civilization

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Heritage Language

A language a person learned at home from family while growing up in a place where a different language is the main one.

Example: Zara is a heritage speaker of Bangla: she understands her Nanu easily but answers in English.

See also: Code-Switching, Cultural Preservation

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Himalaya

The mountain range that separates the plains of the subcontinent from the high Tibetan Plateau to the north. Its name comes from Sanskrit words meaning "abode of snow."

Script and sound: हिमालय, *hi-MAA-lay*, "abode of snow"

Example: Mount Everest, the highest mountain on Earth, stands in the Himalaya on the Nepal-China border.

See also: Mount Everest, Hindu Kush

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Hindi-Urdu (Hindustani)

The shared spoken language that underlies both Hindi and Urdu, which are two standard forms of it. Their everyday grammar and most common words are the same.

Script and sound: हिन्दी, *HIN-dee* (Hindi); اردو, *OOR-doo* (Urdu)

Example: One Bollywood song can be enjoyed in both Lahore and Lucknow because of Hindi-Urdu.

See also: Urdu as National Language, Devanagari, Perso-Arabic Script

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Hindu Kush

A mountain range about 800 km (500 miles) long that stretches from central and eastern Afghanistan into northwestern Pakistan. Its highest peak, Tirich Mir (about 7,700 m), is the highest mountain outside the Himalaya and Karakoram ranges.

Example: Tirich Mir, in Pakistan's Chitral District, is the tallest peak of the Hindu Kush.

See also: Himalaya, Khyber Pass

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Hindu Temple Architecture

The shared design traditions used to build Hindu temples, which many Hindus see as homes for a deity, centered on a small sanctum called the *garbhagriha* with a tower rising above it.

Example: Northern temples have a *shikhara* tower, and southern temples have a *vimana*.

See also: Stupa, Puja

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Hindu-Arabic Numerals

The ten digits 0 through 9 and the place value system that goes with them, which began in South Asia and reached Europe through scholars writing in Arabic. "Hindu" here is an old word meaning "Indian."

Example: The digits on a phone keypad are Hindu-Arabic numerals.

See also: Place Value System, Brahmi Numerals

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Hinduism

A family of related traditions, beliefs and practices that grew in South Asia over thousands of years, with no single founder, no single holy book and no single central authority.

Example: India and Nepal are the world's two Hindu-majority countries, and large Hindu communities also live in Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and Pakistan.

See also: Dharma, Karma and Rebirth, Puja, The Vedas

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Hindustani Music

The classical music of the northern part of the subcontinent: northern and central India, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Nepal. It took shape in temples and in Sultanate and Mughal courts, blending older Indian traditions with ideas from Persian music.

Example: Tansen, a singer at Akbar's court, is remembered as one of the greatest Hindustani musicians.

See also: Carnatic Music, Gharana, Sitar, Tabla

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Holi

The spring festival of colors, held on the full moon of the month of Phalguna and the day after it, usually in March.

Script and sound: होली, *HOH-lee*

Example: On the first evening of Holi, communities light a bonfire called Holika Dahan.

See also: Diwali, Lunisolar Calendar

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Hospitality Customs

The expected ways of welcoming and feeding guests. Across South Asia, being a generous host is a matter of family honor.

Example: The Sanskrit line *atithi devo bhava*, "the guest is like a god," is still quoted in India today.

See also: Chai, Langar, Respect for Elders

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Hyphenated Identity

Belonging to two or more cultures at once, sometimes written with a hyphen, as in "Indian-American." The hyphen has a contested history.

Example: In 2019 the Associated Press dropped the hyphen from terms like "Asian American."

See also: Cultural Identity, Third Culture Kids

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

I

Ikat

A way of patterning cloth in which the threads are tied and dyed before they are woven, so the tied sections resist the dye. The word comes from Indonesia, where it means "to bind."

Script and sound: *EE-kaht*

Example: An ikat weaver may re-tie and re-dye the same threads several times to add new colors.

See also: Silk Weaving

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Immigration Act of 1965

A US law, also called the Hart-Celler Act, signed on 3 October 1965, that ended the "national origins" quota system and gave preference to people with family in the US and people with needed skills.

Example: After 1965, South Asian doctors, engineers, scientists and students came first, followed by their families.

See also: Bhagat Singh Thind Case, South Asians in Minnesota

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Indentured Labor

A system in which workers signed a contract, or indenture, to work for a set number of years, usually five, on a plantation far from home in return for passage, wages and housing. Indian workers called the contract *girmit*.

Example: Indentured laborers from India were taken to plantations in the Caribbean, Fiji and elsewhere.

See also: Indo-Caribbean Communities, Diaspora

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

India-Pakistan Rivalry

The competition between the national cricket teams of India and Pakistan, often called the most intense rivalry in the sport, shaped by politics since the teams first played Test matches in 1952.

Example: No cricket was played between the two teams from 1961 to 1978.

See also: Cricket

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Indian Economy

The system of farms, factories, services and trade through which India's people make and buy goods. In 2025 its GDP was about 3.96 trillion US dollars, the sixth-largest in the world (World Bank), but income per person stayed modest.

Example: India's total output is close to the United Kingdom's, but it is shared among far more people.

See also: Indian Rupee

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Indian National Congress

A political party founded on 28 December 1885 in Bombay (now Mumbai) that became the largest organization in the movement for independence from Britain and wanted a single independent India for people of all religions.

Example: Jawaharlal Nehru, a Congress leader, became a leader of independent India.

See also: Mahatma Gandhi, All-India Muslim League

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Indian Ocean

The third-largest of the world's five oceans, covering about 70.6 million square km and bounded by Asia to the north, Africa to the west and Australia to the east. It is the warmest ocean, and monsoons shape the climate all around it.

Example: The Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal are both arms of the Indian Ocean.

See also: Bay of Bengal, Indian Ocean Trade

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Indian Ocean Trade

The network of sea routes and ports that linked South Asia with East Africa, Arabia, Persia, Southeast Asia and China for many centuries. Sailors rode the monsoon winds one way and returned on the reverse winds months later.

Example: Merchants were using the seasonal monsoon winds to cross the Indian Ocean at least as far back as Roman times.

See also: Monsoon, Indian Ocean, European Traders

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Indian Rupee

India's currency, written ₹ and divided into 100 paise. The word comes from the Hindi *rupaya*, from a Sanskrit word for wrought silver.

Script and sound: रुपया, *ROOP-yah*

Example: Pakistan, Nepal and Sri Lanka also call their currencies rupees.

See also: Indian Economy

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO)

India's national space agency, which builds and launches rockets and satellites and sends missions to the Moon and beyond. It took the name ISRO in 1969 and is headquartered in Bengaluru.

Example: ISRO launches its rockets from Sriharikota, an island off Andhra Pradesh.

See also: Aryabhata

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Indian Subcontinent

An older, physical term for the wedge of land south of the Himalaya that juts into the Indian Ocean between the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal, sitting on its own tectonic plate. It describes the land, while South Asia names the region's countries.

Example: India, Pakistan and Bangladesh cover most of the subcontinent, while Afghanistan is usually not counted as part of it.

See also: South Asia, Himalaya

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Indo-Aryan Languages

The South Asian branch of the Indo-European family, descended from Old Indo-Aryan, the language of the Vedas, through everyday languages called

Prakrits.

Example: Hindi, Urdu, Bangla, Punjabi, Nepali, Sinhala and Dhivehi are all Indo-Aryan languages.

See also: Language Family, Sanskrit, Iranian Languages

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Indo-Aryan Migration

The explanation most scholars accept for how Indo-Aryan languages reached South Asia: speakers of these languages moved into the northwest of the subcontinent from Central Asia in gradual waves after about 2000 BCE, and their languages spread and mixed with those already there over centuries.

Example: Linguistic and genetic evidence supports gradual migration, while the older "invasion" model is rejected, and some in India dispute migration.

See also: Indo-Aryan Languages, Vedic Period

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Indo-Caribbean Communities

The descendants of South Asian migrants, mostly indentured laborers, living in the Caribbean, especially in Guyana, Trinidad and Tobago, and Suriname.

Example: In Guyana's 2012 census about 40% of people were Indo-Guyanese.

See also: Indentured Labor, Diaspora

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Indo-Gangetic Plain

The flat, fertile lowland of about 700,000 square km that stretches across the north of the subcontinent from Pakistan through northern India and southern Nepal to almost all of Bangladesh. It is named for the Indus and Ganga river systems that drain it.

Example: The rich soil of the Indo-Gangetic Plain makes it one of the most heavily farmed and densely populated areas of South Asia.

See also: Indus River, Ganges (Ganga) River

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Indo-Persian Culture

The blend of Persian and South Asian languages, literature, art, architecture, music, food and manners that developed in Muslim-ruled courts and cities of South Asia.

Example: Persian was the official language of the Delhi Sultanate and the Mughal Empire, so officials and poets of every faith learned it.

See also: Mughal Empire, Ghazal, Mughal Miniature Painting

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Indus River

A river about 3,180 km (1,980 miles) long that rises on the Tibetan Plateau, flows through the disputed Kashmir region, and runs the full length of Pakistan to the Arabian Sea near Karachi. It collects five large tributaries in the Punjab.

Example: The Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas and Sutlej join the Indus, which is why Punjab means "land of five rivers."

See also: Indus Valley Civilization, Punjab Region

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Indus Script

The set of signs that Indus people carved on seals, pottery, tools and small tablets. It has not been deciphered, so nobody can read it with confidence.

Example: Many small square stone seals show an animal carved beneath a short line of Indus Script signs.

See also: Indus Valley Civilization, Brahmi Script

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Indus Valley Civilization

A Bronze Age civilization along the Indus River and nearby rivers, mostly in present-day Pakistan and northwestern India, whose mature city-building phase lasted from about 2600 to 1900 BCE. It is also called the Harappan Civilization.

Example: Planned cities with brick drains, such as Mohenjo-daro, belong to the Indus Valley Civilization.

See also: Harappa and Mohenjo-daro, Indus Script, Mehrgarh

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Informed Consent

The agreement of an interview subject who understands what is being done, why, how their words will be used and who may see them, and who freely agrees, with the right to skip questions, stop or change their mind.

Example: Asking an elder's permission before recording an interview is part of informed consent.

See also: Oral History

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Intergenerational Dialogue

Conversation between people of different generations, such as grandparents, parents and teens, in which each side learns from the other.

Example: A teen interviewing a grandparent about festivals back home is intergenerational dialogue.

See also: Oral History, Respect for Elders

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Iranian Languages

A branch of Indo-European closely related to Indo-Aryan but separate from it. In South Asia the major ones are Pashto, Dari and Balochi.

Example: Pashto is the second-largest mother tongue in Pakistan, after Punjabi.

See also: Dari and Pashto, Indo-Aryan Languages

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Islam in South Asia

The faith and culture of South Asia's Muslims, who form one of the largest Muslim populations on Earth. Islam arrived over many centuries through traders, Sufi teachers and conquest, and most South Asian Muslims descend from people who lived in the region long before.

Example: Pakistan, Bangladesh, Afghanistan and the Maldives are Muslim-majority countries.

See also: Early Islam in South Asia, Sunni and Shia Islam, Sufism

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Islamabad

The capital of Pakistan, a planned city built from 1961 on the Potwar Plateau below the Margala Hills, next to Rawalpindi. Its name means "City of Islam" or "City of Peace."

Script and sound: *is-LAHM-ah-bahd*

Example: Before Islamabad, Pakistan's capital was the port city of Karachi.

See also: Islamic Republic of Pakistan

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Islamic Lunar Calendar

A purely lunar calendar of 12 months, with a year of 354 or 355 days and no leap month, that Muslims use for religious dates. It is also called the Hijri calendar.

Example: Because the year is shorter than the solar year, Ramadan starts about 11 days earlier in the Gregorian calendar each year.

See also: Lunisolar Calendar, Ramadan, Calendar Conversion

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Islamic Republic of Pakistan

The full name of Pakistan: a federal, parliamentary republic in which Islam is the state religion. The name was adopted in Pakistan's first constitution in 1956, and the current constitution dates from 1973.

Example: Pakistan's prime minister is chosen by the elected National Assembly.

See also: Islamabad, Provinces of Pakistan

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

J

Jainism

A faith from South Asia that teaches that every living being has a soul, and that souls can be freed from the cycle of rebirth through non-violence, self-discipline and right knowledge.

Example: Jains honor 24 *tirthankaras*, the 24th of whom, Mahavira, lived in what is now Bihar around the time of the Buddha.

See also: Ahimsa, Rise of Buddhism and Jainism

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Jali

A stone screen carved with holes in a geometric, floral or calligraphic pattern that lets in air and filtered light while blocking harsh sun and giving privacy.

Script and sound: जाली, *JAA-lee*, "net"

Example: The marble screens of the Taj Mahal are carved jalis.

See also: Mughal Architecture

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Jamdani

A fine, sheer cotton cloth from the Dhaka region of Bangladesh with patterns woven directly into it on a hand loom, using a discontinuous weft technique.

Script and sound: জামদানী, *JAHM-dah-nee*

Example: A single jamdani saree can take weeks or months to weave.

See also: Cotton in South Asia, Saree

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Jataka Tales

Buddhist "birth stories" about the earlier lives of the Buddha, in which the future Buddha appears as a person or an animal and shows qualities like generosity, patience and courage.

Script and sound: जातक, *JAA-tuh-kuh*

Example: The Theravada collection in Pali contains 547 Jatakas.

See also: Buddhism, Panchatantra

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Jewish Communities

The old Jewish groups that settled in India, especially on the west coast, long before modern times. Jews believe in one God and a covenant between God and the Jewish people, and they worship in synagogues.

Example: The Paradesi Synagogue in Kochi, built in 1568, belongs to the Cochin Jews of Kerala.

See also: Religious Pluralism

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Joint Family

A household in which several generations and branches of one family live together and often share a kitchen, money and property. In the traditional form, married sons stay in their parents' home with their wives and children.

Example: In India, the law recognizes a "Hindu undivided family" as a unit for income tax.

See also: Kinship Terms, Respect for Elders

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

K

Kabaddi

A contact team sport, seven players a side, that combines tag and wrestling: a raider enters the other team's half, tags defenders and tries to return without being tackled.

Script and sound: Hindi कबड्डी, Bangla কাবাডি, *kuh-BUD-dee*

Example: Kabaddi was named the national sport of Bangladesh in 1972.

See also: Field Hockey

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Kabir

A 15th-century poet-saint from Varanasi, traditionally said to be raised by a Muslim weaver family, who composed songs and sharp couplets in everyday Hindi questioning empty ritual in both Hinduism and Islam.

Example: Some of Kabir's hymns are included in the Guru Granth Sahib.

See also: Bhakti Movement, Guru Granth Sahib

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Kabul

The capital and largest city of Afghanistan, about 1,800 m (5,900 ft) above sea level in a mountain-ringed valley along the Kabul River, which flows east to join the Indus.

Script and sound: کابل, *KAH-bool*

Example: People have lived at or near Kabul for about 3,500 years.

See also: Afghanistan, Khyber Pass

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Kalidasa

A poet and playwright who wrote in Sanskrit, probably in the fourth to fifth century CE during the time of the Gupta kings. Very little is known about his life.

Example: Kalidasa's surviving works include three plays and several poems.

See also: Gupta Empire, Sanskrit

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Kandyan Dance

A dance from the hill country around Kandy in Sri Lanka's central highlands, called *Uda Rata Natum*, "up-country dance," in Sinhala.

Example: Kandyan dancers perform in the city's great yearly procession, the *Perahera*.

See also: Folk Dance, Sri Lanka

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Karma and Rebirth

The belief that a person's actions and intentions have effects in this life and in future lives, and that the soul is reborn again and again in a cycle called *samsara*. In many Hindu traditions, the highest goal is *moksha*, release from that cycle.

Script and sound: कर्म, *KUR-muh*, "action" (karma)

Example: In a 2021 Pew survey of India, 77% of Hindus and 77% of Muslims said they believe in karma.

See also: Dharma, Hinduism, Buddhism

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Kashmir Dispute

The continuing disagreement, mainly between India and Pakistan, over who should control the former princely state of Jammu and Kashmir. Each side states its own position on the territory.

Example: Maps in this book show Kashmir as disputed rather than drawing an official border.

See also: Princely States, Partition of 1947

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Kathak

A classical dance from northern India that many dancers trace to traveling storytellers (historians debate how direct that link is) and that was later

danced in royal courts, including Mughal courts. Its name comes from *katha*, "story."

Script and sound: *KUH-thuk*

Example: Kathak is danced today in India, Pakistan and Bangladesh.

See also: Classical Dance, Indo-Persian Culture

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Kathakali

A classical "story play" from Kerala that developed from older temple and folk arts and grew up mainly in the courts and theaters of local kings.

Script and sound: കഥകളി, *KUH-thuh-kuh-lee*

Example: Kathakali performers wear color-coded makeup that shows what kind of character they play.

See also: Classical Dance, Mohiniyattam

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Kathmandu Valley

A bowl-shaped valley in central Nepal, about 1,400 m above sea level, holding Kathmandu, Patan and Bhaktapur, which has been the country's political and cultural center for centuries.

Example: Before the 1700s, the word "Nepal" meant just the Kathmandu Valley.

See also: Nepal

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Kazi Nazrul Islam

A Bengali poet, songwriter and journalist (1899 to 1976) honored as the national poet of Bangladesh, a title made official in December 2024.

Example: His 1922 poem "Bidrohi" ("The Rebel") made him famous as a voice against injustice.

See also: Rabindranath Tagore, Bengali Language

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Kerala School

A line of astronomers and mathematicians in Kerala, beginning in the 1300s with Madhava of Sangamagrama, who found ways to write important quantities as infinite series.

Example: Jyesthadeva's *Yuktibhasha*, written in Malayalam around 1550, recorded the Kerala School's methods.

See also: Aryabhata, Srinivasa Ramanujan

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Khadi

Cloth that is both hand-spun and hand-woven, made from cotton, silk or wool, important for the role it played in India's freedom movement.

Script and sound: खादी, *KHAH-dee*

Example: In the freedom movement, many Indians wore khadi and refused foreign cloth.

See also: Mahatma Gandhi, Cotton in South Asia

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

Pakistan's northwestern province, bordering Afghanistan, with Peshawar as its capital. Until 2010 it was called the North-West Frontier Province.

Script and sound: *KY-ber pukh-TOON-khwah*

Example: The name joins "Khyber," after the pass, and "Pakhtunkhwa," roughly "land of the Pashtuns."

See also: Khyber Pass, Provinces of Pakistan

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Khyber Pass

The mountain pass, about 53 km (33 miles) long, that connects Peshawar in Pakistan with Kabul in Afghanistan, crossing the hills at the end of the Spin Ghar range.

Script and sound: *KY-ber*

Example: The pass runs from near Jamrud, Pakistan, to the border post of Torkham.

See also: Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Kabul, Hindu Kush

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Kinship Terms

The words a language uses for relatives. Many South Asian languages use separate words for relatives on the father's and mother's sides and for older and younger relatives.

Example: Zara calls her maternal grandmother Nanu, a word that names her mother's mother specifically.

See also: Joint Family, Respect for Elders

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Kolam

A line drawing made with white rice flour on the swept, dampened ground outside a home, traditionally drawn each morning before dawn by women in Tamil Nadu. The Tamil word means "form" or "beauty."

Script and sound: கோலம், *KOH-lum*

Example: In Telangana and Andhra Pradesh the same practice is called *muggu*.

See also: Rangoli

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Kuchipudi

A classical dance named after a village in Andhra Pradesh that began as a dance-drama performed by troupes of men who played every role.

Script and sound: కూచిపూడి, *KOO-chee-POO-dee*

Example: Arjun Reddy, from a Telugu-speaking family, performs Kuchipudi.

See also: Classical Dance

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Kurta

A loose tunic, traditionally collarless, with straight sleeves and side seams left open at the bottom, worn by both men and women.

Script and sound: कुरता, *KOOR-tah*

Example: Lucknow is famous for kurtas decorated with *chikankari*, delicate white embroidery.

See also: Shalwar Kameez

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Kushan Empire

An empire founded by newcomers from Central Asia that ruled much of today's Afghanistan, Pakistan and northern India from about the 1st to the 3rd century CE. Its most famous ruler, Kanishka, came to the throne around 127 CE.

Example: Kanishka's main capital was Purushapura, today's Peshawar in Pakistan.

See also: Maurya Empire, Gupta Empire

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

L

Lahore

Pakistan's second-largest city and the capital of Punjab province, on the Ravi River, which has been a royal city under the Ghaznavids, the Mughals and the Sikh ruler Ranjit Singh.

Script and sound: لاہور, *lah-HOR*

Example: Ayesha Qureshi's family comes from Lahore.

See also: Punjab Region, Pakistani Cinema

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Langar

The free community kitchen of a gurdwara, where volunteers cook and serve a vegetarian meal to anyone who comes, regardless of religion, caste, gender or wealth. Everyone sits together on the floor as equals.

Script and sound: ਲੰਗਰ, *LUN-gur*

Example: Sikh tradition says the emperor Akbar sat and ate langar with ordinary people before meeting the third Guru.

See also: Sikhism, Guru Nanak, Hospitality Customs

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Language Family

A group of languages that all descend from one older ancestor language. Linguists identify family members by comparing basic words and grammar.

Example: English and Swedish are both in the Indo-European family, which is why Swedish *tre* and English *three* sound alike.

See also: Indo-Aryan Languages, Dravidian Languages

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Language Movement of 1952

A protest movement in East Bengal demanding that Bangla be recognized as a national language of Pakistan, which peaked on 21 February 1952 when police in Dhaka opened fire on student protesters.

Example: The Shaheed Minar in Dhaka honors the Language Martyrs killed on 21 February 1952.

See also: Ekushey February, Bengali Language

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Life-Cycle Rituals

Ceremonies that mark turning points in a life, such as a birth, coming of age, a wedding or a death. In South Asia they are shaped by faith, region and family.

Example: In Hindu tradition, the *samskaras* are the life-cycle rituals.

See also: Coming-of-Age Rites, Weddings, Funeral Customs

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Linguistic States

States whose borders were drawn so that most people inside share one main language, which usually becomes the state's official language.

Example: Most of India's states, such as Tamil Nadu and Gujarat, are linguistic states.

See also: States and Union Territories, Eighth Schedule

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Losar

The new year of the Tibetan lunisolar calendar, usually in February or March, celebrated for up to 15 days. It is observed in Bhutan and by Sherpa, Tibetan and other Himalayan communities.

Script and sound: ལོ་གསར་, *LOH-sar*, "new year" (Tibetan)

Example: Families clean their homes, visit monasteries and hang new prayer flags for Losar.

See also: Lunisolar Calendar, Sherpa People, Bhutan

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Lumbini

A pilgrimage site in the Terai of southern Nepal that Buddhist tradition honors as the birthplace of Siddhartha Gautama, the Buddha.

Example: Lumbini's Sacred Garden includes the Maya Devi Temple and a sacred pond.

See also: Buddhism, Pilgrimage

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Lungi

A length of cloth worn by men around the waist like a skirt, without passing between the legs, usually cotton in checks or stripes.

Script and sound: লুঙ্গি, *LOONG-gee*

Example: In Bangladesh the lungi is the most commonly seen everyday clothing for men.

See also: Dhoti

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Lunisolar Calendar

A calendar whose months follow the moon but whose years are kept in step with the sun and seasons by adding a leap month from time to time.

Example: In many Hindu calendars the extra month, *adhik maas*, is added about once every 32.5 months.

See also: Islamic Lunar Calendar, Calendar Conversion

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

M

Madhubani Painting

A style of bold, colorful painting, also called Mithila painting, from the Mithila region of northern Bihar and southern Nepal, traditionally made by women on the mud walls and floors of their homes.

Example: Madhubani artists fill every space with pattern and outline figures in double lines.

See also: Rangoli

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Mahabharata

A Sanskrit epic, "the great story of the Bharatas," about a struggle for a throne between two sets of royal cousins, the Pandavas and the Kauravas, that ends in a great war at Kurukshetra. It is traditionally credited to the sage Vyasa.

Script and sound: महाभारत, *muh-haa-BHAA-ruh-tuh*

Example: With more than 100,000 verses in its longest version, it is one of the longest poems ever composed.

See also: Bhagavad Gita, Ramayana

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Mahajanapadas

The sixteen large kingdoms and republics that ruled northern South Asia from about the 6th to the 4th century BCE. The word combines *maha*, "great,"

and *janapada*, a territory where a people had settled.

Script and sound: महाजनपद, *muh-HAA-jun-uh-puh-duh*, "great realms"

Example: The Mahajanapadas stretched from Gandhara in the northwest to Anga in today's Bihar.

See also: Rise of Buddhism and Jainism, Maurya Empire

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Mahatma Gandhi

Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi (1869 to 1948), a lawyer from Porbandar in present-day Gujarat who became the most famous leader of the Indian independence movement by leading mass campaigns of nonviolent resistance. *Mahatma* is an honorific meaning "great soul."

Example: Gandhi first developed his methods in South Africa before returning to India in 1915.

See also: Satyagraha, Indian National Congress

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Maldives

An island country of about 530,000 people (2025, World Bank) in the Indian Ocean southwest of India and Sri Lanka, made up of roughly 1,190 small coral islands. It is the smallest South Asian country by population and land area.

Example: All the Maldives' land adds up to only about 298 square km, spread over about 90,000 square km of ocean.

See also: Atolls, Malé, Sea-Level Rise

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Malé

The capital and largest city of the Maldives, built on a tiny island in North Malé Atoll and one of the most densely packed places on Earth.

Script and sound: *MAA-lay*

Example: In the 2022 census about 212,000 people, roughly two in five Maldivians, lived in the city of Malé.

See also: Maldives, Atolls

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Manipuri Dance

A classical dance from Manipur in northeastern India, part of the culture of the Meitei people, whose best-known form is the *Raas Leela*.

Example: The Meitei king Bhagyachandra is credited with designing Manipuri Dance's famous costume.

See also: Classical Dance, Northeast India

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Maratha Empire

A state founded by Marathi-speaking warriors in western India that grew in the 1700s into one of the largest powers in South Asia. It is also called the Maratha Confederacy.

Example: Its founder, Shivaji, was crowned Chhatrapati at the fort of Raigad in 1674.

See also: Mughal Empire

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Masala

A mixture of spices, whole or ground; the word means "spices" or "seasoning." It can also mean a wet paste of onion, ginger, garlic, tomato and spices that forms the base of a dish.

Script and sound: मसाला, *ma-SAH-lah*

Example: Garam masala is a warm blend that often includes cinnamon, cloves, cardamom, cumin and black pepper.

See also: Tadka, Chai

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Maurya Empire

The first empire to rule most of the Indian subcontinent, lasting from about 321 to 185 BCE with its capital at Pataliputra.

Example: Ashoka, the third Maurya emperor, ruled an empire stretching from present-day Afghanistan to present-day Bangladesh.

See also: Ashoka, Edicts of Ashoka

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Mehndi

The art of decorating the skin, usually hands and feet, with a paste of powdered henna leaves that leaves a reddish-brown stain for about one to three weeks. It is also called henna.

Script and sound: مہندی, *MEH-hn-dee* (Urdu)

Example: Zara's cousins line up on Chand Raat to have mehndi patterns drawn before Eid.

See also: Mehndi Night and Sangeet, Eid al-Fitr

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Mehndi Night and Sangeet

Two pre-wedding celebrations popular in many North Indian, Pakistani and diaspora families: a mehndi night, when the bride's hands and feet are decorated with henna, and a sangeet, a night of singing and dancing.

Script and sound: संगीत, *sun-GEET*, "music" (sangeet)

Example: At many sangeets today, both sides of the family stage dance performances to film songs.

See also: Mehndi, Weddings

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Mehrgarh

An archaeological site on the Kachhi Plain in Balochistan, Pakistan, near the Bolan Pass, that is one of the earliest known places in South Asia where people farmed and herded animals. French archaeologists Jean-François and Catherine Jarrige discovered it in 1974.

Example: Finds at Mehrgarh show farming villages in the region long before the Indus cities were built.

See also: Indus Valley Civilization, Balochistan

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Microfinance

The practice of giving very small loans and other banking services to poor people, especially women, who have no property to offer as security and

cannot borrow from ordinary banks.

Example: A small loan might let someone buy a cow, a sewing machine or stock for a shop.

See also: People's Republic of Bangladesh

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Mirza Ghalib

The most famous ghazal poet in the Urdu language (1797 to 1869), born in Agra, who lived most of his life in Delhi and wrote in both Urdu and Persian.

Example: Ghalib lived through the violence of 1857 in Delhi.

See also: Ghazal, Indo-Persian Culture

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Mithai

South Asian sweets, the kind sold in sweet shops and boxed for guests, many made from milk, fresh cheese curds or thickened milk.

Script and sound: मिठाई, *mi-THAI*; মিষ্টি, *MISH-tee* (Bangla)

Example: Boxes of mithai are shared with neighbors at Diwali and Eid.

See also: Diwali, Hospitality Customs

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Model Minority Myth

The stereotype that Asian Americans, including South Asian Americans, are all successful, wealthy, highly educated and free of problems, often used to

compare them favorably with other minority groups. It hides real differences and struggles.

Example: Assuming every South Asian student finds math easy reflects the model minority myth.

See also: Stereotypes, Representation in Media

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Mohiniyattam

Kerala's second classical dance, traditionally a solo dance by women, named after Mohini, the enchanting female form of the Hindu god Vishnu.

Script and sound: *mo-hi-nee-YAHT-tum*

Example: Mohiniyattam dancers wear an ivory-white sari with a gold border.

See also: Kathakali, Classical Dance

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Monsoon

A wind that reverses direction with the seasons, blowing from the southwest for about half the year and from the northeast for the other half along the Indian Ocean coasts. In everyday speech, the rainy season that the southwest winds bring in summer.

Script and sound: বর্ষা, *BOR-sha*, "rain" or "the rainy season" (Bangla)

Example: Farmers across South Asia time their planting to the arrival of the summer monsoon rains.

See also: Indian Ocean Trade, Rivers and Floods

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Mount Everest

The highest mountain on Earth, 8,848.86 m (29,031.7 ft) above sea level by the 2020 China-Nepal measurement, with its summit on the border between Nepal and China.

Script and sound: सगरमाथा, Sagarmatha, *suh-gur-MAA-thaa*

Example: In Tibetan, Mount Everest is called Chomolungma.

See also: Himalaya, Sherpa People

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Mudra

A hand gesture with a set shape and set meanings, used in dance. In Hindi the word can also mean a seal or a stamp.

Script and sound: मुद्रा, *MOO-druh*

Example: The *Abhinaya Darpana* describes 28 single-hand gestures.

See also: Bharatanatyam, Rasa

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Mughal Architecture

The building style that developed under the Mughal emperors, blending Persian and Central Asian ideas such as domes, arched gateways and walled gardens with Indian building skills and decoration.

Example: The *charbagh*, a garden divided into four parts by water channels, is a signature of Mughal Architecture.

See also: Taj Mahal, Jali, Calligraphy

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Mughal Empire

A Muslim-ruled empire, founded by a dynasty from Central Asia, that ruled much of South Asia from 1526 until it formally ended in 1857. Its founder, Babur, descended from the conqueror Timur.

Example: Akbar and Shah Jahan, the builder of the Taj Mahal, were Mughal emperors.

See also: Akbar, Taj Mahal, Mughal Architecture

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Mughal Miniature Painting

The style of small, detailed paintings made in Mughal imperial workshops to illustrate books or fill albums. It grew out of Persian miniature painting and mixed with the styles of Indian painters.

Example: Under Akbar, senior artists drew outlines and junior artists filled in the colors.

See also: Indo-Persian Culture, Mughal Empire

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Muhammad Ali Jinnah

A lawyer from Karachi (1876 to 1948) who led the All-India Muslim League and became the founder and first Governor-General of Pakistan.

Example: Jinnah's "two-nation theory" argued that Muslims and Hindus in South Asia were two nations.

See also: All-India Muslim League, Partition of 1947

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

N

Nalanda

A great Buddhist monastery and center of learning in today's Bihar, India, founded around 427 CE under the Gupta emperor Kumaragupta I, which operated for roughly 800 years.

Example: Students traveled from across Asia to study at Nalanda.

See also: Gupta Empire, Buddhism

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Naming Traditions

The customs a family follows to choose a child's name: who chooses, when, and what the name should mean or sound like.

Example: Many Sikh families choose a child's name from the Guru Granth Sahib, and many Bengali children have both a "good name" and a "call name."

See also: Surnames, Kinship Terms

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

National Symbols of India

The official emblems, chosen by the government, that stand for India as a whole, including a flag, an emblem, an anthem, a song, an animal, a bird and a flower.

Script and sound: तिरंगा, *ti-RUNG-ah* (tiranga, the national flag)

Example: The tiger is India's national animal, and the peacock has been its national bird since 1963.

See also: Republic of India, Rabindranath Tagore

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Natya Shastra

A Sanskrit handbook on the performing arts, "treatise on drama," credited by tradition to the sage Bharata. Most scholars place its first complete version between about 200 BCE and 200 CE.

Script and sound: नाट्य शास्त्र, *NAHT-yuh SHAHS-truh*

Example: The idea of rasa in dance and theater comes from the Natya Shastra.

See also: Rasa, Classical Dance

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Navaratri and Durga Puja

Two names for the great autumn festival of the goddess. *Navaratri* means "nine nights" and begins the day after the new moon of Ashvin; the tenth day is Vijayadashami, often called Dussehra.

Script and sound: नवरात्रि, *nuh-vuh-RAHT-ree* (Navaratri)

Example: Durga Puja in Kolkata was added to UNESCO's cultural heritage lists in 2021.

See also: Garba, Dashain and Tihar, Puja

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Nepal

A landlocked country of about 30 million people (2025, World Bank) on the southern slope of the Himalaya, between India and China's Tibet region, with Kathmandu as its capital.

Script and sound: नेपाल, *nay-PAAL*

Example: Nepal is one of the world's two Hindu-majority countries.

See also: Kathmandu Valley, Nepal's Republic (2008)

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Nepal's Republic (2008)

The end of Nepal's monarchy, when the Constituent Assembly voted on 28 May 2008 to declare Nepal a federal democratic republic. Nepal's new constitution came into effect on 20 September 2015.

Example: The royal palace in Kathmandu became a museum after the last king left in June 2008.

See also: Nepal

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

New Delhi

The capital of India and seat of its national government, home to Parliament, Rashtrapati Bhavan and the Supreme Court, inside the larger city and union territory of Delhi on the Yamuna River.

Example: The British Raj moved its capital from Calcutta to New Delhi.

See also: Parliament of India, Republic of India

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Nikah

The Islamic marriage contract and ceremony, in which the bride and groom each give consent before witnesses and the groom agrees to give the bride the *mahr*, a gift that belongs to her alone.

Script and sound: نکاح, *ni-KAAH*

Example: In Pakistan and Bangladesh the couple and witnesses sign a marriage contract called a *nikah nama*.

See also: Weddings, Anand Karaj

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Northeast India

The easternmost region of India, made up of eight states, the "Seven Sisters" plus Sikkim, connected to the rest of India by the narrow Siliguri Corridor and bordering five countries.

Example: Assam, Manipur and Nagaland are states of Northeast India.

See also: Tibeto-Burman Languages, Manipuri Dance

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Nowruz

The Persian New Year, "new day," which begins at the March equinox on 20 or 21 March. In Afghanistan it is called Nawruz.

Script and sound: نوروز, *noh-ROOZ*

Example: Afghan families prepare *haft mewa*, a dish of seven dried fruits and nuts soaked in water.

See also: Afghanistan, Zoroastrians (Parsis)

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

O

Odissi

A classical dance from Odisha on India's east coast, whose poses can be seen in the dancing figures carved on the state's old temples.

Script and sound: *oh-DIS-ee*

Example: The Sun Temple at Konark shows carved poses that Odissi dancers still use.

See also: Classical Dance

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Onam

The harvest festival of Kerala, celebrated by Malayali families of many faiths in the Malayalam month of Chingam (August to September). In Kerala tradition it marks the yearly return of the generous king Mahabali.

Script and sound: ഓണം, *OH-num*

Example: Families make a *pookalam*, a round carpet of flower petals, and share a *sadya* feast.

See also: Pongal and Makar Sankranti

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Oral History

The practice of recording people's memories of their own lives, in their own words, and keeping those recordings or notes so others can learn from them later.

Example: Recording Nanu's memories of growing up in Chattogram creates an oral history.

See also: Informed Consent, Oral Tradition, Active Listening

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Oral Tradition

The passing of stories, poems, songs and knowledge from person to person by speaking, singing and memorizing, often across many generations, instead of by writing them down.

Script and sound: कथा, *KUH-thaa*, "story" (Hindi); গল্প, *GOL-po*, "story" (Bangla)

Example: Zara's Nanu telling her a *golpo* she heard as a child is part of an oral tradition.

See also: Oral History, Ramayana, Panchatantra

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

P

Pakistani Cinema

The film industry of Pakistan, making films mainly in Urdu and Punjabi, with Pashto films made in Peshawar. Its old center in Lahore was nicknamed "Lollywood," and Karachi has since become a major center.

Example: Many filmmakers moved from Lahore's studios to Karachi after about 2000.

See also: Pakistani Dramas, Regional Cinemas

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Pakistani Dramas

Pakistani television serials, usually in Urdu, known for family stories, romance and social issues, and for running a set number of episodes instead of going on for years.

Example: Fans in India and abroad watch Pakistani dramas online with subtitles.

See also: Pakistani Cinema, Streaming Era

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Panchatantra

A Sanskrit collection of animal fables, "five treatises," set inside a frame story in which a wise teacher uses clever tales to teach three princes how to live and rule wisely. Its author is unknown.

Script and sound: पञ्चतन्त्र, *PUNCH-uh-TUN-truh*

Example: In each Panchatantra tale, animals argue, scheme and make friends, and the story ends with a lesson about trust or good judgment.

See also: Jataka Tales, Oral Tradition

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Panini's Grammar

The *Ashtadhyayi*, "eight chapters," a complete description of the Sanskrit language in just under 4,000 short rules called *sutras*, by Panini of Shalatula near Attock in present-day Pakistan.

Example: Scholars date Panini anywhere from about the 7th to the 4th century BCE.

See also: Sanskrit

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Parliament of India

India's national legislature, made up of two houses and the president, which makes the country's laws. The lower house, the Lok Sabha, has 543 elected seats.

Script and sound: लोकसभा, *LOKE-sub-ha* (Lok Sabha)

Example: Members of the Lok Sabha are directly elected by voters at least every five years.

See also: Elections in India, New Delhi

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Partition Literature

Poetry, fiction and memoir written about the 1947 Partition and its aftermath, in Urdu, Hindi, Punjabi, Bangla, Sindhi, English and other languages, often focused on ordinary people and loss.

Example: Short stories by Saadat Hasan Manto are classics of Partition Literature.

See also: Partition of 1947, Partition Migration

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Partition Migration

The movement of millions of people across the new India-Pakistan borders in 1947 and the years after, with Hindus and Sikhs moving into India and Muslims moving into Pakistan.

Example: In Punjab, people traveled in columns many kilometers long, on bullock carts and on overcrowded trains.

See also: Partition of 1947, Radcliffe Line

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Partition of 1947

The division of British India into two independent countries, India and Pakistan, in August 1947, largely along religious lines, with Muslim-majority areas becoming Pakistan.

Example: Pakistan celebrates its independence on 14 August and India on 15 August.

See also: Radcliffe Line, Partition Migration, Partition Literature

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Pashmina

The very fine wool from the soft undercoat of goats that live high in the Himalaya, and the shawls made from it. The word comes from *pashm*, Persian for wool.

Script and sound: पश्मीना, *push-MEE-nah*

Example: A shawl woven from pashmina wool is one of the region's most prized textiles.

See also: Himalaya

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Pashtunwali

The traditional, unwritten code of honor, hospitality and justice that guides Pashtun social life. It is a matter of custom, not religious law, and is older than Islam in the region.

Script and sound: *push-toon-WAH-lee*

Example: *Melmastia*, welcoming every guest generously, is one of Pashtunwali's main ideas.

See also: Hospitality Customs, Dari and Pashto

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

People's Republic of Bangladesh

The official name of Bangladesh: a parliamentary republic in the eastern part of the old region of Bengal, independent since 1971, with Bangla as its state language. The name means "country of the Bengalis."

Script and sound: বাংলা, *BANG-lah* (Bangla)

Example: Bangladesh had about 176 million people in 2025 (World Bank).

See also: Dhaka, Bangladesh Liberation War

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Perso-Arabic Script

The Arabic script as adapted for Persian and then for many South Asian languages, written right to left and working mostly as an abjad, which writes consonants and long vowels but usually leaves short vowels out.

Example: Urdu, Pashto, Dari, Sindhi and Shahmukhi Punjabi are written in Perso-Arabic Script.

See also: Hindi-Urdu (Hindustani), Calligraphy

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Phonetic Respelling

Writing how a word sounds using ordinary English spelling patterns, with no special marks and the stressed syllable in capitals. It does not show how the word is spelled in its own script.

Example: Diwali is respelled *dee-VAH-lee*.

See also: Transliteration

Taught in Appendix A: Pronunciation and Script Guide.

Pilgrimage

A journey to a sacred place for prayer, blessing, remembrance or renewal. Every faith in South Asia has its own pilgrimage places.

Example: Buddhists travel to Lumbini, the Buddha's birthplace, and Bodh Gaya, where he reached enlightenment.

See also: Lumbini, Sri Pada (Adam's Peak)

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Place Value System

A way of writing numbers in which a digit's value depends on its position, with each position worth a fixed multiple of the one beside it. The system in use today is base ten.

Example: In 352, the 3 means three hundreds because of its place.

See also: Zero, Hindu-Arabic Numerals

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Playback Singing

The practice of recording film songs with professional singers whose voices are played back while actors lip-sync on camera.

Example: In South Asia, many playback singers are as famous as the actors who appear on screen.

See also: Film Music (Filmi), Bollywood

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Pohela Boishakh

The Bengali New Year, "the first of Boishakh," a national holiday in Bangladesh fixed on 14 April and falling on 14 or 15 April in West Bengal.

Script and sound: পহেলা বৈশাখ, *po-HEH-la boy-SHAKH*

Example: Bangladesh fixed the date by revising its Bengali calendar, officially adopted in 1987.

See also: Vaisakhi, Bengali Language

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Pongal and Makar Sankranti

Winter harvest festivals that mark the sun's move into Makara (Capricorn in the Indian zodiac), usually on 14 or 15 January. Because they follow the sun, their dates are very predictable.

Example: India's 2026 holiday list put both Pongal and Makar Sankranti on 14 January.

See also: Onam, Lunisolar Calendar

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Population of South Asia

The total number of people living in the eight countries of South Asia, about 1.99 billion in 2025 (World Bank). That is roughly one in four people on Earth.

Example: India alone had about 1.46 billion people in 2025 (World Bank), the largest share of the region's population.

See also: South Asia

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Post-9/11 Backlash

The hate crimes, harassment, profiling and discrimination aimed at people perceived as Muslim or Middle Eastern after the 11 September 2001 attacks, including many South Asians.

Example: Sikh men wearing turbans were among those targeted in the post-9/11 backlash.

See also: Turban (Dastar), Stereotypes

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Princely States

The kingdoms inside British-controlled South Asia that kept their own Indian rulers but accepted British control over their defense and foreign relations through treaties. There were officially about 565 of them when Britain left.

Example: Hyderabad, ruled by a Nizam, and Jammu and Kashmir, ruled by a Maharaja, were among the largest Princely States.

See also: British Raj, Kashmir Dispute

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Provinces of Pakistan

The four large regions into which Pakistan is divided, each with its own elected assembly: Punjab, Sindh, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan.

Example: The capital has its own federal area, the Islamabad Capital Territory, separate from the provinces.

See also: Sindh, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Balochistan, Punjab Region

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Puja

The Hindu ritual of offering worship to a deity, often with light, flowers, water, incense or food. It can be a large temple ceremony with priests or a few quiet minutes at a home shrine.

Script and sound: पूजा, *POO-jah*, "worship" or "honor"

Example: Arjun's grandmother does a short puja every day at the small shrine in their kitchen.

See also: Hinduism, Navaratri and Durga Puja

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Punjab Region

The cultural and geographic region of the five rivers that feed the Indus, today divided between Pakistan's Punjab province and India's Punjab state. The name comes from Persian words for "five" and "water."

Example: The Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas and Sutlej are the five rivers of the Punjab.

See also: Indus River, Lahore, Bhangra

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Punjabi Pioneers in California

South Asian men, mostly Sikhs from Punjab, who came to the US West Coast in the early 1900s to work in mills, on railways and on farms, and later farmed in California's agricultural valleys.

Example: Many Punjabi pioneers first worked on railways and farms, then farmed land of their own in California.

See also: Bhagat Singh Thind Case, Diaspora

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Q

Qawwali

A form of Sufi Muslim devotional music sung at Sufi shrines to help listeners feel closer to God. Its development is credited to Amir Khusrau in the 1200s and 1300s.

Script and sound: قوالی, *kuh-WAH-lee* (Urdu)

Example: Qawwali singers perform at dargahs, the shrines of Sufi saints.

See also: Sufism, Ghazal, Coke Studio

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

R

Rabindranath Tagore

A Bengali poet, songwriter, novelist, playwright, painter and educator from Calcutta (1861 to 1941) who won the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1913, the first Asian to win any Nobel Prize.

Example: Tagore wrote "Jana Gana Mana," India's national anthem.

See also: Kazi Nazrul Islam, National Symbols of India

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Radcliffe Line

The boundary drawn in 1947 to divide the provinces of Punjab and Bengal between India and Pakistan, based mainly on which districts had Muslim or non-Muslim majorities.

Example: The Radcliffe Line left Sikh holy sites and farmland on both sides of the new border in Punjab.

See also: Partition of 1947, Partition Migration

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Raga

A framework for creating melody that sets which notes to use, which to emphasize and which phrases give it its character. It is not just a scale: two ragas can share the same notes and still sound different.

Script and sound: राग, *RAH-ga*

Example: The Hindustani ragas Bhoopali and Deshkar use the same five notes but are treated as separate ragas.

See also: Tala, Sargam, Hindustani Music

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Ramadan

The ninth month of the Islamic calendar, a month of fasting, prayer and charity lasting 29 or 30 days, during which adult Muslims go without food and drink from dawn until sunset.

Script and sound: رمضان, *rah-mah-DAHN* (Arabic); রমজান, *rom-JAHN* (Bangla)

Example: People who are ill, traveling, elderly, pregnant or breastfeeding are excused from the Ramadan fast.

See also: Eid al-Fitr, Islamic Lunar Calendar

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Ramayana

A Sanskrit epic, "the story of Rama," about Prince Rama of the kingdom of Ayodhya. Its best-known version is traditionally credited to the poet-sage Valmiki.

Script and sound: रामायण, *raa-MAA-yuh-nuh*

Example: Many families tell the story of Rama's return to Ayodhya at Diwali.

See also: Mahabharata, Oral Tradition, Diwali

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Rangoli

A design made on the floor or ground using dry materials such as colored powders, rice flour, colored sand or flower petals, most often for festivals.

Script and sound: रंगोली, *rung-GOH-lee*

Example: Many families draw a rangoli at the doorway for Diwali, or for Tihar in Nepal.

See also: Kolam, Diwali

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Rasa

In the arts, the emotional flavor that a performance creates in the audience. The word literally means "juice," "taste" or "essence."

Script and sound: रस, *RUH-suh*

Example: A dancer shows a feeling, or *bhava*, and a sensitive audience member "tastes" it as rasa.

See also: Natya Shastra, Mudra

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Regional Cinemas

The film industries that make movies in South Asia's many languages other than Hindi, each with its own stars, studios, history and fans.

Example: Malayalam, Tamil, Telugu and Bengali films come from regional cinemas.

See also: Bollywood, Pakistani Cinema

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Regional Cuisines

Styles of cooking that grow up in one area, shaped by its grain, climate, coast or mountains, trade history and communities. Borders drawn in 1947 or 1971 often run right through them.

Example: Punjabi food is eaten on both sides of the India-Pakistan border.

See also: Staple Grains, Thali

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Regional Diversity

The idea that South Asia is many different places shaped by different land, water and history, rather than one place with one climate, language, faith or way of life.

Example: Snowy Himalayan valleys in Bhutan and the low coral islands of the Maldives are both part of South Asia.

See also: South Asia, Unity in Diversity

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Religious Pluralism

Many faiths living side by side in the same society and, as an ideal, people of different faiths respecting each other's right to believe and practice. South Asia's long history of it includes shared traditions as well as real conflict.

Example: A city where a temple, a mosque, a gurdwara and a church stand on the same street shows religious pluralism.

See also: Unity in Diversity, Sufism

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Remittances

Money that migrants send home to their families, which pays for food, school fees, weddings, medical care and new houses.

Example: A worker in Dubai sending part of each paycheck to family in Nepal is sending remittances.

See also: Gulf Migrant Workers, Transnational Families

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Representation in Media

How a group of people is shown on screen and in the news: how often they appear, what roles they play, who writes their stories, and whether portrayals are accurate or rely on stereotypes.

Example: A show written by South Asian American writers about a South Asian American family is an example of representation in media.

See also: Stereotypes, Streaming Era

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Republic of India

The official name of India: a sovereign, democratic republic and union of states with an elected parliament and a constitution in force since 1950. Its constitution also names the country Bharat.

Script and sound: भारत, *BHAH-rut*

Example: Article 1 of the Constitution begins, "India, that is Bharat, shall be a Union of States."

See also: Constitution of India, States and Union Territories

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Respect for Elders

The value that older relatives and community members deserve special honor, care and obedience, and that families should look after them as they age.

Example: In many Hindu and Sikh families, younger people bend to touch an elder's feet as a greeting, and the elder gives a blessing.

See also: Joint Family, Intergenerational Dialogue

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Revolt of 1857

A large uprising against East India Company rule that began on 10 May 1857 when sepoys at Meerut mutinied, marched to Delhi and declared the Mughal emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar their leader. It spread across much of northern and central India.

Example: Rani Lakshmibai of Jhansi fought on horseback in the Revolt of 1857.

See also: British Raj, East India Company

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Rickshaw Art

The painting and decoration of cycle rickshaws, best known in Dhaka, Bangladesh, with flowers, birds, heroes, movie stars and text.

Example: Because rickshaws move slowly through Dhaka's streets, they work like a moving art gallery.

See also: Truck Art, Dhaka

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Rise of Buddhism and Jainism

The growth of two traditions that began in the Ganga plain in the 6th or 5th century BCE, during the age of the Mahajanapadas, into religions followed by

millions.

Example: The Buddha and Mahavira, the great teacher of Jainism, both taught in the kingdoms of the Ganga plain.

See also: Buddhism, Jainism, Mahajanapadas

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Rivers and Floods

In Bangladesh, the yearly rhythm in which monsoon rain and Himalayan meltwater raise the rivers, which spread across the low delta, bringing both fertile soil and danger.

Example: Farmers plant in the rich silt left behind when the floodwaters go down.

See also: Bengal Delta, Monsoon

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Roti and Naan

Two South Asian flatbreads. Roti is unleavened whole-wheat bread cooked on a flat griddle; naan is usually leavened white-flour bread baked on the inside wall of a tandoor.

Script and sound: रोटी, *ROH-tee* (roti); नान, Urdu نان, *NAHN* (naan)

Example: Many families in northern India and Pakistan eat roti at nearly every meal, while naan in India is mostly a restaurant bread.

See also: Staple Grains, Eating With Hands

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

S

Sangam Age

The period in the Tamil-speaking south when the earliest Tamil poetry was composed, which most scholars place between about 300 BCE and 300 CE. Its dates are debated because the poems rarely mention datable events.

Example: Love poems and war poems collected in the Sangam anthologies come from the Sangam Age.

See also: Sangam Literature, Tamil Language

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Sangam Literature

The earliest known body of Tamil poetry, composed roughly between 300 BCE and 300 CE. *Sangam* means "gathering" or "academy."

Script and sound: சங்கம், *SUNG-gum*

Example: Tamil tradition says the poems were approved by great assemblies of poets in Madurai.

See also: Sangam Age, Tamil Language

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

Sanskrit

The classical language of ancient South Asia, part of the Indo-Aryan branch of the Indo-European family, whose oldest form is the Vedic Sanskrit of the Vedas.

Script and sound: संस्कृत, *SUNS-krit*, "refined" or "perfected"

Example: The grammarian Panini described Sanskrit in his *Ashtadhyayi*, "Eight Chapters."

See also: The Vedas, Panini's Grammar, Indo-Aryan Languages

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Saree

A long, unstitched length of cloth, usually 4.5 to 9 yards long, that a woman wraps around her waist and drapes over one shoulder, worn over a petticoat and a fitted blouse. The decorated end over the shoulder is the *pallu*.

Script and sound: Hindi साड़ी, Bangla শাড়ি, *SAH-ree*

Example: A jamdani saree from Dhaka is woven from fine, sheer cotton.

See also: Jamdani, Dhoti

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Sargam

The practice of singing notes with the syllables sa, re, ga, ma, pa, dha, ni, named after the first four. It works like "do, re, mi" in Western solfege.

Example: A music student warms up by singing sa re ga ma pa dha ni sa up and down the scale.

See also: Raga

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Sattriya

A classical dance from Assam that began in the *sattras*, Vaishnava monasteries started by the teacher Srimanta Sankardev (1449 to 1568) and his followers.

Script and sound: *SUT-tree-yuh*

Example: For centuries, male monks called *bhokots* performed Sankardev's dance-dramas as worship.

See also: Classical Dance, Northeast India

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Satyagraha

Gandhi's method of nonviolent resistance in which people openly refuse to obey unjust laws, accept the punishment, and try to win over their opponents rather than defeat them. Gandhi chose the word in South Africa as a Gujarati name for his campaign, combining *satya*, truth, and *agraha*, firmness or insistence.

Script and sound: સત્યાગ્રહ, *SUT-yaa-gruh*, "holding firmly to truth"

Example: Breaking an unjust law in public and calmly accepting arrest is an act of satyagraha.

See also: Mahatma Gandhi, Ahimsa

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Satyajit Ray

A Bengali filmmaker from Kolkata (1921 to 1992), widely considered one of the greatest directors in the history of cinema, who was also a writer, illustrator, magazine editor and composer.

Example: Ray's films are studied in film schools around the world.

See also: Regional Cinemas

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Sea-Level Rise

The gradual increase in the average height of the ocean, caused mainly by warming seawater expanding and by melting glaciers and ice sheets.

Example: Low coral islands like those of the Maldives are especially threatened by sea-level rise.

See also: Maldives, Atolls

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Shadow Puppetry

A form of storytelling in which flat cut-out figures are held between a light and a thin cloth screen, so the audience sees moving shadows.

Example: *Tholu bommalata*, "dance of leather dolls," is the shadow puppetry of Andhra Pradesh.

See also: Oral Tradition, Ramayana

Taught in Chapter 10: Dance and Theater.

Shalwar Kameez

A two-piece outfit of loose drawstring trousers (the shalwar) and a long tunic with side slits (the kameez), worn by both men and women.

Script and sound: شلوار قمیض, *SHUL-war ka-MEEZ* (Urdu)

Example: In Pakistan, the shalwar kameez is everyday wear for both men and women.

See also: Dupatta, Kurta

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Sherpa People

An ethnic group of the high Himalaya, most of whom live in eastern Nepal, especially Solukhumbu and the Everest region. Their name means something like "people from the east."

Example: Nima Sherpa's family comes from Solukhumbu, Nepal.

See also: Mount Everest, Losar

Taught in Chapter 20: Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives.

Sigiriya

A royal fortress and palace built on top of a granite rock about 180 m (590 ft) high in central Sri Lanka by King Kashyapa I, who ruled from 477 to 495 CE. Its name comes from Sinhagiri, "Lion Rock."

Script and sound: *SEE-gi-ri-ya*

Example: Only the huge brick paws remain of Sigiriya's lion-shaped gateway.

See also: Sri Lankan Kingdoms

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Sikhism

A faith founded in Punjab by Guru Nanak (1469 to 1539) that teaches devotion to one God, honest work, sharing with others and the equality of all people.

Example: The tenth Guru, Guru Gobind Singh, created the Khalsa, the community of initiated Sikhs, on Vaisakhi in 1699.

See also: Guru Nanak, Guru Granth Sahib, Langar

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Silk Weaving

Raising silkworms, unwinding or spinning their cocoon thread and weaving it into cloth, usually for festive and wedding clothes.

Example: Mulberry, tasar and eri silk are among the main kinds of silk India recognizes.

See also: Saree, Cotton in South Asia

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

Sindh

Pakistan's southeastern province, the land of the lower Indus River and its delta, with Karachi as its capital. It takes its name from the river's ancient name, Sindhu.

Example: Mohenjo-daro, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, is in Sindh.

See also: Provinces of Pakistan, Harappa and Mohenjo-daro

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

Sinhala Language

The Indo-Aryan language of the Sinhalese people, the majority of Sri Lankans, written in its own rounded script and most closely related to Dhivehi. It is spoken by about 16 million people.

Script and sound: සිංහල, *SING-ha-la*

Example: Dilan Perera's family in Kandy speaks Sinhala.

See also: Dhivehi, Indo-Aryan Languages

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Sitar

A long-necked plucked string instrument with a round gourd body and 18 to 21 strings, many of them sympathetic strings that ring by themselves. Its name comes from the Persian *sehtar*, "three strings."

Script and sound: सितार, *si-TAAR*

Example: Sitar players pull the string sideways across the curved frets to bend a note.

See also: Hindustani Music, Tabla

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

South Asia

The region in the south of the Asian continent made up of eight countries: Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka. It is a geographic and political label that does not put any one country at the center.

Example: When a news story compares rainfall in Nepal, Bangladesh and Pakistan, it is describing weather across South Asia.

See also: Indian Subcontinent, South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC)

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC)

The regional organization that the eight countries of South Asia set up to work together on trade, health, education and culture. It was founded in Dhaka on 8 December 1985 by seven countries, and Afghanistan joined as the eighth member in 2007.

Example: SAARC's secretariat, its main office, is in Kathmandu, Nepal.

See also: South Asia

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

South Asian English Writing

Literature written in English by writers from South Asia and its diaspora, along with translated works that reach readers worldwide.

Example: Novels by South Asian authors winning major international prizes are milestones of South Asian English Writing.

See also: Rabindranath Tagore, Diaspora

Taught in Chapter 14: Stories and Literature.

South Asians in East Africa

Communities of Indian, and later Pakistani, origin that grew up in Kenya, Uganda, Tanzania and neighboring countries from the late 1800s on, often holding a middle position under British rule.

Example: Many South Asian families in East Africa ran shops or worked as clerks.

See also: Uganda Expulsion of 1972, Diaspora

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

South Asians in Minnesota

Residents of Minnesota with roots in South Asia, a community that includes families from every South Asian country, with temples, mosques, gurdwaras, cultural associations and student clubs across the Twin Cities and beyond.

Example: Zara's family, who moved from Chattogram, Bangladesh, are South Asians in Minnesota.

See also: Diaspora, Student Clubs

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

South India

The southern part of the Indian peninsula, usually meaning Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Telangana plus Puducherry and Lakshadweep, where the main languages are Dravidian.

Example: Telugu, Tamil, Kannada and Malayalam are the main languages of South India.

See also: Dravidian Languages, Northeast India

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Sri Lanka

An island country in the Indian Ocean across the narrow Palk Strait from India, independent since 4 February 1948 and called Ceylon until 1972, when it became a republic. Its official name is the Democratic Socialist Republic of Sri Lanka.

Script and sound: ශ්‍රී ලංකා (Sinhala)

Example: The Portuguese and Dutch ruled Sri Lanka's coasts, and the British ruled the whole island.

See also: Sri Lankan Independence, Colombo, Sinhala Language

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Sri Lankan Civil War

An armed conflict from 1983 to 2009 between the government of Sri Lanka and the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), an armed group fighting for an independent Tamil state in the north and east.

Example: The war ended in 2009, after 26 years of fighting that caused suffering on all sides.

See also: Sri Lankan Tamils, Sri Lanka

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Sri Lankan Independence

The peaceful transfer of power from Britain to the island then called Ceylon, which became an independent country on 4 February 1948 under the Ceylon Independence Act of 1947.

Example: Don Stephen Senanayake became the first prime minister of independent Ceylon.

See also: Sri Lanka

Taught in Chapter 4: Colonialism, Independence, and Partition.

Sri Lankan Kingdoms

The series of kingdoms, some Sinhala and some Tamil and often existing at the same time, that ruled the island of Sri Lanka before European colonial rule.

Example: Anuradhapura was the capital of one of the earliest Sri Lankan Kingdoms.

See also: Anuradhapura, Sigiriya

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Sri Lankan Tamils

Tamil-speaking people whose ancestors have lived in Sri Lanka for many centuries, mostly in the north and east, with a long history centered on the Jaffna Peninsula. They differ from Hill Country Tamils, whose ancestors were brought by the British to work on plantations.

Example: Jaffna, in the far north, is a historic center of Sri Lankan Tamil culture.

See also: Tamil Language, Sri Lankan Civil War

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Sri Pada (Adam's Peak)

A cone-shaped mountain 2,243 m (7,359 ft) high in central Sri Lanka, sacred to people of several faiths because of a footprint-shaped mark in the rock near its summit. Its name means "sacred footprint."

Script and sound: ශ්‍රී පාද

Example: In Buddhist tradition the mark at the summit is the Buddha's footprint, while other faiths explain it differently.

See also: Pilgrimage, Religious Pluralism

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Srinivasa Ramanujan

A mostly self-taught mathematician from Tamil Nadu (1887 to 1920) whose discoveries about numbers, infinite series and fractions still keep mathematicians busy.

Example: In 1913 Ramanujan wrote to G. H. Hardy at Cambridge, who invited him to England.

See also: Kerala School, C. V. Raman

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Staple Grains

The grains a community eats nearly every day and builds most meals around. In South Asia the three main families are rice, wheat and millets.

Example: Rice is the staple in the Bengal delta, while bread made from wheat is the staple on the plains of Pakistan.

See also: Regional Cuisines, Roti and Naan

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

States and Union Territories

The divisions of India: 28 states with their own elected governments that share power with the center, and 8 union territories governed more directly by the national government (as of October 2026).

Example: Kerala is a state, while Delhi is a union territory.

See also: Linguistic States, Republic of India

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Stereotypes

Fixed, oversimplified beliefs about a whole group of people, applied to every member of it.

Example: "They all speak Indian" is a stereotype, since there is no language called "Indian."

See also: Model Minority Myth, Representation in Media

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Streaming Era

The period, mainly since the late 2010s, when films and TV shows began reaching audiences through online services such as Netflix, Amazon Prime Video, Disney+ and YouTube instead of only through theaters and TV.

Example: A Malayalam thriller can now be watched with subtitles anywhere in the world on the day it comes out.

See also: Global South Asian Pop, Representation in Media

Taught in Chapter 15: Cinema, Cricket, and Pop Culture.

Street Food

Food made and sold by vendors at stalls, carts and tiny shops, usually eaten standing up or on the go.

Example: Many South Asians who move abroad say street food is what they miss most.

See also: Regional Cuisines

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Student Clubs

Student-run groups at a school, usually with a faculty advisor, that meet regularly around a shared interest or identity.

Example: A South Asian Student Association is one kind of student club.

See also: Community Organizing, Community Impact

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Stupa

A Buddhist monument shaped like a dome or mound, built over relics or sacred objects. Buddhists honor it by walking around it clockwise.

Script and sound: स्तूप, *STOO-puh*

Example: A classic stupa has a solid round dome topped by a railing and a pole with umbrella-like discs.

See also: Buddhism, Hindu Temple Architecture

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Sufism

The inward, devotional tradition of Islam, focused on the love of God and drawing closer to God through prayer, remembrance and a teacher's guidance. A Sufi usually belongs to an order, a chain of teachers and students.

Script and sound: صوفی, *SOO-fee* (Persian)

Example: Qawwali is devotional music that grew out of Sufi gatherings.

See also: Qawwali, Islam in South Asia, Bhakti Movement

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Sundarbans

The world's largest mangrove forest, on the coast of the Bengal Delta, shared by Bangladesh and India. Its name means "beautiful forest" in Bangla.

Script and sound: সুন্দরবন, *SHOON-dor-bon*

Example: The name may refer to the sundari trees that grow in the Sundarbans.

See also: Bengal Delta, Bay of Bengal

Taught in Chapter 19: Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

Sunni and Shia Islam

The two main branches of Islam, which separated over a disagreement about who should lead the Muslim community after the Prophet Muhammad died in 632. Sunni Muslims accept Abu Bakr as the first caliph; Shia Muslims hold that the Prophet named Ali as his successor.

Example: Ashura is a day of mourning for Shia Muslims and a day of fasting for many Sunni Muslims.

See also: Islam in South Asia, Ashura

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Surnames

Family names passed down from one generation to the next. In much of South Asia they exist but do not always work as they do in the United States, and some people have none.

Example: The Sri Lankan surname Perera dates from Portuguese rule in the 1500s and 1600s.

See also: Naming Traditions

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Sushruta Samhita

An old Sanskrit medical text linked to the physician Sushruta, famous for its detailed descriptions of surgical instruments and operations.

Example: It describes rebuilding a damaged nose using a flap of skin from the cheek.

See also: Ayurveda

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

T

Tabla

A pair of hand drums that is the main drum of Hindustani music: the smaller wooden dayan produces clear tuned tones, and the larger bayan produces deep bass sounds.

Script and sound: तबला, *TUB-la*

Example: The black circle of paste on each tabla head gives the drum its ringing tone.

See also: Tala, Hindustani Music

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Tadka

The cooking step called tempering, in which whole spices, and sometimes garlic, dried chili or curry leaves, are fried briefly in hot oil or ghee and poured over a finished dish.

Script and sound: तड़का, *TUD-kah*

Example: In Bangla the same step is called *phoron*, and in Urdu *baghaar*.

See also: Masala, Dal

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Taj Mahal

A white marble mausoleum in Agra built between about 1631 and 1648 by order of the emperor Shah Jahan in memory of his wife Mumtaz Mahal. UNESCO listed it as a World Heritage Site in 1983.

Example: Shah Jahan himself was later buried in the Taj Mahal beside Mumtaz Mahal.

See also: Mughal Architecture, Mughal Empire

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

Tala

A repeating cycle of beats that organizes time in a piece of music, counted with claps, waves and finger taps. The first beat of the cycle, the *sam*, is its most important moment.

Script and sound: ताल, *TAAL*

Example: Musicians may improvise across the beat but aim to land together on sam at the end of each tala cycle.

See also: Raga, Tabla

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Tamil Language

A Dravidian language spoken by about 69 million people in India in 2011, mostly in Tamil Nadu, and one of the two official and national languages of Sri Lanka. Its literature goes back roughly two thousand years.

Script and sound: தமிழ், *THUH-mizh*

Example: Tamil is also one of the official languages of Singapore.

See also: Dravidian Languages, Sangam Literature, Sri Lankan Tamils

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Terracotta

Clay that is shaped and then fired, usually to an orange-red color. The Italian word means "baked earth."

Example: In the Bengal delta, temple walls were covered with terracotta panels showing gods, epics and daily life.

See also: Hindu Temple Architecture

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Thali

A large round plate, usually metal, holding a complete meal: a staple in the middle and several small dishes in bowls called katori around it. The word means both the plate and the meal.

Script and sound: थाली, *TAH-lee*, "plate"

Example: A Gujarati thali might hold rice and roti with dal, vegetables, pickle and a sweet.

See also: Regional Cuisines, Dal

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Thangka

A Buddhist painting on cotton or silk that can be rolled up like a scroll, showing a deity, a scene from the Buddha's life or a mandala. It is used for teaching and meditation.

Script and sound: ཐང་ཀ, *TAHNG-kah* (Tibetan)

Example: Thangkas are made in Nepal, Bhutan, Tibet and the Himalayan parts of India.

See also: Theravada and Vajrayana

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Thar Desert

A dry region of sandy plains and low hills, also called the Great Indian Desert, that lies mostly in the Indian state of Rajasthan and partly in Pakistan's Sindh and Punjab provinces. It usually gets less than 500 mm (20 inches) of rain a year.

Example: About 85 percent of the Thar Desert lies in India.

See also: Monsoon, Sindh

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

The Vedas

Four collections of sacred hymns, chants, ritual instructions and teachings composed in an early form of Sanskrit, which are the oldest scriptures of Hinduism.

Script and sound: वेद, *VAY-duh*, "knowledge"

Example: The Rig Veda is the oldest of the four Vedas.

See also: Vedic Period, Hinduism

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Theravada and Vajrayana

Two of the main schools of Buddhism. Theravada, "teaching of the elders," is the school of Sri Lanka and follows the Pali Canon; Vajrayana, the "diamond" or "thunderbolt" vehicle, became the Buddhism of Tibet, Bhutan and Himalayan Nepal.

Example: A monk in Kandy follows Theravada, while a monk in a Bhutanese dzong follows Vajrayana.

See also: Buddhism, Thangka

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.

Third Culture Kids

People who spent a large part of their childhood living in a culture different from their parents', usually because a parent's job moved the family between countries. The sociologist Ruth Useem first used the term in the 1960s.

Example: A child of diplomats who grew up in three countries is a third culture kid.

See also: Hyphenated Identity, Cultural Identity

Taught in Chapter 22: Bring It Home.

Tibeto-Burman Languages

The South Asian members of the Sino-Tibetan family, spoken mostly in the Himalaya and in India's northeast. India's 2011 census counted 66 of them, more than any other family.

Example: Dzongkha in Bhutan and Sherpa and Newar in Nepal are Tibeto-Burman languages.

See also: Dzongkha, Language Family

Taught in Chapter 6: Languages and Scripts.

Transliteration

Writing a word from one script in another script, letter by letter, so that a reader could rebuild the original spelling, often using extra marks.

Example: In one widely used system, दीवाली becomes *dīvālī*.

See also: Phonetic Respelling, Devanagari

Taught in Appendix A: Pronunciation and Script Guide.

Transnational Families

Families whose members live in two or more countries but stay closely connected, sharing money, decisions, care and daily life across borders.

Example: A grandmother in Dhaka who joins dinner every night by video call is part of a transnational family.

See also: Remittances, Diaspora

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Truck Art

The tradition of decorating trucks and buses with paintings, calligraphy, carved wood, mirrors and reflective strips, best known in Pakistan.

Example: A decorated Pakistani truck may carry mountain landscapes, poetry and a tall carved wooden "crown" above the cab.

See also: Rickshaw Art

Taught in Chapter 11: Art, Architecture, and Craft.

Turban (Dastar)

For Sikhs, the dastar is an article of faith, a turban that covers uncut hair (*kesh*). In Sikh tradition, the Gurus adopted it to declare the sovereignty and equality of all people.

Script and sound: ਦਸਤਾਰ, *dus-TAAR*

Example: Many Sikh men, and some Sikh women, tie a dastar each day to cover their uncut hair.

See also: Sikhism, Post-9/11 Backlash

Taught in Chapter 12: Clothing and Textiles.

U

Uganda Expulsion of 1972

The forced removal of nearly all South Asians from Uganda by the military ruler Idi Amin, who announced on 4 August 1972 that they had 90 days to leave.

Example: About 80,000 people of South Asian descent, many born in Uganda, had to abandon homes and businesses.

See also: South Asians in East Africa, British South Asians

Taught in Chapter 21: The South Asian Diaspora.

Unani Medicine

A healing tradition that began with the Greek physicians Hippocrates and Galen, was developed by doctors writing in Arabic and Persian, and came to South Asia by the 1100s. It is based on the old idea of balancing four "humors."

Script and sound: یونانی, *yoo-NAA-nee*, "Greek"

Example: Unani practitioners are often called *hakims*.

See also: Ayurveda, Indo-Persian Culture

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Unity in Diversity

The idea that a country can hold many languages, faiths, peoples and cultures and still be one nation, with differences seen as a strength. Indian leaders and schools have used the phrase since independence.

Example: An Indian school assembly with songs in several languages celebrates unity in diversity.

See also: Regional Diversity, Religious Pluralism

Taught in Chapter 17: India.

Urdu as National Language

The status of Urdu as the language Pakistan's constitution names for the whole nation, even though only a small share of Pakistanis speak it as a first language.

Script and sound: اردو, *OOR-doo*

Example: Article 251 of the 1973 constitution names Urdu the national language and lets provinces promote their own languages.

See also: Hindi-Urdu (Hindustani), Language Movement of 1952

Taught in Chapter 18: Pakistan and Afghanistan.

V

Vaisakhi

A harvest festival and new year in Punjab and much of North India on 13 or 14 April, and one of the most important days of the Sikh year. It is also spelled Baisakhi.

Script and sound: *VAI-saa-khee*

Example: Sikhs mark Vaisakhi with prayers at the gurdwara and *nagar kirtan*, processions with hymn singing.

See also: Sikhism, Pohela Boishakh

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Varna and Jati

The two ideas behind what English speakers call caste. Varna is a fourfold social classification described in old Brahmanical Sanskrit texts; jati is the local group a person is born into, of which there are thousands.

Script and sound: वर्ण, *VAR-na* (varna); जाति, *JAA-tee*, "birth" or "kind" (jati)

Example: The *Manusmriti* lists four varnas and assigns each one duties.

See also: Caste System

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Vedic Period

The era from about 1500 to 500 BCE when the Vedas were composed in northern South Asia, between the end of the Indus cities and the rise of new cities and kingdoms around 600 BCE.

Example: The Rig Veda, the oldest of the Vedas, comes from the early part of the Vedic Period.

See also: The Vedas, Sanskrit

Taught in Chapter 2: Ancient Roots.

Veena

An ancient name for stringed instruments used in Indian texts for about 3,000 years. In Carnatic music it usually means the Saraswati veena, a large plucked lute with 24 fixed frets.

Script and sound: वीणा, Tamil வீணை, *VEE-nah*

Example: The Hindu goddess Saraswati is usually shown holding a veena.

See also: Carnatic Music

Taught in Chapter 9: Music.

Vegetarianism in South Asia

The practice of eating diets without meat, and often without fish or eggs, which is more common in South Asia than almost anywhere else, though most South Asians are not vegetarian.

Example: A Pew Research Center survey of nearly 30,000 adults in India, published in 2021, measured how many Indians are vegetarian.

See also: Ahimsa, Dietary Rules and Faith

Taught in Chapter 8: Food and the Table.

Vesak

The most important Buddhist festival in South Asia, on the full moon of the month of Vesak, usually in May, when Buddhists remember the Buddha's birth, enlightenment and passing away. It is also called Buddha Purnima.

Script and sound: වෙසක්, *VAY-suck* (Sinhala)

Example: In 1999 the United Nations General Assembly formally recognized the Day of Vesak.

See also: Buddhism, Lumbini

Taught in Chapter 7: Festivals Through the Year.

Vijayanagara Empire

A large Hindu-ruled empire of southern India from 1336 to 1646, named after its capital city, Vijayanagara, "city of victory."

Example: The ruins of the capital city stand at Hampi, in Karnataka.

See also: Delhi Sultanate, Chola Dynasty

Taught in Chapter 3: Empires and Encounters.

W

Weddings

In South Asia, often multi-day events that join two families, not just two people, with separate ceremonies before, during and after the main rite. Details differ widely by faith, region and family budget.

Example: A wedding with a mehndi night, a nikah or other main ceremony, and a reception afterward can stretch across several days.

See also: Mehndi Night and Sangeet, Nikah, Anand Karaj, Arranged Marriage

Taught in Chapter 13: Family, Names, and Life Events.

Western and Eastern Ghats

The two mountain ranges that frame the Deccan Plateau, one along each coast of peninsular India. *Ghat* means a flight of steps down to a river, or a mountain pass.

Script and sound: घाट, *GHAAT*

Example: The ranges act like giant steps from the plateau down to the sea on India's west and east coasts.

See also: Deccan Plateau

Taught in Chapter 1: What Is South Asia?.

Wootz Steel

A high-carbon steel made in South India and Sri Lanka by melting iron with carbon-rich material in sealed clay crucibles, famous for its strength and wavy surface pattern. "Wootz" comes from *ukku*, the Kannada and Telugu word for steel.

Example: Finds in Tamil Nadu suggest crucible steel was made there before the Common Era.

See also: Indian Ocean Trade

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Y

Yoga

A set of practices rooted in South Asian philosophy that combines body postures, breathing and meditation, which began as a spiritual discipline for training the mind.

Script and sound: योग, *YOH-guh*, "joining" or "union"

Example: The poses taught at a gym are only one part of the much bigger yoga tradition.

See also: Ayurveda, Hinduism

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Z

Zero

Both a symbol that marks an empty place in a number and a number in its own right, the result of subtracting any number from itself. The two ideas arrived at different times.

Example: Brahmagupta wrote rules for calculating with zero as a number in 628 CE.

See also: Place Value System, Brahmagupta

Taught in Chapter 16: Science, Math, and Ideas.

Zoroastrians (Parsis)

Followers of Zoroastrianism, an ancient faith founded by the prophet Zoroaster in Iran; in South Asia most belong to the Parsi community, whose ancestors came from Iran. *Parsi* means "Persian."

Example: In the community's own story, the *Qissa-i Sanjan*, Zoroastrians from Iran landed on the coast of Gujarat.

See also: Religious Pluralism, Nowruz

Taught in Chapter 5: Faiths of South Asia.